

The Iliad

a line-for-line translation

FROM THE GREEK OF

Homer

TRANSLATED BY

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The apparatus — the notes, the translator's commentary, the introduction, the guide to further reading, and the index of names and places — is © 2026 Chris Duffy, licensed Creative Commons CC BY 4.0.

The Greek underlying this translation is the Oxford Classical Text of D. B. Monro and T. W. Allen (*Homeri Opera*, 3rd edition, 1920), in the public domain.

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The text of this edition, in digital form, is at wrath-sing-goddess.com.

μῆνιν ἄειδε θεὰ Πηληϊάδεω Ἀχιλῆος

Sing, goddess, the wrath of Peleus' son Achilles

GENERAL INTRODUCTION

I. THE POEM

The Iliad is not the story of the Trojan War. Everyone knows how that war ended: with a wooden horse, and a city burning. Neither is in this poem. The war lasts ten years; the Iliad covers fifty-one days of it, near the end, and all but a handful of those days pass in a line or two. There is no wooden horse in it, no fall of Troy, no abduction of Helen to start the war, no sacrifice of Iphigenia to launch the fleet. The Judgment of Paris, the beauty contest among goddesses that set everything in motion, gets one glancing mention in the last book, and ancient critics wanted to cut even that. The poem assumes you know these things the way you know the weather. What it tells is announced in its first word, *mēnis*, wrath: the wrath of Achilles, the greatest fighter in the Greek army, from the afternoon it is kindled by an insult to the night, some seven weeks later, when it has burned all the way through him and gone out.

The story is simple to tell. Agamemnon, the commander of the Greek army, is made to give up a captive woman, and takes Achilles' captive, Briseis, in her place. Achilles withdraws from the fighting, and his mother, the sea goddess Thetis, persuades Zeus to let the Greeks lose until they learn what her son was worth. That is Book 1. The debt comes due through the long middle of the poem. The Greeks are beaten back to their ships. Agamemnon offers Achilles a fortune to return, and Achilles refuses: given the chance to end his quarrel on magnificent terms, he finds instead that he can imagine leaving the war altogether. Then the Trojans set fire to the first ship. Here the poem turns. Achilles will not fight, but he lends his armor and his dearest friend, Patroclus, and Patroclus dies in his place, wearing his bronze, at the hands of Hector, the champion of Troy. From then on the wrath has a new object. What was aimed at Agamemnon is aimed at Hector; what was a strike becomes a hunt; and the man who would not fight for honor now fights past every limit, against a river, against decency, against the plain fact of his own approaching death, which he knows about in detail and accepts out loud. He kills Hector, drags the body behind his chariot, and cannot stop; his grief will not close. It closes only in the last book, and not by force. Priam, the old king of Troy and Hector's father, crosses the plain at night, kneels to the man who killed his son, and kisses his hands. The two of them weep, each for his own dead. Then they look at each other and marvel, and eat, and sleep. The Iliad ends with a burial and a meal shared between enemies. The city will still fall. Everyone in the poem knows it, and the poem does not need to show it.

Underneath the story, the subject is death. Achilles is the one figure in the poem who is given a choice: a long, obscure life at home, or a short one and a name that never fades. The poem lets him make the choice twice. Once in the abstract, in Book 9, when he threatens to sail home and questions whether the bargain is worth anything at all: "The portion is equal for the man who hangs back and the man who fights hard." And once for real, in Book 18, over the body of Patroclus, with nothing abstract left anywhere. Around that single free choice the poem arranges hundreds of unfree ones. Minor fighters, each given a name and a father and a home town and often a widow at the moment they die, are "broken" in the poem's flat, carpenter's word for it. And against Achilles it sets one great counter-figure: Hector, who has no choice at all, who fights because a city and a wife and an infant son stand behind him, and who is the only person in the poem we watch being loved. The Iliad's sympathy does not follow its politics. It is a Greek poem, and its most humane scenes belong to Troy: Helen on the wall, Hector's helmet frightening his baby, his wife Andromache running to the ramparts "like a madwoman." Its last line of praise is for the man it's hero killed.

Above the men sit the gods, and the poem's way with them has troubled readers ever since. The gods watch the war and meddle in it. They feel real grief. Zeus rains blood on the field for his son Sarpedon, and says of mortals, in the poem's shortest theology, "they matter to me, even as they perish." But they cannot die, and so nothing for them is ever finally at stake. The poem knows exactly what that means. When gods fight gods, in Book 21, it is comedy: boxed ears and a laughing father. When men fight men, it is everything. Mortality is not the men's handicap. It is their seriousness. The gods watch the war the way we read the poem, with passionate partisanship and in perfect safety, and the discomfort of that resemblance is intended.

II. THE ART OF REPETITION

The Iliad comes out of a tradition of poetry composed aloud, in performance, without writing, and its style is built out of repeated pieces. There are fixed epithets: Achilles is "swift-footed," Hector is "of the flashing helmet," dawn is "rosy-fingered." There are whole lines that recur unchanged ("Then in answer spoke to him ..."). There are repeated blocks, as when a messenger delivers a message in the very words he was given. And there are type-scenes, such as a warrior arming, or a sacrifice, or a plea for mercy, whose skeletons recur with small, controlled variations. To readers trained to prize variety, all this was an embarrassment, and translators of the last two centuries mostly smoothed it away: they varied the epithets and paraphrased the repeated speeches so that the poem would read like a novel. This translation takes the opposite view, and it is the single decision from which most of its other decisions follow. The repetition is the art. A fixed phrase, once rendered, recurs in these pages in the same

words. When the Greek repeats a whole line, the English repeats its own line, word for word. When a messenger relays a speech, the relay repeats the original exactly as far as the Greek does, changing "I" to "he" only where the Greek changes it.

The reason is not fidelity for its own sake. Repetition is how this poem thinks. Five different men, alone at five separate moments of crisis, ask themselves the same line: "But why does my own heart argue these things with me?" The line is the point. The poem is showing you that the solitary man debating flight is a single recurring human situation, and the fifth occurrence carries the weight of the other four. When Achilles taunts a Trojan with "Unhappy are the fathers whose sons face my fury!", he is repeating, word for word, what Diomedes said in Book 6, in a scene that ended, unforgettably, with the two enemies exchanging armor as friends. This time no one exchanges armor. When the poet describes Patroclus arming for battle in the same lines he will use for Achilles three books later, the identity of the lines is a fuse burning between the two scenes. Vary the wording and all of this disappears: the echoes, the ironies, the sense that the poem's world runs on recurrences its characters cannot see. Keep it, and an English reader can hear, for once, the machine turning.

Keeping it takes bookkeeping. Every fixed rendering, once chosen, was entered in a register that bound every later book, and the first English wording of any repeated line was binding on every recurrence. When the whole poem was done, each book was read again entire against the Greek, line against line, to hunt down the places where two occurrences of one Greek line had drifted apart in English. Where the register deliberately gives two Greek words one English word, or one Greek word two English words depending on its context, the notes say so. A companion translation of the *Odyssey*, made on the same principles, shares the register wherever the two poems share their formulas.

III. THE GREEK TEXT

The translation follows the standard Greek text, the Oxford edition of Monro and Allen, and it follows it line for line. English line 200 of any book renders Greek line 200, so that any line here can be laid beside its original, or beside any commentary keyed to the standard numbering, without arithmetic. In three places that numbering has a gap: the four lines 9.458-461, and the single lines 11.543 and 14.269. The Oxford text, following the manuscripts, leaves those lines out, but the traditional numbering keeps their places. This edition keeps the gaps too. Each is marked where it falls, and where antiquity preserves the missing lines, as Plutarch preserves the four suppressed lines of Phoenix's confession, they are translated in the notes.

Ancient scholarship is part of this poem's history, and the edition keeps it visible. The scholars of Alexandria, above all Zenodotus, Aristophanes of Byzantium, and Aristarchus, marked the lines they believed were later additions; the term for this is *athetesis*. Wherever the Oxford text prints such a line, this translation translates it, and a note records the doubt. So the divine singer stays in the dance on Achilles' shield, the Pelian ash spear stays in the arming of Book 19, and the Judgment of Paris stays in Book 24 over Aristarchus's objection. Where the Oxford editors themselves chose against the majority of the manuscripts, the note says so, most famously at 1.350, where their text has Achilles looking out over the "boundless sea" and nearly every manuscript has the "wine-dark" one. And where a rejected ancient variant is too interesting to lose, the notes keep it: the text of Zenodotus in which the corpses of the opening lines become a "feast" for the birds; his Book 19, which could not bear a seated Agamemnon and made him stand; the reading known to the geographer Strabo at 20.307, in which the descendants of Aeneas are to rule over "all" rather than over the Trojans, the variant Rome preferred, for obvious reasons. The apparatus of an ancient poem is not scaffolding to be struck once the building stands. It is the record of twenty-five centuries of readers arguing about the same lines, and this translation was made in their company.

IV. THE ENGLISH LINE

The verse is plain, dignified, modern English free verse: no meter, no rhyme. The line is held to a loose five or six beats and runs to about thirteen syllables, with better than nine lines in ten falling between nine and sixteen. That is not an imitation of Homer's hexameter; English cannot sustain one for fifteen thousand lines without stilts. It is a discipline with a different purpose. Since the translation is line for line, the English line must do neither more nor less work than the Greek line it faces. It cannot pad, because the next Greek line is already waiting; it cannot sprawl, because it has to keep step for twenty-four books. What the rule buys is worth its cost. The poem's pacing survives: the single-line death sentences land as single lines, the sentences break across lines where Homer broke them, the long speeches are exactly as long as Homer made them. And every sentence of the English can be checked against its original by anyone with a parallel text and a dictionary.

The diction aims at the register the Greek actually has: formal but not antique, plain but not flat. Homer's language was never anyone's daily speech. It is a poetic amalgam full of frozen archaisms, but it is rapid, direct, and unembarrassed, and the worst betrayal of it is pomposity. A few English choices carry particular weight and are worth declaring at the door. The word that opens the poem, *mēnis*, is "wrath" throughout, never "rage" or "anger": it is a grudge with divine standing, not a mood.

Timē is always "honor," and geras is always "prize," meaning the concrete object, a tripod or a horse or a captive woman, in which honor is publicly embodied. The quarrel of Book 1 makes no sense unless those two words stay rigid; Achilles is not fighting over a girl but over what he is worth. Atē is "blindness," and takes a capital letter when she walks as a goddess: the god-sent delusion that Agamemnon pleads in his apology, "the eldest daughter of Zeus, who blinds all men." The enslaved of the poem are called slaves. Where the Greek says *dmōs* or *dmōē*, this translation does not say "servant" or "maid," because the difference between a servant and a slave is the difference that Briseis and Andromache spend the poem on the wrong side of, and a translation that softens the word has taken a side. The small change of the formulas is kept literal wherever literalness still works: words are winged; dawn is rosy-fingered and saffron-robed; men glare darkly before they speak; the day of death is "the pitiless day."

Proper names use the familiar Latinized forms, Achilles and Ajax and Hecuba and Clytemnestra, on the principle that this poem belongs to its readers and not to any system of transliteration.

V. THIS EDITION

Each of the twenty-four books opens with a short argument, a sentence saying what happens in it. Then comes the verse, numbered to the Greek, and then the book's notes, marked in the text by small raised numbers that start again with each book. The notes carry four kinds of freight. Textual matters: doubted lines, variant readings, the gaps described above. Formulas, pointed out at their first appearance in the poem and then trusted to the reader's ear. Realia: who this minor king is, where that river runs, why a helmet made of boars' tusks matters. And the occasional confession, where the English had to choose one horn of an ambiguity and the note preserves the other. Apart from the poem stand the translator's notes on the books, an essay on each: what the book is and does, where its difficulties lie, and what this translation did about them. They are kept apart so that the poem can be read without interruption, and so that a reader who wants them can find them all in one place.

A reader who wants a map before setting out can hold the poem in one hand. Book 1: the quarrel, the plague, and Thetis's bargain with Zeus. Book 2: the testing of the army and the great catalogue of the ships. Books 3 to 7: the war seen whole, as if for the first time. Paris and Menelaus fight a duel for Helen; Helen names the Greek kings from the wall; the truce is broken; Diomedes runs wild among gods and men; and at the center, Hector goes home into Troy, to his mother, to Helen, and to his wife Andromache and their baby, the poem's one visit inside the doomed city at peace.

Book 8: Zeus bans the gods from the field and tilts the day to Troy. Book 9: the embassy, with Agamemnon's gifts and Achilles' refusal, the greatest speech in the poem. Book 10: the night raid. Books 11 to 15: the long third day of battle, in which the Greek captains are wounded one by one, the wall is breached, Hera seduces Zeus on Mount Ida, the tide turns twice, and Hector's hand at last closes on the first ship. Book 16: Patroclus, in Achilles' armor, saves the ships, kills Sarpedon, and dies under the walls. Book 17: the fight over his body. Book 18: the news; Achilles' choice; Thetis; and the making of the shield, on which the smith god Hephaestus forges the whole living world the rest of the poem leaves out. Book 19: the wrath against Agamemnon renounced; and the horse Xanthus, given speech for a moment, foretells his master's death. Books 20 and 21: Achilles returned, against Aeneas, against everyone, against the river itself, with the gods loosed into the battle and finally laughing in each other's faces. Book 22: Hector alone before the gates; the chase; the death; Andromache at her loom, not yet knowing. Book 23: the funeral of Patroclus, and the games, in which the poem already practices peace. Book 24: the gods' verdict; Priam's night journey; the ransom of Hector; and the twelve days of truce in which the poem, having begun with two men quarreling over what a life is worth, ends with two enemies agreeing on what a death is owed.

Read it aloud where you can. The poem was made for the ear, and its repetitions, the epithets that toll like bells, the lines that come back in new mouths, the pitiless day arriving on schedule, were composed to be heard coming. This translation has tried to keep every one of them audible.

A NOTE ON THE TEXT

The Greek is the Oxford Classical Text of Monro and Allen (3rd edition, 1920). The English translation is original to this edition, and it is numbered to the Greek, line for line: a citation to the Greek finds the same line here. The printed text is followed throughout, including the passages that ancient critics marked as doubtful, which are kept and noted rather than cut.

Three passages the printed Greek lacks (9.458–461, 11.543, 14.269) are marked in place rather than supplied, and the numbering skips them.

Line numbers are printed in the margin every fifth line. Where a verse runs past the measure of the page, the continuation is indented, so an indented line is always the tail of the verse above it and never a new verse.

The notes are printed at the close of each book. A raised numeral in the verse marks a note; the notes are numbered through each book, and each note also gives the line it belongs to (*l.* 337), which is how it should be cited. The translator's notes on the several books are collected at the back, before the guide to further reading and the index.

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Iliad — Book 1

*The plague; Agamemnon takes Achilles' prize, the girl Briseis, and
Achilles quits the war; Thetis asks Zeus to avenge her son.*

Sing, goddess, the wrath¹ of Peleus' son Achilles,
 ruinous wrath, that laid griefs beyond counting on the Achaeans
 and hurled down to Hades many strong souls²
 of heroes, and made the men themselves prey for dogs
 5 and every bird — and the will of Zeus moved toward fulfillment —³
 from the moment those two first stood apart in strife,
 Atreus' son, lord of men⁴, and brilliant Achilles.
 Which of the gods, then, set the two of them fighting?
 The son of Leto and Zeus. Angered at the king,
 10 he sent an evil plague up through the army, and the people were
 perishing,
 because Atreus' son had dishonored Chryses, his priest.
 For Chryses had come to the Achaeans' swift ships
 to free his daughter, bearing ransom past counting,
 holding in his hands, on a golden staff, the wreaths⁵
 15 of Apollo who strikes from afar⁶, and he begged all the Achaeans,
 but the two sons of Atreus most of all, marshals of the people:
 "Sons of Atreus, and you other strong-greaved Achaeans⁷,
 may the gods who keep their homes on Olympus grant you
 to sack Priam's city and come home safe;
 20 only set my dear child free, and accept this ransom,
 in awe of Zeus's son, Apollo who strikes from afar."
 Then all the other Achaeans shouted assent:
 respect the priest, take the shining ransom.
 But it did not please the heart of Atreus' son Agamemnon;
 25 he sent him off harshly, and laid a hard command on him:
 "Old man, let me not find you by the hollow ships,
 either lingering now or coming back again later,
 or the god's staff and wreath may be no help to you.
 The girl I will not release. Sooner shall old age come upon her
 30 in our house, in Argos, far from her fatherland,

- walking to and fro at the loom and sharing my bed.⁸
 Now go — do not provoke me — so you may get home the safer."
 So he spoke, and the old man was afraid and obeyed his word.
 He went in silence along the shore of the loud-roaring sea⁹,
 35 and then, walking far apart, the old man prayed long
 to lord Apollo, whom lovely-haired Leto bore:
 "Hear me, god of the silver bow, who stand guard over Chryse
 and holy Cilla, who rule Tenedos in strength —
 Smintheus!¹⁰ If ever I roofed a temple that pleased you,
 40 if ever I burned for you the fat-rich thighs
 of bulls and goats, grant me this wish:
 may the Danaans pay for my tears by your arrows."
 So he spoke in prayer, and Phoebus Apollo heard him.
 Down from the peaks of Olympus he came, angry at heart,
 45 with the bow on his shoulders and the covered quiver;
 the arrows clashed on the shoulders of the angry god
 as he moved, and he came on like nightfall.¹¹
 Then he settled apart from the ships and let fly a shaft,
 and terrible was the clang of the silver bow.
 50 The mules he attacked first, and the quick-running dogs,
 but then he loosed his piercing arrows on the men themselves
 and struck; and the crowded pyres of the dead burned without ceasing.
 Nine days the god's shafts ranged through the army,
 and on the tenth Achilles called the people to assembly —
 55 the goddess white-armed Hera¹² had put it in his mind,
 for she cared for the Danaans, seeing them die.
 So when they were gathered and assembled together,
 swift-footed Achilles¹³ rose and spoke among them:
 "Son of Atreus, now I think we shall be beaten back off our course
 60 and go home again — if we escape death at all —
 if war and plague together are to break the Achaeans.
 Come, let us ask some seer or priest,
 or even a reader of dreams — for a dream too is from Zeus —¹⁴
 who might tell us why Phoebus Apollo is so angry:
 65 whether he faults a vow unpaid or a hecatomb¹⁵,
 in hope he may accept the savor of lambs and unblemished goats
 and choose to drive this ruin from us."

So he spoke and sat down; and among them rose
 Calchas, Thestor's son, far the best of bird-readers,
 70 who knew what is, what will be, and what was before,
 and who had guided the Achaeans' ships to Ilion
 by the seercraft Phoebus Apollo gave him.
 With good will toward them he spoke and addressed them:
 "Achilles, dear to Zeus, you command me to explain
 75 the wrath of Apollo, the lord who strikes from afar.
 Then I will speak. But you consider, and swear to me
 that you will readily defend me with word and hand;
 for I think I shall anger a man who rules
 all the Argives in his great power, a man the Achaeans obey.
 80 A king is the stronger when he rages at a lesser man;
 even if he swallows his anger for that one day,
 still he keeps resentment afterward in his chest
 until he brings it to completion. Say, then, if you will keep me safe."
 Answering him spoke swift-footed Achilles:
 85 "Take heart, and speak whatever god-sign you know.
 For by Apollo, dear to Zeus — the god to whom you pray, Calchas,
 when you reveal god-signs to the Danaans —
 no man, while I live and see light on this earth,
 shall lay heavy hands on you beside the hollow ships,
 90 no man of all the Danaans — not if you name Agamemnon,
 who now claims to be far the best of the Achaeans."
 Then the blameless seer took heart and spoke:
 "He faults no vow unpaid, no hecatomb,
 but for the sake of his priest, whom Agamemnon dishonored —
 95 he did not release his daughter, would not accept the ransom —
 for that the far-striker has given griefs, and will give more.
 He will not lift this shameful ruin from the Danaans¹⁶
 until we give back to her dear father the bright-eyed girl,
 unbought, unransomed, and lead a holy hecatomb
 100 to Chryse. Then we might appease him and win him over."
 So he spoke and sat down; and among them rose
 the hero, Atreus' son, wide-ruling Agamemnon,
 in anguish: his darkened heart was brimming full
 of fury, and his eyes were like blazing fire.

- 105 Glaring evil first at Calchas, he spoke:
 "Seer of evils! Never yet have you spoken a word to my good;
 always it is dear to your heart to prophesy evils,
 and no good word have you ever spoken or brought to pass.
 And now you stand prophesying before the Danaans
 110 that this is why the far-striker makes their griefs —
 because I would not take the shining ransom
 for the girl Chryseis, since I greatly wish
 to keep her at home. Indeed I prefer her to Clytemnestra,
 my wedded wife, since she is not her inferior
 115 in build or bearing, in mind or in any work of her hands.
 Even so I am willing to give her back, if that is better;
 I want the people safe, not perishing.
 But make ready a prize¹⁷ for me at once, so that I alone
 of the Argives not go unprized — that would not be fitting;
 120 for you all see it: my prize goes elsewhere."
 Then swift-footed brilliant Achilles answered him:
 "Most glorious son of Atreus, greediest of all men,
 how shall the great-hearted Achaeans give you a prize?
 We know of no common store laid up anywhere;
 125 what we took when we sacked the cities has been shared out,
 and it is wrong to make the people gather it back again.
 No — give the girl up now, to the god; and we Achaeans
 will pay you back three and four times over, if ever Zeus
 grants us to sack the well-walled city of Troy."
 130 Answering him spoke the lord Agamemnon:
 "Do not, brave as you are, godlike Achilles,
 try to cheat me with cleverness; you will not slip past me or persuade
 me.
 Is this your wish — that you keep your own prize, while I
 sit here without one, just because you tell me to give her back?
 135 If the great-hearted Achaeans will give me a prize,
 suiting it to my heart, so it be worth as much — well and good;
 but if they will not give it, then I myself will come and take
 your prize, or Ajax's, or Odysseus's —
 seize it and carry it off. And the man I visit will be angry.
 140 But all that we can think through later.

- For now, come, let us drag a black ship down to the bright sea,
gather rowers enough, set a hecatomb aboard,
and put fair-cheeked¹⁸ Chryseis herself
on deck. And one man of counsel shall be commander —
- 145 Ajax, or Idomeneus, or brilliant Odysseus,
or you, son of Peleus, most terrifying of all men,
to make sacrifice and appease for us the worker-from-afar."
Glaring at him darkly, swift-footed Achilles spoke:
"You — wrapped in shamelessness, mind set on profit!
- 150 How shall any Achaeon gladly obey your orders,
to go on a mission or to fight men in strength?
It was not for the sake of Trojan spearmen that I came
to fight here: they have done nothing to me.
They never drove off my cattle or my horses,
155 never in deep-soiled Phthia, feeder of men,
did they ruin my harvest — since much lies between us,
shadowing mountains and the echoing sea.
No: you, colossal in shamelessness, you we followed,
to please you — winning honor for Menelaus and for you, dog-face¹⁹,
- 160 from the Trojans. None of that do you look at or care for.
And now you threaten to take my prize from me yourself,
the prize I labored hard for, which the sons of the Achaeans gave me.
I never have a prize equal to yours, whenever the Achaeans
sack some well-settled Trojan town;
165 my hands carry the greater part of furious war,
yet when the division comes,
your prize is far the larger, and I go back to my ships
with something small and dear, when I have worn myself out fighting.
Now I am going to Phthia. It is far better
- 170 to go home with my beaked ships. I do not intend,
dishonored here, to go on piling up wealth and riches for you."
Then answered him the lord of men Agamemnon:
"Run, then, if your heart is set on it. I am not begging you
to stay for my sake. Beside me are others
- 175 who will honor me — above all Zeus the counselor.
Of all the kings whom Zeus sustains, you are the most hateful to me:
strife is always dear to you, and wars, and battles.

- If you are very strong, some god gave you that.
 Go home with your ships and your companions,
 180 be king over your Myrmidons. I take no account of you;
 your rage does not move me. But here is my threat:
 since Phoebus Apollo takes Chryseis from me,
 her I will send off with my ship and my companions —
 but I will come myself to your hut and take fair-cheeked
 185 Briseis, your own prize, so you may learn well
 how much greater I am than you, and the next man too may shrink
 from calling himself my equal and matching himself against me."
 So he spoke. And grief came over Peleus' son; the heart
 in his shaggy chest was split two ways:
 190 whether to draw the sharp sword from beside his thigh,
 scatter the men between, and kill the son of Atreus,
 or to check his anger and rein in his spirit.
 While he was turning this over in mind and heart
 and drawing the great sword from its sheath, Athena came
 195 from the sky. White-armed Hera had sent her,
 loving both men alike in her heart, and caring for both.
 She stood behind him and caught Peleus' son by his tawny hair,
 showing herself to him alone; of the others, no one saw her.
 Achilles was startled. He turned, and at once he knew
 200 Pallas Athena — the eyes shining terribly —
 and speaking winged words²⁰ he addressed her:
 "Why have you come this time, child of aegis-bearing Zeus?²¹
 To see the outrage of Agamemnon, Atreus' son?
 I will tell you this, and I think it will be accomplished:
 205 by his own arrogance he may soon lose his life."
 Then the goddess grey-eyed Athena²² answered him:
 "I came from the sky to stop your fury — if you will listen —
 and white-armed Hera sent me,
 loving you both alike in her heart, and caring for both.
 210 Come, leave off this strife; do not draw the sword.
 With words, though — taunt him with what is coming, and it will come.
 I tell you this outright, and it will be accomplished:
 one day gifts three times as splendid will be laid before you
 because of this outrage. Hold back, and obey us."

- 215 Answering her spoke swift-footed Achilles:
 "Goddess, a man must keep the word of you two,
 however angry his heart. That way is better.
 Whoever obeys the gods, him they hear indeed."
 He spoke, and checked his heavy hand on the silver hilt,
 220 and back into the sheath he drove the great sword; he did not disobey
 the word of Athena. And she was gone to Olympus,
 to the house of aegis-bearing Zeus, among the other gods.
 But Peleus' son once more with cutting words
 went at Atreus' son, and did not yet let go his anger:
 225 "Wine-sack! Dog's eyes and a deer's heart!"²³
 Never once to arm yourself for battle with the people,
 never to go out in ambush with the best of the Achaeans —
 you have not the courage; that looks like death to you.
 Far better, no doubt, through the wide Achaean camp
 230 to strip his gifts from any man who speaks against you —
 a king who devours his own people! Because you rule nobodies;
 otherwise, son of Atreus, this outrage would be your last.
 But I will say this to you, and swear a great oath on it:
 by this staff — which will never again put out leaves and branches
 235 once it has left its stump in the mountains,
 nor bloom again, since the bronze stripped it
 of leaf and bark; and now the sons of the Achaeans
 carry it in their palms when they give judgment, those who guard
 the ordinances that come from Zeus — this will be a great oath:
 240 some day a longing for Achilles will come upon the sons of the
 Achaeans,
 all of them together. And then, grieved as you are, you will have no
 power
 to help, when many at the hands of man-slaughtering Hector
 fall dying. And you will tear the heart inside you,
 raging that you paid no honor to the best of the Achaeans."
 245 So spoke Peleus' son, and he dashed to the ground the staff
 studded with golden nails, and sat down himself,
 while Atreus' son raged on the other side. Then Nestor
 sprang up, the sweet-speaking, the clear-voiced speaker of Pylos,
 from whose tongue the voice ran sweeter than honey.

- 250 In his time two generations of mortal men
 had already passed away, who once were born and raised with him
 in sacred Pylos, and he was king among the third.
 With good will toward them he spoke and addressed them:
 "Shame! Great grief comes upon the Achaean land.
- 255 Priam would rejoice indeed, and Priam's sons,
 and the rest of the Trojans would be glad at heart,
 if they learned all this about the two of you quarreling —
 you who surpass the Danaans in counsel, surpass them in fighting.
 But listen to me: you are both younger than I am.
- 260 Once, long ago, I kept company with better men
 even than you, and they never made light of me.
 Such men I have not seen since, nor shall I see —
 Peirithous, and Dryas shepherd of the people,
 Caeneus, Exadius, godlike Polyphemus,
- 265 and Theseus, Aegeus' son, image of the immortals.²⁴
 Strongest they grew of all men reared on earth;
 strongest they were, and with the strongest they fought,
 the beasts that lair in the mountains, and destroyed them terribly.
 With these men I kept company, come from Pylos,
- 270 far away, from a distant land; for they themselves called me.
 And I fought as my own man, by myself. Against them no one
 of mortals now upon the earth could fight.
 And they listened to my counsels and obeyed my word.
 So you two listen also, since listening is better.
- 275 You — do not, great man though you are, take the girl from him;
 let her be, as the sons of the Achaeans first gave her to him, a prize.
 And you, son of Peleus — do not choose to strive with a king,
 force against force. A scepter-holding king, to whom Zeus has given
 glory, has no common share of honor.
- 280 If you are the stronger, and a goddess mother bore you,
 still he is the greater, because he rules over more.
 Son of Atreus, check your fury. It is I who beg you:
 let go your anger against Achilles, who stands, for all the Achaeans,
 a great wall against the evil of war."
- 285 Answering him spoke the lord Agamemnon:
 "Yes, old man — all this you have said rightly and in due measure.

- But this man wants to be above all others:
to hold power over all, to be king over all,
to give orders to all — and there is one, I think, who will not obey.
- 290 If the gods who live forever made him a spearman,
do they therefore give him leave to hurl insults?"²⁵
Breaking in on him, brilliant Achilles answered:
"Yes — for I would be called coward and nobody
if I give way to you in every matter, whatever you say.
- 295 Lay these commands on others; do not give orders
to me. I do not think I shall obey you any longer.
And I will tell you another thing — put it away in your heart:
with my hands I will not fight over the girl,
not with you, not with any man; you gave her, and you have taken her
away.
- 300 But of all else that is mine by my swift black ship,
you shall carry off nothing, taking it against my will.
Go on — try it, so these men too may know:
in a moment your dark blood will spurt around my spear."
So the two of them, fighting it out with head-on words,
305 rose, and dissolved the assembly by the Achaean ships.
Peleus' son went off to his huts and balanced ships
with Menoetius' son²⁶ and his companions.
And Atreus' son had a swift ship dragged to the sea,
chose twenty rowers for her, drove aboard a hecatomb
310 for the god, and brought fair-cheeked Chryseis
and set her aboard; and resourceful Odysseus²⁷ went as commander.
So they embarked and sailed the watery ways.
And Atreus' son commanded the people to purify themselves:
they washed themselves clean, and cast the washings into the sea,
315 and offered to Apollo perfect hecatombs
of bulls and goats along the shore of the barren sea²⁸,
and the savor rose to the sky, curling in the smoke.
So the camp busied itself with this. But Agamemnon
did not let go the quarrel with which he had first threatened Achilles:
320 he spoke to Talthylbius and Eurybates,
his two heralds and ready henchmen:
"Go to the hut of Peleus' son Achilles.

Take fair-cheeked Briseis by the hand and bring her.
 And if he will not give her up, I will come with more men
 325 and take her myself — which will be the worse for him."
 So he sent them off, and laid a hard command on them.
 Unwilling, the two went along the shore of the barren sea
 and came to the huts and ships of the Myrmidons.
 They found him beside his hut and his black ship,
 330 sitting; and Achilles took no joy in seeing them.
 The two, in fear and awe of the king,
 stood, and did not speak to him or question him.
 But he understood in his heart, and spoke:
 "Welcome, heralds, messengers of Zeus and of men.
 335 Come near. You are not to blame in my eyes, but Agamemnon,
 who sends you two for the girl Briseis.
 Come, Patroclus, sprung from Zeus — bring out the girl
 and give her to them to take. And let these two themselves be witnesses
 before the blessed gods and mortal men
 340 and before that hard king, if ever again
 there is need of me to beat back shameful ruin
 from the rest. Truly, he rages in a ruinous mind;
 he has no thought of seeing before and behind at once,
 how his Achaeans might fight safe beside the ships."
 345 So he spoke, and Patroclus obeyed his dear companion:
 he led fair-cheeked Briseis out of the hut
 and gave her to be taken. And the two went back along the Achaean
 ships,
 and the woman went with them, unwilling. Then Achilles,
 weeping, drew apart from his companions and sat down
 350 on the shore of the grey sea, looking out over the boundless deep²⁹,
 and stretched out his hands and prayed hard to his dear mother:
 "Mother, since you bore me to a short life,
 honor at least the Olympian owed me,
 Zeus who thunders on high. Now he has honored me not even a little.
 355 The son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon,
 has dishonored me: he has taken and keeps my prize; he seized it
 himself."
 So he spoke, shedding tears, and his lady mother heard him,

sitting in the depths of the sea beside her old father.
 Quickly she rose from the grey salt water like mist,
 360 and sat down before him as he wept,
 stroked him with her hand, and spoke a word, and named him:
 "Child, why do you weep? What grief has come to your heart?
 Speak out; hide nothing; let us both know."
 Groaning heavily, swift-footed Achilles said:
 365 "You know. Why tell it all to one who knows?
 We went to Thebe, Eëtion's holy city³⁰,
 and sacked it, and brought everything here;
 the sons of the Achaeans divided it fairly among themselves,
 and for Atreus' son they picked out fair-cheeked Chryseis.
 370 Then Chryses, priest of Apollo who strikes from afar,
 came to the swift ships of the bronze-shirted Achaeans
 to free his daughter, bearing ransom past counting,³¹
 holding in his hands, on a golden staff, the wreaths
 of Apollo who strikes from afar, and he begged all the Achaeans,
 375 but the two sons of Atreus most of all, marshals of the people.
 Then all the other Achaeans shouted assent:
 respect the priest, take the shining ransom.
 But it did not please the heart of Atreus' son Agamemnon;
 he sent him off harshly, and laid a hard command on him.
 380 And the old man went back angry; and Apollo
 heard his prayer, since he was very dear to him,
 and loosed an evil shaft on the Argives. And now the people
 were dying thick and fast, and the god's arrows ranged
 everywhere through the wide Achaean camp. But a seer,
 385 knowing well, declared to us the god-word of the far-striker.
 At once I, first, urged appeasing the god;
 but rage took hold of Atreus' son, and standing up
 he made a threat — which now stands accomplished.
 The girl the bright-eyed Achaeans are sending on a swift ship
 390 to Chryse, with gifts for the lord;
 and the other — heralds have just now gone from my hut leading her,
 the daughter of Briseus, whom the sons of the Achaeans gave me.
 But you — if you have the power, defend your son.
 Go to Olympus and entreat Zeus, if ever

- 395 you gladdened the heart of Zeus by word or deed.
 For often in my father's halls I heard you³²
 declare it proudly: that you alone among the immortals
 warded off shameful ruin from the son of Cronos, lord of the dark
 cloud,
 that time the other Olympians wanted to bind him —
- 400 Hera and Poseidon and Pallas Athena.
 But you came, goddess, and set him free of his bonds,
 quickly calling to high Olympus the hundred-handed one
 whom the gods call Briareus, but all men
 Aegaeon³³ — for he in turn is stronger than his father —
- 405 and he sat down beside the son of Cronos, glorying in his splendor,
 and the blessed gods shrank in fear of him, and bound Zeus no more.
 Sit beside him and remind him of this; take his knees;
 see if he may be willing to help the Trojans
 and pen the Achaeans back among the ships' sterns and the sea,
- 410 dying — so they may all have joy of their king,
 and even Atreus' son, wide-ruling Agamemnon, may know
 his blindness, that he paid no honor to the best of the Achaeans."
 Then Thetis answered him, letting fall her tears:
 "Ah my child, why did I raise you, born to sorrow?
- 415 If only you could sit by the ships without tears, without pain,
 since your portion is short — not long at all.
 Now you are both quick-fated and wretched beyond all men;
 so it was for an evil fate I bore you in our halls.
 To tell your word to Zeus who delights in thunder
- 420 I myself will go to snow-capped Olympus; he may listen.
 And you — sit now by your swift-faring ships,
 keep your wrath against the Achaeans, and let war go entirely.
 For Zeus went yesterday to Ocean, to the blameless Ethiopians³⁴,
 for a feast, and all the gods went with him.
- 425 On the twelfth day he will come back to Olympus,
 and then I will go to Zeus's house with its bronze floor,
 and clasp his knees, and I think I will persuade him."
 So she spoke and went away, and left him there,
 the heart in him angry for the fair-belted woman
- 430 they had taken from him by force, against his will. Meanwhile Odysseus

- came to Chryse leading the holy hecatomb.
 When they had come inside the deep harbor,
 they furled the sails and stowed them in the black ship,
 dropped the mast by the forestays into its crutch,
 435 smartly, and rowed her to her mooring with the oars.
 They threw out the anchor-stones and made fast the stern lines,
 and stepped out themselves onto the surf-line of the sea,
 and out came the hecatomb for Apollo who strikes from afar,
 and out of the seagoing ship stepped Chryseis.
 440 Then resourceful Odysseus led her to the altar
 and put her in her dear father's arms, and said:
 "Chryses, the lord of men Agamemnon sent me
 to bring you your child, and to offer a holy hecatomb
 to Phoebus for the Danaans, that we may appease the lord
 445 who has now sent the Argives griefs and groaning."
 So he spoke and put her in his arms, and the old man received
 his dear child, rejoicing. Then quickly they set up
 the holy hecatomb for the god in order around the well-built altar,
 washed their hands, and took up the barley-grains.
 450 And Chryses lifted his hands and prayed aloud for them:
 "Hear me, god of the silver bow, who stand guard over Chryse
 and holy Cilla, who rule Tenedos in strength.
 Once before you heard me when I prayed:
 you honored me, and struck the Achaean army hard.
 455 So now again fulfill this wish of mine:
 now beat the shameful ruin back from the Danaans."
 So he spoke in prayer, and Phoebus Apollo heard him.
 And when they had prayed and thrown the barley-grains,³⁵
 they first drew back the victims' heads, cut their throats, and flayed
 them,
 460 carved out the thigh-pieces and wrapped them in fat,
 making a double fold, and laid raw flesh upon them.
 The old man burned them on split wood, and over them poured
 gleaming wine; beside him young men held five-pronged forks.
 When the thighs were burned and they had tasted the inner parts,
 465 they cut up the rest and threaded it on spits,
 roasted it with care, and drew it all off.

- Then when they had finished the work and made the meal ready,
they feasted, and no heart lacked a fair share of the feast.
And when they had put away desire for eating and drinking,
470 the young men filled the mixing-bowls brim-high with drink
and served all, pouring first drops in each cup for the god.
So all day long they sought the god's grace with song,
the young men of the Achaeans singing the beautiful paean,
hymning the worker-from-afar; and he listened, and his heart was glad.
475 And when the sun went down and darkness came on,
they lay down to sleep by the ship's stern-cables;
and when early-born rosy-fingered Dawn³⁶ appeared,
then they put to sea for the wide Achaean camp,
and Apollo the worker-from-afar sent them a following wind.
480 They stepped the mast and spread the white sails,
and the wind filled the belly of the sail, and around the cutwater
the surging wave sang loud as the ship went on,
and she ran down the waves, making her way.
And when they came to the wide Achaean camp,
485 they hauled the black ship up on the mainland,
high on the sand, and set the long props under her,
and scattered among the huts and ships.
But he raged on, sitting by his swift-faring ships,³⁷
the Zeus-sprung son of Peleus, swift-footed Achilles.
490 He never went now to the assembly where men win glory,
never to war, but wasted his own heart away
staying there, longing for the war-cry and for battle.
But when the twelfth dawn from that day came,
then the gods who live forever went to Olympus
495 all together, Zeus leading. And Thetis did not forget the charge
of her son: she rose from the swell of the sea
and in the early mist went up to the great sky and Olympus.
She found the wide-seeing son of Cronos sitting apart from the others
on the topmost peak of many-ridged Olympus.
500 She sat down before him, and took his knees³⁸
with her left hand, and with her right taking him under the chin,
she spoke in supplication to lord Zeus, son of Cronos:
"Father Zeus, if ever among the immortals I helped you

- by word or deed, grant me this wish:
 505 honor my son, who is doomed to the swiftest death of all —
 and now the lord of men Agamemnon
 has dishonored him: he has taken and keeps his prize; he seized it
 himself.
 But honor him, Olympian Zeus of the counsels:
 give power to the Trojans until the Achaeans
 510 pay my son his due and magnify him with honor."
 So she spoke. And Zeus the cloud-gatherer³⁹ said nothing;
 he sat silent a long time. And Thetis, as she had clasped his knees,
 so she held on, clinging close, and asked a second time:
 "Promise me truly now, and bow your head,
 515 or refuse — you have nothing to fear — so I may know well
 how far I am the most dishonored goddess of all."
 Greatly troubled, Zeus the cloud-gatherer answered her:
 "A sorry business — you will set me at feud
 with Hera, when she provokes me with her taunting words.
 520 Even as it is she is forever at me among the immortal gods,
 saying I help the Trojans in battle.
 Go now, go back, before Hera sees anything;
 these things will be my care, until I accomplish them.
 Look — I will bow my head to you, so you may believe:
 525 that, from me, is the greatest pledge among the immortals;
 for nothing of mine can be taken back, nothing proves false,
 nothing goes unfulfilled, once I bow my head to it."
 The son of Cronos spoke, and nodded with his dark brows,
 and the ambrosial hair rolled forward from the lord's
 530 immortal head; and he shook great Olympus.
 So the two took counsel and parted. She
 leapt into the deep sea from shining Olympus,
 and Zeus went to his own house. And the gods all rose
 from their seats before their father; not one dared
 535 stay seated as he came, but all stood up to meet him.
 So he sat down there on his throne. But Hera
 had seen, and was not fooled: silver-footed Thetis⁴⁰,
 daughter of the old man of the sea, had counseled with him.
 At once she spoke to Zeus, son of Cronos, with cutting words:

- 540 "Which of the gods this time, schemer, has been counseling with you?
It is always dear to you to be apart from me,
deciding things in secret. Never yet have you brought yourself
to tell me openly a word of what you intend."
Then the father of men and gods answered her:
- 545 "Hera, do not hope to know all my words:
they would be hard for you, wife though you are.
Whatever is fitting to hear, no one, god or man,
shall know before you;
but what I choose to think apart from the gods,
550 do not pry into all that, or question me."
Then the ox-eyed lady Hera⁴¹ answered him:
"Most dread son of Cronos, what a word you have spoken!
Before now I have hardly asked or pried;
quite at your ease you decide whatever you wish.
- 555 But now I am terribly afraid at heart that she has won you over —
silver-footed Thetis, daughter of the old man of the sea.
In the early mist she sat beside you and took your knees,
and I think you bowed your head to her, a firm pledge to honor
Achilles, and to destroy many beside the Achaean ships."
- 560 Answering her spoke Zeus the cloud-gatherer:
"Strange one — always suspecting; I can never escape you.
Yet you will have no power to do anything about it, only sit
further from my heart — and that will be the colder for you.
If this is as you say, then it must be my pleasure.
- 565 Sit down and be silent, and obey my word,
or all the gods on Olympus may be no help to you
when I come nearer and lay my irresistible hands on you."
So he spoke, and the ox-eyed lady Hera was afraid,
and sat down in silence, bending her own heart.
- 570 And through the house of Zeus the heavenly gods were troubled.
Then Hephaestus, famed for craft, began to speak among them,
bringing comfort to his dear mother, white-armed Hera:
"A sorry business this will be, not to be borne,
if you two quarrel this way over mortals
575 and drive brawling through the gods. There will be no pleasure
in the good feast, when the worse side wins.

- I advise my mother — though she understands it herself —
to bring comfort to our dear father Zeus, so that the father
not scold again and throw our feast into confusion.
- 580 For if the Olympian, lord of lightning, chooses
to blast us from our seats — well, he is far the strongest.
No — touch him with soft words,
and at once the Olympian will be gracious to us."
So he spoke, and springing up he set the two-handed cup
585 in his dear mother's hand, and said to her:
"Bear up, my mother, and endure it, grieved though you are,
or I may see you beaten before my eyes,
dear as you are — and then, for all my grief, I will have no power
to help. The Olympian is a hard one to stand against.
- 590 Once before, when I was straining to defend you,⁴²
he caught me by the foot and flung me from the threshold of heaven:
all day I fell, and with the setting sun
I dropped on Lemnos, and there was little breath left in me;
there the Sintian men took me up, quickly, where I had fallen."
- 595 So he spoke, and the goddess white-armed Hera smiled,
and smiling took the cup from her son's hand.
Then, moving to the right, he poured for all the other gods,
drawing sweet nectar from the mixing bowl,
and unquenchable laughter rose among the blessed gods
600 as they watched Hephaestus bustling through the halls.
So all day long until the sun went down
they feasted, and no heart lacked a fair share of the feast,
nor of the beautiful lyre that Apollo held,
nor of the Muses, who sang in answer with lovely voice.
- 605 But when the bright light of the sun had set,
they went each to his own house to lie down,
where for each of them the famed crook-footed god,
Hephaestus, had built a house with cunning skill.
And Zeus the Olympian, lord of lightning, went to his own bed,
610 where he always lay when sweet sleep came upon him;
there he climbed and slept, with Hera of the golden throne beside him.

NOTES TO BOOK 1

- 1 l. 1 "wrath" (μῆνιν) — the poem's first word and announced theme. Rendered "wrath" rather than "rage" or "anger": *mēnis* is a sustained, quasi-divine grudge (elsewhere used almost solely of gods), not a flash of temper, and "wrath" carries that weight. See the translator's note on this book.
- 2 l. 3 "souls" (ψυχάς) — Apollonius Rhodius is reported to have read κεφαλάς, "heads" (apparatus at line 3). The vulgate "souls" is kept; "hurled heads to Hades" would make the bodies-for-dogs of the next lines redundant.
- 3 ll. 4-5 Zenodotus athetized both lines (apparatus, Line 4-5: ath. Zen); separately his text is reported (via Athenaeus) to have read δαῖτα, making the corpses "a feast" for the birds. Translated from the vulgate (πᾶσι, "every bird"), keeping the grim literal image over the sardonic "banquet"; see the translator's note on this book.
- 4 l. 7 "lord of men" (ἄναξ ἀνδρῶν) — Agamemnon's fixed title epithet, always so rendered. Likewise δῖος ("heavenly, radiant") is always "brilliant" — of Achilles and Odysseus here, of many heroes later. Epithet conventions are noted at first occurrence only; the full list is kept in the translator's register.
- 5 ll. 14-15 The wreaths (στέμματα) are the god's woolen fillets, carried on the priest's golden staff: portable proof of sacred office. Chryses arrives simultaneously as suppliant and as Apollo's representative, so Agamemnon's threat in 26-32 is sacrilege, not mere rudeness.
- 6 l. 14 "who strikes from afar" (ἐκμήβολος) — first of Apollo's archer epithets, a family rendered consistently: ἐκμήβολος/ἐκατηβόλος and ἐκατηβέλετης "who strikes from afar," ἔκατος "the far-striker," ἐκάεργος "the worker-from-afar."
- 7 l. 17 "strong-greaved Achaeans" (ἑὺκνήμιδες Ἀχαιοί) — stock epithet of the army (greaves: bronze shin-guards). Note also that "Achaeans," "Danaans," and "Argives" all name the same Greek host interchangeably, as meter requires; the translation keeps whichever the Greek uses.
- 8 ll. 29-31 Aristarchus athetized these three lines (apparatus, Line 29-31: ath. Ar.) — ancient critics found Agamemnon's leering detail unbecoming. Kept, following the printed text; the coarseness is dramatically apt at this first display of his character.
- 9 l. 34 "loud-roaring sea" (πολυφλοίσβοιο θαλάσσης) — famous onomatopoeic formula for the surf-line, rendered thus wherever it recurs.
- 10 l. 39 "Smintheus" — obscure cult title of Apollo, in antiquity connected with σμίνθος "mouse"; a mouse-god (whether as sender or averter of vermin and pestilence) suits the plague-god invoked here. Left untranslated, as a cult name.
- 11 ll. 46-47 Zenodotus athetized these two lines (apparatus, Line 46-47: ath. Zen) — the clashing arrows and "he came on like nightfall." Kept; the simile is among the most admired in the poem.

- 12 l. 55 "white-armed Hera" (λευκώλενος Ἥρη) — her fixed epithet; white forearms as a mark of female beauty (elite women stayed unburned).
- 13 l. 58 "swift-footed Achilles" — his defining epithet. The Greek alternates πόδας ὠκύς ("swift as to his feet") and ποδάρκης ("foot-strong") by metrical convenience; both are rendered "swift-footed" rather than inventing a distinction English cannot hear.
- 14 l. 63 "for a dream too is from Zeus" — athetized by Zenodotus (apparatus, Line 63: ath. Zen). Kept; the parenthetical justification is characteristic of Achilles' earnest style here.
- 15 l. 65 "hecatomb" (ἐκατόμβη) — literally "a hundred oxen," in practice any large-scale public sacrifice (the one at 458 ff. is of bulls and goats, far fewer than a hundred). Kept as the standard English term.
- 16 l. 97 For this line Zenodotus' text read instead "until he holds back the plague's heavy hands from the Danaans" (apparatus, Line 97). The vulgate, printed here, makes Apollo the subject throughout; the sense is not materially changed.
- 17 ll. 118-120 "prize" (γέρας) — the concrete share of spoils publicly awarded as the embodiment of a warrior's honor (τιμή). Chryseis and Briseis are both gera. The entire quarrel runs on this institution: to lose one's geras by force is to be publicly declared worthless, which is why Achilles calls the seizure "dishonoring" (ἀτιμάζειν). "Prize" is kept rigidly for γέρας throughout the translation.
- 18 l. 143 "fair-cheeked" (καλλιπάρης) — stock beauty epithet, used in this book of both Chryseis and Briseis; always so rendered.
- 19 l. 159 "dog-face" (κυνῶπα) — in Homeric invective the dog is the type of shamelessness (scavenging, fawning, no sense of decency), not of loyalty; hence also "dog's eyes" in Achilles' next speech (225). The insults are translated literally to keep their animal force.
- 20 l. 201 "winged words" (ἔπεα πτερόεντα) — formula for direct speech launched at an addressee, probably from the image of a feathered arrow flying straight to its mark; always so rendered.
- 21 l. 202 "aegis-bearing Zeus" (αἰγίοχος) — the aegis is Zeus's terror-inducing goat-skin storm-shield, wielded also by Athena; his commonest fixed epithet.
- 22 l. 206 "grey-eyed Athena" (γλαυκῶπις Ἀθήνη) — γλαυκῶπις may mean "gleaming-eyed" or "grey/silvery-eyed," and was anciently connected with γλαῦξ "owl," her bird. "Grey-eyed" is adopted as the conventional English; the gleam, not the hue, is what the scenes exploit (cf. 200, "the eyes shining terribly").
- 23 ll. 225-233 Zenodotus athetized this entire opening of Achilles' tirade through the beginning of the oath (apparatus, Line 225-233: ath. Zen) — presumably as unworthy abuse. Kept: the escalation from insult to formal oath-on-the-staff is the dramatic hinge of the assembly.
- 24 l. 265 The Theseus line is absent from most manuscripts and is identical to Hesiod, Shield 182; it is almost certainly a later insertion here (apparatus, Line 265: om. vulg.). Retained, bracketed by no marks, since the printed text keeps it — but it is the weakest line of the catalogue. The "beasts that lair in the mountains" (268, φῆρες) are the centaurs: Nestor is recalling the Lapith-centaur war.

- 25 l. 291 "give him leave to hurl insults" — the verb προθέουσιν is an old crux: taken here as from προτίθημι, "do they set it before him / license him?"; others derive it from προθέω, "do his insults run out ahead?" The sarcastic sense — prowess is god-given, abuse is not — is the same either way.
- 26 l. 307 "Menoetius' son" — Patroclus, here making his first, silent appearance in the poem; he is named at 337.
- 27 l. 311 "resourceful Odysseus" (πολύμητις) — "of much cunning intelligence (mētis)"; his fixed epithet, always so rendered.
- 28 l. 316 "barren sea" (ἀτρυνέτοιο) — formulaic sea-epithet of uncertain sense, traditionally "unharvested/yielding no crop"; "barren" is adopted as the convention.
- 29 l. 350 "the boundless deep" — the printed text follows Aristarchus' reading ἀπείρονα ("boundless"); nearly all manuscripts have οἴνοπα, the famous "wine-dark sea" (apparatus, Line 350). Readers expecting "wine-dark" here are remembering the manuscript vulgate. Translated as printed, with real regret.
- 30 l. 366 Thebe — a town of the Troad ruled by Eëtion, father of Hector's wife Andromache. Achilles sacked it; Chryseis was captured there (visiting, evidently, since her home is Chryse). The raid resurfaces in Book 6 as the source of Andromache's griefs.
- 31 ll. 372-379 These eight lines repeat 12-16 and 22-25 verbatim — normal epic technique when a character retells events — and Aristarchus athetized the repetition here (apparatus, Line 372-379: ath. hic Ar.). Kept, and translated in identical words, since verbatim recurrence is a deliberate feature of the style.
- 32 ll. 396-406 Zenodotus athetized the whole Briareus digression (apparatus, Line 396-406: ath. Zen) — the only surviving mention of this failed divine coup against Zeus. At 400 his text also named "Phoebus Apollo" among the conspirators instead of "Pallas Athena" (apparatus, Line 400). Kept as printed: the story is doing real work, reminding Zeus (through Thetis) of a concrete debt.
- 33 ll. 403-404 A rare glimpse of double naming: gods say "Briareus," men say "Aegaeon." The hundred-handed giant is elsewhere a son of Uranus; "stronger than his father" here more likely points to a tradition making him Poseidon's son. Zenodotus' text expanded the line with a verse on his strength (apparatus, Line 404).
- 34 ll. 423-425 The gods' twelve-day absence feasting with the "blameless Ethiopians" at the world-encircling stream of Ocean is a standard epic device for clearing the divine stage. "For a feast" follows Aristarchus' reading κατὰ δαῖτα (apparatus, Line 424).
- 35 ll. 458-466 The standard Homeric sacrifice, described with ritual precision: barley thrown, head drawn back, throat cut; thigh-bones wrapped in a double fold of fat with raw strips laid on top are the god's portion, burned with wine poured over; the innards (σπλάγχνα) are tasted first by the participants, then the rest is spitted and roasted for the shared feast. The gods receive smoke and savor; the people, dinner.
- 36 l. 477 "early-born rosy-fingered Dawn" (ροδοδάκτυλος Ἥως) — the most famous of all Homeric formulas, marking daybreak; always so rendered.

- 37 *ll. 488-492* Zenodotus athetized these five lines on Achilles wasting his heart in idleness (apparatus, Line 488-492: ath. Zen.). Kept: they are the essential bridge from quarrel to consequence, holding Achilles motionless while the plot moves to Olympus.
- 38 *ll. 500-501* Thetis performs the full ritual of supplication: crouch before the person, clasp the knees with one hand, reach for the chin with the other. A completed supplication put the supplicated under strong obligation — hence Zeus's trapped silence at 511-512.
- 39 *l. 511* "Zeus the cloud-gatherer" (νεφεληγερέτα Ζεύς) — his fixed weather-god epithet, always so rendered.
- 40 *l. 538* "silver-footed Thetis" (ἄργυρόπεζα) — her fixed epithet. The "old man of the sea" is Nereus, her father, never named in the Iliad but always so designated.
- 41 *l. 551* "ox-eyed lady Hera" (βοῶπις πότνια Ἥρη) — her second fixed epithet: large, dark, liquid eyes as an archaic mark of majesty and beauty, possibly a fossil of older theriomorphic cult. Rendered literally.
- 42 *ll. 590-594* Hephaestus' fall: Zeus once hurled him from Olympus for siding with Hera; he fell a whole day, landed on Lemnos, and was tended by the Sintians, the island's non-Greek early inhabitants. Lemnos was the chief historical center of Hephaestus' cult. (Book 18 has a different, incompatible fall-story — thrown by Hera at birth; the poem tolerates both.)

Iliad — Book 2

Zeus sends Agamemnon a false dream; Agamemnon tests the army and nearly loses it; the catalogue of the ships and their captains.

- The other gods, and men who fight from chariots,
slept the whole night through; but sweet sleep did not hold Zeus.
He was turning over in his mind how he might honor
Achilles, and destroy many beside the Achaeans ships.
- 5 And this plan seemed to his heart the best:
to send baneful Dream to Atreus' son Agamemnon.¹
And speaking winged words he addressed him:
"Up, go, baneful Dream, to the Achaeans' swift ships.
Come to the hut of Agamemnon, Atreus' son,
- 10 and tell him everything exactly as I charge you.
Bid him arm the long-haired Achaeans²
in full force: for now he might take the wide-wayed city
of the Trojans. The immortals who keep their homes on Olympus
are no longer divided; Hera has bent them all
- 15 by her begging, and sorrows are fastened on the Trojans."
So he spoke, and Dream went when he had heard the word.
Swiftly he came to the Achaeans' swift ships
and went to Atreus' son Agamemnon. He found him
sleeping in his hut, ambrosial slumber poured around him.
- 20 He stood above his head in the likeness of Neleus' son
Nestor, whom Agamemnon honored most of the elders;
in his likeness the divine Dream spoke:
"You sleep, son of war-minded Atreus, breaker of horses."³
A man of counsel should not sleep the whole night through,
- 25 a man to whom peoples are entrusted, who has so much to care for.
Now hear me quickly: I am a messenger of Zeus,
who far away cares greatly for you, and pities you.
He bids you arm the long-haired Achaeans
in full force: for now you might take the wide-wayed city
- 30 of the Trojans. The immortals who keep their homes on Olympus
are no longer divided; Hera has bent them all

- by her begging, and sorrows are fastened on the Trojans
from Zeus. Keep this in your mind, and let no forgetting
take you, when honey-hearted sleep lets you go."
- 35 So he spoke and went away, and left him there
believing in his heart things that were not to be:
he thought he would take Priam's city on that very day —
the fool: he did not know what work Zeus was planning,
who meant to lay yet more griefs and groans
- 40 on Trojans and Danaans alike through the strong encounters of war.
He woke from sleep, the divine voice drifting around him,
and sat upright, and pulled on his soft tunic,
fine and new-made, and threw his great cloak around him,
and beneath his shining feet he bound fair sandals,
- 45 and slung about his shoulders the silver-studded sword,
and took up the ancestral scepter, imperishable forever,
and with it went down along the ships of the bronze-shirted Achaeans.
Now the goddess Dawn went up to high Olympus,
announcing light to Zeus and the immortals;
- 50 and he ordered the clear-voiced heralds
to summon the long-haired Achaeans to assembly.
They made the summons, and the men gathered quickly.
But first he seated a council of great-hearted elders
beside the ship of Nestor, the Pylos-born king,
- 55 and calling them together he framed his shrewd plan:
"Hear me, friends. A divine Dream came to me in sleep
through the ambrosial night, and in face, in build, in bearing
it was most like brilliant Nestor.
It stood above my head, and it said to me:
- 60 'You sleep, son of war-minded Atreus, breaker of horses.'⁴
A man of counsel should not sleep the whole night through,
a man to whom peoples are entrusted, who has so much to care for.
Now hear me quickly: I am a messenger of Zeus,
who far away cares greatly for you, and pities you.
- 65 He bids you arm the long-haired Achaeans
in full force: for now you might take the wide-wayed city
of the Trojans. The immortals who keep their homes on Olympus
are no longer divided; Hera has bent them all

by her begging, and sorrows are fastened on the Trojans
70 from Zeus. Keep this in your mind.' So the Dream spoke
and flew away, and sweet sleep released me.
Come then — let us see if we can arm the sons of the Achaeans.
But first I will test them with words, as is the custom,⁵
and order them to flee with the many-benched ships;
75 and you, from your places, one here, one there, hold them back with
words."
So he spoke and sat down; and among them rose
Nestor, who was king of sandy Pylos.
With good will toward them he spoke and addressed them:
"Friends, leaders and lords of the Argives,
80 if any other Achaean had told us this dream,
we would call it a lie and turn our backs on it;
but the man who saw it claims to be far the best of the Achaeans.
Come then — let us see if we can arm the sons of the Achaeans."
So he spoke, and led the way out of the council,
85 and the scepter-holding kings rose and obeyed
the shepherd of the people; and the troops came streaming.
As when the tribes of thronging bees come out
of some hollow rock, always arriving anew,
and fly in clusters over the flowers of spring,
90 and some swarm thick this way, and some that way —
so the many tribes of men from the ships and huts
marched in companies along the deep beach
to the assembly; and among them Rumor blazed like fire,
Zeus's messenger, driving them on; and they kept gathering.
95 The assembly was in turmoil, and the earth groaned beneath
as the troops sat down, and there was uproar. Nine heralds,
shouting, tried to hold them back — to stop the clamor
and make them listen to the Zeus-nurtured kings.
With effort the people were seated, held in their places,
100 and left off shouting. Then the lord Agamemnon stood up,
holding the scepter Hephaestus had labored to make.⁶
Hephaestus gave it to lord Zeus, son of Cronos;
then Zeus gave it to the guide, the slayer of Argus;
lord Hermes gave it to Pelops, driver of horses;

- 105 Pelops in turn gave it to Atreus, shepherd of the people;
 Atreus, dying, left it to Thyestes rich in flocks;
 and Thyestes in turn left it to Agamemnon to carry,
 to be lord over many islands and all of Argos.
 Leaning on it, he spoke his words to the Argives:
- 110 "Friends, Danaan heroes, squires of Ares,
 Zeus, Cronos' great son, has bound me fast in heavy blindness —⁷
 the hard god: he promised me once, he bowed his head,
 that I should sack well-walled Ilion before returning;
 now he has planned a cruel deceit, and orders me
- 115 back to Argos in disgrace, with half my people lost.
 Such, it seems, must be the pleasure of overmastering Zeus,
 who has undone the crowns of many cities
 and will undo more yet: his power is the greatest.
 This is a shameful thing even for men to come to hear of,
- 120 that so fine an Achaean host, so great,
 fought a fruitless war and battled
 fewer men, with no end yet in sight.
 For if we wished — Achaeans and Trojans both —
 to swear a solemn truce and count ourselves,
- 125 the Trojans mustering all who have their hearths in the city,
 and we Achaeans forming up in tens,
 and each ten chose one Trojan man to pour its wine,
 many tens would go without a wine-pourer.
 By so much, I tell you, the sons of the Achaeans outnumber
- 130 the Trojans who live in the city. But there are allies,
 spear-wielding men from many cities,
 who beat me far off my course and will not let me
 sack Ilion's well-settled citadel, for all my wanting it.
 Nine years of great Zeus have gone already,
- 135 and now the ships' timbers are rotten, the rigging loosed,
 and our wives, no doubt, and our little children
 sit in our halls waiting; while the work
 for which we came here stands as undone as ever.
 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:
- 140 let us flee with the ships to our dear fatherland.
 We shall not take wide-wayed Troy now."

- So he spoke, and stirred the heart in the breast
 of everyone in the crowd who had not heard the council.
 The assembly moved like the long waves of the sea,
 145 the Icarian deep, when East Wind and South Wind together
 rouse them, rushing down from the clouds of father Zeus;
 or as when the West Wind comes and moves deep grain,
 driving hard, and the field bows its ears —
 so all that assembly was moved. With a roar
 150 they rushed for the ships, and under their feet the dust
 rose and hung; and they shouted to one another
 to lay hold of the ships and drag them to the bright sea,
 and they cleared out the launching-channels; the cry went up to the
 sky
 as they strained for home; and they pulled the props from under the
 hulls.
 155 Then a homecoming beyond fate would have come to the Argives,
 if Hera had not spoken a word to Athena:
 "Shame! Unwearied one, child of aegis-bearing Zeus —⁸
 is it like this, homeward, to their dear fatherland,
 that the Argives are to flee over the broad back of the sea,
 160 and leave to Priam and the Trojans their boast —
 Argive Helen, for whose sake so many Achaeans
 have perished at Troy, far from their dear fatherland?
 Go now through the host of the bronze-shirted Achaeans;
 with your gentle words hold back every man;
 165 do not let them drag the balanced ships down to the sea."
 So she spoke, and the goddess grey-eyed Athena did not disobey.
 Down from the peaks of Olympus she went darting
 and swiftly came to the Achaeans' swift ships.
 There she found Odysseus, the equal of Zeus in counsel,⁹
 170 standing still: he had not laid a hand on his black
 well-benched ship, for grief had reached his heart and spirit.
 Standing close, grey-eyed Athena spoke to him:
 "Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus of many devices,¹⁰
 is it like this, homeward, to your dear fatherland,
 175 that you will all flee, tumbling into the many-benched ships,
 and leave to Priam and the Trojans their boast —

Argive Helen, for whose sake so many Achaeans
 have perished at Troy, far from their dear fatherland?
 Go now through the host of the Achaeans; hold back no longer;
 180 with your gentle words hold back every man;
 do not let them drag the balanced ships down to the sea."
 So she spoke, and he knew the voice of the goddess speaking.
 He set off at a run, and threw off his cloak — the herald
 Eurybates of Ithaca, who attended him, picked it up —
 185 and coming face to face with Agamemnon, Atreus' son,
 he took from him the ancestral scepter, imperishable forever,
 and with it went along the ships of the bronze-shirted Achaeans.
 Whenever he met a king, or a man of note,
 he would stand beside him and hold him back with gentle words:
 190 "Friend, it is not right to threaten you like a coward;
 but sit down yourself, and seat the rest of your people.
 You do not yet clearly know the mind of Atreus' son:
 now he is testing, and soon he will bear down on the sons of the
 Achaeans.¹¹
 Did we not all hear in council what he said?
 195 May he not in anger do some harm to the sons of the Achaeans.
 Great is the anger of Zeus-nurtured kings;
 their honor is from Zeus, and Zeus the counselor loves them."
 But whatever man of the people he saw, and found him shouting,
 him he would drive with the scepter and berate aloud:
 200 "Fool — sit still and listen to what others tell you,
 your betters. You are unwarlike and without strength,
 never counted, whether in battle or in council.
 We cannot all be kings here, we Achaeans.
 The rule of many is no good thing: let there be one ruler,¹²
 205 one king, to whom the son of crooked-counseled Cronos gave
 the scepter and the ordinances, to do the ruling for his people."
 So, masterfully, he went through the army setting it in order; and they
 came streaming back to the assembly from the ships and huts
 with a roar, as when a wave of the loud-roaring sea
 210 thunders on a great beach, and the deep crashes in answer.
 Then the others sat down and were held in their places —
 all but Thersites, alone, still brawling on, unmeasured in speech,¹³

- whose mind was full of words, disorderly and many,
to quarrel with kings — recklessly, in no kind of order,
215 but with whatever looked likely to raise a laugh
among the Argives. And he was the ugliest man who came under Ilion:
bandy-legged, lame in one foot, his two shoulders
hunched and drawn in over his chest; and above them
a head that came to a point, with sparse stubble growing on it.
220 He was hatefullest of all to Achilles and Odysseus,
for those two he was forever reviling. But now it was brilliant
Agamemnon
he went at, shrieking shrill abuse; the Achaeans
were furious at him, and indignation rose in every heart.
Bawling loudly, he berated Agamemnon:
225 "Son of Atreus, what are you complaining of now? What more do you
want?
Your huts are full of bronze; there are many women
in your huts, choice ones, whom we Achaeans
give you first of all whenever we take a town.
Or do you still lack gold as well, that some son
230 of the horse-taming Trojans will bring out of Ilion as ransom
for a son that I bound and led away — I, or another Achaean?
Or a young woman, to lie with in love,
one you keep apart for yourself? It is not right
for the commander to march the sons of the Achaeans into misery.
235 Soft things! Vile disgraces! Achaean women — Achaean men no longer!
Let us go home, home with the ships, and leave this man
here in Troy to digest his prizes, so he may learn
whether we others are any help to him or not —
he who even now dishonored Achilles, a man
240 far better than himself: he has taken and keeps his prize; he seized it
himself.
But there is no anger in Achilles' heart; he lets it go.
Otherwise, son of Atreus, this outrage would be your last."
So he spoke, reviling Agamemnon, shepherd of the people —
Thersites. But quickly brilliant Odysseus was at his side,
245 and glaring at him darkly he lashed him with hard words:
"Thersites — endless babble, clear-voiced speaker though you are:

- stop; do not stand up alone to quarrel with kings.
 I say there is no viler mortal than you
 of all who came under Ilion with the sons of Atreus.
- 250 So you had better not take kings into your mouth when you hold forth,
 hurling insults at them, with one eye on the voyage home.
 We do not even know clearly yet how these things will end —
 whether we sons of the Achaeans come home well or badly.
 So now you sit here reviling Agamemnon, Atreus' son,
- 255 shepherd of the people, because the Danaan heroes
 give him so much. You speak in mockery.
 But I tell you this outright, and it will be accomplished:
 if I find you playing the fool again as you are now,
 then may Odysseus' head no longer sit on his shoulders,
- 260 may I no longer be called the father of Telemachus,
 if I do not seize you and strip you of your own clothes,
 the cloak and the tunic that cover your shame,
 and send you off to the swift ships in tears,
 whipped out of the assembly with strokes of disgrace."
- 265 So he spoke, and with the scepter he struck his back
 and shoulders. Thersites doubled up, and a fat tear fell from him,
 and a bloody welt rose up out of his back
 under the golden scepter. He sat down, terrified,
 and hurting, with a helpless look, he wiped away the tear.
- 270 And the men, vexed at heart though they were, laughed at him sweetly,
 and thus one would say, with a glance at his neighbor:
 "Well now! Odysseus has done ten thousand good things,
 leading in good counsel, marshaling war;
 but this is the best thing he has done among the Argives:
- 275 he has shut this word-slinging insulter out of our debates.
 That proud heart of his will not send him back again
 to rail at kings with words of abuse."
 So spoke the multitude. Then the sacker of cities, Odysseus,
 stood up with the scepter, and beside him grey-eyed Athena,
- 280 in the likeness of a herald, called the host to silence,
 so that near and far the sons of the Achaeans
 might hear his word alike, and take in his counsel.
 With good will toward them he spoke and addressed them:

"Son of Atreus — now, lord, the Achaeans mean
 285 to make you the most despised of mortal men,
 and they will not fulfill the promise they undertook
 while still on the way here from horse-pasturing Argos:
 that you should sack well-walled Ilion before returning.
 Like little children or widowed women
 290 they wail to one another about going home.
 And truly, there is toil here to send a man home disheartened:
 a man kept even one month from his wife
 frets by his many-benched ship when the winter gales
 and the rising sea shut him in;
 295 and for us this is the ninth year, circling round,
 that we have stayed here. So I cannot blame the Achaeans
 for fretting beside the beaked ships. But even so —
 it is shameful to wait so long and then come home empty.
 Bear up, friends, and stay a while longer, till we learn
 300 whether Calchas prophesies truly or not.
 For this we know well in our hearts, and you are all
 witnesses — all whom the fates of death have not carried off:
 only yesterday, it seems, when the Achaean ships were gathering
 at Aulis, bearing evils for Priam and the Trojans,
 305 and we, around a spring, at the holy altars,
 were offering the immortals perfect hecatombs
 under a beautiful plane tree, where the bright water ran:
 there a great sign appeared. A serpent, its back blood-dark,
 terrible, which the Olympian himself had sent into the light,
 310 darted from under the altar and made for the plane tree.
 There were nestling sparrows there, baby chicks,
 on the topmost branch, cowering under the leaves —
 eight of them, and the mother who hatched them made nine.
 There he devoured them, cheeping piteously,
 315 while the mother fluttered around, crying for her dear chicks;
 and coiling up he caught her by the wing as she shrieked about him.
 But when he had eaten the sparrow's children and the bird herself,
 the god who had shown him made him a sign conspicuous:¹⁴
 the son of crooked-counseled Cronos turned him to stone,
 320 and we stood there marveling at what had happened.

- So then: since this dread portent entered the gods' hecatombs,
 Calchas straightway spoke in prophecy:
 'Why have you fallen silent, long-haired Achaeans?
 For us Zeus the counselor has shown this great sign,
 325 late, late of fulfillment, whose fame will never perish.
 As this serpent ate the sparrow's children and the bird herself —
 eight, and the mother who hatched them made nine —
 so shall we make war here for as many years,
 and in the tenth we shall take the wide-wayed city.'
 330 That is how he spoke; and now it is all being fulfilled.
 Come then, stay, all of you, strong-greaved Achaeans,
 right here, until we take the great city of Priam."
 So he spoke, and the Argives roared aloud — and around them the ships
 echoed terribly under the shouting of the Achaeans —
 335 in praise of the word of godlike Odysseus.
 And among them spoke the Gerenian horseman Nestor:¹⁵
 "Shame! You hold assembly like little boys,
 infants with no interest in deeds of war.
 Where then will our compacts go, and our oaths?
 340 Into the fire, then, with every counsel and plan of men,
 the unmixed libations, the right hands we trusted!
 We are battling with words, and nothing else; a remedy
 we cannot find, for all our long time here.
 Son of Atreus — hold your counsel unshaken, as before,
 345 and lead the Argives through the strong encounters;
 and let them rot, the one or two of the Achaeans
 who take counsel apart — they will accomplish nothing —
 all for going back to Argos before we know
 whether the promise of aegis-bearing Zeus is a lie or not.
 350 For I say the overmastering son of Cronos bowed his head
 on that day when the Argives went aboard their swift-faring ships
 bearing slaughter and doom for the Trojans:
 lightening on the right, showing signs of good omen.
 Therefore let no man press to be gone homeward
 355 before he has lain beside the wife of some Trojan,
 and avenged the struggles and groans of Helen.¹⁶
 But if any man is wildly set on going home,

- let him just lay a hand on his black well-benched ship,
and before all others he will meet his death and doom.
- 360 And you, lord — take good counsel yourself, and listen to another;
not to be tossed aside is the word I speak:
divide the men by tribes and by clans, Agamemnon,
so clan may stand by clan, and tribe by tribe.
If you do this, and the Achaeans obey,
- 365 you will know then which of your leaders is a coward, and which of
your men,
and which is brave: for they will be fighting among their own.
And you will know whether it is by the gods' will you fail to take the
city,
or by men's cowardice and folly in war."
- Answering him spoke the lord Agamemnon:
- 370 "Once again, old man, you outdo the sons of the Achaeans in speech.
O father Zeus, Athena, Apollo —
if I had ten such counselors among the Achaeans,
then the city of lord Priam would soon bow its head,
taken and sacked beneath our hands.
- 375 But instead aegis-bearing Zeus, Cronos' son, gives me griefs,
throwing me into fruitless quarrels and feuds.
I and Achilles fought over a girl
with head-on words — and it was I who began the anger.
If ever we take counsel as one, then no longer
- 380 will there be any putting off of evil for the Trojans, not for a moment.
Now go to your meal, so we may join battle.
Let every man sharpen his spear well, and set his shield right,
let him give his swift-footed horses their feed,
let him look over his chariot on every side, and put his mind on war,
- 385 so that all day long we may measure ourselves in hateful battle.
For there will be no pause, not the least,
until night comes on and parts the fury of men.
The strap of the body-covering shield will be sweated through
on many a chest, and the hand will ache around the spear,
- 390 and many a horse will sweat, straining at the polished chariot.
And whomever I see minded to hang back from the fighting,
lingering by the beaked ships — for him there will be

no hope after that of escaping the dogs and the birds."
 So he spoke, and the Argives roared aloud, like a wave
 395 against a high headland when the South Wind comes and drives it
 on a jutting cliff — the waves never leave it,
 whatever wind is blowing, whether they rise this side or that.
 They stood up and scattered, hurrying to the ships,
 and made their fires smoke among the huts, and took their meal.
 400 And each man sacrificed to one of the gods who are forever,
 praying to escape death and the grind of Ares.
 But Agamemnon, lord of men, slaughtered an ox,
 fat, five years old, to the overmastering son of Cronos,
 and called the elders, the chief men of all the Achaeans:
 405 Nestor first of all, and lord Idomeneus,
 then the two Ajaxes and Tydeus' son,
 and sixth Odysseus, the equal of Zeus in counsel.
 And Menelaus, good at the war-cry, came unbidden,¹⁷
 for he knew in his heart how his brother labored.
 410 They stood around the ox and took up the barley-grains,
 and praying among them the lord Agamemnon spoke:
 "Zeus, most glorious, greatest, lord of the dark cloud, dwelling in the
 sky:
 let not the sun go down, nor the darkness come,
 until I have thrown down Priam's hall headlong,
 415 blackened with smoke, and burned its doors with hostile fire,
 and slashed the tunic on Hector's chest to rags
 with the bronze; and around him may his companions, many of them,
 fall face-down in the dust and bite the earth."
 So he spoke; but the son of Cronos would not yet grant it.
 420 He accepted the offering — and piled up joyless toil.
 Then, when they had prayed and thrown the barley-grains,
 they first drew back the victims' heads, cut their throats, and flayed
 them,
 carved out the thigh-pieces and wrapped them in fat,
 making a double fold, and laid raw flesh upon them;
 425 these they burned on dry leafless billets,
 and spitted the inner parts and held them over the flame of
 Hephaestus.

- When the thighs were burned and they had tasted the inner parts,
they cut up the rest and threaded it on spits,
roasted it with care, and drew it all off.
- 430 Then when they had finished the work and made the meal ready,
they feasted, and no heart lacked a fair share of the feast.
And when they had put away desire for eating and drinking,
the Gerenian horseman Nestor began to speak among them:
"Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of men Agamemnon,
435 let us sit talking here no longer, nor delay
any further the work the god is putting in our hands.
Come: let the heralds of the bronze-shirted Achaeans
make their cry and gather the host along the ships,
and let us go down together, as we are, through the wide Achaean
camp,
440 to waken sharp Ares the sooner."
So he spoke, and the lord of men Agamemnon did not disobey.
At once he ordered the clear-voiced heralds
to summon the long-haired Achaeans to battle;
they made the summons, and the men gathered quickly.
- 445 The Zeus-nurtured kings around Atreus' son
hurried about marshaling them, and among them grey-eyed Athena,
holding the aegis — precious, unaging, immortal,¹⁸
from which a hundred tassels of pure gold float free,
all finely woven, each worth a hundred oxen.
- 450 With it she flashed through the Achaean host,
driving them on; and in each man's heart she roused strength
to war and fight without ceasing.
And at once war became sweeter to them than going home
in the hollow ships to their dear fatherland.
- 455 As an annihilating fire blazes up through a boundless forest
on the peaks of a mountain, and the glare shows from far away,
so, as they marched, from the tremendous bronze
a gleam went flashing through the upper air to the sky.
And as the many tribes of winged birds —
460 geese, or cranes, or long-necked swans —
on the Asian meadow around the streams of Caystrius
fly this way and that, glorying in their wings,

settling with cries, always advancing, and the meadow rings —
 so their many tribes from the ships and huts
 465 poured out onto the Scamandrian plain, and beneath them the ground
 thundered terribly under the feet of men and horses.
 They stood in the flowering Scamandrian meadow,
 tens of thousands, as many as the leaves and flowers in their season.
 As the many tribes of thronging flies
 470 that swarm through a herdsman's steading
 in the season of spring, when milk wets the pails,
 so many were the long-haired Achaeans who stood in the plain
 facing the Trojans, mad to break them.
 And as goatherds easily sort out
 475 their wide-wandering flocks of goats when they mingle at pasture,
 so the leaders sorted the men this way and that
 to go into battle, and among them the lord Agamemnon:
 in eyes and head like Zeus who delights in thunder,
 in girdle like Ares, in chest like Poseidon.
 480 As a bull stands out far the finest of all in the herd,
 conspicuous among the gathering cattle,
 such did Zeus make Atreus' son on that day,
 conspicuous among many, preeminent among heroes.
 Tell me now, Muses, who keep your homes on Olympus —¹⁹
 485 for you are goddesses, you are present, you know all things,
 while we hear only the report and know nothing —
 who were the leaders and lords of the Danaans.
 The multitude I could not tell nor name,
 not if I had ten tongues and ten mouths,
 490 a voice unbreakable, and a heart of bronze within me,
 unless the Olympian Muses, daughters of aegis-bearing
 Zeus, remembered for me all who came under Ilion.
 But the captains of the ships I will tell, and all the ships.
 Of the Boeotians, Peneleos and Leïtus were leaders,²⁰
 495 with Arcesilaus and Prothoenor and Clonius:
 they who dwelt in Hyria and rocky Aulis,
 in Schoenus and Scolus and Eteonus of the many ridges,
 Thespeia, Graea, and spacious Mycalessus;
 who dwelt around Harma and Eilesium and Erythrae;

- 500 who held Eleon and Hyle and Peteon,
 Ocalea and Medeon, that well-built citadel,
 Copae, Eutresis, and Thisbe of the many doves;
 who held Coroneia and grassy Haliartus;
 who held Plataea; who dwelt in Glisas;
- 505 who held Hypothebae, that well-built citadel,
 and holy Onchestus, Poseidon's shining grove;
 who held Arne rich in grapes, and Mideia,
 sacred Nisa, and Anthedon at the land's edge:
 of these came fifty ships, and in each one
- 510 a hundred and twenty young men of the Boeotians.
 And those who lived in Aspledon and Minyan Orchomenus
 were led by Ascalaphus and Ialmenus, sons of Ares,
 whom Astyoche bore in the house of Actor, Azeus' son —
 a modest maiden: she went up to her upper chamber,
- 515 and mighty Ares lay with her in secret.
 With them thirty hollow ships sailed in order.
 And the Phocians were led by Schedius and Epistrophus,
 sons of great-hearted Iphitus, Naubolus' son:
 they who held Cyparissus and rocky Pytho,
- 520 holy Crisa and Daulis and Panopeus;
 who dwelt around Anemoreia and Hyampolis;
 who lived along the brilliant river Cephissus;
 who held Lilaea at the springs of Cephissus.
 With them followed forty black ships.
- 525 Their leaders were busy ranging the Phocian ranks,
 and they armed close beside the Boeotians, on the left.
 Of the Locrians, swift Ajax led, Oileus' son —
 the lesser Ajax, in no way so big as Telamonian Ajax
 but far smaller: a little man, in a linen corslet,²¹
- 530 but with the spear he surpassed all Hellenes and Achaeans:
 they who dwelt in Cynus and Opoeis and Calliarus,
 Bessa and Scarphe and lovely Augeae,
 Tarphe and Thronium, around the streams of Boagrius.
 With him followed forty black ships
- 535 of the Locrians who live across from holy Euboea.
 And the Abantes, breathing fury, who held Euboea —

Chalcis and Eretria and Histiaea rich in grapes,
 Cerinthus by the sea and the steep citadel of Dios;
 who held Carystus; who dwelt in Styra —
 540 these were led by Elephenor, scion of Ares,
 Chalcodon's son, chief of the great-hearted Abantes.
 With him followed the swift Abantes, hair grown long behind,
 spearmen eager with outstretched ash-wood spears
 to tear the cuirasses on the chests of their enemies.
 545 With him followed forty black ships.
 And those who held Athens, that well-built citadel,
 the district of great-hearted Erechtheus, whom once Athena²²
 raised, Zeus's daughter — the grain-giving earth had borne him —
 and settled in Athens, in her own rich temple,
 550 where the young men of the Athenians seek his favor
 with bulls and rams as the years come round —
 these were led by Menestheus, son of Peteos.
 No man on the face of the earth was his equal
 at marshaling horses and shield-bearing men;
 555 Nestor alone rivaled him, for he was older.
 With him followed fifty black ships.
 And Ajax led twelve ships from Salamis,²³
 and brought them and set them where the Athenian ranks stood.
 And those who held Argos and walled Tiryns,
 560 Hermione and Asine that lie on the deep gulf,
 Troezen, Eïones, and vine-clad Epidaurus,
 and the young Achaean men who held Aegina and Mases —
 these were led by Diomedes, good at the war-cry,
 and Sthenelus, dear son of famed Capaneus;
 565 and with them went a third, Euryalus, a godlike man,
 son of lord Mecisteus, Talaus' son;
 but the leader of them all was Diomedes, good at the war-cry.
 With them followed eighty black ships.
 And those who held Mycenae, that well-built citadel,
 570 and wealthy Corinth and well-built Cleonae;
 who dwelt in Orneiae and lovely Araethyrea
 and Sicyon, where Adrastus first was king;
 who held Hyperesia and steep Gonoessa

and Pellene; who dwelt around Aegium
 575 and through all Aegialus and around broad Helice —
 of their hundred ships the leader was the lord Agamemnon,
 Atreus' son. With him followed by far the most
 and the best troops; and he among them, clad in gleaming bronze,
 glorying, stood out preeminent among all the heroes,
 580 because he was the best, and led by far the most men.
 And those who held hollow Lacedaemon full of ravines,
 Pharis and Sparta and Messe of the many doves;
 who dwelt in Bryseiae and lovely Augeae;
 who held Amyclae and Helos, the citadel by the sea;
 585 who held Laas and dwelt around Oetylus —
 these his brother led, Menelaus, good at the war-cry,
 with sixty ships; and they armed apart.
 He himself moved among them, trusting his own eagerness,
 urging them to war; and beyond all others his heart was set
 590 on avenging the struggles and groans of Helen.
 And those who dwelt in Pylos and lovely Arene,
 Thryon, the ford of Alpheius, and well-built Aepy;
 who lived in Cyparisseeis and Amphigeneia,
 Pteleos and Helos and Dorium — where the Muses²⁴
 595 met Thamyras the Thracian and ended his singing,
 as he came from Oechalia, from Eurytus the Oechalian:
 for he had vowed in his boasting that he would win, even if
 the Muses themselves should sing, the daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus;
 and in their anger they maimed him: they took away
 600 his wondrous song and made him forget his harping —
 these were led by the Gerenian horseman Nestor.
 With him ninety hollow ships sailed in order.
 And those who held Arcadia under the steep mountain of Cyllene,
 beside the tomb of Aepytus, where men fight hand to hand;
 605 who dwelt in Pheneos and Orchomenus rich in flocks,
 Rhipse and Stratie and windswept Enispe;
 who held Tegea and lovely Mantinea;
 who held Stymphele and dwelt in Parrhasia —
 these were led by Ancaeus's son, the lord Agapenor,
 610 with sixty ships, and in each ship many

- Arcadian men went aboard, skilled fighters.
 For the lord of men Agamemnon himself had given them
 the well-benched ships to cross the wine-dark sea —
 Atreus' son — since the works of the sea were no concern of theirs.
- 615 And those who dwelt in Buprasium and brilliant Elis,
 all that Hyrmine and Myrsinus at the land's edge
 and the Olenian rock and Alesium enclose between them —
 of these there were four leaders, and ten swift ships
 followed each man, with many Epeians aboard.
- 620 Two of them, Amphimachus and Thalpius, led —
 sons, one of Cteatus, one of Eurytus, of Actor's line;
 of the third company strong Dioreas was leader, Amarynceus' son;
 and of the fourth godlike Polyxeinus was leader,
 son of lord Agasthenes, Augeias' son.
- 625 And those from Dulichium and the holy Echinae,
 the islands that lie across the sea facing Elis —
 these were led by Meges, the equal of Ares,
 Phyleus' son, whom the horseman Phyleus dear to Zeus begot —
 who once, angered at his father, had moved away to Dulichium.
- 630 With him followed forty black ships.
 And Odysseus led the great-hearted Cephallenians,
 who held Ithaca and Neriton with quivering leaves;
 who dwelt in Crocyleia and rugged Aegilips;
 who held Zacynthus; who dwelt around Samos;
 635 who held the mainland and dwelt on the facing shores —
 these Odysseus led, the equal of Zeus in counsel,
 and with him followed twelve ships with cheeks of vermilion.²⁵
 And the Aetolians were led by Thoas, Andraemon's son:
 they who dwelt in Pleuron and Olenus and Pylene,
 640 Chalcis by the shore and rocky Calydon.
 For the sons of great-hearted Oeneus were no more,
 and he himself was no more, and fair-haired Meleager was dead;
 so on Thoas the whole rule of the Aetolians had been laid.
 With him followed forty black ships.
- 645 Of the Cretans, Idomeneus, famed with the spear, was leader:
 they who held Cnossos and walled Gortyn,
 Lyctus and Miletus and chalk-white Lycastus,

Phaestus and Rhytium, fine cities to live in,
 and the others who dwelt through hundred-citied Crete.
 650 Of these Idomeneus, famed with the spear, was leader,
 with Meriones, the equal of Enyalius, slayer of men.
 With them followed eighty black ships.
 And Tlepolemus, Heracles' son, tall and strong,
 led nine ships from Rhodes, of the lordly Rhodians,
 665 who dwelt through Rhodes in three divisions:
 Lindus, Ialysus, and chalk-white Cameirus.
 Their leader was Tlepolemus, famed with the spear,
 whom Astyocheia bore to the might of Heracles —
 he brought her out of Ephyra, from the river Selleïs,
 660 after sacking many towns of Zeus-nurtured fighting men.
 Now when Tlepolemus was grown in the well-built hall,
 he killed, on the instant, his own father's dear uncle,
 Licymnius, scion of Ares, already growing old;
 and quickly he built ships, gathered a great following,
 665 and fled away over the sea, for the others threatened him —
 the sons and the grandsons of the might of Heracles.
 He came at last to Rhodes, a wanderer, a man of sorrows;
 and there they settled in three parts, tribe by tribe, and were loved
 by Zeus, who is king over gods and men,
 670 and the son of Cronos poured wondrous wealth upon them.
 And Nireus led three balanced ships from Syme —²⁶
 Nireus, son of Aglaïa and lord Charopus;
 Nireus, the most beautiful man who came under Ilion
 of all the Danaans, after the blameless son of Peleus.
 675 But he was a slight man, and few people followed him.
 And those who held Nisyrus and Crapathus and Casus,
 and Cos, city of Eurypylus, and the Calydnae islands —
 these were led by Pheidippus and Antiphus,
 two sons of lord Thessalus, Heracles' son.
 680 With them thirty hollow ships sailed in order.
 Now all those who dwelt in Pelasgian Argos,
 who lived in Alos and Alope and Trachis;
 who held Phthia and Hellas of the beautiful women —
 and they were called Myrmidons, and Hellenes, and Achaeans —

- 685 of their fifty ships Achilles was captain.
 But they had no thought of grim-voiced war;²⁷
 there was no one to lead them into the ranks.
 For swift-footed brilliant Achilles lay among the ships,
 in wrath over the girl, Briseis of the lovely hair,
 690 whom he had taken out of Lyrnessus with great toil,
 when he sacked Lyrnessus and the walls of Thebe
 and cut down Mynes and Epistrophus, the spear-mad
 sons of lord Euenus, Selepius' son.
 Grieving for her he lay there; but he was soon to rise.
 695 And those who held Phylace and flowering Pyrasus,
 Demeter's precinct, and Iton, mother of flocks,
 Antron by the sea, and Pteleos deep in meadow-grass —
 these warlike Protesilaus had led
 while he lived; but by then the black earth held him under.
 700 His wife, cheeks torn with mourning, was left behind in Phylace,
 his house but half-built: a Dardanian man had killed him²⁸
 as he leapt from his ship, far the first of the Achaeans.
 Yet the men were not leaderless, though they longed for their leader:
 Podarces, scion of Ares, set them in order,
 705 son of Iphiclus rich in flocks, Phylacus' son,
 own brother of great-hearted Protesilaus,
 the younger-born; the elder and the better man
 was the hero Protesilaus the warlike. So the people
 lacked no leader, though they longed for the brave man gone.
 710 With him followed forty black ships.
 And those who dwelt in Pherae beside Lake Boebeïs,
 in Boebe and Glaphyrae and well-built Iolcus —
 these Admetus' dear son led with eleven ships:
 Eumelus, whom Alcestis bore to Admetus —
 715 brilliant among women, loveliest of the daughters of Pelias.
 And those who dwelt in Methone and Thaumacia;
 who held Meliboea and rugged Olizon —
 these Philoctetes led, the master bowman,²⁹
 with seven ships; and in each one fifty rowers
 720 had come aboard, all skilled bowmen, strong fighters.
 But he lay on an island, suffering hard pains,

on sacred Lemnos, where the sons of the Achaeans had left him
 tormented by the evil wound of the murderous water-snake.
 There he lay grieving. But soon the Argives by their ships
 725 were to remember lord Philoctetes.
 Yet the men were not leaderless, though they longed for their leader:
 Medon set them in order, Oïleus' bastard son,
 whom Rhene bore to Oïleus, sacker of cities.
 And those who held Tricca and terraced Ithome;
 730 who held Oechalia, city of Eurytus the Oechalian —
 these were led by the two sons of Asclepius,
 the good healers Podaleirius and Machaon.
 With them thirty hollow ships sailed in order.
 And those who held Ormenion and the spring Hypereia;
 735 who held Asterium and the white peaks of Titanus —
 these Eurypylus led, Euaemon's shining son.
 With him followed forty black ships.
 And those who held Argissa; who dwelt in Gyrtone,
 Orthe and Elone and the white city Oloosson —
 740 these were led by Polypoetes, steadfast in battle,
 son of Peirithous, whom immortal Zeus begot;
 famed Hippodameia bore him to Peirithous
 on the day he took vengeance on the shaggy beast-men
 and drove them out of Pelion, and pushed them to the Aethices.
 745 Not alone: with him was Leonteus, scion of Ares,
 son of high-hearted Coronus, Caeneus' son.
 With them followed forty black ships.
 And Gouneus led two and twenty ships from Cyphus,
 and with him followed the Enienes and the battle-steadfast Peraebians,
 750 who set their homes around wintry Dodona;
 who worked the fields around lovely Titaressus,
 the river that pours his fair-flowing water into Peneius —
 yet he does not mingle with the silver eddies of Peneius,
 but flows along on top of him like oil:
 755 for he is a branch broken off the water of Styx, the dread oath.
 And the Magnetes were led by Prothoos, Tenthredon's son:
 they who dwelt around Peneius and Pelion
 of the quivering leaves. Swift Prothoos was their leader,

- and with him followed forty black ships.
- 760 These, then, were the leaders and lords of the Danaans.
 Now which was far the best of them — tell me, Muse —
 of the men, and of the horses, that followed the sons of Atreus?
 Best by far of the horses were the mares of Pheres' line,
 which Eumelus drove: swift-footed as birds,
 765 matched in coat and matched in years, their backs as level as a plumb-
 line.
 Apollo of the silver bow had raised them in Pereia,
 both of them mares, carrying with them the panic of war.
 And of the men, far the best was Telamonian Ajax —
 while Achilles kept his wrath: for he was mightiest by far,
 770 he, and the horses that carried the blameless son of Peleus.
 But he lay among his beaked seagoing ships,
 nursing his rage at Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,
 Atreus' son; and his men along the surf-line of the sea
 amused themselves throwing the discus and the hunting-spear,
 775 and shooting with bows; and the horses, each beside its chariot,
 stood cropping lotus and marsh-grown parsley,
 while the chariots lay well covered in the huts
 of their lords; and the men, longing for their leader dear to Ares,
 drifted here and there through the camp, and did not fight.
- 780 On the others came, as if all the land were swept with fire;
 and the earth groaned beneath them, as under Zeus who delights in
 thunder
 in his anger, when he lashes the earth around Typhoeus³⁰
 among the Arimi, where they say Typhoeus has his bed:
 so the earth groaned greatly under their feet
 785 as they came on; and very swiftly they crossed the plain.
 And to the Trojans went wind-footed swift Iris, a messenger³¹
 from aegis-bearing Zeus, with a grievous message.
 They were holding assembly at Priam's doors,
 all gathered together, the young men and the old.
- 790 Standing close, swift-footed Iris spoke to them,
 likening her voice to Priam's son Polites,
 who sat as lookout of the Trojans, trusting the speed of his feet,
 on the very top of the tomb of old Aesyetes,

watching for when the Achaeans should rush out from their ships;
 795 in his likeness swift-footed Iris spoke:
 "Old man, endless talk is always dear to you,
 as once it was in peacetime; but relentless war is upon us.
 Truly I have gone into very many battles of men,
 but never yet have I seen such a host, so great:
 800 for like the leaves, like the sands, in their multitude
 they are coming over the plain to fight for the city.
 Hector, you above all I charge to do this:
 there are many allies through Priam's great city,
 and tongue differs from tongue among men of scattered lands.
 805 Let each man give the word to those he rules;
 let him marshal his own townsmen, and lead them out."
 So she spoke, and Hector did not fail to know the goddess's voice.
 At once he dissolved the assembly, and they rushed to arms.
 All the gates were flung open, and the host streamed out,
 810 foot-soldiers and horsemen; and a great din arose.
 There is a steep mound out before the city,
 apart in the plain, with open ground on every side;
 men call it Batieia,
 but the immortals call it the tomb of Myrine, light of step.³²
 815 There the Trojans and their allies formed their divisions.
 The Trojans were led by great Hector of the flashing helmet,³³
 Priam's son; with him by far the most and the best
 troops armed themselves, eager with their spears.
 The Dardanians were led by the good son of Anchises,
 820 Aeneas, whom brilliant Aphrodite bore to Anchises
 on the spurs of Ida, a goddess bedded with a mortal.
 Not alone: with him were Antenor's two sons,
 Archelochus and Acamas, skilled in all fighting.
 And those who dwelt in Zeleia under the lowest foot of Ida,
 825 men of wealth, who drink the dark water of Aesepus,
 Trojans — these were led by Lycaon's shining son,
 Pandarus, to whom Apollo himself gave the bow.
 And those who held Adresteia and the district of Apaesus;
 who held Pityeia and the steep mount of Tereia —
 830 these were led by Adrestus and Amphius of the linen corslet,

- two sons of Merops of Percote, who beyond all men
 knew the seer's art, and would not let his sons
 go to man-destroying war; but the two would not
 obey him: the fates of black death were leading them on.
- 835 And those who dwelt around Percote and Practius;
 who held Sestus and Abydos and brilliant Arisbe —
 these were led by Hyrtacus' son Asius, marshal of men —
 Asius, Hyrtacus' son, whom horses carried from Arisbe,
 tall and fire-colored, from the river Selleïs.
- 840 And Hippothous led the tribes of the Pelasgian spearmen,
 those who dwelt in deep-soiled Larisa;
 these were led by Hippothous and Pylaeus, scion of Ares,
 two sons of Pelasgian Lethus, Teutamus' son.
 And the Thracians were led by Acamas and the hero Peirooms —
- 845 all those the strong-flowing Hellespont encloses.
 And Euphemus was captain of the Ciconian spearmen,
 son of Zeus-nurtured Troezenus, Ceas' son.
 And Pyraechmes led the Paeonians of the curved bows,
 from far away, from Amydon, from the wide-flowing Axius —
- 850 Axius, whose water spreads fairest over the earth.
 And the Paphlagonians were led by Pylaemenes of the shaggy heart,
 from the Eneti, where the breed of wild mules is born:
 they who held Cytorus and dwelt around Sesamus,
 whose famed homes stood around the river Parthenius,
- 855 Cromna and Aegialus and the heights of Erythini.
 And the Halizones were led by Odios and Epistrophus,
 from far away, from Alybe, where silver has its birthplace.
 And the Mysians were led by Chromis, and Ennomus the bird-reader —
 but his birds did not save him from black doom:
- 860 he was broken under the hands of the swift-footed son of Aeacus³⁴
 in the river, where Achilles cut down Trojans and others with them.
 And Phorcys led the Phrygians, with godlike Ascanius,
 from far Ascania; and they were eager to fight in the press of battle.
 And the Maeonians were led by Mesthles and Antiphus,
- 865 the two sons of Talaemenes, whom the Gygaean lake bore;
 they led the Maeonians, born under Tmolus.
 And Nastes was captain of the Carians of barbarous speech,³⁵

who held Miletus and the mountain of Phthires, dense with leaves,
the streams of Maeander and the steep peaks of Mycale;
870 these were led by Amphimachus and Nastes —
Nastes and Amphimachus, the shining children of Nomion.
And one of them went to war decked in gold, like a girl —
the fool: it did not ward off wretched destruction from him;
he was broken under the hands of the swift-footed son of Aeacus
875 in the river, and war-minded Achilles carried off the gold.
And Sarpedon led the Lycians, with blameless Glaucus,
from far Lycia, from the eddying Xanthus.

NOTES TO BOOK 2

- 1 l. 6 "baneful Dream" (οὔλον ὄνειρον) — Dream is a personified agent here, capitalized accordingly. That Zeus sends a deliberately lying dream scandalized ancient readers (Plato cites this passage disapprovingly, Republic 383a); the poem itself is unembarrassed — the deception is the mechanism of Zeus's promise to Thetis.
- 2 l. 11 "long-haired Achaeans" (κάρη κομόωντες Ἀχαιοί) — stock epithet of the army, literally "letting the hair grow long on the head"; always so rendered.
- 3 l. 23 "breaker of horses" (ἵπποδάμοιο) — here of Atreus; later in the poem it is the standing epithet of the Trojans and of Hector ("horse-taming Trojans," 230). Rendered "breaker(s) of horses" for individuals, "horse-taming" for the people.
- 4 ll. 60-70 The Dream repeats Zeus's instructions verbatim, and Agamemnon repeats them verbatim again to the council — standard epic messenger technique. Zenodotus' text drastically condensed such repetitions (apparatus, Line 60-70), and he omitted 157-168 below (Hera's speech restated by Athena) entirely, replacing it with a single line (apparatus, Line 156, 157-168). The vulgate keeps the full repetitions; so does this translation, in identical English each time.
- 5 l. 73 "I will test them with words, as is the custom" (ἢ θέμις ἐστί) — the "testing" (peira) is one of the poem's strangest plot devices: no custom of testing armies is otherwise known, and the plan nearly destroys the expedition. The phrase may mean only "as is my right." Translated neutrally; the narrative logic is left as the poem leaves it — precarious.
- 6 ll. 101-108 The scepter's pedigree — Hephaestus, Zeus, Hermes, Pelops, Atreus, Thyestes, Agamemnon — is a title-deed in miniature: Agamemnon's authority is literally handed down from Zeus. "The slayer of Argus" (ἀργεΐφόντης) is Hermes' fixed epithet, of disputed meaning ("Argus-slayer" is the traditional reading and is kept); "the guide" (διάκτορος) is his companion title.
- 7 ll. 111-118 Zenodotus athetized this opening of the speech (apparatus). Lines 111-118 recur nearly verbatim at 9.18-25, where Agamemnon speaks them in earnest; here they are play-acted despair. Note the vocabulary: Zeus "bound me in heavy blindness" (ἄτη) — the same word Achilles used of him at 1.412, and Agamemnon concedes at 378 that "it was I who began the anger."
- 8 l. 157 "Unwearied one" (Ἀτρυτώνη) — obscure cult title of Athena, traditionally derived from "not to be worn down"; rendered by that traditional sense.
- 9 l. 169 "the equal of Zeus in counsel" (Διὶ μῆτιν ἀτάλαντον) — Odysseus' loftiest epithet, crediting him with mētis, the cunning practical intelligence that is also Zeus's; always so rendered.
- 10 l. 173 "Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus of many devices" (διογενὲς Λαερτιάδῃ πολυμήχαν' Ὀδυσσεῦ) — the full-line address formula used for Odysseus throughout

both epics; πολυμήχανος ("of many devices") is kept distinct from πολύμητις ("resourceful").

- 11 *ll. 193-197* Aristarchus athetized these five lines, and they are independently absent from Xenophon's quotation of the passage (*Memorabilia* 1.2.56) — two converging hints they may not be original (apparatus at lines 193-197). Without them, Odysseus' speech to the kings loses its "he is only testing" explanation. Translated as printed; the two-tier treatment of kings and commoners on either side of this line is in any case secure. One crux inside the passage: 194 is printed here as a rhetorical question ("Did we not all hear in council what he said?" — so Lattimore), but Kirk reads it as a statement — "in council we did NOT all hear what he said" — which better explains why the man addressed needs Odysseus's telling. The question-rendering stands; the alternative is recorded.
- 12 *l. 204* "The rule of many is no good thing: let there be one ruler" (οὐκ ἀγαθὸν πολυκοιρανίη· εἷς κοίρανος ἔστω) — the most quoted political sentence in Homer (Aristotle cites it in the *Metaphysics* in defense of monarchy). In context it is crowd-control rhetoric, not constitutional theory.
- 13 *ll. 212-219* Thersites is the only common soldier in the *Iliad* who is named, described, and given a speech — and the description is a catalogue of deformities, the epic's physiognomic shorthand for baseness (contrast every hero's beauty). His name suggests θέρσος, "audacity." Zenodotus athetized 220-223 (apparatus). Notice that his complaints against Agamemnon are substantively Achilles' complaints from Book 1, voiced one rung down the social ladder — and answered with a beating the assembly applauds.
- 14 *ll. 318-319* "made him a sign conspicuous" — the vulgate reads ἀρίζηλον ("very plain to see"); the petrified serpent becomes a lasting marker of the portent. An ancient variant read ἄϊζηλον ("unseen"); the god made the serpent vanish. Aristarchus athetized 319 (the petrification line) outright (apparatus, Line 318, 319). Translated from the printed text: conspicuous, then turned to stone.
- 15 *l. 336* "the Gerenian horseman Nestor" (Γερήνιος ἵπποτα Νέστωρ) — his fixed title henceforth; "Gerenian" was obscure already in antiquity (usually connected with Gerenia in Messenia, where Nestor was said to have been raised). Always so rendered.
- 16 *l. 356* "the struggles and groans of Helen" (Ἑλένης ὀρμήματά τε στοναχάς τε) — ambiguous since antiquity: either Helen's own strivings and griefs (a Helen carried off unwilling), or the struggles and groans fought and suffered over her. The English keeps the genitive's ambiguity. The line recurs at 590 of Menelaus.
- 17 *l. 408* "good at the war-cry" (βοῇν ἀγαθός) — fixed epithet of Menelaus and Diomedes: the carrying battlefield voice as a command skill. Always so rendered. Menelaus coming "unbidden" to his brother's feast was proverbial in antiquity.
- 18 *ll. 447-449* The aegis (see Book 1, note [21]) here gets its fullest description: a hundred all-gold tassels, "each worth a hundred oxen" (ἐκατόμβοιός) — value is reckoned in cattle, the Homeric world's standard of price; there is no money in the poem.
- 19 *ll. 484-493* The poet's second and most elaborate invocation of the Muses, marking the Catalogue as a feat of memory beyond unaided human power ("ten tongues, ten

mouths"). The Muses know because they are present and see; the poet otherwise has only kleos — "the report" — at second hand.

- 20 *ll. 494-759* The Catalogue of Ships: 29 Achaean contingents, some 190 place names, 1,186 ships by the traditional count. It has been argued since antiquity to reflect an originally separate composition (its geography fits mainland Greece of an earlier era better than the poem's own dramatic situation — Boeotia leads, plausibly from the muster at Aulis), and several manuscripts omit the whole span (apparatus at lines 494-877). Translated as fully integral, in the same line-for-line verse as the narrative; see the translator's note on this book.
- 21 *ll. 528-530* The disambiguation of the two Ajaxes. Zenodotus athetized 528 and Aristarchus 529-530 (apparatus) — the "linen corslet" (λινόθώραξ) bothered critics, linen being light armor at odds with heroic bronze. Kept: the lesser Ajax's smallness and spear-skill are both plot-relevant later.
- 22 *ll. 546-551* Erechtheus, the primeval Athenian king, is "borne by the grain-giving earth" and raised by Athena in her own temple — the earliest statement of the Athenian autochthony myth, and one of the very few references to hero-cult practice (annual bull and ram offerings) in the Iliad.
- 23 *ll. 557-558* The most notorious couplet in the poem. Aristarchus athetized 558, and ancient tradition (Strabo 9.1.10, Diogenes Laertius 1.48) reports that Solon or Pisistratus inserted it to support Athens's claim to Salamis against Megara — the Megarians circulated a rival version continuing Ajax's line with Megarian towns instead (quoted in the apparatus at Line 557-558). Whether or not the accusation is true, Ajax — the war's second-best fighter — receives a strikingly minimal two-line entry. Translated as printed, with the controversy recorded here.
- 24 *ll. 594-600* Thamyras the Thracian bard boasted he could outsing the Muses; they "maimed" him (πηρόν — later tradition specifies blinding, but the word is unspecific), stripped his song, and made him forget his lyre-craft. A dark in-poem parable of song as the Muses' revocable gift, placed pointedly just after the poet's own humble invocation of them.
- 25 *l. 637* "ships with cheeks of vermilion" (μυλοπάρησι) — Odysseus' ships have bows painted with red ochre; the word transfers the "cheek" of the human face-epithets to the ship's prow.
- 26 *ll. 671-675* The Nireus entry: his name opens three consecutive lines (anaphora unique in the Catalogue) — beautiful, well-born, and militarily negligible. Zenodotus athetized 673-675 and omitted 674 (apparatus). The rhetorical polish of the entry made it famous; it is kept at full strength.
- 27 *ll. 686-694* Zenodotus athetized this Achilles-paragraph (apparatus, Line 686-694). It is the Catalogue's load-bearing link to the poem's plot: the fifty ships are mustered, and their leader lies apart "in wrath over the girl" — with the quiet promise "but he was soon to rise."
- 28 *ll. 698-702* Protesilaus, "far the first of the Achaeans" ashore, killed as he leapt from his ship (an oracle had promised death to the first to land — the poem alludes without

- telling). His "house but half-built" (δόμος ἡμιτελής) is ambiguous: an unfinished hall, or a marriage cut off half-made; the wife with torn cheeks favors hearing both.
- 29 *ll. 716-725* Philoctetes, master of Heracles' bow, abandoned on Lemnos with the festering water-snake wound. "Soon the Argives were to remember" him: prophecy held that Troy could not fall without the bow — the story of Sophocles' Philoctetes. One of the Catalogue's several forward windows beyond the Iliad's own frame.
- 30 *ll. 782-783* Typhoeus, the monstrous challenger of Zeus, lies lashed by his thunderbolts "among the Arimi" (location already disputed in antiquity — Cilicia, Lydia, and volcanic Ischia were all proposed). The marching army makes the earth groan like Zeus's cosmic punishment: the grandest of the muster-similes.
- 31 *l. 786* "wind-footed swift Iris" (ποδὴνέμος ὠκέα Ἴρις) — the rainbow goddess as messenger of Zeus; her fixed epithet, always so rendered.
- 32 *ll. 813-814* Men call the mound Batieia; the gods call it "the tomb of Myrine" (an Amazon, in later tradition). Second instance of divine-versus-human double naming (cf. Briareus/Aegaeon, Book 1 note [33]) — the gods' name preserves the older, true history of the landmark.
- 33 *l. 816* "Hector of the flashing helmet" (κορυθαίολος Ἑκτωρ) — his defining epithet, first appearance in the poem; literally "with glancing/shimmering helm." Always so rendered.
- 34 *ll. 860-861* Aristarchus athetized these lines (and obelized the parallel pair at 874-875): they anticipate, in the future tense of the narrator, Achilles' massacre in the river Scamander — which belongs to Book 21 — and ancient critics disliked the Catalogue "spoiling" it. Kept: the Trojan catalogue's habit of glancing at its captains' deaths is part of its elegiac texture.
- 35 *l. 867* "Carians of barbarous speech" (βαρβαροφώνων) — the first occurrence in Greek literature of any "barbar-" word. Not yet the later blanket term "barbarian": in the whole poem only the Carians get this label, and the Trojans themselves speak with the Achaeans unhindered. Rendered "of barbarous speech" to keep the word's echoic, language-centered sense.

Iliad — Book 3

*Paris and Menelaus fight a duel for Helen; Helen names the Greek chiefs
from the wall; Aphrodite carries Paris off to safety.*

- Now when they were marshaled, each company with its leaders,
the Trojans came on with clamor and a cry, like birds —
like the clamor of cranes that rises against the sky,
when they flee the winter and the measureless rain
5 and fly clamoring toward the streams of Ocean,
bearing slaughter and doom to the Pygmy men,¹
and out of the morning air they carry their evil strife —
but the Achaeans came on in silence, breathing fury,
hearts set on standing by one another.
- 10 As when the South Wind pours mist on the peaks of a mountain,
no friend to shepherds, better than night to the thief,
and a man sees only as far as a stone's throw —
so the dust rose swirling under their feet
as they came on; and very swiftly they crossed the plain.
- 15 And when they were close, advancing on one another,
godlike Alexandros stood out as the Trojans' champion,²
with a leopard skin on his shoulders, and curved bow
and sword; and shaking two spears headed with bronze³
he challenged all the best of the Argives
- 20 to fight him man to man in dread combat.
But when Menelaus dear to Ares caught sight of him⁴
coming out in front of the throng with long strides,
then like a lion delighted to light on a great carcass,
finding a horned stag or a wild goat
- 25 when he is starving — he devours it greedily even though
the swift dogs and the sturdy young hunters are driving at him —
so Menelaus was delighted to see godlike Alexandros
with his own eyes; for he thought to make the offender pay.
At once he leapt from his chariot to the ground in his armor.
- 30 But when godlike Alexandros saw him
appear among the front fighters, his heart was struck cold,

- and he shrank back into the crowd of his companions, dodging death.
 As a man who has seen a snake in a mountain glen
 starts back and away, and trembling seizes his limbs,
 35 and he retreats, and pallor takes his cheeks,
 so back into the throng of the proud Trojans
 slipped godlike Alexandros, in dread of Atreus' son.
 And Hector saw him, and raked him with shaming words:
 "Paris — evil Paris — beauty and nothing more, woman-mad, seducer:
 40 I wish you had never been born, or had died unmarried.
 That is what I would wish, and it would be far better
 than to have you a disgrace like this, a thing others look at sideways.
 How the long-haired Achaeans must be cackling —
 they thought a prince was champion because a fine
 45 look is on him; but there is no strength in his heart, no fight.
 Were you really such a man when in the seagoing ships
 you sailed the deep with your trusted companions gathered,
 and mixed with strangers, and carried off a beautiful woman
 from a far land, a bride of spearmen —
 50 a great grief to your father, to the city, and to all the people,
 a joy to our enemies, a hanging of your own head?
 And will you not stand up to Menelaus dear to Ares?
 You would find out what kind of man it is whose wife in her bloom you
 keep.
 The lyre would be no help to you then, nor the gifts of Aphrodite,
 55 that hair and that fine look, when you went down in the dust.
 The Trojans are cowards indeed — otherwise long since
 you would have put on a shirt of stone for all the evil you have done."⁵
 And godlike Alexandros answered him:
 "Hector, you rake me justly, not more than justly.
 60 Your heart is always unwearying, like an axe
 driven through timber by a man's swing when he skillfully
 cuts out a ship-beam, and the iron strengthens his stroke:
 so unshaken is the spirit in your chest.
 But do not throw in my face the lovely gifts of golden Aphrodite.
 65 Not to be flung away are the gods' glorious gifts —
 whatever they themselves give; no man could take them by choosing.
 Now, if you want me to fight and do battle:

make the other Trojans sit down, and all the Achaeans,
and put me in the middle with Menelaus dear to Ares
70 to fight for Helen and all her possessions.
Whichever of us wins and proves the stronger,
let him take all the wealth, and the woman, and lead them home;
and the rest of you, cutting friendship and sworn oaths,
may you live on in deep-soiled Troy, and they return
75 to horse-pasturing Argos and Achaea of the beautiful women."
So he spoke, and Hector rejoiced greatly to hear the word,
and he went into the middle and held back the Trojan lines
gripping his spear by the middle; and they all sat down.
But the long-haired Achaeans kept shooting at him,
80 aiming with arrows and casting stones,
until the lord of men Agamemnon called out loud and long:
"Hold, Argives! Do not shoot, young men of the Achaeans!
Hector of the flashing helmet stands ready to say something."
So he spoke, and they held from fighting and fell silent,
85 quickly. And Hector spoke between the two armies:
"Hear from me, Trojans and strong-greaved Achaeans,
the word of Alexandros, for whose sake this quarrel rose.
He bids the other Trojans and all the Achaeans
lay down their fine armor on the earth that feeds so many,
90 while he in the middle, with Menelaus dear to Ares,
fights alone for Helen and all her possessions.
Whichever of them wins and proves the stronger,
let him take all the wealth, and the woman, and lead them home;
and the rest of us — let us cut friendship and sworn oaths."
95 So he spoke, and they all went still in silence.
And among them spoke Menelaus, good at the war-cry:
"Hear me now also. The pain of this comes closest
to my heart; and I intend that they part at last,
Argives and Trojans, since you have suffered many evils
100 for the sake of my quarrel, and Alexandros who began it.
For whichever of the two of us death and fate are prepared,
let him die; and the rest of you part, and quickly.
Bring two lambs — one white ram, one black ewe,
for Earth and Sun; and we will bring another, for Zeus."⁶

- 105 And lead down the strength of Priam, so he may cut the oaths
himself, since his sons are overbearing and not to be trusted —
that no one by transgression may do violence to the oaths of Zeus.
The minds of younger men are always blowing in the wind;
but where an old man is present, he looks before and behind
110 at once, how the best may come of it for both sides."⁷
So he spoke, and Achaeans and Trojans rejoiced,
hoping to be done with the misery of war.
They reined the chariots back into the lines, and stepped down,
and stripped off their armor and laid it on the ground
115 close together — there was little field between the armies.
And Hector sent two heralds to the city
quickly, to fetch the lambs and to summon Priam;
and the lord Agamemnon sent Talthibius off
to the hollow ships, and ordered him to bring
120 a lamb; and he did not disobey brilliant Agamemnon.
Now Iris went as messenger to white-armed Helen,
in the likeness of her sister-in-law, the wife of Antenor's son —
the one Antenor's son the lord Helicaon had married,
Laodice, loveliest of the daughters of Priam.
125 She found her in the hall: she was weaving a great web,
a double cloak of purple,⁸ and working into it the many struggles
of the horse-taming Trojans and bronze-shirted Achaeans,
which for her sake they suffered at the hands of Ares.
Standing close, swift-footed Iris spoke:
130 "Come here, dear bride, to see wonderful doings
of the horse-taming Trojans and bronze-shirted Achaeans.
They who before this carried tearful war at each other
in the plain, ravenous for deadly battle —
now they sit in silence, and the war has stopped;
135 they lean on their shields, and the long spears are stuck in the earth.
But Alexandros and Menelaus dear to Ares
will fight for you with their long spears;
and you will be called the dear wife of the man who wins."
So speaking, the goddess put sweet longing into her heart
140 for her first husband, and her city, and her father and mother.
At once she veiled herself in shining white linen

and went out of her chamber, letting fall a soft tear —
 not alone: two handmaids followed with her,
 Aethra, Pittheus' daughter,⁹ and ox-eyed Clymene.

145 And quickly they came to where the Scaean Gates stood.¹⁰
 Now those around Priam — Panthous and Thymoetes,
 Lampus and Clytius and Hicetaon, scion of Ares,
 and Ucalegon and Antenor, wise men both —
 sat as elders of the people at the Scaean Gates,

150 finished with war now because of age, but speakers
 of quality, like cicadas that in the woods
 perch on a tree and send out their lily-thin voice:¹¹
 such were the leaders of the Trojans sitting on the tower.
 And when they saw Helen coming up onto the tower,

155 softly they spoke winged words to one another:
 "No shame that Trojans and strong-greaved Achaeans
 have suffered pain so long for a woman like this one.
 She is terribly like the immortal goddesses to look at.
 But even so — such as she is, let her go home in the ships,

160 and not be left here, a grief to us and our children after."
 So they spoke; but Priam called Helen to him:¹²
 "Come here, dear child, and sit in front of me,
 to see your first husband and your kin and your friends —
 you are not to blame in my eyes: the gods are to blame,

165 who set upon me this tearful war with the Achaeans —
 and to tell me the name of that gigantic man there,
 who that Achaean is, so tall and strong.
 There are others taller by a head, indeed;
 but a man so beautiful I have never yet seen with my eyes,

170 nor so majestic. He looks like a king."
 And Helen answered him, brilliant among women:
 "You are dear to me, dear father-in-law, and dread to me too.
 How I wish vile death had pleased me on the day I followed
 your son here, leaving my bridal chamber and my kinsmen

175 and my own dear daughter and the sweet company of girls my age.
 But that was not to be; and so I waste away with weeping.
 But I will tell you what you ask me and inquire.
 That man is Atreus' son, wide-ruling Agamemnon,

- both things at once: a good king and a strong spearman.
- 180 And he was brother-in-law — to me, dog-face that I am¹³ — if that ever was."
- So she spoke, and the old man marveled at him, and said:
 "Fortunate son of Atreus, child of destiny, blessed of fortune —
 how many young Achaean men are subject to you!
 Once I went into Phrygia of the vines,
 185 and there I saw Phrygian men in their multitudes, with their glancing horses,
 the hosts of Otreus and godlike Mygdon,
 encamped then along the banks of Sangarius;
 for I too, as an ally, was counted among them
 on the day the Amazons came, the match of men.¹⁴
- 190 But even they were not so many as the bright-eyed Achaeans."
 Second, the old man saw Odysseus, and asked:
 "Come, tell me of this one too, dear child — who he is.
 Shorter by a head than Agamemnon, Atreus' son,
 but broader in the shoulders and chest to look at.
- 195 His armor lies on the earth that feeds so many,
 and he himself ranges the ranks of men like a bellwether ram —
 yes, I liken him to a thick-fleeced ram
 that moves through a great flock of white ewes."
 And Helen, sprung of Zeus, answered him:
- 200 "That is Laertes' son, resourceful Odysseus,
 raised in the land of Ithaca — rocky as it is —
 a man who knows every kind of trick and close-woven plan."
 And wise Antenor said to her in answer:
 "Lady, that word of yours is exactly true.
- 205 For brilliant Odysseus came here once before,
 on an embassy about you,¹⁵ with Menelaus dear to Ares;
 and I was their host: I welcomed them in my halls,
 and learned the build of both, and their close-woven plans.
 Now when they mixed with the assembled Trojans,
 210 standing, Menelaus overtopped him with his broad shoulders,
 but with both seated, Odysseus was the more majestic.
 And when they wove their words and their plans before us all,
 Menelaus, certainly, spoke fluently —

- few words, but very clear: he was no man of many words,
 215 no rambler — though he was in fact the younger.
 But whenever resourceful Odysseus rose to speak,
 he would just stand there, eyes fixed down on the ground,
 not moving the scepter backward or forward
 but holding it stiff, like a man who knows nothing;
 220 you would have called him some sulking churl, a plain fool.
 But when he let the great voice out of his chest,
 and the words came like snowflakes in winter,
 then no other mortal could rival Odysseus.
 Then we did not marvel so much at how Odysseus looked."
 225 Third, the old man saw Ajax, and asked:
 "And who is that other Achaean man, tall and strong,
 towering over the Argives in head and broad shoulders?"
 And Helen of the trailing robe answered, brilliant among women:
 "That is gigantic Ajax, wall of the Achaeans.
 230 And on the other side Idomeneus stands among the Cretans
 like a god, and the Cretan captains are gathered around him.
 Often Menelaus dear to Ares was his host
 in our house, whenever he came from Crete.
 And now I see all the other bright-eyed Achaeans,
 235 whom I could well recognize and name their names;
 but two marshals of the people I cannot see —
 Castor breaker of horses and Polydeuces the great boxer,
 my own brothers, whom one mother bore with me.
 Either they did not follow from lovely Lacedaemon,
 240 or they followed here in the seagoing ships
 but now are not willing to enter the battle of men,
 fearing the shame and the many reproaches that are mine."
 So she spoke. But the life-giving earth already held them under,¹⁶
 there in Lacedaemon, in their dear fatherland.
 245 Now the heralds were carrying through the city the gods' oath-
 offerings,
 two lambs, and wine that gladdens the heart, fruit of the field,
 in a goatskin bag; and the herald Idaeus carried
 a gleaming mixing-bowl and cups of gold;
 and he stood beside the old king and roused him:

- 250 "Rise, son of Laomedon. The chief men are calling —
of the horse-taming Trojans and the bronze-shirted Achaeans —
for you to come down to the plain, to cut the sworn oaths.
For Alexandros and Menelaus dear to Ares
will fight with their long spears for the woman;
255 and woman and wealth shall go with the winner,
while the rest, cutting friendship and sworn oaths,
we should live on in deep-soiled Troy, and they return
to horse-pasturing Argos and Achaea of the beautiful women."
So he spoke, and the old man shuddered; but he told his companions
260 to yoke the horses, and they promptly obeyed.
Priam mounted and drew the reins back taut,
and beside him Antenor mounted the beautiful chariot,
and through the Scaean Gates they drove the swift horses toward the
plain.
And when they had come among the Trojans and Achaeans,
265 they stepped from the chariot onto the earth that feeds so many
and walked into the space between Trojans and Achaeans.
At once the lord of men Agamemnon rose,
and resourceful Odysseus rose; and the proud heralds
brought together the gods' oath-offerings, and in the bowl
270 mixed the wine, and poured water over the kings' hands.
And Atreus' son drew with his hand the knife
that always hung beside the great sheath of his sword,
and cut hairs from the lambs' heads; and then
the heralds gave them out to the chief men of the Trojans and
Achaeans.
275 And Atreus' son prayed aloud among them, lifting his hands:
"Father Zeus, ruling from Ida, most glorious, greatest;
and Sun, who see all things and hear all things;
and Rivers, and Earth, and you two below who punish
the dead, whoever has sworn a false oath:¹⁷
280 be witnesses; guard the sworn oaths.
If Alexandros kills Menelaus,
let him keep Helen and all her possessions,
and we will go home in the seagoing ships;
but if tawny-haired Menelaus kills Alexandros,

- 285 then the Trojans are to give back Helen and all her possessions,
and pay the Argives whatever recompense is fitting,
such as will be remembered among men still to come.
And if Priam and Priam's sons refuse
to pay me that recompense when Alexandros has fallen,
- 290 then I will fight on for the payment owed,
staying right here, until I reach the end of the war."
He spoke, and cut the lambs' throats with the pitiless bronze,
and laid them down on the ground gasping,
the life going out of them: the bronze had taken their strength.
- 295 Then drawing wine from the bowl into the cups
they poured it out, and prayed to the gods who are forever;
and thus would one of the Achaeans and Trojans say:
"Zeus most glorious, greatest, and you other immortal gods:
whichever side first does harm against the oaths,
- 300 may their brains run on the ground as this wine runs,
theirs and their children's, and their wives be subdued to other men."¹⁸
So they spoke; but the son of Cronos would not yet bring it to pass.¹⁹
And Priam, Dardanus' descendant, spoke his word among them:
"Hear from me, Trojans and strong-greaved Achaeans.
- 305 I am going back to windswept Ilion,
since I cannot yet bear to watch with my own eyes
my dear son fighting Menelaus dear to Ares.
Zeus, I suppose, knows — and the other immortal gods —
for which of the two the end of death is fated."
- 310 He spoke — a man like a god — and set the lambs in the chariot,
and mounted himself, and drew the reins back taut,
and beside him Antenor mounted the beautiful chariot;
and back again to Ilion the two returned.
Then Hector, Priam's son, and brilliant Odysseus
- 315 first measured out the ground, and then
took lots and shook them in a bronze-fitted helmet,
for which of the two should cast his bronze spear first.
And the hosts prayed, and lifted their hands to the gods,
and thus would one of the Achaeans and Trojans say:
- 320 "Father Zeus, ruling from Ida, most glorious, greatest:
whichever of the two brought these troubles on both peoples,

- grant that he go down, dead, into the house of Hades,
and that friendship and sworn oaths be ours."
So they spoke; and great Hector of the flashing helmet shook the lots,
325 looking away behind him; and Paris's lot leapt quickly out.
Then the men sat down in ranks, where each man's
high-stepping horses and patterned armor lay.
And he girded the fine armor about his shoulders —²⁰
brilliant Alexandros, husband of lovely-haired Helen.
- 330 First he set the greaves along his shins,
beautiful ones, fitted with silver ankle-guards;
next he girt about his chest the corslet
of his brother Lycaon — and it fitted him;
and about his shoulders he slung the silver-studded sword,
335 a sword of bronze, and then the shield, great and heavy;
and on his strong head he set the well-made helmet
with its horsehair crest — and terribly the plume nodded above him —
and took up a stout spear, fitted to his grip.
And in the same way warlike Menelaus put on his gear.
- 340 And when they had armed on either side of the throng,
they strode into the space between Trojans and Achaeans,
glaring terribly; and amazement held the watchers,
the horse-taming Trojans and the strong-greaved Achaeans.
They took their stand near each other on the measured ground,
345 shaking their spears, in fury at one another.
Alexandros first hurled his long-shadowed spear²¹
and struck the shield of Atreus' son, balanced every way;
but the bronze did not break through: its point was bent back
in the strong shield. Second, Atreus' son Menelaus
- 350 rose with his bronze, with a prayer to father Zeus:
"Zeus, lord: grant me to punish the man who wronged me first —
brilliant Alexandros — and break him under my hands,
so that many a man may shudder, even among men yet to be born,
at doing evil to a host who has offered him friendship."
355 He spoke, and balancing his long-shadowed spear he hurled it
and struck the shield of Priam's son, balanced every way.
Through the shining shield the heavy spear went,
and through the richly worked corslet it drove;

- and straight on beside his flank the spear sheared through
 360 the tunic — but he had swerved aside, and dodged black doom.
 Then Atreus' son drew the silver-studded sword,
 rose up, and struck the ridge of his helmet; but around it
 the sword shattered in three and four pieces, and fell from his hand.
 And Atreus' son groaned, looking into the wide sky:
 365 "Father Zeus, no other god is more destroying than you!
 I thought I had made Alexandros pay for his wickedness,
 and now the sword is broken in my hands, and the spear
 flew from my grip for nothing, and I have not hit him."
 He spoke — and springing on him he seized the horsehair helmet
 370 and swung round and dragged him toward the strong-greaved
 Achaeans;
 and the richly stitched strap was strangling the soft throat under it,
 the chin-strap drawn tight beneath his jaw.
 And now he would have dragged him off and won glory past telling,
 had not Aphrodite, Zeus's daughter, seen it sharply:
 375 she broke the strap — leather of an ox felled by force —
 and the helmet came away empty in his heavy hand.
 The hero sent it spinning away toward the strong-greaved Achaeans
 with a whirl, and his trusted companions gathered it up;
 and back again he sprang, raging to kill
 380 with his bronze spear. But Aphrodite snatched Paris away —
 easily, as a god can — and hid him in thick mist,
 and set him down in his fragrant, scented chamber.
 Then she went herself to summon Helen; she found her
 on the high tower, with the women of Troy thick around her.
 385 With her hand she plucked at her nectar-sweet robe and shook it,
 and spoke to her in the likeness of an old woman,
 a wool-comber of long ago, who used to work fine wool
 for her when she lived in Lacedaemon, and whom she dearly loved;
 in her likeness brilliant Aphrodite spoke:
 390 "Come here. Alexandros calls you home.
 There he is, in the bedchamber, on the turned bed,
 gleaming in his beauty and his clothes. You would not say
 he had come from single combat — rather that he was going
 to a dance, or sitting down just now come from dancing."

- 395 So she spoke, and stirred the heart in Helen's breast;
and when she noticed the surpassing beauty of the goddess's throat
and the breasts of desire and the flashing eyes,
awe took her,²² and she spoke a word, and named her:
"Strange goddess — why are you so set on cheating me like this?
- 400 Will you carry me somewhere still farther on, to one of the fine
cities of Phrygia or lovely Maeonia,
if some mortal man is dear to you there too?
Is it because Menelaus has beaten brilliant Alexandros
and wants to lead hateful me home again —
- 405 is that why you stand beside me now, weaving your tricks?
Go sit beside him yourself. Renounce the paths of the gods;
never again turn your feet back to Olympus,
but fret over him forever, and guard him,
until he makes you his wife — or else his slave.
- 410 I will not go to him — that would be a thing for anger —
to serve that man's bed. The women of Troy
would all mock me afterward; and I have griefs past counting in my
heart."
- And in anger brilliant Aphrodite answered her:
"Do not provoke me, hard woman — or I may quit you in my anger
- 415 and hate you as extravagantly as I now love you,
and devise bitter hatreds between both sides,
Trojans and Danaans alike — and you would perish miserably."
So she spoke, and Helen sprung of Zeus was afraid,
and she went in silence, wrapped in her shining white robe,
- 420 unnoticed by all the Trojan women; and the goddess led.
When they came to the beautiful house of Alexandros,
the handmaids turned quickly to their work,
and she went to the high-roofed bedchamber, brilliant among women.
And laughter-loving Aphrodite²³ took a chair for her —
- 425 a goddess! — carried it, and set it facing Alexandros;²⁴
there Helen sat, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus,
her eyes turned away, and she lashed her husband with her word:
"You came back from the fight. How I wish you had died there,
broken by the strong man who was my first husband.
- 430 You used to boast, before, that you were the better man —

- stronger than Menelaus dear to Ares in force and hand and spear.
 Go on then, challenge Menelaus dear to Ares
 to fight you again face to face. — But no; I myself
 advise you to stop: do not fight tawny-haired Menelaus
 435 man against man, do not battle him,
 like a fool — or you may soon go down under his spear."²⁵
 And Paris answered her with his word:
 "Woman, do not lash my heart with hard reproaches.
 This time Menelaus has won — with Athena's help;
 440 another time it will be I. There are gods on our side too.
 Come, let us take our joy in love, in bed together.
 Never has desire so wrapped itself around my heart —
 not even when I first carried you off from lovely Lacedaemon
 and sailed away in the seagoing ships,
 445 and on the island of Kranae²⁶ mixed with you in love and bed —
 as I love you now, and sweet longing takes hold of me."
 He spoke, and led the way to bed; and his wife followed.
 So the two lay together on the corded bed.
 But Atreus' son ranged through the throng like a wild beast,
 450 hunting for a glimpse of godlike Alexandros.
 And no one of the Trojans or their famed allies
 could show Alexandros to Menelaus dear to Ares;
 not out of friendship, surely, would they have hidden him, had anyone
 seen him:
 for he was hated by them all like black death.
 455 And among them spoke the lord of men Agamemnon:
 "Hear me, Trojans and Dardanians and allies.
 Victory clearly belongs to Menelaus dear to Ares.
 Give up, then, Argive Helen and the possessions with her,
 and pay whatever recompense is fitting,
 460 such as will be remembered among men still to come."
 So spoke Atreus' son, and the rest of the Achaeans gave assent.

NOTES TO BOOK 3

- 1 ll. 3-7 The cranes migrating to Ocean's stream to war on the Pygmy men — the oldest surviving reference to the Pygmy legend. The simile's real work is the contrast it frames: the Trojans advance with clamor like birds, the Achaeans in disciplined silence (8-9) — a recurring characterization of the two armies.
- 2 l. 16 "Alexandros" — the poem's usual name for Paris (Πάρις appears only occasionally, e.g. 325, 437). The translation reproduces whichever name the Greek uses in each line rather than normalizing. Hector's opening insult at 39, Δύσπαρι ("Dys-Paris," ill-Paris), is rendered "Paris — evil Paris."
- 3 ll. 18-20 A rare case of overlapping athetesis by both major Alexandrian editors: Zenodotus rejected 18-20, Aristarchus separately 19-20 (apparatus). The bother was partly Paris's arsenal — leopard skin, bow, sword, and two spears is theatrical overload. Kept: the over-dressed entrance is exactly in character.
- 4 l. 21 "dear to Ares" (ἀρηϊφίλος) — Menelaus's standing epithet in this book; his other is "tawny-haired" (ξανθός, 284). Both always so rendered.
- 5 l. 57 "a shirt of stone" (λάϊνον χιτῶνα) — i.e. death by public stoning, the community's punishment for the offense Paris committed; the idiom is kept literal.
- 6 ll. 103-104 The victims are matched to the oath-witnesses: a white ram for the Sun, a black ewe for Earth, a third lamb from the Achaeans for Zeus. Priam must swear in person because oaths bind the swearer alone — and his sons are "not to be trusted" (106): the war began with Paris violating a solemn bond.
- 7 ll. 108-110 Aristarchus athetized these three generalizing lines on young men's flightiness (apparatus, Line 108-110). Kept; the sententiousness suits Menelaus's careful legalism in this speech.
- 8 ll. 125-128 Helen weaving the battles "which for her sake they suffered" — the poem's most self-referential image: she is weaving the subject-matter of the Iliad while living inside it. The Alexandrian editors read "a double cloak of purple" (πορφυρέην, as printed); most manuscripts have "shimmering" (μαρμαρέην) — the apparatus records the split (Line 126).
- 9 l. 144 Aethra, Pittheus' daughter, is in myth the mother of Theseus, made Helen's slave when the Dioscuri sacked Athens's territory to recover the girl Theseus had abducted — a story alien to Homer, and ancient critics condemned the line as an Athenian interpolation (Aristarchus athetized it; apparatus, Line 144). Translated as printed; the name is either a fossil of that lost epic tradition or a coincidence ancient readers over-read.
- 10 l. 145 The Scaean Gates: Troy's main gate facing the plain and the battlefield, the fixed stage-set for departures and watching in this poem (and, in tradition beyond it, the place of Achilles' death).

- 11 *ll. 151-152* The old counselors chirp like cicadas with their "lily- thin voice" (ὄπα λειριόεσσον — literally "lily-like," delicate as a petal): age has left them song without strength. One of the poem's most admired domestic similes.
- 12 *ll. 161-244* The teichoscopia ("viewing from the wall"): Priam, in the war's tenth year, asks Helen to identify Agamemnon, Odysseus, and Ajax as though the enemy were new to him. Critics ancient and modern have noted the impossibility; dramatically it is the audience's own introduction to the Achaean captains, staged through the eyes of the two people most implicated in the war.
- 13 *l. 180* "dog-face that I am" (κυνώπιδος) — Helen turns on herself the poem's harshest shame-insult (cf. Achilles to Agamemnon, Book 1 note [19]). Her self-lacerations ("hateful me," 404; cf. 173-176) are unique in the poem and are rendered at full strength.
- 14 *l. 189* The Amazons, "the match of men" (ἀντιάειραι) — one of only two Iliad references to them (cf. 6.186); Priam fought against them on the Sangarius in his youth. In post-Homeric epic they come to Troy as allies — here they are still simply a memory of a hard war.
- 15 *ll. 205-224* Antenor recalls the pre-war embassy: Odysseus and Menelaus came to Troy to demand Helen back before hostilities — a tradition the Iliad otherwise passes over. His sketch of Odysseus's oratory (the stiff stance, eyes down, then words "like snowflakes in winter") became the classical archetype of deceptive-looking eloquence.
- 16 *ll. 243-244* The famous ironic close of the teichoscopia: Helen scans the plain for her brothers Castor and Polydeuces, imagining them ashamed of her — "but the life-giving earth already held them under." The narrator states their death with the epithet φουσίζοος ("life-giving") set against the grave: kept in its full contradiction. Homer knows nothing (or says nothing) of their later shared immortality.
- 17 *ll. 276-279* The oath-witnesses: Zeus of Ida, the all-seeing Sun, the Rivers and Earth, "and you two below who punish the dead" — probably Hades and Persephone (some ancients understood the Erinyes). Perjury is the one sin explicitly punished after death in the Iliad.
- 18 *ll. 298-301* The curse enacts itself in the ritual: as the wine is poured out, so may the perjurers' brains pour on the ground. "Their wives be subdued to other men" completes the symmetry — the war is, precisely, about a wife taken by another man.
- 19 *l. 302* A Ptolemaic papyrus preserves four extra lines here — Zeus thundering in answer and planning woes for both sides — absent from the medieval manuscripts (apparatus at line 302; one of the Ptolemaic "plus verses"). A live specimen of how fluid the text still was before the Alexandrian standardization. The vulgate's laconic "the son of Cronos would not yet bring it to pass" is translated; the papyrus expansion is recorded here.
- 20 *ll. 328-338* The poem's first full arming type-scene, in the fixed order that recurs whenever a hero arms: greaves, corslet, sword, shield, helmet, spear(s). Later arming scenes (Agamemnon in Book 11, Patroclus in 16, Achilles in 19) elaborate the same skeleton; it will not be re-footnoted. Zenodotus athetized 334-335 (apparatus). Paris borrows his brother Lycaon's corslet — the bowman owns none.

- 21 *l. 346* "long-shadowed spear" (δολιχόσκιον ἔγχος) — the fixed epithet of the thrown spear, always so rendered.
- 22 *ll. 396-418* Aristarchus athetized this whole exchange (apparatus, Line 396-418) — Helen seeing through the disguise, defying the goddess to her face ("Go sit beside him yourself... his wife — or else his slave"), and Aphrodite's naked threat. No other mortal in the Iliad speaks to a god like this; the scene lays bare what Aphrodite's "gifts" cost the one who receives them. Kept entire.
- 23 *l. 424* "laughter-loving Aphrodite" (φιλομειδῆς Ἀφροδίτη) — her fixed epithet, always so rendered.
- 24 *ll. 424-425* A goddess carrying a chair for a mortal woman — service so startling the translation lets the narrator's shock show ("a goddess!" renders the emphatic θεά). Zenodotus rewrote 423-426 into a single innocuous line, "and she herself went and sat opposite lord Alexandros" (apparatus, Line 423-426) — flattening exactly the scandal that gives the gesture its force: Aphrodite is herself procuring, and stoops to it.
- 25 *ll. 428-436* Helen's greeting to the rescued Paris — a death-wish, a taunt, and a mid-sentence collapse from "challenge him again" to "no — you would die." Aristarchus athetized 432-436 (apparatus). Kept: the broken movement of the speech is the psychology.
- 26 *l. 445* Kranae ("Rocky Isle") — the island where Paris and Helen first slept together on the flight from Sparta; possibly a proper name, possibly just "a rocky island." Ancient guesses ranged from Cythera to an islet off the Laconian coast later renamed Helene.

Iliad — Book 4

The gods break the truce with an arrow from Pandarus; Agamemnon reviews his troops; the first day of battle begins.

- Now the gods, seated beside Zeus, were holding assembly
on the golden floor, and among them the lady Hebe
poured nectar; and they with golden cups
pledged one another, looking out at the city of the Trojans.
- 5 And at once the son of Cronos set about provoking Hera
with needling words, speaking sidelong:
"Two of the goddesses are helpers of Menelaus —
Hera of Argos and Athena of Alalcomenae —¹
and yet the two of them sit apart, looking on,
10 taking their pleasure; while laughter-loving Aphrodite
is forever at that other's side, and keeps the fates of death from him:
just now she saved him when he thought to die.
Still — victory belongs to Menelaus dear to Ares.
So let us consider how these things shall be:
15 whether we shall stir up evil war again and the dread din
of battle, or cast friendship between the two sides.
If somehow this should be welcome and sweet to all,
then let the city of lord Priam stay a place men live in,
and let Menelaus take Argive Helen home again."
- 20 So he spoke, and they murmured at it, Athena and Hera,
who sat side by side plotting evils for the Trojans.
Athena, to be sure, stayed silent and said nothing,
sulking at father Zeus, wild anger gripping her;
but Hera's breast could not contain her anger, and she spoke:
25 "Most dread son of Cronos, what a word you have spoken!
How can you wish to make my labor vain and unaccomplished —
the sweat I sweated in my toil, my horses worn out
gathering the host, to bring evils on Priam and his sons?
Do it. But we other gods do not all approve it."
- 30 Greatly troubled, Zeus the cloud-gatherer answered her:
"Possessed one — what great evils do Priam and Priam's sons

- do you, that you rage without respite
to sack the well-built citadel of Ilion?
If you could go in through the gates and the long walls
35 and eat Priam raw, and Priam's sons,²
and the other Trojans too — then you might cure your anger.
Do as you please. Only let not this quarrel
become in time a great strife between you and me.
And I will tell you another thing — put it away in your heart:
40 whenever I in my turn am bent on sacking a city,
and choose one where men dear to you were born,
do not try to delay my anger, but let me be:
for I too have given you this willingly — with unwilling heart.
Of all the cities under the sun and the starry sky
45 that men who dwell on the earth inhabit,
holy Ilion was most honored in my heart,
and Priam, and the people of Priam of the good ash spear.
Never did my altar lack its fair share of the feast,
the libation and the savor: for that is the honor-portion we gods have."
50 Then the ox-eyed lady Hera answered him:
"Three cities there are far dearest of all to me:
Argos, and Sparta, and wide-wayed Mycenae.
Sack these, whenever they grow hateful to your heart;
I do not stand in front of them; I do not grudge them to you.
55 For even if I did begrudge them, and refused you their sacking,
my grudging would accomplish nothing: you are far the stronger.³
But my labor too must not be made unaccomplished.
I also am a god; my birth is from the same stock as yours;
crooked-counseled Cronos begot me, eldest of his daughters —
60 eldest doubly: by birth, and because I am called
your wife, and you are king among all the immortals.
Come — in this let us yield to one another,
I to you and you to me, and the other immortal gods
will follow. Quickly now: order Athena
65 to go down into the dread din of Trojans and Achaeans
and contrive that the Trojans be the first to do harm,
against the oaths, to the Achaeans now in their glory."
So she spoke, and the father of men and gods did not disobey:

- at once he addressed Athena with winged words:
- 70 "Go with all speed to the armies, to the Trojans and Achaeans,
and contrive that the Trojans be the first to do harm,
against the oaths, to the Achaeans now in their glory."
So speaking, he stirred Athena, already eager;
and down from the peaks of Olympus she went darting.
- 75 As the son of crooked-counseled Cronos sends a star,
a portent to sailors or to the wide host of an army,
blazing, and sparks stream from it in multitudes —
in such a likeness Pallas Athena darted to earth
and leapt down into the middle; and amazement held the watchers,
- 80 the horse-taming Trojans and the strong-greaved Achaeans;
and thus one would say, with a glance at his neighbor:
"Either evil war and the dread din of battle
are coming again — or Zeus is setting friendship
between the two sides, Zeus, the dispenser of war to men."
- 85 So one of the Achaeans and Trojans would say.
And she, in the likeness of a man, went down into the Trojan throng —
of Laodocus, Antenor's son, a strong spearman —
searching for godlike Pandarus, if she might find him.
She found Lycaon's son, blameless and strong,
- 90 standing; and around him the strong ranks of shield-bearing
men who had followed him from the streams of Aesepus.
Standing close, she spoke winged words to him:
"Would you let me persuade you, war-minded son of Lycaon?
Would you dare send a swift arrow at Menelaus,
- 95 and win favor and glory in the eyes of all the Trojans —
of prince Alexandros most of all?
From him first of anyone you would carry off shining gifts,
if he should see Menelaus, Atreus' warlike son,
brought down by your shaft and set on the grievous pyre.
- 100 Come then — shoot an arrow at glorious Menelaus,
and vow to Apollo the Lycian-born, famed for the bow,⁴
to offer a splendid hecatomb of firstborn lambs
when you come home to the town of holy Zeleia."
So spoke Athena, and persuaded the fool's heart.
- 105 At once he uncased his polished bow, made from the horn⁵

- of a leaping wild ibex which he himself had once shot
under the chest as it stepped out from a rock — lying
in wait in a blind, he struck it in the chest,
and it fell back flat on the rock. From its head the horns
110 had grown sixteen palms; and the craftsman, the horn-polisher,
fitted them together, smoothed all smooth, and set on a tip of gold.
This bow he strung, bending it well, and laid it down
propped against the ground; and his good companions held their
shields before him,
so the warlike sons of the Achaeans should not spring up
115 before Menelaus, Atreus' warlike son, was hit.
Then he stripped the lid from his quiver and took out an arrow,
never yet shot, winged, a base of black pains;⁶
and quickly he set the bitter shaft in order on the string,
and vowed to Apollo the Lycian-born, famed for the bow,
120 to offer a splendid hecatomb of firstborn lambs
when he came home to the town of holy Zeleia.
Gripping together the notched butt and the string of ox-sinew, he drew:
the string he brought to his breast, and to the bow the iron head.⁷
And when he had strained the great bow into a circle,
125 the horn sang, the string cried aloud, and the arrow leapt,
sharp-pointed, raging to fly on into the crowd.
But the blessed immortal gods did not forget you,
Menelaus — first among them Zeus's daughter, the driver of the spoil,
who stood before you and warded off the piercing shaft.
130 She brushed it back from the skin just so far as a mother
brushes a fly from her child when he lies in sweet sleep,
and steered it herself to where the golden buckles⁸
of the war-belt met and the corslet lay doubled.
Into the fastened war-belt fell the bitter arrow:
135 through the wrought belt it was driven,
through the richly worked corslet it pressed on,
and through the waist-guard he wore to shield his flesh, a fence against
javelins —
that guarded him best, yet it passed through even this;
and the arrow grazed the outermost skin of the man,
140 and at once dark-clouded blood ran down from the wound.

As when some woman of Maeonia or Caria stains⁹
 ivory with crimson, to be a cheek-piece for horses;
 it lies in a treasure-room, and many horsemen
 have prayed to carry it; but it lies there, a king's treasure,
 145 both ornament for the horse and glory for the driver:
 so, Menelaus, your shapely thighs were stained
 with blood, your shins, and your fine ankles beneath.
 Then the lord of men Agamemnon shuddered
 as he saw the black blood running down from the wound,
 150 and Menelaus dear to Ares shuddered himself;
 but when he saw the binding-cord and the barbs still outside the flesh,
 the spirit was gathered back into his breast.
 But groaning heavily, the lord Agamemnon spoke among them,
 holding Menelaus by the hand, and the companions groaned with him:
 155 "Dear brother, it was your death I was cutting in those oaths,¹⁰
 setting you out alone before the Achaeans to fight the Trojans —
 now the Trojans have shot you down and trampled the sworn oaths.
 Yet not in vain are the oath, the blood of lambs,
 the unmixed libations, the right hands we trusted.
 160 For if the Olympian has not fulfilled it at once,
 he fulfills it late — and men pay greatly for it,
 with their own heads, and their wives, and their children.
 For this I know well in my mind and heart:
 the day will come when holy Ilion shall perish,
 165 and Priam, and the people of Priam of the good ash spear,
 and Zeus the son of Cronos, high-throned, dwelling in the sky,
 will himself shake his dark aegis over them all
 in anger at this deceit. These things will not go unaccomplished.
 But my grief for you will be terrible, O Menelaus,
 170 if you die and fill up your portion of life.
 I would go back to thirsty Argos in utter disgrace,
 for the Achaeans would think at once of their fatherland,
 and we would leave to Priam and the Trojans their boast —
 Argive Helen; and the field would rot your bones
 175 as you lay in Troy, the work unaccomplished.
 And thus some overweening Trojan will say,
 leaping on the tomb of glorious Menelaus:

- 'May Agamemnon bring his anger to this end in every case —
as now he led an Achaean army here for nothing,
180 and has gone off home to his dear fatherland
with empty ships, and left good Menelaus behind.'
So some day one of them will say. Then let the wide earth gape for me."
But tawny-haired Menelaus spoke to reassure him:
"Take heart; do not frighten the Achaean host at all.
185 The sharp shaft is not fixed in a mortal place: before that
my glittering war-belt saved me, and beneath it
the loin-guard, and the waist-guard bronze-smiths labored on."
Answering him spoke the lord Agamemnon:
"May it be so indeed, dear Menelaus.
190 But a healer will probe the wound and lay on it
drugs to stop the black pains."
He spoke, and addressed Talthybius the godlike herald:
"Talthybius — as quick as you can, call Machaon here,
the man who is son of Asclepius the blameless healer,¹¹
195 to see Menelaus, Atreus' warlike son,¹²
whom someone skilled in the bow has shot with an arrow,
some Trojan or Lycian: glory for him, grief for us."
So he spoke, and the herald heard and did not disobey.
He went through the host of the bronze-shirted Achaeans
200 peering for the hero Machaon; and he saw him
standing, with the strong ranks of shield-bearing men
around him, who had followed him from horse-pasturing Tricca.
Standing close, he spoke winged words:
"Rise, son of Asclepius. The lord Agamemnon calls,
205 to see Menelaus, the warlike captain of the Achaeans,
whom someone skilled in the bow has shot with an arrow,
some Trojan or Lycian: glory for him, grief for us."
So he spoke, and stirred the heart in his breast,
and they went through the crowd, through the wide Achaean camp.
210 And when they came where tawny-haired Menelaus
was wounded — and around him all the best men were gathered
in a circle, and he, a man like a god, stood among them —
at once Machaon drew the arrow from the fastened belt;
and as it was drawn out, the sharp barbs broke backward.

- 215 Then he loosed the glittering war-belt, and beneath it
the loin-guard, and the waist-guard bronze-smiths labored on.
And when he saw the wound where the bitter arrow had struck,
he sucked out the blood, and skillfully sprinkled on it
soothing drugs, which Chiron once gave his father out of friendship.
- 220 While they were busy about Menelaus, good at the war-cry,
the ranks of the shield-bearing Trojans came on;
and the Achaeans put on their armor again, and remembered their
fighting.
Then you would not have seen brilliant Agamemnon drowsing,¹³
or cowering, or unwilling to fight,
- 225 but hurrying hard toward the battle where men win glory.
He left his horses and his chariot patterned with bronze —
his aide kept them snorting off to the side,
Eurymedon, son of Ptolemaeus, Peiraeus' son,
with strict orders to keep them close at hand for the moment
- 230 weariness should take his limbs, commanding through so many —
and on foot he ranged the ranks of men.
Whomever of the Danaans of swift colts he saw pressing on,
he would stand beside them and hearten them with his words:
"Argives, do not let go your rushing courage now!
- 235 Father Zeus will be no helper to liars:
those who were first to do harm against the oaths —
vultures will eat their tender flesh,
and we will carry off their dear wives and little children
in our ships, when we take their citadel."
- 240 But whomever he saw hanging back from hateful war,
those he would rake with angry words:
"Argives — loud boasters — disgraces! Have you no shame?¹⁴
Why do you stand stunned like this, like fawns
that have run themselves tired over a wide plain
- 245 and stand still, with no courage left in their hearts —
so you stand stunned, and do not fight.
Are you waiting for the Trojans to come right up to where the ships
with their fine sterns are drawn up on the shore of the grey sea,
to find out whether the son of Cronos will hold his hand over you?"
- 250 So, commanding, he ranged through the ranks of men,

- and came to the Cretans, moving through the crowd of fighters.
 They were arming around war-minded Idomeneus:
 Idomeneus among the front-fighters, like a wild boar in courage,
 while Meriones hurried on the rearmost companies.
- 255 Seeing them the lord of men Agamemnon rejoiced,
 and at once he spoke to Idomeneus with honeyed words:
 "Idomeneus, I honor you beyond all the Danaans of swift colts,
 in war and in every other work,
 and at the feast, when the chief men of the Argives
- 260 mix the elders' gleaming wine in the bowl.
 For even if the other long-haired Achaeans
 drink their allotted share, your cup stands always
 full, as mine does, to drink whenever the heart bids.
 Rouse yourself for battle, and be the man you claim of old to be."
- 265 And Idomeneus, captain of the Cretans, answered him:
 "Son of Atreus, I will be a trusty companion to you
 indeed, as I first promised and bowed my head;
 go and rouse the other long-haired Achaeans,
 so we may fight at once — since the Trojans have poured away
- 270 the oaths. Death and sorrows hereafter will be theirs,
 since they were first to do harm against the oaths."
 So he spoke, and Atreus' son passed on, glad at heart,
 and came to the two Ajaxes, moving through the crowd of fighters;
 they were arming for war, and a cloud of foot-soldiers followed them.
- 275 As when from a lookout a goatherd sees a cloud
 coming over the deep before the drive of the West Wind:
 from far off, blacker than pitch it shows,
 moving over the deep, and it brings a great storm with it;
 he shivers at the sight, and drives his flocks into a cave:
- 280 such, beside the two Ajaxes, moved the close-packed companies
 of Zeus-nurtured fighting men, dark masses,
 into destroying war, bristling with shields and spears.
 Seeing them too the lord Agamemnon rejoiced,
 and speaking winged words he addressed them:
- 285 "Ajaxes, leaders of the bronze-shirted Argives —
 to you two I give no orders: it would not be right to push you;
 you yourselves drive your people hard to fight in strength.

O father Zeus, Athena, Apollo —
 if such a spirit were in every breast,
 290 then the city of lord Priam would soon bow its head,
 taken and sacked beneath our hands."
 So speaking he left them there and went to the others.
 There he came on Nestor, the clear-voiced speaker of Pylos,
 arraying his companions and driving them to fight,
 295 around tall Pelagon, and Alastor, and Chromius,
 and the lord Haemon, and Bias, shepherd of the people.
 The charioteers he arrayed in front with horses and cars,¹⁵
 the foot-soldiers behind, many and brave,
 to be a wall of war; the shirkers he drove into the middle,
 300 so that even the unwilling man would have to fight.
 To the charioteers he gave his orders first: he bade them
 hold their horses in hand and not tangle in the crowd:
 "Let no man, trusting his horsemanship and his manhood,
 burn to fight the Trojans alone out in front of the rest,
 305 and let no man fall back — you will be the weaker for it.
 But the man who from his own car can reach an enemy's,
 let him thrust with the spear: it is far better so.
 This was the mind the men before us had when they sacked
 cities and walls, keeping this thought and spirit in their breasts."
 310 So the old man drove them on, wise in war long since.
 Seeing him too the lord Agamemnon rejoiced,
 and speaking winged words he addressed him:
 "Old man — would that, as the spirit is in your own breast,
 so your knees kept pace, and your strength stood firm.
 315 But age wears you, age that comes to all. If only
 some other man had your years, and you were among the young."
 Then answered him the Gerenian horseman Nestor:
 "Son of Atreus, I too could dearly wish to be
 the man I was when I cut down brilliant Ereuthalion.
 320 But the gods never give men everything at once:¹⁶
 if I was young then, now old age comes with me.
 Even so I will be among the charioteers, and command them
 with counsel and with words: that is the honor-portion of the old.
 The spears the younger men will wield, who were born

- 325 after me and trust in their strength."
 So he spoke, and Atreus' son passed on, glad at heart.
 He found Menestheus, driver of horses, son of Peteos,
 standing; and around him the Athenians, masters of the war-cry;
 and close by stood resourceful Odysseus,
 330 and beside him the ranks of Cephalenians, no weaklings,
 stood; for their people had not yet heard the war-cry,
 since the companies of horse-taming Trojans and Achaeans
 had only just begun to move; and they stood waiting
 for another Achaean column to come on,
 335 charge the Trojans, and begin the war.
 Seeing them, the lord of men Agamemnon raked them,
 and speaking winged words he addressed them:
 "You — son of Peteos, that Zeus-nurtured king;
 and you, master of evil tricks, greedy-hearted:
 340 why do you stand apart cowering, and wait for others?
 It is for you two to stand among the first
 and take your share of scorching battle face on;
 for you are first to hear of my feast
 whenever we Achaeans set out a feast for the elders.
 345 There it pleases you to eat the roasted meat and drink
 the cups of honey-sweet wine as long as you wish;
 but now you would gladly watch even if ten columns of Achaeans
 fought with the pitiless bronze out in front of you."
 Glaring at him darkly, resourceful Odysseus answered:
 350 "Son of Atreus — what a word has escaped the fence of your teeth!¹⁷
 How can you say I hang back from fighting, whenever we Achaeans
 wake sharp war on the horse-taming Trojans?
 You will see — if you wish to, and if it matters to you —
 the dear father of Telemachus mixing with the front-fighters
 355 of the horse-taming Trojans. What you say is empty wind."
 And the lord Agamemnon answered him, smiling,
 when he saw his anger, and took back his word:
 "Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus of many devices,
 I neither scold you beyond measure nor give you orders.
 360 I know the heart in your breast
 knows gentle counsels: you think what I think.

- Come — we will make this good later, if any harsh thing
has been said now; may the gods make it all come to nothing."
So speaking he left them there and went to the others.
- 365 He found Tydeus' son, high-hearted Diomedes,
standing among the horses and the bolted chariots,
and beside him stood Sthenelus, Capaneus' son.
Seeing him too the lord Agamemnon raked him,
and speaking winged words he addressed him:
- 370 "Ah me — son of war-minded Tydeus, breaker of horses:¹⁸
why do you cower? Why do you eye the causeways of battle?
It was not Tydeus' way to cower like this,
but to fight the enemy far ahead of his own companions —
so said those who watched him at his work; I myself
- 375 never met him, never saw him; but they say he was beyond all others.
Once, indeed, he came to Mycenae — no war in it —
a guest, with godlike Polyneices, raising troops:
they were then marching on the holy walls of Thebes,
and they begged us hard to give them famed allies;
- 380 and our people were willing, and approved what they asked,
but Zeus turned them back with unfavorable signs.
So they went on their way, and when they were well along the road
and came to the Asopus, deep in rushes, bedded in grass,
the Achaeans sent Tydeus forward with a message.
- 385 He went, and found the Cadmeans in their numbers
feasting through the house of the might of Eteocles.
There, stranger though he was, the horseman Tydeus
was not afraid, alone among so many Cadmeans:
he challenged them to contests, and won every one
- 390 with ease — such a helper to him was Athena.
But the Cadmeans, goaders of horses, were angered,
and as he rode back they set a close-packed ambush,
fifty young men, with two leaders:
Maeon, Haemon's son, a match for the immortals,
- 395 and Autophonus' son, Polyphontes steadfast in battle.
On these too Tydeus let loose an unseemly fate:
he killed them all, and sent one man alone home —
Maeon he sent off, obeying the gods' portents.

- Such a man was Tydeus the Aetolian. But the son
 400 he fathered is worse than he in battle — better in the assembly."
 So he spoke, and strong Diomedes said nothing at all,
 humbled by the reverend king's rebuke.
 But the son of glorious Capaneus answered him:
 "Son of Atreus, do not lie when you know how to speak the truth."¹⁹
 405 We claim to be far better men than our fathers:
 we took the seat of seven-gated Thebes,
 though we led a smaller host beneath a stronger wall,
 because we trusted the gods' portents and the help of Zeus;
 they perished by their own recklessness.
 410 So never set our fathers in honor equal to ours."
 Glaring at him darkly, strong Diomedes answered:
 "Old friend — sit quiet, and listen to my word."²⁰
 I hold nothing against Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,
 for driving the strong-greaved Achaeans to fight:
 415 the glory will follow him if the Achaeans
 cut down the Trojans and take holy Ilion —
 and his the great grief if the Achaeans are cut down.
 Come — let the two of us also remember our rushing courage."
 He spoke, and leapt from the chariot to the ground in his armor,
 420 and the bronze rang terribly on the chest of the lord
 as he sprang: fear would have seized even a stone-hearted man.
 As when on a booming beach the swell of the sea
 rises, wave on wave, under the West Wind's driving:
 out on the deep it first rears its crest, and then
 425 breaking on the land it thunders aloud, and around the headlands
 it arches and comes to a peak and spits out the salt foam:
 so wave on wave the companies of the Danaans moved
 without pause into war; and each captain called commands
 to his own; and the rest went silently — you would not think
 430 so great a host was following with voices in their chests —
 in silence, fearing their commanders; and on all of them
 the patterned armor shone as they marched in order.
 But the Trojans — as ewes past counting stand in the fold
 of a man of much substance while their white milk is drawn,
 435 bleating without cease because they hear the voices of their lambs:

- so the clamor of the Trojans rose through the wide army;
 for their speech was not one, their cry not a single tongue,
 but language mixed with language, men called from many lands.
 These Ares drove on, and those grey-eyed Athena,
 440 and Terror, and Panic, and Strife insatiably raging,²¹
 sister and companion of man-slaughtering Ares —
 she who rears her crest small at first, but soon
 props her head against heaven while she walks the earth.
 She then cast common hatred into their midst,
 445 moving through the crowd, swelling the groaning of men.
 And when they had come together into one place,
 they dashed together shields, and spears, and the fury of men
 armored in bronze; the bossed shields
 pressed hard on one another, and a great din arose.
 450 There rose together the groaning and the boasting of men
 killing and killed, and the earth ran with blood.
 As when winter torrents pouring down the mountains
 hurl together their weight of water at a meeting of glens
 out of great springs, deep in a hollow ravine,
 455 and far off in the mountains a shepherd hears the thunder of it:
 such was the roar and the toil of them as they came together.
 First Antilochus took a Trojan armored fighter,²²
 a brave man among the front-fighters, Echepolus, Thalysias' son:
 he struck him first on the ridge of his horsehair helmet,
 460 and the bronze point fixed in his forehead and drove
 inside the bone; and darkness covered his eyes,
 and he crashed like a tower in the strong encounter.
 As he fell, the lord Elephenor took him by the feet —
 Chalcodon's son, chief of the great-hearted Abantes —
 465 and dragged him out from under the missiles, straining to strip
 his armor with all speed. But his effort was short-lived:
 great-hearted Agenor saw him dragging the corpse,
 and where his side showed from under the shield as he bent,
 he stabbed him with the bronze-pointed spear, and unstrung his limbs.
 470 So the spirit left him; and over his body the work
 of Trojans and Achaeans grew grim: like wolves
 they leapt at one another, and man tore at man.

Then Telamonian Ajax struck Anthemion's son,²³
the young man Simoeisios in his bloom, whom once his mother
475 bore beside the banks of Simois, coming down
from Ida, where she had followed her parents to see the flocks:
for that they called him Simoeisios. But to his dear parents
he never paid back the cost of his rearing; his life was short,
broken under the spear of great-hearted Ajax.
480 For as he came on in the front, Ajax struck him in the chest
by the right nipple, and straight through his shoulder
the bronze spear came; and he fell to the ground in the dust
like a poplar that has grown up in the wet meadow
of a great marsh — smooth, with the branches growing
485 at its very top — and a chariot-maker with the bright iron
fells it, to bend a wheel-rim for a beautiful car,
and it lies there seasoning along the river bank:
such was Anthemion's son Simoeisios, whom Ajax
the Zeus-sprung killed. And at him Antiphos of the glancing corslet,
490 Priam's son, cast his sharp spear through the crowd:
he missed him, but struck Leucus, Odysseus' brave companion,
in the groin as he dragged the corpse to the other side,
and he collapsed over it, and the body fell from his hand.
For his killing Odysseus was enraged to the heart,
495 and he strode through the front-fighters helmed in flashing bronze,
and came up very close and cast his shining spear,
glancing all around him; and the Trojans shrank back
from the man as he cast. He did not send the shaft in vain,
but struck Democoon, Priam's bastard son,
500 who had come from Abydos, from the fast mares:
him Odysseus, enraged for his companion, struck with the spear
in the temple, and out through the other temple passed
the bronze point; and darkness covered his eyes,
and he fell with a thud, and his armor clattered upon him.
505 Then the front-fighters gave ground, and glorious Hector too;
and the Argives shouted aloud and dragged away the corpses
and pressed far forward. But Apollo took offense,
looking down from Pergamos, and called aloud to the Trojans:
"Rouse yourselves, horse-taming Trojans! Do not yield the fight

- 510 to the Argives: their flesh is not stone, not iron,
to hold off the flesh-cutting bronze when they are hit.
And Achilles, son of lovely-haired Thetis, is not
fighting: by the ships he digests his heart-paining anger."
So spoke the dread god from the city. And the Achaeans
515 were urged on by Zeus's daughter, most glorious Tritogeneia,²⁴
moving through the crowd wherever she saw them slacken.
Then fate shackled Diores, Amarynceus' son:
he was struck by a jagged stone beside the ankle,
in his right shin, and the thrower was the captain of the Thracians,
520 Peiroos, Imbrasus' son, who had come from Aenus.
Both tendons and the bones the shameless stone
crushed utterly; and he fell back in the dust,
stretching out both hands to his dear companions,
gasping out his life; and the man who hit him ran up,
525 Peiroos, and stabbed him with the spear beside the navel; and all
his bowels poured out on the ground, and darkness covered his eyes.
But as Peiroos sprang back, Thoas the Aetolian struck him
with a spear in the chest above the nipple, and the bronze fixed in his
lung;
and Thoas came up close, wrenched the heavy spear
530 out of his chest, and drew his sharp sword,
and struck him full in the belly, and took his life.
But he did not strip his armor: his companions stood round him,
the Thracians with their hair in topknots, long spears in their hands,
who, big and strong and proud as he was,
535 thrust him back from them; and he gave ground, staggering.
So the two lay stretched in the dust beside each other,
captains, one of the Thracians, one of the bronze-shirted
Epeians; and around them many others were killed.
Then no man could have come and made light of the work —²⁵
540 no man still unhit, unstabbed by the sharp bronze,
who whirled through the middle of it, with Pallas Athena leading him
by the hand and turning aside the rush of missiles:
for many Trojans and Achaeans on that day
were stretched face-down in the dust beside one another.

NOTES TO BOOK 4

- 1 *l. 8* "Hera of Argos and Athena of Alalcomenae" — cult titles tying each goddess to a major sanctuary (the Argive Heraion; Alalcomenae in Boeotia). Zeus needles them by their official addresses, like reading their titles off a temple inscription.
- 2 *ll. 34-36* "eat Priam raw" — the extremity of hatred in the poem's idiom; the image recurs at its darkest moments (Achilles to Hector, 22.346-347; Hecuba on Achilles, 24.212). Here it is Zeus's sardonic measure of Hera's appetite.
- 3 *ll. 51-56* Hera offers Zeus her own three dearest cities — Argos, Sparta, Mycenae, the great centers of her cult — to destroy at his pleasure, as the price of Troy. Aristarchus athetized 55-56 (apparatus, Line 55-56: ath. Ar), where she concedes that resistance would be futile anyway. The bargain frames the war's resumption as a cold divine transaction; note Zeus's matching concession at 43, "willingly — with unwilling heart" (ἐκὼν ἄέκοντί γε θυμῷ), the poem's most compressed oxymoron.
- 4 *l. 101* "Apollo the Lycian-born" (Λυκηγενής) — disputed already in antiquity: "born in Lycia" (Pandarus's men are Lycians of the Troad) or "wolf-born" (λύκος). The traditional rendering is kept. This is the same Pandarus whose bow "Apollo himself gave" (2.827) — the god of archery presides, with grim irony, over the poem's most disastrous bowshot.
- 5 *ll. 105-111* The bow: horns of a wild ibex Pandarus shot himself, sixteen palms (about four feet) of horn, joined and gold-tipped by a craftsman. The loving technical excursus at the moment of treachery is a signature Homeric effect — the made thing described while its use damns its user.
- 6 *l. 117* Aristarchus athetized this line ("never yet shot, winged, a base of black pains"), as he did 140 and 149 in the same scene (apparatus) — ornamental lines the tradition found dispensable. All are kept as printed.
- 7 *l. 123* "to the bow the iron head" — one of the poem's rare iron weapons: arms in the Iliad are bronze, and iron appears mainly as raw wealth or for tools (the chariot-maker's axe at 485). The arrowhead here and the mace of Areithous (7.141) are the notable exceptions — often taken as glimpses of the poet's own later age.
- 8 *ll. 132-138* The arrow passes through three layers: the ζωστήρ ("war-belt," the outer clasped belt), the doubled corslet, and the μίτρη ("waist-guard," a bronze-faced apron beneath). These renderings are fixed for the rest of the translation; the ζῶμα ("loin-guard") appears at 187.
- 9 *ll. 141-147* The ivory simile: a Maeonian or Carian craftswoman staining ivory crimson for a horse's cheek-piece — a treasure "many horsemen prayed to carry." Blood on Menelaus's thighs becomes luxury inlay: the poem's first great aestheticizing of a wound, and a deliberate shock after the fly-brushing tenderness of 130-131.
- 10 *l. 155* "it was your death I was cutting in those oaths" — the oath-cutting idiom (see the translator's note on Book 3) turned bitter: Agamemnon hears the ritual he performed as

a throat-cutting of his own brother.

- 11 *ll. 194, 219* Asclepius is in Homer a mortal hero-physician, taught by Chiron the centaur (the wise counter-image of the beast-men of 1.268) — not yet the god of healing of later cult. His sons Machaon and Podaleirius lead a contingent (2.731-732); Machaon's treatment — extraction, sucking the wound, herbal dressings — is the poem's standard battlefield medicine.
- 12 *ll. 195-197* These lines recur verbatim at 205-207 when Talthybius delivers the message. Aristarchus athetized the first occurrence (apparatus, Line 195-197: ath. hic Ar. (= 205-207)) — a doctrinaire application of his dislike of repetition; the messenger-repetition is normal epic technique (cf. Book 2, note [4]). Both passages are translated, identically.
- 13 *ll. 223-421* The epipōlēsis ("review"): Agamemnon on foot down the line, praising Idomeneus, the Ajaxes, and Nestor, insulting Menestheus, Odysseus, and Diomedes. The scene is a portrait gallery — and a study of Agamemnon's leadership, whose goads are as ill-judged as his flatteries are smooth.
- 14 *l. 242* "loud boasters" (ἰόμωποι) — obscure insult, already opaque in antiquity: perhaps "braggarts with arrows" (fighting from range, not in the line), perhaps just "loudmouths." The translation keeps the taunt and this note keeps the doubt.
- 15 *ll. 297-309* Nestor's tactics — chariots massed in front, infantry behind, shirkers penned in the middle, with a doctrine of chariot- line fighting "the men before us" used — describe a kind of massed chariot warfare that the poem's actual battles never show (Homeric chariots are battle-taxis). Either a memory of older warfare or the old man's idealization of it; the poem lets Nestor be the keeper of both.
- 16 *l. 320* "the gods never give men everything at once" — athetized by Aristarchus (apparatus; cf. the similar 13.729). Ereuthalion (319) is the club-wielding champion Nestor killed in his youth — the full story is saved for 7.136-156.
- 17 *l. 350* "what a word has escaped the fence of your teeth" (ἔρκος ὀδόντων) — the fixed formula for speech that should have been kept in; always so rendered.
- 18 *ll. 370-400* Agamemnon's Tydeus-tale reaches back to the Theban war: Tydeus and Polyneices recruiting at Mycenae, the embassy to Thebes, the athletic challenges, the fifty-man ambush he wiped out. This is the Iliad's fullest window on the Theban saga — the great rival epic cycle — deployed, characteristically, as a father held up against a son. "The might of Eteocles" (386) is the same periphrasis pattern as "the might of Heracles" (2.658).
- 19 *ll. 404-410* Sthenelus's retort: the Epigoni — the sons of the Seven — actually took Thebes, which their fathers failed to do and died trying, "by their own recklessness" (ἄτασθαλίῃσιν, the Odyssey's opening moral keyword). Aristarchus athetized 407-409 (apparatus, Line 407-409: ath. Ar). Kept: the exchange sets up Diomedes' pointed contrast.
- 20 *l. 412* "Old friend" (τέττα) — an affectionate, untranslatable address found only here. Diomedes silences Sthenelus and absorbs the insult out of respect for the king's office — restraint he will pointedly recall when he answers Agamemnon back at 9.32-49. The moment defines him: youngest of the great captains and the most self-governed.

- 21 *ll. 440-443* Terror (Δεῖμος), Panic (Φόβος), and Strife (Ἔρις) — war's demons personified; Strife "small at first" but growing to prop her head on heaven is the ancestor of Virgil's Fama. Her epithet "insatiable" earns itself over the next twenty books.
- 22 *ll. 457-462* The first death of the Iliad: Antilochus (Nestor's son) kills Echeolus. The kill establishes the death-formulas this translation keeps fixed from here on: "darkness covered his eyes," "he fell with a thud, and his armor clattered upon him," "unstrung his limbs," "his spirit left him." Their unvarying recurrence is the poem's own drumbeat and is preserved, never elegantly varied.
- 23 *ll. 473-489* Simoeisios: named for the river Simois where his mother bore him, killed in his first bloom, who "never paid back the cost of his rearing" (θρέπτρα — the son's debt of care to his parents), falling like a poplar cut down to be a chariot's wheel-rim. The first full pathos-vignette of the battle books: an entire peacetime life conjured at the instant of its ending, the template for the poem's way of killing men.
- 24 *l. 515* "Tritogeneia" — ancient title of Athena, of unknown meaning even to the ancients (connected variously with lake Tritonis, the river Triton, or "third-born"). Left as a name, like Atrytone (2.157).
- 25 *ll. 539-544* The book closes with an imagined observer led through the carnage by Athena, untouched and turning missiles aside — only under those impossible conditions could a man "make light of the work." The narrator's device measures the day: many Trojans and Achaeans "stretched face-down in the dust beside one another."

Iliad — Book 5

*The great day of Diomedes, who wounds two gods, Aphrodite and Ares,
and drives them from the field.*

- Then it was that Pallas Athena gave Tydeus' son¹
 Diomedes fury and daring, so that he might stand out
 among all the Argives and win himself high fame.
 She kindled unwearying fire from his helmet and shield,
 5 like the star of late summer that beyond all others
 blazes bright when it rises bathed in Ocean:
 such was the fire she kindled from his head and shoulders,
 and she drove him into the middle, where the press was thickest.
 There was among the Trojans one Dares, wealthy, blameless,²
 10 a priest of Hephaestus; and he had two sons,
 Phegeus and Idaeus, skilled in all fighting.
 These two broke from the line and charged him head on,
 the two of them from their car, he on foot from the ground.
 And when they were close, advancing on one another,
 15 Phegeus first hurled his long-shadowed spear:
 over Tydeus' son's left shoulder the spear-point
 passed, and did not hit him. Second, Tydeus' son
 rose with his bronze; and not in vain did the shaft escape his hand:
 he struck his chest between the nipples, and thrust him from the car.
 20 Idaeus sprang away, leaving the beautiful chariot;
 he did not dare stand over his slain brother —
 nor would he himself have escaped black doom either,
 but Hephaestus snatched him out and saved him, wrapped in night,
 so that his old priest should not be wholly broken with grief.
 25 And the son of great-hearted Tydeus drove off the horses
 and gave them to his companions to lead down to the hollow ships.
 Now when the great-hearted Trojans saw the two sons of Dares,
 one fleeing, one killed beside his chariot,
 the hearts of all were shaken. And grey-eyed Athena
 30 took rushing Ares by the hand and spoke to him:
 "Ares, Ares, bane of mortals, blood-stained stormer of walls —³

- shall we not leave the Trojans and Achaeans
to fight it out, and let father Zeus give glory where he will,
while we two withdraw, and keep clear of the wrath of Zeus?"
- 35 So speaking she led rushing Ares out of the battle,
and sat him down on the high bank of Scamander.
Then the Danaans bent the Trojans back; and each of the captains
took his man. First the lord of men Agamemnon
threw great Odios, captain of the Halizones, from his chariot:
- 40 as he turned, first of all, the spear fixed in his back
between the shoulders and drove through his chest;
he fell with a thud, and his armor clattered upon him.
And Idomeneus cut down Phaestus, son of Maeonian Borus,
who had come from deep-soiled Tarne:
- 45 him Idomeneus famed with the spear, just as he mounted
behind his horses, stabbed with the long spear through the right
shoulder;
he crashed from the car, and hateful darkness seized him.
And Idomeneus' aides stripped him of his armor.
And Scamandrius, son of Strophius, the keen hunter,
- 50 fell to Atreus' son Menelaus and his sharp spear —
a fine huntsman: Artemis herself had taught him
to bring down all the wild things the mountain forest breeds.
But Artemis who showers arrows was no help to him then,⁴
nor the long shots in which he once excelled;
- 55 Atreus' son Menelaus, famed with the spear,
stabbed him with the spear in the back as he fled before him,
between the shoulders, and drove it through his chest;
he crashed face-down, and his armor clattered upon him.
And Meriones cut down Phereclus, son of Tecton,
- 60 Harmon's son, whose hands knew how to fashion
all cunning work, for Pallas Athena loved him beyond all men;
he was the one who had built for Alexandros the balanced ships
that began the evil — a curse to all the Trojans⁵
and to himself, since he knew nothing of the gods' decrees.
- 65 Him Meriones, when he caught him in the chase,
struck in the right buttock, and the point passed under the bone
straight through into the bladder;

he dropped to his knees with a scream, and death enfolded him.
 And Meges killed Pedaeus, Antenor's son —
 70 bastard-born, but brilliant Theano had reared him⁶
 with care, like her own dear children, to please her husband.
 Phyleus' son, famed with the spear, came in close
 and struck him with the sharp spear in the tendon of the head;
 straight on through the teeth the bronze cut under his tongue,
 75 and he crashed in the dust, his teeth clenched on cold bronze.
 And Eurypylus, Euaemon's son, killed brilliant Hypsenor,
 son of high-hearted Dolopion, who was made
 Scamander's priest, and was honored by his people like a god:
 him Eurypylus, Euaemon's shining son,
 80 running him down as he fled before him, struck on the shoulder
 with a sweep of his sword, and sheared away his heavy arm;
 the bloody arm fell in the field; and over his eyes
 came purple death, and fate the overpowering.⁷
 So they labored in the strong encounter.
 85 But Tydeus' son — you could not have told which side he fought on,
 whether he ran with the Trojans or the Achaeans:
 for he stormed across the plain like a river in flood,
 a winter torrent that scatters the dikes in its rushing;
 the close-built dikes cannot contain it,
 90 nor the walls of the fruitful orchards hold it,
 when it comes suddenly, swollen with the rain of Zeus,
 and everywhere the fine works of strong men crash before it:
 so before Tydeus' son the packed companies of the Trojans
 were driven, and for all their numbers they could not stand him.
 95 But when Lycaon's shining son caught sight of him
 storming across the plain, driving the companies before him,
 quickly he bent his curved bow at Tydeus' son
 and shot him as he charged, striking the right shoulder
 at the plate of the corslet; the bitter arrow flew through
 100 and held straight on, and the corslet was splattered with blood.
 Over him Lycaon's shining son shouted aloud:
 "Rouse yourselves, great-hearted Trojans, goaders of horses!
 The best of the Achaeans is hit; and I say he will not
 long stand up under the strong shaft — if truly it was

- 105 the lord Apollo, Zeus's son, who sped me here from Lycia."
 So he spoke in his boasting. But the swift shaft did not break him:
 he drew back and stood before his horses and chariot
 and spoke to Sthenelus, Capaneus' son:
 "Up, good son of Capaneus — get down from the chariot,
 110 and pull this bitter arrow out of my shoulder."
 So he spoke, and Sthenelus leapt from the car to the ground
 and stood beside him and drew the swift shaft clean through the
 shoulder,
 and the blood came spurting up through the supple tunic.
 Then Diomedes, good at the war-cry, prayed aloud:
 115 "Hear me, child of aegis-bearing Zeus, Unwearied one!
 If ever with kind intent you stood by my father
 in the heat of war, now befriend me in turn, Athena:
 grant me to kill this man — let him come in range of my spear —
 who shot me before I saw him and now boasts of it, and says
 120 I shall not long look on the bright light of the sun."
 So he spoke in prayer, and Pallas Athena heard him.
 She made his limbs light, the feet and the hands above them,
 and standing close she spoke winged words:
 "Take heart now, Diomedes, and fight the Trojans:
 125 for into your chest I have put your father's fury,
 the fearless fury the shield-shaking horseman Tydeus had;
 and I have taken from your eyes the mist that was on them before,⁸
 so that you may know clearly god and man alike.
 Therefore, if some god comes here to test you,
 130 do not fight face to face with any immortal —
 any of the others; but if Aphrodite, Zeus's daughter,
 comes into the fighting, wound her with the sharp bronze."
 So speaking, grey-eyed Athena went her way,
 and Tydeus' son went back and mixed with the front-fighters;
 135 and eager as his heart had been before to fight the Trojans,
 now fury three times as great took hold of him — like a lion
 that a shepherd in the field, guarding his woolly sheep,
 has grazed as it leapt the fold-wall, and not brought down:
 he has only roused its strength; and after that, no help —
 140 he slips in among the folds, and the flock panics, abandoned;

- the sheep are heaped in piles on one another,
 while the lion in its fury leaps the deep fold's wall again:
 so in his fury strong Diomedes mixed with the Trojans.
 There he took Astynous, and Hypeiron, shepherd of the people:
 145 one he struck above the nipple with the bronze-pointed spear;
 the other he hit with the great sword on the collarbone
 by the shoulder, and sheared the shoulder from the neck and back.
 These he left, and went after Abas and Polyidus,
 sons of Eurydamas, the old reader of dreams;
 150 but the old man read no dreams for them at their going —⁹
 strong Diomedes killed them both.
 Then he went after Xanthus and Thoon, sons of Phaenops,
 both late-born and beloved; and their father was worn with hard age,
 and had fathered no other son to leave over his possessions.
 155 There Diomedes killed them, and took the dear life
 of both, and left the father lamentation and bitter cares:
 he never welcomed them home alive from the fighting,
 and kinsmen of the widowed house divided the estate.
 Then he took two sons of Priam, Dardanus' descendant,
 160 Echemmon and Chromius, both in one chariot.
 As a lion leaps in among cattle and snaps the neck
 of a heifer or a cow as they graze the woodland,
 so the son of Tydeus forced them both from their horses,
 hard against their will, and stripped their armor;
 165 and the horses he gave his companions to drive to the ships.
 Now Aeneas saw him tearing the ranks of men apart,
 and went off through the fighting and the clatter of spears
 searching for godlike Pandarus, if he might find him.
 He found Lycaon's son, blameless and strong,
 170 and stood before him and spoke a word to his face:
 "Pandarus, where are your bow, and your winged arrows,
 and your fame? No man here rivals you in it,
 and no man in Lycia claims to be better than you.
 Come — lift your hands to Zeus, and loose a shaft at this man,
 175 whoever he is, who is master here, who has done the Trojans
 so much evil already, and unstrung the knees of many good men —
 unless he is some god enraged at the Trojans,

- angry over sacrifices; and a god's wrath is a heavy thing."
 Then answered him Lycaon's shining son:
- 180 "Aeneas, counselor of the bronze-shirted Trojans,
 in everything I liken him to the war-minded son of Tydeus:
 I know him by his shield and his crested helmet's eye-slits,
 and by the look of his horses. Yet I cannot say for sure he is not a god.
 But if he is the man I think, the war-minded son of Tydeus,
- 185 then not without a god does he rage like this: one of the immortals
 stands close by him, shoulders wrapped in cloud,
 who turned aside my swift shaft even as it reached him.
 For I have already loosed a shaft at him, and I hit him
 in the right shoulder, straight through the plate of the corslet;
- 190 I said to myself I had hurled him down to Aïdoneus —
 and yet I did not break him. Some god is angry.
 And horses I have none, no chariot I might mount —
 though somewhere in Lycaon's halls stand eleven chariots,¹⁰
 beautiful, new-built, fresh from the maker, with cloths
- 195 spread over them; and beside each a yoked pair of horses
 stands, champing white barley and spelt.
 Endlessly, as I was leaving, the old spearman Lycaon
 charged me in our well-built house:
 he told me to mount horse and chariot
- 200 and lead the Trojans in the strong encounters.
 But I would not listen — it would have been far better —
 sparing the horses, for fear that in the crush of men
 they would go short of fodder, they who were used to eating their fill.
 So I left them, and came on foot to Ilion,
- 205 trusting my bow — and it was to do me no good.
 Already I have shot at two of their best,
 Tydeus' son and Atreus' son, and out of both
 I drew real blood with my hits — and only roused them the more.
 It was a bad fate that made me take my curved bow from its peg
- 210 that day when I led my Trojans to lovely Ilion,
 doing a favor for brilliant Hector.
 If ever I come home, and set eyes on
 my fatherland and my wife and my great high-roofed house,
 let some stranger strike my head off then and there

- 215 if I do not break this bow with my hands and throw it
into the blazing fire. It follows me around like wind."
Then Aeneas, captain of the Trojans, answered him:
"No more of that kind of talk. Nothing will change
until we two go against this man with horses
220 and chariot and try him in his armor, face to face.
Come, get up into my car, and see
what the horses of Tros are like, how they know their plain —
how to wheel fast this way and that, in pursuit or flight.
They will carry the two of us safe to the city, if once again
225 Zeus hands the glory to Diomedes, Tydeus' son.
Come then, take the whip and the glossy reins,
and I will dismount to do the fighting; or you
face the man yourself, and I will look after the horses."
Then answered him Lycaon's shining son:
230 "Aeneas, keep the reins yourself, and your own two horses.
Better they pull the curved car under the driver they know,
if we should have to run from the son of Tydeus.
I would not have them take fright and stand useless, balking,
unwilling to carry us out of the fighting, missing your voice,
235 while the son of great-hearted Tydeus springs on us
and kills the two of us and drives off the single-hoofed horses.
You drive your own chariot and your own horses,
and I will take him, when he comes on, with the sharp spear."
So the two spoke, and mounting the patterned chariot
240 they drove the swift horses hard at Tydeus' son.
And Sthenelus saw them, Capaneus' shining son,
and quickly he spoke winged words to Tydeus' son:
"Diomedes, Tydeus' son, delight of my heart,
I see two strong men bent on fighting you,
245 men of measureless power: one the master Bowman
Pandarus — and he claims to be Lycaon's son;
the other Aeneas, who claims blameless Anchises
for father — and his mother is Aphrodite.
Come, let us give ground on the chariot. Stop raging¹¹
250 through the front-fighters like this, or you may lose your dear life."
Glaring at him darkly, strong Diomedes answered:

- "No talk of flight: I do not think you will persuade me.
It is not in my blood to dodge a fight
or cower down. My fury is still steady in me.
- 255 I balk at mounting the chariot: no — just as I am
I will go to meet them. Pallas Athena forbids me to tremble.
As for those two, their swift horses will not carry both
back out of range of us — even if one gets away.
And I will tell you another thing — put it away in your heart:
- 260 if Athena of the many counsels grants me the glory
to kill them both, then you check our own swift horses
here, and stretch the reins tight to the chariot rail,
and remember to make a dash for Aeneas' horses,
and drive them out of the Trojan lines to the strong-greaved Achaeans.
- 265 For they are of that stock which wide-seeing Zeus gave Tros¹²
in payment for his son Ganymede — the best
of all horses under the dawn and the sun;
and from that stock the lord of men Anchises stole a breed,
putting his mares to them without Laomedon's knowledge.
- 270 From these a line of six was born him in his halls:
four he kept himself and reared at the manger,
and these two he gave to Aeneas, machines of rout.
If we could take those two, we would win high fame."
So the two of them spoke such things to one another,
- 275 and the other two came quickly on, driving the swift horses.
First Lycaon's shining son called out to him:
"Hard-hearted, war-minded son of proud Tydeus —
so my swift shaft did not break you, my bitter arrow.
Now I will try with the spear, and see if I hit."
- 280 He spoke, and balancing his long-shadowed spear he hurled it
and struck the shield of Tydeus' son: straight through it
the bronze point flew and pressed on to the corslet.
Over him Lycaon's shining son shouted aloud:
"You are hit clean through the flank! I do not think
- 285 you will hold up long now. You have given me great glory!"
Unshaken, strong Diomedes answered him:
"A miss, not a hit! But you two, I think, will not
be done before one or the other of you falls

and gluts with his blood Ares, the fighter under the ox-hide shield."
 290 So speaking he hurled; and Athena steered the shaft
 to the nose beside the eye, and it passed the white teeth.
 The unwearying bronze cut off his tongue at the root¹³
 and the point came out under the base of the chin;
 he crashed from the car, and his armor clattered upon him,
 295 glancing-bright, shimmering; and the swift-footed horses
 shied aside; and there his life and strength were unstrung.
 Then Aeneas sprang down with shield and long spear,
 fearing the Achaeans might somehow drag the corpse away.
 He strode around it like a lion sure of its strength,
 300 holding before him his spear and the shield balanced every way,
 set on killing whoever came against him,
 crying terribly. But Tydeus' son caught up a boulder
 in his hand — a great feat: two men could not carry it,¹⁴
 such as mortals are now; but he swung it easily, even alone,
 305 and struck Aeneas with it on the hip, where the thigh
 turns in the hip-socket — the cup, as men call it:
 he crushed the cup, and tore both tendons through,
 and the jagged stone stripped the skin away. The hero
 dropped to his knees and stayed there, propping himself
 310 with one thick hand on the earth; and black night covered his eyes.
 And now the lord of men Aeneas would have perished,
 if Zeus's daughter Aphrodite had not been quick to see —
 his mother, who conceived him to Anchises herding cattle.
 She poured her white arms around her dear son,
 315 and spread before him a fold of her shining robe
 to be a screen against missiles, for fear some Danaan of the swift colts
 might drive bronze into his chest and take his life.
 So she began to carry her dear son out of the fighting.
 But the son of Capaneus did not forget the orders
 320 that Diomedes, good at the war-cry, had laid on him:
 he checked their own single-hoofed horses
 clear of the tumult, stretching the reins tight to the rail,
 made his dash for the lovely-maned horses of Aeneas,
 and drove them out of the Trojan lines to the strong-greaved Achaeans,
 325 and gave them to Deipylus, his dear companion, whom he honored

- beyond all his agemates because their minds ran together,
 to drive to the hollow ships. Then the hero
 mounted his own car and took the glossy reins
 and drove his strong-hoofed horses hard after Tydeus' son,
 330 eagerly. But Diomedes had gone after Cypris with the pitiless bronze,¹⁵
 knowing her for a god without war-strength — none
 of those goddesses who lord it in the wars of men,
 no Athena, no Enyo, sacker of cities.
 And when he caught her, chasing through the thick of the crowd,
 335 the son of great-hearted Tydeus lunged
 and leaping in stabbed with the sharp spear the tip
 of her soft hand; and the spear pierced the skin straight through
 the ambrosial robe the Graces themselves had made her,
 above the base of the palm. And the immortal blood of the goddess ran
 —
 340 ichor, such as runs in the veins of the blessed gods:¹⁶
 for they eat no bread, they drink no gleaming wine,
 and so they are bloodless, and are called deathless ones.
 She gave a great shriek, and flung her son from her —
 and Phoebus Apollo caught him up in his arms
 345 and hid him in a blue-dark cloud, for fear some Danaan of the swift
 colts
 might drive bronze into his chest and take his life.
 And over her Diomedes, good at the war-cry, shouted aloud:
 "Give way, daughter of Zeus, from war and fighting!
 Is it not enough that you cozen strengthless women?
 350 If you must haunt the war, then I think
 war will make you shudder after this, even at the rumor of it."
 So he spoke; and she went off dazed, in terrible pain;
 and wind-footed Iris took her and led her out of the crowd
 crushed with agony, her lovely skin darkening.
 355 She found rushing Ares seated on the battle's left,
 his spear leaning on a cloud-bank, and his swift horses.
 Dropping to her knees before her dear brother
 she begged and begged him for the golden-fronted horses:
 "Dear brother, take me in — give me your horses,
 360 so I may reach Olympus, where the immortals have their seat.

- The wound is too much for me — a mortal man struck me:
 Tydeus' son, who would fight father Zeus himself now."
 So she spoke, and Ares gave her the golden-fronted horses,
 and she climbed into the chariot, her dear heart aching,
 365 and Iris climbed in beside her and took the reins in her hands
 and whipped the horses on; and the two flew, nothing loath.
 Quickly they came to the gods' seat, steep Olympus,
 and there swift wind-footed Iris halted the horses,
 loosed them from the car, and threw them ambrosial fodder;
 370 and brilliant Aphrodite fell on the knees of Dione,¹⁷
 her mother; and Dione gathered her daughter in her arms
 and stroked her with her hand, and spoke a word, and named her:
 "Who has done this to you, dear child — which of the sons of Heaven —
 so wantonly, as though you had been caught doing wrong in the open?"
 375 Then answered her laughter-loving Aphrodite:
 "Tydeus' son wounded me, high-hearted Diomedes,
 because I was carrying my dear son out of the fighting —
 Aeneas, who is far the dearest of all things to me.
 This is no longer the dread din of Trojans and Achaeans:
 380 now the Danaans are fighting even with the immortals."
 Then answered her Dione, brilliant among goddesses:
 "Bear up, my child, and endure it, grieved though you are."¹⁸
 Many of us who keep our homes on Olympus have endured
 things from men, in the hard griefs we lay on one another.
 385 Ares endured it, when Otus and strong Ephialtes,
 the sons of Aloeus, bound him in strong bonds:
 thirteen months he lay bound in a bronze jar,
 and Ares the insatiate of war might have perished there,
 if their stepmother, beautiful Eëriboea,
 390 had not brought word to Hermes; and Hermes stole Ares out,
 worn down already, for the hard bonds were breaking him.
 Hera endured it, when the strong son of Amphitryon
 struck her in the right breast with a three-barbed arrow;
 then pain took hold of her too, past all comfort.
 395 Hades the gigantic endured a swift arrow with the rest,
 when the same man, the son of aegis-bearing Zeus,
 shot him at Pylos among the dead, and gave him over to pain:

- he went to the house of Zeus and high Olympus
 aching at heart, skewered with agony; the arrow
 400 was driven deep in his massive shoulder, and it wore his spirit.
 Paiëon sprinkled pain-killing drugs upon the wound
 and healed him: for he was not of mortal make.
 The hard man, the violent-worker! — he cared nothing what outrage he
 did,
 who vexed with his arrows the gods who hold Olympus.
- 405 And this one — grey-eyed Athena set him on you.
 The fool: the son of Tydeus does not know in his heart
 that the man who fights the immortals does not live long;
 his children do not climb to his knees and call him papa¹⁹
 when he comes home from war and the dread fighting.
- 410 So now let Tydeus' son, for all his strength,
 look to it, or a better fighter than you may face him,
 and Aegialeia, Adrastus' watchful-minded daughter,
 wake her whole house from sleep with her wailing,
 mourning the wedded husband of her youth, the best of the Achaeans
 —
- 415 the strong wife of Diomedes, breaker of horses."
 She spoke, and with both hands wiped the ichor from the arm;
 the arm was made whole, and the heavy pains were eased.
 But Athena and Hera, looking on,
 began to provoke Zeus, son of Cronos, with needling words;
- 420 and the goddess grey-eyed Athena led the talk:
 "Father Zeus, will you be angry at all with me for what I say?
 It must be that Cypris was coaxing some Achaean woman
 to run off with the Trojans she now so wonderfully loves,
 and stroking that soft-robed Achaean woman's gown,
 425 she scratched her slender hand on a golden brooch-pin."
 So she spoke, and the father of men and gods smiled,
 and he called golden Aphrodite to him and said:
 "Not to you, my child, are given the works of war."²⁰
 No — you attend to the lovely works of marriage;
- 430 all this shall be the business of quick Ares and Athena."
 So they spoke such things to one another.
 But Diomedes, good at the war-cry, sprang at Aeneas,

though he well knew Apollo himself held his arms above him;
 he did not stand in awe even of the great god, but pressed on,
 435 always straining to kill Aeneas and strip his famed armor.
 Three times he sprang at him, raging to kill,
 and three times Apollo beat back his shining shield;
 but when for the fourth time he came on like more than man,²¹
 Apollo the worker-from-afar called out with a terrible cry:
 440 "Think, son of Tydeus — and fall back. Do not try to think
 thoughts equal to the gods: never of one kind
 are the race of immortal gods and of men who walk the earth."
 So he spoke, and Tydeus' son gave back a little way,
 shunning the wrath of Apollo who strikes from afar.
 445 And Apollo set Aeneas down apart from the crowd
 in holy Pergamos, where his own temple stood;
 and Leto and Artemis who showers arrows
 healed him in the great inner shrine, and made him glorious.
 But Apollo of the silver bow made a phantom,²²
 450 the very likeness of Aeneas, armor and all,
 and around the phantom the Trojans and brilliant Achaeans
 hacked at one another's chests, at the round
 ox-hide shields and the light fringed bucklers.
 Then Phoebus Apollo spoke to rushing Ares:
 455 "Ares, Ares, bane of mortals, blood-stained stormer of walls —
 will you not go in and drag this man out of the fighting,
 this son of Tydeus, who would fight father Zeus himself now?
 First he wounded Cypris, close in, on the hand at the wrist;
 then he charged at me myself, like more than man."
 460 So speaking, he sat down on the height of Pergamos,
 and baneful Ares went in among the Trojan ranks and roused them,
 in the likeness of Acamas, swift captain of the Thracians,
 and called to the Zeus-nurtured sons of Priam:
 "You sons of Priam, the king whom Zeus sustains,
 465 how long will you let your people be killed by the Achaeans?
 Until they are fighting around the well-built gates?
 A man is down whom we honored like brilliant Hector —
 Aeneas, son of great-hearted Anchises.
 Come, let us save our brave companion from the tumult!"

- 470 So speaking he stirred the fury and heart of every man.
 And then Sarpedon raked brilliant Hector hard:²³
 "Hector, where has that fury gone that you had before?
 You used to say, I think, that you would hold the city without armies,
 without allies — alone, with your sisters' husbands and your brothers.
- 475 I cannot see one of them now, cannot pick one out:
 they cower like dogs around a lion.
 It is we who do the fighting — we, your mere allies.
 I am an ally myself, and I came from very far:
 far away is Lycia, on the eddying Xanthus,
- 480 where I left my dear wife and my little son,
 and great wealth besides, which every have-not covets.
 Even so I drive my Lycians on, and I am eager myself
 to fight my man — though there is nothing of mine here
 for the Achaeans to carry off or drive away.
- 485 And you just stand there — you do not even order
 the rest of your people to hold and defend their wives.
 Take care, or like men caught in the meshes of an all-catching net
 you become the prey and spoil of your enemies —
 and they will sack your well-peopled city soon.
- 490 All this should be your care, night and day:
 to beg the captains of your far-famed allies
 to hold on without flinching — and to put away hard reproach."
 So spoke Sarpedon, and the word bit Hector to the heart.
 At once he leapt in his armor from the chariot to the ground,
- 495 and shaking his two sharp spears went everywhere through the army,
 driving men to fight, and woke the dread din of battle.
 And the Trojans wheeled about and stood to face the Achaeans;
 and the Argives, massed close, awaited them and did not run.
 As the wind carries chaff across the sacred threshing-floors
- 500 when men are winnowing, and tawny-haired Demeter
 in the driving wind divides the grain from the husks,
 and the chaff-heaps whiten: so the Achaeans then
 turned white from above with dust, which through their ranks
 the horses' hooves beat up to the all-bronze sky
- 505 as the fighting rejoined; and the drivers wheeled them round.
 Straight on they carried the fury of their hands; and rushing Ares

drew night over the battle to help the Trojans,
 ranging everywhere — carrying out the charge
 of Phoebus Apollo of the golden sword, who had bidden him
 510 wake the Trojans' spirit when he saw Pallas Athena
 leaving the field: for she was the Danaans' helper.
 And Apollo himself sent Aeneas out from the rich inner shrine
 and put fury into the chest of the shepherd of the people.
 Aeneas took his place among his companions; and they rejoiced
 515 to see him come to them alive and unhurt
 and full of brave fury. But they asked him nothing:
 the other toil would not let them — the toil the god of the silver bow
 was waking, and Ares bane of mortals, and Strife insatiably raging.
 And on the other side the two Ajaxes and Odysseus and Diomedes
 520 drove the Danaans on to fight; and they of themselves
 feared neither the Trojans' force nor their charges,
 but stood fast, like the clouds the son of Cronos
 halts in windless weather on the mountain-tops,
 motionless, while the fury of the North Wind sleeps, and the other
 525 hard-blowing winds, whose shrill blasts
 scatter the shadowing clouds whenever they rise:
 so the Danaans stood the Trojans, steady, unfleeing.
 And Atreus' son ranged through the crowd, commanding everywhere:
 "Friends — be men! Take hold of a fighting heart;
 530 feel shame before each other in the strong encounters.
 Where men feel shame, more are saved than slain;²⁴
 where they run, no fame rises, and no strength."
 He spoke, and hurled his spear quick, and struck a front-rank man,
 Deicoon, Pergasus' son, companion of great-hearted
 535 Aeneas — a man the Trojans honored like Priam's own children,
 for he was quick to fight among the foremost.
 The lord Agamemnon struck his shield with the spear,
 and the shield did not stop it: the bronze passed clean through
 and drove through the war-belt into the lower belly;
 540 he fell with a thud, and his armor clattered upon him.
 Then Aeneas took two of the Danaans' best men,
 the sons of Diocles, Crethon and Orsilochus,
 whose father lived in well-built Pherae,

- rich in substance; his line was from the river
 545 Alpheius, which flows wide through the Pylians' land,
 and the river begot Ortilochus, lord over many men,²⁵
 and Ortilochus fathered great-hearted Diocles,
 and of Diocles were born twin sons,
 Crethon and Orsilochus, skilled in all fighting.
 550 These two in their first manhood, on the black ships,
 followed with the Argives to Ilion of the fine colts,
 winning recompense for the sons of Atreus, Agamemnon
 and Menelaus; and there the end of death enfolded them both.
 Like two lions reared by their mother
 555 on the mountain peaks, in the thickets of deep forest,
 that harry the cattle and the fat sheep
 and lay waste the steadings of men, until they too
 are killed at men's hands by the sharp bronze:
 such were these two, broken under the hands of Aeneas,
 560 and they fell like tall fir trees.
 And as they fell, Menelaus dear to Ares pitied them,
 and strode through the front-fighters helmed in flashing bronze,
 shaking his spear; and Ares whetted his fury,
 with this thought: that he should go down under Aeneas' hands.
 565 But Antilochus saw him, great-hearted Nestor's son,
 and strode through the front-fighters; for he feared for the shepherd of
 the people,
 lest he suffer harm and cheat them of all their labor.
 The two were holding out their hands and sharp spears
 face to face, raging to fight,
 570 when Antilochus came and stood close by the shepherd of the people;
 and Aeneas did not stand his ground, quick fighter though he was,
 when he saw two men holding the line side by side.
 And when they had dragged the corpses back to the Achaean host,
 they laid the poor pair in their companions' arms,
 575 and turned themselves, and fought on among the foremost.
 There the two of them took Pylaemenes, the equal of Ares,²⁶
 captain of the great-hearted Paphlagonian shieldmen:
 him Atreus' son Menelaus, famed with the spear,
 stabbed with the spear as he stood, striking through the collarbone;

- 580 and Antilochus struck Mydon, his driver and aide,
 Atymnius' brave son, just as he wheeled the single-hoofed horses —
 caught his elbow square with a boulder; and out of his hands
 the reins, white with ivory, dropped in the dust.
 Antilochus sprang in and drove his sword through his temple,
 585 and gasping he pitched from the well-made chariot
 headfirst in the dust, on his crown and shoulders.
 A long moment he stood there planted — he had struck deep sand —
 till his own horses knocked him flat in the dust
 as Antilochus whipped them, and drove them to the Achaean camp.
- 590 But Hector marked them across the ranks, and charged them
 shouting; and with him followed the strong companies
 of the Trojans; and Ares led them, and the lady Enyo —²⁷
 she bringing Tumult with her, the shameless spirit of carnage,
 while Ares handled a gigantic spear in his fists
 595 and ranged now in front of Hector, now behind him.
 And seeing him Diomedes, good at the war-cry, shuddered.
 As a man crossing a great plain stops helpless
 at a quick-running river flowing down to the sea,
 sees it seething with foam, and starts back and away:
 600 so Tydeus' son now gave ground, and said to his people:
 "Friends — no wonder we marvel at brilliant Hector
 as spearman and daring fighter:
 beside him always stands some god who beats ruin away.
 There — Ares stands by him now, in the likeness of a mortal man.
- 605 Keep your faces to the Trojans, and give ground
 backward; do not rage to fight force against force with gods."
 So he spoke; and the Trojans came on very close.
 There Hector killed two men skilled in fighting,
 Menesthes and Anchialus, both in one chariot.
- 610 And as they fell, great Telamonian Ajax pitied them,
 and came up close and made his stand, and cast his shining spear
 and struck Amphius, Selagus' son, who in Paesus
 lived rich in substance, rich in grainland; but fate
 led him to fight as ally for Priam and his sons.
- 615 Telamonian Ajax struck him in the war-belt:
 the long-shadowed spear fixed in the lower belly,

- and he fell with a thud. And glorious Ajax ran in
to strip his armor; but the Trojans rained down spears on him,
sharp, glittering; and his shield took many.
- 620 He set his heel on the corpse and pulled out
his bronze spear; but the rest of the fine armor he could not
lift from the shoulders: the missiles pressed him too hard.
And he feared the strong ring of the proud Trojans,
who stood over him many and brave with spears set,
- 625 who, big and strong and proud as he was,
thrust him back from them; and he gave ground, staggering.
So they labored in the strong encounter.
And Tlepolemus, Heracles' son, tall and brave,
was driven against godlike Sarpedon by fate the overpowering.
- 630 And when they were close, advancing on one another —
the son and the grandson of Zeus the cloud-gatherer —
Tlepolemus spoke to him first:
"Sarpedon, counselor of the Lycians — what forces you
to cower here, a man who knows nothing of battle?
- 635 They lie when they call you the son of aegis-bearing
Zeus: you fall far short of those men
who were born of Zeus in the generations before us —
what they say the might of Heracles was,
my own father, bold-hearted, lion-spirited!
- 640 He came here once for the horses of Laomedon,²⁸
with only six ships and fewer men,
and sacked the city of Ilion, and widowed her streets.
But your heart is a coward's, and your people are dying away.
I do not think you will be any bulwark to the Trojans
- 645 for having come from Lycia — no, not if you are very strong —
but broken by me you will pass the gates of Hades."
Then Sarpedon, captain of the Lycians, answered him:
"Tlepolemus — yes, that man destroyed holy Ilion
through the folly of one proud man, Laomedon,
- 650 who paid his good service with a hard word
and refused the horses he had come so far for.
But for you, I say your portion here from me is slaughter
and black doom: broken under my spear you will give

- the glory to me, and your life to Hades of the famed colts."
- 655 So spoke Sarpedon; and Tlepolemus lifted his ash spear,
and the two long spears sprang from their hands
in the same instant. Sarpedon struck him full in the neck,
and the point passed through, bringing anguish;
and murky night covered his eyes.
- 660 And Tlepolemus's long spear had struck the left thigh:
the point tore through, raging,
and grazed the bone — but his father still warded off ruin.
Then his brilliant companions bore godlike Sarpedon
out of the fighting; and the long spear dragging from his thigh
- 665 weighed on him; no one noticed it, no one thought
in their haste to draw the ash spear from his thigh
so he might stand: such toil they had in tending him.
And on the other side the strong-greaved Achaeans bore
Tlepolemus out of the fighting. Brilliant Odysseus marked it,
- 670 his enduring heart holding, and his spirit blazed up;
and he weighed it then in his mind and heart,
whether to press on after the son of loud-thundering Zeus
or take the lives of more of the Lycian rank and file.
But it was not fated for great-hearted Odysseus
- 675 to kill the strong son of Zeus with the sharp bronze;
so Athena turned his fury against the mass of the Lycians.
There he took Coeranus, and Alastor, and Chromius,
Alcandrus and Halius and Noëmon and Prytanis;
and brilliant Odysseus would have killed still more Lycians,
- 680 if great Hector of the flashing helmet had not been quick to see.
He strode through the front-fighters helmed in flashing bronze,
bringing terror to the Danaans; and Sarpedon, Zeus's son,
rejoiced at his coming, and spoke a piteous word:
"Son of Priam — do not leave me lying here
- 685 a prize for the Danaans. Stand over me! Afterward, if it must be,
let life leave me in your city — since it was not to be
that I should come home to my own dear fatherland
and gladden my dear wife and my little son."
So he spoke; and Hector of the flashing helmet answered him nothing,
- 690 but swept past, straining to thrust the Argives back

with all speed, and take the lives of many.
 Then his brilliant companions laid godlike Sarpedon
 under a beautiful oak of aegis-bearing Zeus,
 and strong Pelagon, who was his dear companion,
 695 pushed the ash spear out through his thigh;
 and his spirit left him, and a mist poured down over his eyes.
 Then he breathed again: the breath of the North Wind²⁹
 blowing round him brought back to life the spirit he had gasped away.
 Meanwhile the Argives, under Ares and bronze-helmed Hector,
 700 neither turned and ran for the black ships
 nor stood up to them in fight, but always backward
 they gave ground, once they learned Ares was with the Trojans.
 Whom first, whom last did they strip of his arms,³⁰
 Hector, Priam's son, and brazen Ares?
 705 Godlike Teuthras first, and Orestes, driver of horses,
 and Trechus the Aetolian spearman, and Oenomaus,
 and Helenus, Oenops' son, and Oresbius of the glancing waist-guard,
 who lived in Hyle, hoarding his wealth with care,
 on the shore of the Cephisian lake; and near him other
 710 Boeotians lived, and held a rich district of land.
 Now when the goddess white-armed Hera marked the two of them
 killing Argives in the strong encounter,
 at once she spoke winged words to Athena:
 "Shame! Unwearied one, child of aegis-bearing Zeus —
 715 empty, then, was the word we pledged to Menelaus,
 that he should sack well-walled Ilium before returning,
 if we let baneful Ares rage on like this.
 Come — let the two of us also remember our rushing courage."
 So she spoke, and the goddess grey-eyed Athena did not disobey.
 720 Hera went to and fro harnessing the golden-fronted horses —
 Hera, eldest goddess, daughter of great Cronos;
 and Hebe quickly set on the chariot the curved wheels,³¹
 bronze, eight-spoked, at the two ends of the iron axle.
 Their fellow is imperishable gold, and over it
 725 bronze tires are fitted, a wonder to see;
 the naves that circle at either side are silver,
 and the car is slung on plaited straps of gold

and silver, with a double rail running round it.
 From it the pole ran out, of silver; and on its end
 730 she bound the beautiful golden yoke, and cast on it
 the beautiful golden breast-straps; and under the yoke Hera
 led the swift-footed horses, hungry for strife and the war-cry.
 And Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus,
 let fall her soft robe on her father's floor,³²
 735 the many-colored robe she herself had made and worked with her
 hands,
 and put on the tunic of Zeus the cloud-gatherer,
 and armed herself in his gear for tearful war.
 Around her shoulders she cast the tasseled aegis,³³
 terrible, crowned on every side with Rout;
 740 on it is Strife, on it Valor, on it blood-chilling Pursuit,
 and on it the Gorgon's head, the dread monster's,
 dreadful and grim, the portent of aegis-bearing Zeus.
 On her head she set the golden helmet, double-ridged,
 four-bossed, fitted with the fighting men of a hundred cities.
 745 Into the flaming chariot she stepped, and gripped the spear —
 heavy, huge, compact — with which she breaks the ranks of men,
 of heroes, when she of the mighty father is angered with them.
 And Hera swiftly touched the horses with the whip;
 and self-moved the gates of heaven groaned open, kept by the
 Seasons,³⁴
 750 to whom great heaven and Olympus are entrusted,
 to roll the thick cloud aside, or set it back.
 There, straight through, they held the goaded horses;
 and they found the son of Cronos sitting apart from the other gods
 on the topmost peak of many-ridged Olympus.
 755 There the goddess white-armed Hera halted the horses
 and questioned Zeus most high, the son of Cronos:
 "Father Zeus, have you no anger at Ares for these brute works —
 how great a host of the Achaeans he has destroyed, and what men,
 recklessly, in no kind of order? It is grief to me; and meanwhile
 760 at their ease Cypris and Apollo of the silver bow
 enjoy it, having let loose this madman who knows no law.
 Father Zeus — will you be angry at all with me if I

- strike Ares a bitter blow and chase him out of the fighting?"
 Answering her spoke Zeus the cloud-gatherer:
- 765 "Go to it: set the driver of the spoil on him — Athena,
 who beyond all others is used to bringing him hard pain."
 So he spoke, and the goddess white-armed Hera did not disobey.
 She whipped the horses on; and the two flew, nothing loath,
 between the earth and the starry sky.
- 770 As far as a man can see into the haze with his eyes,³⁵
 sitting on a lookout, gazing over the wine-dark sea,
 so far at a single bound spring the gods' high-neighing horses.
 And when they came to Troy and the two flowing rivers,
 where Simois and Scamander join their streams,
- 775 there the goddess white-armed Hera halted the horses,
 loosed them from the car, and poured thick mist around them;
 and Simois made ambrosia spring up for them to graze.
 And the two went with steps like shy doves' in their gait,
 hot to bring help to the Argive men.
- 780 And when they came to where the most and the best of them
 stood packed around the might of Diomedes, breaker of horses,
 like lions that eat flesh raw
 or wild boars, whose strength does not give out,
 there the goddess white-armed Hera stood and shouted,
- 785 in the likeness of great-hearted Stentor of the bronze voice,³⁶
 whose shout was as loud as fifty other men's:
 "Shame, Argives! Vile disgraces — admired only for your looks!
 While brilliant Achilles still came out to war,³⁷
 the Trojans never ventured past the Dardanian gates:
- 790 they feared his massive spear too much.
 Now they fight far from the city, at the hollow ships."
 So speaking she stirred the fury and heart of every man.
 And the goddess grey-eyed Athena sprang to Tydeus' son.
 She found that lord beside his horses and chariot,
- 795 cooling the wound Pandarus's arrow had made.
 For the sweat was wearing him under the broad strap
 of his round shield — it wore him, and his arm was tired;
 he was lifting the strap and wiping off the dark-clouded blood.
 The goddess laid her hand on his horses' yoke and spoke:

- 800 "Little like himself, the son Tydeus got!"³⁸
 Tydeus was a small man in build — but a fighter.
 Even that time I would not let him fight
 or flash to the front — when he came apart from the Achaeans
 as a messenger to Thebes, among the Cadmeans in their numbers,
 805 and I told him to feast in their halls at his ease —
 even then, keeping that strong heart of his, as always,
 he challenged the young Cadmean men, and won everything
 with ease: such a helper was I to him.
 And you — here I stand beside you, and guard you,
 810 and bid you with good will: fight the Trojans!
 But either the weariness of many charges has soaked your limbs,
 or some spiritless fear is holding you. Then you are no
 son of Tydeus, the war-minded son of Oeneus' line."
 Answering her spoke strong Diomedes:
 815 "I know you, goddess, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus;
 so I will tell you my word freely, and hide nothing.
 No spiritless fear is holding me, no hanging back:
 I am still keeping the commands you laid on me yourself.
 You would not let me fight face to face with the blessed gods —
 820 the others; but if Aphrodite, Zeus's daughter,
 came into the fighting, her I might wound with the sharp bronze.
 That is why I now give ground myself, and why I ordered
 all the other Argives to fall in here around me:
 for I know it is Ares who is lording it over the battle."
 825 Then answered him the goddess grey-eyed Athena:
 "Diomedes, Tydeus' son, delight of my heart —
 no: fear neither Ares for that, nor any other
 of the immortals: such a helper am I to you.
 Come — at Ares first! Drive the single-hoofed horses at him
 830 and strike him at close quarters. No awe of rushing Ares —
 that raving thing, that made evil, that turncoat,
 who just now stood promising me and Hera to his face
 that he would fight the Trojans and help the Argives —
 and now he runs with the Trojans, and has forgotten all of it."
 835 So speaking she pushed Sthenelus back off the chariot,
 hauling him with her hand — and he leapt down smartly —

and the goddess mounted the car beside brilliant Diomedes,
 blazing for the fight; and the beechwood axle groaned aloud³⁹
 under the weight: it carried a dread goddess, and the best of men.

840 Pallas Athena took up the whip and the reins,
 and at Ares first she drove the single-hoofed horses.
 He was in the act of stripping gigantic Periphas,
 far the best of the Aetolians, Ochesius' shining son —
 blood-stained Ares was stripping him. And Athena

845 put on the helmet of Hades, so that massive Ares should not see her.⁴⁰
 But when Ares, bane of mortals, saw brilliant Diomedes,
 he let gigantic Periphas lie where he was,
 there where he had first killed him and taken his life,
 and made straight for Diomedes, breaker of horses.

850 And when they were close, advancing on one another,
 Ares lunged first, over the yoke and the horses' reins,
 with his bronze spear, raging to take his life;
 but the goddess grey-eyed Athena caught it in her hand
 and thrust it up over the car to spend itself on air.

855 Second, Diomedes, good at the war-cry, drove in
 with his bronze spear; and Pallas Athena rammed it home
 into the lowest belly, where the waist-guard girded him:
 there he stabbed and struck, and tore the fair flesh open,
 and wrenched the spear out again. And brazen Ares bellowed

860 as loud as nine thousand men, or ten thousand,⁴¹
 cry out in war when they join the strife of the war-god.
 And trembling took hold of Achaeans and Trojans alike
 in their fear: so loud was the bellow of Ares insatiate of war.
 As dark air shows out of clouds

865 when after heat a foul stormwind rises,
 so brazen Ares showed to Diomedes, Tydeus' son,
 as he went up with the clouds into the wide sky.
 Swiftly he came to the gods' seat, steep Olympus,
 and sat down beside Zeus, son of Cronos, aching at heart,

870 and showed the immortal blood running down from the wound,
 and whimpering he spoke winged words:
 "Father Zeus, have you no anger, seeing these brute works?
 Always we gods endure the most shuddering pains

- by one another's devices, when we bring favor to men.
- 875 And with you we are all at war: for you fathered the mad,
accursed girl whose mind is forever on lawless deeds.
All the other gods on Olympus
obey you; each one of us is subject to you;
but her you never check by word or deed —
- 880 you let her run, because you bore this destroying child yourself.
Now she has set the son of Tydeus, overweening Diomedes,
raging against the immortal gods.
First he wounded Cypris, close in, on the hand at the wrist;
then he charged at me — at me! — like more than man.
- 885 My quick feet carried me out of it; otherwise I should long
be suffering agonies there among the ghastly heaps of dead,
or living strengthless from the strokes of the bronze."
Glaring at him darkly, Zeus the cloud-gatherer answered:
"Do not sit beside me and whimper, turncoat.⁴²
- 890 Most hateful to me are you of all the gods who hold Olympus:
strife is always dear to you, and wars, and battles.
You have your mother Hera's temper — unbearable,
past yielding; I can scarcely break her with words;
and so I think it is by her promptings you suffer this.
- 895 Still, I will not bear to see you long in pain:
you are of my stock; your mother bore you to me.
But had you been born so destroying from any other god,
long since you would have lain lower than the sons of Uranus."
So he spoke, and told Paiëon to heal him;
- 900 and Paiëon sprinkled pain-killing drugs upon the wound
and healed him: for he was not of mortal make.
As when fig-juice thickens the white milk at a stir,⁴³
liquid before, and it curdles fast as a man turns it,
so quickly he healed rushing Ares.
- 905 And Hebe bathed him and dressed him in graceful clothing,
and he sat down beside Zeus, son of Cronos, exulting in his glory.
And the two came back to the house of great Zeus —
Hera of Argos and Athena of Alalcomenae —
having stopped the bane of mortals from his slaughter of men.

NOTES TO BOOK 5

- 1 *ll. 1-8* The poem's first *aristeia* — a single hero's sustained blaze of supremacy — opens with literal blaze: Athena kindles fire from Diomedes' armor, like "the star of late summer" (Sirius, whose rising brings fever-heat; the same star will light Achilles in Book 22). The scene-type recurs for Agamemnon (11), Patroclus (16), and Achilles (19-22); it will not be re-footnoted.
- 2 *ll. 9-24* The book's first vignette is a priest's sons — and Hephaestus saves the survivor "so that his old priest should not be wholly broken with grief." A god honoring his priest's grief is the Chryses situation of Book 1 in miniature, here granted mercy.
- 3 *l. 31* "Ares, Ares, bane of mortals, blood-stained stormer of walls" (Ἄρες Ἄρες βροτολοιγὲ μαιφόνε τειχεσιπλήτῃ) — the famous triple invocation; repeated verbatim by Apollo at 455. The epithets are now fixed: βροτολοιγός "bane of mortals," μαιφόνος "blood-stained," θοῦρος "rushing," χάλκεος "brazen."
- 4 *ll. 51-54* "Artemis herself had taught him... But Artemis was no help to him then" — the recurring pathos-pattern of the divine gift that fails its owner at the killing moment (cf. the seer's sons at 148-151, whose father "read no dreams for them at their going").
- 5 *ll. 59-64* Phereclus, the shipwright who built Paris's ships "that began the evil" (ἀρχεκάκους) — the craftsman of the war's first cause, loved by Athena, killed in her war. His genealogy is a craft-pedigree: son of Tecton ("Carpenter"), Harmon's son ("Joiner"). Aristarchus athetized 64 (apparatus).
- 6 *ll. 69-71* Theano — Antenor's wife and (in Book 6) priestess of Athena in Troy — reared her husband's bastard "like her own dear children, to please her husband": a one-line window into the social workings of concubinage and legitimacy in the poem's households.
- 7 *ll. 82-83* "over his eyes closed purple death, and fate the overpowering" — the grandest of the death-formulas, reserved for moments of special weight; πορφύρεος is the dark surge-color of a swelling sea. Fixed rendering hereafter.
- 8 *ll. 127-132* Athena lifts the mist so Diomedes can tell god from man, and issues the standing order that structures the whole book: fight no immortal — except Aphrodite. His exact obedience (he yields to Apollo at 443, cites the order verbatim at 815-824) is what marks his god-fighting as sanctioned service rather than *hybris* — until she herself revokes the order at 825-834.
- 9 *ll. 148-151* Eurydamas "read no dreams for them at their going" — the dream-interpreter who could not (or did not) read his own sons' deaths; the same irony as note [4], sharpened to a profession.
- 10 *ll. 192-216* Pandarus's self-revelation: eleven new chariots at home under dust-cloths, the father's advice refused, the horses spared their fodder — thrift and half-measures,

ending in the bowman's curse on his own bow. The poem gives the truce-breaker of Book 4 a small-souled domestic interior just before killing him.

- 11 *ll. 249-250* Zenodotus athetized Sthenelus's counsel of retreat (apparatus, Line 249-250: ath. Zen.) — perhaps as unworthy of a hero. Kept: the exchange sets up Diomedes' refusal ("It is not in my blood," 253) and the horse-raid plan.
- 12 *ll. 265-272* The horses of Tros: Zeus's compensation to the mortal father for carrying off Ganymede — the poem's matter-of-fact note that gods pay for what they take. Anchises' stealth breeding from Laomedon's stock supplies Aeneas's team; their theft at 323-327 re-enacts the pedigree.
- 13 *ll. 290-296* Athena steers the spear through Pandarus's mouth, severing "his tongue at the root": the oath-breaker and boaster of Book 4 is killed through the organ of his boasting. The poem does not say "poetic justice"; it merely aims the spear.
- 14 *ll. 302-304* "two men could not carry it, such as mortals are now" (οἶοι νῦν βροτοί εἶσι) — first occurrence of the diminished-present formula: the narrator measures his heroes against his own lesser age. It recurs at 12.383, 12.449, 20.287.
- 15 *l. 330* "Cypris" (Κύπρις) — Aphrodite's cult-name from Cyprus, used in the Iliad only in this book (330, 422, 458, 760, 883). Kept as the name wherever the Greek uses it.
- 16 *ll. 339-342* Ichor: the poem invents divine hematology on the spot — gods bleed a different fluid because "they eat no bread, they drink no gleaming wine." Wounded, a god is proved bloodless and deathless at once; the theology is delivered as physiology.
- 17 *ll. 370-371* Dione — Aphrodite's mother here, otherwise almost absent from Greek epic; in Hesiod Aphrodite is born of the sea-foam from Uranus's severed flesh, motherless. The Iliad's genealogy makes her a daughter of Zeus with a mother whose name is the feminine of Zeus (Dīōnē ~ Dios). At Dodona, Dione was worshipped as Zeus's consort.
- 18 *ll. 382-404* Dione's consolation-catalogue — mortals have wounded gods before: Ares chained thirteen months in a bronze jar by the giant twins Otus and Ephialtes; Hera shot in the breast and Hades shot "at Pylos among the dead" by Heracles. These are shards of older, wilder myth preserved nowhere else; "at Pylos" was already disputed in antiquity (the town? or "at the gate" — πύλῳ — of the dead?). Paiëon, the gods' own healer (distinct from Apollo in this poem), closes the paradigm — and will be needed again at 899. Consolation-by-precedent ("others have endured; endure") is the poem's standard comfort, used on gods exactly as on men.
- 19 *ll. 406-415* Dione's veiled prophecy: the god-fighter "does not live long; his children do not climb to his knees and call him papa" — with Diomedes' wife Aegialeia imagined waking the house with her mourning. The Iliad lets the warning hang unfulfilled (Diomedes survives the poem); later tradition made Aegialeia faithless on his return — a grim afterlife for Aphrodite's grudge that the poem does not know or does not say.
- 20 *ll. 428-430* "Not to you, my child, are given the works of war" — Zeus's gentle, smiling demarcation of spheres; among the most quoted lines of the poem in antiquity (Cicero renders it in Latin, apparatus at Line 428). The smile, and the fact that it is Aphrodite's only wound in the poem, keep the scene comedy.

- 21 ll. 436-442 Three times he charged — the fourth time "like more than man" (δαίμονι ἴσος) — and the god's warning: "never of one kind / are the race of immortal gods and of men who walk the earth." The poem's theology in a couplet, and the planting of its most fateful rhythm: the same three-then-fourth pattern, with the same phrase, will kill Patroclus at the hands of this same god (16.702-711, 784-793).
- 22 ll. 449-453 The eidōlon: Apollo fashions a phantom Aeneas, and both armies fight over an image while the man heals in the temple. The poem's first phantom — a device more at home in the Odyssey and in later Helen-legend — dropped here without comment.
- 23 ll. 471-492 Sarpedon's rebuke of Hector: the great statement of the ally's claim — "It is we who do the fighting — we, your mere allies," from a man with nothing at stake here, whose wife and little son wait in Lycia. It is the seed of his famous speech on why kings must fight (12.310-328), and the wife and son return in his death-scene (16.431-461). First full appearance of the poem's noblest Trojan-side figure.
- 24 ll. 529-532 "Where men feel shame, more are saved than slain" — Agamemnon's couplet on αἰδώς, the battlefield ethic of mutual shame that holds lines together; quoted and reused throughout antiquity as the classic statement of shame-culture soldiering (it recurs at 15.561-564).
- 25 ll. 541-549 The twins Crethon and Orsilochus, with the river Alpheius three generations back — note the grandfather Ortilochus and grandson Orsilochus: the printed text itself varies the name's spelling across one genealogy (Zenodotus regularized both to Ortilochus; apparatus, Lines 542-549). Translated as printed, variation and all.
- 26 ll. 576-579 Pylaemenes, the Paphlagonian captain, is killed here by Menelaus — and at 13.658-659 he will walk, alive and weeping, behind his own son's corpse: the most famous continuity slip in the Iliad, noticed since antiquity ("even Homer nods" is Horace's phrase for it). The translation of course leaves both passages as they stand.
- 27 ll. 592-593 Enyo, war-goddess ("sacker of cities," 333), leading with Ares and carrying Tumult (Κυδοιμός, "the shameless spirit of carnage" — the war-demons of 4.440-443 gaining a new member. Personifications capitalized, per convention.
- 28 ll. 638-651 Heracles' sack of Troy, one generation before this war: Laomedon (Priam's father) promised divine horses for the rescue of his daughter Hesione and cheated the hero of his wage; six ships sufficed. The story — Troy already once destroyed for a Laomedon's bad faith — shadows the present war with precedent; the poem glances at it again at 7.452-453 and 21.441-457.
- 29 ll. 696-698 Sarpedon's swoon: "his spirit left him... then he breathed again" — ψυχή here is literally breath, gasped out and blown back by the North Wind. The physiology of the Homeric soul, caught in the act of almost leaving.
- 30 ll. 703-704 "Whom first, whom last did they strip of his arms...?" — the narrator's roll-call question, first occurrence; a formula for the turning tide, reused at 8.273, 11.299, 16.692 (there addressed, devastatingly, to Patroclus himself).
- 31 ll. 722-732 Hebe assembles the chariot of the gods — eight-spoked bronze wheels on an iron axle, gold felloes, bronze tires, silver naves and pole — the poem's most loving machine-description, in present tenses, as of divine property that simply is. Hebe

("Youth"), cupbearer of Book 4, here shows a mechanic's hands; at 905 she bathes Ares. The Seasons (749) mind the gates.

- 32 *ll. 734-735* Athena "let fall her soft robe on her father's floor, the many-colored robe she herself had made" — the goddess of weaving strips her own handiwork to put on her father's tunic for war. Zenodotus athetized the couplet (apparatus, Line 734-735); kept — the gesture is the whole meaning.
- 33 *ll. 738-744* The aegis unfurled — its fullest description: crowned with Rout, set with Strife, Valor, blood-chilling Pursuit, and the Gorgon's head, "the portent of aegis-bearing Zeus" (cf. 2.447-449 for its golden tassels). The golden helmet "fitted with the fighting men of a hundred cities" (744) was obscure already in antiquity — big enough for the armies of a hundred cities, or adorned with them in relief; the translation keeps the strangeness.
- 34 *ll. 749-751* The gates of heaven, "self-moved," groan open — kept by the Seasons (῾Ωραι), doorkeepers whose "gate" is the thick cloud they roll aside or set back. Sky-weather as divine architecture.
- 35 *ll. 770-772* The horizon-leap: as far as a watchman on a headland can see into the haze over the wine-dark sea, so far the divine horses clear at a single bound. Longinus quotes the lines (On the Sublime 9.5) as the measure of Homeric grandeur — "the universe is not big enough for their second stride"; the apparatus records the citation at Line 772.
- 36 *ll. 785-786* Stentor of the bronze voice, "as loud as fifty other men" — the origin of "stentorian." Only here in the poem; ancient scholars knew further verses about him (apparatus at 2.609 mentions them): a famous figure of whom the Iliad keeps only the shout.
- 37 *ll. 788-791* Hera's taunt measures the plot: while Achilles fought, the Trojans never left their gates; now they fight at the ships. The absent hero is the book's invisible unit of measure — the same arithmetic Achilles himself will state at 9.352-355. (Echo note.)
- 38 *ll. 800-813* Athena retells the Tydeus embassy — the same story Agamemnon told at 4.370-400 as a goad, now told by the goddess who was there ("such a helper was I to him"), with the detail that she had forbidden Tydeus to fight and been disobeyed with impunity. The father's licensed recklessness frames the son's licensed obedience: Diomedes' defense (818-824) is that he was following her orders exactly. (Echo note.)
- 39 *ll. 838-839* "the beechwood axle groaned aloud under the weight: it carried a dread goddess, and the best of men." Aristarchus athetized the couplet (apparatus, Line 838-839) — divine weight straining mortal carpentry was evidently too physical for him. Kept: it is the book's theology of embodied gods in one image.
- 40 *ll. 844-845* The helmet of Hades — the cap of invisibility (Hades' name was heard as "the Unseen One"): Athena puts it on so that Ares cannot see her, god blinding god. Only here in Homer; later myth gives it to Perseus.
- 41 *ll. 859-863* The wounded Ares bellows "as loud as nine thousand men, or ten thousand... in war" — the war-god's pain measured in the units of his own element. Both armies tremble at a sound they cannot place.

- 42 *ll. 888-898* Zeus to Ares: "Most hateful to me are you of all the gods who hold Olympus: strife is always dear to you, and wars, and battles" — repeating verbatim Agamemnon's words to Achilles at 1.176-177. The poem's supreme father passes on a mortal king's rebuke, god-scale: the quarrel of Book 1 was a theomachy in miniature, and this theomachy is a family quarrel. "Turncoat" (ἄλλοπρόσαλλος, 831, 889) — Ares' new epithet, "the one who leaps to either side." And the threat: born of any other god, Ares would lie "lower than the sons of Uranus" — beneath the imprisoned Titans, in the pit below Tartarus. (Echo note.)
- 43 *ll. 899-906* Paiëon heals the war-god, and the simile is from the dairy: as fig-juice curdles milk, the wound knits — the homeliest image in the poem laid against divine flesh. Hebe bathes him, and he sits by Zeus "exulting in his glory" — a line repeated from 1.405 (of Briareus), and athetized here by Aristarchus for that reason (apparatus, Line 906). The unrepentant swagger of the freshly healed is, either way, perfect Ares.

Iliad — Book 6

Glaucus and Diomedes exchange armor instead of blows; Hector in Troy with his mother Hecuba, with Helen, and with his wife Andromache.

- So the dread din of Trojans and Achaeans was left to itself;
and this way and that the battle swayed across the plain
as they aimed their bronze-pointed spears at one another,
midway between the streams of Simois and Xanthus.
- 5 Ajax first, Telamon's son, wall of the Achaeans,
broke a Trojan company and made light for his companions,
striking the man who was best among the Thracians,
Acamas, Eussorus' son, tall and brave.
He struck him first on the ridge of his horsehair helmet,
10 and the bronze point fixed in his forehead and drove
inside the bone; and darkness covered his eyes.
And Diomedes, good at the war-cry, killed Axylus,
Teuthras' son, who lived in well-built Arisbe,
a man rich in substance, and a friend to all mankind:¹
15 living in his house by the road, he welcomed all comers.
But not one of them stood before him then to beat off wretched
destruction,
meeting the enemy for him; Diomedes took the life of both,
the man himself and his aide Calesius, who was then
his charioteer; and the two of them went under the earth.
- 20 And Euryalus killed Dresus and Opheltius,
and went after Aesepus and Pedasus, whom once the water-nymph
Abarbarea bore to blameless Bucolion.
Bucolion was proud Laomedon's son,²
eldest born, though his mother bore him in darkness:
25 shepherding his flocks he lay with the nymph in love,
and she conceived, and bore him twin sons —
and Mecisteus' son unstrung the strength and the shining limbs
of both, and stripped the armor from their shoulders.
And Polypoetes steadfast in battle killed Astyalus;
30 and Odysseus cut down Pidytes of Percote

with his bronze spear, and Teucer brilliant Aretaon.
 Antilochus, Nestor's son, took Ablerus with his shining spear,
 and the lord of men Agamemnon took Elatus,
 who lived by the banks of fair-flowing Satnioeis
 35 in steep Pegasus. And the hero Leitus caught Phylacus
 as he ran; and Eurypylus cut down Melanthius.
 Then Menelaus, good at the war-cry, took Adrestus
 alive: for his two horses, bolting across the plain,
 fouled in a tamarisk branch, snapped the curved chariot
 40 at the pole's tip, and themselves ran on
 toward the city, where the rest were bolting in panic,
 while he rolled from the car beside the wheel,
 face-down in the dust on his mouth. And beside him stood
 Atreus' son Menelaus, holding his long-shadowed spear.
 45 Then Adrestus clasped his knees and begged him:
 "Take me alive, son of Atreus — and take a worthy ransom.
 Many treasures lie stored in my rich father's house,
 bronze, and gold, and iron worked with much labor:
 out of these my father would gladden you with ransom past counting
 50 if he learned I was alive by the ships of the Achaeans."
 So he spoke, and was moving the heart in his chest;
 and soon he would have given him to his aide to lead down
 to the Achaeans' swift ships. But Agamemnon
 came running to meet him, and cried out his word:
 55 "Soft-hearted Menelaus! Why do you care so tenderly
 for men? Were such fine things done in your house
 by Trojans? Let not one of them escape sheer destruction
 and our hands — not even the boy his mother carries
 in her womb, not even he: let all of them together
 60 perish out of Ilion, unmourned, and leave no trace."
 So speaking the hero turned his brother's mind,
 for his urging was of things due; and Menelaus pushed³
 the hero Adrestus back with his hand, and the lord Agamemnon
 stabbed him in the flank; he doubled over, and Atreus' son
 65 set a heel on his chest and pulled out the ash spear.
 Then Nestor called to the Argives with a far-carrying shout:
 "Friends, Danaan heroes, squires of Ares —

let no man now hang back for spoils,
 to reach the ships carrying the biggest load:
 70 let us kill men. Afterward, at your ease,
 you will strip the corpses dead across the plain."
 So speaking he stirred the fury and heart of every man.
 Then once more the Trojans, under the Achaeans dear to Ares,
 would have climbed back into Ilion, broken by their own cowardice,
 75 had not Helenus, Priam's son, far the best of bird-readers,⁴
 come and stood by Aeneas and Hector:
 "Aeneas and Hector — since on you two above all rests
 the labor of the Trojans and Lycians, because for every venture
 you are the best men, for fighting and for counsel:
 80 make your stand here; go everywhere and hold the army
 before the gates, before they run and fall
 into their women's arms, and become a joy to our enemies.
 Then, when you have set all the companies moving,
 we will hold here and fight the Danaans,
 85 hard-pressed though we are: necessity drives.
 But you, Hector — go to the city, and speak there
 to your mother and mine: let her gather the older women
 at grey-eyed Athena's temple on the city's height,
 and open with her key the doors of the holy house,
 90 and the robe that seems to her the loveliest and amplest
 in the hall, and far the dearest to herself,
 let her lay it on the knees of lovely-haired Athena,⁵
 and vow to sacrifice to her in the temple twelve heifers,
 yearlings, never goaded, if she will pity
 95 the town, and the Trojans' wives, and their little children —
 if she will hold back Tydeus' son from holy Ilion,
 that wild spearman, that strong machine of rout,
 who I say has proved the strongest of the Achaeans.
 Not even Achilles, that leader of men, ever made us fear so,
 100 who they say was born of a goddess; but this man
 rages beyond measure, and no one can match his fury."
 So he spoke, and Hector did not disobey his brother.
 At once he leapt in his armor from the chariot to the ground,
 and shaking his two sharp spears went everywhere through the army,

- 105 driving men to fight, and woke the dread din of battle.
 And they wheeled about and stood to face the Achaeans;
 and the Argives gave ground and left off their killing:
 they thought some immortal had come down from the starry sky
 to stand by the Trojans, so suddenly they wheeled.
- 110 And Hector called to the Trojans with a far-carrying shout:
 "High-hearted Trojans, and you far-famed allies —
 be men, my friends; remember your rushing courage,
 while I go up to Ilion and tell
 the elders of the council and our wives
- 115 to pray to the divine ones, and vow them hecatombs."
 So speaking Hector of the flashing helmet went;
 and against his ankles and his neck the black oxhide beat,
 the rim that ran outermost on his bossed shield.
 Now Glaucus, Hippolochus' son, and Tydeus' son⁶
- 120 came together in the space between, raging to fight.
 And when they were close, advancing on one another,
 Diomedes, good at the war-cry, spoke to him first:
 "Who are you, brave friend, of mortal men?
 I have never seen you in the battle where men win glory
- 125 before this; yet now you have come out far in front of all
 in your daring, to stand my long-shadowed spear.
 Unhappy are the fathers whose sons face my fury!
 But if you are some immortal come down from the sky —
 I will not fight with heavenly gods.
- 130 No — even Dryas' son, strong Lycurgus,⁷
 did not live long, who strove with heavenly gods:
 he once chased the nurses of raving Dionysus
 down the holy mountain of Nysa; and all together
 they flung their sacred wands to the ground, as man-slaughtering
- 135 Lycurgus beat them with an ox-goad; and Dionysus in terror
 dived under the salt sea's wave, and Thetis took him,
 frightened, to her bosom: for a strong trembling held him
 at the man's shouting. But the gods who live at ease were angered
 at Lycurgus, and Cronos' son struck him blind; nor did he
- 140 live long after, hated by all the immortal gods.
 I would not choose to fight the blessed gods.

- But if you are a mortal, one of those who eat the fruit of the field,
come closer — and come the sooner to the borders of destruction."
Then Hippolochus' shining son addressed him:
- 145 "Great-hearted son of Tydeus — why ask my lineage?
As the generation of leaves, so is the generation of men.⁸
The wind pours some leaves to the ground, and others the forest
grows in their fullness when the season of spring comes on:
so with the generations of men — one grows, one dies away.
- 150 But if you wish to hear even this, and to know
my lineage — many men know it already:
there is a city, Ephyra, in a fold of horse-pasturing Argos,
and there lived Sisyphus, craftiest of men —⁹
Sisyphus, Aeolus' son; and he fathered a son, Glaucus,
155 and Glaucus fathered blameless Bellerophon.
To him the gods gave beauty and lovely manhood;
but Proetus plotted evil against him in his heart,
and drove him out of the land of the Argives — being far
the stronger: for Zeus had bowed them under his scepter.
- 160 For Proetus' wife, brilliant Anteia, was mad
to lie with him in secret love; but she could not
move right-minded, war-minded Bellerophon.
So she lied to King Proetus:
'Die yourself, Proetus — or kill Bellerophon,
165 who wanted to lie with me in love, and I unwilling.'
So she spoke, and anger took hold of the king at what he heard.
He shrank from killing him — his heart stood in awe of that —
but he sent him to Lycia, and gave him baneful signs,
scratching in a folded tablet many life-destroying marks,¹⁰
170 and told him to show it to his wife's father: that he might perish.
So he went to Lycia, under the gods' blameless escort.
And when he came to Lycia and the flowing Xanthus,
the lord of wide Lycia honored him with a ready heart:
nine days he feasted him, and slaughtered nine oxen.
- 175 But when the tenth rosy-fingered Dawn appeared,
then he questioned him, and asked to see the token,
whatever it was he brought from his son-in-law Proetus.
And when he had received his son-in-law's evil token,

- first he ordered him to kill the raging Chimaera —
 180 a thing of divine stock, not of men:
 in front a lion, behind a serpent, in the middle a she-goat,
 breathing out the terrible fury of blazing fire.¹¹
 And he killed her, trusting the portents of the gods.
 Second, he fought the far-famed Solymi:
 185 the hardest battle of men, he said, he ever entered.
 Third, he cut down the Amazons, the match of men.
 And as he came back the king wove him another close-set trap:
 choosing the best men out of wide Lycia
 he set an ambush; and they never came home again —
 190 blameless Bellerophon killed them all.
 But when the king came to know he was the brave son of a god,
 he kept him there, and gave him his daughter,
 and gave him half of all his kingly honor;
 and the Lycians cut him a precinct beyond all others,
 195 fine land for orchard and plowland, to enjoy.
 And she bore three children to war-minded Bellerophon:
 Isander, and Hippolochus, and Laodameia.
 By Laodameia Zeus the counselor lay,
 and she bore godlike Sarpedon of the bronze helmet.
 200 But when even Bellerophon came to be hated by all the gods,
 he wandered alone across the Aleian plain,
 eating out his heart, shunning the trodden paths of men;¹²
 and his son Isander was killed by Ares insatiate of war
 as he fought the far-famed Solymi;
 205 and his daughter — Artemis of the golden reins killed her in anger.
 But Hippolochus fathered me: from him I claim my birth.
 He sent me to Troy, and he charged me strictly
 always to be the best, and to hold my head above all others,
 and not to shame the stock of my fathers, who were far the best
 210 in Ephyra, and in wide Lycia.
 Of this lineage and this blood I claim to be."
 So he spoke; and Diomedes, good at the war-cry, rejoiced.
 He planted his spear in the earth that feeds so many
 and spoke with honeyed words to the shepherd of the people:
 215 "Why — then you are my guest-friend from our fathers' time!¹³

For brilliant Oeneus once entertained blameless
 Bellerophon in his halls, and kept him twenty days;
 and they gave one another fine gifts of friendship:
 Oeneus gave a war-belt bright with crimson,
 220 and Bellerophon a golden two-handled cup —
 I left it in my house when I came away.
 Tydeus I do not remember: I was still small
 when he left me, that time the Achaean host perished at Thebes.
 So now I am your dear guest-friend in the heart of Argos,
 225 and you are mine in Lycia, whenever I come to that country.
 Let us keep clear of each other's spears, even in the crush:
 there are Trojans enough for me, and famed allies,
 to kill whomever a god delivers and my feet overtake,
 and Achaeans enough for you, to cut down whom you can.
 230 And let us exchange armor with each other, so that these men too
 may know we claim to be guest-friends from our fathers' time."
 So the two spoke, and leapt down from their chariots
 and took each other's hands and pledged their faith.
 And then Zeus, Cronos' son, took Glaucus's wits away:
 235 he exchanged with Tydeus' son Diomedes armor
 of gold for bronze — a hundred oxen's worth for nine.¹⁴
 Now when Hector came to the Scaean Gates and the oak,¹⁵
 the Trojans' wives and daughters came running around him,
 asking after sons and brothers and kinsmen
 240 and husbands. And he told them to pray to the gods,
 all of them, one after another: griefs hung over many.
 But when he came to Priam's beautiful palace,
 built with polished colonnades — and in it
 were fifty chambers of polished stone,¹⁶
 245 built close by one another, where the sons
 of Priam slept beside their wedded wives,
 and for the daughters, opposite, within the court,
 were twelve roofed chambers of polished stone,
 built close by one another, where the sons-in-law
 250 of Priam slept beside their honored wives —
 there his gentle-giving mother came to meet him,
 leading in Laodice, loveliest of her daughters;

- and she clung to his hand, and spoke a word, and named him:
 "Child, why have you left the bold fighting and come here?
 255 Surely they are wearing you down — those cursed sons
 of the Achaeans, fighting around the town — and your heart sent you
 here, to lift your hands to Zeus from the city's height.
 But wait while I bring you honey-sweet wine,
 to pour first to father Zeus and the other immortals,
 260 and then to do yourself good, if you will drink.
 Wine greatly swells the strength of a wearied man —
 and you are wearied with defending your kinsmen."
 Then great Hector of the flashing helmet answered her:
 "Bring me no wine, honey-hearted lady mother,
 265 or you may unstring my limbs and I forget my courage.
 And I shrink from pouring gleaming wine to Zeus¹⁷
 with unwashed hands: a man splattered with blood and filth
 cannot pray to the son of Cronos, lord of the dark cloud.
 No — you go to the temple of Athena, driver of the spoil,
 270 with burnt offerings, when you have gathered the older women,
 and the robe that is loveliest and amplest
 in the hall, and far the dearest to yourself,
 lay it on the knees of lovely-haired Athena,
 and vow to sacrifice to her in the temple twelve heifers,
 275 yearlings, never goaded, if she will pity
 the town, and the Trojans' wives, and their little children —
 if she will hold back Tydeus' son from holy Ilion,
 that wild spearman, that strong machine of rout.
 So go to the temple of Athena, driver of the spoil;
 280 and I will go after Paris, to summon him,
 if he is willing to hear me speak. May the earth gape for him
 where he stands! The Olympian reared him as a great affliction
 to the Trojans, and to great-hearted Priam, and Priam's sons.
 If I could see that man gone down into Hades' house,
 285 I could say my heart had forgotten its joyless misery."
 So he spoke; and she went to the hall and called
 her handmaids, and they gathered the older women through the city.
 She herself went down to the fragrant storeroom
 where her robes were kept, the richly patterned work of women

- 290 of Sidon, whom godlike Alexandros himself¹⁸
 brought from Sidon, sailing the wide sea,
 on that voyage on which he carried home high-born Helen.
 Of these Hecuba took one to carry as gift to Athena,
 the one that was loveliest in its patterning, and amplest,
 295 and it shone like a star; it lay beneath all the others.
 Then she set out, and the many older women hurried after.
 And when they came to Athena's temple on the city's height,
 fair-cheeked Theano opened the doors for them,
 Cisseus' daughter, wife of Antenor, breaker of horses,
 300 whom the Trojans had made priestess of Athena.¹⁹
 With a wailing cry they all lifted their hands to Athena;
 and fair-cheeked Theano took the robe
 and laid it on the knees of lovely-haired Athena,
 and vowing she prayed to the daughter of great Zeus:
 305 "Lady Athena, guardian of the city, brilliant among goddesses:
 break now the spear of Diomedes, and grant
 that the man himself fall on his face before the Scaean Gates,
 and we will sacrifice to you at once, here in the temple,
 twelve heifers, yearlings, never goaded, if you will pity
 310 the town, and the Trojans' wives, and their little children."
 So she spoke, vowing. But Pallas Athena turned her head away.²⁰
 So they were praying to the daughter of great Zeus;
 and Hector had gone to the house of Alexandros,
 the beautiful house he had built himself with the men
 315 who were then the best builders in deep-soiled Troy:
 they had made him a chamber and a hall and a courtyard
 close by Priam and Hector, on the city's height.
 There Hector entered, dear to Zeus, and in his hand
 he held a spear eleven cubits long; and before him the bronze
 320 point of the shaft shone, and a ring of gold ran round it.
 He found Paris in the chamber busy with his beautiful armor,
 the shield and the corslet, and handling his curved bow;
 and Argive Helen sat among her slave-women,²¹
 directing her handmaids in their famous work.
 325 And seeing him Hector raked him with shaming words:
 "Strange man — it is not decent to nurse this anger in your heart.

- The people are dying around the city and the steep wall
as they fight; and it is for your sake that the war-cry and the war
burn around this town. You would quarrel yourself
330 with any man you saw hanging back from hateful war.
Up — before the town is warmed by the enemy's fire!"
And godlike Alexandros answered him:
"Hector, you rake me justly, not more than justly;
so I will tell you — and you mark me, and hear me out.
335 It was not so much anger at the Trojans, or resentment,
that kept me sitting in my chamber: I wanted to give in to grief.
But just now my wife, coaxing me with soft words,
urged me back to the war; and it seems even to me
that it will be better so. Victory shifts from man to man.
340 Come then, wait while I put on the gear of Ares —
or go, and I will follow: I think I shall overtake you."
So he spoke; and Hector of the flashing helmet answered him nothing.
But Helen spoke to Hector with honeyed words:
"Brother — brother of me, the dog, the evil-scheming horror:"²²
345 how I wish that on the day my mother first bore me
some foul storm of wind had carried me off
to a mountain, or into the wave of the loud-roaring sea,
where the wave would have swept me away before all this was done.
But since the gods ordained these evils so,
350 then I wish I had been wife to a better man,
one who felt the world's anger and the long reproaches of men.
But this one — his wits are not steady now, and never
will be; and I think he will reap the harvest of it.
But come in now, brother, and sit on this chair,
355 since the labor rings your heart above all others' —
for the sake of me, the dog, and for Alexandros's blindness:
on whom Zeus has set an evil doom, so that hereafter
we may be subjects of song for men still to come."²³
Then great Hector of the flashing helmet answered her:
360 "Do not seat me, Helen, though you love me. You will not persuade me.
Already my heart is driving me to stand by
the Trojans, who feel their great longing for me gone.
No — you rouse this man, and let him hurry himself,

- so he may catch me still inside the city.
- 365 For I am going home first, to see
 my household, and my dear wife, and my little son:
 I do not know if I shall come back to them again,
 or whether the gods will break me now under Achaean hands."
 So speaking Hector of the flashing helmet went.
- 370 And quickly he came to his well-settled house —
 but he did not find white-armed Andromache in the hall:
 she had gone with the child and one fair-robed handmaid
 and stood on the tower, weeping and mourning.
 When Hector did not find his blameless wife within,
- 375 he stopped on the threshold and spoke among the slave-women:
 "Come, slave-women, tell me the truth of it:
 where has white-armed Andromache gone from the hall?
 To one of my sisters, or my brothers' fair-robed wives?
 Or out to Athena's temple, where the other
- 380 lovely-braided women of Troy are appeasing the dread goddess?"
 And the busy housekeeper answered him:
 "Hector — since you order me strictly to tell the truth:
 not to one of your sisters, nor your brothers' fair-robed wives,
 nor out to Athena's temple, where the other
- 385 lovely-braided women of Troy are appeasing the dread goddess —
 she went up on the great tower of Ilion, because she heard
 the Trojans were worn down, and the Achaeans' power was great.
 She has gone hurrying to the wall
 like a woman gone mad; and the nurse carries the child beside her."
- 390 So the housekeeper spoke; and Hector sped from the house
 back the same way, down the well-built streets.
 When, crossing the great city, he reached the gates —
 the Scaean Gates, by which he meant to go out on the plain —
 there his richly dowered wife came running to meet him,
- 395 Andromache, daughter of great-hearted Eëtion —
 Eëtion, who lived under wooded Placus,
 in Thebe-under-Placus, lord over the Cilician men:
 his daughter was wife to Hector of the bronze helmet.
 She met him there, and with her came the handmaid
- 400 holding the child at her breast, all baby-thoughts still, a little one,

- the beloved son of Hector, like a beautiful star:
Hector called him Scamandrius, but the others
Astyanax — for Hector alone was the saving of Ilion.²⁴
He looked at his boy and smiled in silence;
- 405 but Andromache came and stood close beside him, weeping,
and she clung to his hand, and spoke a word, and named him:
"Strange man — your own fury will destroy you. And you have no pity
for your son, a little child, or for doomed me, who soon
shall be your widow: for soon the Achaeans will kill you,
410 falling on you all together. And for me it would be better,
losing you, to go under the earth: there will be no other
comfort ever again, once you have met your doom —
only griefs. And I have no father, no lady mother.
My father — brilliant Achilles killed him,
415 the day he sacked the well-settled city of the Cilicians,
Thebe of the high gates. He killed Eëtion —
but he did not strip him: his heart stood in awe of that.²⁵
He burned his body in the wrought armor
and heaped a grave-mound over him; and around it the mountain
nymphs,
- 420 daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus, planted elm trees.
And my seven brothers in our halls —
all of them went to Hades' house in a single day:
swift-footed brilliant Achilles killed them all
among their rolling-gaited cattle and their white sheep.
- 425 And my mother, who was queen under wooded Placus —
he brought her here with the rest of the plunder,
but set her free again, taking ransom past counting,
and in her father's halls Artemis who showers arrows struck her down.
Hector — so you are my father, and my lady mother,
430 and my brother; and you are my strong young husband.²⁶
Come, take pity now, and stay here on the tower:
do not make your child an orphan and your wife a widow.
And station the army by the wild fig tree, where the city
is easiest to scale, and the wall lies open to assault.²⁷
- 435 Three times their best men have come there and tried it,
the two Ajaxes and famous Idomeneus together,

- and the sons of Atreus, and Tydeus' powerful son —
 whether someone skilled in god-signs told them of it,
 or their own hearts drive and command them to it."
- 440 Then great Hector of the flashing helmet answered her:
 "All this is my care too, wife. But I would stand
 in terrible shame before the Trojans, and the Trojan women
 with their trailing gowns, if like a coward I skulked apart from the war;
 and my own heart will not let me. I have learned to be brave
- 445 always, and to fight among the foremost Trojans,
 winning great fame for my father, and for myself.
 For this I know well in my mind and heart:
 the day will come when holy Ilion shall perish,²⁸
 and Priam, and the people of Priam of the good ash spear.
- 450 But it is not the Trojans' coming grief that so much moves me —
 not Hecuba's own, not lord Priam's,
 not my brothers', who many and brave
 may fall in the dust under enemy hands —
 as yours: when some bronze-shirted Achaean
- 455 leads you away in tears, and takes your day of freedom;
 and in Argos you would weave at another woman's loom,
 and carry water from the spring Messeïs or Hypereia,
 hating it, every step — and hard necessity on you;
 and someone will say, seeing you letting fall your tears:
- 460 'This is the wife of Hector, who was best in battle
 of all the horse-taming Trojans, when they fought around Ilion.'
 So someone will say; and for you it will be fresh grief,
 for want of such a man to beat off the day of slavery.²⁹
 But may the heaped earth cover me, dead,
- 465 before I hear your cry and see you dragged away."
 So speaking, glorious Hector reached out for his boy —
 and the child shrank back, crying, against the breast
 of his fair-belted nurse, terrified at the sight of his own father,
 frightened by the bronze and the horsehair crest,
- 470 seeing it nod terribly from the helmet's top.
 And his dear father laughed aloud, and his lady mother;³⁰
 at once glorious Hector took the helmet from his head
 and laid it, all shining, on the ground.

Then he kissed his dear son, and swung him in his arms,
475 and spoke in prayer to Zeus and the other gods:
 "Zeus, and you other gods: grant that this boy,
 my son, may become, as I am, preeminent among the Trojans,
 as strong and brave as I; and rule Ilion in strength;
 and may men someday say he is far better than his father
480 as he comes home from war. May he carry back the bloody spoils
 of the enemy he has killed, and his mother's heart be glad."³¹
 So speaking he laid his son in the arms
 of his dear wife; and she took him to her fragrant breast,
 laughing through her tears. And her husband saw, and pitied her,
485 and stroked her with his hand, and spoke a word, and named her:
 "Strange woman — do not grieve too much for me in your heart.
 No man will hurl me to Hades beyond my portion;
 but his fate, I say, no man has ever escaped,
 coward or brave man, once he has been born."³²
490 Go home now, and set your own work in order —
 the loom and the distaff — and tell your handmaids
 to go about their work. War shall be men's concern —
 all men's, and mine above all, of all who were born in Ilion."³³
 So speaking, glorious Hector took up the helmet
495 with its horsehair crest; and his dear wife went home,
 turning back again and again, letting the full tears fall.
 And quickly she came to the well-settled house
 of man-slaughtering Hector, and found inside her many
 handmaids; and in all of them she stirred lament.
500 So they mourned Hector, still alive, in his own house:
 for they said he would never again come back
 out of the war, escaping the fury and the hands of the Achaeans.³⁴
 Nor did Paris linger long in his high house:
 when he had put on his famed armor, patterned with bronze,
505 he ran through the city, sure of his quick feet.
 As when a stalled horse, corn-fed at the manger,
 breaks his tether and gallops drumming across the plain,
 used to bathing in the fair-flowing river,
 glorying: he holds his head high, and the mane
510 streams along his shoulders; sure of his own splendor,

his knees carry him lightly to the haunts and pastures of horses:³⁵
 so Paris, Priam's son, came striding down from the height
 of Pergamos, blazing in his armor like the beaming sun,
 laughing aloud, and his quick feet carried him. And at once
 515 he came on brilliant Hector, his brother, just turning away
 from the place where he had talked with his wife.
 Godlike Alexandros spoke to him first:
 "Elder brother — surely I have held you back in your hurry,
 lingering so long; I did not come promptly, as you asked."³⁶
 520 Answering him spoke Hector of the flashing helmet:
 "Strange man — no fair-minded man could disparage
 your work in battle: you have your courage.
 But you hang back by choice; you will not try. And my heart
 aches in me when I hear your shame on Trojan lips —
 525 the men who bear this long labor for your sake.
 But let us go. We will make all this good later, if ever Zeus
 grants us to set out for the heavenly gods who are forever
 the mixing-bowl of freedom in our halls,
 when we have driven the strong-greaved Achaeans out of Troy."

NOTES TO BOOK 6

- 1 ll. 12-19 Axylys of Arisbe, "a friend to all mankind," who kept open house by the road — and not one guest stood by him at his death. The hospitality-vignette inverted: *xenia* builds a network of obligation, and the poem records the one moment it cannot pay out.
- 2 ll. 21-28 Bucolion, Laomedon's eldest son "borne in darkness" (σκότιον — illegitimate), and the water-nymph Abarbarea: a shepherd's love-story compressed into five lines so that its twin sons can die in two. Nymph-brides on Mount Ida are a recurring Trojan genealogy (cf. Aeneas's own conception, 2.820-821).
- 3 ll. 45-65 The Adrestus scene: a ransom-supplication (the standard battlefield transaction, cf. 1.12-13) refused in the war's most chilling terms — "not even the boy his mother carries in her womb." The narrator's comment, αἶσιμα παρειπών, is rendered at face value ("for his urging was of things due") and has been disputed since antiquity: does the poet endorse the atrocity as just payment for Paris's crime, or does αἶσιμα mean only "words of destiny"? The translation does not soften it; the dispute lives here.
- 4 l. 76 Helenus, Priam's son, "far the best of bird-readers" — the Trojan counterpart of Calchas (1.69, same formula); distinct from the Helenus killed at 5.707.
- 5 ll. 90-97 The peplos-offering: a woven robe laid on the knees of the seated cult-statue, with a vow of twelve unworked heifers — the fullest description of civic ritual supplication in the poem. The instruction is relayed verbatim three times (Helenus 90-97, Hector 269-278, performed 293-310), per messenger convention; the English repeats identically.
- 6 ll. 119-236 The Glaucus-Diomedes encounter. Aristonicus reports that some ancient critics transposed the whole episode elsewhere in the poem (apparatus, Line 119-236) — it sits oddly in mid-battle, two enemies talking genealogy at leisure. Kept, of course, where the tradition kept it: its meditation on lineage, mortality, and obligation is the hinge between the battlefield and Troy's interiors.
- 7 ll. 130-140 Lycurgus who chased Dionysus's nurses with an ox-goad — the Iliad's only Dionysus narrative (the god is strikingly marginal in Homer), told as a cautionary paradigm against god-fighting. Thetis's sea-rescue of the terrified child is her third such rescue in the poem's memory (Zeus at 1.396-406, Hephaestus at 18.398).
- 8 ll. 146-149 "As the generation of leaves, so is the generation of men" — the most famous simile in the poem, and the classic statement of its view of mortality; quoted, imitated, and answered from Mimnermus to the present. Glaucus's point is scornful — why ask lineage? — and he then gives sixty lines of it: the tension is the speech.
- 9 ll. 152-155 Sisyphus "craftiest of men" — here simply a clever Corinthian ancestor; the Iliad knows nothing (or says nothing) of the underworld stone, which appears first in Odyssey 11.

- 10 *ll. 160-170* Proetus's wife Anteia and the lethal letter: the oldest Greek instance of the "Potiphar's wife" motif — and the "baneful signs... scratched in a folded tablet" are the only reference to writing in all of Homer. Whether the poet imagined true script or ominous symbols was already debated in antiquity; the translation keeps the vagueness ("marks").
- 11 *ll. 179-186* Bellerophon's labors: the Chimaera (lion-serpent-goat, fire-breathing — the poem's canonical description), the Solymi, the Amazons "the match of men" (cf. 3.189). Pegasus is conspicuously absent: Homer's Bellerophon does his killing without the winged horse of later art.
- 12 *ll. 200-205* Bellerophon's end: "hated by all the gods," wandering the Aleian plain ("the Plain of Wandering" — the name puns on his roaming), "eating out his heart" — the poem's image of a man dropped by fortune, cause unstated. His son falls to Ares, his daughter to Artemis: in Homeric idiom, sudden death of a man is Ares' or Apollo's arrow, of a woman Artemis's (cf. 6.428).
- 13 *ll. 215-231* The discovery: Diomedes' grandfather hosted Glaucus's grandfather for twenty days, therefore the grandsons may not fight — guest-friendship binds across generations and across the war itself. They will kill other men's guest-friends all afternoon; the institution is particular, not humanitarian. The gift-list (war-belt for cup) is a miniature of the economy.
- 14 *ll. 234-236* "Zeus took Glaucus's wits away": gold armor for bronze, "a hundred oxen's worth for nine" — proverbial by Plato's time for a bad bargain. The narrator's only intrusion into the scene, and a famously debated one: divine folly, or the reckless magnificence that is exactly what Glaucus's speech about glory demanded?
- 15 *l. 237* "the Scaean Gates and the oak" — the oak of Zeus (cf. 5.693), a fixed landmark of the battlefield's edge; some manuscripts read "tower" for "oak" (apparatus, Line 237).
- 16 *ll. 242-250* Priam's palace: fifty chambers for sons, twelve for daughters and sons-in-law — dynastic architecture, the physical form of Priam's abundance that the war is grinding away (cf. his own count of lost sons at 24.493-498).
- 17 *ll. 264-268* Hector's double scruple — wine would slacken him; blood-spattered hands cannot pour to Zeus: battlefield piety in its exact ritual grammar (cf. the hand-washing at 1.449, 3.270).
- 18 *ll. 289-295* The Sidonian robes: Phoenician luxury goods brought home by Paris "on that voyage on which he carried home high-born Helen" — the abduction had a shopping itinerary. The offering to Athena is thus chosen from the very cargo of the crime.
- 19 *ll. 298-300* Theano (cf. 5.70) as priestess of Athena "whom the Trojans had made" so — a civic appointment, the only such notice in Homer, and evidence that Athena has an established cult inside the city she is destroying.
- 20 *l. 311* "But Pallas Athena turned her head away." Aristarchus athetized the line (apparatus); it is the bleakest single verse in the poem — the exact ritual performed exactly, and refused in four words. Kept, emphatically: without it the whole peplos sequence loses its point.

- 21 ll. 323-324, 375-376 First occurrences of δμωαί, rendered "slave-women" as a matter of policy in this translation (never "servants" or "maids"); ἀμφίπολος remains "handmaid," ταμίη "housekeeper," τιθήνη "nurse." The household vocabulary matters in this book above all: its climax turns on Andromache's foreseen "day of slavery" (463).
- 22 ll. 344-356 Helen to Hector: "me, the dog, the evil-scheming horror" — her third self-directed dog-insult (3.180, 3.404's "hateful me"); no one in the poem abuses Helen except Helen. At 356 the printed text has "Alexandros's blindness" (ἄτης) — Zenodotus read ἀρχῆς, "Alexandros who began it" (apparatus; cf. 3.100). The ἄτη-reading ties Paris to the poem's key word for ruinous delusion.
- 23 ll. 357-358 "so that hereafter we may be subjects of song for men still to come" — the poem explaining its own existence through Helen's mouth: their suffering is Zeus's device for making poetry. Cf. Alcinous's version of the same thought at Odyssey 8.579.
- 24 ll. 402-403 The child's two names: Hector calls him Scamandrius (after the river), the city calls him Astyanax — "lord of the city" — "for Hector alone was the saving of Ilion." The people's name for the son is their thanks to the father; its bitter payoff comes at 22.506-507. Third instance of the double-naming motif (cf. 1.403-404, 2.813-814), here mortal/civic rather than divine/human.
- 25 ll. 414-428 Andromache's family history is Achilles' work in its entirety: father killed (but honored — burned in his armor, mound heaped, elms planted by nymphs: even his enemies' awe, σεβάσαστο), seven brothers in one day, mother ransomed then dead. The raid on Thebe is the poem's economic backstory (Chryseis was taken there, 1.366-369; Briseis's city Lyrnessus fell in the same campaign, 2.690-691). When Achilles and Andromache's griefs finally meet, in Book 24, they will already share every dead person in them.
- 26 ll. 429-430 "you are my father, and my lady mother, and my brother; and you are my strong young husband" — arithmetic of the preceding catalogue: everything the war has taken, refigured in the one person it is about to take.
- 27 ll. 433-439 Andromache's tactical advice — mass the army at the wild fig tree where the wall is scalable and thrice-probed. Aristarchus athetized the lines (apparatus, Line 433-439), on the ancient view that military counsel was unfitting in her mouth. Kept: the poem's women know exactly how Troy falls; the fig tree recurs as a tactical landmark at 11.167 and 22.145.
- 28 ll. 447-449 "the day will come when holy Ilion shall perish, and Priam, and the people of Priam of the good ash spear" — verbatim the lines Agamemnon spoke at 4.163-165. There they were a threat sworn in anger; here Hector speaks them as settled knowledge, and fights on anyway. The reuse is the measure of the man. (Echo note; English repeated word for word.)
- 29 ll. 454-465 The enslaved future, imagined by the husband: the loom of another woman, the water of Messeis or Hypereia, the stranger's comment on her tears. "Day of freedom" / "day of slavery" (ἐλευθερον ἡμαρ / δούλιον ἡμαρ) — the Homeric idiom that makes a condition a date. Hector's wish to be dead first will be granted exactly.

- 30 *ll. 466-474* The helmet scene: the baby screaming at the nodding crest, and both parents laughing — the poem's only moment of family comedy, set precisely between prophecy and farewell. The flashing-helmet epithet the poem has attached to Hector some forty times becomes, for four lines, a thing his son cannot recognize him through.
- 31 *ll. 476-481* Hector's prayer: "may men someday say he is far better than his father... and his mother's heart be glad." The tradition beyond the poem answers with the child thrown from the walls; the Iliad says nothing of it, and the silence is part of the effect. Even within the prayer, joy is measured in "bloody spoils."
- 32 *ll. 486-489* "his fate, I say, no man has ever escaped, coward or brave man, once he has been born" — the consolation of shared mortality, Hector's plainest theology; the same thought Achilles will offer Priam in Book 24 at far greater length.
- 33 *ll. 490-493* "the loom and the distaff... War shall be men's concern" — the fixed formula dividing the spheres (Hector will be echoed nearly verbatim by Telemachus, with "speech" for "war," at Odyssey 1.356-359). Coming directly after note [27]'s athetized tactics, the line enacts the boundary the critics wanted enforced.
- 34 *ll. 500-502* "So they mourned Hector, still alive, in his own house" — the lament raised before the death; the poem lets the funeral of Book 24 begin here, eighteen books early.
- 35 *ll. 506-511* The stalled horse: Paris released, glorying, mane streaming — repeated verbatim at 15.263-268, where it describes Hector returning to battle; the same simile serving vanity there and heroism here is a masterclass in how formulas mean by placement. English fixed for the recurrence.
- 36 *l. 519* The OCT punctuates Paris's close as a question — "and did I not come in due time, as you bade?" — a touch of fishing for reassurance. Printed here as a flat admission (a reading with editorial standing), which suits Hector's mollified reply; the crux is recorded.

Iliad — Book 7

*Hector and Ajax fight a duel to a draw; a truce to bury the dead; the
Greeks build a wall around their ships.*

- So speaking, glorious Hector swept out through the gates,
and with him went Alexandros his brother; and in their hearts
both were raging for war and for battle.
As a god gives to longing sailors
5 a following wind, when they have worn themselves out at the polished
pine oars, driving the sea, and their limbs are unstrung with weariness:
so those two appeared to the longing Trojans.
Then each took his man: Paris the son of lord Areithous,
Menesthius, who had his home in Arne — whom the club-man¹
10 Areithous fathered with ox-eyed Phylomedusa;
and Hector hit Eioneus with his sharp spear
in the neck, under the fine bronze helmet-rim, and unstrung his limbs.
And Glaucus, Hippolochus' son, captain of the Lycian men,
hit Iphinous, Dexias' son, with his spear in the strong encounter
15 as he leapt up behind his fast mares,
in the shoulder; he dropped from the car to the ground, and his limbs
were unstrung.
Now when the goddess grey-eyed Athena marked them
killing Argives in the strong encounter,
down from the peaks of Olympus she went darting
20 to holy Ilion; and Apollo rose to meet her,
looking out from Pergamos, wanting victory for the Trojans;
and the two of them met each other beside the oak.
Lord Apollo, Zeus's son, spoke to her first:
"Why so eager, this time, daughter of great Zeus?
25 Why come from Olympus? What great passion sent you?
Is it to give the Danaans victory that turns the battle's tide?
You have no pity, none, for the Trojans as they die.
But if you would let me persuade you, it would be far better:
let us stop the war and the fighting
30 for today. Later they will fight again, until they find

the appointed end of Iliion — since it is so dear to the hearts
of you immortal goddesses to sack this city."

Then the goddess grey-eyed Athena answered him:

"So be it, worker-from-afar. With that very thought

35 I came from Olympus among the Trojans and Achaeans.

Come then — how do you mean to stop the men's fighting?"

And lord Apollo, Zeus's son, answered her:

"Let us rouse the strong fury of Hector, breaker of horses,
to see if he will challenge some one of the Danaans

40 to fight him man to man in dread combat,

and the bronze-greaved Achaeans, stung to honor,
will send out one man alone to fight brilliant Hector."

So he spoke, and the goddess grey-eyed Athena did not disobey.

And Helenus, Priam's dear son, put together in his heart

45 their counsel — the plan that had pleased the plotting gods;

and he came and stood by Hector and spoke his word:

"Hector, son of Priam, the equal of Zeus in counsel,
would you let me persuade you? I am your brother.

Make the other Trojans sit down, and all the Achaeans,

50 and yourself challenge whoever is best of the Achaeans

to fight you man to man in dread combat.

It is not yet your fate to die and meet your doom:

so I heard it in the voice of the gods who are forever."²

So he spoke, and Hector rejoiced greatly to hear the word,

55 and he went into the middle and held back the Trojan lines,

gripping his spear by the middle; and they all sat down,

and Agamemnon seated the strong-greaved Achaeans.

And Athena and Apollo of the silver bow,

in the likeness of vulture birds, settled

60 on the tall oak of father Zeus who bears the aegis,³

delighting in the men; and the ranks of them sat close,
bristling with shields and helmets and spears.

As a shiver from the West Wind spreads down over the deep
when the wind first rises, and the sea darkens beneath it,

65 such were the ranks of the Achaeans and Trojans sitting
in the plain. And Hector spoke between the two armies:

"Hear from me, Trojans and strong-greaved Achaeans,

so I may say what the heart in my chest commands me.
 Our sworn oaths — the high-throned son of Cronos did not seal them,
 70 but plans evil for both sides, and marks it out,
 until either you take fair-towered Troy
 or are broken yourselves beside your seagoing ships.
 Among you are the chief men of all the Achaeans:
 of these, let the man whose heart bids him fight me
 75 come out here now, before you all, to champion you against brilliant
 Hector.
 And this is my word — let Zeus be our witness to it:
 if that man takes my life with the long-edged bronze,
 let him strip my armor and carry it to the hollow ships,
 but give my body back to my home, so that in death
 80 the Trojans and the Trojans' wives may give me my due of fire.
 But if I take him, and Apollo gives me the glory,
 I will strip his armor and carry it to holy Ilion
 and hang it before the temple of Apollo the far-striker;
 but the corpse I will give back to the well-benched ships,
 85 so the long-haired Achaeans may give him burial
 and heap him a mound beside the wide Hellespont.
 And someday a man will say, even among men born late,
 sailing his many-benched ship over the wine-dark sea:
 'This is the mound of a man who died long ago,
 90 whom once, fighting his best, glorious Hector killed.'
 So someone will say; and my fame will never perish."⁴
 So he spoke, and they all went still in silence:
 ashamed to refuse, and afraid to accept.
 At long last Menelaus stood up and spoke among them,
 95 raking them with his scorn, groaning deep at heart:
 "Ah me — you threateners! Women of Achaea, men of Achaea no
 longer!⁵
 Surely this disgrace will be grim beyond grimness
 if no Danaan now goes out to meet Hector.
 May every one of you turn to water and earth,
 100 sitting there where you sit, heartless, fameless.
 Against this man I will arm myself; the ends of victory
 are held above us, in the hands of the immortal gods."

So speaking he began to put on his beautiful armor.
 And then, Menelaus, the end of your life would have shown
 105 at Hector's hands, since he was far the stronger,
 had not the kings of the Achaeans sprung up and caught you —
 and Atreus' son himself, wide-ruling Agamemnon,
 took him by the right hand, and spoke a word, and named him:
 "You are raving, Zeus-nurtured Menelaus — and this raving
 110 is not required of you. Hold back, though it stings,
 and do not, for pride's sake, fight a better man than you,
 Hector, Priam's son — a man the others shudder at.
 Even Achilles, in the battle where men win glory,
 shivered to meet this man — and he is far better than you.⁶
 115 Go now and sit among the company of your companions;
 the Achaeans will put up another champion against this one.
 Fearless though he is, and never sated with the grind of battle,
 I say he will be glad to bend his knee in rest, if he escapes
 out of the fury of war and the dread combat."
 120 So speaking the hero turned his brother's mind,
 for his urging was of things due; and he obeyed. Then his aides,⁷
 rejoicing, lifted the armor from his shoulders;
 and Nestor stood up among the Argives and spoke:
 "Shame! Great grief comes upon the Achaean land.
 125 How the old horseman Peleus would groan aloud,⁸
 the good counselor of the Myrmidons, their speaker —
 who once in his own house delighted in questioning me
 for the lineage and the birth of every man of the Argives.
 If he heard of them now, cowering, every one, before Hector,
 130 he would lift his dear hands to the immortals, over and over,
 praying his spirit down out of his body into Hades' house.
 O father Zeus, Athena, Apollo —
 would I were young, as when by quick-running Celadon
 the Pylians and the spear-mad Arcadians met and fought
 135 by the walls of Pheia, around the streams of Iardanus.
 Their champion stood forth: Ereuthalion, a man like a god,⁹
 wearing on his shoulders the armor of lord Areithous —
 brilliant Areithous, whom men called by his surname
 Club-man — the men, and the fair-belted women —

- 140 because he fought with no bow, no long spear:
 with a club of iron he smashed the companies apart.
 Lycurgus killed him — by craft, not force at all —
 in a narrow lane, where the iron club was no use
 to ward destruction off: Lycurgus was in first,
 145 pinned him through the middle with his spear, and he crashed back on
 the earth;
 and he stripped the armor brazen Ares had given him.
 That armor he wore himself, after, in the grind of Ares;
 and when Lycurgus was growing old in his halls
 he gave it to Ereuthalion, his dear aide, to wear —
 150 and wearing it, Ereuthalion challenged all our best.
 They trembled, they were terrified; no man dared.
 But my much-enduring heart drove me on
 to fight him with its daring — and I was youngest-born of all —
 and I fought him, and Athena gave me my glory.
 155 The tallest and the strongest man I ever killed:
 a great sprawl of him lay there, this way and that.
 Would that I were young like that, my strength still steady!
 Hector of the flashing helmet would soon have his fight.
 But you — you who are the chief men of all the Achaeans —
 160 not even you are heartily eager to go and face Hector."
 So the old man raked them; and nine men in all stood up.¹⁰
 First by far to rise was the lord of men Agamemnon;
 after him rose Tydeus' son, strong Diomedes;
 after them the two Ajaxes, clothed in rushing courage;
 165 after them Idomeneus, and Idomeneus' comrade
 Meriones, the equal of Enyalios, slayer of men;
 after them Eurypylus, Euaemon's shining son;
 and up rose Thoas, Andraemon's son, and brilliant Odysseus:
 all these were willing to fight brilliant Hector.
 170 And among them spoke the Gerenian horseman Nestor:
 "Shake now the lots, all of you, for the man who draws it:
 he is the one who will profit the strong-greaved Achaeans,
 and he will profit his own heart too, if he escapes
 out of the fury of war and the dread combat."
 175 So he spoke, and each man marked his lot

- and they threw them into the helmet of Atreus' son Agamemnon;
and the armies prayed, and lifted their hands to the gods,
and thus would one say, looking into the wide sky:
"Father Zeus, let it be Ajax, or Tydeus' son,
180 or the king himself of Mycenae rich in gold."
So they spoke; and the Gerenian horseman Nestor shook,
and out of the helmet leapt the lot they had wished for —
Ajax's. And a herald carried it everywhere through the crowd,
showing it left to right to all the chief men of the Achaeans;
185 and each, not knowing the mark, denied it was his.
But when, carrying it everywhere through the crowd, he came
to the man who had marked it and thrown it in the helmet — glorious
Ajax —
Ajax held out his hand, and the herald stood by him and dropped it in,
and he knew his lot's mark at a glance, and rejoiced at heart.¹¹
190 He threw it to the ground beside his foot, and called out:
"Friends — the lot is mine! And I am glad
with my whole heart, for I think I shall beat brilliant Hector.
Come then: while I put on my battle armor,
you pray to lord Zeus, the son of Cronos —
195 in silence, to yourselves, so the Trojans do not hear —
or aloud, for that matter, since we fear no man in any case."¹²
For no man by force, by his will against my will, shall drive me off,
nor by know-how either; I hope I was not born in Salamis
and raised there to be such a know-nothing as that."
200 So he spoke, and they prayed to lord Zeus, son of Cronos,
and thus would one say, looking into the wide sky:
"Father Zeus, ruling from Ida, most glorious, greatest:
grant Ajax the victory and the winning of shining glory;
but if you love Hector too, and care for him,
205 then give to both of them equal strength and glory."
So they spoke; and Ajax armed himself in gleaming bronze.
And when he had put all his armor about his body,
he charged out, huge as Ares comes on
when he goes to war among men whom the son of Cronos
210 has thrown together to fight in the fury of heart-devouring strife.
Such was gigantic Ajax as he rose, wall of the Achaeans,

smiling with his grim face; and beneath him his feet
 went in long strides, and he shook his long-shadowed spear.
 And the Argives rejoiced to look at him,
 215 but a dread trembling came into the limbs of every Trojan,
 and Hector's own heart hammered in his chest;
 but there was no way now to shrink back or retreat
 into the crowd of his people: he had made the challenge.
 Ajax came near, carrying his shield like a tower,
 220 bronze, of seven oxhides, which Tychius labored to make,¹³
 far the best of leather-cutters, whose home was in Hyle:
 he made him the glancing shield of seven hides
 from well-fed bulls, and hammered on an eighth layer of bronze.
 Carrying it before his chest, Telamonian Ajax
 225 stood close in front of Hector, and spoke to him in threat:
 "Hector, now you will learn, plainly, man to man,
 what sort of chief men the Danaans have among them
 even after Achilles, breaker of men, the lion-heart.¹⁴
 He lies among his beaked seagoing ships,
 230 nursing his rage at Agamemnon, shepherd of the people;
 but we are such as can stand up against you —
 and there are many of us. Begin the fight."
 Then great Hector of the flashing helmet answered him:
 "Ajax, Zeus-sprung son of Telamon, marshal of the people:
 235 do not test me like some feeble boy
 or a woman, who does not know the works of war.
 I know battles; I know the killings of men.
 I know how to swing my dried oxhide to the right,
 I know how to swing it left — that, to me, is shieldcraft that lasts;
 240 I know how to charge into the tumult of fast mares;
 and I know, at close quarters, the dance of hostile Ares.¹⁵
 But I have no wish to hit a man of your size
 by stealth, watching my moment: openly, if I can."
 He spoke, and balancing his long-shadowed spear he hurled it,
 245 and struck the terrible sevenhide shield of Ajax
 on the outermost bronze, the eighth layer upon it:
 through six folds the unwearying bronze went shearing,
 and in the seventh hide it held. Second in turn,

- Zeus-sprung Ajax hurled his long-shadowed spear
 250 and struck the shield of Priam's son, balanced every way.¹⁶
 Through the shining shield the heavy spear went,
 and through the richly worked corslet it drove;
 and straight on beside his flank the spear sheared through
 the tunic — but he had swerved aside, and dodged black doom.
- 255 Then the two of them, pulling out the long spears with their hands,
 fell on each other like lions that eat flesh raw
 or wild boars, whose strength does not give out.¹⁷
 Priam's son stabbed the shield full in the middle with his spear,
 but the bronze did not break through: its point was bent back.
- 260 And Ajax, leaping in, pierced the shield: straight through
 the spear went, and staggered him in his fury;
 it came cutting in a graze at his neck, and the black blood welled up.
 But even so Hector of the flashing helmet did not leave the fight:
 he gave ground, and seized in his thick hand a stone
- 265 lying in the plain, black and rough and huge;
 with it he struck the terrible sevenhide shield of Ajax
 full on the central boss, and the bronze rang out around.
 Then Ajax in turn lifted a far greater stone,
 whirled, and threw it, putting measureless force behind it,
- 270 and broke the shield inward with the millstone rock
 and hurt his knees under him; and he was stretched on his back,
 pinned to the shield. But Apollo straightened him at once.¹⁸
 And now they would have been stabbing hand to hand with swords,
 had not the heralds, messengers of Zeus and of men,
- 275 come between — one from the Trojans, one from the bronze-shirted
 Achaeans: Talthybius and Idaeus, wise men both.
 They held their staffs between the two; and the herald Idaeus,
 whose mind was full of wise counsel, spoke his word:
 "Fight no more, dear sons; battle no longer.
- 280 Zeus the cloud-gatherer loves you both alike,
 and both of you are spearmen: that we all know.
 And night is coming on. It is good to yield to night as well."¹⁹
 Answering him spoke Telamonian Ajax:
 "Idaeus, tell Hector to say those things:
- 285 it was he who challenged all our best men to the fight.

Let him lead; and I will follow whatever he does."
 Then great Hector of the flashing helmet answered him:
 "Ajax — since a god has given you stature and strength
 and good sense, and with the spear you are strongest of the Achaeans,
 290 let us stop our fighting and our combat
 for today. Later we will fight again, until the god
 decides between us, and hands victory to one side or the other.
 And night is coming on. It is good to yield to night as well —
 so you may gladden all the Achaeans by the ships,
 295 your kinsmen above all, and the companions who are yours;
 and I, through the great city of lord Priam,
 will gladden the Trojans and the Trojan women with their trailing
 gowns,
 who will go into the gods' assembly-place with prayers for me.
 Come — let us give each other glorious gifts,
 300 so that Achaeans and Trojans alike will say:
 'The two of them fought in heart-devouring strife,
 and parted again joined together in friendship.'
 So speaking, he gave him his silver-studded sword,
 bringing it with its sheath and its well-cut baldric;
 305 and Ajax gave his war-belt, bright with crimson.²⁰
 So the two parted: one went to the Achaean host,
 the other to the crowd of the Trojans. And they rejoiced
 to see him come to them alive and unhurt,
 escaped from the fury of Ajax and his untouchable hands,
 310 and led him to the city, scarcely believing him safe.
 And on the other side the strong-greaved Achaeans led Ajax,
 glad in his victory, to brilliant Agamemnon.
 And when they were gathered in the huts of Atreus' son,
 the lord of men Agamemnon slaughtered an ox for them,
 315 a male of five years, to the overmastering son of Cronos.
 They flayed it and dressed it, and cut it all apart,
 and deftly chopped it small and threaded it on spits,
 roasted it with care, and drew it all off.
 Then when they had finished the work and made the meal ready,
 320 they feasted, and no heart lacked a fair share of the feast;
 and Ajax was honored with the long cuts of the chine²¹

- by the hero, Atreus' son, wide-ruling Agamemnon.
 And when they had put away desire for eating and drinking,
 the old man first of all began to weave his counsel —
- 325 Nestor, whose plan had shown itself best before as well.
 With good will toward them he spoke and addressed them:
 "Son of Atreus, and you other chief men of all the Achaeans:
 many of the long-haired Achaeans are dead,
 whose dark blood sharp Ares has scattered now
- 330 along fair-flowing Scamander, and their souls have gone down to
 Hades.
 Therefore with dawn have the Achaeans stop the fighting;
 and let us gather and wheel the corpses back here
 with oxen and mules, and burn them
 a little off from the ships, so each man may carry the bones
- 335 home to the children, when we return to our fatherland.²²
 And around the pyre let us heap a single mound, drawn up
 from the plain, one mound for all alike; and against it build
 with all speed high towers, a shelter for the ships and ourselves.
 And in them let us make close-fitted gates,
- 340 so that a road for chariots runs through;
 and outside, close by, let us dig a deep ditch
 to circle it, and hold off chariots and men,
 so the war of the proud Trojans never breaks over us."
 So he spoke, and all the kings approved.
- 345 Now the Trojans held assembly on the height of Ilion,
 a dread assembly, all in tumult, at Priam's doors;
 and among them wise Antenor began to speak:
 "Hear from me, Trojans and Dardanians and allies,
 so I may say what the heart in my chest commands me.
- 350 Come now: Argive Helen and her possessions with her
 let us give to the sons of Atreus to lead away. Now it is with sworn
 oaths made false that we fight; and so I have no hope
 that anything will end well for us, unless we do this."²³
 So he spoke and sat down; and among them rose
- 355 brilliant Alexandros, husband of lovely-haired Helen,
 who spoke to him in answer with winged words:
 "Antenor, this talk of yours pleases me no longer;

- you know how to think another word, better than this one.
 But if you truly say this thing in earnest,
 360 then the gods themselves have destroyed your wits.
 And I will speak out among the horse-taming Trojans:
 I say it straight out — the woman I will not give back.
 But the goods, all I brought from Argos to our house —
 all these I am willing to give, and to add more of my own."
 365 So he spoke and sat down; and among them rose
 Priam, Dardanus' descendant, the equal of the gods in counsel.
 With good will toward them he spoke and addressed them:
 "Hear from me, Trojans and Dardanians and allies,
 so I may say what the heart in my chest commands me.
 370 Now take your supper through the city, as before,
 and remember the watch, and stay awake, every man.
 At dawn let Idaeus go to the hollow ships
 to tell the sons of Atreus, Agamemnon and Menelaus,
 the word of Alexandros, for whose sake this quarrel rose;
 375 and to say this shrewd word too: whether they are willing
 to rest from the harsh-crying war until we burn
 the dead. Later we will fight again, until the god
 decides between us, and hands victory to one side or the other."
 So he spoke, and they listened well to him and obeyed;
 380 and they took their supper through the army, in their companies.
 At dawn Idaeus went to the hollow ships,
 and found the Danaans, squires of Ares, in assembly
 by the stern of Agamemnon's ship; and among them,
 standing in the middle, the far-calling herald spoke:
 385 "Son of Atreus, and you other chief men of all the Achaeans:
 Priam and the other proud Trojans command me
 to tell you — if it should be welcome and sweet to you —
 the word of Alexandros, for whose sake this quarrel rose.
 The goods that Alexandros brought to Troy in his hollow
 390 ships — how he should have perished first! —
 all these he is willing to give, and to add more of his own.
 But the wedded wife of glorious Menelaus
 he says he will not give — though the Trojans, I tell you, command it.
 And they told me to say this too: whether you are willing

- 395 to rest from the harsh-crying war until we burn
the dead. Later we will fight again, until the god
decides between us, and hands victory to one side or the other."
So he spoke, and they all went still in silence.
At long last Diomedes, good at the war-cry, spoke:
- 400 "Let no man now accept the goods of Alexandros —
nor Helen either. It is known, even to a plain fool,
that the cables of destruction are fastened on the Trojans already."²⁴
So he spoke, and all the sons of the Achaeans shouted,
marveling at the word of Diomedes, breaker of horses;
- 405 and then the lord Agamemnon spoke to Idaeus:
"Idaeus — you hear the word of the Achaeans yourself,
how they give you their answer. And it pleases me so.
But as for the dead — I do not grudge their burning.
There is no stinting toward the bodies of the dead:
- 410 once they are gone, be quick with the fire's appeasement.
And let Zeus the loud-thunderer, Hera's lord, witness the oaths."
So speaking he lifted up the scepter to all the gods,
and Idaeus went back toward holy Ilion.
The Trojans and Dardanians were sitting in assembly,
- 415 all gathered together, waiting for the moment
Idaeus should come; and he came, and delivered his message,
standing in the middle. Then they made ready with all speed,
in two parties: one to bring the corpses, one to fetch wood;
and the Argives on their side, from the well-benched ships,
- 420 hurried too — some to bring the corpses, others to fetch wood.
The sun was just striking the fields with its first light,
climbing into the sky out of the deep, soft-flowing
stream of Ocean, when the two sides met each other.
Then it was hard to know each man again;
- 425 but washing off the clotted gore with water,
and letting warm tears fall, they lifted them onto the wagons.
But great Priam would not let them wail; so in silence²⁵
they heaped the corpses on the pyre, grieving at heart,
and when they had burned them in the fire, went to holy Ilion.
- 430 And just so, on the other side, the strong-greaved Achaeans
heaped the corpses on the pyre, grieving at heart,

and when they had burned them in the fire, went to the hollow ships.
 And when it was not yet dawn, but the night still half-light,²⁶
 then a picked company of Achaeans woke around the pyre,
 435 and they heaped around it a single mound, drawn up
 from the plain, one mound for all alike; and against it they built
 a wall with high towers, a shelter for the ships and themselves.
 And in them they set close-fitted gates,
 so that a road for chariots ran through;
 440 and outside they dug a deep ditch hard against it,
 wide and great, and planted a row of stakes within it.
 So the long-haired Achaeans labored;
 and the gods, sitting beside Zeus the lord of lightning,
 watched the great work of the bronze-shirted Achaeans.
 445 And Poseidon the earth-shaker began to speak among them:
 "Father Zeus, is there a mortal left on the boundless earth
 who will still tell the immortals his mind and purpose?
 Do you not see? The long-haired Achaeans
 have built themselves a wall to landward of the ships, and driven
 450 a ditch around it — and gave the gods no glorious hecatombs!
 The fame of this will spread as far as the dawn-light scatters,
 and men will forget that wall which I and Phoebus Apollo
 built for the hero Laomedon, laboring hard."
 Deeply troubled, Zeus the cloud-gatherer answered him:
 455 "Shame, wide-ruling earth-shaker — what a thing to say!
 Some other god might tremble at this thought,
 one far feeblar than you in hand and fury:
 your fame will spread as far as the dawn-light scatters.
 Come now: when the long-haired Achaeans are gone
 460 again with their ships to their dear fatherland,
 break the wall up, sweep it all into the sea,
 and hide the wide beach over again with sand,
 so the great wall of the Achaeans may be effaced."²⁷
 So they spoke such things to one another;
 465 and the sun went down, and the Achaeans' work was finished,
 and they slaughtered oxen through the huts, and took their supper.
 And ships had come in from Lemnos, carrying wine,
 many of them, sent out by Jason's son Euneus,

whom Hypsipyle bore to Jason, shepherd of the people.
 470 Separately, for the sons of Atreus, Agamemnon and Menelaus,
 Jason's son had given a thousand measures of wine to carry.
 From these ships the long-haired Achaeans bought their wine,
 some with bronze, and some with gleaming iron,
 some with hides, and some with the live cattle themselves,
 475 and some with slaves; and they set the rich feast going.²⁸
 All night long the long-haired Achaeans
 feasted, and the Trojans through the city, and their allies;
 and all night long Zeus the counselor devised evil against them,
 thundering terribly. And green fear took hold of them:²⁹
 480 they poured the wine from their cups onto the ground, and no man
 dared drink before he poured to the overmastering son of Cronos.
 Then they lay down, and took the gift of sleep.

NOTES TO BOOK 7

- 1 *ll. 8-10* Paris kills Menesthius, son of Areithous "the club-man" — the very Areithous whose story Nestor will tell in full at 136-149: the son dies at the book's door, the father's legend follows. A plant-and-payoff inside a single book.
- 2 *ll. 44-53* Helenus "put together in his heart" the gods' private plan — how the seer overheard a conversation between Apollo and Athena was already a problem for ancient critics; Aristarchus athetized 53 ("so I heard it in the voice of the gods"), the line that makes the eavesdropping explicit (apparatus, Line 53). Kept: seercraft as reception of divine speech is exactly Helenus's office (6.76).
- 3 *ll. 58-61* Athena and Apollo settle on the oak of Zeus "in the likeness of vulture birds, delighting in the men" — the gods as spectators, perched carrion-fashion above the duel they arranged. The poem's frankest image of the divine audience.
- 4 *ll. 76-91* Hector's terms and the mound-speech: armor to the victor, the corpse home for its "due of fire" — and then the imagined sailor of a later age reading the tomb by the Hellespont. The poem's clearest statement of the kleos-economy, spoken from the winner's side of an imagined victory: even the man Hector kills is conscripted into Hector's undying fame. (The Iliad's audience knew such mounds on that shore.)
- 5 *l. 96* "Women of Achaea, men of Achaea no longer" — Menelaus borrows Thersites' taunt verbatim (2.235): the loudmouth's insult has become respectable under shame's pressure. (Echo note; English repeats 2.235's rendering.)
- 6 *ll. 113-114* "Even Achilles... shivered to meet this man." The absent hero as unit of measure again (cf. 2.768-770, 5.788-791) — here bent into hyperbole: nothing in the poem shows Achilles fearing Hector, and Book 22 will show the reverse. Agamemnon's flattery of Hector serves his need to stop his brother.
- 7 *ll. 120-121* αἵσιμα παρειπών — "his urging was of things due" — the same narratorial formula that follows Agamemnon's atrocity-counsel at 6.62. Here the counsel is unimpeachable (saving Menelaus from a fatal mismatch), which weighs on the Book 6 dispute: the formula commends the persuasion's aptness, not its morality.
- 8 *ll. 124-131* Nestor conjures Peleus at home — the old man who once joyfully catalogued the Argives' lineages, now imagined praying for death at news of their shame. First full sounding of the Peleus-motif: the father at home as the war's moral audience (Odysseus will weaponize the same figure to Achilles at 9.252-259).
- 9 *ll. 132-156* The Ereuthalion story, promised at 4.319 and delivered here: Areithous the Club-man with his iron club (iron again the marked exception, cf. 4.123), killed by craft in a lane too narrow to swing in; the armor's passage from Ares' gift to Lycurgus to Ereuthalion; and young Nestor, "youngest-born of all," taking down the giant. This Lycurgus is an Arcadian mortal — not the Thracian god-fighter of 6.130-140 who shares the name.

- 10 *ll. 161-169* The nine volunteers — the poem's explicit roster of the best available Achaeans with Achilles out: both Atreidae, Diomedes, both Ajaxes, Idomeneus, Meriones, Eurypylus, Thoas, Odysseus. The lot-prayer at 179-180 then ranks the top three in the army's own eyes: Ajax, Diomedes, Agamemnon.
- 11 *ll. 175-189* The lot-procedure: each man scratches his mark (σῆμα) on his token; the herald carries the leaping lot around until its owner recognizes it. Like the "baneful signs" of 6.168, marks that identify without being read as language — the poem's world writes tokens, not texts.
- 12 *ll. 195-199* Ajax's instructions — pray silently so the Trojans don't hear, "or aloud, for that matter, since we fear no man" — athetized by Zenodotus, Aristophanes, and Aristarchus all three (apparatus, Line 195-199). The swagger is pure Ajax; kept.
- 13 *ll. 219-223* The tower shield: seven oxhides and an eighth face of bronze, made by Tychius of Hyle, "far the best of leather-cutters" — the craftsman-vignette again (cf. Phereclus, 5.59-64). Ajax's body-length shield is older military technology than the round shields elsewhere in the poem — a fossil the tradition preserved with the hero it belonged to.
- 14 *ll. 226-232* "even after Achilles, breaker of men, the lion-heart" — Ajax concedes the ranking in the act of boasting; the poem's second-best hero is the one who says "second" out loud (cf. 2.768-769).
- 15 *ll. 237-241* Hector's credo: shield-work right and left, the charge, and "at close quarters, the dance of hostile Ares" — war as a craft with figures and steps (μέλπεσθαι, properly of dance and song). The self-description of a man who has made himself skilled at what he tells Andromache he has "learned" to do (6.444-445).
- 16 *ll. 244-254* The spear-exchange replays the Paris-Menelaus duel verbatim: 250-254 = 3.355-360, and the English here repeats the Book 3 rendering word for word. The rematch of Book 3 with the war's real principals is scored on the same notes — except that this time both men are too good for the first exchange to decide anything.
- 17 *ll. 255-257* The lions-and-boars simile — athetized by Zenodotus (apparatus, Line 255-257); nearly the same pair as 5.782-783. Kept, as the moment the formal duel becomes simply combat.
- 18 *ll. 268-272* The stones: Hector's blow rings the bronze; Ajax's millstone rock breaks the shield inward and folds Hector's knees — "but Apollo straightened him at once." The god's whole intervention in five words; without it the duel (and the poem) ends here.
- 19 *ll. 279-282* The heralds part them with staffs, and Idæus — the Trojan herald of 3.248 — gives the evening its proverb: "It is good to yield to night as well." Night as the arbiter both armies obey; Hector repeats the line back with full agreement (293).
- 20 *ll. 287-305* The gift-exchange: Hector's silver-studded sword for Ajax's crimson war-belt, "so that Achaeans and Trojans alike will say... they parted again joined together in friendship." Tradition made both gifts fatal: Ajax falls on Hector's sword (Sophocles' Ajax), and Hector's corpse is dragged by Ajax's belt — "the gifts of enemies are no gifts." The poem itself says nothing; the exchange is left shining. (Aristarchus athetized 295, the "kinsmen and companions" line, within Hector's speech.)

- 21 ll. 321-322 The chine — the unbroken length of the back-cut — is the portion of honor, awarded to Ajax by Agamemnon: the feast as scoreboard (cf. Idomeneus's ever-full cup, 4.257-263).
- 22 ll. 327-343 Nestor's double proposal: burn the dead, and build the wall. Aristarchus athetized 334-335 — carrying the bones "home to the children" reflects classical Athenian practice (the state funeral), not Homeric cremation-and-mound, and the couplet has long been suspected as an Athenian interpolation (apparatus, Line 334-335). The wall itself is the poem's new stage-set: Books 8-15 will be fought around it.
- 23 ll. 345-353 Antenor moves to give Helen back — the appeasement party in Troy made explicit (he hosted the pre-war embassy, 3.205-224; later tradition spared his house at the sack for it). Aristarchus athetized 353. Paris's counter-offer — goods yes, "the woman I will not give back" — and Priam's meek relay of it complete the pattern: Troy's assembly knows the right answer and cannot act on it.
- 24 ll. 399-402 Diomedes' refusal: take neither the goods "nor Helen either — the cables of destruction are fastened on the Trojans already." The rope-image answers Menelaus's "ends of victory... held above" (101-102): the gods hold the rope-ends of outcomes. The young man silent under rebuke in Book 4 now answers embassies for the army, with the crowd shouting assent — the arc runs straight on to 9.32-49. (Echo note.)
- 25 ll. 421-432 The shared field at dawn: both sides washing the clotted blood from the dead they cannot recognize, "letting warm tears fall" — and Priam forbidding lament, as the Achaeans mourn unforbidden. The armies' identical griefs are given identical lines (428-429 = 431-432, Ilion for the ships); the translation keeps the symmetry exact.
- 26 ll. 433-441 "not yet dawn, but the night still half-light" (ἀμφιλύκη νύξ — only here in Homer): in the grey hour, the Achaeans raise one mound "for all alike" (ἄκριτον — undivided, no man singled) — the common grave of a common army, in contrast to every individual mound the poem imagines (cf. 86-91).
- 27 ll. 443-464 The gods audit the wall: Poseidon's professional jealousy (he and Apollo built Laomedon's wall — the last time Troy's ruler cheated them, 21.441-457), the missing hecatombs, and Zeus's remedy: erase it when the war ends, sea and sand over everything. Zenodotus, Aristophanes, and Aristarchus athetized the whole exchange (apparatus, Line 443-464); Aristotle admired it as the poet "effacing" his own invention — the poem arranges in advance why no trace of its greatest earthwork survives on the real coast (the demolition comes at 12.13-33).
- 28 ll. 467-475 The wine-fleet from Lemnos, sent by Euneus, son of Jason and Hypsipyle — the poem's one glance at the Argonaut generation, now middle-aged commerce. The market-list prices the camp's economy: bronze, iron, hides, live cattle — "and some with slaves" (ἀνδραπόδοισι, the only occurrence of the classical word for chattel-slaves in Homer; all three Alexandrians athetized the line, partly for that anachronism). Rendered "slaves" as a matter of policy: the traffic the poem's captives fear is here, briefly, a line-item.
- 29 ll. 478-482 The book closes on the uneasy feast: Zeus thundering all night "devising evil," green fear (χλωρὸν δέος — the fixed color of dread) on both armies, and no man

ILIAD — BOOK 7

drinking undedicated wine. After a day of institutions — duel, truce, wall, market — the last word is the god's weather, and it is against them.

Iliad — Book 8

Zeus forbids the gods to take part; the Trojans win the day and camp on the plain, their watchfires burning until dawn.

- Dawn in her saffron robe was spreading over all the earth¹
 when Zeus who delights in thunder made an assembly of the gods
 on the topmost peak of many-ridged Olympus;
 and he spoke to them himself, and all the gods gave ear:
- 5 "Hear me, all you gods and all you goddesses,
 so I may say what the heart in my chest commands me.
 Let no female god attempt — and no male either —
 to cut across this word of mine: all of you together
 assent to it, so I may bring these things quickly to their end.
- 10 Whomever I mark trying, apart from the gods, by his own choice,
 to go and help either Trojans or Danaans,
 struck out of all order he shall come back to Olympus —
 or I will take and hurl him into misty Tartarus,
 far down, where the deepest pit yawns under the earth,
- 15 where the gates are iron and the threshold bronze,
 as far beneath Hades as heaven is above the earth:²
 then he will know how far I am strongest of all gods.
 Or come, try it, gods — so all of you may know:
 hang a golden cord down out of heaven
- 20 and lay hold of it, all you gods and all you goddesses:
 you could not drag out of heaven down to the plain
 Zeus the counselor most high — not if you wore yourselves out.
 But whenever I chose to pull in earnest,
 I would haul you up, and the earth and the sea with you;
- 25 then I would bind the cord around a horn of Olympus,
 and the whole of it would hang in the air.
 By so much am I beyond gods, and beyond men."³
 So he spoke, and they all went still in silence,
 marveling at his word: he had spoken with great power.
- 30 At long last the goddess grey-eyed Athena spoke:
 "Father of us all, son of Cronos, highest of the mighty:

- well do we know your strength is not to be bent;
but even so we grieve for the Danaan spearmen
who will fill up an evil doom and perish.
- 35 Yes: we will hold back from the war, as you command;
but we will put counsel into the Argives — such as will help them —
so they do not all perish under your anger."
Smiling, Zeus the cloud-gatherer answered her:
"Take heart, Tritogeneia, dear child: I do not speak
40 with a set purpose; and toward you I mean to be gentle."⁴
So speaking he yoked beneath his car the bronze-hoofed horses,
swift-flying, with manes streaming gold,
and clothed himself in gold, and took the whip,
gold, well-wrought, and mounted the chariot,
45 and whipped the horses on; and the two flew, nothing loath,
between the earth and the starry sky.
He came to Ida of the many springs, mother of wild things,
to Gargaron, where his precinct is, and his smoking altar.⁵
There the father of men and gods halted his horses,
50 loosed them from the car, and poured thick mist around them;
and he sat on the peaks, exulting in his glory,
looking out at the Trojans' city and the ships of the Achaeans.
Now the long-haired Achaeans took their meal
quickly through the huts, and armed themselves straight after;
55 and the Trojans on their side armed through the city,
fewer — yet even so they were mad to join battle,
under hard necessity, for their children and their wives.
All the gates were flung open, and the host streamed out,
foot-soldiers and horsemen; and a great din arose.
60 And when they had come together into one place,
they dashed together shields, and spears, and the fury of men
armored in bronze; the bossed shields
pressed hard on one another, and a great din arose.
There rose together the groaning and the boasting of men
65 killing and killed, and the earth ran with blood.
So long as it was morning, and the sacred day still growing,
so long the missiles of both sides struck home, and the people fell.
But when the Sun bestrode the middle of heaven,

- then the father stretched out his golden scales,
70 and set in them two fates of death that lays men low,
one for the horse-taming Trojans, one for the bronze-shirted Achaeans,
and took the middle and pulled; and the Achaeans' day of doom sank.⁶
The Achaeans' fates settled down on the earth
that feeds so many, and the Trojans' rose toward the wide sky.
- 75 And he thundered aloud from Ida, and sent a blazing
flash among the Achaean host; and they saw it
and were stunned, and green fear took hold of them all.
Then neither Idomeneus dared stand, nor Agamemnon,
nor the two Ajaxes hold their ground, squires of Ares:
- 80 Nestor alone stayed, the Gerenian, warden of the Achaeans —
in no way willing; his horse was failing, shot by an arrow
from brilliant Alexandros, lovely-haired Helen's husband,
on the very crown of the head, where a horse's first hairs
grow on the skull — the deadliest spot of all.
- 85 It reared in agony as the shaft went into the brain,
and threw the team into chaos, writhing around the bronze.
And while the old man leapt with his sword to cut away
the trace-horse, Hector's swift horses came on
through the rout, carrying their bold driver —
- 90 Hector. And there the old man would have lost his life,
had not Diomedes, good at the war-cry, been quick to see.
He shouted terribly, calling Odysseus on:
"Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus of many devices —
where are you running, your back turned, like a coward in the crowd?
- 95 Take care no one plants a spear in that back as you flee!
Stand, till we beat this wild man off the old one."
So he spoke; and much-enduring brilliant Odysseus did not hear,⁷
but swept on past, toward the hollow ships of the Achaeans.
Then Tydeus' son, alone as he was, mixed with the front-fighters
100 and made his stand before the horses of the old man, Neleus' son,
and speaking winged words he addressed him:
"Old man, the young fighters are wearing you hard;
your force is unstrung, and hard old age attends you;
your aide is feeble now, and your horses slow.
- 105 Come, get up into my car, and see

- what the horses of Tros are like, how they know their plain —⁸
 how to wheel fast this way and that, in pursuit or flight.
 I took the pair from Aeneas — those two machines of rout.
 Let our aides look after yours; these two
 110 we will drive straight at the horse-taming Trojans, so that even Hector
 may know whether my spear too rages in my hands."
 So he spoke, and the Gerenian horseman Nestor did not disobey.
 Then their two aides looked after Nestor's mares,
 strong Sthenelus, and Eurymedon the kindly;
 115 and the two of them mounted Diomedes' chariot.
 Nestor took the glossy reins into his hands
 and whipped the horses; and quickly they closed with Hector.
 Straight at him, as he charged, the son of Tydeus cast:
 him he missed — but his driver and aide,
 120 Eniopeus, son of high-hearted Thebaeus,
 he struck in the chest by the nipple as he held the reins.
 He crashed from the car, and the swift-footed horses
 shied back; and there his life and strength were unstrung.
 And terrible grief closed over Hector's heart for his driver;
 125 but he left him lying there, though grieving for his companion,
 and went after a bold driver in his place; nor did his horses
 lack a master long: for soon he found
 bold Archeptolemus, Iphitus' son, and set him up
 behind the swift horses, and gave the reins into his hands.
 130 And now there would have been ruin, deeds beyond remedy,
 and they would have been penned in Ilion like lambs,
 had not the father of men and gods been quick to see.
 Thundering terribly he let fly a white-hot bolt
 and dashed it to the ground before the horses of Diomedes;
 135 and a terrible flame rose up of burning sulphur,
 and the two horses, terrified, cowered under the car.
 The glossy reins slipped out of Nestor's hands,
 and he was afraid at heart, and said to Diomedes:
 "Tydeus' son — come, turn the single-hoofed horses to flight.
 140 Do you not see? Victory out of Zeus does not go with you.
 Today it is that man Zeus, Cronos' son, hands the glory —
 today; later, if he chooses, he will give it

- to us in turn. No man can fend off the purpose of Zeus,
not even the strongest: for he is stronger by far."⁹
- 145 Then answered him Diomedes, good at the war-cry:
"Yes, old man — all this you have said rightly and in due measure.
But this bitter grief comes over my heart and spirit:
Hector one day will say, speaking among the Trojans:
'Tydeus' son ran before me to his ships.'
- 150 So he will boast one day. Then let the wide earth gape for me."
Then answered him the Gerenian horseman Nestor:
"Ah me, war-minded Tydeus' son — what a thing to say.
Even if Hector calls you coward and weakling,
the Trojans will never believe him, nor the Dardanians,
155 nor the wives of the great-hearted Trojan shieldmen
whose husbands in their strength you tumbled in the dust."
So speaking he turned the single-hoofed horses to flight
back through the rout; and the Trojans and Hector after them
with unearthly clamor poured their groaning missiles.
- 160 And over him great Hector of the flashing helmet shouted:
"Tydeus' son — the Danaans of swift colts honored you
beyond all others, with the seat, the meats, the full cups.
Now they will dishonor you: you were a woman after all.
Away with you, painted doll! Never, with me not yielding,
165 shall you scale our towers, never carry off our women
in your ships: before that, I will deal you your doom."¹⁰
So he spoke; and Tydeus' son was torn two ways,
whether to wheel the horses and fight him face to face.
Three times he pondered it in mind and heart,
170 and three times from the mountains of Ida Zeus the counselor
thundered,
giving his sign to the Trojans: victory that turns the battle's tide.¹¹
And Hector called to the Trojans with a far-carrying shout:
"Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians who fight at close quarters —
be men, my friends; remember your rushing courage.
- 175 I know that the son of Cronos has bowed his head and promised me
victory and great glory — and grief for the Danaans.
The fools! — contriving those walls of theirs,
feeble things, not worth a thought: they will not hold my fury,

- and our horses will lightly leap the ditch they dug.
- 180 But when I have come among their hollow ships,
 then let there be some memory of burning fire,
 so I may fire the ships and kill the men themselves —
 the Argives by their ships, dazed in the smoke."
 So speaking he called to his horses, and named them:
- 185 "Xanthus, and you, Podargus, and Aethon, and brilliant Lampus:¹²
 now pay me back your keep — all the care and plenty
 of Andromache, great-hearted Eëtion's daughter,
 who set the honey-hearted wheat before you first,
 and mixed wine for you to drink when your hearts commanded —
- 190 before me, and I claim to be her strong young husband.¹³
 After them now, at full stretch, so we may take
 the shield of Nestor, whose fame now reaches heaven —
 solid gold, they say, the cross-rods and the shield itself —
 and off the shoulders of Diomedes, breaker of horses,
- 195 the wrought corslet Hephaestus labored to make.¹⁴
 Could we take those two things, I should hope to put the Achaeans
 aboard their swift ships this very night."
 So he spoke in his vaunting; and the lady Hera was outraged:
 she shook on her throne and made high Olympus tremble,
- 200 and spoke straight out to the great god Poseidon:
 "Shame, wide-ruling earth-shaker — not even you,
 in your own chest, grieve for the Danaans as they die.
 Yet to you, to Helice and Aegae, they bring gifts up,¹⁵
 many and pleasing; then wish them victory now.
- 205 If only we chose — all of us who stand by the Danaans —
 to thrust the Trojans back and hold off wide-seeing Zeus,
 he could sit there and sulk, alone on Ida."
 Deeply troubled, the lord earth-shaker answered her:
 "Hera, reckless of tongue — what a word you have spoken!
- 210 I would not choose to have the rest of us fight
 Zeus, Cronos' son: for he is stronger by far."
 So they spoke such things to one another;
 and all the space the ditch walled off between wall and ships
 filled with a crush of horses and shield-bearing men
- 215 penned in: and the penner was Hector, Priam's son,

- the equal of quick Ares, now that Zeus gave him glory.
 And he would have burned the balanced ships with blazing fire,
 had not the lady Hera put it in Agamemnon's mind
 to bestir himself and rouse the Achaeans, quickly.
- 220 He went his way along the huts and ships of the Achaeans
 holding a great purple cloak in his heavy hand,
 and stood on Odysseus's black ship, huge of hull,
 which lay midmost, so a shout could carry to both ends,
 both to the huts of Ajax, Telamon's son,
- 225 and to Achilles' — for they had drawn their balanced ships up
 at the ends, trusting their courage and the strength of their hands.¹⁶
 There he called to the Danaans, piercing-clear:
 "Shame, Argives! Vile disgraces — admired only for your looks!
 Where have the boasts gone, when we said we were the best —
- 230 the boasts you made on Lemnos, all empty wind,¹⁷
 eating your fill of the flesh of straight-horned oxen,
 drinking the bowls brimmed over with wine:
 that each of you would stand against a hundred Trojans
 in battle — two hundred! Now we are not worth one:
- 235 Hector, who soon will fire the ships with blazing flame.
 Father Zeus — was there ever another great king
 you blinded with blindness like this, and stripped of his great glory?
 And yet I say I never passed one beautiful altar of yours
 on my luckless way here in my many-benched ship:
- 240 on every one I burned the fat and the thighs of oxen,
 in my longing to sack well-walled Troy.
 But Zeus — grant me at least this wish:
 let these men at least escape and get away;
 do not let the Achaeans be broken by the Trojans so."
- 245 So he spoke; and the father pitied his weeping,
 and nodded: the host should be saved, and not perish.
 At once he sent an eagle — surest of omens among birds —
 holding a fawn in its talons, young of a running deer;
 beside the beautiful altar of Zeus it dropped the fawn,
- 250 where the Achaeans made offering to Zeus of All Voices.¹⁸
 And when they saw that the bird had come from Zeus,
 they leapt the more on the Trojans, and remembered their fighting.

Then no Danaan there, many as they were, could boast
 he was before Tydeus' son in holding his swift horses,
 255 driving them across the ditch, and fighting face to face:
 far the first, he took a Trojan armored fighter,
 Agelaus, Phradmon's son, just wheeling his horses to flight:
 as he turned, the spear fixed in his back
 between the shoulders and drove through his chest;
 260 he crashed from the car, and his armor clattered upon him.
 After him came the sons of Atreus, Agamemnon and Menelaus;
 after them the two Ajaxes, clothed in rushing courage;
 after them Idomeneus, and Idomeneus' comrade
 Meriones, the equal of Enyalios, slayer of men;
 265 after them Eurypylus, Euaemon's shining son;
 and ninth came Teucer, bending his back-sprung bow,
 and took his stand under the shield of Ajax, Telamon's son.
 Ajax would edge the shield aside; and the hero,
 when he had scanned his man and shot into the crowd
 270 and hit him — the man dropped where he stood and lost his life —
 then back he would slip, like a child to his mother,¹⁹
 to Ajax; and Ajax hid him with the shining shield.
 Whom first of the Trojans did blameless Teucer take?
 Orsilochus first, and Ormenus, and Ophelestes,
 275 Daetor and Chromius and godlike Lycophontes,
 and Amopaon, Polyaeon's son, and Melanippus —
 all these, one on another, he brought down to the earth that feeds so
 many.
 And seeing him the lord of men Agamemnon rejoiced
 as he wrecked the Trojan companies from his strong bow;
 280 and he came and stood beside him and spoke his word:
 "Teucer, dear heart, Telamon's son, marshal of the people:
 keep shooting like that — and be a light to the Danaans,
 and to your father Telamon, who reared you when you were little
 and cared for you in his own house, bastard though you were:
 285 set him in the way of glory, far off as he is.
 And I will tell you outright, and it will be accomplished:
 if aegis-bearing Zeus and Athena grant me
 to sack the well-built citadel of Iliion,

- first after myself I will set a prize of honor in your hands —
 290 a tripod, or a pair of horses with their chariot,
 or a woman, to climb into one bed with you."
 Answering him spoke blameless Teucer:
 "Most glorious son of Atreus — why urge me on when I am
 eager myself? So far as the strength is in me
 295 I do not stop: from the hour we pushed them back toward Ilion,
 from then I have watched with my bow, and killed my men.
 Eight long-barbed arrows I have loosed by now,
 and all of them fixed in the flesh of quick young fighters;
 but this mad dog I cannot hit."
 300 He spoke, and shot another arrow from the string
 straight at Hector, his heart aching to hit him:
 him he missed — but blameless Gorgythion,
 Priam's brave son, he struck in the chest with the arrow —
 the son his wedded mother bore, brought from Aesyme,
 305 beautiful Castianeira, in body like the goddesses.
 And as a poppy in a garden lets its head fall sideways,
 heavy with its own seed and the rains of spring,
 so his head bowed to one side under the weight of the helmet.²⁰
 And Teucer shot another arrow from the string
 310 straight at Hector, his heart aching to hit him;
 but this one too he missed — Apollo brushed it wide —
 and struck bold Archeptolemus, Hector's driver,
 as he swept into battle, in the chest by the nipple.
 He crashed from the car, and the swift-footed horses
 315 shied back; and there his life and strength were unstrung.
 And terrible grief closed over Hector's heart for his driver;
 but he left him lying there, though grieving for his companion,
 and called to his brother Cebriones, who was near,
 to take the horses' reins; and he heard, and did not disobey.
 320 Hector himself leapt down from the shining chariot
 with a terrible cry, and caught up a boulder in his hand,
 and went straight for Teucer, his heart driving him to strike.
 Teucer had drawn a bitter arrow from the quiver
 and laid it on the string; and just as he drew, Hector
 325 of the flashing helmet struck him with the jagged stone

- beside the shoulder, where the collarbone parts the neck
 and chest, the deadliest spot of all, as he aimed at him,
 and snapped the bowstring; his hand went numb at the wrist;
 he dropped to his knees and stayed, and the bow fell from his hand.
- 330 But Ajax did not neglect his fallen brother:
 running, he stood over him and covered him with the shield.
 Then two loyal companions stooped beneath him,
 Mecisteus, Echius' son, and brilliant Alastor,
 and carried him, groaning heavily, to the hollow ships.
- 335 And once more the Olympian woke fury in the Trojans,
 and they pushed the Achaeans straight on the deep ditch;
 and Hector went among the first, glorying in his strength.
 As when a hound with quick feet presses a wild boar
 or a lion from behind, snapping at flank
- 340 and buttock, and watches for the moment it turns,
 so Hector pressed the long-haired Achaeans,
 killing always the hindmost as they fled.
 But when they had crossed the stakes and the ditch, running,
 and many were broken under Trojan hands,
- 345 they halted and held their ground beside the ships,
 calling to one another, and lifting their hands
 to all the gods, each man prayed aloud;
 and Hector wheeled his lovely-maned horses this way and that,
 with the eyes of the Gorgon, or of Ares bane of mortals.²¹
- 350 And seeing them the goddess white-armed Hera pitied them,
 and quickly spoke winged words to Athena:
 "Shame — child of aegis-bearing Zeus! Shall the two of us
 no longer care for the Danaans dying, even at the last?
 They will fill up an evil doom and perish
- 355 under one man's onset — this Hector, Priam's son,
 raging now past all bearing; and great evil he has done already."
 Then the goddess grey-eyed Athena answered her:
 "That man might well have lost his fury and his life,
 broken at Argive hands, dead in his own fatherland —
- 360 but my father rages with no good mind:
 the hard god, forever the sinner, thwarter of my purposes.
 He remembers nothing of all the times I saved his son

worn to breaking under Eurystheus's labors:
 he would cry up to heaven, and Zeus would send me
 365 down out of heaven to stand by him and help.
 If my crafty mind had only known all this
 that time Eurystheus sent him down to the house of Hades the gate-
 closer,
 to bring out of Erebus the hound of hateful Hades —
 he would not have escaped the sheer waters of the Styx.²²
 370 But now Zeus loathes me, and works out the plans of Thetis,
 who kissed his knees, and took his chin in her hand,
 begging him to give honor to Achilles, sacker of cities.
 The day will come when he calls me his dear grey-eyes again.
 But you — harness the single-hoofed horses for the two of us,
 375 while I go down into the house of aegis-bearing Zeus
 and arm myself in gear for war — so I may see
 whether Priam's son, Hector of the flashing helmet,
 will be glad when the two of us appear on the causeways of battle —
 or whether some Trojan too will glut the dogs and the birds
 380 with his fat and his flesh, fallen beside the ships of the Achaeans."
 So she spoke, and the goddess white-armed Hera did not disobey.
 Hera went to and fro harnessing the golden-fronted horses —
 Hera, eldest goddess, daughter of great Cronos;
 and Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus,
 385 let fall her soft robe on her father's floor,
 the many-colored robe she herself had made and worked with her
 hands,
 and put on the tunic of Zeus the cloud-gatherer,²³
 and armed herself in his gear for tearful war.
 Into the flaming chariot she stepped, and gripped the spear —
 390 heavy, huge, compact — with which she breaks the ranks of men,
 of heroes, when she of the mighty father is angered with them.
 And Hera swiftly touched the horses with the whip;
 and self-moved the gates of heaven groaned open, kept by the Seasons,
 to whom great heaven and Olympus are entrusted,
 395 to roll the thick cloud aside, or set it back.
 There, straight through, they held the goaded horses.
 But father Zeus, when he saw it from Ida, was terribly angered,

- and sent Iris of the golden wings to bear his message:
 "Up, go, swift Iris: turn them back; do not let them
 400 come against me. It will be no fair meeting if we join in war.
 For I say this outright, and it will be accomplished:
 I will lame their swift horses under the chariot,
 hurl the two of them from the car, and smash the chariot;
 and not in ten circling years will they be healed
 405 of the wounds the thunderbolt tears — so grey-eyes may learn
 what it is to fight against her own father.
 With Hera I am not so indignant, not so angry:
 it has always been her way to cross whatever I say."
 So he spoke; and storm-footed Iris rose to bear the message,
 410 and went from the mountains of Ida to high Olympus.
 At the very gates of many-folded Olympus
 she met them and held them, and told them the word of Zeus:
 "Where are you two rushing? What is this madness raging in your
 hearts?
 The son of Cronos forbids you to stand by the Argives.
 415 For thus the son of Cronos threatens — and he will do it:
 to lame your swift horses under the chariot,
 hurl the two of you from the car, and smash the chariot;
 and not in ten circling years will you be healed
 of the wounds the thunderbolt tears — so you may learn,
 420 grey-eyes, what it is to fight against your own father.
 With Hera he is not so indignant, not so angry:
 it has always been her way to cross whatever he says.
 But you — appalling; you shameless dog — if you truly
 dare to lift your gigantic spear against Zeus."²⁴
 425 So speaking, swift-footed Iris went her way;
 and Hera spoke her word to Athena:
 "Shame — child of aegis-bearing Zeus: I say no longer
 can the two of us make war on Zeus for the sake of mortals.
 Of them, let one man perish, and another live,
 430 as it may fall; and let him, pondering his own purposes,
 judge between Trojans and Danaans, as is fitting."²⁵
 So speaking she turned the single-hoofed horses back.
 The Seasons unyoked their lovely-maned horses for them,

- and tethered them at the ambrosial mangers,
435 and leaned the chariot against the shining inner wall;
and the goddesses sat down on golden chairs
among the other gods, their dear hearts sorrowing.
And father Zeus drove his strong-wheeled chariot and horses
from Ida to Olympus, and came to the sessions of the gods.
440 For him the famed earth-shaker unyoked the horses
and set the car on its stand, and spread a cloth across it;
and wide-seeing Zeus himself sat down on his golden throne,
and great Olympus shook beneath his feet.
Apart from Zeus, and alone, sat Athena and Hera,
445 and did not speak to him or question him;
but he understood in his heart, and spoke:
"Why so stricken, Athena and Hera?
Surely you are not worn out with battle where men win glory —
with killing Trojans, against whom you have set your dread hatred!
450 Come what may — such is my fury, so untouchable my hands —
all the gods there are on Olympus could not turn me.
As for you two: trembling took your shining limbs
before you ever saw the war, and war's grim works.
For I will say this outright — and it would have been accomplished:
455 struck by my thunderbolt, you two would never have come back
on your own chariot to Olympus, where the immortals have their seat."
So he spoke, and they murmured at it, Athena and Hera,
who sat side by side plotting evils for the Trojans.
Athena, to be sure, stayed silent and said nothing,
460 sulking at father Zeus, wild anger gripping her;
but Hera's breast could not contain her anger, and she spoke:
"Most dread son of Cronos, what a word you have spoken!
Well do we know your strength is nothing feeble;
but even so we grieve for the Danaan spearmen
465 who will fill up an evil doom and perish.
Yes: we will hold back from the war, if you command;
but we will put counsel into the Argives — such as will help them —
so they do not all perish under your anger."
Answering her spoke Zeus the cloud-gatherer:
470 "At dawn you will see him — if you have the heart for it,

ox-eyed lady Hera — the overmastering son of Cronos
 wrecking still more of the great host of Argive spearmen.
 For massive Hector will not stop from the fighting
 until the swift-footed son of Peleus rises beside the ships,
 475 on that day when they fight at the ships' sterns,
 in the narrowest, most terrible press, over Patroclus fallen.²⁶
 So it is decreed by heaven. And for your anger
 I care nothing — not if you go to the nethermost limits
 of earth and sea, where Iapetus and Cronos
 480 sit, and take no joy in the rays of Hyperion the Sun,
 nor in any wind, and deep Tartarus is all around them:
 not if you reach that place in your wandering do I care
 for your sulking — since there is nothing more dog-like than you."²⁷
 So he spoke; and white-armed Hera answered him nothing.
 485 And the bright light of the sun fell into Ocean,
 drawing black night across the grain-giving earth.
 To the Trojans the light sank unwelcome; but to the Achaeans
 dark night came welcome — thrice prayed for — very welcome.
 Now glorious Hector made an assembly of the Trojans,
 490 leading them apart from the ships, by the eddying river,
 in a clear space, where ground showed empty of the dead.²⁸
 Stepping from their chariots to the earth they listened to the word
 that Hector spoke, dear to Zeus. In his hand
 he held a spear eleven cubits long; and before him the bronze
 495 point of the shaft shone, and a ring of gold ran round it.
 Leaning on this, he spoke his words to the Trojans:
 "Hear from me, Trojans and Dardanians and allies.
 Just now I said that I should destroy the ships and all
 the Achaeans, and go back again to windy Ilion;
 500 but darkness came too soon. That, above all, has saved
 the Argives now, and the ships at the surf-line of the sea.
 So then: for now, let us yield to black night
 and make our supper ready. The lovely-maned horses —
 loose them from under the cars, and throw fodder beside them;
 505 and bring oxen from the city, and fat sheep,
 quickly; get honey-hearted wine, and bread
 from your halls; and gather plenty of wood besides,

so that all night long, till early-born Dawn,
 we may burn fires in plenty, and the glare go up to heaven —
 510 lest even by night the long-haired Achaeans
 make a run for home over the broad back of the sea.
 Not at their ease, at least! — not unbloodied shall they board:
 let many a one of them have a shaft to digest at home,
 struck by an arrow or a sharp spear
 515 as he leaps for his ship — so that others too may shudder
 to bring tearful war on the horse-taming Trojans.
 And let heralds dear to Zeus announce through the city
 that boys in first youth and grey-templed old men
 are to post themselves around the town on the god-built towers;
 520 and the women, every one of them, each in her hall,
 to burn a great fire; and let the watch be kept unbroken,
 lest a raiding party enter the town while the army is away.
 So let it be, great-hearted Trojans, as I say it:
 let the word that serves this night stand as spoken,
 525 and the word for dawn I will speak among the horse-taming Trojans
 tomorrow.
 I hope — with prayer to Zeus and the other gods —
 to drive out of here those dogs whom the death-fates carry,²⁹
 whom the fates carried to us on their black ships.
 So: through the night we will guard ourselves,
 530 and early, toward dawn, armed in our gear,
 we will waken sharp Ares beside the hollow ships.
 I will know whether Tydeus' son, strong Diomedes,
 will thrust me from the ships back on their wall — or whether I
 will break him with the bronze and carry off his bloody spoils.
 535 Tomorrow he will find out his own worth — whether he can stand
 my spear as it comes on. No: among the first, I think,
 he will lie speared, and many companions around him,
 as the sun climbs tomorrow. Would that I were as surely
 deathless and ageless for all my days,
 540 and honored as Athena and Apollo are honored,
 as surely as this day now brings evil to the Argives!³⁰
 So Hector spoke; and the Trojans roared applause.
 They loosed their sweating horses from under the yoke

and tethered them with straps, each by his own chariot;
 545 and they brought oxen from the city, and fat sheep,
 quickly; got honey-hearted wine, and bread
 from their halls; and gathered plenty of wood besides;
 and they offered to the immortals perfect hecatombs.
 The winds carried the savor from the plain into the sky —
 550 sweet savor; but the blessed gods took no share of it;
 they would not: for holy Ilion was hated in their hearts,³¹
 and Priam, and the people of Priam of the good ash spear.
 But they, high in their hopes, on the causeways of battle
 sat all night long, and their fires burned in multitudes.
 555 As when in the sky the stars around the shining moon
 appear in all their glory, when the air falls windless,
 and all the lookout-peaks show clear, and the jutting headlands,
 and the glens; and from heaven the measureless air breaks open,
 and every star is seen; and the shepherd's heart is glad:³²
 560 so many, between the ships and the streams of Xanthus,
 shone the fires the Trojans burned before Ilion.
 A thousand fires burned in the plain, and beside each one
 sat fifty men in the glare of the blazing fire.
 And the horses, champing white barley and spelt,
 565 stood beside the chariots, and waited for fair-throned Dawn.

NOTES TO BOOK 8

- 1 l. 1 "Dawn in her saffron robe" (κροκόπεπλος) — a new dawn-formula for the register, distinct from "early-born rosy-fingered Dawn" (1.477); the book will close with a third, "fair-throned Dawn" (565).
- 2 ll. 13-16 Tartarus mapped: iron gates, bronze threshold, "as far beneath Hades as heaven is above the earth" — the cosmos as three equal stories, with the threat calibrated to the architecture.
- 3 ll. 18-27 The golden cord: all gods and goddesses on one end, Zeus on the other — and he would reel in "the earth and the sea with you," and hang the whole from a horn of Olympus. Zenodotus athetized 25-26 and Aristarchus condemned the sequel (apparatus, Lines 25-26, 28-34). Later antiquity allegorized the cord endlessly (the sun, the chain of being); in context it is a weight-boast, and the whole book is its demonstration.
- 4 ll. 38-40 Zeus smiles: "I do not speak with a set purpose; toward you I mean to be gentle." Aristarchus athetized (= 22.183-184, where the lines recur). The wink complicates the ban — how seriously Zeus means his own decree is exactly what Books 8-15 keep testing.
- 5 ll. 47-48 Gargaron, Ida's peak, "where his precinct is, and his smoking altar" — Zeus takes his seat above the battle at one of his own cult-sites: spectator's box and shrine in one.
- 6 ll. 69-74 The golden scales: two "fates of death" weighed, and the Achaeans' day of doom sinks. Aristarchus athetized 73-74 (apparatus). Zeus weighs but does not choose — the gesture that poses, without solving, the poem's deepest question about Zeus and fate; it returns, for two men instead of two armies, at 22.209-213.
- 7 ll. 90-98 Odysseus, called by name to stand for old Nestor, "did not hear" (οὐδ' ἑσάκουσε) — or did not heed? The Greek permits both, and ancient readers already argued; the poem moves on without comment, and Diomedes goes back alone. First Iliad occurrence of the Odyssey's great epithet "much-enduring brilliant Odysseus" — in the poem's least flattering moment for him.
- 8 ll. 105-108 Diomedes' offer repeats his own words about the horses of Tros (5.221-223, verbatim in Greek and in this translation) — the captured team already a talking point. (Echo note.)
- 9 ll. 139-144 Nestor's counsel of retreat: "No man can fend off the purpose of Zeus." The old man articulates the book's rule — divine favor is temporal ("today... later") — and Diomedes' agonized compliance (146-150 reuse the formulas of 1.286 and 4.182) marks the limit of even the best mortal's aristeia.
- 10 ll. 161-166 Hector's taunt — "you were a woman after all. Away with you, painted doll!" (κακὴ γλῆνῃ, a glass-eyed puppet or doll). Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized 164-166, and Zenodotus's text read "I will deal you your death" (πότημον ἐφῆσω) for "deal you your doom" (δαίμονα δώσω) at 166 — this book's one entry among the disputed lines.

Kept: the gendered insult answers 163's "you were a woman," and Diomedes' three-fold hesitation at 167-169 shows it landed.

- 11 *ll. 169-171* "Three times he pondered... and three times Zeus thundered" — the three-then-fourth pattern (5.436-438) with the fourth beat removed: against Zeus there is no fourth try, only the sign obeyed.
- 12 *l. 185* Hector names four horses — Xanthus, Podargus, Aethon, Lampus — but a Homeric chariot is drawn by two, and Aristarchus athetized the line as un-Homeric (apparatus). This Xanthus is not Achilles' immortal horse (19.400) nor the river; the poem's names circulate.
- 13 *ll. 186-190* Andromache fed the horses "before me" — wheat, and wine mixed in — the domestic tenderness of Book 6 recruited into Hector's war-speech (Aristarchus athetized 189). The detail is the marriage in one image; that it surfaces as an argument to horses is Hector all over.
- 14 *ll. 191-195* The fabulous targets: Nestor's shield of solid gold "whose fame now reaches heaven," Diomedes' corslet forged by Hephaestus — neither is mentioned anywhere else in the poem. Rumor-armor, conjured by desire at the moment of imagined victory.
- 15 *l. 203* Helice and Aegae — Poseidon's great cult-seats on the Achaean gulf; Hera's argument is a priest's ledger: they pay you; act accordingly.
- 16 *ll. 220-226* The camp's geography, stated plainly: Odysseus's ship at the midpoint, where a shout reaches both ends; Ajax and Achilles holding the exposed extremities, "trusting their courage and the strength of their hands." The arrangement (repeated at 11.5-9) is the war's org-chart in ship-positions — and explains why Hector's assault will fall where it falls.
- 17 *ll. 228-235* "the boasts you made on Lemnos" — the wine-stop of the outbound voyage (the same Lemnos whose wine-fleet supplied the camp at 7.467-475): each man good for a hundred Trojans, two hundred. Agamemnon's rebuke opens with the same "Shame, Argives!" line as Hera's at 5.787 — the army's leaders now sound like its goddess.
- 18 *ll. 247-252* The eagle drops the fawn beside the altar of "Zeus of All Voices" (Παντοφῶτος — source of every omen): a sign delivered to the address of signs. Zeus grants the prayer's minimum — the host will not perish — while the day's verdict stands.
- 19 *ll. 266-334* Teucer's aristeia: shooting from under Ajax's shield and slipping back "like a child to his mother" — the bastard brother (Agamemnon says the word, 284, in praise) whose skill is framed by dependency; his reward-list runs tripod, horses, "or a woman"; and his day ends with Hector's stone to the collarbone — "the deadliest spot" (326-327, the same anatomical formula as the horse's crown at 83-84).
- 20 *ll. 302-308* Gorgythion: the son of a mother "beautiful as the goddesses," and the poppy heavy with seed and spring rain — the poem's most famous image of a death, a garden conscripted to carry a battlefield. Virgil took it for Euryalus (Aeneid 9.435-437). The vignette-technique of 4.473-489 perfected in three lines.
- 21 *ll. 348-349* Hector wheeling "with the eyes of the Gorgon, or of Ares bane of mortals" — the Gorgon-face from Athena's own aegis (5.741) lent to the poem's most human warrior

at his most daemonic. The book's Hector is glory running ahead of its limit.

- 22 *ll. 362-369* Athena's grievance: she was Zeus's instrument for saving Heracles through Eurystheus's labors — including the descent "to bring out of Erebus the hound of hateful Hades": Cerberus, present but unnamed, as at *Odyssey* 11.623. Her wish that he had drowned in Styx is savage even by Olympian standards (Zenodotus omitted, Aristarchus athetized 371-372, the Thetis-supplication reprise).
- 23 *ll. 384-391* Athena's arming repeats 5.733-747 in abridged form — the robe she made herself falling on her father's floor — and Zenodotus/Aristophanes/Aristarchus objected here too (apparatus, Line 385-387). The English repeats the Book 5 rendering verbatim, per the repetition policy.
- 24 *ll. 397-424* The Iris relay: Zeus's threat — lamed horses, smashed chariot, thunderbolt wounds that "not in ten circling years" will heal — delivered word for word, with the messenger's licensed shift of person... and then one line of Iris's own: "you shameless dog" (423, *κύων ἄδελός*). Aristarchus athetized 420-424; but the herald who adds venom the principal never spoke is a precise, humanized touch. Dogs are this book's insult-currency (299, 423, 483, 527).
- 25 *ll. 427-431* Hera's retreat: "let one man perish, and another live, as it may fall." The coldest couplet in the poem's divine politics — the goddess of the Achaean cause, rebuffed once, reverting to actuarial indifference. It is the exact opposite of the poem's own attention, which never lets a death be "as it may fall."
- 26 *ll. 470-477* The Patroclus prophecy: Hector will not stop "until the swift-footed son of Peleus rises beside the ships, on that day when they fight at the ships' sterns... over Patroclus fallen. So it is decreed" (*θέσφατον*). The poem's plot through Book 18, announced by Zeus as settled fact — the first time Patroclus's death is spoken. Suspense in Homer is never whether, only how and at what cost.
- 27 *ll. 478-483* "where Iapetus and Cronos sit" — the imprisoned Titans, sunless and windless in deep Tartarus (cf. 5.898, Zeus's threat to Ares; and 14.279). Zeus's rhetoric to his wife reaches for the family's oldest violence — and ends on "nothing more dog-like than you."
- 28 *ll. 489-491* The Trojan assembly "in a clear space, where ground showed empty of the dead" — the plain is now so strewn that open ground needs remarking. Hector's eleven-cubit spear repeats 6.318-320 verbatim (English likewise): the domestic Hector of Book 6 and the field-marshal of Book 8 carry the same spear.
- 29 *ll. 526-528* "those dogs whom the death-fates carry, whom the fates carried here on their black ships" — *κῆρες* as both escort and doom: the Achaeans came shipped by their own deaths. Hector's grimmest wordplay.
- 30 *ll. 538-541* "Would that I were as surely deathless and ageless for all my days... as surely as this day brings evil to the Argives": the adynaton-wish at the peak of Hector's confidence. Zenodotus omitted 535-537 and Aristarchus flagged 538-541 with critical points (apparatus) — ancient discomfort at Hector wishing himself Athena's and Apollo's equal. Kept: the wish measures exactly how far Zeus's one day of favor has carried him; its cadence returns, desperate, at 22.304-305.

- 31 *ll. 548-552* The Trojans sacrifice perfect hecatombs — "but the blessed gods took no share of it; they would not: for holy Ilion was hated in their hearts." Ritual perfectly performed and refused (cf. 6.311): between Athena's turned head and this rejected savor, Troy's fate is already liturgically sealed.
- 32 *ll. 555-565* The watchfires: stars around the moon in windless air, every peak and headland clear, "and the shepherd's heart is glad" — the observer's joy that Zenodotus deleted (apparatus, Line 557-558) and that makes the simile: dread from the Achaean wall is wonder from the hills. A thousand fires, fifty men to each; and the last word of this most martial book belongs to horses champing barley, "waiting for fair-throned Dawn."

Iliad — Book 9

*The embassy to Achilles: Agamemnon offers gifts and Briseis back;
Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax plead with him, and he refuses.*

- So the Trojans kept their watches. But the Achaeans
 were held by unearthly Panic, the companion of icy Rout,¹
 and all their best were stricken with grief past bearing.
 As two winds stir up the sea where the fish swarm,
 5 the North Wind and the West Wind, blowing out of Thrace,
 arriving suddenly: and all at once the dark wave
 crests, and heaps the seaweed out along the tide-line:
 so the heart was torn in the chests of the Achaeans.
 And Atreus' son, stricken to the heart with great grief,
 10 went to and fro, bidding the clear-voiced heralds
 summon every man by name to assembly,
 but not to shout; and he himself worked among the first.
 So they sat in assembly, dejected; and Agamemnon
 stood up, letting fall tears like a spring of dark water²
 15 that pours its black stream down a goat-proof cliff.
 So, groaning heavily, he spoke his words to the Argives:
 "Friends, leaders and lords of the Argives,
 Zeus, Cronos' great son, has bound me fast in heavy blindness —³
 the hard god: he promised me once, he bowed his head,
 20 that I should sack well-walled Ilion before returning;
 now he has planned a cruel deceit, and orders me
 back to Argos in disgrace, with half my people lost.
 Such, it seems, must be the pleasure of overmastering Zeus,
 who has undone the crowns of many cities
 25 and will undo more yet: his power is the greatest.
 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:
 let us flee with the ships to our dear fatherland.
 We shall not take wide-wayed Troy now."
 So he spoke, and they all went still in silence.
 30 A long while the sons of the Achaeans sat mute, dejected;
 and at long last Diomedes, good at the war-cry, spoke:

- "Son of Atreus, it is you I will fight first — your folly —⁴
 where it is right, lord: in assembly. And do not be angered.
 My courage you insulted once before the Danaans:
 35 you called me unwarlike, without strength. And all this
 the Argives know, the young men and the old.
 To you the son of crooked-counseled Cronos gave by halves:
 with the scepter he gave you honor beyond all men,
 but courage he did not give you — and that is the greatest power.
 40 Strange man — do you really suppose the sons of the Achaeans
 are as unwarlike and strengthless as you say?
 If your own heart is set on going home,
 go: the way lies open, and your ships stand by the sea,
 the great fleet that followed you from Mycenae.
 45 But the other long-haired Achaeans will stay
 until we sack Troy. And if they too —
 well, let them flee with their ships to their dear fatherland;
 the two of us, Sthenelus and I, will fight on until we find
 the appointed end of Ilion: for we came here with the god."
 50 So he spoke, and all the sons of the Achaeans shouted,
 marveling at the word of Diomedes, breaker of horses.
 And the horseman Nestor stood up and spoke among them:
 "Tydeus' son, in war you are strong beyond others,
 and in counsel you are best of all your age-mates.
 55 Not a man of all the Achaeans will fault your word
 or speak against it. But you have not reached the end of words.
 You are young indeed — you could be my own son,
 the latest-born; and yet you speak good sense
 to the kings of the Argives, for you have spoken rightly.
 60 Come then, I — who claim to be older than you —
 will speak out and go through everything; and no one
 will slight my word, not even the lord Agamemnon.
 Clanless, lawless, hearthless: that is the man⁵
 who is in love with war among his own people — the horror of it.
 65 But for now, let us yield to black night
 and make our supper ready. Let the sentries
 post themselves along the dug ditch outside the wall —
 that is my charge to the young men. And then,

- son of Atreus, you lead: for you are most the king.
- 70 Give the elders a feast: it becomes you; it is no disgrace.⁶
 Your huts are full of wine, which the Achaeans' ships
 bring over the wide sea from Thrace daily;
 all hosting is yours to give: you are king over many.
 With many gathered, you will heed the man who counsels
- 75 the best counsel; and sorely do all the Achaeans need
 good counsel and shrewd — with the enemy this close to the ships,
 burning their fires past counting. Who could rejoice at that?
 This night will break the army, or will save it."
 So he spoke, and they listened well to him and obeyed.
- 80 Out went the sentries in their armor, mustered
 around Nestor's son Thrasymedes, shepherd of the people,
 around Ascalaphus and Ialmenus, sons of Ares,
 around Meriones, and Aphareus, and Deïpyrus,
 and around Creon's son, brilliant Lycomedes.
- 85 Seven were the captains of the sentries, and with each went
 a hundred young men carrying their long spears;
 and they went and took post between the ditch and wall,
 and there lit fires, and each man set about his supper.
 And Atreus' son led the gathered elders of the Achaeans
- 90 to his hut, and set before them a feast to fill the heart;
 and they put out their hands to the good things lying ready.
 And when they had put away desire for eating and drinking,
 the old man first of all began to weave his counsel —
 Nestor, whose plan had shown itself best before as well.
- 95 With good will toward them he spoke and addressed them:
 "Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of men Agamemnon,
 with you I will end, and with you begin: because you are
 lord of many peoples, and Zeus has put into your hands⁷
 the scepter and the ordinances, to take counsel for them.
- 100 Therefore you above all must speak a word and listen,
 and act for another too, whenever his heart bids a man
 speak for the good: whatever he begins will hang on you.
 And I will say how it seems to me to be best.
 No other man will think a better thought than this —
- 105 the thought I think, and thought long since and still,

- from that day, Zeus-born, when you went and took the girl
 Briseis out of the hut of Achilles in his anger —
 in no way by our judgment. I myself
 argued long against it; but you, yielding
- 110 to your great-hearted spirit, dishonored the best of men,
 a man the immortals honor: for you took and keep his prize.
 Even now — even late — let us consider how to make amends
 and win him over with soothing gifts and with honeyed words."
 Then answered him the lord of men Agamemnon:
- 115 "Old man, that was no false telling of my blindness.⁸
 Blinded I was — I do not deny it myself. Worth many
 hosts of men is the man whom Zeus loves in his heart:
 as now he has honored this man, and broken the Achaean host.
 But since I was blinded, and followed my wretched heart,
- 120 I am willing to make amends, and to give ransom past counting.
 Before you all I will name the glorious gifts:⁹
 seven tripods untouched by fire, ten talents of gold,
 twenty gleaming cauldrons, and twelve horses,
 strong-built, prize-winners, who have taken races with their speed.
- 125 No man who owned all they have won for me
 would be poor in goods, or lacking in precious gold —
 all the prizes those single-hoofed horses have carried home.
 And I will give seven women skilled in blameless work,
 women of Lesbos — the ones I chose when he himself
- 130 took well-built Lesbos, who in beauty outdid the tribes of women.
 These I will give; and among them will be the one I took away:
 the daughter of Briseus. And I will swear the great oath besides:
 I never went up into her bed, I never lay with her,¹⁰
 as is the way of human kind, of men and women.
- 135 All this shall be his at once. And if hereafter
 the gods grant us to sack the great city of Priam,
 let him heap his ship with gold and bronze
 when he comes in, when we Achaeans divide the spoil,
 and let him choose out twenty Trojan women for himself,
- 140 the loveliest there are after Argive Helen.
 And if we come home to Achaean Argos, udder of the plowland,
 he can be my son-in-law: I will honor him the equal of Orestes,

- my late-born boy, reared in high plenty.
 I have three daughters in my strong-built hall,
 145 Chrysothemis, Laodice, and Iphianassa:¹¹
 of these let him lead the one he chooses, without bride-price,
 to the house of Peleus; and I will add wedding-gifts
 in plenty — more than any man yet gave with his daughter.
 And I will give him seven well-peopled citadels:
 150 Cardamyle, and Enope, and grassy Hire,
 sacred Pherae, and Antheia of the deep meadows,
 beautiful Aipeia, and Pedasus of the vines —¹²
 all near the sea, on the edge of sandy Pylos,
 and in them live men rich in flocks and rich in cattle,
 155 who will honor him like a god with their gifts
 and render him, under his scepter, their shining dues.
 All this I will accomplish for him, if he leaves off his anger.
 Let him be broken. Hades is the one unappeasable,¹³
 the untamable — and for that, of all gods, mortals hate him most.
 160 And let him yield place to me, by as much as I am more kingly,
 by as much as I claim to be the elder-born."
 Then answered him the Gerenian horseman Nestor:
 "Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of men Agamemnon,
 the gifts you offer lord Achilles now — no man could scorn them.
 165 Come then, let us send chosen men, to go
 with all speed to the hut of Peleus' son Achilles —
 or come: those my eye falls on, let them consent.
 Phoenix first, dear to Zeus — let him lead;¹⁴
 and then great Ajax, and brilliant Odysseus;
 170 and of the heralds, Odios and Eurybates go with them.
 Now bring water for our hands, and call the holy silence,
 that we may pray to Zeus, Cronos' son, for his pity."
 So he spoke, and the word he spoke was pleasing to them all.
 At once the heralds poured water over their hands,
 175 the young men filled the mixing-bowls brim-high with drink
 and served all, pouring first drops in each cup for the god;
 and when they had poured, and drunk what their hearts would,
 they set out from the hut of Atreus' son Agamemnon.
 And the Gerenian horseman Nestor charged them well,

- 180 with a look at each in turn, at Odysseus above all:
try hard to win over the blameless son of Peleus.
So the two of them went along the shore of the loud-roaring sea,¹⁵
praying hard to the holder and shaker of the earth
that they might easily bend the great mind of Aeacus' grandson;
185 and the two came to the huts and the ships of the Myrmidons.
They found him delighting his heart with the clear-toned lyre,
beautiful, richly worked, with a crossbar of silver on it,
which he had taken from the spoils when he wrecked Eëtion's city:
with this he was pleasuring his heart, and singing the fames of men.¹⁶
190 And Patroclus alone sat facing him, in silence,
waiting for Aeacus' grandson to leave off singing.
So the two of them came forward, brilliant Odysseus leading,
and stood before him; and Achilles sprang up amazed,
lyre still in hand, leaving the seat where he had sat;
195 and Patroclus likewise rose when he saw the men.
And greeting the two of them, swift-footed Achilles said:
"Welcome! Truly dear men have come — the need must be great —
you who even in my anger are dearest to me of the Achaeans."¹⁷
So speaking, brilliant Achilles led them forward
200 and seated them on chairs with coverings of purple,
and quickly said to Patroclus, who stood near:
"Set out a bigger mixing-bowl, son of Menoetius;
mix the wine stronger; and make ready a cup for each man:¹⁷
for the men beneath my roof are the men I love best."
205 So he spoke, and Patroclus obeyed his dear companion.
He threw down a great chopping-block in the light of the fire
and laid on it the chine of a sheep and of a fat goat,
and the back of a great hog, rich with lard.
Automedon held them for him, and brilliant Achilles carved,
210 and sliced the meat with skill, and threaded it on spits;
and the son of Menoetius, a man like a god, built up the fire.
And when the fire had burned down and the flame died,
he leveled the embers and stretched the spits above them,
and sprinkled the holy salt, resting the spits on their stones.
215 And when he had roasted it all and heaped it on platters,
Patroclus took bread and set it out on the table

in beautiful baskets, and Achilles served the meat.
 He himself sat down facing godlike Odysseus
 against the far wall, and told his companion Patroclus
 220 to sacrifice to the gods; and he threw the offerings in the fire.
 And they put out their hands to the good things lying ready.
 And when they had put away desire for eating and drinking,
 Ajax nodded to Phoenix. But brilliant Odysseus caught it,
 and filling a cup with wine he pledged Achilles:
 225 "Your health, Achilles! Of the fair-shared feast we have no lack,
 whether in the hut of Agamemnon, Atreus' son,
 or here and now: plenty to fill the heart
 is set before us. But the works of the lovely feast are not
 our business now. We are looking at grief too great, Zeus-nurtured;
 230 we are afraid. It stands in doubt whether we save
 the well-benched ships or lose them — unless you clothe yourself in
 valor.
 For close to the ships and the wall they have made their camp,
 the high-hearted Trojans and their far-famed allies,
 with fires past counting through their host; and they say
 235 nothing will hold them now from falling on the black ships.
 And Zeus, Cronos' son, shows them signs on the right,
 flashing his lightning; and Hector, glorying in his strength,
 rages terribly, trusting in Zeus, and gives way to nothing,
 neither man nor god: the strong madness has entered him.
 240 He prays for the brilliant Dawn to show herself quickly,
 for he vows he will hew off the ships' stern-horns,
 burn the hulls themselves with ravening fire, and cut down
 the Achaeans beside them, dazed in the smoke.
 This is the fear my heart dreads terribly — that the gods
 245 may make his threats good, and it prove our portion
 to die at Troy, far from horse-pasturing Argos.
 Up, then! — if you mean, even at this late hour, to save
 the wearied sons of the Achaeans from the Trojan onslaught.
 It will be your own grief later; and there is no finding
 250 a cure for harm once done. Far sooner, then:
 think how to ward the evil day from the Danaans.
 Dear friend — surely your father Peleus charged you¹⁹

- the day he sent you out of Phthia to Agamemnon:
'My child, the victory Athena and Hera
255 will give, if they choose; but the great-hearted spirit —
rein that in in your own chest. Friendliness is better.
Break off strife, the deviser of evil, so the Argives
may honor you the more, the young men and the old.'
So the old man charged you; and you forget. Yet even now
260 stop; let go the anger that grieves the heart. Agamemnon
offers you worthy gifts, if you leave off your anger.
Come, listen to me, and I will count out for you
all the gifts Agamemnon promised in his huts:²⁰
seven tripods untouched by fire, ten talents of gold,
265 twenty gleaming cauldrons, and twelve horses,
strong-built, prize-winners, who have taken races with their speed.
No man who owned all they have won
would be poor in goods, or lacking in precious gold —
all the prizes Agamemnon's horses have carried home.
270 And he will give seven women skilled in blameless work,
women of Lesbos — the ones he chose when you yourself
took well-built Lesbos, who in beauty outdid the tribes of women.
These he will give; and among them will be the one he took away:
the daughter of Briseus. And he will swear the great oath besides:
275 he never went up into her bed, he never lay with her,
as is the way, lord, of men and women.
All this shall be yours at once. And if hereafter
the gods grant us to sack the great city of Priam,
you may heap your ship with gold and bronze
280 when you come in, when we Achaeans divide the spoil,
and choose out twenty Trojan women for yourself,
the loveliest there are after Argive Helen.
And if we come home to Achaean Argos, udder of the plowland,
you can be his son-in-law: he will honor you the equal of Orestes,
285 his late-born boy, reared in high plenty.
He has three daughters in his strong-built hall,
Chrysothemis, Laodice, and Iphianassa:
of these you may lead the one you choose, without bride-price,
to the house of Peleus; and he will add wedding-gifts

- 290 in plenty — more than any man yet gave with his daughter.
 And he will give you seven well-peopled citadels:
 Cardamyle, and Enope, and grassy Hire,
 sacred Pherae, and Antheia of the deep meadows,
 beautiful Aipeia, and Pedasus of the vines —
- 295 all near the sea, on the edge of sandy Pylos,
 and in them live men rich in flocks and rich in cattle,
 who will honor you like a god with their gifts
 and render you, under your scepter, their shining dues.
 All this he will accomplish for you, if you leave off your anger.
- 300 But if Atreus' son is grown too hateful to your heart,
 he and his gifts together — then pity all the rest,
 the Achaeans of every rank, worn down through the camp, who will
 honor you
 like a god. Truly, you would win great glory in their eyes:
 for now you might take Hector's very self — he would come
- 305 in close to you in his deadly madness, since he says no man
 is his equal of all the Danaans the ships brought here."
 Answering him spoke swift-footed Achilles:
 "Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus of many devices:
 I must speak my word to you outright, without mercy —
- 310 exactly as I think it, and as it will be accomplished —
 so you will not sit by me and coo at me, one after another.
 For hateful to me as the gates of Hades is the man²¹
 who hides one thing in his mind and says another.
 So I will speak it as it seems to me best.
- 315 Neither Atreus' son Agamemnon will persuade me, I think,
 nor the other Danaans — since there was no thanks, it seems,
 for battling the enemy without respite, forever.
 The portion is equal for the man who hangs back and the man who
 fights hard;²²
 in one honor stand the coward and the brave;
- 320 death comes alike to the do-nothing and the man of many deeds.
 And nothing is laid up for me because I suffered
 the pains of it, forever staking my life in the fighting.
 As a bird carries to her unfledged chicks²³
 every morsel she takes, and it goes hard with herself,

- 325 so I have lain awake through many an unsleeping night
and fought through bloody days of battle,
contending with men for the sake of their women.
Twelve cities of men I have sacked from my ships,²⁴
and eleven by land, I tell you, across deep-soiled Troy:
330 from all of them I took out treasure, much and good,
and brought it all and gave it to Agamemnon,
Atreus' son — who waited behind by the swift ships,
took it in, doled out a little, and kept the most.
What he gave the chief men and the kings as prizes
335 stands untouched with them; from me alone of the Achaeans
he took — and he keeps my bed-dear wife. Let him lie beside her²⁵
and take his pleasure! But why must the Argives make war
on the Trojans? Why did Atreus' son gather an army
and lead it here? Was it not for lovely-haired Helen?
340 Are the sons of Atreus alone among mortal men
the ones who love their wives? — since any man who is good
and sensible loves his own and cares for her,
as I loved that one from my heart, spear-won though she was.
Now, since he took my prize out of my hands and cheated me,
345 let him not try me: I know him too well. He will not persuade me.
No, Odysseus — with you and the other kings
let him think how to beat the enemy fire from the ships.
Truly he has labored greatly with me gone:
he has even built a wall, and driven a ditch along it,
350 wide and great, and planted stakes within it —
and even so he cannot hold the strength of man-slaughtering
Hector! While I was fighting among the Achaeans,
Hector had no wish to raise battle away from his wall;
he came only as far as the Scaean Gates and the oak.²⁶
355 There once he stood up to me alone — and barely escaped my charge.
But now, since I have no wish to fight brilliant Hector,
tomorrow I will sacrifice to Zeus and all the gods,
load my ships well, and drag them down to the sea —
and you will see, if you care to, if such things interest you,
360 my ships at earliest light sailing the Hellespont
where the fish swarm, and in them men rowing with a will;

- and if the famed earth-shaker grants fair passage,
on the third day I should reach deep-soiled Phthia.
I have great possessions there, left when I made my luckless
365 journey here; and more from here — gold, red bronze,
fair-belted women, grey iron — I will carry home,
all that fell to me by lot. But my prize — the man who gave it,
the lord Agamemnon, Atreus' son, in his insolence
took it back. Tell him all of it, just as I charge you,
370 openly — so the other Achaeans too may be angry,
if he hopes to cheat some other Danaan yet,
clothed as he always is in shamelessness. And yet —
dog though he is — he would not dare look me in the face.
I will not join him in counsel, and not in action:
375 he cheated me outright, he wronged me. Never again
will he trick me with words. Once is enough. Let him go
to ruin at his ease: Zeus the counselor has taken his wits.
His gifts are hateful to me; I count him at a hair's worth.²⁷
Not if he gave me ten times as much, and twenty times,
380 all he has now and more from elsewhere besides;
not all the revenue of Orchomenus, or of Thebes —
Egyptian Thebes, where the houses hold the greatest treasures,
the city of a hundred gates, and through each gate
two hundred men drive out with horses and chariots;
385 not if he gave me gifts as many as the sand and dust —
not even so would Agamemnon persuade my heart
until he has paid me back all the outrage that galls it.
And the daughter of Agamemnon, Atreus' son — I will not
marry her: not if she rivaled golden Aphrodite in beauty
390 and matched the works of grey-eyed Athena.
Not even so will I marry her. Let him choose another Achaean,
one who suits him — someone more kingly than I.
For if the gods preserve me, and I come home,
Pelex himself will find me a wife.²⁸
395 There are Achaean girls enough through Hellas and through Phthia,
daughters of chieftains, men who guard their citadels:
of these I will make whichever one I choose my own dear wife.
There — that is where my proud heart kept urging me:

- to take a wedded wife, a fitting bride,
 400 and enjoy the possessions old Peleus won.
 For not worth my life is all they say was stored²⁹
 in Ilion, that well-peopled citadel,
 before, in peacetime, before the sons of the Achaeans came —
 nor all the stone threshold of the Archer holds within it,
 405 Phoebus Apollo's, in rocky Pytho.
 Cattle can be lifted, and fat sheep;
 tripods can be won, and the tawny heads of horses:
 but a man's life cannot be lifted back, cannot be caught,
 once it has crossed the fence of his teeth.
 410 For my mother tells me — Thetis, the goddess of the silver feet —³⁰
 that two fates carry me toward the end of death:
 if I stay here and fight around the Trojans' city,
 my homecoming is lost — but my fame will be imperishable;
 and if I come home to my dear fatherland,
 415 my noble fame is lost — but my life will be long,
 and the end of death will not be quick to find me.
 And to the rest of you I would give this counsel:
 sail home — since you will never now reach the end
 of steep Ilion: wide-seeing Zeus has held
 420 his hand over her, and her people have taken heart.
 So go; and carry my message to the chief men
 of the Achaeans — that is the honor-portion of the old —
 so they may devise in their minds some better plan
 to save the ships, and the Achaean host
 425 beside the hollow ships: since this one — this they thought of —
 will not serve, while my anger stands. But Phoenix —
 let him stay and sleep here with us,
 so he may follow in my ships to our dear fatherland
 tomorrow, if he wishes. I will not take him by force."
 430 So he spoke, and they all went still in silence,
 marveling at his word: he had refused with great power.
 At long last the old horseman Phoenix spoke,³¹
 bursting into tears, in terrible fear for the ships:
 "If it is homecoming you now ponder, shining Achilles,
 435 and you will not lift ruinous fire from the swift ships

at all, because anger has fallen on your heart —
 how then could I be left here without you, dear child,
 alone? It was to you the old horseman Peleus sent me
 the day he sent you out of Phthia to Agamemnon,
 440 a child still, knowing nothing yet of leveling war,
 nothing of assemblies, where men become preeminent.
 For that he sent me: to teach you all these things —
 to be a speaker of words, and a doer of deeds.
 After all that, dear child, I would not choose to be left
 445 without you — no, not if a god himself should promise
 to scrape old age from me and set me young again,
 as I was when I first left Hellas of the beautiful women,
 fleeing a quarrel with my father, Amyntor, Ormenus' son.³²
 He was enraged with me over his lovely-haired concubine:
 450 he loved her, and dishonored his own wife,
 my mother; and my mother begged me endlessly by my knees
 to lie with the concubine first, so she would loathe the old man.
 I obeyed her, and did it. And my father, guessing at once,
 cursed me long and hard, and called up the hateful Erinyes:
 455 that never should a dear son born of me
 be set upon his knees. And the gods fulfilled his curses —
 Zeus of the world below, and dread Persephone.

[Lines 458-461 are absent from the printed text; see note 32.]

Then the heart in my chest could no longer be held at all
 to linger in the halls of my angry father.
 Kinsmen and cousins in plenty, gathered around me,
 465 held me there in the halls with their begging:
 many a fat sheep and rolling-gaited crook-horned ox
 they slaughtered; many a hog rich in lard
 was stretched to singe across the flame of Hephaestus,
 and much of the old man's wine was drunk from the jars.
 470 Nine nights together they kept their watch around me;
 they took the guard in turns, and the fires never died —
 one under the colonnade of the strong-fenced court,
 one in the porch, before my bedchamber doors.
 But when the tenth dark night came on me,
 475 then I burst the close-fitted doors of my chamber

- and got out, and vaulted the courtyard fence
lightly, unseen by the watchmen and the slave-women.
Then I fled far away through Hellas of the wide spaces
and came to deep-soiled Phthia, mother of flocks,
480 to lord Peleus. And he received me with a ready heart,
and loved me as a father loves his son,
his only son, late-born, heir to great possessions;
and he made me rich, and gave me a numerous people:
I lived at the edge of Phthia, ruling the Dolopes.
- 485 And I made you what you are, Achilles like the gods,³³
loving you from my heart: you would not go with another
to the feast, or eat in the halls,
until I had sat you on my knees and cut
the first bit of meat for you, and held the wine to your lips.
- 490 Many a time you soaked the tunic on my chest,
spitting up wine in your troublesome babyhood.
So I suffered much for you, and toiled much,
minding always that the gods would bring no child of mine
to birth; no — I made you my child, godlike Achilles,
495 so that someday you might ward unseemly ruin from me.
Achilles — break your great spirit. It does not become you
to keep a pitiless heart. Even the gods themselves can bend,
and theirs is the greater excellence, honor, and strength:
with burnt offerings and gentle vows,
500 with libation and savor, men turn even them
by their prayers, when a man has transgressed and gone wrong.
For Prayers, too, are daughters of great Zeus —³⁴
lame, and wrinkled, and eyes turned aside,
who make it their care to follow after Blindness.
- 505 But Blindness is strong and sound of foot, and far outruns them
all, and gets in first over all the earth
tripping mankind; and they come healing after.
Now the man who respects the daughters of Zeus when they approach,
him they greatly bless, and hear him when he prays;
510 but when a man denies them and stiffly refuses,
they go to Zeus, Cronos' son, and pray
that Blindness go with that man, till he trips, and pays in full.

So you too, Achilles — grant the daughters of Zeus
 their due of honor, which bends the will of others, and good men too.
 515 If Atreus' son were not bringing gifts, and naming more
 to come — if he raged on furiously still —
 I would not be the one to tell you: throw your wrath away
 and defend the Argives, however much they need it.
 But now he gives much at once, and has promised more hereafter,
 520 and has sent out the best men to entreat you,
 chosen through the Achaean host, the men who are dearest
 to you yourself of the Argives. Do not shame their words
 or their coming; till now, no one could blame your anger.
 So it was with the men before us too — the fames we hear of,
 525 heroes of old, when furious anger came on one of them:
 they could be won by gifts, and won over by words.
 I remember this deed of old — no new thing —
 how it was; and I will tell it among you, friends, all of you.
 The Curetes were fighting, and the battle-biding Aetolians,³⁵
 530 around the city of Calydon, and killing one another —
 the Aetolians in defense of lovely Calydon,
 the Curetes raging to sack it in war.
 For golden-throned Artemis had raised that evil among them,
 in anger that Oeneus brought no harvest-offering
 535 from his orchard slope: the other gods feasted on hecatombs,
 and to her alone, great Zeus's daughter, he offered nothing —
 he forgot, or he did not think of it: a great blindness of heart.
 Enraged, the child of Zeus who showers arrows
 roused against him a wild boar, white-tusked ravager,
 540 who did great damage, haunting Oeneus' orchard land,
 tearing up tall trees and hurling them to the ground,
 roots and all, apple-blossom and all.
 Him the son of Oeneus killed — Meleager —
 when he had gathered huntsmen out of many cities,
 545 and hounds: for the boar was not brought down by few men,
 so huge he was; and he set many on the pyre of grief.
 But around the carcass the goddess raised a great clamor and battle-
 cry,
 over the boar's head and the bristling hide,

- between the Curetes and the great-hearted Aetolians.
- 550 Now as long as Meleager dear to Ares fought,
 so long it went hard with the Curetes; they could not
 hold their ground outside the wall, though they were many.
 But when anger entered Meleager — anger that swells
 in the chests of others too, even the close-thinking —
- 555 enraged at his own mother Althaea, he lay idle
 beside his wedded wife, beautiful Cleopatra,
 daughter of Marpessa of the beautiful ankles, Euenus' child,
 and of Idas, strongest of men on the earth
 in his time — who even lifted his bow against the lord
- 560 Phoebus Apollo, for the sake of his lovely-ankled bride.
 Her, in those days, in their halls her father and lady mother
 called by the name Alcyone — halcyon — because
 her own mother, with the mourning halcyon's fate upon her,
 wept when Phoebus Apollo the worker-from-afar snatched her away.
- 565 By her Meleager lay, digesting his heart-paining anger,
 enraged at his mother's curses: for she prayed the gods
 against him, in her grief for a brother's killing —
 over and over she beat the earth that feeds so many with her hands,
 calling on Hades and dread Persephone,
- 570 crouched on her knees, her bosom wet with tears,
 to give her son death; and out of Erebus an Erinys
 who walks in mist heard her, with her unappeasable heart.
 Soon the din of the enemy rose around the gates, the thud
 of towers battered; and the Aetolian elders begged him,
- 575 sending the gods' chosen priests:
 come out and defend us — and they promised a great gift:
 where the plain of lovely Calydon was fattest,
 there they bade him choose a beautiful precinct,
 fifty fields broad, half of it vineyard,
- 580 half open plowland, cut from the plain.
 And the old horseman Oeneus begged him over and over,
 standing at the threshold of his high-roofed chamber,
 shaking the bolted doors, entreating his son;
 over and over his sisters and his lady mother
- 585 begged him — he refused the more — and his companions,

- the truest and dearest of them all:
 but not even so could they move the heart in his chest —
 until the chamber itself was under thick bombardment, and the Curetes
 were scaling the towers and firing the great city.
- 590 Then at last his fair-belted wife begged Meleager,
 wailing, and counted out for him all
 the griefs that come to people whose city is taken:
 the men killed, the town burned down to ash,
 the children led away by strangers, and the deep-belted women.
- 595 And his heart was stirred as he heard those terrible things:
 he went out, and clothed his body in shining armor.
 So he beat the evil day back from the Aetolians,
 yielding to his own heart. And they no longer made good
 the gifts, the many gracious gifts; yet he ward off the evil all the
 same.
- 600 But you — do not think that way in your heart; do not let a god
 turn you that way, dear boy. It would be worse
 to defend the ships already burning. While there are gifts,
 come: the Achaeans will honor you like a god.
 But if without gifts you enter man-destroying war,
- 605 you will not be honored the same, though you beat the war away."
 Answering him spoke swift-footed Achilles:
 "Phoenix, old father, aged one, Zeus-nurtured: I have no need³⁶
 of that honor. I judge that I am honored by the portion of Zeus,
 which will keep me here by the beaked ships as long as breath
- 610 stays in my chest and my knees have their spring.
 And I will tell you another thing — put it away in your heart:
 do not blur my heart with weeping and grieving
 to gratify the hero son of Atreus. You must not
 love him, or my love for you may turn to hatred.
- 615 It is right for you to wound the man who wounds me.
 Be king equally with me; take half my honor.
 These men will carry the message; you stay here and sleep
 in a soft bed; and with the showing of Dawn
 we will decide whether to go to our own country, or to stay."
- 620 He spoke, and with his brows signed silently to Patroclus
 to spread a thick bed for Phoenix, so the others

might think the sooner of leaving the hut. And Ajax,
 Telamon's godlike son, spoke his word among them:
 "Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus of many devices —³⁷
 625 let us go. I do not think the end of this errand
 will be reached by this road. We must report the word,
 unwelcome as it is, to the Danaans with all speed —
 they sit waiting for it now. But Achilles
 has made the great-hearted spirit in his chest a savage thing —
 630 the hard man! — and cares nothing for the love of his companions,
 the love we honored him with by the ships beyond all others.
 Pitiless! And yet a man accepts blood-price
 even from his brother's killer, even for his own dead son;
 and the killer stays in his own country, having paid the great price,
 635 and the kinsman's heart and proud spirit are held in check
 once he has taken the price. But you — the gods have set
 in your chest an anger unending, and evil, over a girl —
 one girl! — while we now offer you seven, far the best,
 and much else besides. Put a gracious spirit in you;
 640 respect your own roof: we are under it,
 out of the whole Danaan host; and beyond all others we have longed
 to be nearest to you and dearest of all the Achaeans."
 Answering him spoke swift-footed Achilles:
 "Ajax, Zeus-sprung son of Telamon, marshal of the people:
 645 everything you have said is very nearly after my own heart.
 But my heart swells with rage whenever I remember
 those things — how Atreus' son treated me like dirt among the
 Argives,³⁸
 as if I were some vagrant without honor.
 But you two go, and carry back my message:
 650 I will not think of bloody war again
 until brilliant Hector, war-minded Priam's son,
 comes killing Argives right up to the huts and ships
 of the Myrmidons, and blackens the ships with fire.
 At my hut, though — at my black ship — I think
 655 Hector will be stopped, for all his hunger for battle."
 So he spoke; and each of them took a two-handled cup,
 poured the libation, and went back along the ships, Odysseus leading.

- And Patroclus told his companions and the slave-women
to spread a thick bed for Phoenix with all speed;
660 and they obeyed, and spread the bed as he commanded —
fleeces, a rug, and a fine flare of linen.
There the old man lay down, and waited for brilliant Dawn.
And Achilles slept in the innermost corner of the strong-built hut,
and beside him lay a woman he had brought from Lesbos:³⁹
665 Phorbas's daughter, fair-cheeked Diomede.
And Patroclus lay down on the other side, and by him too
lay fair-belted Iphis, whom brilliant Achilles gave him
when he took steep Scyros, Enyeus' citadel.
Now when the envoys were back in the huts of Atreus' son,
670 the sons of the Achaeans, springing up on every side,
pledged them with golden cups, and pressed their questions;
and the lord of men Agamemnon asked first:
"Come, tell me, Odysseus of the many tales, great glory of the
Achaeans:
is he willing to beat the enemy fire from the ships,
675 or did he refuse — does anger still hold that great-hearted spirit?"
Then answered him much-enduring brilliant Odysseus:
"Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of men Agamemnon:
that man has no will to quench his anger — he is filled
fuller yet with fury; he refuses you, and your gifts.
680 He bids you take counsel yourself, among the Argives,
how you may save the ships and the Achaean host;
and he himself threatens, with the showing of Dawn,⁴⁰
to drag his well-benched, well-curved ships to the sea.
And he said he would counsel the others too
685 to sail for home — since you will never now reach the end
of steep Ilion: wide-seeing Zeus has held
his hand over her, and her people have taken heart.
So he spoke. And here are these to confirm it, who went with me:
Ajax, and the two heralds, wise men both.
690 But old Phoenix has laid himself down there — as Achilles bade —
so he may follow in the ships to his dear fatherland
tomorrow, if he wishes; he will not take him by force."
So he spoke, and they all went still in silence,

- marveling at his word: he had spoken with great power.
- 695 A long while the sons of the Achaeans sat mute, dejected;
and at long last Diomedes, good at the war-cry, spoke:
"Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of men Agamemnon:⁴¹
would you had never begged the blameless son of Peleus,
offering gifts past counting. He is proud at the best of times,
700 and now you have driven him deeper into pride by far.
No — let us leave him be: whether he goes
or stays; he will fight again whenever
the heart in his chest commands him, and the god rouses him.
Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:
705 sleep now, when you have taken your hearts' content
of bread and wine — for in them are fury and valor;
and when the beautiful rosy-fingered Dawn appears,
marshal the men and the horses quickly before the ships,
urging them on — and fight yourself among the first."
710 So he spoke, and all the kings approved,
marveling at the word of Diomedes, breaker of horses.
Then they poured libation, and went each man to his hut,
and there they lay down, and took the gift of sleep.

NOTES TO BOOK 9

- 1 ll. 1-8 Panic (Φύζα) "companion of icy Rout" — the war-demons of 4.440 gain another member; and the two-winds simile makes the army's heart a sea worked by opposed gales: the book's whole subject — a mind torn two ways — announced in weather.
- 2 ll. 14-15 Agamemnon weeps "like a spring of dark water" pouring down a cliff — the exact simile that will describe Patroclus weeping for the dying Achaeans at 16.3-4. The poem opens its two great turning-points, the embassy and the Patrocleia, with the same tears. (Echo note; English will repeat verbatim there.)
- 3 ll. 17-28 Agamemnon repeats his own test-speech of 2.110-118 and 139-141 word for word (the English repeats the Book 2 rendering) — but this time he means it. The counterfeit despair of Book 2 has become real, and no Odysseus rises to stop the flight: only Diomedes.
- 4 ll. 32-49 Diomedes' answer — the payoff planted at 4.401-402, where he took Agamemnon's insult in silence "where it is right" now claims the assembly's license: "it is you I will fight first — your folly." The scepter/courage antithesis (37-39) dismantles Agamemnon's authority with surgical courtesy. Aristarchus athetized 44.
- 5 ll. 63-64 "Clanless, lawless, hearthless is the man who is in love with war among his own people" — Nestor's anathema on civil strife, the most quoted political sentence in the poem after 2.204; the triple alpha-privative (ἀφρήτωρ ἀθέμιτος ἀνέστιος) strips the stasis-lover of every circle of belonging.
- 6 ll. 70-72 Wine-ships from Thrace "daily" — with 7.467-475 (Lemnos), the poem's second glimpse of the supply-economy behind the war.
- 7 ll. 97-99 "Zeus has put into your hands the scepter and the ordinances" — Odysseus's crowd-control theology of 2.205-206, now recited to the king as obligation rather than of him as privilege: with the scepter comes the duty to listen.
- 8 ll. 115-120 "Blinded I was — I do not deny it" (ἄσάμην): Agamemnon at last speaks the ἄτη-word of 1.412 and 2.111 in the first person. A line quoted by Athenaeus adds after 119: "or maddened with wine, or the gods themselves harmed me" (apparatus, Line 119) — an ancient plus-verse softening the confession that the vulgate leaves bare. His fullest self-exculpation waits for 19.86-138.
- 9 ll. 121-157 The catalogue of gifts: seven tripods, ten talents, twenty cauldrons, twelve racehorses, seven women of Lesbos, Briseis with an oath, and on the far side of victory a ship's hold of treasure, twenty Trojan women, a royal marriage "without bride-price" (146 — the suitor's payment waived and reversed: Agamemnon dowers the groom), and seven cities. It is a king's ransom — and every item denominates honor in exactly the currency Achilles is about to declare bankrupt.
- 10 ll. 132-134 The oath that he never touched Briseis — offered unprompted, and revealing what the quarrel's language of "prizes" had buried: that this is also about a woman's bed,

and that Agamemnon knows it. He will swear it publicly at 19.258-265.

- 11 *ll. 144-145* Chrysothemis, Laodice, Iphianassa: no Electra, and an Iphianassa alive and marriageable in the war's tenth year — the Iliad appears not to know (or pointedly ignores) the sacrifice of Iphigenia at Aulis. The tragedians' house of Atreus is not yet this poem's.
- 12 *ll. 149-156* The seven cities stand on the Messenian coast, "on the edge of sandy Pylos" — inside Nestor's sphere, not Agamemnon's: ancient critics already asked by what right he gives them away. Royal gift-geography is aspirational; the point is the scale.
- 13 *ll. 158-161* The poison pill: "Let him be broken (δμηθήτω)... and let him yield place to me, by as much as I am more kingly." The gift-list ends by re-enacting the original offense — the gifts are to purchase not reconciliation but submission. Odysseus will cut these lines in the retelling (note [20]).
- 14 *ll. 168-170* The envoys: Phoenix — Achilles' own tutor, somehow present in Agamemnon's council — to lead; then Ajax and Odysseus, with two heralds (this Odys is not the Halizone captain of 2.856). The oddity of Phoenix's presence and the dual verbs that follow (note [15]) have fed two centuries of analysis about whether his role was a later expansion. The poem's own logic is plain: it sends Achilles' three loves — his teacher, his bluntest peer, and the army's best voice.
- 15 *ll. 182-198* The famous duals: "the two of them went... the two came... greeting the two of them" — the Greek uses strict dual verbs for a party of three envoys plus two heralds. Ancient solutions (Aristarchus: the duals cover only the two principals; others: Phoenix went ahead) and modern ones (an older two-man embassy, with Phoenix stitched in later; or the heralds as the pair) all leave a seam showing. The translation renders every dual visibly as "the two," per project policy, so the crux is present in English rather than smoothed away.
- 16 *ll. 186-191* Achilles singing "the fames of men" (κλέα ἀνδρῶν) to a lyre taken at the sack of Eëtion's Thebe — Andromache's city (6.414-428). The poem's only scene of epic performed shows its greatest hero as the singer, and his instrument as spoil of the very raid whose griefs thread the poem; while Patroclus waits, silent, for his turn in the song. What Achilles sings, he is choosing between at 410-416.
- 17 *ll. 197-198, 202-220* "You who even in my anger are dearest to me" — the greeting concedes at once what the answers will struggle to unsay. The hosting is done by the heroes' own hands (Patroclus mixing "stronger" wine, Achilles carving) — the full feast type-scene performed personally: the quarrel is with one man, not with fellowship.
- 19 *ll. 252-259* Odysseus quotes Peleus's parting advice verbatim — "rein in the great-hearted spirit... break off strife" — the absent-father motif (cf. 7.124-128) turned into an instrument of persuasion. Whether Odysseus actually heard it (he was there, 11.765-790 implies) or reconstructs what fathers say, it is the speech's shrewdest stroke — and its failure measures how far Achilles now stands from Phthia's ethics.
- 20 *ll. 264-299* The relay: Odysseus repeats the catalogue word for word (the English repeats it too, person-shifted, per policy) — and stops at 299. The poison lines (158-161, "let him yield to me...") are silently omitted, and in their place he pivots to pity for the army and

the bait of Hector's nearness (300-306). The poem's masterclass in diplomatic editing: fidelity as technique, suppression as tact. Achilles' "hateful as the gates of Hades" answer suggests he smells the redaction anyway.

- 21 *ll. 308-314* "Hateful to me as the gates of Hades is the man who hides one thing in his mind and says another": the referent is contested — a warning aimed at Odysseus the professional speaker standing before him, or at the absent Agamemnon, the actual hider-and-sayer of the quarrel? The translation keeps the generalizing third person that lets both targets stand. Plato quotes the passage (Hippias Minor 365a) in just this connection — Achilles the plain speaker against Odysseus the polytropic.
- 22 *ll. 318-321* "The portion is equal for the man who hangs back and the man who fights hard; in one honor stand the coward and the brave; death comes alike..." — the sentence that unmakes the poem's social contract. If *timē* no longer tracks merit, the whole exchange-economy of prizes, and the war built on it, loses its reason. This is the radical center of the book: not a bigger price demanded, but the currency refused.
- 23 *ll. 323-327* Achilles as mother-bird, carrying every morsel to unfledged chicks "and it goes hard with herself" — the fighter's self-image as feeder and nurturer, gender-crossed; the tenderest simile any warrior applies to himself in the poem.
- 24 *ll. 328-336* Twelve cities by sea, eleven by land: the sack-list that stocked the poem's backstory (Thebe, Lyrnessus, Lesbos, Scyros...) — all carried to Agamemnon, "who waited behind by the swift ships." The distribution-economy described from the point of view of its producer.
- 25 *ll. 336-343* "He keeps my bed-dear wife (ἄλοχον θυμαρέα)... as I loved that one from my heart, spear-won though she was." Achilles calls Briseis by the word for wedded wife, and answers the whole war's premise with a question — "are the sons of Atreus alone among mortal men the ones who love their wives?" The captive "prize" of Book 1 is re-described as a loved woman; Briseis's own voice, confirming, comes at 19.287-300.
- 26 *ll. 354-355* "only as far as the Scaean Gates and the oak" — the landmark of 7.22 and 6.237; Achilles' memory of a Hector who would not fight in the open is the exact inverse of the Hector of Book 8, and both are true in their seasons of divine favor.
- 27 *ll. 378-387* "I count him at a hair's worth" (ἐν καρὸς αἴσῃ) — and the great refusal-crescendo: ten times, twenty times the gifts; the wealth of Orchomenus; "Egyptian Thebes, the city of a hundred gates" (the Iliad's only mention of Egypt); gifts like sand and dust. Not until "he has paid me back all the outrage" — a price no catalogue can denominate.
- 28 *ll. 388-400* The marriage refused: "Peleus himself will find me a wife." Against Agamemnon's dynastic offer Achilles sets an ordinary happiness — a local bride, his father's goods — spoken by the one man in the poem who knows (410-416) he will never have it.
- 29 *ll. 401-409* "Not worth my life (ψυχῆς ἀντάξιον)": cattle can be raided, tripods won, "but a man's life cannot be lifted back... once it has crossed the fence of his teeth." The formula for guarded speech (4.350) turned into the body's last gate — words return, breath does

not. This is the poem's deepest sentence against its own heroic premise, and the Odyssey's Achilles in the underworld will say it again in other words.

- 30 *ll. 410-416* The two fates: stay and win "imperishable fame" (κλέος ἄφθιτον — the oldest phrase of Indo-European praise-poetry, cognate formulas in the Vedas), or go home to long, fameless life. Only Achilles receives destiny as a menu; and the poem that preserves his fame is itself the content of the first option — the choice is between existing in epic and existing. Zenodotus omitted and Aristarchus athetized 416.
- 31 *ll. 432-445* Phoenix: guardian of Achilles' boyhood, teacher of the heroic double curriculum — "a speaker of words, and a doer of deeds" (443) — the poem's one-line definition of the complete man, spoken by the man who taught it to its greatest exemplar.
- 32 *ll. 447-461* Phoenix's own story: his father's concubine, his mother's plea, the old man's curse of childlessness sworn to the Erinyes and ratified by "Zeus of the world below" (Hades) "and dread Persephone." At this point the vulgate — and the Oxford text — omits four lines (458-461), and the numbering jumps: preserved only by Plutarch (*How to Study Poetry* 26f), they read, in translation: "Then I planned in my heart to cut him down with the sharp bronze; but some immortal checked my anger, putting in my heart the people's talk and the many reproaches of men, that I might not be called a father-killer among the Achaeans." Aristarchus athetized them for their shocking content, and the printed tradition dropped them so thoroughly that editors since Wolf (1785) have had to reinsert them from Plutarch (apparatus, Line 457). The translation reproduces the transmitted gap; the suppressed confession — Phoenix nearly a parricide, saved by fear of what men would say — is the darkest mirror the poem holds up to anger mastered.
- 33 *ll. 485-495* Phoenix nursing the baby Achilles — cutting his meat, holding the wine, the tunic soaked "in your troublesome babyhood": the war's most terrifying fighter recalled as a spitting infant, by the childless man who made him his child. The plea's authority is this memory, and its failure is measured by it.
- 34 *ll. 502-514* The Litai — the Prayers: daughters of Zeus, "lame, and wrinkled, and eyes turned aside," limping forever after swift, strong Blindness (Ἄτη) to heal what she wrecks; scorn them, and they ask Zeus to send Atē against the scorner. The poem's only sustained allegory, and its moral crux: within the fiction, Achilles' refusal of these suppliants files the request that his own ruin follow — as it does, through Patroclus. The ἄτη-thread (1.412, 2.111, 9.115, 19.91-136 where Agamemnon tells Atē's own myth) runs straight through this passage.
- 35 *ll. 524-599* The Meleager paradigm — the poem in miniature, told to its own hero: Artemis slighted (the same forgotten-sacrifice motif, with the ἄτη-verb at 537), the boar, the wrath, the hero idle beside his wife while his city burns; the ladder of suppliants — priests and elders with a gift of land, father at the threshold, sisters, mother, dearest companions — all refused; then the wife, Cleopatra, with her catalogue of a sacked city's griefs; he yields, fights, saves them — "and they no longer made good the gifts." Every rung maps onto Achilles' own night (elders-with-gifts = Odysseus; father-figure = Phoenix; companions = Ajax), and the poem's audience can finish the map: the beloved whose plea will finally move Achilles is the one sitting silent in this very hut — and

Meleager's wife bears the name Cleopatra, "famed of her fathers," Patroclus's name with its elements reversed. The onomastic mirror was noticed in antiquity and remains the most elegant argument in Homer. (The Marpessa-Idas digression, 557-564 — a mortal who drew his bow on Apollo for love, and a wife nicknamed Halcyon for her mother's mourning — folds yet another tale of defiance and grief inside the paradigm.) Phoenix's warning lands askew: Meleager's lesson as told is "yield before it is too late for gifts," but its buried lesson is "the wife's plea — the Cleopatra — comes last, and works." Book 16 is that plea.

- 36 *ll. 606-619* To Phoenix, the first softening: "I am honored by the portion of Zeus" (the replacement for the army's failed *timē*); "be king equally with me; take half my honor"; and the schedule slips — from "tomorrow I sail" (357-363) to "at dawn we will decide whether to go or stay." ἄττα, "old father" — the nursery word — enters the register in the same breath as the threat to hate whomever Phoenix loves.
- 37 *ll. 624-642* Ajax, to Odysseus, about Achilles, in front of him — the bluntest speech in the poem: a man takes blood-price (*ποινὴ*) even for a murdered brother or son, and the killer walks his own country; Achilles is implacable "over a girl — one girl! — while we offer seven." The argument from composition for homicide is the strongest yet — it names the going rate for the unpayable — and its miss is the most revealing: the wrong is no longer priced in girls at all. Then the master-stroke of the plain man: "respect your own roof: we are under it" — the *xenia*-claim, which is the one Achilles grants.
- 38 *ll. 643-655* The third answer, to Ajax: "everything you have said is very nearly after my own heart" — and the line that started it all restated raw: he treated me "as if I were some vagrant without honor (*ἀτίμητον μετανάστην*).\" Then the third position: not sailing, not deciding at dawn, but — I fight when Hector reaches the ships of the Myrmidons. Refusal has become a timetable; the plot of Books 11-16 is Achilles' own sentence coming true at his hut, where Hector is indeed stopped — by Patroclus's death.
- 39 *ll. 658-668* The beds: Phoenix's made by the slave-women; Achilles with Diomedes of Lesbos, Patroclus with Iphis, taken at Scyros — the sack-list of 328-329 embodied in the hut's sleeping arrangements; each concubine a city. The embassy departs one man lighter: Phoenix stays, the first crack in Achilles' isolation.
- 40 *ll. 673-692* The report: to "Odysseus of the many tales" (*πολύαινος* — new epithet, register), Odysseus repeats Achilles' first answer verbatim (682-687 = 417-420, English likewise) — and reports nothing of the second or third: not "at dawn we decide," not "when Hector reaches my ships." The editor of the offer (note [20]) now edits the refusal, presenting the council with the starkest version — whether as rigor, or despair, or policy is the reader's to judge. Aristarchus athetized 688-692, Zenodotus 692.
- 41 *ll. 693-709* Diomedes closes the book he opened: "would you had never begged him... he will fight again whenever the heart in his chest commands him, and the god rouses him" — the truest prophecy in the book, and the completion of the arc from the silent young man of 4.401 to the voice the kings applaud into the night. Eat, sleep, fight at dawn: the war goes on without its best man, which is exactly what Books 10-15 now show.

Iliad — Book 10

*A night raid: Odysseus and Diomedes catch the Trojan spy Dolon, kill
King Rhesus in his sleep, and steal his horses.*

- The other captains of all the Achaeans by the ships¹
 slept the whole night through, mastered by soft sleep;²
 but not Atreus' son Agamemnon, shepherd of the people —
 sweet sleep did not hold him, his mind churning many things.
- 5 As when the husband of lovely-haired Hera flashes lightning,
 working a huge rain beyond all telling, or hail,
 or a snowstorm, when snow powders over the plowlands,
 or somewhere the great mouth of bitter war,³
 so thick and fast came the groans of Agamemnon in his chest,
- 10 from the bottom of his heart; and his mind shook within him.
 Whenever he looked out toward the Trojan plain,
 he marveled at the many fires burning before Ilion,
 at the voice of flutes and pipes, and the din of men;⁴
 but whenever he looked at the ships and the Achaean host,
- 15 he tore the hair from his head out by the roots
 before Zeus on high, and his glorious heart groaned greatly.
 And this to his mind seemed the best counsel:
 to go first of all men to Nestor, Neleus' son,
 and see whether with him he might build some blameless plan
- 20 that would prove a warder-off of evil for all the Danaans.
 He rose upright, and put his tunic on about his chest,
 and beneath his shining feet he bound fair sandals,
 and after that wrapped round him the blood-red hide of a lion,
 fiery, huge, reaching his feet; and he took up a spear.
- 25 In the same way trembling held Menelaus; on his eyelids
 either, sleep would not settle: for fear something befall
 the Argives, who for his sake across so much water
 had come to Troy, nursing their audacious war.
 First he covered his broad back with the skin of a leopard,⁵
- 30 dappled; and then he lifted a rimmed helmet of bronze
 and set it on his head, and took a spear in his thick hand.

- Then he went to rouse his brother, who ruled with might
over all the Argives, honored by the people like a god.
He found him putting his fine armor about his shoulders
35 by the stern of his ship; and his coming was welcome to him.
Menelaus, good at the war-cry, spoke to him first:
"Elder brother, why arm yourself so? Is it to rouse
some companion to spy upon the Trojans? I am afraid,
badly afraid, that no one will undertake that work for you —
40 to go out alone against the enemy men, and scout them,
through the ambrosial night. It will need a very bold heart."
Answering him spoke the lord Agamemnon:
"There is need of counsel, Zeus-nurtured Menelaus, for me
and for you — cunning counsel, that will protect and save
45 the Argives and the ships; for the mind of Zeus has turned:
his heart is set now rather on Hector's sacrifices.
For never have I seen, nor heard a man tell of it,
one man contriving so much havoc in one day
as Hector, dear to Zeus, has done against the sons of the Achaeans,
50 unaided — no dear son of a goddess or a god.
He has done deeds that I tell you will be the Argives' concern
long and lastingly — such evils he has devised against the Achaeans.⁶
But go now, run beside the ships, and call
Ajax and Idomeneus; and I will go to brilliant Nestor
55 and urge him to rise — to see if he is willing
to go to the sacred company of the guards, and give the orders.
They would obey him soonest, for his own son
is a commander of the guards, with Idomeneus' aide
Meriones; to them above all others we gave the charge."
60 Then answered him Menelaus, good at the war-cry:
"How do you mean this word of command you give me?
Do I stay there with them, waiting until you come,
or run after you again, once I have delivered your orders?"
Then the lord of men Agamemnon answered him:
65 "Stay there, so that we do not miss one another
as we come and go; there are many paths through the camp.
Call out, wherever you go, and bid them stay awake,
naming each man from his father, by his lineage,⁷

- giving every man his honor. Do not be lofty in spirit;
70 no, let us do the labor ourselves, we too. This must be
the heavy misery Zeus laid on us at our very birth."
So speaking, he sent his brother off with clear instructions,
and set out himself for Nestor, shepherd of the people.
He found him beside his hut and his black ship,
75 in a soft bed; beside him lay his intricate gear —
a shield, and two spears, and a shining helmet;
beside him lay the glittering war-belt the old man girded on
whenever he armed himself for man-destroying war
and led out his people; he made no concession to grim old age.
80 He raised himself up on his elbow, lifted his head,
and spoke to Atreus' son, questioning him with a word:
"Who are you, walking alone through the camp among the ships
in the murky night, when other mortals are sleeping?
Seeking one of your mules, or one of your companions?"
85 Speak — do not come at me silent. What is your need?"
Then answered him the lord of men Agamemnon:
"Nestor, Neleus' son, great glory of the Achaeans,
you will know Atreus' son Agamemnon — the man whom Zeus
beyond all men has plunged into toils without end, while breath
90 stays in my chest and my knees have their spring.
I wander so because sweet sleep will not settle on my eyes;
the war is my care, and the sufferings of the Achaeans.
I fear terribly for the Danaans. My heart is not
steady; I am storm-tossed; the heart leaps out of my chest,
95 and my shining limbs tremble beneath me.
But if you will bestir yourself — since sleep has not come to you either
—
come, let us go down to the guards, and look:
for fear that, sodden with weariness and with sleep,
they have dropped off, and forgotten the watch entirely.
100 Enemy men are camped close by, and we know nothing:
they might even be minded to fight us in the night."
Then answered him the Gerenian horseman Nestor:
"Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of men Agamemnon,
surely not all of Hector's designs will Zeus the counselor

- 105 accomplish for him — all he now hopes. I think instead
 he will sweat under troubles even more than ours, if once Achilles
 turns his own heart back from its galling anger.
 And I will follow you, gladly. But let us wake others as well:
 Tydeus' son, famed with the spear, and Odysseus,
 110 and swift Ajax, and the stout son of Phyleus.⁹
 And if someone would also go and summon the rest —
 godlike Ajax, and the lord Idomeneus,
 whose ships are the farthest off of all, nowhere near us.
 But Menelaus — dear though he is to me, and respected —
 115 I will fault him, though you may resent me; I will not hide it:¹⁰
 he sleeps, and has left the labor to you alone.
 Now is when he should be laboring among all the captains,
 pleading with them; the need that has come will not be borne."
 Then the lord of men Agamemnon answered him:
 120 "Old man, another day I would even bid you blame him;
 he does often hang back, and is unwilling to labor —
 not that he yields to sloth or thoughtlessness of mind,
 but he looks to me, and waits for my lead.
 This time he woke well before me, and came and stood over me,
 125 and I sent him ahead to summon the very men you ask for.
 Let us go: we shall overtake them before the gates,
 among the guards; for that is where I told them to gather."
 Then answered him the Gerenian horseman Nestor:
 "Then no man of the Argives will resent him
 130 or disobey, when he stirs a man on and gives commands."
 So speaking, he put his tunic on about his chest,
 and beneath his shining feet he bound fair sandals,
 and pinned about himself a purple-red cloak,
 double-folded, full-falling, thick with a nap of wool.
 135 And he took up a stout spear, edged with sharp bronze,
 and went along the ships of the bronze-shirted Achaeans.
 First it was Odysseus, the equal of Zeus in counsel,
 that the Gerenian horseman Nestor woke from sleep,
 calling out; and the voice came quickly about his senses,
 140 and he came out of the hut, and spoke to them a word:
 "Why do you wander alone like this by the ships, through the camp,

- in the ambrosial night — what need is so great upon you?"
 Then answered him the Gerenian horseman Nestor:
 "Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus of many devices,
 145 do not be angry: such grief has overmastered the Achaeans.
 Come with us, so we may wake the next man too, one fit
 to take counsel together, whether to run or fight."
 So he spoke; and resourceful Odysseus, going into the hut,
 put his figured shield about his shoulders, and went with them.
 150 They went on to Tydeus' son Diomedes, and came upon him
 outside his hut with his weapons; and around him his companions
 slept with their shields beneath their heads; their spears
 stood driven upright on their butt-spikes, and far off the bronze
 flashed like the lightning of father Zeus. The hero himself
 155 slept, the hide of a field-ox spread underneath him
 and a bright carpet stretched beneath his head.
 The Gerenian horseman Nestor stood by him and woke him,
 stirring him with a kick of his heel, and scolded him to his face:
 "Wake, son of Tydeus! Why doze away the whole night's sleep?"¹¹
 160 Do you not hear how the Trojans, on the swell of the plain,
 sit close to the ships, and only a little ground still holds them off?"
 So he spoke; and Diomedes started sharply out of sleep,
 and speaking winged words he addressed him:
 "You are a hard one, old man. You never cease from labor.
 165 Are there not other, younger sons of the Achaeans,
 who might go round and wake each of the kings in turn,
 walking everywhere? You are impossible, old man."
 Then answered him the Gerenian horseman Nestor:
 "Yes, friend — all this you have said rightly and in due measure.
 170 I have blameless sons of my own, and I have people,
 plenty of them; one of these might go around and call.
 But a very great need has overmastered the Achaeans:
 now for all of us it stands upon the razor's edge —¹²
 either grim destruction for the Achaeans, or life.
 175 Go then and rouse swift Ajax and the son of Phyleus —
 you are the younger — if you have pity on me."
 So he spoke; and round his shoulders he wrapped the hide of a lion,
 fiery, huge, reaching his feet; and he took up a spear.

- And the hero went, woke those men, and brought them from their places.
- 180 And when they came among the assembled guards,
they did not find the leaders of the watch asleep:
all of them sat wide awake with their weapons.
As dogs around sheep in a fold keep painful watch,
hearing a hard-hearted beast that through the timber
- 185 comes down among the mountains, and much clamor rises
about it from men and dogs, and their sleep is destroyed,
so sweet sleep was destroyed from their eyelids
as they kept watch through the evil night; toward the plain
they were turned always, listening for the Trojans coming.
- 190 The old man rejoiced to see them, and heartened them with a word,
and speaking winged words he addressed them:
"Keep your watch like that, dear children. Let no one
be taken by sleep — or we become a joy to our enemies."
So speaking he swept on across the ditch; and with him followed
- 195 the kings of the Argives, all who had been summoned to council.
With them went Meriones and Nestor's shining son,
for the kings themselves had called them in to share the counsels.
They crossed the deep-dug ditch and seated themselves
in a clear space, where ground showed empty of the dead¹³
- 200 who had fallen — there where massive Hector had turned back
from destroying Argives, when night closed in around them.
There they sat down and declared their words to one another,
and the Gerenian horseman Nestor began to speak among them:
"Friends, will no man put trust enough in his own
- 205 daring heart to go out among the great-hearted
Trojans? He might catch some straggler at the enemy's edge,
or he might even gather some rumor among the Trojans —
what they are counseling among themselves — whether they mean
to stay where they are by the ships, far away, or will withdraw
- 210 back to the city, since they have beaten down the Achaeans.
All that he might learn, and come back to us again
unharméd; and great would his fame be under heaven
among all men, and a noble gift will be his:
for as many of the best men as command the ships,

- 215 of all of those, each single one will give him a black ewe,
a female with lamb at teat — no possession like it —¹⁴
and he will always be included at feasts and banquets."
So he spoke, and they all went still in silence.
And among them spoke Diomedes, good at the war-cry:
- 220 "Nestor, my own heart and my proud spirit urge me
to enter the camp of the enemy men who lie
close by — the Trojans. But if some other man went with me,
there would be more comfort in it, and more boldness too.
When two go together, one marks before the other¹⁵
- 225 where the advantage lies. A man alone may see it,
but his wit is slower, and his cunning thin."
So he spoke; and many were willing to follow Diomedes.
The two Ajaxes were willing, those squires of Ares;
Meriones was willing; most willing, Nestor's son;
- 230 willing was Atreus' son Menelaus, famed with the spear;
and willing was hardy Odysseus to slip into the throng
of the Trojans — the heart in his chest was always daring.
And among them spoke the lord of men Agamemnon:
"Diomedes, Tydeus' son, delight of my heart,
- 235 the companion — you shall choose him yourself, whichever you want,
the best of those who offer themselves; many are eager.
Do not, from deference in your heart, leave the better man
behind, and take the worse to go with you,
yielding to respect, eyeing birth — not even if he is the more kingly."
- 240 So he spoke, and was afraid for tawny-haired Menelaus.¹⁶
And among them spoke again Diomedes, good at the war-cry:
"If you truly bid me choose my companion myself,
how then could I forget godlike Odysseus,
whose heart is forward and whose spirit proud
- 245 in every kind of labor — and Pallas Athena loves him.
With him following me, even out of blazing fire
the two of us would come home; he knows beyond all how to think."
Then answered him much-enduring brilliant Odysseus:
"Tydeus' son, neither praise me overmuch nor blame me;
- 250 these are things known to the Argives you say them among.
Come, let us go. The night is far spent, and dawn is near;

- the stars have moved far on; and more of the night has passed
than two of its parts, and only the third part is left."¹⁷
So the two spoke, and got themselves into their fearsome gear.
- 255 Thrasymedes, steadfast in battle, gave Tydeus' son
a two-edged sword — for his own was left by his ship —
and a shield; and about his head he set a helmet
of bull's hide, ridgeless, crestless — the kind men call
a skull-cap, and it guards the heads of strong young men.¹⁸
- 260 And Meriones gave Odysseus a bow and a quiver
and a sword; and about his head he set a helmet
made of leather; and inside it was strung taut
with many thongs; and outside the white teeth
of a shining-tusked boar were set close along it, this way and that,
265 well and with skill; and in the middle a cap of felt was fitted.
This helmet Autolycus once stole out of Eleon¹⁹
from Amyntor, Ormenus' son, breaking into his close-built house;
he gave it at Scandeia to Amphidamas of Cythera;
Amphidamas gave it to Molus, to be his guest-gift,
270 and Molus gave it to his son Meriones to wear;
and now it was set round the head of Odysseus, and covered it.
And when the two had got themselves into their fearsome gear,
they set out, and left all the best men there in their places.
And close by their road Pallas Athena sent them
275 a heron on the right; their eyes could not see it²⁰
through the murky night, but they heard it cry aloud.
Odysseus rejoiced at the bird-sign, and prayed to Athena:
"Hear me, child of aegis-bearing Zeus — you who always
stand beside me in every labor, and I do not
280 escape your eye when I move: now again love me best, Athena,
and grant that we come back with glory to the ships,
having done a great deed, one that will be the Trojans' concern."
And second in turn prayed Diomedes, good at the war-cry:
"Hear me now also, child of Zeus, Unwearied one.
- 285 Go with me as once you went with my father, brilliant Tydeus,²¹
into Thebes, when he went before the Achaeans as their envoy.
He left the bronze-shirted Achaeans there at the Asopus,
and himself carried a honeyed word to the Cadmeans

- there; but on the way back he devised deeds of sheer havoc
 290 with you, brilliant goddess, when you stood by him in your kindness.
 So now again be willing to stand by me, and guard me.
 And I in return will sacrifice to you a yearling heifer,
 broad-browed, unbroken, that no man has yet led under the yoke:
 that I will sacrifice to you, and sheathe her horns in gold."²²
- 295 So they spoke in prayer, and Pallas Athena heard them.
 And when they had prayed to the daughter of great Zeus,
 they went on their way like two lions through the black night,
 through the slaughter, through the corpses, through the gear and the
 black blood.²³
- Nor did Hector allow the proud Trojans to sleep
 300 either; he called together all their best men,
 all who were leaders and lords of the Trojans;
 and calling them together he framed his shrewd plan:
 "Who will undertake a work for me and bring it through
 to the end, for a great gift? The wage will be enough:
- 305 I will give a chariot and two strong-necked horses,
 the finest that there are beside the swift ships of the Achaeans,
 to the man who dares — and he will win glory for himself —
 to go close to the swift-faring ships, and find out
 whether the swift ships are guarded as before,
- 310 or whether by now, beaten down under our hands,
 they are planning flight among themselves, and have no wish
 to keep watch through the night, sodden with brutal weariness."
 So he spoke, and they all went still in silence.
- Now there was among the Trojans one Dolon, the son of Eumedes²⁴
 315 the sacred herald — rich in gold and rich in bronze —
 who was ugly to look at, but swift-footed;
 and he was an only son among five sisters.
 He then spoke his word to the Trojans and Hector:
 "Hector, my own heart and my proud spirit urge me²⁵
- 320 to go close to the swift-faring ships, and find out.
 Come then, lift up your scepter to me, and swear
 that you will give the horses, and the chariot intricate with bronze,
 that carry the blameless son of Peleus;
 and I will not be a vain scout for you, nor fall short of your thought.

- 325 For I will go straight on through the camp until I come
to Agamemnon's ship, where no doubt their best men
are taking counsel together, whether to run or fight."
So he spoke; and Hector took the scepter in his hand, and swore:
"Let Zeus himself now witness it, the loud-thunderer, Hera's lord:
330 no other man of the Trojans shall mount behind those horses;
you and none other, I declare, shall glory in them forever."
So he spoke, and swore it falsely — and set the man on fire.
At once he slung his curved bow over his shoulders,
and over it put on the hide of a grey wolf,
335 and on his head a ferret-skin cap; and he took a sharp javelin,²⁶
and set out from the camp toward the ships — nor was he ever
to come back from the ships and carry his word to Hector.
But when he had left the crowds of horses and men behind,
he went up the road, all eagerness; and Zeus-sprung Odysseus
340 marked him coming on, and said to Diomedes:
"Diomedes, here is some man coming out of the camp;
I cannot tell if he means to spy upon our ships
or to strip one of the corpses of the dead.
Let us let him pass us by on the plain
345 a little first; then rushing after we can take him
quickly. And if he outruns the two of us on foot,
keep crowding him always toward the ships, away from the camp,
lunging with your spear, so he cannot slip off to the town."
So the two spoke, and they lay down off the road
350 among the corpses; and in his folly he ran quickly past.
But when he was as far away as mules plow in one stretch —²⁷
for mules are better beasts than oxen
at dragging the jointed plow through deep fallow land —
the two ran after him; and he stopped still at the sound of feet,
355 for he hoped in his heart they were companions coming
from the Trojans to turn him back, Hector recalling him.
But when they were a spear-throw off, or even less,
he knew them for enemy men, and moved his nimble knees
in flight; and they leapt quickly into the chase.
360 As when two jag-toothed hounds that know the hunt
press hard on a fawn or a hare, unrelenting, always,

- through wooded country, and it runs crying before them,
 so Tydeus' son and Odysseus, sacker of cities,
 cut him off from his people and chased him, unrelenting, always.
- 365 But when he was on the point of mixing with the guards
 in his flight toward the ships, then Athena put fury
 into Tydeus' son, so that no bronze-shirted Achaean
 might boast that he struck first, with Diomedes coming second.
 Rushing at him with the spear, strong Diomedes spoke:
- 370 "Stand — or I reach you with the spear; and I tell you,
 you will not long escape sheer destruction from my hand."
 He spoke, and let the spear fly — and missed the man on purpose:²⁸
 over his right shoulder the point of the polished spear
 stuck fast in the earth. Dolon stood still, terrified,
- 375 stammering — through his mouth came the chatter of his teeth —
 green with fear. Panting, the two caught up with him
 and seized his hands; and he burst into tears and said:
 "Take me alive, and I will ransom myself: at home there lies
 bronze, and gold, and iron worked with much labor;
- 380 out of these my father would gladden you with ransom past counting
 if he learned I was alive by the ships of the Achaeans."
 Answering him spoke resourceful Odysseus:
 "Take heart; and let death be no concern of your mind."²⁹
 But come, tell me this, and recount it truly:
- 385 where are you going alone to the ships, away from the camp,
 in the murky night, when other mortals are sleeping?
 To strip one of the corpses of the dead?
 Or did Hector send you out to spy on everything
 at the hollow ships? Or did your own heart drive you?"
- 390 Then Dolon answered him, his limbs trembling under him:
 "With many blindnesses Hector led my mind astray:³⁰
 the whole-hoofed horses of the illustrious son of Peleus
 he promised on his nod to give, and the chariot intricate with bronze,
 and told me to go on through the swift black night,
- 395 and get close to the enemy men, and find out
 whether the swift ships are guarded as before,
 or whether by now, beaten down under our hands,
 they are planning flight among themselves, and have no wish

- to keep watch through the night, sodden with brutal weariness."³¹
- 400 And resourceful Odysseus answered him, smiling:
 "Great gifts indeed those were your heart was set on —
 the horses of the war-minded son of Aeacus. They are hard
 for mortal men to break or to drive,
 for any man but Achilles, whom an immortal mother bore.
- 405 But come, tell me this, and recount it truly:
 where, when you came here, did you leave Hector, shepherd of the
 people?
 Where does his warlike gear lie? Where are his horses?
 And the other Trojans — how are their watches and sleeping-places?
 What are they counseling among themselves — whether they mean
- 410 to stay where they are by the ships, far away, or will withdraw
 back to the city, since they have beaten down the Achaeans?"
 Then answered him Dolon, Eumedes' son:
 "Well then, I will recount all this to you very truly.
 Hector, with all those men who are counselors,
 415 is taking counsel by the tomb of godlike Ilus,³²
 apart from the din. But the watches you ask about, hero —
 no picked guard protects the camp, and none keeps watch.
 As for the Trojans' watch-fires: the men under necessity,
 they stay awake beside them, and call to one another
- 420 to keep the watch. But the allies, called from many lands,
 are sleeping; they leave the watching to the Trojans,
 for their own children and wives do not lie near them."
 Answering him spoke resourceful Odysseus:
 "Now how is it — do they sleep mingled with the horse-taming
- 425 Trojans, or apart? Tell me plainly, so I may know."
 Then answered him Dolon, Eumedes' son:
 "Well then, I will recount this too to you very truly.
 Toward the sea lie the Carians and the Paeonians of the curved bows,³³
 the Leleges and the Caucones and the brilliant Pelasgians;
- 430 toward Thymbre fell the lot of the Lycians and the lordly Mysians
 and horse-fighting Phrygians, and Maeonians, men who fight from
 chariots.
 But why do you question me through all this, point by point?
 If you two are bent on slipping into the Trojans' throng,

here, apart, are the Thracians, new-come, outermost of all,
 435 and among them their king Rhesus, son of Eioneus.
 His horses are the finest I have ever seen, and the biggest:
 whiter than snow, and like the winds in running.
 His chariot is finely worked with gold and silver,
 and the armor he came in is golden, gigantic, a wonder³⁴
 440 to look at — armor that suits, not mortal men
 to carry, but the deathless gods.
 But now, take me with you to the swift-faring ships,
 or bind me with a pitiless bond and leave me here,
 until you two have gone and made your trial of me,
 445 whether I have spoken to you justly, or not."
 Glaring at him darkly, strong Diomedes spoke:
 "Do not put escape into your heart, Dolon,
 good though your news is, now you have come into our hands.
 For if we free you now for ransom, or let you go,
 450 surely later you will come again to the swift ships of the Achaeans,
 either spying once more, or fighting us face to face;
 but if, beaten down under my hands, you lose your life,
 never again will you be a plague upon the Argives."
 He spoke; and the man was reaching for his chin with his broad hand,
 455 meaning to plead — but the other drove at the middle of his neck,
 springing with the sword, and sheared through both the tendons;
 and the head of the still-speaking man was mingled with the dust.³⁵
 From him they took the cap of ferret skin,
 the grey wolf's hide, the back-bent bow, and the long spear;
 460 and these to Athena of the Spoils brilliant Odysseus³⁶
 held up high in his hand, and praying spoke a word:
 "Rejoice in these, goddess. To you first of all the immortals
 on Olympus we will give your share. But once again
 send us on, to the Thracian men's horses and sleeping-places."
 465 So he spoke, and lifted the spoils high away from himself
 and set them on a tamarisk; and he set a mark plain to see,
 pulling together reeds and the tamarisk's flourishing boughs,
 so they would not miss it, coming back through the swift black night.
 The two went forward, through the gear and the black blood,
 470 and quickly, pressing on, they reached the company of Thracian men.

They were sleeping, sodden with weariness, and their fine gear
 lay by them on the ground, all in good order,
 in three rows; and beside each man his yoke-pair of horses.
 Rhesus slept in the middle, and beside him his swift horses
 475 were tethered by the reins to the chariot's outer rail.
 Odysseus saw him first, and pointed him out to Diomedes:
 "That is the man, Diomedes; and those are the horses
 that Dolon marked out for us — the man we killed.
 Come then, show your great strength. You have no business
 480 standing idle in your armor. Untie the horses —
 or else you kill the men, and the horses will be my care."
 So he spoke; and grey-eyed Athena breathed fury into him.
 He killed, wheeling on every side, and a hideous groaning rose
 from men struck by the sword; and the earth reddened with blood.
 485 As a lion coming upon flocks without their herdsman,
 on goats or on sheep, springs in with evil purpose,
 so Tydeus' son moved up and down among the Thracian men
 until he had killed twelve. And resourceful Odysseus —
 whomever Tydeus' son struck with the sword, standing above him,
 490 him Odysseus would seize by the foot from behind and drag aside,
 with this thought in his mind: that the fair-maned horses
 might pass through easily, and not shiver in their hearts
 at stepping on dead men — being still unused to them.
 But when Tydeus' son came upon the king,
 495 he was the thirteenth he robbed of his honey-sweet life,
 gasping hard: for an evil dream stood at his head
 that night — the son of Oeneus' son — by the cunning of Athena.³⁷
 All that time hardy Odysseus was untying the whole-hoofed horses;
 he bound them together with reins and drove them from the crowd,
 500 beating them with his bow, because he had not thought³⁸
 to take up in his hands the shining whip from the intricate chariot;
 then he gave a whistle, his signal to brilliant Diomedes.
 But Diomedes waited, weighing what boldest thing he might do:
 whether to seize the chariot where the intricate gear lay
 505 and drag it out by the pole, or heave it high and carry it,
 or take away the life of still more Thracians.
 While he was turning this over in his mind, Athena

- came near and stood, and spoke to brilliant Diomedes:
 "Think of your return now, son of great-hearted Tydeus,³⁹
 510 back to the hollow ships — or you may go back to them running,
 and some other god may waken the Trojans too."
 So she spoke; and he knew the voice of the goddess speaking,
 and swiftly mounted a horse; and Odysseus struck the pair
 with his bow, and they flew toward the swift ships of the Achaeans.
 515 But Apollo of the silver bow kept no blind man's watch⁴⁰
 when he saw Athena attending on Tydeus' son:
 angry with her, he sank into the great throng of Trojans
 and woke a counselor of the Thracians, Hippocoon,
 Rhesus' noble kinsman. And he leapt up out of sleep,
 520 and when he saw the place empty where the swift horses had stood,
 and the men gasping amid the grim slaughter,
 he groaned aloud, and called out the name of his dear companion.
 And a clamor rose from the Trojans, and measureless uproar,
 as they rushed together; they gazed at the deeds of havoc —
 525 all that the men had done before going to the hollow ships.
 And when the two came where they had killed Hector's scout,
 there Odysseus, dear to Zeus, held in the swift horses,
 and Tydeus' son leapt down, and put the bloody spoils
 into Odysseus' hands, and mounted up again;
 530 and he whipped the horses on, and the two flew, nothing loath,
 toward the hollow ships; for that way was dear to their hearts.
 Nestor was the first to hear the drumming of hooves, and spoke:
 "Friends, leaders and lords of the Argives,
 shall I be wrong, or right, in what I say? My heart commands it.⁴¹
 535 The drumming of swift-footed horses strikes about my ears.
 If only it were Odysseus and strong Diomedes
 driving whole-hoofed horses here, so quickly, out of the Trojans!
 But terribly I fear in my heart that they have come to harm —
 the best of the Argives — in the uproar of the Trojans."
 540 The whole word was not yet spoken when they came themselves,
 and stepped down to the ground; and the others, rejoicing,
 welcomed them with clasped right hands and honeyed words.
 And first to question them was the Gerenian horseman Nestor:

- "Come, tell me, Odysseus of the many tales, great glory of the Achaeans:
- 545 how did you two take these horses? By slipping into the throng of the Trojans? Or did some god meet you, and give them? They are terribly like the rays of the sun. Always I mix with the Trojans; I say I am no lingerer beside the ships, old warrior though I am;
- 550 but never yet have I seen such horses, or dreamed of them. No — I think some god must have met you and given them, for Zeus the cloud-gatherer loves the two of you, and the daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, grey-eyed Athena." Answering him spoke resourceful Odysseus:
- 555 "Nestor, Neleus' son, great glory of the Achaeans, easily could a god, if he wished, give better horses even than these, since the gods are far mightier. But these horses you ask about, old man, are newly come — Thracians; their lord — brave Diomedes killed him,
- 560 and beside him twelve companions, all their best men. The thirteenth was a scout we took near the ships,⁴² a man sent out to be a spy upon our army by Hector and the rest of the illustrious Trojans." So speaking, he drove the whole-hoofed horses across the ditch,
- 565 laughing aloud; and the other Achaeans followed, rejoicing. And when they reached the well-built hut of Tydeus' son, they tied up the horses with well-cut thongs at the horse-manger, where the horses of Diomedes stood, swift-footed, eating their honey-sweet grain.
- 570 And on his ship's stern Odysseus laid the bloody spoils of Dolon, till they could make the offering ready for Athena. And the men themselves waded into the sea, and washed away the heavy sweat from their shins and necks and thighs. And when the waves of the sea had washed the heavy sweat
- 575 from their skin, and the dear heart in them was cooled, they stepped into polished bathing-tubs and bathed.⁴³ And when the two had bathed and rubbed themselves sleek with oil, they sat down to their meal, and from a brimming mixing-bowl they drew honey-sweet wine and poured it out to Athena.

NOTES TO BOOK 10

- 1 *l. 1* The Doloneia is the only book of the Iliad whose place in the poem was disputed in antiquity as a whole (curated dispute #8). A scholion preserved in the T manuscript reports: "they say that this rhapsody was arranged separately by Homer and was not counted part of the Iliad, but was placed into the poem by Pisistratus." Aristarchus treated the book as genuine; modern critics have gone both ways, Analysts excising it, defenders reading it as an old ambush-theme (the *lochos*) integral to the tradition. The internal evidence is genuinely double-edged — see the translator's note on this book, and notes [39] and [43]. The apparatus for this book records only line-level variants; the whole-book question lives in the testimonia.
- 2 *ll. 1-2* The opening repeats the shape of Book 2's opening, in our same words ("slept the whole night through"; 2.1-2). The reversal is exact: there all slept but Zeus, who lay awake devising the Achaeans' ruin through a false dream; here all sleep but Agamemnon, who lies awake suffering that ruin — and the night will end with a true nightmare standing over a sleeper's head (note [37]).
- 3 *ll. 5-8* Zeus's lightning as the portent of prodigious rain, hail, snow, "or somewhere the great mouth of bitter war": *πενκεδανοῖο* (8), a rare word cognate with pine-pitch bitterness, occurs only here in Homer. Agamemnon's groans come as thick as the flashes.
- 4 *ll. 11-13* The many fires are the ones Hector lit at the end of Book 8 (8.553-565); Book 10, like Book 9 (9.77), opens inside the tableau Book 8 left burning. The "flutes and pipes" are the only battlefield music in the Iliad — the sound of an army sure of tomorrow — heard otherwise only in the city at peace on the Shield (18.495).
- 5 *l. 29* Night gear. This book replaces the formal bronze arming scene with skins: Agamemnon's lion (23-24), Menelaus's leopard and plain bronze cap, Diomedes' lion (177-178), Dolon's wolf-hide and ferret cap (334-335), and the two spies' leather helmets (257-265). Animal dress belongs to the night-world of the ambush, where the day-world's flashing crests would kill their wearer; the poet has an exact costume-vocabulary for it, most of it appearing nowhere else.
- 6 *ll. 51-52* Athetized by Aristophanes of Byzantium and Aristarchus — the hyperbole (one day's work to be the Argives' concern "long and lastingly") judged un-Homeric.
- 7 *l. 68* "naming each man from his father, by his lineage" — courtesy as night-discipline: a voice in the dark must honor to be trusted. With it goes Agamemnon's "let us do the labor ourselves... Zeus laid this heavy misery on us at our very birth" (70-71): the night-book consistently shows the commanders' fear and drudgery that the day-books dress in ceremony.
- 8 *l. 84* Athetized by Aristarchus, presumably for the mules: Nestor's guess that a man groping through the camp at midnight is after a strayed mule struck ancient taste as beneath the epic. It is also the poem's one quartermaster's-eye view of its own camp.

- 9 *l.* 110 "swift Ajax" is the Locrian, Oïleus' son (2.527); "the stout son of Phyleus" is Meges (2.627). The greater Ajax is the "godlike Ajax" of 112, paired as usual with Idomeneus.
- 10 *ll.* 114-125 Nestor's rebuke of the sleeping Menelaus, and Agamemnon's careful defense — he often hangs back, "not that he yields to sloth... but he looks to me, and waits for my lead" — reverse the Book 1 Agamemnon, who could not take one word of blame. The night steadies him; his fairest self appears at his least kingly hour.
- 11 *ll.* 158-159 Nestor wakes Diomedes "with a kick of his heel" — the poem's only comic reveille, answered by the sleeper's growl that the old man is "impossible." After 159 some ancient texts carried an extra line preserved only by Diogenes Laertius (6.53), who has Diogenes the Cynic quote it while prodding a sleeping man: "lest someone plant a spear in your back while you sleep." It is not in the printed text.
- 12 *ll.* 173-174 "it stands upon the razor's edge" — ἐπὶ ξυροῦ ἴσταται ἀκμῆς: the earliest surviving occurrence of the idiom English still uses, taken up by Theognis, Sophocles, and Herodotus (6.11).
- 13 *ll.* 199-201 The Achaean council convenes beyond the ditch "in a clear space, where ground showed empty of the dead" — line 199 repeats 8.491 (our wording kept), where Hector held his night assembly by the river on the same terms. Each army deliberates sitting in the other's killing-ground; the mirrored councils organize the whole book (note [25]).
- 14 *ll.* 212-217 The scout's reward: fame "under heaven," plus a black ewe with her lamb from every captain, and a standing place at the feasts. Livestock and a seat at table — the modest, concrete economy of the night-book, set against Book 9's seven tripods, twenty cauldrons, and seven cities.
- 15 *ll.* 224-226 "When two go together, one marks before the other / where the advantage lies" — proverbial already in antiquity: Plato has Socrates quote it on the way to the banquet (Symposium 174d) and again at Protagoras 348d. The couplet is the book's thesis; the Iliad's only two-man aristeia follows from it.
- 16 *l.* 240 Omitted by Zenodotus, athetized by Aristarchus: the narrator's aside that Agamemnon "was afraid for tawny-haired Menelaus." The aside decodes 237-239 — "do not leave the better man behind... not even if he is the more kingly" is a king's coded plea that his brother not be chosen; the critics apparently preferred the code left unbroken.
- 17 *ll.* 252-253 Odysseus tells time by the stars — the working star-clock of a night operation. Line 253 was athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus over the arithmetic: if "more of the night has passed than two of its parts," then less than a third should remain — yet Odysseus allows "the third part." The Greek is loose the way spoken time-reckoning is loose ("it's past two in the morning; we have till first light"), and the ancient fussing over it is a small monument of pedantry.
- 18 *ll.* 257-259 The καταῖτυξ, "skull-cap": a plain bull's-hide helmet, "ridgeless, crestless," glossed in-line by the poet as if his audience needed the word explained — it occurs nowhere else in Greek literature. Night war strips off whatever catches light.

- 19 ll. 261-271 The boar's-tusk helmet is a genuine Bronze Age object: rows of sliced boar-tusk plates over felt and leather, known from Mycenaean excavation and art, and centuries obsolete by any plausible date of the poem's composition — the pedigree the poet gives it (stolen by Autolycus, passed via Amphidamas of Cythera to Molus to Meriones) is epic's own memory of the object's antiquity. Two ironies ride with it. Autolycus is Odysseus's maternal grandfather (Od. 19.394-466): the master-thief's loot ends the night on his own grandson's head. And its original owner, "Amyntor, Ormenus' son" of Eleon, is Phoenix's father (9.448) — the house Phoenix fled in Book 9 is burgled again, as it were, in Book 10's props.
- 20 ll. 274-276 A heron on the right hand is a favorable sign; in the dark the omen is heard, not seen. The entire daylight apparatus of the poem — arming, augury, even prayer-answer — is systematically converted to the ear in this book (cf. the hooves at 532-535, the whistle at 502).
- 21 ll. 285-290 Tydeus at Thebes for the fourth time in the poem (4.372-398; 5.800-808; cf. 23.679-680): the friendly embassy, the "honeyed word," and on the road home the ambush of fifty men that he destroyed — "deeds of sheer havoc." Diomedes has been measured against his father since Book 4; only here, on a night ambush, does the paternal precedent exactly fit the son's occasion.
- 22 ll. 292-294 The vow of the unbroken heifer with gilded horns recurs nearly verbatim in the Odyssey (3.382-384) — vowed there too by a Nestor, and fulfilled at 3.430-438, where a goldsmith actually sheathes the horns in gold leaf: the fullest "receipt" for any Homeric vow, and a famous cross-epic pair with this passage.
- 23 ll. 297-298 The epigraph lines. "Through the slaughter, through the corpses" (ἄμ φόνον, ἄν νέκυας) is the literal ground of the whole night-walk — repeated when they go forward again at 469. The two lions become two hounds on a hare (360-362) and a lion among unshepherded flocks (485-486): the book's men are beasts of prey throughout, and the skins they wear (note [5]) say so.
- 24 ll. 314-317 Dolon: the name is transparently "Sneak" (from δόλος, "trick"). A rich herald's son, "ugly to look at, but swift-footed" — the poet lends him Achilles' own epithet — and an only son among five sisters: a portrait, unique in the poem, of the spoiled volunteer. He will demand Achilles' horses as his wage (321-323) and be run down on foot.
- 25 ll. 319-332 Dolon's speech opens word for word as Diomedes' did (220): "my own heart and my proud spirit urge me..." — twinned volunteer-scenes, one issuing in the choice of Odysseus, the other in an empty oath. Hector swears by the scepter that "no other man of the Trojans shall mount behind those horses," and the narrator files his verdict flat: "he swore it falsely" — not because Hector meant to cheat, but because the oath was never his to keep. Coveting the immortal horses of Achilles is this book's measure of delusion (cf. note [30]; at 17.75-78 Hector himself is warned off them).
- 26 ll. 334-335 The grey wolf's hide and the ferret-skin cap (κτιδέη, marten or weasel): the spy dressed as a small night predator — the bottom rung of the book's ladder of skins (note [5]). Attic vase-painters loved the costume; several show Dolon on all fours in the wolf-suit.

- 27 ll. 351-353 Distance measured by plowing: "as far as mules plow in one stretch" is the οὔρον, the length of furrow a team draws before turning. The homely aside — mules out-pull oxen in deep fallow — arrives at the moment of highest suspense; the epic measures its night-chase by a farmer's daylight (cf. the fence-post interval of 23.431-432).
- 28 ll. 372-376 The spear "missed the man on purpose" — thrown to stop, not kill: they need him talking. Dolon's terror is clinically itemized: rooted feet, stammer, teeth chattering audibly, "green with fear" — our fixed color of fear (7.479), here soaked into the man himself.
- 29 l. 383 "Take heart; and let death be no concern of your mind" — literally true (his death is already decided, so no longer worth minding) and utterly false as the comfort it pretends to be. The interrogation that follows is the poem's only one: two rounds, each opened with the courteous fixed line "But come, tell me this, and recount it truly" (384 = 405), each answered "Well then, I will recount... very truly" (413, 427) — the formulas of guest-conversation conducted over a man already dead.
- 30 l. 391 "With many blindnesses Hector led my mind astray" — ἄτησι, the register's "blindness" (1.412): the god-sent delusion by which Agamemnon will explain the whole war in Book 19, here claimed by a small man about a promise of horses. Everyone in this poem accounts for ruin the same way; the poet lets the excuse shrink to the size of its owner.
- 31 ll. 397-399, 409-411 Both passages were athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus. Dolon reports Hector's briefing in Hector's very words (396-399 = 309-312 — kept verbatim in our English, "our hands" and all), and Odysseus's question repeats Nestor's proposal (409-411 = 208-210, flagged in the scholia as a wrongful repeat). The critics disliked the mechanical reuse; but verbatim relay is exactly how a chain of command speaks, and the poem's economy of repeated blocks is nowhere more functional than in a spy's debriefing.
- 32 l. 415 The tomb of Ilus, eponym and founder of Ilion, is the plain's standing landmark (11.166, 371-372; 24.349): Hector holds his war-council at the ancestor's grave, as the Achaeans hold theirs among the fresh dead (note [13]).
- 33 ll. 428-431 A miniature order of battle, complement to the Trojan Catalogue (2.816-877): the same allied peoples, now laid out by billet rather than muster — Carians, Paeonians, Leleges, Caucones, Pelasgians toward the sea; Lycians, Mysians, Phrygians, Maeonians toward Thymbre. The Thracians of Rhesus stand in no catalogue: "new-come, outermost of all" — arrived, and doomed, within the one night.
- 34 ll. 435-441 Rhesus: horses "whiter than snow, and like the winds in running," a gold-and-silver chariot, and golden armor fit for "the deathless gods." Later tradition — the scholia, Virgil (Aeneid 1.469-473), and the Rhesus transmitted under Euripides' name — knew an oracle that Troy could never fall once Rhesus and his horses had grazed Trojan pasture and drunk of Scamander, making the raid a preemption of fate. Our text knows nothing of it: here the splendor simply dwarfs its owner's one-night part, and the armor "for the deathless gods" lies on the ground at 504 while the gods' own agent decides against taking it.

- 35 *ll. 454–457* Dolon's hand is out for the suppliant's touch of the chin (the gesture of 1.501) when the sword falls: supplication not refused, as Agamemnon refused Adrestus (6.55–65), but forestalled — a beat crueler. "And the head of the still-speaking man was mingled with the dust" (457): Aristotle quotes the line in earnest (*Parts of Animals* 673a), discussing whether severed heads can speak. The grammar performs the horror: the man is still a speaking subject in mid-construction as his head meets the ground.
- 36 *ll. 460–466* "Athena of the Spoils" (ληϊτις) — an epithet found only here. The trophies are hung on a tamarisk and flagged with reeds and boughs for the return leg: fieldcraft doubling as votive religion, an altar-less offering to match the unseen omen of note [20]. The dedication is completed at 570–571 and the libation of 578–579.
- 37 *ll. 496–497* Rhesus dies "gasping hard: for an evil dream stood at his head / that night — the son of Oeneus' son — by the cunning of Athena." The nightmare stands at the sleeper's head in the regular posture of Homeric dreams (2.20, 23.68) — and the dream is Diomedes himself, Oeneus' grandson, sword in hand: dream and killer are one figure, the boldest compression in the book, closing the frame the false dream of Book 2 opened (note [2]). Zenodotus and Aristophanes omitted 497 and Aristarchus athetized it — flattening the vision back into ordinary death; the printed text keeps it.
- 38 *ll. 498–502* Odysseus improvises: the whip is still lying in the chariot, so he beats the horses with his bow, and signals with a whistle — the only whistle in Homer. Someone did not think of everything: the small unheroic realism the day-books never allow.
- 39 *ll. 509–513* "Think of your return" — νόστου δὴ μνήσσαι: the Odyssey's theme-word sounded by Athena in the *Iliad*, to the other poem's kind of hero on the other poem's kind of errand; a centerpiece of the book's Odyssean coloring (see the translator's note on this book). And they escape riding bareback — nearly the only riding of horses in the *Iliad* (elsewhere a simile, 15.679–684) — because the chariot stayed with the dead.
- 40 *l. 515* "kept no blind man's watch" — ἀλαοσκοπή, fixed here at its first occurrence; it recurs of Poseidon at 13.10 and 14.135. Zenodotus read the phrase as two words with a different sense; the printed text follows Aristarchus.
- 41 *l. 534* "shall I be wrong, or right, in what I say? My heart commands it" — literally "shall I lie, or speak true?": Nestor's strange scruple, omitted by Zenodotus here, recurs in Helen's mouth at *Odyssey* 4.140. It is the night-book's epistemology in one line: hooves heard in the dark must be guessed at aloud before they can be greeted.
- 42 *ll. 561–565* Odysseus's tally makes Dolon "the thirteenth" — answering Rhesus, the thirteenth Thracian (495): each side's night closes its account in the same figure, and Odysseus books his interrogation-kill as a line-item. Then he drives the ditch "laughing aloud" (565) — no other killing in the *Iliad* ends in laughter; the book's moral register, and part of what has always made readers uneasy in it, is in that word.
- 43 *ll. 572–579* The close: a wade in the sea, then "polished bathing-tubs" — ἀσάμινθοι, only here in the *Iliad* against nine occurrences in the *Odyssey* — oil, a meal, and honey-sweet wine poured to Athena. An Odyssean hospitality-sequence grafted onto the war-camp, and a chief exhibit in the authenticity dossier (note [1]); it is also precisely what the poem's one successful night requires — the blood of 483–484 washed off before rosy-

fingered dawn, eight lines into Book 11, restores the rules of the day. In 579 Aristarchus read "drew" (ἄφυσσόμενοι); the vulgate carried a variant of the same sense.

Iliad — Book 11

*Agamemnon's day of glory; Diomedes, Odysseus, and other Greek chiefs
are wounded one by one; Nestor sends Patroclus to plead with Achilles.*

- Dawn rose from her bed beside illustrious Tithonus¹
to bring light to the immortals and to mortal men;
and Zeus sent Strife down to the swift ships of the Achaeans,
the grim goddess, holding a portent of war in her hands.
- 5 She stood on Odysseus's black ship, huge of hull,
which lay midmost, so a shout could carry to both ends,
both to the huts of Ajax, Telamon's son,
and to Achilles' — for they had drawn their balanced ships up
at the ends, trusting their courage and the strength of their hands.
- 10 Standing there the goddess screamed, great and terrible,
a high shriek; and into each Achaean's heart she threw
great strength, to war and fight without ceasing.
And at once war became sweeter to them than going home²
in the hollow ships to their dear fatherland.
- 15 And Atreus' son shouted aloud, commanding the Argives
to gird themselves; and he himself put on the flashing bronze.
First he set the greaves along his shins,
fine greaves, fitted with silver ankle-pieces;
second, he put the corslet about his chest,
- 20 the one that Cinyras once gave him as a guest-gift:³
for the great report had reached him in Cyprus — the Achaeans
were about to sail up in their ships for Troy —
and so he gave it to him, a favor for the king.
On it there were ten bands of dark blue enamel,⁴
- 25 and twelve of gold, and twenty of tin;
and serpents of blue enamel reached up toward the neck,
three on either side, like the rainbows the son of Cronos
sets in a cloud, a portent for mortal men.
Around his shoulders he threw his sword: on it the studs
- 30 glittered gold, and the scabbard about it
was silver, fitted with golden straps.

- And he took up his man-covering, rich-worked, rushing shield,
 a fine shield: around it ran ten circles of bronze,
 and on it were twenty bosses of tin,
 35 white, and in the center one of dark blue enamel;
 and crowning it was the Gorgon, grim of face,
 glaring terribly, and around her Terror and Panic.⁵
 The shield-strap was of silver, and along it
 writhed a serpent of blue enamel, with three heads
 40 twisting every way, grown from a single neck.
 On his head he set his helmet, double-ridged, four-bossed,
 horsehair-crested; the plume nodded terribly above him.
 And he took two stout spears, headed with bronze,
 sharp ones; and far off into heaven the bronze
 45 flashed from them; and Athena and Hera thundered over him,
 doing honor to the king of Mycenae rich in gold.⁶
 Then each man gave his charioteer the order
 to hold the horses in good order there at the ditch,
 while they themselves, on foot, armed in their gear,
 50 swept forward; and quenchless rose the shouting before dawn.
 They formed at the ditch well ahead of the charioteers,
 who followed a little behind. And an evil tumult
 the son of Cronos stirred among them, and down from on high he sent
 dewes dripping with blood out of the upper air, because he was about⁷
 55 to hurl down to Hades many strong heads.
 The Trojans on the other side, on the swell of the plain,
 gathered around great Hector and blameless Polydamas
 and Aeneas, honored like a god among Trojans by the people,
 and Antenor's three sons — Polybus, and brilliant Agenor,
 60 and young Acamas, the image of the immortals.
 Hector among the foremost carried his shield, balanced every way.
 As out of clouds a baleful star shows clear,⁸
 all shining, and then sinks again into the shadowed clouds,
 so Hector would appear now among the foremost,
 65 now in the rearmost ranks, giving commands; and all in bronze
 he flashed like the lightning of father Zeus who bears the aegis.
 And as reapers, facing one another down the rows,⁹
 drive their swathes through a rich man's field

of wheat or barley, and the handfuls fall thick and fast,
 70 so Trojans and Achaeans, springing at one another,
 cut men down, and neither side thought of ruinous flight.
 The battle held their heads level; and they raged
 like wolves. And Strife of the many groans rejoiced to see it,
 for she alone of the gods was with them as they fought;
 75 the other gods were not there, but at their ease
 they sat in their own halls, where for each of them
 a fair house was built along the folds of Olympus.
 And all were blaming the son of Cronos, lord of the dark cloud,¹⁰
 because his will was to hand the glory to the Trojans.
 80 The father took no thought of them. Withdrawn apart,
 he sat away from the others, exulting in his glory,
 looking out at the city of the Trojans and the ships of the Achaeans,
 at the flash of bronze, at the killers and the killed.
 So long as it was morning, and the sacred day still growing,¹¹
 85 so long the missiles of both sides struck home, and the people fell.
 But at the hour a woodcutter makes his meal ready
 in the mountain glens, when his arms have had their fill
 of felling the tall trees, and weariness comes on his heart,
 and desire for sweet food takes hold of his mind,
 90 at that hour the Danaans by their courage broke the battle-lines,
 calling to their companions down the ranks. And Agamemnon
 charged first, and killed a man: Bienor, shepherd of the people —
 the man himself, then his companion Oileus, lasher of horses,
 who had leapt down from the chariot and stood to face him;
 95 and as he came straight on, he stabbed him with the sharp spear
 in the forehead; the helmet's heavy bronze rim did not stop it —
 through rim and bone it went, and the brain
 was all splattered inside it. He broke him in mid-charge.
 And the lord of men Agamemnon left them there,
 100 their chests gleaming bare, when he had stripped their tunics,
 and went on to kill Isus and Antiphus,
 two sons of Priam, bastard and true-born both,
 riding one chariot: the bastard held the reins,
 and famed Antiphus stood beside him to fight. Achilles
 105 once bound these two with willow shoots, in the spurs of Ida,

taking them as they watched their sheep, and freed them for ransom.¹²
 But now the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon,
 struck one with the spear in the chest above the nipple,
 and struck Antiphus by the ear with the sword, and threw him from the
 chariot.

- 110 Hurrying, he stripped their fine armor from them —
 knowing them: for he had seen them once before by the swift ships,
 when swift-footed Achilles brought them down from Ida.
 As a lion easily crushes the helpless young
 of a swift deer, seizing them in his strong teeth,
 115 having come to their bed, and takes their soft life away,
 and the mother, even if she chances to be very near, can do
 nothing to help them, for terrible trembling comes on her too,
 and swiftly she darts away through the thick brush and the timber,
 sweating, at speed, before the assault of the mighty beast —
 120 so no one of the Trojans could ward destruction
 from those two; they themselves were fleeing before the Argives.
 Next Peisander and Hippolochus, staunch in the fight,
 sons of war-minded Antimachus — the man who, above all,
 taking Alexandros's gold, his glittering gifts,
 125 opposed giving Helen back to tawny-haired Menelaus —
 his two sons the lord Agamemnon caught,
 both in one chariot, trying to hold their swift horses,
 for the shining reins had slipped out of their hands
 and the pair had panicked. Like a lion the son of Atreus
 130 rose to meet them; and from the chariot the two begged him:
 "Take us alive, son of Atreus — and take a worthy ransom.
 Many treasures lie stored in the house of Antimachus,
 bronze, and gold, and iron worked with much labor:
 out of these our father would gladden you with ransom past counting
 135 if he learned we were alive by the ships of the Achaeans."
 So the two of them, weeping, addressed the king
 with honeyed words; but the voice they heard was unhoneyed:¹³
 "If you two are truly sons of war-minded Antimachus,
 who once in the Trojan assembly urged that Menelaus,
 140 come as an envoy with godlike Odysseus,
 be killed on the spot and not released back to the Achaeans —

- now you will pay for your father's foul outrage."
 He spoke, and thrust Peisander from the chariot to the ground,
 striking him with the spear in the chest; he crashed on his back in the
 dust.
- 145 Hippolochus leapt away; and him he killed on the ground,
 shearing his hands off with the sword, and striking off his neck,
 and sent him rolling like a stone through the crowd.
 He left them; and where the thickest battle-lines were driven,
 there he charged in, and with him other strong-greaved Achaeans.
- 150 Foot-soldiers killed foot-soldiers, forced into flight,
 and horsemen horsemen — from under them rose the dust
 out of the plain, stirred by the thundering feet of horses —
 dealing death with the bronze. And the lord Agamemnon,
 killing always, followed, calling on the Argives.
- 155 As when annihilating fire falls on unthinned timber,
 and the whirling wind carries it everywhere, and the thickets
 fall root and all under the fire's assault,
 so under Atreus' son Agamemnon fell the heads
 of Trojans in flight; and many strong-necked horses
- 160 rattled empty chariots down the causeways of the battlefield,
 missing their blameless charioteers — who lay on the earth,
 far dearer now to the vultures than to their wives.¹⁴
 But Hector — Zeus drew him out of the missiles and the dust,
 out of the man-slaughter, out of the blood and the tumult,
- 165 while Atreus' son followed on, hot, calling to the Danaans.
 Past the tomb of ancient Ilus, Dardanus' descendant,¹⁵
 across the middle of the plain, past the fig tree they streamed,
 straining for the city; and always Atreus' son followed
 screaming, his invincible hands spattered with gore.
- 170 But when they came to the Scaean Gates and the oak tree,
 there at last they halted, and stood waiting for one another.
 Others were still in full flight across the plain, like cattle
 a lion has set running, coming on them in the milking-dark of night —¹⁶
 all of them; but to one of them sheer destruction appears:
- 175 her neck he breaks first, seizing it in his strong teeth,
 and then he gulps down the blood and all the inward parts;
 so Atreus' son, the lord Agamemnon, pressed them,

- killing always the hindmost man; and they fled before him.
 Many fell from their chariots on their faces, or on their backs,
 180 under Atreus' son's hands, for he raged with the spear before all.¹⁷
 But when he was on the point of coming up under the city
 and the steep wall, then the father of men and gods
 came down from heaven and took his seat on the peaks
 of Ida of the many springs; and he held the lightning in his hands.
 185 And he sent Iris of the golden wings to carry his word:
 "Up, go, swift Iris; tell this word to Hector.
 So long as he sees Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,
 raging among the front-fighters, cutting down the ranks of men,
 so long let him give ground, and command the rest of the army
 190 to fight the enemy through the strong encounter.
 But when, struck by a spear or hit by an arrow,
 Agamemnon leaps to his horses, then I will hand him the power
 to kill, until he reaches the well-benched ships
 and the sun goes down and the sacred darkness comes on."¹⁸
 195 So he spoke, and wind-footed swift Iris did not disobey,
 and went down from the hills of Ida to holy Ilium.
 She found the son of war-minded Priam, brilliant Hector,
 standing among his horses and his bolted chariot;
 and standing close, swift-footed Iris spoke to him:
 200 "Hector, son of Priam, the equal of Zeus in counsel,
 Zeus the father has sent me out to tell you this.
 So long as you see Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,
 raging among the front-fighters, cutting down the ranks of men,
 so long yield from the fighting, and command the rest of the army
 205 to fight the enemy through the strong encounter.
 But when, struck by a spear or hit by an arrow,
 Agamemnon leaps to his horses, then Zeus will hand you the power
 to kill, until you reach the well-benched ships
 and the sun goes down and the sacred darkness comes on."
 210 So speaking, swift-footed Iris went her way,
 and Hector with his weapons leapt from the chariot to the ground,
 and shaking his sharp spears went everywhere through the army,
 stirring them to fight; and he woke the dread din of battle.
 They wheeled about and stood to face the Achaeans,

- 215 and the Argives on their side strengthened their battle-lines.
 The battle was set, and they stood face to face; and Agamemnon
 charged first, determined to fight far ahead of all.
 Tell me now, Muses, who keep your homes on Olympus —¹⁹
 who was the first to come against Agamemnon,
 220 either of the Trojans themselves or of their famed allies?
 Iphidamas, Antenor's son, a good man and a big one,
 who was reared in Thrace of the deep soil, mother of flocks.
 Cisses raised him in his house when he was little,
 his mother's father, who begot fair-cheeked Theano;
 225 and when he reached the measure of glorious youth,
 Cisses tried to keep him there, and offered him his daughter.
 But newly wed, out of the bridal chamber he went chasing the report
 of the Achaeans, with twelve beaked ships that followed him.
 The balanced ships he left behind at Percote,
 230 and came on foot the rest of the way to Ilion;
 and now he came against Atreus' son Agamemnon.
 And when they were close, advancing on one another,
 Atreus' son missed his cast; the spear was turned aside;
 but Iphidamas stabbed at the belt, below the corslet,
 235 and leaned into the thrust, trusting his heavy hand.
 He did not pierce the glittering war-belt: long before that,
 meeting the silver, the point bent back like lead.
 And wide-ruling Agamemnon caught the shaft in his hand
 and dragged it toward him, furious as a lion, and out of his grip
 240 wrenched it; and he struck his neck with the sword, and unstrung his
 limbs.
 So he fell there, and slept a sleep of bronze,²⁰
 pitiable man — far from his wedded bride, helping his townsmen,
 far from the wife he had seen no joy of, though he gave much for her:
 first he gave a hundred cattle, then promised a thousand
 245 goats and sheep together, out of his numberless flocks.
 But now Agamemnon, Atreus' son, stripped him bare
 and carried his fine armor away through the crowd of the Achaeans.
 But when Coon saw him — a man conspicuous among men,
 Antenor's eldest-born — strong grief came down
 250 over his eyes for his fallen brother.

- He took his stand aside with his spear, unseen by brilliant Agamemnon,
 and stabbed him mid-forearm, below the elbow;
 and the point of the shining spear drove clean through.
 Then the lord of men Agamemnon shuddered —
 255 but even so he did not leave off from battle and war:
 he sprang at Coon, gripping his wind-toughened spear.
 Coon was dragging Iphidamas, his brother by one father,
 hurrying, holding his foot, calling to all the best men;
 but as he dragged him through the crowd, under his bossed shield
 260 Agamemnon thrust with the bronze-shod shaft, and unstrung his
 limbs,
 and stepped up close and cut his head off, over Iphidamas.²¹
 There the sons of Antenor, at the hands of the king, Atreus' son,
 filled up their measure of doom and went down into the house of
 Hades.
 But he kept ranging down the ranks of the other men
 265 with spear and sword and with great stones,
 so long as the blood still welled warm from his wound.
 But when the wound began to dry, and the blood stopped,
 sharp pains came sinking into the strength of Atreus' son.
 As when the sharp shaft of labor seizes a woman in her pangs,²²
 270 the piercing shaft the Eileithyiai of hard labor send,
 Hera's daughters, keepers of the bitter pangs,
 so sharp pains sank into the strength of Atreus' son.
 He sprang into the chariot and told his charioteer
 to drive to the hollow ships; for his heart was heavy.
 275 And he cried a piercing cry, to carry to the Danaans:
 "Friends, leaders and lords of the Argives,
 yours be the task now: keep from the seafaring ships
 the grim din of battle, since Zeus the counselor has not
 allowed me to war with the Trojans all day long."
 280 So he spoke; and the charioteer whipped the fair-maned horses
 toward the hollow ships, and the two flew, nothing loath;
 their chests were white with foam, dusted beneath with dust,
 as they carried the worn king out of the fighting.
 And when Hector saw Agamemnon going off,
 285 he called to Trojans and Lycians with a great shout:

"Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians who fight at close quarters —
 be men, my friends; remember your rushing courage.
 Their best man is gone, and Zeus the son of Cronos has given
 great glory to me. Drive your whole-hoofed horses straight
 290 at the powerful Danaans, and win the higher glory."
 So speaking he stirred the fury and the heart of every man.
 As when some hunter sets his white-toothed hounds
 on a wild boar or a lion,
 so on the Achaeans Hector, Priam's son, the equal
 295 of Ares bane of mortals, set the great-hearted Trojans.
 He himself strode among the foremost, thinking great things,
 and fell upon the battle like a howling squall
 that leaps down and lashes the violet-colored sea.
 Whom first, whom last did he strip of his arms,²³
 300 Hector, Priam's son, when Zeus gave him the glory?
 Asaeus first, and Autinous, and Opites,
 and Dolops, Clytius' son, and Opheltius, and Agelaus,
 and Aesymnus, and Orus, and Hipponous staunch in the fight.
 These leaders of the Danaans he took, and after them
 305 the multitude — as when the West Wind batters the clouds
 of the white South Wind, striking with deep squall,
 and the swollen wave rolls huge, and the spray
 is scattered high under the wandering wind's blast,
 so thick and fast were the heads of the army beaten down by Hector.
 310 And now there would have been ruin, deeds beyond remedy,²⁴
 and the Achaeans in flight would have flung themselves on their ships,
 had not Odysseus called to Tydeus' son Diomedes:
 "Tydeus' son, what has come over us? We have forgotten our rushing
 courage.
 Come here, old friend; stand beside me. It will be disgrace
 315 if Hector of the flashing helmet takes the ships."
 Answering him spoke strong Diomedes:
 "I will stand, certainly, and I will endure it; but small
 will be our profit, since Zeus the cloud-gatherer
 would rather hand the power to the Trojans than to us."
 320 He spoke, and thrust Thymbraeus from his chariot to the ground,
 striking him with the spear by the left nipple; and Odysseus

- killed Molion, the godlike aide of that same lord.
 They left them there, done with fighting for good,
 and the two went through the crowd wreaking havoc, as when two
 boars
- 325 fall on the hunting hounds, thinking great things;
 so, turning back, they cut down Trojans; and the Achaeans
 gladly caught their breath in their flight from brilliant Hector.
 Then they took a chariot and two men, the best of their district,
 two sons of Merops of Percote, who beyond all men²⁵
- 330 knew the seer's art, and would not let his sons
 go to man-destroying war; but the two would not
 obey him: the fates of black death were leading them on.
 Tydeus' son Diomedes, famed with the spear,
 robbed them of life and breath and took their glorious armor;
- 335 and Odysseus killed Hippodamus and Hypeirochus.
 Then the son of Cronos stretched the battle level between them,
 looking down from Ida; and they went on killing one another.
 Tydeus' son wounded the hero Agastrophus with his spear,
 Paeon's son, at the hip-joint; his horses were not
- 340 near for escape — great was the blindness of his heart:
 his aide was holding them apart, while he on foot
 raged through the front-fighters, until he lost his own life.
 But Hector marked them sharply down the ranks, and rushed at them
 shouting; and with him followed the Trojan battle-lines.
- 345 Diomedes, good at the war-cry, shuddered to see him,
 and quickly spoke to Odysseus, who was near:
 "Here it comes rolling at the two of us, this plague — massive Hector.
 Come, let us stand and beat him off, holding our ground."
 He spoke, and balanced his long-shadowed spear and hurled it,
- 350 and hit — he did not miss — aiming at the head,
 at the helmet's crown; but bronze was turned by bronze
 and never reached the fair skin: the helmet stopped it,
 three-layered, socket-eyed, which Phoebus Apollo gave him.²⁶
 And Hector ran back an immense way, and merged with the crowd,
- 355 dropped to his knees and stayed there, propping himself
 with one thick hand on the earth; and black night covered his eyes.
 But while Tydeus' son went after his spear's cast,

far through the front-fighters, where he saw it strike the earth,
Hector caught his breath again, and springing back into his chariot
360 drove out into the mass of men, and dodged black doom.
Rushing after with his spear, strong Diomedes called:
"Dog! Again you have run out from under death — and yet the evil²⁷
came close. Now once more Phoebus Apollo has pulled you out —
to him you must pray whenever you go into the thud of javelins.
365 I will finish you yet, meeting you later,
if any god anywhere stands helper to me too.
For now I will go after the others, whoever I can catch."
He spoke, and set to stripping Paeon's spear-famed son.
But Alexandros, the husband of lovely-haired Helen,
370 drew his bow against Tydeus' son, shepherd of the people,
leaning against the pillar on the man-made mound,
the tomb of Ilus, Dardanus' son, elder of the people of old.
Diomedes was lifting the corslet of powerful Agastrophus
from his chest, all glittering, and the shield from his shoulders,
375 and the heavy helmet — and Paris drew back the grip of his bow
and shot; and the shaft did not leave his hand in vain:
he hit the flat of the right foot, and the arrow, clean through,
fixed in the earth. And laughing very sweetly
Paris leapt up out of his hiding-place, and spoke in triumph:²⁸
380 "You are hit! The arrow did not fly in vain. If only
I had struck deep in the groin and taken your life!
Then the Trojans could have breathed again after their misery —
they who shudder at you as bleating goats at a lion."
Unshaken, strong Diomedes answered him:
385 "Bowman, foul-mouth, glorious with your curls, ogler of girls —²⁹
if you made trial of me face to face, in armor,
your bow would not help you, and your showers of arrows;
as it is you have scratched the flat of my foot, and boast of it.
I care no more than if a woman had hit me, or a witless child;
390 blunt is the dart of a worthless man, a nobody.
From me it is otherwise: even if it only grazes,
the point is sharp, and makes its man a corpse on the instant.
His wife's cheeks are torn on both sides in mourning,
his children are fatherless; and he, reddening the earth with his blood,

- 395 rots, and there are more birds than women about him."
 So he spoke; and Odysseus, famed with the spear, came near
 and stood in front of him; and sitting behind, Diomedes drew
 the swift arrow out of his foot; and hard pain went through his flesh.
 He sprang into the chariot and told his charioteer
 400 to drive to the hollow ships; for his heart was heavy.
 Now Odysseus, famed with the spear, was left alone: not one
 of the Argives stayed by him, for fear had seized them all.
 Troubled, he spoke to his own great-hearted spirit:
 "Ah me, what happens to me now? Great evil if I run,
 405 fearing their numbers; but grimmer still if I am taken
 alone — and the son of Cronos has set the rest of the Danaans running.
 But why does my own heart argue these things with me?
 For I know that cowards walk away from the war,
 but whoever would be best in battle, his duty is
 410 to stand his ground with strength, whether he is hit or hits another."³⁰
 While he was turning this over in mind and heart,
 the ranks of the Trojan shield-men came on
 and penned him in their midst — setting their own plague among
 them.
 As when hounds and young men in their vigor rush
 415 a boar on every side, and he comes out of the deep thicket
 whetting the white tusk in his curved jaws,
 and they charge in around him, and from under comes the noise
 of gnashing tusks; but they stand up to him, terrible as he is —
 so then around Odysseus, dear to Zeus, the Trojans
 420 rushed. And he first wounded blameless Deïopites
 above the shoulder, leaping in with his sharp spear;
 and after that he stripped the life from Thoon and Ennomus,
 and next Chersidamas, as he sprang down from his chariot,
 he stabbed with the spear below the bossed shield
 425 in the navel; and he fell in the dust and clutched the earth with his
 palm.
 These he left, and wounded with the spear Charops, Hippasus' son,
 own brother of wealthy Socus;
 and Socus came to his rescue, a man like a god,
 and came up very close and spoke his word to him:

- 430 "Odysseus of the many tales, insatiate of tricks and of labor,³¹
 today you will either boast over both of Hippasus' sons —
 such a pair of men! — for killing them and stripping their armor,
 or struck under my spear you will lose your life."
 So speaking, he struck the shield balanced every way:
 435 through the shining shield the heavy spear went,
 and through the richly worked corslet it drove,
 and tore all the flesh clean from his ribs; but Pallas Athena
 did not let it reach the man's inward parts.
 Odysseus knew the point had not come home to a mortal spot,
 440 and drawing back he spoke his word to Socus:
 "Poor wretch — sheer destruction has surely caught you now.
 True: you have stopped my fighting against the Trojans;
 but I say that death and black doom will be yours
 here, on this day; broken under my spear you will give
 445 the triumph to me, and your soul to Hades of the famed colts."
 He spoke; and Socus had turned and was moving into flight,
 and square in his back as he turned he fixed the spear
 between the shoulders, and drove it through the chest.
 He fell with a thud; and brilliant Odysseus exulted over him:
 450 "Socus, son of war-minded Hippasus, breaker of horses:
 death's end was too quick for you — you did not slip it.
 Poor wretch! Your father and your lady mother will not³²
 close your eyes in death; the flesh-eating birds
 will pull at you long before, their wings beating thick about you.
 455 But me, when I die, the brilliant Achaeans will bury with honors."
 So speaking, he dragged the massive spear of war-minded Socus
 out of his flesh and out of his bossed shield;
 and when it was wrenched free the blood sprang up, and his heart sank.
 And the great-hearted Trojans, when they saw Odysseus's blood,
 460 called to one another through the crowd, and all made for him.
 He gave ground backward, and shouted to his companions.
 Three times he shouted, as loud as a man's head can hold,
 and three times Menelaus, dear to Ares, heard him crying,
 and quickly spoke to Ajax, who was near:
 465 "Ajax, Zeus-sprung son of Telamon, marshal of the people,
 the cry of patient-hearted Odysseus rings around me,

- and it sounds as though the Trojans had cut him off alone
in the strong encounter and were forcing him under.
Come, let us go through the crowd; better to defend him.
- 470 I fear he may suffer something, alone among the Trojans,
brave as he is, and a great longing come to the Danaans."
So speaking he led the way, and the other followed, a man like a god.
They found Odysseus, dear to Zeus; and around him
the Trojans pressed, like tawny jackals in the mountains
475 around an antlered stag that is wounded — a man has hit it
with an arrow from the bowstring, and it escaped him, running
on its feet, while the blood ran warm and its knees still lifted;
but when at last the swift arrow has beaten it down,
the flesh-eating jackals tear it apart in the mountains,
480 in a shadowy grove; but then some god leads in a ravening
lion, and the jackals scatter in terror, and he does the tearing —³³
so then around war-minded Odysseus of the subtle wiles
the Trojans pressed, many and stout, while the hero
lunging with his spear held off the pitiless day.
- 485 And Ajax came up close, carrying his shield like a tower,
and stood beside him; and the Trojans broke, every man a different
way.
Then warlike Menelaus led Odysseus out of the crowd,
holding him by the hand, till his aide drove the horses close.
And Ajax, springing on the Trojans, killed Doryclus,
490 Priam's bastard son, and then wounded Pandocus,
and wounded Lysander, and Pyrasus, and Pylartes.
As when a river in flood comes down onto the plain,
a winter torrent off the mountains, driven by the rain of Zeus,
and carries with it many dry oaks and many pines,
495 and flings much wrack and driftwood into the sea,
so glorious Ajax swept the plain then, harrying it,
slaughtering horses and men. And Hector knew nothing of it,
for he was fighting at the far left of the whole battle
by the banks of the river Scamander, where beyond all places
500 the heads of men were falling, and the quenchless roar had risen,
around great Nestor and warlike Idomeneus.
Among these Hector moved, wreaking deeds of havoc

with spear and horsemanship, wrecking the young men's battle-lines.
 Yet even so the brilliant Achaeans would not have given way
 505 from his path, had not Alexandros, the husband of lovely-haired Helen,
 stopped Machaon, shepherd of the people, in mid-valor,
 hitting his right shoulder with a three-barbed arrow.
 Then the Achaeans, breathing fury, feared for him,
 that the enemy might take him as the fighting tilted;
 510 and at once Idomeneus spoke to brilliant Nestor:
 "Nestor, Neleus' son, great glory of the Achaeans,
 up, mount your chariot; let Machaon mount beside you;
 and drive your whole-hoofed horses to the ships with all speed.
 For a healer is a man worth many other men together,
 515 at cutting out arrows and sprinkling gentle drugs."³⁴
 So he spoke, and the Gerenian horseman Nestor did not disobey.
 At once he mounted his chariot, and beside him Machaon
 mounted, the son of Asclepius the blameless healer;
 and he whipped the horses on, and the two flew, nothing loath,
 520 toward the hollow ships; for that way was dear to their hearts.
 But Cebriones, standing beside Hector, saw
 the Trojans being driven, and spoke his word to him:
 "Hector, the two of us are engaged with the Danaans here
 at the outermost edge of the harsh-sounding war, while the other
 525 Trojans are driven in confusion, horses and men together.
 Telamonian Ajax is driving them — I know him well,
 for the broad shield is around his shoulders. Come,
 let us steer our horses and chariot there, where beyond all
 horsemen and foot-soldiers, hurling their evil strife at one another,
 530 are killing each other, and the quenchless roar has risen."
 So speaking, he lashed the fair-maned horses on
 with the whistling whip; and feeling the stroke
 they carried the swift chariot lightly among Trojans and Achaeans,
 trampling corpses and shields; with blood the axle
 535 beneath was all spattered, and the rails that ran round the car,
 struck by the drops thrown up from the horses' hooves
 and from the wheel-rims. And Hector strained to plunge into the crowd
 of men and break it, leaping in; and an evil tumult
 he hurled among the Danaans, and gave the spear little rest.

540 But he kept ranging down the ranks of the other men
 with spear and sword and with great stones —
 yet he shunned the fight with Ajax, Telamon's son.

[Line 543 is absent from the printed text; see note 35.]

But father Zeus, high-throned, stirred fear in Ajax.³⁵
 545 he stood dazed, and slung the sevenfold-oxhide shield behind him,
 and trembled, glancing round at the crowd like a wild beast,
 turning this way and that, slowly changing knee for knee.
 As a fiery lion from a yard of cattle
 is driven off by dogs and countrymen,
 550 who will not let him take the fat of the herd,
 watching all night long; and he, craving the meat,
 charges in but gets nowhere, for javelins thick and fast
 fly out to meet him from daring hands,
 and burning brands besides, and he flinches at those for all his fury,
 555 and at dawn he goes off apart, sullen at heart;
 so Ajax then, sullen at heart, fell back from the Trojans,
 much against his will; for he feared for the Achaeans' ships.
 As when a donkey going past a cornfield masters the boys who drive
 him,
 a slow one, on whose ribs many sticks have been broken,
 560 and he gets in and crops the deep grain, while the boys
 beat him with sticks — but their strength is a child's strength —
 and only just drive him out when he has eaten his fill,
 so then great Ajax, Telamon's son, was harried
 by the high-hearted Trojans and their allies called from many lands,
 565 stabbing the middle of his shield with pikes, following him always.³⁶
 And Ajax would now remember his rushing courage,
 wheeling round again to hold back the battle-lines
 of the horse-taming Trojans; and now again turn to flee.
 But he barred them all from the path to the swift ships,
 570 standing alone between Trojans and Achaeans,
 raging. And the spears from daring hands
 stuck fast, some in his great shield, driving forward,
 and many midway, before they could reach the white flesh,
 stood planted in the earth, still hungry to glut themselves on it.
 575 But when Euaemon's shining son Eurypylus

- saw him under the pressure of the thick missiles,
 he came and stood beside him and cast with his shining spear,
 and hit Apisaon, Phausius' son, shepherd of the people,
 in the liver below the midriff, and unstrung his knees on the instant.
- 580 And Eurypylus sprang on him to strip the armor from his shoulders.
 But when godlike Alexandros saw him
 stripping the armor of Apisaon, at once he drew
 his bow at Eurypylus, and hit him with an arrow
 in the right thigh; the reed shaft snapped, and the thigh grew heavy.
- 585 Back into the band of his companions he shrank, dodging doom,
 and cried a piercing cry, to carry to the Danaans:
 "Friends, leaders and lords of the Argives,
 turn and stand, and beat off the pitiless day
 from Ajax, who is under pressure of missiles: I do not think
- 590 he will escape out of the harsh-sounding war. Come, stand
 face to face around great Ajax, Telamon's son."
 So spoke the wounded Eurypylus; and they stood
 close beside him, shields leaned against their shoulders,
 spears held high; and Ajax came to meet them,
- 595 and turned and stood, when he reached the band of his companions.
 So they fought on, like blazing fire;
 and the mares of Neleus, sweating, carried Nestor
 out of the battle, bringing Machaon too, shepherd of the people.
 And swift-footed brilliant Achilles saw him, and marked him;
- 600 for he stood on the stern of his ship, huge of hull,
 gazing at the sheer toil and the tearful rout.
 At once he spoke to his companion Patroclus,
 calling from beside the ship; and he heard it in the hut
 and came out, the equal of Ares — and that was the beginning of his
 evil.³⁷
- 605 Menoetius's stout son spoke to him first:
 "Why do you call me, Achilles? What need have you of me?"
 Answering him spoke swift-footed Achilles:
 "Brilliant son of Menoetius, delight of my heart,
 now I think the Achaeans will soon stand about my knees
- 610 begging; for the need that has come will not be borne.
 But go now, Patroclus dear to Zeus, and ask Nestor

who this wounded man is he brings out of the fighting.
 From behind, he looks in every way like Machaon,
 Asclepius' son — but I did not see the man's eyes,
 615 for the horses shot past me, straining forward."
 So he spoke, and Patroclus obeyed his dear companion,
 and set off running along the huts and ships of the Achaeans.
 Now when the others reached the hut of Neleus' son,
 they stepped down onto the earth that feeds so many,
 620 and Eurymedon, the old man's aide, loosed the horses
 from the chariot; and the two men cooled the sweat from their tunics,
 standing in the breeze by the shore of the sea; and then
 they went into the hut and sat down on the couches.
 And lovely-braided Hecamede made them a posset —
 625 the woman the old man took out of Tenedos, when Achilles sacked it,
 daughter of great-hearted Arsinous; the Achaeans
 had picked her out for him, because in counsel he was best of all.
 First she drew up before the two of them a table,
 fair, blue-enameled at the feet, well polished, and on it
 630 a bronze basket, and an onion beside it, relish for the drink,
 and pale honey, and beside it the meal of sacred barley,
 and a magnificent cup, which the old man had brought from home,
 studded with golden nails. Four handles
 it had, and about each one a pair of golden doves
 635 was feeding, and beneath it were two supports.
 Another man could barely have shifted it from the table
 when it was full; but Nestor, the old man, raised it without strain.³⁸
 In it the woman like the goddesses mixed them the posset
 with Pramnian wine, and over it grated goat's-milk cheese
 640 with a bronze grater, and sprinkled white barley on top,
 and invited them to drink, when she had made the posset ready.³⁹
 And when the two had drunk, and put away their parching thirst,
 they took their pleasure in talk, telling tales to one another;
 and Patroclus stood at the door, a man like a god.
 645 Seeing him, the old man rose from his shining chair,
 took him by the hand, led him in, and pressed him to be seated.
 But Patroclus, from where he stood, declined, and spoke a word:
 "No seat for me, aged sir, Zeus-nurtured; you will not persuade me.

- To be respected — and feared — is the man who sent me, to learn
 650 who this man is you bring in wounded. But I myself
 can see; I recognize Machaon, shepherd of the people.
 Now I will go back with the word, a messenger to Achilles.
 And you know well, aged sir, Zeus-nurtured, what kind of man
 he is — a terrible man. He would quickly blame even the blameless."⁴⁰
 655 Then answered him the Gerenian horseman Nestor:
 "Why is Achilles so full of pity now for the sons of the Achaeans,
 for all who have been hit by missiles? He knows nothing
 of the grief that has risen through the army: the best men
 lie by the ships, hit from afar or stabbed close.
 660 Hit is Tydeus' son, strong Diomedes;
 stabbed is Odysseus, famed with the spear; and Agamemnon;
 and hit too is Eurypylus, by an arrow in the thigh;
 and this man here is another, whom I have just brought
 out of the fighting, hit by an arrow from the bowstring. But Achilles,
 665 brave as he is, has no care for the Danaans and no pity.
 Is he waiting until the swift ships by the sea,
 against the will of the Argives, are warm with consuming fire,
 and we ourselves are killed one after another? For my strength
 is not what once it was in my supple limbs.
 670 Would that I were young like that, my strength still steady,
 as when the quarrel arose between us and the Eleians
 over a cattle-raid, when I killed Itymoneus,
 Hypeirochus' brave son, who lived in Elis,
 as I drove off our reprisal. Defending his cattle
 675 he was hit among the foremost by a javelin from my hand,
 and fell; and his country people scattered in terror.
 And we drove together plunder out of that plain past counting:
 fifty herds of cattle, as many flocks of sheep,
 as many droves of pigs, as many wide-ranging herds of goats,
 680 and a hundred and fifty tawny horses,
 all mares, and many with foals beneath them.
 All these we drove at night into Neleian Pylos,
 into the town; and Neleus was glad at heart
 that so much had fallen to me, going young to war.
 685 And with the showing of dawn the heralds cried aloud

- for all to come who were owed a debt in brilliant Elis;
 and the leading men of the Pylians gathered together
 and divided it up — for the Epeians owed a debt to many,
 few and battered as we were in Pylos:
- 690 for the might of Heracles had come and battered us
 in the years before, and all our best men had been killed.
 Twelve sons of blameless Neleus we had been,
 and of these I alone was left; the others had all perished.
 Puffed up over all this, the bronze-shirted Epeians
- 695 treated us with outrage, and devised their reckless works.
 And the old man chose out for himself a herd of cattle
 and a great flock of sheep — three hundred, with their herdsman —
 for a great debt was owed to him in brilliant Elis:
 four prize-winning horses, chariot and all,
- 700 come to the games to compete — for a tripod they were
 to race — and Augeias, lord of men, kept them
 there, and sent their driver home grieving for his horses.
 Angered by all this, words and deeds alike, the old man
 chose out a mass past telling; and the rest he gave to the people
- 705 to divide, so no man might go cheated of his fair share.
 So we were settling each matter, and around the town
 were offering sacrifice to the gods; and on the third day they came,
 all of them at once, men in numbers and whole-hoofed horses,
 in full force; and with them the two Moliones armed,
- 710 boys still, not yet well skilled in rushing courage.
 There is a city, Thryoessa, a steep hill
 far off on the Alpheius, at the edge of sandy Pylos:
 this they besieged, furious to raze it to the ground.
 But when they had crossed the whole plain, Athena
- 715 came running to us by night, a messenger from Olympus,
 crying "To arms!" — and no unwilling army did she gather
 in Pylos: men hot to fight. But Neleus would not
 let me arm myself, and hid my horses,
 for he said I did not yet know the works of war.
- 720 Even so I stood out among our own horsemen,
 on foot as I was, since Athena led the quarrel so.
 There is a river, Minyeïus, that falls into the sea

near Arene, where we waited for the brilliant Dawn,
we horsemen of the Pylians, while the streams of foot-soldiers flowed
in.

- 725 From there in full force, armed in our gear,
we came by midday to the sacred stream of Alpheius.
There we sacrificed fine victims to Zeus the almighty,
a bull to Alpheius, a bull to Poseidon,
and to grey-eyed Athena a cow of the herd,
730 and then took supper through the camp by companies,
and lay down to sleep, each man in his armor,
along the streams of the river. And the great-hearted Epeians
stood round the city, furious to raze it to the ground;
but before that could be, a great work of Ares showed before them:
735 for when the blazing sun stood clear above the earth,
we joined battle, praying to Zeus and Athena.
And when the fight between Pylians and Epeians began,
I was first to kill a man — and I took his whole-hoofed horses —
Mulius the spearman. He was Augeias' son-in-law,
740 husband of his eldest daughter, tawny-haired Agamede,
who knew as many drugs as the wide earth grows.
As he came on I hit him with the bronze-headed spear,
and he crashed in the dust; and I, springing into his chariot,
took my stand among the front-fighters. And the great-hearted Epeians
745 fled in terror every man a different way, when they saw the man fallen
who led their horsemen, who was their best in battle.
And I charged in on them like a black squall,
and took fifty chariots, and around each one two men
caught the earth in their teeth, broken under my spear.
750 And now I would have cut down the two Moliones, Actor's line,
had not their father, the wide-ruling earth-shaker,
saved them out of the war, wrapping them in thick mist.
Then Zeus handed great power to the Pylians:
for we followed them across the wide plain,
755 killing the men and gathering up their fine armor,
until we drove our horses to Buprasion rich in wheat
and the Olenian rock, and where the hill is called
the hill of Alesion; from there Athena turned our army back.

- There I killed the last man and left him. And the Achaeans
 760 steered their swift horses back from Buprasion to Pylos,
 and all gave glory among gods to Zeus, and among men to Nestor.
 Such was I among men — if ever I was. But Achilles⁴¹
 will have the profit of his valor alone. And yet I think
 he will weep for it bitterly, when the army has perished.
- 765 Dear boy, this was surely what Menoetius charged you
 on that day when he sent you out of Phthia to Agamemnon.
 The two of us were inside — I and brilliant Odysseus —
 and heard it all in the halls, everything he charged you.
 We had come to the well-built house of Peleus,
 770 gathering the army through Achaea that feeds so many,
 and there inside we found the hero Menoetius,
 and you, and Achilles beside you. The old horseman Peleus
 was burning the fat thigh-pieces of an ox to Zeus who delights in
 thunder,
 in the enclosure of the court; and he held a golden cup,
 775 pouring the fire-bright wine over the burning offerings.
 The two of you were busy with the ox's flesh; and we two
 stood in the doorway. Achilles sprang up amazed,
 took us by the hand, led us in, and pressed us to be seated,
 and set out a guest-meal well, all that is due to guests.
- 780 And when we had taken our pleasure of eating and drinking,
 I began the talk, and urged the two of you to follow us;
 and you were both entirely willing, and both fathers charged you well.
 Old Peleus charged his son Achilles
 always to be the best, and to hold his head above all others;
 785 and to you Menoetius, Actor's son, gave this charge:
 'My child, in birth Achilles is above you,
 but you are the elder — though in strength he is far the better.
 Speak to him a close-packed word; advise him well;
 give him direction: he will listen — for his own good.'⁴²
- 790 So the old man charged you — and you have forgotten. Yet even now
 you might say all this to war-minded Achilles, and he might listen.
 Who knows whether, with a god's help, you might stir his heart
 by your persuading? The persuasion of a companion is a good thing.
 But if in his heart he is dodging some prophecy,

795 something his lady mother has told him from Zeus,
then let him send you out at least, and let the rest of the army
of Myrmidons follow, and you may be a light to the Danaans;
and let him give you his fine armor to carry into the war,
so that the Trojans may take you for him, and hold back
800 from the fighting, and the warlike sons of the Achaeans catch their
breath,
worn as they are; for the breathing-spaces of war are few.
Fresh men, with one shout, could easily push men weary
of battle back on the city, away from the ships and the huts."⁴³
So he spoke, and stirred the heart in Patroclus's chest,
805 and he set off running along the ships to Achilles, son of Aeacus.
But when in his running Patroclus came to the ships
of godlike Odysseus, where the assembly and the judgment-ground
lay, and where the altars of the gods were built,
there wounded Eurypylus met him,
810 Euaemon's Zeus-sprung son, hit in the thigh by the arrow,
limping out of the battle; the sweat ran streaming down
his shoulders and his head, and from the grievous wound
the black blood trickled; but his mind held firm.
Seeing him, Menoetius's stout son pitied him,
815 and in sorrow he spoke winged words:
"Poor wretches, leaders and lords of the Danaans!
So it was your fate, far from your friends and your fatherland,
to glut the quick dogs of Troy with your white fat.
But come, tell me this, Zeus-nurtured Eurypylus, hero:
820 will the Achaeans somehow still hold gigantic Hector,
or will they perish now, broken under his spear?"
And wounded Eurypylus answered him face to face:
"No longer, Zeus-sprung Patroclus, will there be any bulwark
of the Achaeans; they will fall upon the black ships.
825 For all the men who before were our best
lie by the ships, hit from afar or stabbed close
at Trojan hands; and the enemy's strength rises and rises.
But save me now — take me to my black ship,
and cut the arrow out of my thigh, and wash the black blood
830 from it with warm water, and sprinkle on the wound the gentle drugs,

the good ones they say you have learned of from Achilles,
 whom Chiron taught, the most righteous of the Centaurs.
 For the healers, Podaleirius and Machaon —
 one, I think, lies wounded in the huts,
 835 himself in need of a blameless healer,
 and the other waits on the plain for the sharp war-god of the Trojans."
 Then Menoetius's stout son answered him:
 "How can these things be? What are we to do, Eurypylus, hero?
 I am on my way to tell war-minded Achilles the word
 840 that Nestor, the Gerenian, warden of the Achaeans, charged me with;
 but even so I will not abandon you in your suffering."
 He spoke, and gripping him under the chest led the shepherd of the
 people
 to his hut; and his aide, seeing them, spread down oxhides.
 There Patroclus laid him at full length, and with a knife cut
 845 the sharp, biting arrow out of his thigh, and washed the black blood
 from it with warm water, and cast on a bitter root,
 rubbing it between his hands, a pain-killer, which stayed
 all his pains; and the wound began to dry, and the blood stopped.⁴⁴

NOTES TO BOOK 11

- 1 ll. 1-2 Dawn rises "from her bed beside illustrious Tithonus" — the same couplet opens *Odyssey* 5, a famous cross-epic doublet. Tithonus is the Trojan prince (brother of Priam, 20.237) whom Dawn carried off as her consort; the story of his withering immortality is later. A new dawn-formula for the register, distinct from "early-born rosy-fingered Dawn": this is the dawn of the poem's longest day, which will not set until 18.239-242.
- 2 ll. 3-14 Strife (Eris) opens the day as Dream opened Book 2 — Zeus's emissary to a sleeping army. Lines 5-9 repeat the camp geometry of 8.222-226 in our same words: Odysseus's ship lies at the midpoint of the beached fleet, Ajax and Achilles hold the exposed ends. And 13-14 repeat 2.453-454 ("war became sweeter to them than going home...") — there the effect of Odysseus and Athena rallying a mob that had run for the ships; here the work of a shrieking goddess. Ancient critics (Zenodotus omitted, Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized) judged the couplet wrongly repeated here; the poet's point may be exactly the repetition: what rhetoric did in Book 2, mere *din* does now.
- 3 ll. 20-23 Cinyras, legendary king of Cyprus — the island's only appearance in the *Iliad*. He hears the "great report" (κλέος) of the coming war and buys his distance from it with a corslet: a guest-gift as diplomatic exemption. Later tradition made him promise fifty ships and send one real ship and forty-nine clay models; the poem knows only the elegant bribe.
- 4 ll. 24-28 κύανος, rendered "blue enamel," is dark-blue glass paste or niello inlay — a genuine Bronze Age luxury technique (the inlaid daggers of Mycenae). Serpents "like rainbows" that Zeus "sets in a cloud, a portent for mortal men": the rainbow as omen of war or storm (17.547-549), armor that carries the day's weather on the king's chest.
- 5 ll. 36-37 The Gorgon between Terror and Panic (Deimos and Phobos, capitalized personifications since 4.440): the shield's face is the face of battle itself — cf. the aegis at 5.739-742, which carries the same company.
- 6 ll. 45-46 Athena and Hera thunder in honor of "the king of Mycenae rich in gold" — a unique gesture: thunder is Zeus's instrument, but the arming of the paramount king draws a salute from the two pro-Achaean goddesses. The *aristeia* of Agamemnon is thus formally announced; it will last some two hundred lines.
- 7 ll. 52-55 Zeus rains dew dripping with blood — the sky itself hemorrhaging before the killing (again at 16.459, for Sarpedon, where the drops are explicitly tears). Line 55 reads "many strong heads" where the proem (1.3) has "many strong souls"; ancient copies show the variant ψυχάς here too — the echo of the poem's opening is audible either way.
- 8 ll. 62-66 Hector as the "baleful star" (οὐλιος ἀστὴρ) that shows and hides among clouds: the star similes track him and Achilles across the poem until Achilles becomes the Dog Star itself at 22.26-31 — "brightest of all, but an evil sign."

- 9 *ll. 67-73* The reapers: two lines of harvesters facing each other, driving swathes toward the middle of a rich man's field — armies as farmhands, the plain as harvest. "The battle held their heads level" (72): the fighting itself is the subject, holding the two lines like a beam of scales (cf. Zeus's actual scales, 8.69). Then the wolves; and Strife alone of the gods present, rejoicing — the day's one spectator-deity on the field, while Zeus watches from Ida "exulting in his glory."
- 10 *ll. 78-83* The gods sit at home blaming Zeus; he ignores them. Zenodotus omitted the passage and Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized it, apparently as inconsistent with the gods' oath-bound quiescence of Book 8. But the tableau — all heaven sulking in its fine houses while one god watches the killing with pleasure — is the day's theology in miniature.
- 11 *ll. 84-91* The register morning-line (fixed at 8.66-67) is followed by the poem's homeliest time-stamp: the hour when the woodcutter, arms weary, makes his midday meal. Homer's clock runs on labor, not hours — dawn, the woodcutter's dinner, the unyoking of oxen (16.779). At that hour the line breaks, and the *aristeia* proper begins.
- 12 *ll. 101-112* Isus and Antiphus: Achilles once caught these same two on Ida, bound them with willow shoots, and released them for ransom — pastoral war, an economy of capture and return. Agamemnon recognizes them and kills them: the third ransom-refusal of the poem (6.45-65 Adrestus; 10.378-457 Dolon) and the mark of what the war has become since Achilles left it.
- 13 *ll. 122-147* Peisander and Hippolochus: their father Antimachus took Paris's gold to block the return of Helen, and proposed murdering the ambassador Menelaus (the embassy of 3.205-224). Agamemnon's sentence — "now you will pay for your father's foul outrage" — is justice as inherited debt, and the execution (hands sheared off, head struck off, the trunk sent "rolling like a stone") is the poem's most clinical mutilation. The frame is a bitter pun kept from the Greek: they beg "with honeyed words" (*μειλιχίοις*) and hear a voice "unhoneyed" (*ἀμείλικτον*). Compare 21.98-135, where Achilles will answer a suppliant's plea with the same adjective and worse.
- 14 *ll. 159-162* The empty chariots rattling down the causeways, their drivers "far dearer now to the vultures than to their wives" — the *aristeia*'s cost stated in one hexameter of domestic arithmetic. It prepares the Iphidamas vignette (note [20]).
- 15 *ll. 166-168* The rout streams past the tomb of Ilus and the wild fig tree: the plain's fixed survey-marks (the tomb: 10.415, and again 11.371; the fig tree: 6.433, 22.145). Landmarks let the audience feel the front move — from mid-plain to the Scaean Gates and the oak, and back again within the book.
- 16 *ll. 172-178* "in the milking-dark of night" (*νυκτὸς ἀμολγῶ*) — an already-obscure formula (recurring 15.324, 22.28, 22.317) connected by the ancients with milking-time; the lion who scatters the whole herd but eviscerates one cow is Agamemnon exactly: the multitude flees, the hindmost dies.
- 17 *ll. 179-180* Omitted by Zenodotus, athetized by Aristarchus (179-180) and Aristophanes (180): the couplet generalizing the slaughter ("many fell from their chariots...") judged a weak doublet of what precedes.

- 18 *ll. 185-194* Zeus's message is the day's script, delivered in advance: Agamemnon's wounding as the trigger-clause, Hector's power to run "until he reaches the ships and the sun goes down and the sacred darkness comes on." Everything from here to 18.242 executes this sentence. Iris relays it with the change the grammar demands and nothing more (202-209 = 187-194) — divine messages are verbatim or they are nothing (cf. 2.23-33).
- 19 *ll. 218-220* The Muse-invocation repeats 2.484 in our fixed line — full formality for a single duel: Iphidamas is granted a catalogue-style entrance, which is his funeral honor too (the other invocations: 2.484, 14.508, 16.112).
- 20 *ll. 221-247* Iphidamas of Thrace: raised by his grandfather Cisses, married to his young aunt (Theano's sister — the poet does not pause over it), he left the bridal chamber for the war and "slept a sleep of bronze" — χάλκεον ὕπνον, the poem's hardest metal laid over its softest noun. The bride-price arithmetic — a hundred cattle down, a thousand head promised — turns the obituary into a ledger: everything paid, nothing enjoyed. This is the Iliad's marriage-economics of death at its most explicit, and the template for Protesilaus (2.700-702) and for Othryoneus later (13.363-382).
- 21 *ll. 248-263* Coon wounds Agamemnon and dies trying to drag his brother's body clear; Agamemnon beheads him over the corpse — the two sons of Antenor "filled up their measure of doom" in one another's arms. Antenor, the Trojan advocate of returning Helen (7.347-353), loses two sons in this book to the king Helen was taken from; the poet says nothing, and the silence does the work.
- 22 *ll. 269-272* The wounded king's pain is a woman's labor: the sharp shaft the Eileithyiai send, "Hera's daughters, keepers of the bitter pangs." The inversion is deliberate and unique — the most masculine act in the heroic economy, the aristeia, ends in the most feminine of agonies; war-wound and birth-pang are the poem's two involuntary cries. The Eileithyiai (birth-goddesses) enter the register here; one returns at 16.187, 19.103.
- 23 *ll. 299-300* The narrator's roll-call question, fixed at 5.703: here it marks the transfer of the aristeia — the same frame that measured Hector-and-Ares now measures Hector alone, with "when Zeus gave him the glory" as the ominous answer-clause.
- 24 *ll. 310-319* The register despair-line (8.130) sounds again, and Diomedes' answer to Odysseus is the day's arithmetic at its most honest: I will stand, "but small will be our profit," since Zeus wills it otherwise. Piety and futility in one breath — the last speech of Diomedes' fighting day.
- 25 *ll. 328-334* The two sons of Merops of Percote fall to Diomedes: lines 329-332 repeat their Catalogue entry (2.831-834) almost verbatim, our wording kept. The Catalogue planted the seer-father who foresaw and forbade and was not obeyed; Book 11 harvests it. Compare 5.148-151 (the sons of the dream-reader).
- 26 *ll. 349-356* Diomedes' cast rings off the helmet "which Phoebus Apollo gave him" — divine equipment as plot-armor — yet Hector goes down; 355-356 repeat 5.309-310 (Aeneas's swoon), our words kept, and the ancients athetized the repeat here. Hector's day of guaranteed glory (192-194) nearly ends at its opening; the promise covered the outcome, not the pain.

- 27 ll. 362-367 "Dog! Again you have run out from under death..." — this six-line taunt returns, word for word, in Achilles' mouth at 20.449-454. Diomedes has been the poem's stand-in Achilles all through the middle books; here he even pre-speaks him. Reuse the English verbatim there.
- 28 ll. 369-379 Paris shoots from the tomb of Ilus, leaning on the ancestor's grave-pillar — the city's founder as cover for the city's most criticized fighter — and comes up "laughing very sweetly." Three captains leave the field by his arrows in this book (Diomedes, Machaon, Eurypylus): the day of the bow.
- 29 ll. 385-395 "Bowman, foul-mouth, glorious with your curls, ogler of girls" — the concentrated contempt-vocabulary of the spear-ethos. "Glorious with your curls" renders κέρχ ἄγλαέ, an old crux: "horn" was read by some ancients as the horn bow, by others as a horn-shaped lovelock (the reading our translation follows; the apparatus records the living dispute). Diomedes' disdain — "I care no more than if a woman had hit me, or a witless child" — is the poem's fullest statement of the bow's dishonor; yet the arrow-graze sends him from the field for the rest of the epic's fighting, and an arrow of Paris will one day kill Achilles (19.416-417, 22.359-360). The taunt loses the war.
- 30 ll. 401-410 Odysseus alone: the poem's first full deliberative soliloquy ("Troubled, he spoke to his own great-hearted spirit" — a frame that will recur for Menelaus, Agenor, Hector). The deliberation runs the heroic code to its bare axiom: "cowards walk away; whoever would be best must stand, hit or hitting." Hector's fatal monologue at 22.99-130 is this scene's dark twin — there the same logic will forbid the retreat that would have saved him.
- 31 ll. 428-433 Socus — the only man in the poem to wound Odysseus — addresses him with a new-minted title: "Odysseus of the many tales, insatiate of tricks and of labor." Even his enemies speak his epithets; the compliment is the challenge.
- 32 ll. 450-455 Odysseus over Socus: your parents will not close your eyes; the birds will have you; "but me, when I die, the brilliant Achaeans will bury with honors." The grimmest speech Odysseus makes in the Iliad — burial as the last competitive good, boasted over a corpse (Plutarch quotes the lines in his Consolation). It is the exact inverse of the poem's ending, where the enemy dead is given back for burial.
- 33 ll. 473-484 The triple simile: jackals round the arrowed stag — until "some god leads in" a lion who scatters them and eats. Ajax arrives as the lion; the rescued Odysseus, uncomfortably, occupies the stag's place, and the "rescue" is another predation. In 480 Zenodotus read "hollow" for "shadowy" grove, and some copies inserted a line naming the shield of Tychius (= 7.220) after 485 — the apparatus notes both; the printed text keeps neither.
- 34 ll. 514-515 "A healer is a man worth many other men together" — proverbial ever after; the specifying line 515 ("at cutting out arrows and sprinkling gentle drugs") was omitted by Zenodotus and athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus as a prosaic gloss. Homeric medicine is exactly these two skills — extraction and pharmacy — practiced by warriors: Machaon and Podaleirius are fighting doctors, and when both are down the craft passes to laymen taught by laymen (830-832: Patroclus, taught by Achilles, taught by Chiron).

- 35 *l. 543* The printed Greek text genuinely lacks line 543 (the numbering jumps 542 to 544): the line was absent from the medieval manuscripts and is known because Aristotle quotes it, discussing righteous indignation (Rhetoric 1387a; cf. Plutarch's citations of the passage): "for Zeus would be indignant with him, whenever he fought a better man" — Ajax retreating not from Hector but from theology. Editors since Wolf print it in brackets; the Oxford text omits it, and the translation reproduces the gap. With 9.458-461, this is the second transmission-wound this translation keeps visible.
- 36 *ll. 544-565* The double simile of Ajax's retreat: first the lion driven all night from the cattle-yard by dogs, javelins, and firebrands, going off "sullen at heart" at dawn; then, without pause, the donkey — slow, stick-broken, cropping the deep grain while boys beat him, leaving only when he is full. The lion was athetized by Zenodotus (548-557), and ancient taste flinched at the donkey; but the pair is the whole portrait: nobility from inside Ajax's chest, comedy from outside — the strongest man in the army backing away at his own pace, the only donkey in Homer, and one of the great tonal risks in epic.
- 37 *ll. 596-604* The hinge of the Iliad. Achilles, "gazing at the sheer toil and the tearful rout" from his stern — spectator by choice — sees Nestor pass with a wounded man and calls out Patroclus, who comes out "the equal of Ares — and that was the beginning of his evil" (ἐκμολεν ἴσος Ἄρηϊ, κακοῦ δ' ἄρα οἱ πέλεν ἀρχή). The narrator breaks his own reticence to mark the moment: a door opens, and the poem names it fate. Achilles' stated hope — "now I think the Achaeans will soon stand about my knees begging" — shows the wrath still fed by the sight; his curiosity about one wounded man is what kills his friend.
- 38 *ll. 632-637* The cup of Nestor: golden studs, four handles, doves feeding at each — and the poet's tape-measure detail that another man could barely lift it full, "but Nestor, the old man, raised it without strain." On a clay cup from Pithekoussai (Ischia), c. 730-720 BC, someone scratched three lines: "I am the cup of Nestor, good to drink from; whoever drinks from me, straightway desire of fair-crowned Aphrodite will seize." It is among the oldest surviving Greek writing — and it is a joke that only works on an audience that already knew this passage: the earliest external witness to the Iliad in circulation. Scholars have matched the described cup to Mycenaean finds (the gold "dove cup" from Shaft Grave IV); the poem's furniture is centuries older than the poem.
- 39 *ll. 624-641* Hecamede — Nestor's prize-woman from Tenedos, sacked by Achilles (every comfort in this hut traces back to the man refusing to fight) — mixes the κυκεῶν, "posset": Pramnian wine, grated goat's-milk cheese, white barley, with honey and onion as relish alongside. Plato quotes the recipe (Ion 538c) — and elsewhere (Republic 405e-406a) makes it a scandal of Homeric medicine that a wine posset is served to wounded men; Machaon, shot through the shoulder, drinks it. The same drink, drugged, is Circe's instrument in Odyssey 10 — the ordinary hospitality this scene shows straight.
- 40 *l. 654* "a terrible man. He would quickly blame even the blameless" — Patroclus on Achilles, the poem's most intimate character-note: fear inside love. Plutarch quotes the line (How to Tell a Flatterer). Patroclus will say the harder version to Achilles' face at 16.29-35 ("your parent was the grey sea and the cliffs").

- 41 *ll. 656-762* Nestor's Pylian epic, his longest memory: the cattle-raid against Elis, the debt-division at dawn, Heracles' devastation of Pylos (eleven brothers dead), the Moliones saved by their father Poseidon, and Nestor's first aristeia — fifty chariots taken, "two men around each." Its function is paradigm: the young Nestor fought although Neleus forbade him and hid his horses; Achilles, with every power to fight, withholds. (One line of the tale, 699, is flagged in the scholia as suspected spurious.) The close is the old man's whole tragedy in seven words: "Such was I among men — if ever I was" (εἴ ποτ' ἔον γε) — glory so far off that its owner half-doubts it happened.
- 42 *ll. 765-790* The send-off at Peleus's house: the embassy of recruitment, the sacrifice in the courtyard, young Achilles leaping up to seat the guests — the poem's one glimpse of its hero at home, in a scene of pure *xenia*. Peleus's charge repeats 6.208 word for word in Greek and in our English — "always to be the best, and to hold one's head above all others" — the aristocratic imperative issued identically to Glaucus and to Achilles; and against it Menoetius sets the other ethic: you are lesser-born and weaker, but older — advise him. Patroclus's whole life is in that division of labor. Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized 767-785 (the reminiscence's core!) as inconsistent in its geography; the vulgate kept it, and so does the printed text.
- 43 *ll. 794-803* The fatal plan, invented by Nestor: if a prophecy holds Achilles back, "let him send you out at least... and let him give you his fine armor to carry into the war, so that the Trojans may take you for him." Patroclus will repeat these lines to Achilles nearly verbatim at 16.36-45 — reuse this English there. Ancient critics chipped at the passage from both ends (794-795 athetized by Zenodotus; 802-803 by Aristarchus, as lifted from 16.44-45 — where they stand in Patroclus's mouth). "You may be a light to the Danaans": the image is of the beacon-fire — and what the disguise actually buys is Patroclus's death, Hector's brief triumph, and Achilles' return. The oldest man in the army, meaning pure good, sets the poem's catastrophe in motion in ten lines.
- 44 *ll. 804-848* The delay that structures the middle of the poem: Patroclus, running back with Nestor's words in him, is stopped at the assembly-ground by wounded Eurypylus, pities him, and stays — "even so I will not abandon you in your suffering." He cuts out the arrow, washes the wound, crushes the bitter root: the healer's craft learned from Achilles, learned from Chiron "the most righteous of the Centaurs" — the gentlest genealogy in the poem, running through its two great killers. Patroclus will still be in this hut at 15.390-404, and what finally moves him is watching the wall fail. The book's last clause — "and the wound began to dry, and the blood stopped" — repeats 267 exactly: Agamemnon's wound opened the day's subtraction, Eurypylus's closes the book; between the two dryings, the poem has chosen its victim.

Iliad — Book 12

*The Trojans storm the Greek wall; Sarpedon tears down the rampart, and
Hector smashes the gate with a boulder.*

- So in the huts Menoetius's stout son
was healing wounded Eurypylus. But the others fought on,¹
Argives and Trojans in their masses; nor was the ditch
to hold much longer, nor the wide wall above it
- 5 the Danaans built to shield the ships — they drove the ditch
around it, but gave the gods no glorious hecatombs —
so that it might guard for them the swift ships and the great
plunder within. It was built against the will of the gods,
the immortals; and so it stood firm for no long time.
- 10 So long as Hector was alive, and Achilles in his wrath,
and the city of lord Priam unsacked,
so long the great wall of the Achaeans too stood firm.
But when all the best of the Trojans had died,
and of the Argives many were broken, though some were left,
- 15 and Priam's city was sacked in the tenth year,
and the Argives had gone in their ships to their dear fatherland,
then at last Poseidon and Apollo took counsel
to wash the wall away, turning against it the fury of rivers,
all that flow from the mountains of Ida down to the sea:
- 20 Rhesus and Heptaporus, Caresus and Rhodius,
Granicus and Aesepus, and brilliant Scamander,
and Simois, where so many oxhide shields and helmets
had fallen in the dust, and the race of half-god men:
the mouths of all these Phoebus Apollo turned together,
- 25 and nine days hurled their flood against the wall; and Zeus rained
without ceasing, to drown the wall in sea the sooner.
And the earth-shaker himself, trident in hand,
led them, and sent out on the waves all the foundations
of beams and stones the Achaeans had laid with labor,
- 30 and made all smooth along the strong-flowing Hellespont,
and covered the great beach over again with sand,

- the wall washed away; and he turned the rivers back to run
in their channels, where before they had poured their fair streams.²
So Poseidon and Apollo were to dispose of it
- 35 hereafter. But now battle and clamor blazed
around the well-built wall, and the beams of the towers rang
under the blows. The Argives, broken under the whip of Zeus,
were penned by the hollow ships and held there,
dreading Hector, the strong machine of rout;
- 40 while he, as before, fought on like a whirlwind.
As when among hounds and hunting men
a boar or lion wheels, glorying in his strength,
and they form themselves into a tower-line
and stand to face him, hurling from their hands
- 45 spearheads thick and fast; but his glorious heart
knows no fear and no flight — and his courage kills him —³
and again and again he wheels, testing the ranks of men,
and wherever he charges, there the ranks of men give way:
so Hector went through the crowd and begged his companions,
- 50 urging them to cross the ditch. But his swift-footed horses
did not dare it; loudly they neighed, standing
at the very lip, for the wide ditch frightened them off —
not easy to leap from close up, nor to drive across,
for overhanging banks stood all around it
- 55 on both sides, and above it was fitted with pointed
stakes, planted by the sons of the Achaeans,
close-set and great, a defense against enemy men.
A horse straining at a well-wheeled chariot could not easily
get in; but the foot-soldiers were mad to try it.
- 60 Then Polydamas came and stood by daring Hector:
"Hector, and you other leaders of Trojans and allies,
it is folly to drive our swift horses across the ditch.
It is very hard to cross: sharp stakes
stand in it, and right up against them is the Achaeans' wall.
- 65 There is no way down there, no way to fight
for men in chariots: the space is narrow, and I think we would be hurt.
For if Zeus who thunders on high, with evil in mind,
is wiping out the Achaeans utterly, eager to help the Trojans,

- then I too would wish it done this very instant —
 70 the Achaeans perishing here, nameless, far from Argos.
 But if they turn on us, and we are driven back
 from the ships, and get ourselves tangled in the dug ditch,
 then not even a messenger, I think, will make it back
 to the city, once the Achaeans have wheeled on us.
- 75 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:
 let the aides hold the horses at the ditch,
 while we ourselves, on foot, armed in our gear,
 follow Hector in one mass; and the Achaeans
 will not hold, if the cables of destruction are fastened on them."
- 80 So spoke Polydamas, and the prudent word pleased Hector,⁴
 and at once he leapt with his weapons from the chariot to the ground.
 Nor did the other Trojans stay massed on their chariots:
 they all sprang down, when they saw brilliant Hector do it.
 Then each man gave his charioteer the order
- 85 to hold the horses in good order there at the ditch;
 and they divided, formed themselves in companies,
 and marshaled in five bodies they followed their leaders.
 Those who went with Hector and blameless Polydamas
 were the most and the best, and were most determined
- 90 to break the wall and fight beside the hollow ships;
 and Cebriones followed as third man — by the chariot
 Hector had left another man, a lesser one than Cebriones.
 The second body Paris led, with Alcatous and Agenor;
 the third, Helenus and godlike Deiphobus,
- 95 two sons of Priam; the third with them was the hero Asius —
 Asius, Hyrtacus' son, whom horses carried from Arisbe,⁵
 tall and fire-colored, from the river Selleïs.
 The fourth was led by Anchises' brave son
 Aeneas, and with him Antenor's two sons,
- 100 Archelochus and Acamas, well skilled in all fighting.
 And Sarpedon led the far-famed allies,
 choosing to himself Glaucus and warlike Asteropaeus,
 for they seemed to him beyond dispute the best
 of the rest after himself — he stood out even among all.⁶
- 105 And when they had locked shields of worked oxhide together,

- they went straight for the Danaans, hot with eagerness, certain
the Achaeans would hold no longer, but fall upon the black ships.
Then the other Trojans and their far-famed allies
obeyed the counsel of blameless Polydamas;
- 110 but Asius, Hyrtacus' son, marshal of men, refused
to leave his horses there with his charioteer-aide:
with horses and all he drove at the swift ships —
the fool: he was not to dodge the evil death-spirits
and come home again, exulting in horses and chariot,
- 115 back from the ships to windy Ilion.
Before that, fate of the hateful name closed round him
through the spear of Idomeneus, Deucalion's illustrious son.⁷
For he steered left of the ships, where the Achaeans
came back out of the plain with horses and chariots;
- 120 there he drove his horses and car, and at the gates
he found the doors not shut, the long bar not in place:
men were holding them thrown open, hoping to save
any companion in flight from the battle, and bring him to the ships.
Straight for that point, deliberate, he held his horses, and his men
- 125 followed, screaming sharply, certain the Achaeans
would hold no longer, but fall upon the black ships —
the fools: at the gates they found two men of the bravest,
high-hearted sons of Lapith spearmen,
one the son of Peirithous, strong Polypoetes,
- 130 the other Leonteus, the equal of Ares bane of mortals.
These two, in front of the high gates,
stood like high-crowned oaks in the mountains
that abide the wind and rain through all their days,
fast-fixed by their great roots running deep —
- 135 so the two of them, trusting their hands and their strength,
abode the coming of great Asius, and did not run.
But the Trojans, holding their dried-oxhide shields high,
came straight for the well-built wall with a great war-shout
around lord Asius, and Iamenus, and Orestes,
- 140 and Asius's son Adamas, and Thoon, and Oenomaus.
And for a while the two, staying inside, were urging
the strong-greaved Achaeans to defend the ships;

but when they saw the Trojans storming at the wall,
 and shouting and panic broke out among the Danaans,
 145 the two burst out and fought in front of the gates
 like a pair of wild boars in the mountains
 that stand the oncoming rabble of men and dogs,
 and charging slantwise shatter the timber around them,
 shearing it off at the root, and from under comes the noise
 150 of gnashing tusks, until a man's cast takes their life:
 so the shining bronze on their chests rang under the blows
 struck face to face; for they fought hard indeed,
 trusting the troops above them and their own strength.⁸
 For the men above hurled stones from the well-built towers,
 155 defending themselves, their huts,
 and the swift-faring ships. Like snowflakes the stones fell earthward,
 flakes a blustering wind, driving the shadowed clouds,
 pours thick and fast on the earth that feeds so many:
 so the missiles streamed from their hands, from Achaeans
 160 and Trojans alike; and helmets and bossed shields
 rang harsh and dry, pounded with millstone rocks.
 Then Asius, Hyrtacus' son, groaned aloud and struck
 both his thighs, and spoke in outrage:
 "Father Zeus, so even you, it turns out, are an utter
 165 lover of lies! I did not think the Achaean heroes
 would stand our fury and our invincible hands —
 and they, like wasps of the nimble waist, or bees
 that make their homes beside a rocky road
 and will not abandon their hollow house, but stay
 170 and fight off the raiding men for their children's sake,
 so these men will not give back from the gates, two though they are,
 until they kill or are taken."⁹
 So he spoke, but speaking did not persuade the mind of Zeus:
 his heart willed the glory for Hector.
 175 And others fought the fight at other gates —
 hard for me to tell it all through, as though I were a god:¹⁰
 for everywhere around the wall a prodigious fire had risen,
 a fire of stone; and the Argives, grieved to the heart,
 fought on for the ships by necessity; and the gods were downcast,

- 180 all of them who were the Danaans' helpers in the fighting.
 And the Lapiths clashed into war and combat.
 There the son of Peirithous, strong Polypoetes,
 hit Damasus with the spear through the bronze-cheeked helmet:
 the bronze helmet did not hold; straight on through
 185 the bronze point broke the bone, and the brain
 was all spattered inside it. He broke him in mid-charge.
 And after him he stripped the life from Pylon and Ormenus.
 And Leonteus, scion of Ares, hit Antimachus's son
 Hippomachus with the spear, catching him at the war-belt;
 190 then drawing his sharp sword out of its sheath
 he sprang through the crowd and struck Antiphates first,
 close-in, hand to hand; he crashed on his back on the ground;
 and after him Menon, and Iamenus, and Orestes —
 all these, one on another, he brought down to the earth that feeds so
 many.
- 195 While they were stripping the glittering armor from these,
 the young men who followed Polydamas and Hector,
 who were the most and the best, and were most determined
 to break the wall and set fire to the ships,
 still stood at the ditch's edge and were divided in mind:
 200 for a bird had come upon them as they strained to cross:
 an eagle, flying high, herding the army to the left,
 carrying in its talons a monstrous blood-red snake,
 alive, still writhing — and it had not forgotten its war-craft,
 for it struck the bird that held it, on the chest beside the neck,
 205 coiling itself backward; and the eagle flung it from him earthward,
 stung with the pain, and let it fall in the middle of the crowd,
 and with a scream flew off down the gusts of the wind.
 And the Trojans shuddered when they saw the writhing snake
 lying in their midst: a portent of aegis-bearing Zeus.¹¹
- 210 Then Polydamas came and stood by daring Hector:
 "Hector, always somehow you rebuke me in the assemblies
 though I counsel well — since it is never fitting, it seems,
 for a man of the people to speak against you, in council
 or ever in war, but always to swell your power.
 215 Yet now once more I will say what seems to me best.

Let us not go forward to fight the Danaans for the ships.
 For this, I think, is how it will end — if truly
 this bird came for the Trojans as they strained to cross:
 an eagle, flying high, herding the army to the left,
 220 carrying in its talons a monstrous blood-red snake,
 alive — and it dropped it before it reached its own nest,
 and never finished carrying it home to give its young.
 So we: even if we break the gates and the wall
 of the Achaeans by main strength, and the Achaeans give way,
 225 we will come back from the ships in no good order by the same road;
 for we will leave many Trojans behind, whom the Achaeans
 will cut down with the bronze, defending their ships.
 So a reader of gods' signs would interpret, one whose heart
 truly knew the portents, and the people would believe him."
 230 Glaring at him darkly, Hector of the flashing helmet answered:
 "Polydamas, this talk of yours pleases me no longer;
 you know how to think another word, better than this one.
 But if you truly say this thing in earnest,
 then the gods themselves have destroyed your wits —
 235 you who tell me to forget the counsels of loud-thundering
 Zeus, which he himself promised me, and bowed his head;
 you who tell me to put my faith in birds
 with wings outstretched. I take no thought of them, no care
 whether they go to the right, toward the dawn and the sun,
 240 or to the left, toward the misty dark.
 Let us put our faith in the counsel of great Zeus,
 who is king over all mortals and immortals.
 One bird-sign is best: to fight for your fatherland.¹²
 Why are you so afraid of war and combat?
 245 For even if the rest of us are killed to a man
 beside the Argive ships, you need not fear to perish:
 your heart is not battle-staunch, not a fighter's heart.
 But if you hang back from the fighting, or talk any other man
 around with your words and turn him away from war,
 250 struck down at once under my spear you will lose your life."
 So speaking he led the way, and they followed him
 with a prodigious roar; and Zeus who delights in thunder

- roused out of the mountains of Ida a squall of wind
 that carried the dust straight at the ships; and it bewitched
 255 the mind of the Achaeans, and handed glory to the Trojans and
 Hector.¹³
- Trusting his portents, then, and their own strength,
 they set to trying to break the great wall of the Achaeans.
 They dragged at the towers' galleries, pulled down the breastworks,
 and levered up the jutting buttress-piles the Achaeans
 260 had set first in the earth to shore the towers:¹⁴
 these they tried to pull out, hoping to break the wall
 of the Achaeans. But the Danaans did not yet yield the path:
 they fenced the breastworks with oxhide shields
 and from behind them hurled at the enemy coming under the wall.
- 265 And the two Ajaxes, marshaling on the towers,
 ranged everywhere, urging on the fury of the Achaeans;
 one man with honeyed words, another with hard ones
 they would lash, whomever they saw hanging wholly back from the
 fight:
 "Friends — you who are excellent among the Argives, you who are
 middling,
 270 you who are lesser — since men are in no way all equal
 in war — now there is work for every man of you,¹⁵
 and you know it yourselves. Let no one turn back
 toward the ships now he has heard the man who drives you;
 press forward instead, and call each other on,
 275 in hope that Olympian Zeus, lord of lightning, may grant us
 to beat back the assault and drive our enemies to their city."
 So the two, shouting ahead, stirred up the Achaeans' battle.
 And as flakes of snow fall thick and fast on a winter's day,
 when Zeus the counselor has bestirred himself to snow
 280 on mankind, and shows them what his missiles are,
 and lulling the winds he pours it down steadily, until he has covered
 the peaks of the high mountains, and the jutting headlands,
 and the clover meadows, and men's rich worked fields;
 and it is poured out over the harbors and shores of the grey sea,
 285 and only the wave, breaking on it, keeps it off; but all things else
 are wrapped from above, when the storm of Zeus drives down upon it:¹⁶

so from both sides their stones flew thick and fast,
 some onto the Trojans, some from Trojans onto Achaeans,
 as they pelted each other; and over the whole wall the din rose.
 290 Yet not even then would the Trojans and glorious Hector
 have broken the gates of the wall and the long bar,
 had not Zeus the counselor roused his own son Sarpedon
 against the Argives, like a lion on twist-horned cattle.¹⁷
 At once he held before him his shield, balanced every way,
 295 fair, of hammered bronze, which the smith had hammered out,
 stitching inside it oxhides thick and close
 with golden rods running unbroken round the rim.¹⁸
 Holding this before him, shaking his two spears,
 he went his way like a mountain-bred lion who has long
 300 gone hungry for meat, and his proud spirit drives him
 to make trial of the flocks, to go even into the close-built fold;
 and even if he finds the herdsmen there beside them,
 watching over the sheep with dogs and spears,
 he will not be driven from the steading without his try:
 305 either he leaps in and seizes one, or himself
 is hit among the foremost by a javelin from a quick hand:
 so then his spirit drove godlike Sarpedon
 to rush the wall and break through the breastworks.
 And at once he spoke to Glaucus, Hippolochus's son:
 310 "Glaucus, why is it that we two are honored beyond all
 with the seat of honor, and the cuts of meat, and full cups,
 in Lycia, and all men look on us like gods,
 and we are granted a great estate on the banks of Xanthus,
 fine land, orchard and wheat-bearing plowland?
 315 For that, it is our duty now to stand among the first
 of the Lycians, and to meet the blaze of battle,
 so that many a Lycian in his close armor may say:
 'No, they are not inglorious, these kings of ours
 who rule in Lycia, who eat the fat sheep
 320 and drink the choice honey-sweet wine: their strength too
 is noble, since they fight among the first of the Lycians.'
 Old friend, if the two of us could escape this war
 and live forever, ageless and immortal,

I would not fight among the foremost myself,
 325 nor would I send you into the battle where men win glory.
 But now — since the death-spirits stand over us
 in their thousands, and no mortal can flee them or slip past —
 let us go: we will give the triumph to some man, or he to us."¹⁹
 So he spoke; and Glaucus did not turn away or disobey,
 330 and the two went straight on, leading the great Lycian nation.
 And Menestheus, Peteos' son, shuddered to see them,
 for it was toward his tower they came, carrying ruin.
 He peered along the Achaean wall, hoping to see
 some captain who would ward off harm from his companions,
 335 and made out the two Ajaxes, never sated with war,
 standing there, and Teucer, just come from his hut,
 close by; but there was no way to shout and be heard,
 so great was the din — the clamor went up to heaven —
 of battered shields and horsehair-crested helmets
 340 and of the gates: for all had been shut, and the Trojans
 stood against them, trying to break them by force and get in.
 At once he sent the herald Thootes to Ajax:
 "Go, brilliant Thootes — run, and call Ajax;
 or rather both of them; that would be best of all,
 345 since sheer destruction will soon be upon us here.
 The leaders of the Lycians bear down so — men who have always
 come storming into the strong encounters.
 But if toil and struggle have risen for them there as well,
 then at least let stout Telamonian Ajax come alone,
 350 and let Teucer follow with him, who knows the bow well."²⁰
 So he spoke; and the herald heard, and did not disobey,
 and set off running along the wall of the bronze-shirted Achaeans,
 and came and stood by the Ajaxes, and spoke at once:
 "You two Ajaxes, leaders of the bronze-shirted Argives:
 355 the dear son of Zeus-nurtured Peteos bids you
 come there, to share the toil at least a little while —
 or rather both of you; that would be best of all,
 since sheer destruction will soon be upon them there.
 The leaders of the Lycians bear down so — men who have always
 360 come storming into the strong encounters.

- But if here too war and struggle have risen,
 then at least let stout Telamonian Ajax come alone,
 and let Teucer follow with him, who knows the bow well."
 So he spoke, and great Telamonian Ajax did not disobey.
- 365 At once he spoke winged words to Oïleus' son:²¹
 "Ajax — you and strong Lycomedes stay here,
 stand fast, and urge the Danaans to fight their hardest.
 I will go over there and take my share of the fighting,
 and come back quickly, when I have given them good defense."
- 370 So speaking, Telamonian Ajax went off,
 and with him went Teucer, his brother by one father,
 and with them Pandion carried Teucer's curved bow.
 And when they reached the tower of great-hearted Menestheus,
 passing inside the wall — they came to men hard pressed,
- 375 for up onto the breastworks like a dark squall
 came the powerful leaders and lords of the Lycians;
 and they clashed together in combat, and the war-cry rose.
 Telamonian Ajax was first to kill his man:
 great-hearted Epicles, Sarpedon's companion,
- 380 striking him with a jagged block of marble that lay
 inside the wall, huge, topmost by the breastwork. Not easily
 could a man hold it in both hands, not in his youth's best,
 such as mortals are now; but he heaved it high and threw it,²²
 and crushed the four-bossed helmet, and smashed the bones
- 385 of the head all in together; and like a diver
 he dropped from the high tower, and the life left his bones.
 And Teucer hit Glaucus, Hippolochus's strong son,
 with an arrow as he came storming up the high wall,
 just where he saw the arm bared, and stopped his fighting.
- 390 He sprang back down from the wall, keeping hidden, so that no
 Achaean
 might see that he was hit and glory over him with words.²³
 And grief came over Sarpedon at Glaucus's going,
 the moment he knew it; but he did not forget his war-craft:
 he caught Alcmaon, Thestor's son, with a lunge of the spear
- 395 and stabbed, then wrenched the spear out; and the man, following the
 spear,

- fell on his face, and his armor, intricate with bronze, clashed about him.
 And Sarpedon, gripping the breastwork with his massive hands,
 pulled — and the whole length of it followed; and above,
 the wall was laid naked; and he had made a road for many.²⁴
- 400 Ajax and Teucer answered him together: Teucer's arrow
 struck the shining strap that held the man-covering shield
 about his chest; but Zeus beat the death-spirits away
 from his son — he was not to be broken by the ships' sterns —²⁵
 and Ajax, leaping in, stabbed at the shield; the spear
 405 did not drive through, but staggered him in mid-fury.
 He gave back a little space from the breastwork, but wholly
 he did not yield, for his heart still hoped to seize glory.
 Wheeling round, he called to the godlike Lycians:
 "Lycians, why do you slacken your rushing courage so?
- 410 It is hard for me, powerful as I am,
 to break through alone and make a path to the ships.
 Follow me in! More hands make better work."²⁶
 So he spoke; and they, in dread of their king's rebuke,
 pressed on harder around their counselor-king.
- 415 And the Argives on the other side strengthened their battle-lines
 inside the wall; and the work before them showed very great:
 for neither could the powerful Lycians break the wall
 of the Danaans and make a path to the ships,
 nor could the Danaan spearmen ever push back
 420 the Lycians from the wall, once they had come close against it.
 But as two men quarrel over boundary-stones,
 measuring-rods in hand, in a common field,
 who in a little strip of ground contend over the fair share:²⁷
 so the breastworks held them apart; and over them
 425 they hacked at one another, at the chests, at the oxhide
 shields, round and well-made, and the fluttering bucklers.
 Many were wounded in the flesh by the pitiless bronze,
 whenever a man turned and his back was left bare
 in the fighting, and many straight through the shield itself.
- 430 Everywhere the towers and breastworks were spattered
 with the blood of men, from both sides, Trojan and Achaean.
 But even so they could not turn the Achaeans to flight:

the lines held — as an honest working woman holds the scales,
 who with the weight in one pan and the wool in the other
 435 draws them level, to win a pitiful wage for her children:²⁸
 so their battle and their war were drawn level and taut,
 until the moment Zeus handed the higher glory to Hector,
 Priam's son, who was first to leap inside the wall of the Achaeans.
 He cried a piercing cry, to carry to the Trojans:
 440 "Rise up, horse-taming Trojans! Break the wall
 of the Argives, and hurl prodigious fire among the ships!"
 So he spoke, spurring them on; and every ear heard him,
 and they charged the wall in one mass; and then they
 began mounting the galleries, sharpened spears in hand,
 445 while Hector snatched up a stone and carried it — it stood
 before the gates, thick at the base and sharp
 on top; the two best men of a district could not easily
 lever it off the ground and onto a wagon,
 such as mortals are now; but he swung it easily, even alone,²⁹
 450 for the son of crooked-counseled Cronos made it light for him.
 As when a shepherd carries the fleece of a ram
 easily in one hand, and its weight is little burden,
 so Hector lifted the stone and carried it straight
 at the doors that guarded the close and strong-fitted gates,
 455 double doors, high, with two crossed bars
 inside to hold them, fastened with a single bolt.
 He came and stood very close, and planted himself, and struck them
 full in the middle, legs braced wide, to give the blow its force,
 and broke both hinges away; and the stone fell inside
 460 by its own weight; and the gates groaned loud on either side; the bars
 did not hold, and the doors were burst apart this way and that
 under the rush of the stone. And glorious Hector leapt in,
 in his face the very likeness of swift night; and he blazed in the bronze
 that terribly clothed his body, and in his hands he held
 465 two spears. No one who met him could have held him back —
 none but the gods — when he leapt the gates; and his eyes flared with
 fire.
 Wheeling in the crowd, he called out to the Trojans
 to climb over the wall; and they obeyed his urging:

at once some were climbing over the wall, while others poured
470 through the built gates themselves; and the Danaans fled
among the hollow ships; and the din rose unabating.³⁰

NOTES TO BOOK 12

- 1 *ll. 1-2* The book opens by holding the camera on Patroclus, still in the hut healing Eurypylus — where 11.848 left him, and where he stays until 15.390-404. The whole battle at the wall is thus bracketed inside Patroclus's delayed errand: the poem keeps its catastrophe waiting in a doorway.
- 2 *ll. 3-35* Unique in Homer: the narrator leaves the story's time entirely to relate the wall's future annihilation — after the sack, Poseidon and Apollo turn the eight rivers of Ida against it for nine days, Zeus rains, the trident-bearer levers out the foundations and re-beds the beach in sand. The passage explains to the poet's own audience why no trace of so great a work survived to be visited: epic erasing its own footprint (already at 7.443-464 Poseidon complained the wall would out-fame the one he built for Laomedon; Zeus there licensed this very deletion). Line 23 contains the poem's only "race of half-god men" (ἡμιθέων γένος ἀνδρῶν): elsewhere the heroes are simply men; only here, looking back from the audience's diminished present, does the narrator name the gulf. Aristotle admired the maneuver (Strabo 13.1.36 preserves the remark): "the poet who made the wall also made it disappear."
- 3 *ll. 41-48* The boar-or-lion at bay, wheeling on the closing ring: "his glorious heart knows no fear and no flight — and his courage kills him" (ἀγηνορίη δέ μιν ἔκτα, 46). The aside is proverb-grade and is the book's thesis about Hector — spoken inside a simile about him, six books before 22.99-130 proves it.
- 4 *ll. 60-80* Polydamas's first counsel, accepted. He appears here for the first time speaking (named 11.57): born the same night as Hector (18.251), the poem's designated counter-voice — his four speeches (here; 211; 13.726; 18.254) run accepted, rejected, accepted, rejected, and the last rejection kills Hector's army. The pattern begins with success: chariots left at the ditch, the wall attacked on foot.
- 5 *ll. 96-97* Asius's entry repeats his Catalogue lines (2.838-839) verbatim — our wording kept: the muster-roll recalled at the moment the muster begins to die (cf. the Merops sons, 11.329).
- 6 *ll. 87-104* The five battalions — the Trojan order of battle, with two debuts that matter: Alcahous (dead at 13.427-444) and Asteropaeus the Paeonian, "warlike," chosen by Sarpedon as third — the man whose duel with Achilles in the river (21.139-204) will be the last full combat before Hector's. Sarpedon "stood out even among all": the poem promotes him steadily toward Book 16.
- 7 *ll. 108-117* Asius refuses the plan — "the fool" (νήπιος), and the narrator files the death-notice in advance, naming the killer: Idomeneus, at 13.384-393. The prolepsis-with-obituary is the poem's standard seal on disobedience (2.38, 16.46, 20.466); "fate of the hateful name" (μοῖρα δυσώνυμος) belongs to the small class of fate-phrases where the word itself winces.

- 8 *ll. 127-153* The Lapith aristeia: Polypoetes and Leonteus keep their Catalogue credentials (2.740-746). The similes stack — oaks with roots running deep (131-134), then wild boars shattering the brush (146-150). The apparatus preserves Hephaestion's observation that 131-140 and 141-153 read like alternative versions of the same scene, only one of which was meant to stand — a rare window onto the poem's own workshop; the printed text, and this translation, keep both.
- 9 *ll. 162-172* Asius's outrage: "Father Zeus, so even you, it turns out, are an utter lover of lies!" (φιλοψευδής — nowhere else does a mortal call Zeus a liar to his face). The wasps-and-bees simile he builds — nest defenders who "will not abandon their hollow house... for their children's sake" — is finer than he knows: he has conceded that the two Lapiths are the ones fighting for something. The narrator's dry audit follows: Zeus was not persuaded; the glory was Hector's.
- 10 *ll. 175-181* "hard for me to tell it all through, as though I were a god" — the narrator's only confession of overload in the Iliad, athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus and omitted by Zenodotus, perhaps precisely because it lets the human singer show through the Muse's voice. The "prodigious fire... of stone" (θεσπιδᾶες πῦρ λάϊνον) is a famous compression: the stone barrage burns like fire along the whole wall — the enjambed adjective detonates the metaphor.
- 11 *ll. 200-209* The omen: an eagle on the left with a great snake in its talons; the snake, "not forgetting its war-craft," strikes the eagle's chest, is dropped in the crowd, and the eagle screams away empty. Polydamas will read it exactly (218-227): you may take the prey, but you will not carry it home. The scene is the poem's fullest bird-sign, and the interpretation is never refuted — only overruled.
- 12 *ll. 230-250* Hector's answer, culminating in the most quoted hexameter of the Iliad: "One bird-sign is best: to fight for your fatherland" (243). Cited from classical Athens onward as the motto of patriotic defense — and in context it is a king dismissing accurate intelligence on the strength of a private promise from Zeus (236) that expires at sundown (11.192-194, which Hector was not told). The rhetoric is immortal; the generalship is the disaster Polydamas predicted, and both men will say so later — Polydamas at 18.254-283, Hector to himself at 22.99-107. The closing threat (248-250) to kill any Trojan who hangs back completes the inversion: the omen-scene ends with the patriot promising to spear his own men.
- 13 *ll. 251-255* Zeus's dust-squall off Ida "bewitched the mind of the Achaeans": the day's tilt made weather. θέλγε — the verb of enchantment (Circe's verb in the Odyssey) — for what a dust storm does to a defending army's judgment.
- 14 *ll. 258-264* Siege engineering, precisely itemized: the galleries (κρόσσαι), the breastworks, the jutting buttress-piles set as footings for the towers — pulled, pried, and levered by hand. The Iliad's only sustained description of fortification assault, and the vocabulary is a hapax-cluster to match the singular event.
- 15 *ll. 265-276* The Ajaxes' exhortation sorts the army into "excellent... middling... lesser — since men are in no way all equal in war — now there is work for every man": the clearest statement in Homer of the mass army's ethic, where even the worse man's labor

counts — a note closer to the hoplite line than to the duel of champions, and fittingly spoken by the defensive hero par excellence.

- 16 *ll. 278-289* The great snow simile: Zeus "shows them what his missiles are," lulls the winds, and covers peaks, headlands, clover meadows, "men's rich worked fields," harbors and shores — only the breaking wave keeps it off. The barrage of stones is rendered as the silencing of the whole worked world under steady snow: *din* translated into hush, war into weather, and for four lines the poem simply looks at peace. Among the most admired similes in ancient and modern criticism alike.
- 17 *ll. 290-293* "Yet not even then would the Trojans... have broken the gates, had not Zeus roused his own son Sarpedon": the breach requires a demigod, and the poet says so in the counterfactual frame he reserves for real turning-points. The lion simile that follows (299-306) is the poem's fullest: the hungry lion who will either seize his prey or "himself be hit among the foremost" — the exact two outcomes Sarpedon offers Glaucus at 328.
- 18 *ll. 294-297* Sarpedon's shield, described from the smith's bench: hammered bronze face, oxhides stitched inside with golden rods running full circle. The poem's craftsmanship-passages dignify what is about to be risked; compare the cup of Nestor (11.632-637) and Hector's stone below.
- 19 *ll. 310-328* The Sarpedon speech — the classic statement of the heroic contract, in two movements. First, honor as obligation: the seat, the cuts, the full cups, the riverside estate — all are wages, and the Lycian in the ranks must be able to say his kings earn them ("not inglorious... their strength too is noble"). Second, the deeper clause (322-328): if escaping this battle meant being "ageless and immortal forever," fighting would be senseless — I would neither fight nor send you; it is because death comes anyway, in ten thousand forms no mortal dodges, that courage is rational: "let us go: we will give the triumph to some man, or he to us." Mortality is not the objection to heroism but its premise. This is the contract Achilles has just repudiated in Book 9 (life outweighs all Troy's wealth, 9.401-409), and the poem has placed its finest defense in the mouth of the man Zeus's own son — whom Zeus will watch die in Book 16, weeping blood-rain. Quoted and imitated from antiquity forward; the whole aristocratic ethics of the West descends through these nineteen lines.
- 20 *ll. 331-363* The Menestheus episode: the Athenian captain — praised in the Catalogue as a marshal, silent ever since — peers for help and sends Thootes. The herald delivers the message nearly word for word (354-363 = 343-350 with only the deixis shifted: "here" to "there"), our wording kept: messenger- fidelity as verbal discipline. Ancient critics athetized the Teucer line in both copies (350 = 363) as needless; it is the request's whole point — the bowman is wanted against Sarpedon.
- 21 *l. 365* "Oïleus' son" — the lesser Ajax. Zenodotus read a different form of the patronymic here (Ἰλιάδην), and — a marvel of textual history — his reading appears on a vase of the sixth century BC (published J.H.S. 1898): a pre- Alexandrian variant caught in paint before any surviving manuscript. The printed text follows Aristarchus.
- 22 *ll. 378-386* Epicles goes down under the jagged marble block — "not easily could a man hold it in both hands... such as mortals are now" (the fixed diminished-present formula, 5.304) — and falls "like a diver... from the high tower." The diver- image for a death-

plunge recurs at 16.742 (Cebriones, with Patroclus's terrible joke about oysters): grace at the instant of obliteration.

- 23 *ll. 387-391* Teucer's arrow finds Glaucus's bared arm, and Glaucus drops back off the wall hiding the wound, "so that no Achaean might see that he was hit and glory over him." The concealment is heroic bookkeeping — deny the enemy the boast — and the wound is a plot-load: at 16.508-531 it is this arm Glaucus begs Apollo to heal so he can defend Sarpedon's corpse.
- 24 *ll. 397-399* Sarpedon pulls down the breastwork with his bare hands: "the wall was laid naked; and he had made a road for many." He does not enter — that honor is reserved (note [30]); he opens. Made a road for many: the plain half-line has the whole tragedy of Book 16 folded in it — the road is for Hector, and for Patroclus coming the other way.
- 25 *ll. 400-403* Teucer's arrow finds only the shield-strap: "Zeus beat the death-spirits away from his son — he was not to be broken by the ships' sterns." Not saved: rescheduled. The clause quietly fixes the terms of 16.433-461, where Zeus will weigh saving him and be talked out of it by Hera. Every rescue in this poem is a date moved.
- 26 *ll. 409-412* After the grandest speech in the book, Sarpedon's working voice: I cannot break through alone — "Follow me in! More hands make better work." The proverb (πλέονων δέ τι ἔργον ἄμεινον) is the plain-prose twin of Diomedes' "when two go together" (10.224-226): heroism, at the wall as in the night, is cooperative labor.
- 27 *ll. 421-426* The deadlock as a boundary dispute: two men with measuring-rods in a common field, quarreling "in a little strip of ground over the fair share." The war for Troy reduced to village litigation over inches — and with the surveyor's precision comes the bitter joke: this, too, is a war about property. The breastwork is the boundary-stone; the poem's great space annihilates to a farmer's furrow.
- 28 *ll. 432-436* The second scales of the poem: not Zeus's golden balance (8.69) but a wage-worker's — "an honest working woman" (γυνή χερνήτις ἀληθής) holding weight against wool, drawing them level "to win a pitiful wage for her children." The adjective ἀληθής — "true, honest" — is given to the poorest person in the Iliad, and the whole stalemated battle hangs from her steady hand. The pathos is in the economics: she balances so carefully because the wage is pitiful and the children are hers. No simile in the poem reaches further down the social order, or carries more weight per line.
- 29 *ll. 445-450* Hector's stone: thick-butted, sharp-topped — a natural battering ram — "the two best men of a district could not easily lever it off the ground and onto a wagon, such as mortals are now; but he swung it easily even alone." The diminished-present formula again (its second use in the book, the fifth in the poem), and then the theological asterisk: "the son of crooked-counseled Cronos made it light for him." Line 450 was omitted by Zenodotus and athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus — deleting the asterisk credits Hector; keeping it credits Zeus; the printed text keeps it, and the shepherd- and-fleece simile (451-452) plays the weight both ways.
- 30 *ll. 457-471* The breach, in carpenter's detail: double doors, two crossed bars, one bolt; the stance ("legs braced wide, to give the blow its force"), both hinges sheared, the stone falling inside "by its own weight," the gates bellowing. Then the poem's great darkness-image: Hector leaps in "in his face the very likeness of swift night" — νυκτὶ θοῇ

ἀτάλαντος — man as nightfall, the bronze blazing about the dark (Zenodotus read "wrapped in night," and the vulgate's phrase has passed into proverb as "sudden night"). "No one who met him could have held him back — none but the gods... and his eyes flared with fire." The book ends at the exact instant of penetration — Trojans over the wall and through the gates, Danaans in rout among the ships — the only book of the poem that closes inside an unresolved catastrophe: the door broken, and everything still to lose.

Iliad — Book 13

While Zeus looks away, Poseidon rallies the Greeks in disguise, and the battle for the ships hangs in the balance.

- Now Zeus, when he had brought the Trojans and Hector to the ships,
left them beside them, to bear the toil and the misery
without respite; and he himself turned his shining eyes
away, gazing far off at the land of the horse-herding Thracians,
5 and the close-fighting Mysians, and the proud Mare-milkers
who drink the milk, and the Abioi, most righteous of men.¹
To Troy he no longer turned his shining eyes at all,
for he did not expect in his heart that any immortal
would come to stand by either Trojans or Danaans.
10 But the lord earth-shaker kept no blind man's watch:
he sat marveling at the war and the fighting,
high on the topmost peak of wooded Samos,
Thracian Samos; for from there all Ida showed clear,
and Priam's city showed clear, and the ships of the Achaeans.
15 There he sat, come up out of the sea, and he pitied the Achaeans
broken under the Trojans; and against Zeus his anger was strong.
At once he came down from the rugged mountain,
striding fast on his feet; and the tall hills trembled, and the timber,
under the immortal feet of Poseidon as he went.²
20 Three strides he made, and with the fourth he reached his goal,
Aegae, where his famous house in the depths of the water,
golden, glittering, is built for him, imperishable forever.
There he came, and yoked beneath his chariot the bronze-hoofed
horses,
swift-flying, with manes streaming gold,
25 and clothed himself in gold, and took the whip,
gold, well-wrought, and mounted the chariot,
and drove out over the waves. And the sea-beasts gamboled beneath
him,
coming from every hollow, and did not fail to know their lord;
and the sea in its joy stood apart; and the horses flew on

- 30 lightly, and the bronze axle beneath was not even wetted;³
 and the bounding horses carried him toward the ships of the Achaeans.
 There is a broad cave in the depths of the deep water,
 midway between Tenedos and rugged Imbros:
 there Poseidon the earth-shaker stayed his horses,
 35 loosing them from the chariot, and threw down ambrosial fodder
 for them to eat; and around their feet he cast golden hobbles,
 unbreakable, not to be undone, so they would stay there unmoved
 for their lord's return; and he went to the army of the Achaeans.
 And the Trojans, massed like flame or like a stormwind,
 40 followed Hector, Priam's son, in insatiable fury,
 roaring, crying as one; and they hoped to take the ships
 of the Achaeans, and kill all their best men beside them.
 But Poseidon, holder of the earth, the earth-shaker,
 come up out of the deep water, was rousing the Argives,
 45 likened to Calchas in body and tireless voice.
 First he spoke to the two Ajaxes, eager as they already were:
 "You two Ajaxes — you will save the army of the Achaeans
 if you remember your courage, and no shiver of panic.
 Elsewhere I do not fear the invincible hands
 50 of the Trojans who have climbed our great wall in a mass:
 the strong-greaved Achaeans will hold all of them.
 But here I fear most terribly that we suffer something —
 here where that rabid one leads them, like a flame,
 Hector, who claims to be a son of mighty Zeus.
 55 May some god put it into the hearts of you two
 to stand hard yourselves, and to command the others:
 then you might beat him back from the swift-faring ships
 for all his fury, even if the Olympian himself is driving him."
 He spoke, and the holder of the earth, the earth-shaker,
 60 striking both of them with his staff, filled them with strong fury,
 and made their limbs light, their feet and their hands above.
 And he himself rose to fly like a swift-winged hawk
 that lifts from a sheer towering rock-face
 and swoops to chase some other bird across the plain:
 65 so Poseidon the earth-shaker darted away from them.
 Of the two, swift Ajax, Oïleus' son, knew him first,

- and at once he spoke to Ajax, Telamon's son:
 "Ajax — since some one of the gods who hold Olympus,
 likened to the seer, tells us to fight beside the ships —
 70 and that is not Calchas, the reader of gods' bird-signs:
 the trace of his feet and legs from behind, as he went off,
 I knew it easily — the gods are easy to know —⁴
 now the heart in my own chest, for its part,
 is set far more on warring and fighting,
 75 and my feet beneath are hungry for it, and my hands above."
 Answering him spoke Telamonian Ajax:
 "So with me: my invincible hands about the spear
 are hungry, and my fury has risen, and beneath me both
 my feet are driving; and I long — even alone —
 80 to fight Hector, Priam's son, in his insatiable fury."
 So the two of them spoke to one another,
 in the joy of battle-craving the god had cast into their hearts;
 and meanwhile the holder of the earth roused the Achaeans behind
 them,
 who were cooling their hearts back by the swift ships.
 85 Their limbs were unstrung with grievous weariness,
 and grief was rising in their hearts as they watched
 the Trojans, who had climbed the great wall in a mass:
 looking at them, they let the tears spill under their brows,
 for they did not think they would escape the evil. But the earth-shaker,
 90 passing easily among them, stirred the strong battle-lines.
 To Teucer first he came, and Leïtus, commanding,
 and the hero Peneleos, and Thoas, and Deïpyrus,
 and Meriones and Antilochus, masters of the war-shout;
 urging these on, he spoke winged words:
 95 "Shame, Argives — young men! It was you I trusted:
 fight, and you will save our ships.
 But if you slacken from the misery of this war,
 now dawns the day we are broken under the Trojans.
 Shame! — a great marvel is this I see with my eyes,
 100 a terrible thing I never once said would come to pass:
 the Trojans advancing on our ships — the Trojans, who before
 were like skittering deer, which through the timber,

- feed for jackals and leopards and wolves,
wander witless and weaponless, with no fight in them:
- 105 so before now the Trojans would not stand against
the fury and the hands of the Achaeans — not for a moment.
Now, far from their city, they are fighting at the hollow ships,
through a leader's failing and the slackness of the army,
who quarrel with him, and will not defend
- 110 the swift-faring ships, but are killed among them.
Yet even if the truth is that the man wholly to blame
is the hero, Atreus' son, wide-ruling Agamemnon,
because he dishonored the swift-footed son of Peleus,
we, for our part, have no leave to slacken from the war.
- 115 No: let us heal it, quickly. The minds of good men can be healed.⁵
It is no longer honorable, this slackening of your rushing courage,
you who are all of you the best men in the army. I would not
quarrel with any man who hung back from the fighting
because he was worthless; but with you my heart is angry to the core.
- 120 Soft men! Soon you will make some greater evil yet
by this hanging back. Let each of you put in his heart
shame, and the fear of blame: a great struggle has risen.
Hector is fighting at the ships now, good at the war-cry,
in his power, and he has broken the gates and the long bar."
- 125 So the holder of the earth, commanding, roused the Achaeans.
And around the two Ajaxes the battle-lines took their stand,
strong lines: Ares himself could not have come and faulted them,
nor Athena, driver of armies. For the chosen best
stood and awaited the Trojans and brilliant Hector,
- 130 locking spear on spear, shield on layered shield:
buckler pressed on buckler, helmet on helmet, man on man,
and the horsehair crests on the bright ridges touched
as they nodded, so close they stood to one another;⁶
and the spears, shaken in daring hands,
- 135 crossed over one another; and their minds were set straight ahead, hot
to fight.
The Trojans struck first, massed; Hector led them,
straining straight on, like a boulder off a cliff-face
that a river swollen with winter shoves down the ledge,

- breaking with prodigious rain the shameless rock's moorings;
 140 bounding high it flies, and the timber crashes
 under it; and it runs on unswerving, steady, until it reaches
 the level plain — and there it rolls no more, for all its rush:⁷
 so Hector for a while threatened to sweep clean to the sea,
 clean through the huts and ships of the Achaeans,
 145 killing; but when he ran against those close-set battle-lines,
 he stopped, jammed hard against them. And the sons of the Achaeans
 facing him,
 stabbing with swords and double-curved spears,
 thrust him away from them; and he shuddered and gave ground.
 He cried a piercing cry, to carry to the Trojans:
 150 "Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians who fight at close quarters —
 stand by me! Not for long will the Achaeans hold me,
 not though they have built themselves into a tower,
 no — I think they will give way under my spear, if truly
 the best of gods drove me on, the loud-thunderer, Hera's lord."
 155 So speaking he stirred the fury and the heart of every man.
 And Deiphobus strode among them thinking great things,
 Priam's son, holding before him his shield, balanced every way,
 stepping light on his feet, advancing under the shield's cover.
 And Meriones aimed at him with his shining spear
 160 and threw, and did not miss, striking the shield, balanced every way,
 the bull's-hide shield — but drove nowhere through it: well before that
 the long spear snapped at the socket. And Deiphobus
 held the bull's-hide shield away from him, and his heart feared
 the spear of war-minded Meriones; but that hero
 165 drew back into the band of his companions, angry to the bone
 both ways — for the lost victory, and the spear he had shattered —
 and set off along the huts and ships of the Achaeans
 to fetch a long spear that was left him in his hut.
 The others fought on, and the quenchless roar rose.
 170 Teucer, Telamon's son, was first to kill his man,
 the spearman Imbrius, son of Mentor rich in horses.
 He lived in Pedaeum, before the sons of the Achaeans came,
 and had for wife a bastard daughter of Priam, Medesicaste;
 but when the double-ended ships of the Danaans came,

- 175 he came back to Ilion, and stood out among the Trojans,
 and lived with Priam, who honored him like his own children.
 Him the son of Telamon stabbed under the ear with the long spear,
 and wrenched the spear out; and he fell like an ash tree
 that on the crest of a mountain seen clear from every side
 180 is cut down by the bronze, and brings its soft leaves to the ground:
 so he fell, and his armor, intricate with bronze, clashed about him.
 And Teucer rushed in, hot to strip the armor off him;
 but as he rushed, Hector cast at him with his shining spear.
 He saw it coming and dodged the bronze spear —
 185 barely; and Hector struck Amphinomachus, son of Cteatus
 of Actor's line, with the spear in the chest as he came into the battle:
 he fell with a thud, and his armor clattered upon him.
 And Hector rushed in to tear the helmet, close-fitted
 at the temples, from the head of great-hearted Amphinomachus;
 190 but as he rushed, Ajax lunged at him with the shining spear —
 yet nowhere reached the flesh, for all of him was sheathed
 in terrible bronze. He stabbed the boss of the shield instead
 and shoved him back with great strength; and Hector gave ground
 behind the two corpses, and the Achaeans dragged them clear.
 195 Amphinomachus, then, Stentor and brilliant Menestheus,
 captains of the Athenians, carried back among the Achaean host;
 and Imbrius the two Ajaxes, hot with rushing courage,
 as two lions snatch a goat from under the guard
 of sharp-toothed dogs and carry it through the thick brush,
 200 holding it high above the ground in their jaws:
 so the two Ajaxes, helmed for war, holding him high,
 stripped his armor; and the head from the soft neck
 Oileus' son cut off, in wrath for Amphinomachus,
 and swung and sent it rolling like a ball through the crowd;
 205 and it fell in the dust in front of Hector's feet.⁸
 And then it was that Poseidon was angered to the heart,
 his grandson fallen in the dread combat,⁹
 and he set off along the huts and ships of the Achaeans
 to rouse the Danaans; and he was building sorrows for the Trojans.
 210 And Idomeneus, famed with the spear, met him
 coming from a companion who had just come out of the fighting,

cut behind the knee by the sharp bronze.
His comrades carried him in; and Idomeneus, giving the healers
their orders, was going to his hut, for he still longed
215 to face the war. And the lord earth-shaker spoke to him,
likening his voice to Thoas, Andraemon's son,
who in all Pleuron and steep Calydon
ruled the Aetolians, honored like a god by the people:
"Idomeneus, counselor of the Cretans, where have they gone,
220 the threats the sons of the Achaeans threatened against the Trojans?"
And Idomeneus, leader of the Cretans, answered him:
"Thoas, no man is at fault now — not so far
as I can tell; for all of us know how to fight.
No one is gripped by bloodless fear, no one yields
225 to shirking and ducks out of this evil war. No — this, it seems,
must be the pleasure of the overmastering son of Cronos:
that the Achaeans perish here, nameless, far from Argos.
But Thoas — you were always staunch before,
and you rouse any other man you see slackening:
230 so do not leave off now. Call to every man."
Then answered him Poseidon the earth-shaker:
"Idomeneus, may the man never come home
from Troy — may he be sport for dogs on this ground —
who on this day chooses to slacken from the fighting.
235 Come then, take up your weapons and come out with me. We must
press this together, and see if the two of us can be of use.
Even sorry men, combined, come to some courage —¹⁰
and the two of us would know how to fight even the best."
So speaking, the god went back into the toil of men;
240 and Idomeneus, when he reached his well-built hut,
put his fine armor about his body, caught up two spears,
and went his way like the lightning-bolt the son of Cronos
takes in his hand and brandishes from glittering Olympus,
showing a sign to mortals, and its flashes blaze far:
245 so the bronze blazed on his chest as he ran.
And Meriones, his brave aide, met him
while he was still near the hut — he was going to fetch
a bronze spear — and the strength of Idomeneus spoke to him:

- "Meriones, Molus's son, swift-footed, dearest of my companions,"¹¹
 250 why have you come, leaving the war and the combat?
 Are you hit somewhere — is an arrowhead wearing you down?
 Or do you come after me with some message? I myself
 have no wish to sit in the huts, but to fight."
 And level-headed Meriones answered him:
 255 "Idomeneus, counselor of the bronze-shirted Cretans,
 I come to fetch a spear, if one is left
 in your huts; the one I carried before, we shattered it —
 I struck the shield of Deiphobus in his arrogance."
 And Idomeneus, leader of the Cretans, answered him:
 260 "Spears — if you want them you will find one, and twenty,
 standing in my hut against the bright entrance-wall:
 Trojan spears, which I strip from the men I kill. I hold¹²
 it is not my way to fight standing far from enemy men;
 and so I have spears, and bossed shields,
 265 and helmets, and corslets shining bright."
 And level-headed Meriones answered him:
 "I too, by my hut and my black ship, have plenty
 of Trojan spoils — but they are not close by for the taking.
 For I say I am no more forgetful of courage than you:
 270 I take my stand among the first in the battle where men win glory
 whenever the strife of war has risen.
 Some other of the bronze-shirted Achaeans might miss
 my fighting; but you — you are the one who knows it, I think."
 And Idomeneus, leader of the Cretans, answered him:
 275 "I know your worth, and what kind of man you are. Why recite it?
 If now beside the ships all our best were being counted
 for an ambush — where the worth of men shows clearest,
 where the coward and the brave man stand revealed:
 the coward's color changes to one thing and another,
 280 and the spirit in his chest cannot hold him steady in his seat,
 but he shifts his crouch, sits back from foot to foot,
 and the heart in his ribs hammers hugely
 as he imagines the death-spirits, and his teeth chatter aloud;
 but the brave man's color never changes, and no fear in him
 285 is too great, once he has settled into the ambush of men,

- and he prays to be mixed at once in the misery of battle —
there, no man could fault your fury or your hands.
For even if you were hit in the work, or struck close in,
the missile would not fall on the nape of your neck, or your back:
290 it would meet your chest or your belly
as you pressed forward into the front-fighters' trysting-place.¹³
But come, no more standing here talking of this
like children — someone might scoff beyond all measure.
Go to the hut, and choose yourself a massive spear."
- 295 So he spoke; and Meriones, the equal of swift Ares,
quickly took up a bronze spear from the hut
and went after Idomeneus, his whole mind on war.
As Ares, bane of mortals, goes out to war,
and with him follows Panic, his dear son, strong and fearless,
300 who sends even the patient-hearted warrior running;
the two of them arm out of Thrace against the Ephyri
or the great-hearted Phlegyes — and they do not hear¹⁴
both sides' prayers, but hand the glory to one:
such were Meriones and Idomeneus, leaders of men,
305 as they went into the war, helmed in blazing bronze.
And Meriones spoke to him first with his word:
"Son of Deucalion, where are you eager to enter the crowd?
On the right of the whole army, or through the middle,
or on the left? For nowhere else, I think, do the long-haired
310 Achaeans so fail of hands in the fighting."
And Idomeneus, leader of the Cretans, answered him:
"In the center ships there are others to hold the defense,
the two Ajaxes, and Teucer, who is best of the Achaeans
in bowmanship, and good too in the standing fight:
315 they will drive him to sickness of it, however hot for battle —
Hector, Priam's son — however strong he is.
It will be steep going for him, blaze as he may to fight:
against their conquering fury and invincible hands
he will not fire the ships — unless the son of Cronos in person
320 hurls a burning brand onto the swift ships.
To no man would he yield, great Telamonian Ajax —
to no man who is mortal and eats the grain of Demeter,

who can be broken by bronze or by great hurled stones.
 Not even to Achilles, breaker of men, would he give way —
 325 in the standing fight; in speed of foot there is no contesting him.
 So take us leftward of the army, and quickly: we will see
 whether we give the triumph to some man, or he to us."
 So he spoke; and Meriones, the equal of swift Ares,
 led on, until they came to the army where he had bidden.
 330 And when they saw Idomeneus, strong as a flame,
 him and his aide, in their intricate war-gear,
 they called to one another through the crowd and made for him,
 and their struggle joined, one mass, by the sterns of the ships.
 As when squalls come racing under shrill winds
 335 on a day when the dust lies thickest on the roads,
 and all together they raise up a great cloud of dust:
 so their battle came together in one mass, and they were hot
 in their hearts to slaughter each other in the crowd with the sharp
 bronze.
 And the man-destroying battle bristled with the long
 340 flesh-cutting spears they gripped; and eyes were blinded
 by the flare of bronze off glittering helmets
 and fresh-burnished corslets and shining shields
 as they came on in one mass. It would be a hard-hearted man
 who could rejoice at the sight of that toil, and not be grieved.¹⁵
 345 And the two strong sons of Cronos, divided in purpose,
 were building grim sorrows for the fighting men.
 Zeus willed the victory for the Trojans and Hector,
 glorifying swift-footed Achilles; yet he had no wish
 for the Achaean army to perish wholly before Ilion —
 350 he was glorifying Thetis, and her strong-hearted son.
 But Poseidon had come among the Argives and was stirring them,
 slipped up in secret from the grey salt water; for it galled him
 to see them broken by Trojans, and against Zeus his anger was strong.
 Both, to be sure, were of one stock and one parentage,
 355 but Zeus was elder-born, and he knew more.
 For that reason Poseidon shunned defending them openly,
 and in secret, always, roused them down the army, likened to a man.
 So the two of them knotted the cord of strong strife

- and leveling war, and drew it taut over both sides —
360 a cord unbreakable, not to be untied; and it unstrung the knees of many.¹⁶
Then — though his hair was half-grey — Idomeneus,
calling on the Danaans, leapt on the Trojans and drove panic among them.
For he killed Othryoneus, in the town from Cabeus —
lately come, chasing the report of the war,
365 and he had asked for the loveliest of Priam's daughters,
Cassandra, without bride-gifts — promising a great work instead:
to drive the sons of the Achaeans out of Troy against their will.
And old Priam had promised her, had bowed his head:
give her he would; and Othryoneus fought trusting the promises.
370 Idomeneus aimed at him with his shining spear
and threw, and hit him in mid-stride; the corslet of bronze
he wore did not hold: the spear fixed in his belly's middle.
He fell with a thud; and Idomeneus exulted, calling:
"Othryoneus — I congratulate you beyond all living men
375 if you are really going to accomplish all you promised
Priam, Dardanus' heir! He promised you his daughter.
Look — we too could promise you as much, and keep it:
we would give you the loveliest of the daughters of Atreus' son,
bringing her out of Argos for you to marry, if you will join us
380 and sack the well-peopled city of Ilion.
Come along: let us settle the marriage at the seafaring ships —
you will find we are not hard men over bride-terms."¹⁷
So speaking the hero Idomeneus dragged him by the foot
through the strong encounter. But Asius came to avenge him,
385 on foot before his horses; the aide who drove them
kept them breathing at his shoulders always. And his heart was hot
to hit Idomeneus; but the other was quicker, and struck him with the
spear
in the throat under the chin, and drove the bronze clean through.
He fell as an oak falls, or a white poplar,
390 or a towering pine, that carpenters up in the mountains
cut down with fresh-whetted axes to be a ship's timber:¹⁸
so he lay stretched out before his horses and chariot,

- bellowing, clawing at the blood-soaked dust.
 And the charioteer was struck out of the wits he had:
 395 he did not dare wheel the horses round and slip
 out of the enemy's hands; and Antilochus, staunch in the fight,
 caught him with the spear mid-body; the corslet of bronze
 he wore did not hold: the spear fixed in his belly's middle,
 and he fell gasping out of the well-built chariot.
 400 And the horses Antilochus, great-hearted Nestor's son,
 drove off from the Trojans to the strong-greaved Achaeans.
 Then Deiphobus came up very close to Idomeneus,
 grieving for Asius, and cast with his shining spear.
 But Idomeneus saw it coming and dodged the bronze spear:
 405 he hid himself behind his shield, balanced every way,
 the shield he carried, built of oxhides and gleaming bronze
 rounded on the wheel, fitted with two cross-rods:
 under it he gathered himself whole, and the bronze spear flew over
 and the shield rang dry and harsh as the spear grazed
 410 across it. Yet Deiphobus's heavy hand had not thrown in vain:
 he hit Hypsenor, Hippasus's son, shepherd of the people,
 in the liver below the midriff, and unstrung his knees on the instant.
 And Deiphobus vaunted terribly over him, crying far:
 "Not unavenged, after all, lies Asius! No — I say
 415 that even going down to Hades, the strong closer of the gate,
 he will be glad at heart: I have given him an escort for the road."¹⁹
 So he spoke, and grief came over the Argives at his vaunting,
 and most of all he stirred the heart of war-minded Antilochus;
 yet grieved as he was, he did not forget his companion:
 420 running, he stood over him and covered him with the shield,
 and two loyal companions stooped beneath him,
 Mecisteus, Echius' son, and brilliant Alastor,
 and carried him, groaning heavily, to the hollow ships.
 And Idomeneus did not slacken his great fury: he strained
 425 always either to wrap some Trojan in blinding night
 or to fall himself with a crash, warding ruin from the Achaeans.
 Then the dear son of Zeus-nurtured Aesyetes,
 the hero Alcathous — he was Anchises' son-in-law,
 married to the eldest of his daughters, Hippodameia,

- 430 whom her father and her lady mother loved with all their hearts
at home; for she outshone all the girls of her age
in beauty and in handiwork and in wit, and for that
the best man in the breadth of Troy had married her —
him, then, Poseidon broke under Idomeneus's hand:
- 435 he charmed his shining eyes and shackled his glorious limbs,²⁰
so that he could neither run back nor swerve aside,
but stood unmoving, like a grave-pillar or a tree
in high leaf, while the hero Idomeneus stabbed him with the spear
mid-chest, and burst the bronze tunic around it,
440 the tunic that till then had kept ruin from his flesh:
it screamed dry and harsh as it tore around the spear.
He fell with a thud, the spear stuck fast in his heart,
and the heart, still beating, shook even the butt-end
of the spear, quivering — until at last massive Ares stilled its fury.
- 445 And Idomeneus vaunted terribly over him, crying far:
"Deiphobus! Shall we call it a fair reckoning now —
three men killed for one? — since it was you who boasted.
Strange man: come stand against me yourself, face to face,
and learn what son of Zeus's line has come here:
- 450 Zeus first begot Minos, warden of Crete;
and Minos got a son, blameless Deucalion;
and Deucalion fathered me, lord over many men
in wide Crete; and now the ships have carried me here,
an evil to you, and your father, and the rest of the Trojans."²¹
- 455 So he spoke; and Deiphobus was torn two ways —
whether to fall back and take as companion some one
of the great-hearted Trojans, or to try it alone.
And as he weighed it, this seemed to him the better course:
to go for Aeneas. He found him standing rearmost
460 of the crowd; for he was forever furious at brilliant Priam,
because, brave among men as he was, Priam gave him no honor.²²
Standing close, he spoke winged words to him:
"Aeneas, counselor of the Trojans, now the great need is on you
to stand for your sister's husband — if kinship's grief can reach you.
- 465 Come, let us fight for Alcatous, who long ago,
as your sister's husband, reared you in his house when you were little;

- and Idomeneus, famed with the spear, has stripped him."
 So he spoke, and stirred the heart in Aeneas's chest,
 and he went after Idomeneus, his whole mind on war.
- 470 But no panic took hold of Idomeneus, as though he were some
 pampered boy:
 he stood his ground, like a boar in the mountains sure of his strength,
 who abides the great oncoming rabble of men
 in a lonely place, and the ridge of his back bristles up,
 and his eyes shine with fire, and he whets his tusks,
- 475 hot to beat off the dogs and the men:
 so Idomeneus, famed with the spear, stood fast and did not yield
 to Aeneas coming swift to the rescue. But he called his companions,
 looking to Ascalaphus and Aphareus and Deïpyrus
 and Meriones and Antilochus, masters of the war-shout;
- 480 urging these on, he spoke winged words:
 "Here, friends — I am alone: defend me! I dread him terribly,
 swift-footed Aeneas, who is coming at me —
 who is very strong in battle at killing men,
 and has the flower of youth besides, which is the greatest power.
- 485 If we were of one age, with the heart I carry now,
 quickly would he carry off great power — or I would."
 So he spoke; and all of them, one spirit in their chests,
 took their stand close by him, shields leaned against their shoulders.
 And Aeneas on the other side called to his companions,
- 490 looking to Deiphobus and Paris and brilliant Agenor,
 fellow-leaders of the Trojans with him; and after them
 the troops followed, as flocks follow the bell-ram
 down from the pasture to drink — and the shepherd's heart is glad:²³
 so the heart in Aeneas's chest rejoiced
- 495 when he saw the mass of troops following his own lead.
 And around Alcatous they went at each other, close in,
 with their long pikes; and the bronze about their chests
 rang terribly as they aimed at one another
 through the crowd. And two men of war beyond the others,
- 500 Aeneas and Idomeneus, the equals of Ares,
 strained to hew each other's flesh with the pitiless bronze.
 Aeneas first cast at Idomeneus;

but he saw it coming and dodged the bronze spear,
 and the point of Aeneas's spear went quivering
 505 into the earth, hurled in vain from his massive hand.
 But Idomeneus struck Oenomaus mid-belly,
 and burst the plate of his corslet, and the bronze
 spilled his bowels through; and falling in the dust he clutched the earth
 in his palm.

And Idomeneus wrenched the long-shadowed spear out
 510 of the corpse, but could not strip the rest of the fine armor
 from his shoulders: the missiles pressed him too hard.
 For the joints of his feet no longer held firm in the charge —
 no spring left, either to follow his own cast or to dodge another's.
 So in the standing fight he still fended off the pitiless day,
 515 but in retreat his feet could no longer carry him quick out of the battle.
 And as he was stepping slowly back, Deiphobus cast at him
 with his shining spear — for the grudge he held him was relentless,
 always.

But this time too he missed; and the spear hit Ascalaphus,
 the son of Enyalius; through the shoulder the massive spear
 520 drove; and falling in the dust he clutched the earth in his palm.
 But loud-roaring massive Ares knew nothing of it yet —
 that his son had fallen in the strong encounter —
 for he sat on the peak of Olympus, under the golden clouds,
 penned there by the designs of Zeus, where the other
 525 immortal gods sat too, barred from the war.²⁴

And around Ascalaphus they went at each other close in:
 Deiphobus tore the shining helmet from Ascalaphus,
 but Meriones, the equal of swift Ares, leaping in,
 stabbed his upper arm with the spear, and out of his hand
 530 the socketed helmet fell ringing to the ground.
 And Meriones, springing in again like a vulture,
 wrenched the massive spear out of his upper arm
 and drew back into the band of his companions. And Polites,
 Deiphobus's own brother, throwing his arms around his waist,
 535 led him out of the harsh-sounding war, until they reached
 his swift horses, which stood behind the battle and the fighting
 with their charioteer and the intricate chariot;

- these carried him toward the city, groaning heavily,
worn; and the blood ran down from the fresh wound on his arm.
- 540 The others fought on, and the quenchless roar rose.
There Aeneas sprang on Aphareus, Caletor's son,
and struck his throat — it was turned toward him — with the sharp
spear;
his head dropped to one side, and shield and helmet
crumpled down on him, and death that breaks the spirit poured round
him.
- 545 And Antilochus, watching Thoon as he turned around,
leapt in and stabbed him, and severed the whole vein
that runs up the length of the back to reach the neck:
the whole of it he severed, and the man dropped on his back in the
dust,
stretching both hands out toward his dear companions.
- 550 And Antilochus sprang on him and set to stripping the armor
from his shoulders, watching all round; for the Trojans, ringing him,
stabbed at his broad glittering shield from this side and that, yet could
not
get through to graze the soft flesh behind it with the pitiless bronze —
the flesh of Antilochus; for Poseidon the earth-shaker
- 555 guarded Nestor's son on every side, even amid the thick missiles.
For never was he out of reach of enemies; he wheeled
among them; and his spear was never held still, but always
shaken, quivering; and his aim was set in his mind
either to cast at someone, or to charge in close.
- 560 But as he aimed through the crowd he did not go unseen
by Adamas, Asius's son, who leapt in close and stabbed
the middle of his shield with the sharp bronze; but the blue-maned
Poseidon made the point strengthless, grudging him that life.²⁵
And half of it stuck there, like a fire-hardened stake,
- 565 in the shield of Antilochus, and half lay on the ground;
and Adamas drew back into the band of his companions, dodging doom.
But Meriones, following as he went, threw the spear
and hit him between the genitals and the navel — there
where the war-god comes most grievous to wretched mortals.
- 570 There the spear stuck fast; and doubled over the shaft

he writhed, as a bull writhes that herdsmen in the mountains
 have bound with willow-ropes and drag along unwilling:
 so, stabbed, he writhed a little while — not long —
 until the hero Meriones came close and wrenched
 575 the spear out of his flesh; and darkness covered his eyes.
 And Helenus struck Deïpyrus close in, on the temple,
 with a great Thracian sword, and sheared the helmet away;
 it was knocked spinning to the ground, and some Achaean
 picked it up as it rolled between the fighters' feet;
 580 and gloomy night came down and covered his eyes.
 Then grief seized Atreus' son, Menelaus good at the war-cry,
 and he strode out threatening against the hero, lord Helenus,
 shaking his sharp spear; and Helenus drew back the grip of his bow.
 So the two came on together, the one hot to cast
 585 the sharp-pointed spear, the other the arrow off the string.
 Priam's son struck him first, with the arrow, on the chest,
 on the corslet's plate — and the bitter arrow sprang off.
 As off a broad winnowing-shovel, on a great threshing-floor,
 the dark-skinned beans or the chickpeas jump
 590 under the shrill wind and the winnower's swing,
 so from the corslet of glorious Menelaus
 the bitter arrow glanced far off, turned hard away.²⁶
 But Atreus' son, Menelaus good at the war-cry, struck
 the hand in which he held the polished bow: and into the bow
 595 the bronze spear drove, clean through the hand.
 He drew back into the band of his companions, dodging doom,
 his hand hanging slack at his side, dragging the ash spear.
 Great-hearted Agenor drew it out of the hand,
 and bound the hand itself in a sling of twisted
 600 sheep's wool, which his aide carried for the shepherd of the people.²⁷
 Then Peisander came straight at glorious Menelaus —
 but an evil fate was leading him toward death's end:
 toward you, Menelaus, to be broken in the dread combat.
 And when they were close, advancing on one another,
 605 Atreus' son missed his cast; the spear was turned aside;
 and Peisander stabbed at the shield of glorious Menelaus
 but could not drive the bronze on through:

the broad shield held it, and the spear snapped
at the socket. Yet he rejoiced in his heart, and hoped for victory.

- 610 But Atreus' son, drawing his silver-studded sword,
sprang at Peisander; and he, from under his shield, pulled out
a fine axe of good bronze on a haft of olive-wood,
long and well-polished; and in the same instant they reached each
other.

- Peisander chopped at the ridge of the horsehair-crested helmet
615 at its very peak, under the plume; Menelaus caught him coming on
at the forehead, above the base of the nose: the bones cracked loud,
and his eyes, all blood, dropped in the dust by his feet,
and he doubled over and fell. And setting a heel on his chest
Menelaus stripped his armor, and spoke in triumph over him:

- 620 "This is how you will leave the ships of the swift-colted Danaans —
you Trojans past all pride, never sated with the terrible war-shout —
nor short of any other outrage and disgrace,
like the outrage you did to me, you foul dogs, with never a fear
in your hearts for the harsh wrath of loud-thundering Zeus
625 of Guest-right, who one day will destroy your steep city.
You who went off — wantonly — carrying away my wedded wife
and much of my wealth, when it was she who had made you welcome;
and now you rage to hurl annihilating fire
on the seafaring ships, and to kill the Achaean heroes.

- 630 But you will be stopped, somewhere, war-hungry as you are.
O father Zeus — they say you stand above all others
in wisdom, men and gods alike; yet all this comes from you:
what favor you are showing to men of violence —
these Trojans, whose fury is forever reckless, who cannot
635 get their fill of the din of leveling war!
Of all things there is satiety — of sleep, of love,
of sweet song and of blameless dancing;
a man would sooner pray to take his fill of these
than of war. But the Trojans are never sated with battle."²⁸

- 640 So speaking, blameless Menelaus stripped the bloody armor
from the body and gave it to his companions,
and went back himself again and mixed with the front-fighters.
There the son of king Pylaemenes leapt out at him,

Harpalion, who had followed his dear father to fight
 645 at Troy, and never came home again to his fatherland.
 He stabbed the middle of Atreus' son's shield with his spear,
 close in, but could not drive the bronze on through,
 and drew back into the band of his companions, dodging doom,
 glancing on every side, lest flesh of his meet bronze.
 650 But Meriones, as he retreated, shot a bronze-tipped arrow
 and hit him in the right buttock; and the arrow
 passed under the bone, straight on, into the bladder.
 Sinking down on the spot, in the arms of his dear companions,
 breathing out his life, he lay stretched on the ground
 655 like a worm; and the dark blood ran out and soaked the earth.²⁹
 Around him the great-hearted Paphlagonians busied themselves:
 they lifted him into a chariot and drove him toward holy Ilion,
 grieving; and among them went his father, shedding tears;
 and there was no blood-price for his son who was dead.
 660 Now at his killing the heart of Paris was angered exceedingly,
 for he had been his guest-friend among the many Paphlagonians;
 and angered for him, he let fly a bronze-tipped arrow.
 There was one Euchenor, the son of the seer Polyidus,
 a rich man and a brave one, whose house was in Corinth,
 665 who had boarded his ship knowing well his deadly fate:
 for the good old man Polyidus had told him, often,
 that he would waste to death of a grievous sickness at home,
 or go down under Trojan hands among the ships of the Achaeans;
 and so he shunned two things at once: the heavy fine
 670 of the Achaeans, and the loathsome sickness, that his heart might feel
 no pain.³⁰
 Him Paris struck below the jaw, under the ear; and quickly the spirit
 went out of his limbs, and the hateful darkness took him.
 So they fought on, like blazing fire;
 and Hector, dear to Zeus, had not heard, and did not know at all
 675 that on the left of the ships his people were being cut down
 by the Argives — and soon the triumph would have belonged
 to the Achaeans: such was the holder of the earth, the earth-shaker,
 driving the Argives on, and defending them besides with his strength.
 But Hector held where first he had leapt the gates and the wall,

680 breaking the close-set battle-lines of Danaan shield-men,
 there where the ships of Ajax and Protesilaus
 were drawn up on the beach of the grey sea, and above them
 the wall was built at its lowest — there where beyond all places
 the men themselves and their horses were fiercest in the fight.
 685 There the Boeotians, and the Ionians with their trailing tunics,³¹
 the Locrians, and the Phthians, and the shining Epeians
 held him off the ships as he charged hard, but had not strength
 to thrust him back away from them — brilliant Hector like a flame —
 the picked men of the Athenians among them; and their leader
 690 was Menestheus, Peteos' son, and with him followed
 Pheidias and Stichius and brave Bias; and the Epeians' leaders
 were Meges, Phyleus' son, and Amphion and Dracius,
 and before the Phthians, Medon, and Podarces steadfast in battle.
 Now the one — Medon — was a bastard son of godlike Oïleus
 695 and brother of Ajax; but he lived in Phylace,
 far from his own fatherland, having killed a man,
 a kinsman of his stepmother Eriopis, wife of Oïleus;³²
 and the other was a son of Iphiclus, Phylacus's line.
 These, armed in the front of the great-hearted Phthians,
 700 fought in defense of the ships beside the Boeotians;
 and Ajax, the swift son of Oïleus, would no longer
 stand apart from Ajax, Telamon's son — not by a step:
 but as in fallow land two wine-dark oxen strain
 at the jointed plow with one and the same heart, and around
 705 the roots of their horns the sweat wells up in streams,
 and only the polished yoke holds the two apart
 as they drive down the furrow, and the plow cuts to the field's edge:
 so the two of them took their stand, shoulder to shoulder.³³
 But the son of Telamon had troops with him, many and brave,
 710 companions who took his shield from him
 whenever weariness and sweat came over his knees;
 while no Locrians followed the great-hearted son of Oïleus:
 their hearts had no stomach for the standing fight,
 for they had no bronze helmets, thick with horsehair,
 715 no round shields and no ash spears:
 it was trusting in their bows, and in the twisted wool

- of sheep, that they had followed him to Ilion; and with these,
shooting thick and fast, they broke the Trojan battle-lines.
So then: the ones in front, in their intricate war-gear,
720 fought the Trojans and Hector of the bronze helmet,
while the others shot from behind, unseen; and the Trojans
lost all memory of the joy of battle: the arrows drove them into rout.³⁴
And then, in misery, back from the ships and the huts
the Trojans would have retreated to windy Ilion,
725 had not Polydamas come and stood by daring Hector:
"Hector, there is no dealing with you: no man's persuasion moves you.
Because a god gave you the works of war beyond others,
you insist on knowing counsel, too, better than others;
but you cannot possibly take all things to yourself at once.
730 To one man the god has given the works of war,
to another the dance, to another the lyre and song,
and in another's chest wide-seeing Zeus sets a mind
of worth, and many men get profit of it,
and it saves many, and he who has it knows it best of all.³⁵
735 But I will say it as it seems to me to be best.
Everywhere around you the garland of war is blazing;
and the great-hearted Trojans, now they have crossed the wall,
are some of them standing back with their arms, and some fighting,
fewer against more, scattered along the ships.
740 Fall back, then, and summon all our best men here;
and then we could weigh the whole counsel together —
whether to fall on the many-benched ships, if the god
is willing to hand us the power, or whether after all
to come away from the ships unhurt. For I, for one, fear
745 the Achaeans may pay us back yesterday's debt in full:
a man waits by the ships insatiate of war,
and I think he will hold back from the fighting no longer."
So spoke Polydamas, and the prudent word pleased Hector,
and at once he leapt with his weapons from the chariot to the ground,
750 and speaking winged words he addressed him:
"Polydamas — you hold all our best men here,
I will go over there and take my share of the fighting,
and come back quickly, when I have given them their orders."

- He spoke, and set off — like a snow-shining mountain —³⁶
755 screaming, and flew through the Trojans and the allies.
And they all surged toward Panthous's son, gracious Polydamas,
when they heard the voice of Hector.
But he went ranging through the front-fighters, searching
for Deiphobus, and the strength of lord Helenus,
760 and Adamas, Asius's son, and Asius, Hyrtacus's son —
if he might find them anywhere. He found them
not unhurt, not unruined: some by the sterns
of the Achaean ships lay dead at Argive hands,
and some were inside the wall with wounds from far or near.
765 But one he found quickly, on the left of the tearful battle:
brilliant Alexandros, the husband of lovely-haired Helen,
heartening his companions and urging them to fight.
Standing close, he raked him with shaming words:
"Paris — evil Paris — beauty and nothing more, woman-mad, seducer:³⁷
770 where is Deiphobus, and the strength of lord Helenus,
and Adamas, Asius's son, and Asius, Hyrtacus's son?
And where is Othryoneus? Now all of steep Ilion
is ruined, top to bottom. Now your own sheer destruction is sure."
Then godlike Alexandros answered him:
775 "Hector — since your heart is set on blaming the blameless,
some other day, perhaps, I may hang back from the fighting;
but not now: my mother did not bear me wholly a coward.
From the moment you woke the battle of our companions at the ships,
from then we have stood our ground here, engaging the Danaans
780 without respite. The companions you ask after are dead —
except Deiphobus and the strength of lord Helenus:
those two have gone off, each wounded in the hand
by long spears; the son of Cronos kept death from them.
Now lead on, wherever your heart and spirit command,
785 and we will follow you, and gladly; nor do I think
you will find us short of courage, so far as the strength is in us.
Beyond his strength no man can fight, however hot he burns."
So speaking the hero turned his brother's mind.
They set off for where the battle and struggle burned thickest,
790 around Cebriones, and blameless Polydamas,

- and Phalces, and Orthaeus, and godlike Polyphetes,
 and Palmys, and Ascanius and Morys, sons of Hippotion,
 who had come in relief out of deep-soiled Ascania
 the dawn before; and now Zeus drove them to fight.
- 795 And they came on like a squall of punishing winds
 that under the thunder of father Zeus drives at the plain
 and with a prodigious roar meets the sea, and the countless
 seething waves of the loud-roaring water
 arch up, white-crested, some in front, and others behind them:
- 800 so the Trojans, closed up, some in front, and others behind them,
 glittering in bronze, came on behind their leaders.
 And Hector led them, the equal of Ares bane of mortals,
 Priam's son; before him he held his shield, balanced every way,
 thick with hides, with heavy bronze hammered over it,
- 805 and about his temples the shining helmet shook.
 Everywhere he probed the battle-lines, advancing,
 trying whether they might give before him as he came under shield-
 cover;
 but he could not confound the heart in the Achaeans' chests.
 And Ajax, striding long, was first to challenge him:
- 810 "Possessed one — come closer! Why try to frighten Argives
 with mere noise? We are not unschooled in battle;
 it is the evil whip of Zeus that has broken us Achaeans.
 I suppose your heart hopes to strip the ships clean —
 well, we too have hands, quick hands, to hold them.
- 815 Long before that, mark me, your own well-peopled city
 will be taken under our hands, and sacked.
 And for you yourself, I say the hour is near when, running,
 you will pray to father Zeus and the other immortals
 to make your fair-maned horses swifter than falcons
- 820 as they carry you to the city, raising the dust of the plain."
 And as he spoke, a bird flew by on the right hand,
 an eagle, flying high; and the Achaean army shouted at it,
 heartened by the sign. But glorious Hector answered:
 "Ajax, you blundering ox of a braggart — what a thing to say!
- 825 I wish I were as surely, all my days, the son
 of aegis-bearing Zeus, and the lady Hera had borne me,

and I were honored as Athena and Apollo are honored,
 as surely as this day now brings evil to the Argives —
 all of them; and you will be killed among them, if you dare
 830 stand against my long spear, which will tear open
 your lily-soft skin; and you will glut the dogs and birds of Troy³⁸
 with your fat and your flesh, fallen beside the ships of the Achaeans."
 So speaking he led the way, and they followed him
 with a prodigious roar, and the army screamed behind him.
 835 And the Argives on the other side raised their cry, and did not forget
 their courage, but stood fast against the best of the Trojans coming on;
 and the clamor of both reached the ether and the radiance of Zeus.³⁹

NOTES TO BOOK 13

- 1 ll. 1-9 Zeus, sure of his arrangements, turns his shining eyes away from the war — north, to the horse-herding Thracians, the close-fighting Mysians, and then clean off the map of the war: the Hippemolgoi, "Mare-milkers who drink the milk," and the Abioi, "most righteous of men." The lines are the most famous ethnographic glance in Homer — steppe pastoralists (later identified with Scythians; Ammianus Marcellinus was still quoting the verse in the fourth century AD) whose remoteness from the war is precisely their righteousness. Zeus rests his eyes on the people who own least and quarrel least — and his inattention is the hinge of the plot: no god, he thinks, will dare (7-9). One will.
- 2 ll. 17-22 Poseidon's descent: "the tall hills trembled, and the timber, under the immortal feet of Poseidon as he went. Three strides he made, and with the fourth he reached his goal." Longinus quotes the passage in *On the Sublime* (9.8) as an instance of the divine measured by cosmic stride. Aegae, his golden house under the water, was paired with Helice at 8.203; Samothrace ("Thracian Samos"), the north-Aegean peak, really does command a sight-line over Imbros to the Troad — the poet's geography of watching is checkable, and correct.
- 3 ll. 23-31 The ride: gold horses, gold whip, gold armor — and then the great verse of the animal world's homage: "the sea-beasts gamboled beneath him, coming from every hollow, and did not fail to know their lord; and the sea in its joy stood apart." The wave makes way; the axle stays dry. After eleven books of the sea as grey backdrop for grief, one god's commute turns it joyful — the *Iliad's* single moment of happy nature.
- 4 ll. 66-75 The lesser Ajax detects the god from the way he moves: "the trace of his feet and legs from behind, as he went off, I knew it easily — the gods are easy to know" (ἀρίγνωτοι δὲ θεοί περ). Divine disguise deceives the face-to-face view only; gait betrays godhead. The other symptom is inward: both Ajaxes' hands and feet go "hungry" for battle — possession described from inside the possessed.
- 5 ll. 95-124 Poseidon's rebuke, pivoting on the poem's political nerve: even if Agamemnon is "wholly to blame... because he dishonored the swift-footed son of Peleus, we, for our part, have no leave to slacken" — and then the great clause: "let us heal it, quickly. The minds of good men can be healed" (ἄκεσταί τοι φρένες ἔσθλῶν, 115). The god concedes the grievance and dissolves its authority in nine words — the whole ethics of the quarrel-plot, and the sentence Achilles will not hear until Book 19.
- 6 ll. 126-135 The locked phalanx: "buckler pressed on buckler, helmet on helmet, man on man, and the horsehair crests on the bright ridges touched as they nodded." The lines (131-133) recur at 16.215-217 when the Myrmidons form up — reuse this English there. Whatever the date of hoplite tactics, this is the sensation of close order: equipment touching equipment before any enemy is met.
- 7 ll. 136-146 Hector as the boulder: torn loose by a river in flood, bounding, the woods crashing beneath it — "until it reaches the level plain, and there it rolls no more, for all

its rush." The simile carries its own prophecy: the stone's momentum is the cliff's gift, not the stone's, and the plain is waiting. Hector jams against the close-set lines within five lines of it.

- 8 *ll. 170-205* Imbrius, the son-in-law from Pedaeum who came back to Troy when the war began and was honored by Priam "like his own children" — another of the poem's in-law obituaries (cf. Iphidamas, Othryoneus, Alcatous: Troy's defense is a web of marriages). He falls like an ash on a mountain crest cut down by bronze. Then the book's most brutal image: the lesser Ajax cuts the head from the corpse "in wrath for Amphimachus" and bowls it through the crowd "like a ball," to stop in the dust at Hector's feet. Wrath answered with sport: the small Ajax's savagery is a fixed trait (cf. 23.473-498, and his end in the Odyssey), and the head at Hector's feet is a delivery with an address on it.
- 9 *ll. 206-209* Amphimachus was Cteatus's son — a grandson of the Moliones pair whom Poseidon fathered and once rescued from Nestor (11.750-752). So the god's rage here is family grief: the Iliad's gods enter its casualty-lists two generations removed, and Poseidon's next intervention (note [25]) is likewise a grandfather's grudge.
- 10 *ll. 232-238* Poseidon-as-Thoas: on the day's deserter, "may he be sport for dogs"; then the recruiting proverb — "Even sorry men, combined, come to some courage — and the two of us would know how to fight even the best." The arithmetic of the wall (12.412) again: courage as a sum, spoken by a god enlisting one tired middle-aged king.
- 11 *l. 249* "Meriones, Molus's son": Molus received the boar's- tusk helmet in its pedigree (10.269-270) — the same household's war-gear economy continues here, an entire scene about where spears come from. Idomeneus and Meriones bicker with perfect courtesy — the older man teasing, the younger standing on his record — before the god-stirred battle lets either spend it.
- 12 *ll. 260-294* The armory speech: twenty Trojan spears against the bright wall of the hut, "which I strip from the men I kill," because Idomeneus does "not fight standing far from enemy men." Then the great set-piece (275-286): the ambush as the assay of worth — the coward's color running, his crouch shifting from foot to foot, the heart hammering on the ribs, the teeth chattering aloud; the brave man's color "never changes," and his one prayer is to be mixed in the fighting at once. It is the poem's fullest psychology of fear, set not in the charge but in the waiting — and given to the oldest front-fighter in the army.
- 13 *l. 291* "the front-fighters' trysting-place" — ὁριστός, the word for lovers' intimate talk (cf. 22.127-128, where Hector uses it of a boy and girl whispering), applied to the range where chests meet spears. The battlefield as terrible intimacy: one of the boldest single words in the Iliad.
- 14 *ll. 298-305* Ares and Panic (Phobos, his son, the capitalized personification of 4.440) arming out of Thrace against the Ephyri or Phlegyes — gods who "do not hear both sides' prayers, but hand the glory to one." War-god theology in miniature; and an uneasy simile to hang on Idomeneus and Meriones, since Ares at this hour is penned on Olympus, deaf to everything — not even hearing of his own son's death (note [24]).
- 15 *ll. 339-344* The battle "bristled" (ἔφριξεν) with flesh- cutting spears — the field itself gets gooseflesh; eyes are blinded by bronze glare. Then the narrator's aside: "It would be a

hard-hearted man who could rejoice at the sight of that toil, and not be grieved." As at 12.176 and 4.539-542, the poem turns to check the audience's pleasure — the singer measuring the distance between glory sung and toil seen.

- 16 *ll. 345-360* The theological knot of the middle Iliad: Zeus wills Trojan victory (to glorify Thetis and her son), yet not Achaean annihilation; Poseidon works the other side "in secret... likened to a man" — because "both were of one stock and one parentage, but Zeus was elder-born, and he knew more." Primogeniture as cosmology (restated by force in 15.165-167, and contested at 15.185-199). And so the two sons of Cronos "knotted the cord of strong strife and leveling war, and drew it taut over both sides — a cord unbreakable, not to be untied; and it unstrung the knees of many": the tug-of-war image of battle (cf. 7.102, 11.336) tied to its grimmest clause — the knot the gods cannot break is loosed instead in men's knees. Aristarchus athetized 350 (the Thetis line) as needless; the printed text keeps it.
- 17 *ll. 363-382* Othryoneus, war-bridegroom: he bid for Cassandra — her first appearance in the poem, "loveliest of Priam's daughters," with no word of prophecy, which is post-Homeric — "without bride-gifts," offering instead the war itself as bride-price. Idomeneus kills him mid-stride and conducts the poem's cruellest wedding-negotiation over the body: we'll give you Agamemnon's loveliest daughter "if you will join us and sack the well-peopled city of Ilion. Come along: let us settle the marriage at the seafaring ships — you will find we are not hard men over bride-terms." The marriage-economics of death (Iphidamas, 11.241-245) turned entirely to mockery: the dead man dragged by the foot toward his "wedding."
- 18 *ll. 389-393* Asius falls "as an oak falls, or a white poplar, or a towering pine, that carpenters up in the mountains cut down with fresh-whetted axes to be a ship's timber" — paying the death-notice filed at 12.116-117, killed by the very man it named. The simile recurs verbatim at 16.482-484 for Sarpedon — reuse this English there. Man as felled timber "to be a ship's timber": the war's dead as material for the very machines that brought the war.
- 19 *ll. 402-416* Deiphobus's vaunt for Hypsenor: Asius shall not lie unavenged — "even going down to Hades, the strong closer of the gate, he will be glad at heart: I have given him an escort for the road." The dead man as travel-arrangement; the poem's bookkeeping of vengeance (ποινί) spoken as courtesy. (In fact Hypsenor's death-wound is described and mourned — but the poet never says he died; ancient critics worried the point.)
- 20 *ll. 424-444* Alcatous: the poem's most terrible intervention. Poseidon "charmed his shining eyes and shackled his glorious limbs" — the god holds the man still, "like a grave-pillar or a tree in high leaf," while Idomeneus spears him through the chest. The bridegroom-obituary again (Hippodameia, who outshone her age-mates "in beauty and in handiwork and in wit"); the grave-stele simile stands the man's own monument up in advance; and the heart, still beating, shakes the butt-end of the spear — the most clinically horrifying detail in the poem. A god fighting for the Achaeans does this: the poem does not flinch, and does not comment.
- 21 *ll. 446-454* Idomeneus's ledger ("three for one") and pedigree: Zeus - Minos "warden of Crete" - Deucalion - Idomeneus. The Cretan king's genealogy is the shortest distance in

the poem between Zeus and a living fighter — three generations — and he ends it flatly: the ships have carried me here, "an evil to you, and your father, and the rest of the Trojans."

- 22 *Il. 459-461* Aeneas found sulking, "rearmost of the crowd, for he was forever furious at brilliant Priam, because, brave among men as he was, Priam gave him no honor." The Achilles-pattern in Trojan miniature: worth unhonored by the king, service withheld. The grievance (never elsewhere explained) belongs to the junior branch of the royal house — cf. 20.178-183, where Achilles taunts him with hoping to inherit Priam's rank, and 20.302-308, where Poseidon prophesies that his line, not Priam's, will rule the Trojans hereafter.
- 23 *Il. 489-495* Aeneas's men follow "as flocks follow the bell-ram down from the pasture to drink — and the shepherd's heart is glad": war-following rendered as the tameest scene the poem knows, with the commander's joy set inside the shepherd's. The gentlest simile in a savage book.
- 24 *Il. 518-525* Deiphobus's cast kills Ascalaphus, "son of Enyalios" (Ares' son by the Catalogue, 2.512) — "but loud-roaring massive Ares knew nothing of it yet... he sat on the peak of Olympus, under the golden clouds, penned there by the designs of Zeus." A father's ignorance held in suspension across two books: at 15.110-142 Ares learns, arms for revenge against Zeus's edict, and must be forced down by Athena. The quiet lines here are the fuse.
- 25 *Il. 554-575* Poseidon shields Antilochus (Nestor's son — the god's affection for the house of Neleus again) and makes Adamas's spear-point "strengthless... grudging him that life." Adamas dies under Meriones' throw "between the genitals and the navel — there where the war-god comes most grievous to wretched mortals" — the poem's plainest statement about wounds and pain — writhing "as a bull writhes that herdsmen in the mountains have bound with willow-ropes and drag along unwilling." The pastoral world keeps arriving as the measure of agony.
- 26 *Il. 586-592* Helenus's arrow springs off Menelaus's corslet "as off a broad winnowing-shovel, on a great threshing-floor, the dark-skinned beans or the chickpeas jump under the shrill wind and the winnower's swing." Harvest again — the missile as chaff-work; the deadly and the domestic in one bounce. The duel itself is asymmetric: spear against bow, and the spear pins the bow-hand to the bow.
- 27 *Il. 598-600* The wounded hand is bound "in a sling of twisted sheep's wool" — the σφενδόνη, the Iliad's only named sling, here as bandage; at 716 the same twisted wool arms the Locrians as a weapon. One humble implement, both uses, thirty lines apart: the poem's quartermaster memory at work.
- 28 *Il. 620-639* Menelaus over Peisander (killed in the poem's one axe-against-sword exchange, his eyes dropped bloody in the dust): the wronged husband's theology. The Trojans are indicted under "the harsh wrath of loud-thundering Zeus of Guest-right" (Ζηνὸς ξεινίου... μῆνιν — the poem's theme-word "wrath" given to Zeus as protector of hospitality, the war's whole legal basis in one phrase); then the strange, wonderful complaint: "Of all things there is satiety — of sleep, of love, of sweet song and of blameless dancing; a man would sooner pray to take his fill of these than of war. But the

Trojans are never sated with battle." The catalogue of things men can have enough of is the poem's shyest confession of what peace is for. Ancient critics athetized here (637); readers have loved the passage in exact proportion.

- 29 *ll. 643-659* Harpalion dies "like a worm... stretched on the ground" — the poem's smallest death-simile, for a boy who followed his father to war. And then the famous impossibility: "among them went his father, shedding tears" — his father is Pylaemenes, killed by Menelaus at 5.576-579 in our own text. Ancient critics athetized 658-659 to heal the contradiction; moderns treat it as the clearest seam of oral composition — the poet reaching for the pathos-formula (a father behind a bier) without an audit of Book 5. The translation keeps the printed text and the wound. The closing line — "and there was no blood-price for his son who was dead" — prices the loss in the currency the poem uses everywhere (cf. 9.632-636, 18.498).
- 30 *ll. 663-672* Euchenor of Corinth, the seer's son, who sailed "knowing well his deadly fate": his father had told him he would die of sickness at home or under Trojan hands at the ships. He chose the spear — "and so he shunned two things at once: the heavy fine of the Achaeans, and the loathsome sickness." The precise double of Achilles' two fates (9.410-416) at commoner's scale — and with the poem's driest touch, the war-death is also a tax dodge: the *θωρή*, the fine levied on draft-evaders, listed in one breath with mortal disease. He is killed by Paris, absent-mindedly, in someone else's revenge.
- 31 *ll. 685-700* The defense roster: Boeotians, Locrians, Phthians, Epeians, picked Athenians — and "the Ionians with their trailing tunics" (*Ἰάονες ἐλκεχίτωνες*), the name's only occurrence in Homer, applied to Athenian-led troops: a single audible seam between the poem's world and the poet's own Ionian one.
- 32 *ll. 694-697* Medon, bastard son of Oileus, exiled from his fatherland "having killed a man, a kinsman of his stepmother Eriopis": the homicide-exile is epic's standard hard-luck biography (cf. Patroclus, 23.85-88). These four lines recur verbatim at 15.333-336, where Medon dies — the poem files a man's whole story twice, once at his post and once at his death. Reuse this English there.
- 33 *ll. 701-708* The two Ajaxes as "two wine-dark oxen" (*βόε οἶνοντε* — the sea's own color-word given to plow-beasts) straining at one plow, sweat welling at the roots of their horns, the polished yoke alone holding them apart: the poem's great image of joint labor — heroic partnership rendered as agriculture, down the furrow to the field's edge.
- 34 *ll. 712-722* The Locrian way of war: no helmets, no shields, no ash spears — bows and wool slings, shooting "from behind, unseen," while the armored line fights in front. Combined arms, and the breaking of the Trojan rush credited to the missile troops the heroic code barely deigns to see (cf. 11.385-390): the poem knows exactly what wins battles, and says so here without editorializing.
- 35 *ll. 726-747* Polydamas's third counsel — accepted, like the first: the famous division of gifts. "To one man the god has given the works of war, to another the dance, to another the lyre and song, and in another's chest wide-seeing Zeus sets a mind of worth... But you cannot possibly take all things to yourself at once." (Line 731 — dance and song — was omitted by Aristarchus; Zenodotus kept it, Lucian quoted it, and the printed text prints it.) The tactical advice — regroup, count heads, decide — carries a shadow-clause:

"a man waits by the ships insatiate of war," the book's only reference to Achilles as a standing threat, from the man who is always right.

- 36 l. 754 Hector sets off "like a snow-shining mountain" — ὄρεϊ νιφόεντι ἐοικώς: a man like a mountain, and a moving one; ancient and modern readers have puzzled at it (a mass of glittering bronze? a peak walking?). It is the largest thing Hector is ever compared to, on the day his rush crests.
- 37 l. 769 "Paris — evil Paris — beauty and nothing more, woman-mad, seducer": Hector's rebuke repeats 3.39 word for word, our English kept. There it opened the poem's first duel, here its last day of Trojan victory — and Paris's answer this time is measured, brave, and just ("your heart is set on blaming the blameless" — the very phrase Patroclus used of Achilles, 11.654), ending on the proverb "Beyond his strength no man can fight, however hot he burns." The poem allows Paris his best moment exactly where Hector repeats his worst line.
- 38 ll. 809-832 The exchange before the charge: Ajax's taunt promises Hector a prayer for horses "swifter than falcons," and the eagle confirms it on the right; Hector's reply is the strangest oath-wish in the poem — "I wish I were as surely, all my days, the son of aegis-bearing Zeus... as this day is bringing evil on the Argives": certainty of today traded against an impossible divinity, from the man who cannot know his warrant expires at sundown. His threat gives Ajax "lily- soft skin" (χρόα λειριόεντα) — the flower-word for the flesh of the enemy's biggest man; and "you blundering ox of a braggart" (βουγάϊε) is one of the poem's rare pure insults, coarse as a barnyard.
- 39 l. 837 The last line: "and the clamor of both reached the ether and the radiance of Zeus." The book that began with Zeus turning his shining eyes away ends with the battle arriving at him as sound — αἰθέρα καὶ Διὸς αὐγάς, the noise climbing into the very brightness he looked away with. The ring closes: he will look back down at 15.4, and the correction will be immediate and total.

Iliad — Book 14

Hera seduces Zeus and lulls him to sleep; Poseidon turns the tide; Ajax fells Hector with a stone.

- But the war-cry did not escape Nestor, drinking though he was:¹
 he spoke winged words to Asclepius' son:
 "Consider, brilliant Machaon, how these things will go:
 the cry of the strong young men is louder by the ships.
- 5 You sit here now and drink the fire-bright wine
 until lovely-braided Hecamede has heated
 a warm bath, and washed away the clotted blood;
 I will go out to a lookout point and quickly learn the truth."
 So speaking he took up the well-made shield of his son,
- 10 horse-taming Thrasymedes, that lay in the hut
 all glittering with bronze — the son had his father's shield —
 and took up a stout spear, edged with sharp bronze,
 and stood outside the hut, and at once saw ugly work:
 his own men being driven, and the high-hearted Trojans
- 15 hounding them from behind; and the Achaeans' wall was down.
 As when the great open sea darkens with soundless swell,²
 boding the quick paths of the shrill winds —
 only boding; it neither rolls forward nor to either side,
 until some deciding blast comes down from Zeus:
- 20 so the old man weighed it, his heart torn two ways —
 to go into the crowd of the swift-coltd Danaans,
 or after Atreus' son Agamemnon, shepherd of the people.
 And as he weighed it, this seemed to him the better course:
 to go to Atreus' son. Meanwhile the others went on killing
- 25 one another as they fought; and the unwearying bronze rang
 about their bodies, stabbed with swords and double-curved spears.
 And the Zeus-nurtured kings fell in with Nestor,
 coming up from the ships — all who had been hit by the bronze,
 Tydeus' son, and Odysseus, and Atreus' son Agamemnon.³
- 30 For their ships were drawn up far away from the fighting
 on the beach of the grey sea: those had been hauled first,

- up toward the plain, and the wall was built by the sterns.
For the beach, wide as it was, could not hold all
the ships, and the armies were cramped for room;
35 so they had drawn them up in tiers, and filled the whole
long mouth of the shore, all the headlands penned between.
So the kings, wanting to see the battle and the war-cry,
came up together leaning on their spears; and the heart
in each man's chest was grieved. And the old man met them,
40 Nestor — and the heart in the Achaeans' chests went cold.
And the lord Agamemnon called to him and spoke:
"Nestor, Neleus' son, great glory of the Achaeans,
why have you left the man-destroying war and come here?
I fear massive Hector may make good the word he spoke
45 when he threatened us once, haranguing the Trojans:
that he would not go back from the ships to Ilion
until he had burned the ships with fire and killed the men.
So that man talked; and now it is all coming to pass.
Shame! — surely the other strong-greaved Achaeans too
50 are storing anger against me in their hearts, like Achilles,
and have no will to fight by the sterns of the ships."
Then answered him the Gerenian horseman Nestor:
"Yes — all this stands accomplished before us, and not even
Zeus who thunders on high could build it otherwise now.
55 For the wall is down — the wall we trusted
to be an unbreakable shield for the ships and for ourselves;
and the enemy at the swift ships keep up their relentless
battle without pause. You could no longer tell, however hard
you studied it, from which side the Achaeans are being driven:
60 so mixed is the killing; and the clamor goes up to heaven.
Let us take thought how these things will go —
if thought can do anything. But I do not counsel
that we enter the fighting: a wounded man cannot fight."
Then the lord of men Agamemnon answered him:
65 "Nestor — since they are fighting by the sterns of the ships,
and the built wall was no use, nor the ditch,
though the Danaans suffered so much for it, and hoped in their hearts
it would be an unbreakable shield for the ships and for ourselves —

- Such, it seems, must be the pleasure of overmastering Zeus:
70 that the Achaeans perish here, nameless, far from Argos.
I knew it when he defended the Danaans with a will,
and I know it now, when he glorifies our enemies
like the blessed gods, and has bound our fury and our hands.
Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:
75 the ships that are drawn up nearest the sea —
let us drag them down and haul them all to the bright water,
and moor them riding high at anchor-stones, until
the deathless night comes — if even by night the Trojans
will hold off from war; and then we might haul down every ship.
80 There is no shame in fleeing ruin, not even by night.
Better a man who flees and escapes the evil than one who is caught."
Glaring at him darkly, resourceful Odysseus answered:
"Son of Atreus — what a word has escaped the fence of your teeth!⁴
Ruinous man! I wish you commanded some other army,
85 a shabby one — not that you were lord over us, for whom Zeus
has given it, from youth right down to old age,
to wind the skein of hard wars, till we perish every one.
Is this how you long to leave the wide-wayed city
of the Trojans, for which we have suffered so much misery?
90 Silence! — before some other Achaean hears this word,
which no man should so much as bring through his mouth,
no man whose heart knows how to speak what is fitting,
no sceptered king whom armies obey —
armies as many as the Argives you rule.
95 This time I scorn your judgment outright — such a thing to say!
You tell us, with the war standing joined and the shouting up,
to haul the well-benched ships to the sea, so that the Trojans
can have still more of their prayers, winning as they already are,
and sheer destruction tip its beam onto us. For the Achaeans
100 will not hold their battle while the ships are dragged seaward:
they will look back over their shoulders and drop out of the fighting.
Then, marshal of the people, your counsel will have wrecked us."
Then the lord of men Agamemnon answered him:
"Odysseus — you have caught me hard, straight to the heart,
105 with that grim rebuke. I do not order the sons of the Achaeans

- to haul the well-benched ships to the sea against their will.
 Now let there be a man with better counsel than mine —
 young or old — and I would welcome him gladly."
 And among them spoke Diomedes, good at the war-cry:
- 110 "The man is here — we need not search for long — if you are willing
 to listen, and each of you does not bristle with resentment
 because by birth I am the youngest among you.
 I too claim my descent from a noble father,
 Tydeus, whom the heaped earth covers now at Thebes.⁵
- 115 For to Portheus three blameless sons were born,
 and they lived in Pleuron and steep Calydon:
 Agrius, and Melas, and the third was the horseman Oeneus,
 my father's father — in valor the best of them.
 Oeneus stayed there; but my father settled at Argos,
- 120 a wanderer: so, I suppose, Zeus and the other gods willed it.
 He married a daughter of Adrastus, and lived in a house
 rich in substance: he had wheat-bearing fields enough,
 and many orchards of trees stood round about,
 and he had flocks in plenty; and he surpassed all the Achaeans
- 125 with the spear. You will have heard all this — that it is true.
 So you cannot say my stock is base and cowardly
 and dishonor the word I speak, if I speak it well.
 Come: let us go to the battle, wounded as we are. We must.
 There, let us hold ourselves out of the combat,
- 130 beyond spear-cast, lest anyone take wound upon wound;
 but the others we will drive in and send to it — those who before,
 indulging their tempers, have stood apart and would not fight."
 So he spoke; and they heard him well, and obeyed,
 and set off; and the lord of men Agamemnon led them.
- 135 But the famed earth-shaker kept no blind man's watch:
 he came after them in the likeness of an old man,⁶
 and took the right hand of Agamemnon, Atreus' son,
 and speaking winged words he addressed him:
 "Son of Atreus — now, I think, Achilles' ruinous heart
- 140 is rejoicing in his chest, watching the slaughter
 and the rout of the Achaeans; for there is no sense in him, none.
 Well — let him perish just so; may a god strike him lame.

But with you the blessed gods are not yet wholly angry:
 the day is coming, I think, when the leaders and lords of the Trojans
 145 will raise the dust of the wide plain, and you yourself will watch them
 running for the city, away from the ships and the huts."
 So speaking he gave a great shout, and swept off across the plain.
 as loud as nine thousand men, or ten thousand,
 cry out in war when they join the strife of the war-god,
 150 so great was the voice the lord earth-shaker sent
 out of his chest; and into each Achaean's heart he threw
 great strength, to war and fight without ceasing.⁷
 Now Hera of the golden throne looked out and saw them,
 standing on her peak of Olympus; and at once she knew
 155 her own brother — her husband's brother too — bustling
 through the battle where men win glory, and her heart was glad;
 and she saw Zeus, seated on the topmost peak
 of Ida of the many springs, and he was hateful to her heart.
 Then ox-eyed lady Hera fell to pondering
 160 how she might trick the mind of aegis-bearing Zeus;⁸
 and this to her mind seemed the best counsel:
 to array herself with care and go to Ida —
 in hope that he might desire to lie in love
 against her body, and she might pour a sleep, harmless and warm,
 165 over his eyelids and over his close counsels.
 She went to her chamber, which her dear son Hephaestus
 had built her, fitting the close doors to their posts
 with a secret bolt no other god could open.
 There she went in, and closed the shining doors.
 170 With ambrosia first she washed from her desirable body
 every stain, and anointed herself with rich oil,
 ambrosial, soft, and scented for her especially:
 if it were so much as stirred in the bronze-floored house of Zeus,
 its breath reached earth and heaven alike.
 175 With this she anointed her fair body, and combed her hair,
 and with her own hands plaited the shining braids,
 beautiful, ambrosial, streaming from her immortal head.
 And she put on the ambrosial robe that Athena
 had smoothed and worked for her, and set with many figures,

- 180 and pinned it across her breast with brooches of gold.
 She belted it with a girdle hung with a hundred tassels,
 and in her pierced earlobes she hung the earrings,
 three-dropped, mulberry-dark; and great grace shone from her.
 And over all, brilliant among goddesses, she veiled herself
- 185 in a headdress lovely and new, white as the sun,
 and beneath her shining feet she bound fair sandals.⁹
 And when she had set all this adornment about her body,
 she went from the chamber, and calling Aphrodite
 apart from the other gods she spoke her word:
- 190 "Would you do something for me, dear child, if I ask it?
 Or will you refuse me, holding it against me in your heart
 that I defend the Danaans, and you the Trojans?"
 Then Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus, answered her:
 "Hera, eldest goddess, daughter of great Cronos,
- 195 say what is in your mind. My heart bids me do it,
 if do it I can — if it is a thing that can be done."
 And with guile in her heart the lady Hera answered:
 "Give me now love, and desire — the power with which
 you master all the immortals, and mortal men.
- 200 For I am going to the ends of the generous earth, to see
 Oceanus, the begetting of the gods, and mother Tethys,
 who reared me well in their own halls and cherished me,
 taking me from Rhea, when wide-seeing Zeus put Cronos
 down beneath the earth and the barren sea.
- 205 I go to see them, and to loose their endless quarrel:
 for a long time now they have held apart from one another,
 from bed and from love, since anger fell upon their hearts.
 If with words I could persuade those two dear hearts,
 and bring them back to their bed, to be joined in love,
- 210 forever I would be called dear to them, and revered."
 Then laughter-loving Aphrodite answered her:
 "It cannot be, and it would not be right, to refuse your word:
 you sleep in the arms of Zeus, and Zeus is highest."
 She spoke, and loosed from her breast the pierced band,
 215 embroidered, where all her enchantments lie worked:
 in it is love, in it desire, in it the trysting-talk —

persuasion, that steals the wits even of the close-thinkers.¹⁰
 She put it in her hands, and spoke a word, and named her:
 "There: take this band and put it away in the fold
 220 of your breast — embroidered: everything is worked into it. And I tell
 you
 you will not come back unaccomplished, whatever your heart intends."
 So she spoke; and ox-eyed lady Hera smiled,
 and smiling put it away in the fold of her breast.
 Then Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus, went to the house,
 225 and Hera in one spring left the peak of Olympus,
 and touching down on Pieria and lovely Emathia¹¹
 swept over the snowy mountains of the horse-herding
 Thracians, over their topmost summits, nor grazed the ground with her
 feet;
 from Athos she stepped out over the heaving sea
 230 and came to Lemnos, city of godlike Thoas.
 There she met Sleep, the brother of Death,¹²
 and clung to his hand, and spoke a word, and named him:
 "Sleep, lord of all gods and of all men —
 as once before you heard my word, so now again
 235 obey me; and I will owe you thanks all my days.
 Put Zeus's shining eyes to sleep for me beneath his brows,
 the moment I have lain beside him in love.
 And I will give you gifts: a fair throne, imperishable forever,
 golden, which my own son Hephaestus the crook-footed
 240 will make with all his craft; and under it he will set a footstool
 where you can rest your shining feet at the feast."
 And answering her spoke sweet Sleep:
 "Hera, eldest goddess, daughter of great Cronos,
 any other of the gods, the everlasting-born,
 245 I would easily put under — even the streams of the river
 Oceanus, who is the begetting of them all;
 but Zeus, the son of Cronos — I would not come near him,
 much less put him to sleep, unless he himself commanded.
 For once before now a command of yours taught me my lesson,
 250 the day when that high-hearted son of Zeus
 sailed from Ilion, having sacked the Trojans' city.

- I laid the mind of aegis-bearing Zeus asleep,
 poured sweet about him; and you devised evils in your heart,
 rousing the blasts of punishing winds over the sea,
 255 and carried Heracles away to well-peopled Cos,
 far from all his friends. And Zeus, waking, was furious,
 hurling gods this way and that through the house; and me above all
 he hunted, and would have flung me from the sky into the sea, gone
 forever,
 had Night not saved me — Night, subduer of gods and men.
 260 To her I came running; and he checked himself, for all his anger:
 he stood in awe of doing what swift Night would hate.
 And now you ask me to do this other impossible thing."
 Then ox-eyed lady Hera answered him:
 "Sleep, why do you brood on such things in your heart?
 265 Do you think wide-seeing Zeus will rage for the Trojans
 as he raged that time over Heracles, his own son?
 Come — I will give you one of the younger Graces:
 marry her, and let her be called your wife."

[Line 269 is absent from the printed text; see note 13.]

- 270 So she spoke; and Sleep was delighted, and answered her:¹³
 "Swear to me now by the inviolable water of Styx —
 lay one hand on the earth that feeds so many,
 and the other on the shining sea, so that all may be
 witnesses between us, the gods below with Cronos —
 275 that you will truly give me one of the younger Graces:
 Pasithea, whom I myself have longed for all my days."
 So he spoke, and the goddess white-armed Hera did not refuse:
 she swore as he commanded, and named all the gods
 under Tartarus, who are called the Titans.
 280 And when she had sworn and brought the oath to completion,
 the two of them left the towns of Lemnos and Imbros,
 clothed in mist, and made their road swiftly.
 They came to Ida of the many springs, mother of wild things,
 to Lecton, where they first left the sea; and over dry land
 285 they went, and the treetops shook beneath their feet.
 There Sleep halted, before the eyes of Zeus could see him,
 climbing into a towering fir, the tallest

then grown on Ida, that reached through the mist to the upper air.
 There he perched, hidden close in the fir boughs,
 290 in the likeness of the clear-voiced mountain bird
 the gods call chalkis, and men call kymindis.¹⁴
 But Hera went quickly on up to Gargaron peak
 on lofty Ida; and Zeus the cloud-gatherer saw her.
 And the moment he saw her, desire wrapped his close mind round,
 295 as on the day they first mingled in love,
 going to the bed again and again behind their dear parents' backs.¹⁵
 He stood before her, and spoke a word, and named her:
 "Hera — where are you rushing, that you come down from Olympus
 like this — with no horses near, no chariot to mount?"
 300 And with guile in her heart the lady Hera answered:
 "I am going to the ends of the generous earth, to see
 Oceanus, the begetting of the gods, and mother Tethys,
 who reared me well in their own halls and cherished me;
 I go to see them, and to loose their endless quarrel:
 305 for a long time now they have held apart from one another,
 from bed and from love, since anger fell upon their hearts.
 My horses stand at the foot of Ida of the many springs,
 ready to carry me over dry land and water both.
 It is on your account I have come down from Olympus now —
 310 so that you would not be angry with me afterward, if I went
 in silence to the house of deep-flowing Oceanus."
 Answering her spoke Zeus the cloud-gatherer:
 "Hera — you can set out for there later just as well.
 Come, let the two of us go to bed, and turn to love.
 315 For never has desire for goddess or for woman
 so flooded and mastered the heart inside my chest —
 not when I loved Ixion's wife,¹⁶
 who bore Peirithous, the equal of the gods in counsel;
 nor Danaë of the lovely ankles, Acrisius' daughter,
 320 who bore Perseus, most admired of all men;
 nor the daughter of far-famed Phoenix,
 who bore me Minos and godlike Rhadamanthys;
 nor Semele, nor Alcmene in Thebes —
 and she bore Heracles, my strong-hearted son,

- 325 while Semele bore Dionysus, a joy to mortals;
 nor when I loved the lady Demeter of the lovely braids,
 nor glorious Leto — no, nor you yourself:
 none as I love you now, and sweet desire takes hold of me."
 And with guile in her heart the lady Hera answered:
- 330 "Most dread son of Cronos, what a word you have spoken!¹⁷
 If now you long to lie down in love
 on the peaks of Ida, where everything stands open to view —
 how would it be if some one of the everlasting gods
 saw us asleep, and going among all the gods
- 335 told them? I could not rise from that bed and simply
 walk home to your house; it would be a scandal.
 But if you will — if that is truly your heart's pleasure —
 you have a chamber, which your dear son Hephaestus
 built you, fitting the close doors to their posts:
- 340 let us go and lie there, since the bed is your desire."
 Answering her spoke Zeus the cloud-gatherer:
 "Hera, have no fear that any god or man
 will see: such a cloud will I wrap around us,
 a golden one. Not even Helios could spy us through it,
- 345 and his light is the sharpest sight there is."
 He spoke, and the son of Cronos caught his wife in his arms;
 and beneath them the bright earth put out fresh grass,
 and dewy lotus, and crocus, and hyacinth,
 thick and soft, that held them up off the ground.
- 350 In that they lay together, and drew over them a cloud,
 fair and golden; and glittering dew-drops fell away from it.¹⁸
 So the father slept, unmoving, on Gargaron peak,
 broken by sleep and love, his wife in his arms;
 and sweet Sleep set off at a run for the ships of the Achaeans
- 355 to bring the word to the holder of the earth, the earth-shaker.
 Standing close, he spoke winged words to him:
 "Now, Poseidon, help the Danaans with a will,¹⁹
 and hand them the glory — at least a little while, while Zeus
 still sleeps; for I have wrapped him in a soft daze,
- 360 and Hera has tricked him into bed, into love."
 So speaking he went off toward the famed tribes of men;

and Poseidon, stirred still more to defend the Danaans,
 sprang far out among the foremost at once, and called:
 "Argives! Are we to concede the victory again to Hector,
 365 Priam's son — let him take the ships and win the glory?
 That is his own claim and his boast, because Achilles
 sits by the hollow ships with anger in his heart.
 But Achilles will not be missed so very much
 if the rest of us rouse ourselves to defend each other.
 370 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:
 let us dress ourselves in the biggest and best shields
 in the army, and hide our heads in helmets
 blazing all over, and take the longest spears in our hands,
 and go. And I will lead; and I say Hector, Priam's son,
 375 will not stand us, however hot he burns.
 And whatever staunch fighter has a small shield at his shoulder,
 let him give it to a worse man, and get into a bigger."²⁰
 So he spoke; and they heard him well, and obeyed.
 And the kings themselves, wounded as they were, marshaled them —
 380 Tydeus' son, and Odysseus, and Atreus' son Agamemnon —
 and going down the whole line they made the exchange of war-gear:
 the good man got into good armor, and gave the worse to the worse.
 And when they had clothed their bodies in the flashing bronze
 they set out; and Poseidon the earth-shaker led them,
 385 holding in his heavy hand a terrible thin-edged sword
 like a lightning-flash — a thing no man may meet
 in the grim combat: dread holds men back from it.²¹
 And on the other side glorious Hector marshaled the Trojans.
 Then it was that they stretched the most terrible strife of war,
 390 blue-maned Poseidon and glorious Hector,
 one defending the Trojans, the other the Argives;
 and the sea washed up to the huts and ships
 of the Argives, and the armies met with a great war-shout.
 Not so loud does the sea's wave roar against the land,²²
 395 driven up out of open water by the hard North Wind;
 not so loud the bellow of blazing fire
 in mountain glens, when it rises to burn the timber;
 not so loud the wind through the high-crowned oaks —

the wind at its loudest, when its rage is up and roaring —
 400 as the voice of Trojans and Achaeans then,
 crying terror, when they sprang upon each other.
 At Ajax first glorious Hector cast
 his spear, as Ajax stood turned full toward him, and did not miss:
 he hit where the two straps lay stretched across the chest,
 405 one for the shield, one for the silver-studded sword;
 the two of them saved the soft flesh. And Hector was angered
 that his swift missile had flown from his hand in vain,
 and drew back into the band of his companions, dodging doom.
 But as he went back, great Telamonian Ajax
 410 took up a stone — one of the many that rolled there
 under the fighters' feet, props for the swift ships —
 and struck his chest, over the shield-rim, close to the neck,
 and set him spinning like a top with the blow: he reeled full circle.²³
 As when an oak goes down under the stroke of father Zeus,
 415 torn out by the roots, and the terrible smell of sulphur
 rises off it, and courage fails whoever sees it
 from close by — for hard is the bolt of great Zeus:
 so Hector's fury dropped in an instant to the dust.
 His hand let go the spear, and shield and helmet
 420 crumpled down on him, and his armor, intricate with bronze, clashed
 about him.
 With a great shout the sons of the Achaeans ran in,
 hoping to drag him off, and hurled their spears
 thick and fast; but no one could wound the shepherd of the people
 with thrust or throw: before that, the best men ringed him round —
 425 Polydamas, and Aeneas, and brilliant Agenor,
 and Sarpedon, leader of the Lycians, and blameless Glaucus;
 and of the rest not one neglected him, but they held
 their round shields before him. And his companions
 lifted him in their arms and carried him out of the toil,
 430 until they reached his swift horses, which stood behind
 the battle and the fighting with their charioteer and the intricate
 chariot;
 these carried him toward the city, groaning heavily.
 But when they came to the ford of the fair-flowing river,²⁴

- eddy Xanthus, whom immortal Zeus begot,
 435 there they laid him from the chariot onto the ground, and poured
 water over him; and he got his breath, and looked up with his eyes,
 and sitting on his knees he vomited dark blood;
 then sank back again to the ground, and both his eyes
 were covered in black night: the blow still broke his spirit.
- 440 And the Argives, when they saw Hector going off,
 leapt at the Trojans all the harder, and remembered their war-craft.
 There first of all the swift Ajax, Oïleus' son,
 sprang in and wounded Satnius with his sharp-pointed spear —
 Enops's son, whom the blameless naiad nymph bore
 445 to Enops as he herded by the banks of Satnioeis.²⁵
 Oïleus' spear-famed son came close and stabbed him
 in the flank; he tumbled backward, and around him
 Trojans and Danaans joined the strong encounter.
 Polydamas the spear-shaker came to avenge him,
 450 Panthous's son, and hit Prothoenor, Areïlycus's son,
 in the right shoulder; through the shoulder the massive spear
 drove; and falling in the dust he clutched the earth in his palm.
 And Polydamas vaunted terribly over him, crying far:
 "There — again! From the massive hand of the great-hearted
 455 son of Panthous the javelin did not leap in vain:
 one of the Argives caught it in his flesh; and I think
 he will lean on it for a staff as he walks down into Hades."²⁶
 So he spoke, and grief came over the Argives at his vaunting,
 and most of all he stirred the heart of war-minded Ajax,
 460 Telamon's son — for the man fell closest to him.
 Quickly he cast at the other with his shining spear as he drew back.
 Polydamas himself escaped black doom,
 springing aside; but Antenor's son Archelochus
 caught it — for the gods had counseled his destruction.
 465 It struck him where head and neck join,
 at the topmost bone of the spine, and sheared both tendons through;
 and his head and mouth and nostrils hit the ground
 long before his shins and knees, as he fell.²⁷
 And Ajax in his turn called out to blameless Polydamas:
 470 "Think it over, Polydamas, and tell me truly:

- is this man not a worthy exchange for Prothoenor
dead? He seems to me no base man, of no base line:
a brother of horse-taming Antenor,
or a son — the family look sits close upon him."
- 475 He spoke knowing it well; and grief seized the Trojans' hearts.
Then Acamas, standing over his brother, wounded with the spear
Promachus the Boeotian, who was hauling the body by the feet.
And Acamas vaunted terribly over him, crying far:
"Argives — arrow-braggarts — never sated with threats!"²⁸
- 480 Not for us alone, I promise you, the toil
and the misery: you too will be killed like this, in your turn.
Look how your Promachus sleeps, beaten down
by my spear — so my brother's blood-price should not go
long unpaid. That is why a man prays for a kinsman
- 485 left in his halls: to ward off ruin for him."
So he spoke, and grief came over the Argives at his vaunting,
and most of all he stirred the heart of war-minded Peneleos.
He went for Acamas; and Acamas did not stand the charge
of lord Peneleos; and Peneleos wounded Ilioneus,
490 son of Phorbas rich in flocks, whom Hermes loved
beyond all the Trojans, and gave him wealth;
and to him his mother had borne one only son, Ilioneus.
Him he stabbed beneath the brow, at the roots of the eye,
and pushed the eyeball out; straight through the eye
- 495 and through the nape the spear drove, and he sank down,
stretching out both his hands. And Peneleos, drawing
his sharp sword, hewed through the middle of the neck, and struck
to the ground head and helmet together; and the massive spear
still stood in the eye; and holding it up like a poppy-head²⁹
- 500 he displayed it to the Trojans, and spoke in triumph:
"Trojans — take a message for me to the dear father
and the mother of illustrious Ilioneus: let them wail in their halls.
For neither will the wife of Promachus, Alegenor's son,
rejoice to meet her dear husband coming home, that day
- 505 when we young men of the Achaeans sail back from Troy."
So he spoke; and trembling took the limbs of every one of them,³⁰
and each man looked about him for escape from sheer destruction.

Tell me now, Muses, who keep your homes on Olympus —³¹
 who was first of the Achaeans to lift the bloody spoils
 510 of men, once the famed earth-shaker had tilted the battle?
 Ajax first, Telamon's son, wounded Hyrtius,
 Gyrtius' son, leader of the strong-hearted Mysians;
 and Antilochus stripped the life from Phalces and Mermerus;
 and Meriones killed Morys and Hippotion,
 515 and Teucer brought down Prothoon and Periphetes;
 and Atreus' son next wounded Hyperenor, shepherd of the people,
 in the flank, and the bronze drank his bowels through,
 tearing in; and his soul through the stabbed wound
 came hurrying out, and darkness covered his eyes.
 520 But the most were killed by the swift Ajax, Oïleus' son:
 for there was no one like him for speed of foot in the chase
 when men broke and ran, when Zeus drove the panic in them.³²

NOTES TO BOOK 14

- 1 *ll. 1-8* The book opens on the smallest possible hinge: Nestor, still in the hut of Book 11, hears the noise change pitch — "drinking though he was" — sets down the cup, borrows his son's shield (the son has his father's: the family's gear swapped down the generations), and steps outside into the catastrophe. Machaon is left with the wine and the promised bath: the wounded man's war is a warm tub.

- 2 *ll. 16-22* The old man's indecision as ground-swell: the open sea darkening "with soundless swell, boding the quick paths of the shrill winds — only boding: it neither rolls forward nor to either side, until some deciding blast comes down from Zeus." Deliberation rendered as weather that has not chosen; among the subtlest interior similes in the poem — the mind as sea before the decision that will move it, and the decision, as always, filed under Zeus.

- 3 *ll. 27-40* The council of the wounded: Diomedes, Odysseus, Agamemnon, "leaning on their spears," come up merely to watch — the poem's commanders reduced to spectators with walking-sticks. The parenthesis on the camp's terraced ship-rows (30-36) is the Iliad's clearest picture of its own stage-set: the beach too small for the fleet, the ships in tiers filling "the whole long mouth of the shore."

- 4 *ll. 82-102* Agamemnon's third flight-proposal (cf. 2.139, 9.26) — this time under fire, ships to be dragged seaward mid-battle — meets the poem's fiercest rebuke, reusing 4.349-350 verbatim: "what a word has escaped the fence of your teeth!" Odysseus's indictment is total: the wish for "some other army, a shabby one"; the credo of the war-generation ("for whom Zeus has given it, from youth right down to old age, to wind the skein of hard wars, till we perish every one" — war as spun wool, the life-thread and the war-thread one); the flat imperative "Silence!" (σίγα); and the tactical point that settles it — armies do not fight while their transport is leaving. Agamemnon's answer is the best thing he does in the poem: "you have caught me hard... Now let there be a man with better counsel than mine — young or old — and I would welcome him gladly."

- 5 *ll. 109-132* Diomedes claims the floor by genealogy — Portheus, Agrius, Melas, Oeneus; Tydeus the wanderer who married Adrastus's daughter and lies "under the heaped earth at Thebes" — the poem's fullest version of his family tree, deployed for the right to advise elders. The advice itself is modest and correct: go down, stay out of range, and shame the shirkers in. The youngest speaks last and best (cf. 9.31-49).

- 6 *ll. 135-152* Poseidon as anonymous old man, taking Agamemnon by the right hand: the gesture of pledge. His curse on Achilles — "let him perish just so; may a god strike him lame" — is the harshest thing said of Achilles in the poem, and it is said by a god fighting for Achilles' own side. (Zenodotus's text added a line making the disguise Phoenix — tidier and much less interesting.) Then the shout of "nine thousand men, or ten thousand": divine encouragement measured in decibels, repeating the strength-verse used of Strife at 11.11-12.

- 7 *ll. 148-152* See above — the shout-lines close with the same formula that opened Book 11's Strife-scene: the gods' rallying voices are interchangeable parts, and the poem knows it.
- 8 *ll. 153-165* The plan, stated with the poem's usual candor about Hera: she saw her brother-in-law working "and her heart was glad"; she saw her husband "and he was hateful to her heart." The deception is her own invention from desire's raw materials: body, sleep, and the borrowed girdle. The Dios Apatē is the one stretch of the Iliad where the plot of Zeus is successfully counter-plotted — by his wife, with comedy's weapons.
- 9 *ll. 166-186* The toilette is built exactly like an arming scene — the sequence of items (wash, anoint, robe, girdle, earrings, veil, sandals) laid out with the same formulaic machinery as greaves-corslet-sword-shield-helmet-spear (cf. 3.330-338), ending in the same clause that ends armings. Hera arms for bed. Every item has its maker or provenance (the chamber and bolt by Hephaestus, the robe worked by Athena) — divine materiel, like Agamemnon's corslet or Achilles' spear. The scent of the oil reaching earth and heaven; the veil "white as the sun"; the earrings "three-dropped, mulberry- dark": the poem's richest inventory of female adornment.
- 10 *ll. 187-223* The lie to Aphrodite runs on real cosmology: Oceanus "the begetting of the gods" and mother Tethys — an alternative theogony in which the world-river, not Cronos or Zeus, is origin (Sleep repeats it at 246: "the begetting of them all"; ancient readers from Plato and Crates on treated these lines as Homer's cosmological fragment). The *kestos himas* — the "pierced, embroidered band" — carries the poem's finest abstraction-list: "in it is love, in it desire, in it the trysting-talk — persuasion, that steals the wits even of the close-thinkers" (ὀαριστός again — the intimacy-word the poem put on the front line at 13.291; here in its home register). Aristotle quotes the couplet in the *Nicomachean Ethics* (1149b) on the coercive power of desire. Aphrodite's consent-line — "you sleep in the arms of Zeus, and Zeus is highest" (213) — was athetized in antiquity; it is also, dramatically, the girdle working before it is even lent: persuasion stealing the wits of the goddess of persuasion.
- 11 *ll. 225-230* The flight-path: Olympus - Pieria - Emathia - the Thracian snow-mountains - Athos - Lemnos, feet never touching ground. Divine travel in the Iliad is always mapped (cf. 13.20-33): the geography is real and sequential, a northern-Aegean arc drawn at a goddess's speed.
- 12 *ll. 231-262* Sleep, "brother of Death" (the pairing returns with terrible weight at 16.672, carrying Sarpedon home). His refusal recalls the poem's deepest backstory: after Heracles sacked Troy, Hera used Sleep against Zeus and blew the hero to Cos; Zeus woke "hurling gods this way and that through the house," and Sleep survived only by running to Night, "subduer of gods and men" — "he checked himself: he stood in awe of doing what swift Night would hate." The one being before whom Zeus restrains himself is primordial darkness; the theology is older than Olympus, glimpsed once, through a frightened minor god's memory. Note too the escalation of fees: golden throne and footstool (furniture, the standard divine honorarium) refused; a Grace accepted — Sleep bargains like a craftsman who knows his labor's worth.

- 13 *ll. 267-276* The printed Greek lacks line 269 — "Pasithea, for whom you long always, all your days" — the naming of the offered Grace inside Hera's speech; the line stands in only part of the manuscript tradition (an addition in several copies, as the apparatus records), and the numbering here jumps 268 to 270. Nothing is lost but an anticipation: Sleep himself names Pasithea at 276, with the longing-clause intact. This is the third genuine transmission-gap this translation reproduces (9.458-461; 11.543). The oath Sleep demands is the great one: by Styx, one hand on the earth, one on the shining sea, "so that all may be witnesses between us, the gods below with Cronos" — the defeated elder gods, "under Tartarus, who are called the Titans" (279), summoned as notaries: the old world-order exists, in the Iliad, to witness contracts.
- 14 *ll. 283-291* Landfall at Lecton, "and the treetops shook beneath their feet"; then Sleep in the tallest fir on Ida, "in the likeness of the clear-voiced mountain bird the gods call chalkis, and men call kymindis." The double-name motif (Briareus/Aegaeon 1.403, Batieia/Myrine 2.813) — the universe bilingual, and the poet claiming the gods' dictionary — here attached to a real bird (likely a hawk-owl) waiting in a tree to watch a seduction.
- 15 *ll. 292-296* Zeus sees her, "and the moment he saw her, desire wrapped his close mind round, as on the day they first mingled in love, going to the bed again and again behind their dear parents' backs." The marriage's beginning as adolescent secrecy — brother and sister evading Cronos and Rhea — is the poem's one glimpse of the primal domestic scene, and it makes the seduction work: what Hera has staged is his memory of their youth.
- 16 *ll. 313-328* The Leporello-catalogue: seven loves — Ixion's wife (mother of Peirithous), Danaë (Perseus), Europa the daughter of Phoenix (Minos and Rhadamanthys), Semele (Dionysus, "a joy to mortals" — his only Iliadic mention as Zeus's son), Alcmene (Heracles), Demeter, Leto — each with issue noted, ending "no, nor you yourself: none as I love you now." As courtship, an itemized list of adulteries addressed to one's wife is catastrophically tactless; as enchantment- symptom it is exact — the girdle's power made audible as babble. Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized all twelve lines as unseemly; antiquity laughed and kept them; so does the printed text.
- 17 *ll. 330-340* Hera's answer opens with the register's fixed outrage-line ("Most dread son of Cronos, what a word you have spoken!" = 1.552) — deployed now in mock-modesty: what if some god saw us and told? The counter-offer (Hephaestus's chamber with the secret bolt) is a trap avoided by Zeus's own escalation: the golden cloud.
- 18 *ll. 346-353* The hieros gamos: "beneath them the bright earth put out fresh grass, and dewy lotus, and crocus, and hyacinth, thick and soft, that held them up off the ground." Earth flowering under the union of Sky-god and his queen — a fossil of fertility-religion set blooming in the middle of the war- poem; the golden cloud rains glittering dew. Then the plainest possible clause: "So the father slept." The plot of the Iliad from 8.473 onward hangs suspended inside a nap.
- 19 *ll. 354-360* Sleep reports to Poseidon in person — "I have wrapped him in a soft daze" — divine conspiracy with courier service. The alliance of Sleep and the sea-god frees the battle for exactly one Achaean surge, on borrowed time.

- 20 ll. 364-382 Poseidon's tactical speech, with its remarkable order: swap armor by capability — "whatever staunch fighter has a small shield at his shoulder, let him give it to a worse man, and get into a bigger... the good man got into good armor, and gave the worse to the worse." Ancient critics athetized (376-377); soldiers will recognize the first recorded redistribution of kit by fighting value, ordered by a god and executed by three wounded kings.
- 21 ll. 384-387 Poseidon leads with "a terrible thin-edged sword like a lightning-flash — a thing no man may meet in the grim combat: dread holds men back from it." The god's blade is not said to kill anyone: its work is categorical, a boundary (θέμις) — mortals simply may not engage it.
- 22 ll. 389-401 The triple negative simile: not the sea's wave under the North Wind, not fire in the mountain glens, not the wind in the high oaks roars so loud as the two armies' voice. The poem's own sound-engineering: three natural crescendos stacked and overtopped — and all three (wave, fire, wind) are the similes this battle has been using for its charges, now outshouted by the real thing.
- 23 ll. 402-420 The duel of the day: Hector's spear defeated by the crossing-point of two straps — the war of equipment again — and Ajax's answer with one of the ship-props: the stone "set him spinning like a top." Then the great oak simile: struck by the bolt of Zeus, torn out by the roots, "and the terrible smell of sulphur rises off it, and courage fails whoever sees it from close by." The lightning-smell is the most sensorily exact divine detail in the poem — and its theology cuts: Hector, whose whole warrant is Zeus's bolt, falls like a tree struck by it, while Zeus sleeps.
- 24 ll. 433-439 The retreat to "the ford of the fair-flowing river, eddying Xanthus, whom immortal Zeus begot" — the line- pair that will open Book 21, laid down here; the river-god's paternity registered in passing. Hector's revival is clinical concussion: water poured over him, breath recovered, "sitting on his knees he vomited dark blood," relapse, "black night" again. He is out of the poem until 15.239 — and it takes Apollo, on Zeus's woken orders, to put him back.
- 25 ll. 442-448 Satnius, son of Enops and "the blameless naiad nymph" who bore him "as Enops herded by the banks of Satnioeis": a river-bank begetting, a boy named for the river, killed in the mud of a different one. The smallest pastoral obituary in the poem.
- 26 ll. 449-457 Polydamas's vaunt: the spear in Prothoenor's shoulder becomes "a staff... as he walks down into Hades" — death as an old man's stroll, cane provided by the killer. The counselor's wit is colder than the warriors'. The vaunt- chain that follows (458 = 486: "grief came over the Argives / Trojans at his vaunting") is built as strict alternation — grief answering grief, kill for kill, four boasts in sequence: the poem's mechanics of escalation laid bare.
- 27 ll. 463-474 Archelochus, taking the spear meant for Polydamas "for the gods had counseled his destruction": struck at the join of head and neck, "and his head and mouth and nostrils hit the ground long before his shins and knees." Ajax's forensic vaunt — no base man, "a brother of horse- taming Antenor, or a son — the family look sits close upon him" — identifies the corpse by resemblance: kinship legible in a dead face, the poem's grimmest use of family likeness.

- 28 ll. 476-485 Acamas over Promachus: "arrow-braggarts" for the Argives; then the blood-price logic said straight — "so my brother's blood-price (ποινὴ) should not go long unpaid. That is why a man prays for a kinsman left in his halls: to ward off ruin for him." The economy of vengeance (cf. 13.659, where Harpalion's death has no ποινὴ) stated as household prudence: brothers are insurance.
- 29 ll. 489-505 Ilioneus: only son of Hermes-loved, flock-rich Phorbas — the eye put out at its roots, the spear through eye and nape, the head severed and lifted, spear and all, "like a poppy-head" (κώδεια, the seed-capsule). At 8.306-308 a dying boy's head drooped "as a poppy in a garden... heavy with seed and the rains of spring"; here the poppy returns as a thing brandished. Peneleos completes it with the poem's cruelest message home: tell his father and mother "to wail in their halls" — and Promachus's wife will not rejoice either, when the young men sail home. The taunt's real addressees are the two houses where the news will arrive; the Iliad's wars are always fought, at last, in the rooms of the parents and the wives.
- 30 ll. 506-507 After the poppy-head, no answering vaunt: "trembling took the limbs of every one of them, and each man looked about him for escape." The chain of reciprocal boasts (note [26]) ends because one image exceeded the genre. Even this poem's warriors have a limit, and Peneleos found it.
- 31 ll. 508-510 The fixed Muse-invocation (= 2.484, 11.218) for the rout's tally — "who was first of the Achaeans to lift the bloody spoils of men" (ἀνδράγρια, "man-spoils," a word that occurs nowhere else): full epic formality summoned for a plunder-list, as the tide turns on Poseidon's tilt.
- 32 ll. 511-522 The tally: Hyrtius, Phalces, Mermerus, Morys, Hippotion, Prothoon, Periphetes — and Hyperenor, whose death at Menelaus's hands is recalled with strange precision at 17.24-28 (there with an insult-backstory the narrative here lacks; the poem's ledgers do not always reconcile). The last word goes to the lesser Ajax: "there was no one like him for speed of foot in the chase when men broke and ran" — the book's closing epitaph is for a sprinter of the pursuit, the specialist of the broken field: the Deception of Zeus ends with the poem's ugliest hero doing the one thing he does best, to men who can no longer fight back.

Iliad — Book 15

Zeus wakes and foretells the end of the war; Apollo levels the wall; Hector reaches the ships and calls for fire.

- But when in their flight they had crossed the stakes and the ditch,
and many were broken under Danaan hands,
they halted and held their ground beside the chariots,
green with fear, panic-driven. And Zeus woke
- 5 on the peaks of Ida beside Hera of the golden throne,
and started up, and stood, and saw Trojans and Achaeans —
the ones being driven, the others driving them on
from behind, the Argives, and among them lord Poseidon;
and he saw Hector lying on the plain, his companions
- 10 sitting around him, and he laboring for breath, his wits astray,
vomiting blood — for not the feeblest of the Achaeans had hit him.¹
Seeing him, the father of men and gods felt pity,
and glaring darkly, terribly, he spoke his word to Hera:
"Past all handling, Hera — this evil craft, this trick of yours
- 15 has stopped brilliant Hector from the fight, and routed his army.
I wonder whether you may not be the first to reap the fruit
of your grievous plot-weaving, when I flog you with lashes.
Do you not remember hanging from on high, when from your feet²
I slung two anvils, and threw about your wrists a band
- 20 of gold, unbreakable? In the clear air and the clouds
you hung; and the gods raged up and down high Olympus
but could not come and free you: whomever I caught
I seized and hurled from the threshold, till he struck
the earth with little life in him. Even so my heart would not
- 25 let go its relentless pain for godlike Heracles,
whom you, suborning the storm-blasts with the North Wind's help,
sent driving over the barren sea, plotting evils,
and carried away at last to well-peopled Cos.
I rescued him from there, and brought him back again
- 30 to horse-pasturing Argos, after all his labors.
I remind you of this so you will drop your deceits — so you will see

- whether the love-making helps you, and the bed
 you came from among the gods and lay in, and tricked me."
 So he spoke; and ox-eyed lady Hera shuddered,
 35 and speaking winged words she addressed him:
 "Let Earth be my witness now, and wide Heaven above,³
 and the down-flowing water of Styx — the greatest oath
 and the most terrible for the blessed gods —
 and your own sacred head, and the bed of the two of us,
 40 our bridal bed — a thing I would never swear by falsely:
 it is not by any will of mine that Poseidon the earth-shaker
 harms the Trojans and Hector and gives help to the others.
 It is his own heart, I suppose, that drives and commands him:
 he saw the Achaeans worn down at the ships and pitied them.
 45 Why — I would as soon give him my counsel
 to walk the road you lead us, lord of the dark cloud."
 So she spoke; and the father of men and gods smiled,
 and answering her he spoke winged words:
 "If from now on, then, ox-eyed lady Hera,
 50 you would sit among the immortals thinking with my mind,
 Poseidon, however much his will runs otherwise,
 would soon enough bend his thought to your heart and mine.
 But if you are speaking truly now, and without evasion,
 go to the tribes of the gods, and call for me
 55 Iris to come here, and Apollo famed for the bow:
 she to go to the army of bronze-shirted Achaeans⁴
 and tell lord Poseidon to leave the war
 and come to his own house; and Phoebus Apollo
 to rouse Hector into the fighting and breathe fury into him
 60 again, and make him forget the pains that now
 wear down his wits; and to turn the Achaeans back
 again, driving strengthless panic into them,
 till in their flight they fall among the many-benched ships
 of Achilles, Peleus' son. And he will send out his companion
 65 Patroclus; and glorious Hector will kill him with the spear
 before Ilion, after he has cut down many strong young men —
 and among them my own son, brilliant Sarpedon.
 And in anger for him brilliant Achilles will kill Hector.

- From that hour on I will make the tide run back
70 from the ships, steadily, without pause, until the Achaeans
take steep Ilion through the counsels of Athena.
Before that I do not cease my anger, and no other
immortal will I allow to defend the Danaans here,
not before the desire of Peleus' son is accomplished
75 as I promised him at the first, and bowed my head to it,
on the day the goddess Thetis clasped my knees,
begging me to honor Achilles, sacker of cities."
So he spoke, and the goddess white-armed Hera did not disobey,
and went from the mountains of Ida to high Olympus.
80 As when the mind of a man darts, who has traveled⁵
over much country, and thinks in his quick wits
"would I were here, or there," and wishes himself many places,
so swiftly, straining, flew the lady Hera;
and she came to steep Olympus, and found the immortal gods
85 assembled in the house of Zeus. And when they saw her
they all sprang up and pledged her with their cups.
The others she let be; but from fair-cheeked Themis
she took the cup, for Themis came running first to meet her,
and speaking winged words addressed her:
90 "Hera, why have you come? You look like one struck senseless.
Cronos's son has frightened you badly — your own husband."
Then answered her the goddess white-armed Hera:
"Do not ask me that, goddess Themis. You yourself know
what kind of heart is his — how arrogant, how unbending.
95 Lead the gods to the fair-shared feast in the house,
and you will hear with all the immortals together
what evil works Zeus is announcing. I do not think
every heart will be pleased alike, mortal or god,
however cheerfully some may be feasting still."
100 So the lady Hera spoke, and took her seat;
and the gods were troubled through the house of Zeus. And she
laughed
with her lips; but the forehead above her dark brows
did not warm; and she spoke among them all, vexed:⁶
"Fools — who rage against Zeus with no more sense than children!

- 105 Do we still mean to march up close and stop him,
by word or by force? He sits apart and takes no thought,
no notice; for he says that among the immortal gods
in power and might he is beyond dispute the first.
So — swallow whatever evil he sends each one of you.
- 110 Already now, I think, calamity is built for Ares:
his son has perished in the fighting — the dearest of men to him —
Ascalaphus, whom massive Ares calls his own."
So she spoke; and Ares struck his sturdy thighs
with his flat hands, and cried out in grief:
- 115 "Do not blame me now, you who keep the halls of Olympus,⁷
if I go down to the ships of the Achaeans to avenge
the killing of my son — even if my fate is to be struck
by Zeus's bolt, and lie with the corpses in the blood and the dust."
So he spoke, and ordered Terror and Panic to yoke
- 120 his horses; and he himself got into his blazing armor.
And then a greater and more grievous anger and wrath
would have been wrought by Zeus against the immortals,
had not Athena, in terror for all the gods,
sprung through the doorway, leaving the chair where she sat.
- 125 She tore the helmet from his head, the shield from his shoulders,
and took the bronze spear out of his heavy hand
and set it up; and she lashed rushing Ares with words:
"Madman! Wits gone — you are destroyed! So you do have ears
for hearing — but your mind is perished, and your shame.
- 130 Do you not hear what the goddess white-armed Hera says,
come straight now from Olympian Zeus?
Or do you want to fill your own cup of evils and come back
to Olympus by compulsion, grieving as you go,
and plant a great calamity for all the rest of us?
- 135 For he will leave the high-hearted Trojans and the Achaeans
on the instant, and come to Olympus to set us tumbling,
and he will seize us each in turn, guilty or not.
So drop your anger now for your son. Better men
than he by strength of hands have been killed before this,
- 140 or will be killed hereafter. It is a hard thing
to rescue the line and offspring of every man."

- So speaking she seated rushing Ares on his chair.
 And Hera called Apollo outside the house,
 and Iris, who runs messages for the immortal gods,
 145 and speaking winged words she addressed them:
 "Zeus commands you both to come to Ida with all speed;
 and when you have come, and looked on the face of Zeus,
 do whatever he urges and commands."
 So speaking the lady Hera went back in
 150 and sat on her chair; and the two sprang up and flew.
 They came to Ida of the many springs, mother of wild things,
 and found the wide-seeing son of Cronos seated on Gargaron
 peak; and a fragrant cloud was wreathed about him.
 The two of them came before Zeus the cloud-gatherer
 155 and stood; and seeing them his heart was not angered,
 because they had obeyed his dear wife's words so quickly.
 To Iris first he spoke winged words:
 "Up, go, swift Iris; to lord Poseidon
 carry all this word, and be no false messenger.
 160 Command him to leave the battle and the war
 and go to the tribes of the gods, or into the bright sea.
 And if he will not obey my words, but makes light of them,
 let him consider then in his mind and heart
 whether, strong as he is, he can dare to stand my coming —
 165 since I say my strength is far greater than his,
 and my birth is elder; yet his heart does not shrink
 from calling himself my equal — whom the others dread."
 So he spoke, and wind-footed swift Iris did not disobey,
 and went down from the mountains of Ida to holy Ilion.
 170 As when out of the clouds the snow flies, or the hail,
 cold under the blast of the sky-born North Wind,
 so swiftly, straining, flew swift Iris,
 and standing close she spoke to the famed earth-shaker:
 "A message for you, holder of the earth, blue-maned one:
 175 I have come here carrying it from aegis-bearing Zeus.
 He commands you to leave the battle and the war
 and go to the tribes of the gods, or into the bright sea.
 And if you will not obey his words, but make light of them,

- he threatens to come here himself and fight you
 180 strength against strength; and he warns you to keep out
 from under his hands, since he says his strength is far greater
 than yours, and his birth is elder; yet your heart does not shrink
 from calling yourself his equal — whom the others dread."
 Then, deeply angered, the famed earth-shaker answered her:
 185 "Shame on him! Great as he is, this is arrogance —⁸
 to hold me back by force, against my will, who am his equal in honor.
 Three brothers are we, whom Rhea bore to Cronos:
 Zeus, and I, and Hades third, who is king of those below.
 All was divided three ways; each got his share of honor:
 190 I drew the grey sea to live in forever
 when the lots were shaken; and Hades drew the misty dark,
 and Zeus drew the wide heaven, in the clear air and the clouds;
 but the earth is common to all three still, and high Olympus.
 So I will not walk by the mind of Zeus. Let him stay
 195 quiet in his third portion, strong as he is;
 and let him not try to frighten me with his hands as though I were
 some coward. Better he keep his blustering words
 to scold the daughters and the sons he fathered himself,
 who will have to listen to whatever he commands."
 200 Then answered him wind-footed swift Iris:
 "Is this really the word, holder of the earth, blue-maned one,
 that I am to carry to Zeus — this hard, unbending word?
 Or will you turn a little? The hearts of the great can turn.⁹
 You know how the Erinyes always side with the elder-born."
 205 Then Poseidon the earth-shaker answered her:
 "Iris, goddess — that word of yours was rightly spoken:
 it is a fine thing when a messenger knows what is fitting.
 But this comes as bitter grief to my heart and spirit —
 when he chooses to rail with angry words at one
 210 allotted an equal share, doomed to the same portion.
 Still — for now I will yield, indignant though I am.
 But I will tell you this, and it is a threat from my heart:¹⁰
 if in spite of me, and Athena driver of the spoil,
 and Hera, and Hermes, and lord Hephaestus,
 215 he spares steep Ilion — if he refuses

- to sack it and to hand great power to the Argives —
 let him know this: between us two the anger will have no healing."
 So speaking the earth-shaker left the Achaean army
 and went into the sea and sank; and the Achaean heroes missed him.
- 220 Then Zeus the cloud-gatherer spoke to Apollo:
 "Go now, dear Phoebus, to Hector of the bronze helmet.
 For by this time the holder of the earth, the earth-shaker,
 has gone into the bright sea, dodging our sheer anger —
 otherwise even the others would have heard of our fight,
 225 the gods who are down below, gathered around Cronos.
 But this is far better, for me and for himself:
 that he yielded, for all his indignation, before my hands —
 since not without sweat would the business have been settled.
 Now: take up in your hands the tasseled aegis¹¹
- 230 and shake it hard over the Achaean heroes, to rout them.
 And for yourself, far-striker: let glorious Hector be your care.
 Wake the great fury in him, until the Achaeans
 come in their flight to the ships and the Hellespont.
 From there I myself will devise the word and the work
 235 by which the Achaeans may catch their breath again from toil."
 So he spoke, and Apollo did not disobey his father,
 but went down from the mountains of Ida like a hawk,
 the swift dove-killer, fastest of flying things.
 He found the son of war-minded Priam, brilliant Hector,
 240 sitting up — no longer lying down: he had just gathered his spirit,
 knowing the companions around him; and the gasping and the sweat
 had ceased, for the mind of aegis-bearing Zeus was waking him.
 And standing close, the worker-from-afar, Apollo, spoke to him:
 "Hector, son of Priam — why do you sit apart from the others,
 245 with so little strength in you? Has some trouble found you?"
 And with the little strength he had, Hector of the flashing helmet
 answered:¹²
 "Which of the gods are you, kindest one, who ask me face to face?
 Have you not heard? By the sterns of the Achaean ships,
 as I killed his companions, Ajax good at the war-cry
 250 struck me on the chest with a stone, and stopped my rushing courage.
 Indeed I thought that on this day I would look on the dead

and the house of Hades: I was breathing out my own dear life."
 Then lord Apollo the worker-from-afar answered him:
 "Take heart: such a helper has the son of Cronos
 255 sent down from Ida to stand beside you and defend you —
 Phoebus Apollo of the golden sword: I who before now
 have guarded you, yourself and your steep citadel alike.
 Up now: command your many charioteers
 to drive their swift horses at the hollow ships;
 260 and I will go before them and smooth the whole road
 for the horses, and turn the Achaeon heroes back."
 So speaking he breathed great fury into the shepherd of the people.
 As when a stalled horse, corn-fed at the manger,¹³
 breaks his tether and gallops drumming across the plain,
 265 used to bathing in the fair-flowing river,
 glorying: he holds his head high, and the mane
 streams along his shoulders; sure of his own splendor,
 his knees carry him lightly to the haunts and pastures of horses:
 so Hector plied his feet and knees, quick and light,
 270 urging on his horsemen, now he had heard the god's voice.
 And the others — as when dogs and countrymen
 chase an antlered stag or a wild goat,
 and a sheer rock-face or a shadowy wood
 saves it, since it was not their portion to catch it,
 275 and then, drawn by their clamor, a bearded lion
 shows himself in the way, and turns them all back for all their fury:
 so for a while the Danaans followed close, in a mass,
 stabbing with swords and double-curved spears;
 but when they saw Hector ranging down the ranks of men,
 280 they were afraid, and every man's heart dropped to his feet.
 Then Thoas spoke among them, Andraemon's son,¹⁴
 far the best of the Aetolians — skilled with the javelin,
 brave in the standing fight; and in assembly few Achaeans
 could beat him, when the young men contended in debate.
 285 With good will toward them he spoke and addressed them:
 "Shame! — a great marvel is this I see with my eyes:
 how he has risen again, escaped the death-spirits —
 Hector! The heart in each of us hoped hard enough

- that he had died under the hands of Ajax, Telamon's son.
- 290 But some one of the gods has rescued and saved him again —
Hector, who has unstrung the knees of many Danaans,
as he will now too, I think: for not without loud-thundering Zeus
does he stand there in the front rank, blazing like this.
Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:
- 295 Let us order the multitude back to the ships;
and we ourselves, all who claim to be best in the army,
let us stand, and see if we can blunt him first, meeting him
with spears held high. For all his fury, I think
his heart will fear to sink into the crowd of the Danaans."
- 300 So he spoke; and they heard him well, and obeyed.
Those around Ajax and lord Idomeneus,
and Teucer, and Meriones, and Meges the equal of Ares,
called up the best men and formed for battle,
facing Hector and the Trojans; and behind them
- 305 the multitude went back to the ships of the Achaeans.
The Trojans struck first, massed; Hector led them
with long strides; and in front of him went Phoebus Apollo,
his shoulders wrapped in cloud, holding the rushing aegis,
terrible, shag-fringed, dazzling — which the smith
- 310 Hephaestus gave to Zeus, to carry for the routing of men;¹⁵
holding this in his hands he led the army.
And the Argives stood to meet them, close-massed, and the war-cry
rose shrill from both sides; from the bowstrings the arrows
leapt; and many spears from daring hands
- 315 fixed themselves in the flesh of quick young fighters,
and many midway, before they could reach the white flesh,
stood planted in the earth, still hungry to glut themselves on it.
So long as Phoebus Apollo held the aegis unmoving,
so long the missiles of both sides struck home, and the people fell;
- 320 but when he looked the swift-colted Danaans full in the face
and shook it, and himself gave a great shout, then the heart
in their chests he bewitched, and they forgot their rushing courage.
And as two wild beasts stampede a herd of cattle
or a great flock of sheep in the milking-dark of night,
- 325 coming suddenly, when the herdsman is not by,

- so the Achaeans panicked, strengthless: for Apollo drove
the panic into them, and handed glory to the Trojans and Hector.
Then man killed man, as the battle scattered.
Hector cut down Stichius and Arcesilaus,¹⁶
- 330 the one a leader of the bronze-shirted Boeotians,
the other the trusted companion of great-hearted Menestheus;
and Aeneas stripped the life from Medon and Iasus.
Now the one — Medon — was a bastard son of godlike Oileus
and brother of Ajax; but he lived in Phylace,
- 335 far from his own fatherland, having killed a man,
a kinsman of his stepmother Eriopis, wife of Oïleus;
and Iasus was set a captain of the Athenians,
and was called the son of Sphelus, Boucolus's son.
And Polydamas killed Mecisteus, and Polites Echius,
- 340 in the first onset, and brilliant Agenor killed Clonius;
and Paris hit Deiochus at the base of the shoulder, from behind,
as he fled through the front-fighters, and drove the bronze clean
through.
- While they were stripping the armor from these, the Achaeans,
tangled in the dug ditch and the stakes,
- 345 were fleeing this way and that, and diving behind the wall by necessity.
And Hector called to the Trojans with a great shout:
"Straight for the ships — and leave the bloody spoils!"¹⁷
Whomever I see hanging back, away from the ships,
I will plan his death on the spot; and no brothers of his,
- 350 no sisters, will give his dead body its portion of fire:
the dogs will drag him before our city."
So speaking, with a full swing of the whip he drove his horses on,
calling to the Trojans down the ranks; and all of them with him,
shouting as one, steered the chariot-pulling horses
- 355 with a prodigious roar. And in front of them Phoebus Apollo,
kicking down the banks of the deep ditch with his feet,
easily, tumbled them into the middle, and bridged a causeway
long and wide — about as wide as a spear-cast
carries, when a man is trying his strength.
- 360 Down this they poured, rank after rank, and before them Apollo
held the aegis beyond all price; and he kicked down the wall

of the Achaeans — easily — as when a boy by the sea¹⁸
 heaps sand into shapes in his childish play,
 and then, still playing, scatters them again with his feet and hands:
 365 so you, archer Phoebus, poured into ruin the long
 labor and misery of the Argives, and drove the panic through them.
 So they halted and held their ground beside the ships,
 calling to one another, and lifting their hands
 to all the gods, each man prayed aloud;
 370 and Nestor above all, the Gerenian, warden of the Achaeans,
 prayed, stretching his arms toward the starry heaven:
 "Father Zeus — if ever anyone in wheat-rich Argos,¹⁹
 burning to you the fat thighs of ox or sheep,
 prayed for his homecoming, and you promised it with a nod:
 375 remember it, Olympian; ward off the pitiless day,
 and do not let the Achaeans be broken so by the Trojans."
 So he spoke in prayer; and Zeus the counselor thundered loud,
 hearing the prayers of the old man, Neleus' son.
 But the Trojans, when they heard the thunder of aegis-bearing Zeus,
 380 leapt at the Argives all the harder, and remembered their war-craft.
 As a great wave of the wide-wayed sea²⁰
 comes down over a ship's bulwarks, when the strength of the wind
 drives it high — for that above all makes the waves grow:
 so the Trojans with a great cry came down over the wall,
 385 and driving their horses in they fought at the sterns,
 hand to hand with double-curved spears — they from their chariots,
 and the Achaeans high up, from the decks of their black ships,
 with the long pikes that lay aboard for sea-fighting,
 jointed and socketed, their heads clothed in bronze.
 390 Now Patroclus, so long as the Achaeans and Trojans
 fought for the wall, outside the swift ships,
 sat in the hut of gracious Eurypylus
 and delighted him with talk, and on his grievous wound
 sprinkled the remedies against the black pains.
 395 But when he saw the Trojans storming over the wall,
 and the Danaans' shouting and panic broke out,
 he groaned aloud, and struck both his thighs
 with his flat hands, and cried out in grief:

- "Eurypylus — I can stay with you here no longer,"²¹
 400 much as you need me: a great struggle has risen.
 Let your aide look after you now; I myself
 will hurry to Achilles, to rouse him to fight.
 Who knows whether, with a god's help, I might stir his heart
 by my persuading? The persuasion of a companion is a good thing."
 405 And even as he spoke his feet were carrying him. Meanwhile the
 Achaeans
 stood fast against the Trojan advance, yet could not
 push them from the ships, though they were fewer;
 nor could the Trojans ever break the Danaans' lines
 and force their way in among the huts and the ships.
 410 But as a chalk-line trues a ship-timber straight²²
 in the hands of a skilled carpenter, who knows
 his whole craft well by the promptings of Athena,
 so their battle and their war were drawn even and taut.
 And others fought their fight at other ships,
 415 but Hector made straight for glorious Ajax.
 The two of them labored over a single ship, and neither
 could win: Hector could not drive Ajax off and fire the ship,
 nor Ajax push Hector back — since a god had brought him.
 Then shining Ajax hit Caletor, Clytius's son,²³
 420 with the spear in the chest as he carried fire toward the ship:
 he fell with a thud, and the brand dropped from his hand.
 And Hector, when he saw with his own eyes his cousin
 fallen in the dust before the black ship,
 called to the Trojans and Lycians with a great shout:
 425 "Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians who fight at close quarters —
 do not give back from the battle in this narrow place:
 save the son of Clytius, or the Achaeans will strip
 his armor, fallen where the ships stand gathered."
 So speaking he cast at Ajax with his shining spear.
 430 Him he missed; but Lycophron, Mastor's son,
 Ajax's henchman from Cythera, who lived with him —
 for he had killed a man in most holy Cythera —
 him he struck on the head above the ear with the sharp bronze
 as he stood beside Ajax; and backward in the dust

- 435 he dropped from the ship's stern to the ground, and his limbs were
unstrung.
And Ajax shuddered, and spoke to his brother:
"Teucer, old friend — our trusted companion is killed,
Mastor's son, the man from Cythera we honored
in our halls like our own dear parents.
- 440 Great-hearted Hector has killed him. Where now are your arrows
of quick death, and the bow that Phoebus Apollo gave you?"
So he spoke; and Teucer understood, and came running to stand
beside him, his back-bent bow in his hand
and the arrow-holding quiver; and fast he loosed his shafts at the
Trojans.
- 445 And he hit Cleitus, the shining son of Peisenor,
companion of Polydamas, Panthous's illustrious son,
with the reins in his hands, laboring with his horses;
for he held them where the most battle-lines were driven
in confusion, doing a favor to Hector and the Trojans. But swiftly
- 450 the evil came on him that no one could hold off, wish it as they might:
for the arrow of many groans dropped into the back of his neck,
and he crashed from the chariot, and the horses shied back,
rattling the empty car. And lord Polydamas saw it
at once, and was first to come and stand at the horses' heads.
- 455 He gave them to Astynous, Protiaon's son,
with many orders to hold them close and keep them
in his eye; and himself went back and mixed with the front-fighters.
And Teucer was drawing another arrow, for Hector
of the bronze helmet — and would have stopped the battle
- 460 at the ships of the Achaeans, had he hit him mid-triumph
and torn out his life. But he did not slip the close mind of Zeus,
who was guarding Hector, and robbed Teucer, Telamon's son, of his
triumph:²⁴
the well-twisted string on the blameless bow —
Zeus broke it as he drew; and the bronze-weighted arrow
- 465 swerved wide and away, and the bow dropped from his hand.
And Teucer shuddered, and spoke to his brother:
"Look — how utterly some power is shearing off the plans
of our fighting! It has struck the bow from my hand

- and snapped the fresh-twisted string I bound on it
 470 this very morning, to bear the arrows springing thick and fast."
 Then great Telamonian Ajax answered him:
 "Old friend — then let the bow and the showering arrows
 lie, since a god has spited the Danaans and wrecked them.
 Take a long spear in your hands and a shield on your shoulder
 475 and fight the Trojans yourself, and drive on the rest of the army.
 If they take us, at least let it cost them labor —
 the well-benched ships. Let us remember our war-craft."
 So he spoke; and Teucer set the bow away in the huts,
 and about his shoulders he slung a shield of four hides,
 480 and on his powerful head he set a well-made helmet,
 horsehair-crested; the plume nodded terribly above it;
 and he took up a stout spear, edged with sharp bronze,
 and set off at a run, and quickly stood by Ajax.
 And Hector, when he saw Teucer's shots crippled,
 485 called to the Trojans and Lycians with a great shout:
 "Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians who fight at close quarters —
 be men, my friends; remember your rushing courage
 here along the hollow ships: for I have seen with my own eyes
 the shots of their best man crippled by Zeus.
 490 Easily known among men is the strength of Zeus —²⁵
 both those to whom he hands the higher glory
 and those he wears down and will not defend:
 so now he wears down the Argives' fury, and helps us.
 Fight at the ships in one mass! And whichever of you,
 495 hit from afar or stabbed close, meets his death and his doom —
 let him die. It is no dishonor for him to die
 defending his fatherland: his wife is safe after him, and his children,
 his house and his portion of land unharmed, if the Achaeans
 go away in their ships to their dear fatherland."
 500 So speaking he stirred the fury and the heart of every man.
 And Ajax on the other side called to his companions:
 "Shame, Argives! Now it is certain: either we perish²⁶
 or we are saved, and beat the ruin back from the ships.
 Do you hope, if Hector of the flashing helmet takes the ships,
 505 that each of you will walk home on foot to his fatherland?

- Do you not hear him driving his whole army —
Hector, who is raging now to burn the ships?
It is not to a dance he is inviting them: he invites them to fight.
For us there is no plan, no better thought than this:
- 510 to bring our hands and fury against them, body to body.
Better once for all to seize our death or our life
than be squeezed slowly dry in the dread combat,
here by the ships, uselessly, under worse men than ourselves."
So speaking he stirred the fury and the heart of every man.
- 515 Then Hector cut down Schedius, Perimedes' son,
a captain of the Phocians; and Ajax cut down Laodamas,
a leader of the foot-soldiers, Antenor's shining son;
and Polydamas stripped the life from Otus of Cyllene,
companion of Phyleus' son, a captain of the great-hearted Epeians.
- 520 Meges saw it and sprang at him; but Polydamas swerved
from under, and Meges missed him — for Apollo
would not let Panthous's son be broken among the front-fighters —
but he stabbed Croesmus full in the chest with the spear:
he fell with a thud, and Meges set to stripping the armor from his
shoulders.
- 525 But meanwhile Dolops sprang on him, a master of the spear,
Lampus's son — the strongest son that Lampus fathered,
Laomedon's own son, well skilled in rushing courage —
who stabbed the middle of Phyleus' son's shield with his spear²⁷
at close range; but the thick corslet saved him,
- 530 the corslet he wore, close-fitted with its plates: the one Phyleus
brought home once out of Ephyra, from the river Selleïs.
A guest-friend gave it to him — Euphetes, lord of men —
to carry into war, a defense against enemy men;
and now it kept destruction from the flesh of his son.
- 535 Then Meges stabbed with his sharp-pointed spear at the topmost
ridge of Dolops's bronze helmet, thick with horsehair,
and sheared the horsehair plume clean off; and the whole of it
fell in the dust, fresh-shining with its scarlet dye.
While Meges held his ground and fought him, still hoping for victory,
- 540 warlike Menelaus came to his rescue:
he took his stand aside with his spear, unseen, and hit his shoulder

from behind; and the point, raging, drove through his chest
 and out, straining onward; and he crumpled down on his face.
 The two of them moved in to strip the bronze armor
 545 from his shoulders; but Hector called on his kinsmen,
 all of them; and first he rebuked Hicetaon's son,
 strong Melanippus. He had herded his shambling cattle²⁸
 in Percote a while, with the enemy far away;
 but when the double-ended ships of the Danaans came,
 550 he came back to Ilion, and stood out among the Trojans,
 and lived with Priam, who honored him like his own children.
 Him Hector rebuked, and spoke a word, and named him:
 "Is this how we slacken, Melanippus? Is your own heart
 not turned at all — for your cousin killed?
 555 Do you not see how they swarm over Dolops's armor?
 Follow me. No longer can we stand off and fight
 the Argives at a distance: now we kill them, or they pull down
 steep Ilion from its height and cut her citizens down."
 So speaking he led the way, and the other followed, a man like a god.
 560 And great Telamonian Ajax roused the Argives:
 "Friends — be men! Set shame in your hearts,
 and feel shame before each other in the strong encounters.
 Where men feel shame, more are saved than slain;²⁹
 where they run, no fame rises, and no strength."
 565 So he spoke; and they themselves were furious to beat the enemy off,
 and took his word to heart, and fenced the ships
 in a hedge of bronze; and Zeus drove the Trojans on against them.
 And Menelaus, good at the war-cry, urged Antilochus:
 "Antilochus — no other Achaean is younger than you,
 570 none faster on his feet or braver in the fighting:
 might you not spring out and hit some man of the Trojans?"
 So speaking he hurried back; but he had stirred him,
 and out from the front-fighters he sprang, and cast his shining spear,
 glancing all round him; and the Trojans shrank away
 575 from the man as he threw. And his shot did not go in vain:
 Hicetaon's high-hearted son, Melanippus,
 coming into the battle, he hit in the chest by the nipple:
 he fell with a thud, and darkness covered his eyes.

And Antilochus sprang on him as a hound springs on a fawn
 580 that is hit — the hunter's shot caught it leaping
 out of its bed, and unstrung its limbs beneath it:
 so on you, Melanippus, staunch Antilochus sprang,
 to strip your armor. But he was not unseen by brilliant Hector,
 who came running through the combat to face him;
 585 and Antilochus did not stand him, quick fighter though he was,
 but fled, like a wild beast that has done some mischief —³⁰
 that has killed a dog, or a herdsman with his cattle,
 and runs before the crowd of men can gather:
 so Nestor's son ran; and after him the Trojans and Hector
 590 with a prodigious roar poured their missiles of groaning;
 and he turned and stood, when he reached the band of his companions.
 And now the Trojans, like flesh-eating lions,
 stormed at the ships, accomplishing the commands of Zeus,
 who woke the great fury in them always, and bewitched the heart
 595 of the Argives, and stole their triumph, and drove the others on.
 For his heart willed the glory for Hector,
 Priam's son, so he might hurl on the beaked ships
 the prodigious, unwearying fire, and bring to pass
 the whole extraordinary prayer of Thetis. For Zeus the counselor
 600 waited for one thing: to see with his own eyes
 the flare of a single burning ship. From that moment on
 he would make the Trojans' tide run back
 from the ships, and hand the glory to the Danaans.
 With this in mind he woke against the hollow ships
 605 Hector, Priam's son — already burning hot himself.
 He raged like Ares the spear-shaker, or as annihilating fire
 rages in the mountains, in the thickets of a deep wood;
 the foam stood at his mouth, and his two eyes
 blazed under his grim brows, and around his temples the helmet
 610 shook terribly as Hector fought. For out of the upper air
 Zeus himself was his defender — Zeus who honored
 and glorified him, one man among many; for he was to be³¹
 short-lived: already Pallas Athena was speeding
 his death-day on, under the strength of Peleus' son.
 615 And he strained to break the ranks of men, probing them

wherever he saw the thickest crowd and the best armor;
 but he could not break them for all his blazing:
 they held, locked like a tower — like a rock-face,
 sheer and huge, hard by the grey salt water,
 620 that abides the quick paths of the shrill winds
 and the swollen waves belching against it:
 so the Danaans stood the Trojans, steady, and did not run.
 But he, glittering with fire on every side, leapt on the mass,
 and fell on them as a wave falls on a swift ship,
 625 wind-fed, ravening, out of the clouds: and the whole ship
 is buried in spray, and the terrible blast of the wind
 roars in the sail, and the sailors tremble at heart,
 terrified: for they are carried only just out from under death:
 so the heart was torn in the chest of every Achaean.
 630 And he came on like a murderous lion on cattle³²
 grazing in their thousands in the water-meadow of a great marsh,
 and among them a herdsman not yet sure of his skill
 to fight a beast off from the carcass of a twist-horned cow:
 he keeps pace always with the first ranks or the last,
 635 but the lion leaps on the middle and devours a cow,
 and all the rest stampede: so then the Achaeans
 fled unearthly before Hector and father Zeus,
 all of them — though he killed one man only: Periphetes of Mycenae,
 the dear son of Copreus, who used to carry the messages
 640 of king Eurystheus to the might of Heracles.
 Of that far worse father was born a better son
 in every virtue — in speed of foot and in fighting,
 and in mind among the first of the Mycenaeans;
 and it was he, then, who handed Hector the higher glory.
 645 For turning back, he tripped against the rim of his shield —
 the shield he carried himself, reaching his feet, a tower against javelins;
 tangled in it he tumbled backward, and the helmet
 clanged terribly about his temples as he fell.
 And Hector saw it sharply, and ran to stand beside him,
 650 and fixed the spear in his chest, and killed him close by
 his own dear companions; and they could not help him, though
 grieving:

they were themselves too much afraid of brilliant Hector.
Now they had come inside the ships, and around them stood
the ends of the ships drawn up in the first line; and the Trojans poured
in.

- 655 And the Argives gave back from the first line of ships
by necessity, but held their ground right there among the huts,
massed together, not scattering through the camp: shame held them,
and fear; and they called to one another without ceasing.
And Nestor above all, the Gerenian, warden of the Achaeans,
660 begged each man by his parents, clasping their knees with his words:
"Friends — be men! Set in your hearts the shame³³
of what other men will say; and remember, each of you,
your children and your wives, your property and your parents —
you whose parents live, and you whose parents are dead:
665 for their sake, absent though they are, I clasp your knees here:
stand strong — and do not turn yourselves to panic."
So speaking he stirred the fury and the heart of every man.
And from their eyes Athena thrust away the prodigious
cloud of mist; and light came hard and clear on both sides,
670 toward the ships and toward the leveling war alike.
And they made out Hector, good at the war-cry, and his companions,
both those who stood behind and were not fighting
and those who fought the battle along the swift ships.
Nor did it please the heart of great-hearted Ajax any longer
675 to stand where the other sons of the Achaeans stood back:
he went striding along the decks of the ships,
wielding in his hands a great jointed pike for sea-fighting,
twenty-two cubits long, socketed with rings.
And as a man well skilled in trick-riding,³⁴
680 who has yoked together four horses picked from many
and comes sweeping in from the plain toward the great city
along the public road — and many marvel at him,
men and women both — while he, steady, sure, and always
leaping, changes from horse to horse as they fly along:
685 so Ajax went striding deck to deck across the swift ships
with long steps, and his voice went up to the very sky
as with terrible shouts, always, he called on the Danaans

to defend the ships and the huts. Nor did Hector
 stay back in the crowd of close-armored Trojans:
 690 but as a fiery eagle drops on a nation of winged birds
 feeding by a river's edge —
 geese, or cranes, or long-necked swans —
 so Hector went straight at a dark-prowed ship,
 charging it head-on; and from behind Zeus thrust him
 695 onward with his very great hand, and drove the army with him.
 And again the fighting sharpened by the ships.
 You would say they met each other in the war unworn
 and unbroken, so furiously they fought;
 and this was the thinking of the fighters: the Achaeans
 700 said they would not escape the evil, but must perish;
 and the heart in every Trojan's chest was hoping
 to fire the ships and cut down the Achaean heroes.
 With these thoughts they stood against each other;
 and Hector laid his hand on the stern of a seagoing ship —³⁵
 705 a fair ship, quick on the salt water, that had carried Protesilaus
 to Troy, and never carried him home again to his fatherland.
 Around that ship Achaeans and Trojans
 cut each other down hand to hand; no longer at a distance
 did they stand the volleys of arrows and of javelins,
 710 but standing close, one heart in all of them,
 they fought with sharpened axes and with hatchets
 and with great swords and double-curved spears;
 and many fine blades, dark-bound at the hilt,
 fell to the ground, some from the hands, some from the shoulders
 715 of the fighting men; and the black earth ran blood.
 And Hector, once he had seized the stern-horn, would not let go:
 gripping it in his hands, he called to the Trojans:
 "Bring fire! And all together raise the war-cry!
 Now Zeus has given us a day worth all the rest:
 720 to take the ships — the ships that came here against the gods' will
 and made us so much misery — through the cowardice of the elders,
 who, when I wanted to fight at the ships' sterns,
 held me back myself, and kept the army in.
 But if wide-seeing Zeus was damaging our wits then,

- 725 now he himself is driving and commanding us."
 So he spoke; and they leapt at the Argives all the harder,
 and Ajax could hold no longer: the missiles pressed him too hard.
 He gave back a little, thinking now to die,
 onto the seven-foot bridge-plank, and left the deck of the balanced
 ship.
- 730 There he stood watchful; and always with his spear
 he beat the Trojans off the ships — whoever carried the unwearying
 fire —
 and always with terrible shouts he called on the Danaans:
 "Friends, Danaan heroes, squires of Ares —³⁶
 be men, my friends; remember your rushing courage.
- 735 Do we imagine there are allies at our backs?
 Some stronger wall, to ward the ruin off our men?
 There is no city near us fitted with towers
 where we might make defense, and a people to turn the scale.
 No: we sit in the plain of the close-armored Trojans,
- 740 pinned against the sea, far from our fatherland.
 Our light of safety is in our hands — not in any gentleness of war."
 He spoke, and pressed on furious with his sharp-pointed spear.
 And whoever of the Trojans came driving at the hollow ships
 with blazing fire, to please Hector at his urging,
- 745 Ajax stood waiting and stabbed him with the long spear:
 twelve men he wounded close-in before the ships.

NOTES TO BOOK 15

- 1 *ll. 4-11* Zeus wakes to the whole tableau at once: the rout, Poseidon among the Argives, and Hector "laboring for breath, his wits astray, vomiting blood — for not the feeblest of the Achaeans had hit him." The litotes is the poem's dry salute to Ajax; the concussion is continuous from 14.433-439. What wakes is not just the god but the plot.

- 2 *ll. 18-33* The punishment of Hera: hung from heaven in a golden unbreakable band, "and from your feet I slung two anvils" — the gods raging up and down Olympus, unable to free her, and any who tried "I seized and hurled from the threshold, till he struck the earth with little life in him." The cosmic-discipline memory (cf. Hephaestus's version, 1.590-594) is deployed as marital threat; and the occasion was the same Heracles-storm that Sleep remembered at 14.249-261 — the poem's back-story is consistent across books, and both tellings exist to make one point: this has happened before, and she did it anyway.

- 3 *ll. 36-46* Hera's oath — the fullest in the poem: Earth, wide Heaven, the down-flowing water of Styx ("the greatest oath and the most terrible for the blessed gods"), "and your own sacred head, and the bed of the two of us, our bridal bed." And it is a lawyer's oath: every word true — Poseidon did act of his own heart (13.15-16 confirms it) — and the seduction, the girdle, and Sleep's errand to Poseidon (14.354-360) nowhere within its terms. She swears by the very bed she used. Zeus smiles (47): readers have argued ever since about how much of that smile is belief.

- 4 *ll. 49-77* The plan of the poem, spoken by its administrator: Hector to drive the Achaeans on the ships of Achilles; "and he will send out his companion Patroclus; and glorious Hector will kill him with the spear... and among them my own son, brilliant Sarpedon. And in anger for him brilliant Achilles will kill Hector" — then the reversed tide "until the Achaeans take steep Ilion through the counsels of Athena." Sixty lines of Iliad and the fall of Troy, dictated in advance and pinned to the Book 1 promise ("on the day the goddess Thetis clasped my knees"). Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized 56-77 and Zenodotus omitted 64-77 — prophecy so total seemed to them to deflate the tale. It does the opposite: from here on, suspense is replaced by witness. Zeus names his own son among the costs with zero comment; Book 16 will price that silence.

- 5 *ll. 80-83* Hera travels at the speed of homesick thought: "as when the mind of a man darts, who has traveled over much country, and thinks in his quick wits 'would I were here, or there'" — the mind's instant travel as the fastest thing the poet knows (cf. Odyssey 7.36, ships "swift as wing or thought"). Cognition itself becomes the vehicle of a god.

- 6 *ll. 101-103* Hera's laugh: "she laughed with her lips; but the forehead above her dark brows did not warm." The poem's greatest piece of face-writing — the smile as mask worn over rage, observed with a portraitist's exactness three thousand years before the psychology had a vocabulary.

- 7 *ll. 110-142* The Ascalaphus fuse (13.518-525) detonates: Hera lights it deliberately, naming the death to wound Zeus through Ares. Ares' reply is the book's darkest heroism — "do not blame me... even if my fate is to be struck by Zeus's bolt, and lie with the corpses in the blood and the dust": the war-god volunteering for mortality's posture. Athena disarms him physically — helmet, shield, spear — and delivers the poem's mortality-policy in the flattest possible terms: "Better men than he... have been killed before this, or will be killed hereafter. It is a hard thing to rescue the line and offspring of every man." A god may not grieve past policy; men, the poem knows, do nothing else.
- 8 *ll. 185-199* Poseidon's cosmology: three brothers, three lots — "I drew the grey sea to live in forever when the lots were shaken; and Hades drew the misty dark, and Zeus drew the wide heaven... but the earth is common to all three still, and high Olympus." Sovereignty by sortition, not primogeniture — the constitutional counter-claim to Zeus's "elder-born and stronger" (165-166). The tripartite division by lot has close Near Eastern kin (the Akkadian Atrahasis opens with Anu, Enlil, and Enki dividing sky, earth, and waters); here it surfaces once, in anger, and nowhere else in Homer. "Let him stay quiet in his third portion": for one speech, the Iliad's monarchy of heaven is a contested federation.
- 9 *ll. 200-211* Iris earns her wage: "Is this really the word... Or will you turn a little? The hearts of the great can turn. You know how the Erinyes always side with the elder-born." The messenger exceeds her brief with a diplomat's question and a theological reminder — the Furies as enforcers of birth-order — and Poseidon's capitulation praises the craft itself: "it is a fine thing when a messenger knows what is fitting." The scene is the poem's tribute to its own couriers.
- 10 *ll. 212-217* The yielding god's condition: if Zeus spares Ilion against the will of Poseidon, Athena, Hera, Hermes, and Hephaestus, "between us two the anger will have no healing." Athetized in antiquity, but load-bearing: the fall of Troy is established as an inter-divine settlement no single god — not even Zeus — can cheaply revoke (cf. 4.30-49, where Zeus traded away his own three cities).
- 11 *ll. 229-230, 308-311* The aegis passes to Apollo: made by the smith Hephaestus for Zeus "to carry for the routing of men" — the one artifact in the poem whose function is pure panic. Apollo carries it unshaken at first (318-320: stalemate), then shakes it and shouts — and the balance-clause the poem used for whole mornings of battle ("the missiles of both sides struck home, and the people fell") snaps in a single line.
- 12 *ll. 244-262* Hector's revival: he answers the unrecognized god with the accurate history of his own concussion, believing he was bound that day for "the dead and the house of Hades"; Apollo answers with his full title — "Phoebus Apollo of the golden sword: I who before now have guarded you, yourself and your steep citadel alike" (the helmet of 11.353; the walls he built, 7.452-453; 21.446-447). The god who will one day stand off and let him die (22.213) introduces himself as his oldest bodyguard.
- 13 *ll. 263-270* The stalled-horse simile, repeated verbatim from 6.506-511 — our English kept, as the Greek is kept (ancient critics athetized the repeat here). In Book 6 it carried Paris, glittering and trivial, down from Pergamos; here it carries Hector back from the edge of death. Same gallop, same streaming mane, opposite gravities: the formula system's boldest double exposure, and the poem trusts its audience to hold both.

- 14 *ll. 281-300* Thoas of Aetolia, given a rare résumé — best with the javelin, brave standing, "and in assembly few Achaeans could beat him, when the young men contended in debate": the full heroic curriculum (deeds and words, 9.443) in a supporting player. His plan — multitude back, champions stand — is the professional's answer to a revenant: you cannot outfight a portent, but you can blunt it.
- 15 *ll. 318-327* The physics of the aegis: held still, nothing; shaken, with the god's shout laid over it, it "bewitched" (θέλγε) the heart — the enchantment-verb again (12.255, Circe's verb). Panic in Homer is not an emotion but a possession, and the stampede simile that follows (two beasts, the herdsman absent, "in the milking-dark of night") makes the Achaeans the cattle of a masterless field.
- 16 *ll. 328-345* The counter-rout's ledger, paying debts across three books: Stichius (13.691) and Arcesilaus (2.495) fall to Hector; Aeneas kills Iasus and Medon — whose biography (334-337) repeats 13.694-697 verbatim, our English kept: the homicide-exile's story told once at his post and once at his death, as the register promised. Mecisteus, who carried the wounded off the field at 8.333 and 13.422, is carried off himself; Clonius (2.495) and Deiochus complete the roll. The poem audits its minor lives with the same care as its princes.
- 17 *ll. 346-352* Hector's field-order crosses the poem's deepest line: the man who hangs back "I will plan his death on the spot; and no brothers of his, no sisters, will give his dead body its portion of fire: the dogs will drag him before our city." Denial of burial as military discipline, threatened by Hector against his own — the exact fate Achilles will attempt on Hector's corpse, and the theme of the poem's whole last movement. The words are spoken at his triumph's crest; the poem never forgets them.
- 18 *ll. 355-366* Apollo bridges the ditch with a kick and levels the wall — the wall of Books 7-12, the wall that cost the dead their monument-fires — "as when a boy by the sea heaps sand into shapes in his childish play, and then, still playing, scatters them again with his feet and hands." And the narrator turns, for once, to face the god directly: "so you, archer Phoebus, poured into ruin the long labor and misery of the Argives." The apostrophe (elsewhere reserved for Menelaus and Patroclus, figures of pathos) here carries something close to reproach: the distance between divine play and human toil has never been measured more exactly, in either direction. What Books 12-13 fought for line by line, a god undoes as recreation.
- 19 *ll. 372-380* Nestor's prayer — the old contract-form: "if ever anyone in wheat-rich Argos... prayed for his homecoming, and you promised it with a nod: remember it." Zeus thunders — hearing him, the poet says plainly. And the Trojans, hearing the same thunder, take it for their own sign and charge harder. One peal, two readings, both catastrophic in different keys: the poem's most economical lesson in omens.
- 20 *ll. 381-390* The wave-over-the-bulwarks simile lands the Trojans inside the ships' line, and the fighting goes naval: they from chariots, the Achaeans from the decks "with the long pikes that lay aboard for sea-fighting, jointed and socketed, their heads clothed in bronze" — the ναύμαχα ξυστά, boarding weapons stowed since the landing ten years ago, at last taken down. The war has come full circle to the gear of its arrival.

- 21 *ll. 390-405* The Patroclus thread, resumed from 11.848: he is still in Eurypylus's hut, "delighting him with talk" and dressing the wound — the poem's gentlest man at his gentlest — when the wall's fall ends the interlude. His exit couplet repeats Nestor's own persuasion-lines (11.792-793) in the first person, our English kept: "Who knows whether, with a god's help, I might stir his heart by my persuading?" He leaves to fetch Achilles and will return only inside the plan of Zeus (note [4]). "Even as he spoke his feet were carrying him": the poem's quietest sentence of doom.
- 22 *ll. 410-414* The carpenter's chalk-line: battle-equilibrium as a timber trued straight "in the hands of a skilled carpenter, who knows his whole craft well by the promptings of Athena." The deadlock similes have run from farmers' scales (12.433) to boundary stones (12.421) to this: war measured, again, by the honest work it interrupts.
- 23 *ll. 419-441* Caletor, Hector's cousin, falls with the fire- brand still in his hand; and Hector's answering cast kills Lycophron of Cythera — Ajax's henchman, a homicide-exile "we honored in our halls like our own dear parents." The third such exile in three books (Medon, note [16]; Patroclus himself, 23.85-88): the heroic household absorbs killers as kin, and they die defending the men who took them in.
- 24 *ll. 458-478* Teucer's bowstring, "fresh-twisted... bound on this very morning," snaps in the draw — Zeus, guarding Hector, disarms the one man whose shot could end the day. Teucer reads it exactly ("some power is shearing off the plans of our fighting"); Ajax's answer is the poem's practical theology: "let the bow and the showering arrows lie, since a god has spited the Danaans... Take a long spear." No lament, no inquiry: identify the interference, change weapons, keep fighting. Between them the brothers state the whole range of sane response to an intervening god.
- 25 *ll. 486-499* Hector's great exhortation. First the sign read right for once ("I have seen with my own eyes the shots of their best man crippled by Zeus — easily known among men is the strength of Zeus"); then the lines Lycurgus read out to an Athenian jury in 330 BC (Against Leocrates 103), prosecuting a man who fled the city after Chaeronea: "whichever of you... meets his death and his doom — let him die. It is no dishonor for him to die defending his fatherland: his wife is safe after him, and his children, his house and his portion of land unharmed." The patriot-death ethic of 12.243 completed with its economic clause — what the dying man's death purchases, itemized. That the poem gives this creed to Hector, whose wife will not be safe, whose child will not live, whose city burns in every listener's knowledge, is the deepest irony the Iliad ever builds into a speech; and it was still doing civic work in a law-court three centuries later.
- 26 *ll. 502-514* Ajax's counter-speech strips the same choice of all its consolations: "either we perish or we are saved"; the savage joke ("It is not to a dance he is inviting them"); and the preference — "Better once for all to seize our death or our life than be squeezed slowly dry... under worse men than ourselves." Where Hector offers death a meaning, Ajax offers only the arithmetic of now or slowly: the defender's creed, with no city behind it (completed at 733-742, note [36]).
- 27 *ll. 525-539* Dolops, son of Lampus — grandson of Laomedon: even the Trojan royal cousins now feed the ships' battle. His death turns on heirloom armor: the corslet Phyleus brought out of Ephyra, guest-gift of Euphetes, "and now it kept destruction from the

flesh of his son" — a cuirass with a passport, protecting the second generation (cf. the boar's- tusk helmet, 10.261-271). The plume Meges shears falls "fresh- shining with its scarlet dye" — the ornament dies first; then Menelaus, "unseen," finishes the man from behind.

- 28 *Il. 547-559* Melanippus of Percote: the cattle-herding cousin who came back when the ships came — lines 550-551 repeat the Imbrius formula (13.175-176) verbatim, our English kept: the poem has a fixed biography for Troy's returned provincials, honored "like his own children" by Priam and spent like coin by Hector, whose rebuke ends on the naked alternative: "now we kill them, or they pull down steep Ilium from its height and cut her citizens down."
- 29 *Il. 561-565* Ajax's shame-couplet repeats 5.531-532 (our English kept): "Where men feel shame, more are saved than slain; where they run, no fame rises, and no strength." Once Agamemnon's marshaling wisdom, now the last doctrine of a shrinking perimeter — αἰδώς as the army's remaining wall.
- 30 *Il. 579-591* Antilochus springs like a hound on a shot fawn, then flees Hector "like a wild beast that has done some mischief — that has killed a dog, or a herdsman with his cattle, and runs before the crowd of men can gather." The guilty-animal simile is unique — predation with a conscience attached — and it fits the poem's tenderest young fighter: Antilochus kills, knows the price of the field instantly, and is standing again the moment he reaches his friends.
- 31 *Il. 592-615* The narrator's double disclosure. Zeus drives everything toward one image: "to see with his own eyes the flare of a single burning ship" — Thetis's "extraordinary prayer" made a visual trigger; from that flare the tide reverses. Then over Hector — foam at his mouth, eyes blazing under grim brows — the lines Zenodotus cut and Aristarchus athetized: Zeus honored him "for he was to be short-lived: already Pallas Athena was speeding his death-day on, under the strength of Peleus' son." Glory as hospice-gift: every act of Hector's greatest hour is performed inside a sentence that has already ended him. The ancients found the disclosure intolerable; it is the poem's whole method — nothing is suspenseful, everything is witnessed.
- 32 *Il. 630-652* The lion takes one cow from the middle of thousands: Periphetes of Mycenae — son of Copeus ("Dung-man"), Eurystheus's herald to Heracles, "of that far worse father was born a better son in every virtue." The Heracles-cycle surfaces as family shame redeemed one generation on — and then the poem's most pitilessly ordinary death: he trips backward over his own shield-rim, "the shield he carried himself, reaching his feet, a tower against javelins," and Hector spears him where he lies tangled in his own protection. The best equipment in the panic is the thing that kills him; his friends watch, too afraid to help.
- 33 *Il. 653-667* The last line before the huts. Nestor "begged each man by his parents, clasping their knees with his words" — supplication conducted by proxy, at range: "remember, each of you, your children and your wives, your property and your parents — you whose parents live, and you whose parents are dead: for their sake, absent though they are, I clasp your knees here." The absent invoked as the army's true country (Ajax will say the

country itself is absent, note [36]); and Athena lifts the mist so that they can at least see the enemy that is upon them — the poem's recurring mercy of light (17.646-647).

- 34 *ll. 674-688* Ajax's pike-walk: deck to deck with the twenty- two-cubit boarding pike, "as a man well skilled in trick- riding... yoked together four horses... steady, sure, and always leaping, changes from horse to horse as they fly along." The one extended image of equestrian spectacle in the poem — public road, admiring crowd, the city ahead — laid over a man hopping burning-threatened hulls with a siege-pole: peacetime's showman as war's last acrobat.
- 35 *ll. 704-726* Hector's hand closes on the stern of the ship "that had carried Protesilaus to Troy, and never carried him home again": the war's first casualty (2.698-702) supplying the altar for its crisis — the fleet's mortality concentrated in one hull. Hector's speech from the stern-horn rewrites his own history — the elders' "cowardice" held him back (it was Polydamas's prudence, and his own obedience) — and then produces the poem's most convenient theology: "if wide-seeing Zeus was damaging our wits then, now he himself is driving and commanding us." Both clauses are true; neither means what he thinks. The day Zeus gave him is real, and expires at sundown (11.192-194); "bring fire!" is the exact fulfillment, and the exact limit, of his warrant.
- 36 *ll. 727-746* The last stand, measured in carpentry: Ajax gives back from the deck to "the seven-foot bridge-plank" — θριῖνυς ἑπταπόδης, the cross-bench of a beached hull as the war's entire remaining ground. His speech is the reply to Hector's fatherland-creed (note [25]) from men who have none in reach: "Do we imagine there are allies at our backs? Some stronger wall?... There is no city near us fitted with towers ... We sit in the plain of the close-armored Trojans, pinned against the sea, far from our fatherland. Our light of safety is in our hands — not in any gentleness of war." τὼ ἐν χερσὶ φόως: salvation as a thing held, like a spear. Then the book's last sentence does the accounting its hero would approve: "twelve men he wounded close-in before the ships." No simile, no god, no glory-word — a count. The fire is one torch away, and Book 16 opens with Patroclus weeping in front of Achilles.

Iliad — Book 16

*Patroclus fights in Achilles' armor, drives the Trojans from the ships, kills
Sarpedon, and dies at Hector's hands.*

- So they fought on around the well-benched ship;
and Patroclus stood beside Achilles, shepherd of the people,
letting fall hot tears like a spring of dark water¹
that pours its black stream down a goat-proof cliff.
- 5 And swift-footed brilliant Achilles saw him, and pitied him,
and speaking winged words he addressed him:
"Why are you in tears, Patroclus — like a little girl
running at her mother's side, begging to be carried,
clutching her skirt, dragging at her hurrying steps,
10 and looking up at her in tears until she lifts her:
that is you, Patroclus — spilling soft tears just so.
Have you some news for the Myrmidons, or for me myself?
Some message out of Phthia that you alone have heard?
They say Menoetius, Actor's son, is still living,
15 and Peleus, Aeacus' son, lives among his Myrmidons —
the two whose deaths would grieve us most of all.
Or are you mourning for the Argives, watching them perish
by the hollow ships for their own high-handedness?
Speak out: hide nothing. Then we will both know."
- 20 Then, groaning heavily, you answered, Patroclus, horseman:²
"Achilles, son of Peleus, far greatest of the Achaeans,
do not be angry: such grief has overmastered the Achaeans.
For all the men who before were our best
lie by the ships, hit from afar or stabbed close.
- 25 Hit is Tydeus' son, strong Diomedes;
stabbed is Odysseus, famed with the spear; and Agamemnon;
and hit too is Eurypylus, by an arrow in the thigh.
Around these men the healers with their many drugs
are busy, tending their wounds. But you, Achilles — there is no dealing
with you.
- 30 May such anger never take me as this anger you nurse,

- cursed in your valor! What good will any late-born man get of you³
 if you will not beat back shameful ruin from the Argives?
 Pitiless man: the horseman Peleus was no father of yours,
 nor Thetis your mother — the grey sea bore you,
 35 and the sheer cliffs, so unbending is the mind in you.
 But if in your heart you are dodging some prophecy,⁴
 something your lady mother has told you from Zeus,
 then send me out at least, and let the rest of the army
 of Myrmidons follow, and I may be a light to the Danaans;
 40 and give me your own armor to buckle on my shoulders,
 so that the Trojans may take me for you, and hold back
 from the fighting, and the warlike sons of the Achaeans catch their
 breath,
 worn as they are; for the breathing-spaces of war are few.
 Fresh men, with one shout, could easily push men weary
 45 of battle back on the city, away from the ships and the huts."
 So he spoke, begging — the great fool: it was his own
 death and evil doom he was begging for.
 And deeply troubled, swift-footed Achilles answered him:
 "Ah, Zeus-sprung Patroclus — what a thing you have said.
 50 I care for no prophecy, none that I know of,
 nor has my lady mother told me anything from Zeus.
 But this bitter grief keeps coming at my heart and spirit:⁵
 when a man is minded to rob his own equal
 and take his prize back, just because he outranks him in power.
 55 That is my bitter grief; I have suffered it to the heart.
 The girl the sons of the Achaeans picked out as my prize —
 won with my own spear when I sacked her walled city —
 her the lord Agamemnon took back out of my hands,
 Atreus' son, as if I were some vagrant without honor.
 60 But we will let that be — a thing done and past. It seems there was
 no way, after all, to be angry in my heart forever;
 and yet I said I would not lay my wrath aside
 until the moment the war-shout and the fighting reached
 my own ships. So: you put my famous armor on your shoulders,
 65 and lead the war-loving Myrmidons into the fight,
 since the dark cloud of Trojans has closed hard

- around the ships, and the Argives are penned against
the surf-line of the sea, and hold only a little strip
of ground; and the whole city of the Trojans has come out
70 emboldened — because they do not see the face of my helmet
blazing near them. Soon enough they would be running
and choking the gullies with their dead, if the lord Agamemnon
knew how to deal kindly with me. Instead they besiege the camp.
For no spear rages in the hands of Diomedes,
75 Tydeus' son, to beat destruction off the Danaans;
and I have not yet heard the voice of Atreus' son
shouting from his hated head. It is man-slaughtering Hector's
voice that breaks around them, calling the Trojans on; and they
hold the whole plain with their war-cry, beating the Achaeans in battle.
80 Even so, Patroclus — beat the ruin off the ships:
fall on them with all your power, or they will burn
the ships with blazing fire and take away our own dear homecoming.
But obey me — here is the whole end of my word, laid in your mind —
so that you may win me great honor and glory⁶
85 in the eyes of all the Danaans, and they send back
the beautiful girl, and bring shining gifts besides:
once you have driven them from the ships, come back. And if
the loud-thunderer, Hera's lord, grants you your hour of glory,
do not go lusting after battle apart from me
90 against the war-loving Trojans — you will strip my honor thinner;
and do not, exulting in the war and the slaughter,
killing Trojans, lead the way to Iliion:
one of the everlasting gods from Olympus may step in —
the worker-from-afar, Apollo, loves them dearly.
95 Turn back, once you have set the light of safety in the ships,
and leave the rest to cut each other down across the plain.
For — O father Zeus, Athena, Apollo — would⁷
that not one Trojan might escape death, of all there are,
and not one Argive; and that we two alone might slip destruction,
100 so that alone we might undo Troy's holy coronal of towers."
So the two of them spoke such things to one another.
But Ajax could hold no longer: the missiles pressed him too hard.⁸
The mind of Zeus was breaking him, and the proud Trojans

with their throwing; and the bright helmet at his temples
 105 rang terribly under the blows — struck and struck again
 on its well-made cheek-pieces; and his left shoulder ached,
 steady so long under the glittering shield; yet they could not
 shake him loose for all the missiles they leaned against him.
 And always he labored, gasping hard, the sweat streaming
 110 down from every limb of him, and he could nowhere
 catch his breath: everywhere evil was propped on evil.
 Tell me now, Muses, who keep your homes on Olympus —⁹
 how the fire first fell on the ships of the Achaeans.
 Hector, coming close, struck the ash spear of Ajax
 115 with his great sword, behind the point at the socket,
 and sheared it clean off; and Telamonian Ajax
 brandished a docked shaft, useless in his hand, while far away
 the bronze point rang on the ground where it fell.
 And Ajax knew in his blameless heart, and shuddered at it:
 120 the work of gods — that Zeus who thunders on high was shearing off
 all the plans of his fighting, and willed victory to the Trojans.
 He drew back out of range. And onto the swift ship they hurled
 unwearying fire; and the quenchless flame poured over it at once.
 So the fire wrapped the stern of the ship. And Achilles
 125 struck both his thighs and spoke to Patroclus:
 "Up, Zeus-sprung Patroclus, master of horses!
 I see the rush of consuming fire at the ships.
 Before they take them, and there is no escaping left —
 get into the armor, quick, and I will gather the men."
 130 So he spoke; and Patroclus armed himself in the flashing bronze.¹⁰
 First he set the greaves along his shins,
 fine greaves, fitted with silver ankle-pieces;
 second, he put the corslet about his chest,
 the intricate, star-bright corslet of the swift-footed son of Aeacus.
 135 Around his shoulders he threw the sword, silver-studded,
 bronze; and after that the shield, great and heavy;
 and on his powerful head he set the well-made helmet,
 horsehair-crested; the plume nodded terribly above it.
 And he took two stout spears, fitted to his grip —
 140 only the spear he did not take of Aeacus' blameless son:

- heavy, huge, compact — no other of the Achaeans
 could swing it; Achilles alone knew how to swing it —
 the Pelian ash that Chiron gave his dear father
 from the peak of Pelion, to be death for heroes.
- 145 The horses he told Automedon to yoke, and quickly —
 the man he honored most after Achilles breaker of men,
 and trustiest at his post to await the shout of battle.
 So Automedon led the swift horses under the yoke,
 Xanthus and Balius, the pair who flew with the winds:¹¹
- 150 the harpy Podarge conceived them by the West Wind
 as she grazed in a meadow beside the stream of Ocean.
 And in the side-traces he put blameless Pedasus,
 whom Achilles brought home when he took Eëtion's city:
 a horse who, mortal as he was, kept pace with immortal horses.
- 155 And Achilles went down the huts and armed the Myrmidons,
 all of them, in their war-gear. And they, like wolves¹²
 that eat flesh raw, hearts full of unspeakable courage,
 who have brought down a great antlered stag in the mountains
 and tear it, and every muzzle among them is red with blood;
- 160 and in a pack they go to a spring of dark water
 to lap with their thin tongues the black surface-water,
 belching up clotted gore; and the heart in their chests
 is fearless still, though every belly is stretched:
 such were the leaders and lords of the Myrmidons
- 165 streaming round the brave aide of the swift-footed son of Aeacus;
 and among them stood Achilles the warlike,
 urging on the horses and the shield-bearing men.
 Fifty were the swift ships that Achilles,¹³
 dear to Zeus, led to Troy, and in each one
- 170 fifty men, companions at the oar-benches;
 and he made five men leaders, and trusted them
 to command, while he himself in his great power was king.
 One line was led by Menesthius of the glittering corslet,
 the son of Spercheius, the sky-fed river:
- 175 Peleus' daughter bore him, beautiful Polydora,
 a woman bedded with a god, to tireless Spercheius —
 though in name to Borus, Perieres' son, who wed her

openly before men, and gave bride-gifts past counting.
 The second was led by warlike Eudorus, born
 180 out of wedlock: Polymele, beautiful in the dance,
 bore him — Phylas's daughter. Strong Hermes, the slayer of Argus,
 fell in love with her, his eyes catching her among the singers
 in the dancing-choir of Artemis of the golden distaff, the huntress-
 crier;
 and straightway he climbed to her upper room and lay with her
 185 in secret — Hermes the gracious — and she gave him a shining son,
 Eudorus, quick beyond all men to run, and a fighter.
 And when Eileithyia of hard labor had brought him
 out into the light, and he had seen the rays of the sun,
 the strong might of Echeclus, Actor's son,
 190 led her home to his house, once he had given countless bride-gifts;
 and old Phylas reared the boy well, and cherished him,
 wrapping him round with love, as though he were his own son.
 The third was led by warlike Peisander,
 Maemalus's son, who outshone all the Myrmidons
 195 in spear-fighting, after Peleus' son's own companion.
 The fourth the old horseman Phoenix led;
 the fifth, Alcimedon, Laerces' blameless son.
 Now when Achilles had set them all with their leaders,
 duly marshaled, he laid this hard word upon them:¹⁴
 200 "Myrmidons — let no man forget for me the threats
 you made beside the swift ships against the Trojans
 all through my wrath, when every one of you accused me:
 'Cruel son of Peleus — your mother reared you on bile!
 Pitiless — holding your companions by the ships against their will!
 205 Let us at least sail home again in our seagoing ships,
 since this ruinous anger has fallen on your heart.'
 So you would gather and mutter at me. Now here it is —
 the great work of battle you were lusting for, in plain sight.
 Now let each man fight the Trojans with a stout heart."
 210 So speaking he stirred the fury and the heart of every man,
 and the ranks locked tighter, once they heard their king.
 As when a man fits close the stones of a high house's wall,¹⁵
 building against the strength of the winds,

- so close were fitted the helmets and the bossed shields:
 215 buckler pressed on buckler, helmet on helmet, man on man,
 and the horsehair crests on the bright ridges touched
 as they nodded, so close they stood to one another.
 And in front of them all two men armed themselves,
 Patroclus and Automedon, of one mind between them:
 220 to fight in the forefront of the Myrmidons. But Achilles
 went into his hut, and lifted the lid of a chest,
 beautiful, intricate, that silver-footed Thetis¹⁶
 had put aboard his ship to carry, filled with tunics
 and wind-proof cloaks and thick-piled rugs.
 225 And in it lay a wrought cup: no other man
 drank the fire-bright wine from it, and to no god
 did he pour from it, except to Zeus the father.
 This he took from the chest and cleansed with sulphur
 first, then washed it in fair streams of water,
 230 and washed his own hands, and drew off the fire-bright wine.
 Then he prayed, standing in the middle of the yard, and poured the
 wine
 looking up into heaven; and Zeus who delights in thunder marked him
 well:
 "Zeus — lord — Dodonaean — Pelasgian — dweller far off,¹⁷
 ruling over wintry Dodona; and around you the Selloi
 235 live, your interpreters, men of unwashed feet, who sleep on the ground.
 Once before, when I prayed, you heard my word:
 you did me honor, and struck the Achaean army hard.
 So now again accomplish this desire for me.
 I myself will stay in the gathering-place of the ships,
 240 but I am sending out my companion, with many Myrmidons,
 to fight. Send glory out with him, wide-seeing Zeus,
 and make the heart bold in his chest, so that even Hector
 may learn whether our aide knows how to make war
 alone — or whether his hands rage invincible only
 245 when I myself go into the grind of the war-god.
 But when he has driven the fighting and the war-cry from the ships,
 then let him come back to me at the swift ships unhurt,
 with all his armor, and his close-fighting companions."

So he spoke in prayer, and Zeus the counselor heard him;
 250 and the father granted him one thing, and refused the other:¹⁸
 that Patroclus should push the war and battle back from the ships
 he granted; and refused that he come back safe out of the fighting.
 So Achilles, having poured and prayed to Zeus the father,
 went into his hut again and laid the cup in the chest,
 255 and came out and stood before the hut; for his heart still longed
 to watch the dread struggle of Trojans and Achaeans.
 And they, armed all together with great-hearted Patroclus,
 marched until they charged the Trojans, thinking great things.
 At once they came pouring out like roadside wasps¹⁹
 260 that boys are forever provoking, forever tormenting —
 wasps with their nests along the road — as boys will,
 the little fools: they make a common evil for many.
 If some traveling man going by then stirs the wasps
 without meaning it, out they come with fearless hearts,
 265 every one flying at him, defending their young:
 with their heart and courage the Myrmidons then
 came pouring from the ships; and the quenchless roar rose.
 And Patroclus called to his companions with a great shout:
 "Myrmidons, companions of Achilles, Peleus' son —
 270 be men, my friends; remember your rushing courage;
 so we may honor Peleus' son, who is far the best
 of the Argives by the ships — he, and his close-fighting aides —
 and so that Atreus' son, wide-ruling Agamemnon,
 may know his blindness: that he honored not at all the best of the
 Achaeans."²⁰
 275 So speaking he stirred the fury and the heart of every man,
 and they fell on the Trojans in one mass; and around them the ships
 echoed terribly under the shouting of the Achaeans.
 But the Trojans, when they saw the stout son of Menoetius,
 himself and his aide beside him, blazing in their armor,
 280 the heart was shaken in all of them, and the battle-lines wavered:
 they thought the swift-footed son of Peleus by the ships
 had thrown away his wrath and taken back friendship;
 and each man looked about him for escape from sheer destruction.
 Then Patroclus first cast with his shining spear,

285 straight into the middle, where the most men were driven
 in confusion around the stern of the ship of great-hearted
 Protesilaus, and he struck Pyraechmes — who led the Paeonians,²¹
 who fight from chariots, out of Amydon, from the wide-flowing Axios
 —
 in the right shoulder; and he went down on his back in the dust
 290 with a groan, and around him his companions panicked,
 the Paeonians: for Patroclus had driven the panic among them all,
 killing their leader, who was their best in battle.
 He drove them from the ships, and quenched the blazing fire;
 and the ship was left there, half-burnt. And the Trojans fled
 295 with an unearthly din, and the Danaans poured after them
 along the hollow ships; and the roar rose unabating.
 As when from the high crest of a great mountain
 Zeus who gathers the lightning moves a close-packed cloud,
 and all the lookout-peaks show clear, and the jutting headlands,
 300 and the glens; and from heaven the measureless air breaks open:
 so the Danaans, having thrust the enemy fire from the ships,
 caught their breath a little. But there was no pause in the war:
 for the Trojans, before the Achaeans dear to Ares, were not yet
 turned in headlong flight away from the black ships —
 305 they still stood facing them, giving ground from the ships only by need.
 Then man killed man, as the battle scattered,
 among the leaders. First the stout son of Menoetius
 hit Areilycus in the thigh, just as he turned,
 with his sharp-pointed spear, and drove the bronze clean through;
 310 the spear shattered the bone, and he came down on his face
 to the ground. Then warlike Menelaus wounded Thoas
 where the chest showed bare beside the shield, and unstrung his limbs.
 And Phyleus' son, watching Amphiclus as he charged in,
 was quicker: he lunged and hit the top of his leg,
 315 where a man's muscle is thickest, and around the spear-point
 the sinews were torn through; and darkness covered his eyes.
 And of Nestor's sons, one — Antilochus — stabbed Atymnius
 with his sharp spear, and drove the bronze point through his flank;
 he fell forward. But Maris, close in, rushed Antilochus
 320 with his spear, in fury for his brother,

- standing in front of the corpse; but godlike Thrasymedes
 was quicker: he lunged before he could stab — and did not miss —
 straight at the shoulder; and the spear-point tore the arm's base
 away from the muscles, and cracked the bone clean through:
- 325 he fell with a thud, and darkness covered his eyes.
 So those two, beaten down by two brothers,
 went to Erebus — the brave companions of Sarpedon,
 spearmen sons of Amisodarus, the man who reared
 the raging Chimaera, an evil to many men.²²
- 330 And Ajax, Oïleus' son, sprang on Cleobulus
 and took him alive, tangled in the crush; but there and then
 he unstrung his strength, driving the hilted sword through his neck:
 the whole blade ran hot with blood, and down over his eyes
 came purple death, and fate the overpowering.
- 335 Peneleos and Lycon ran together: with their spears
 they had missed each other, both casts thrown in vain,
 so they ran together again with swords. There Lycon
 hacked at the ridge of the horsehair-crested helmet,
 and the sword shattered at the hilt; but Peneleos struck
- 340 his neck below the ear, and the whole blade sank in,
 and only skin held: the head lolled sideways, and his limbs were
 unstrung.
 And Meriones, overtaking Acamas on quick feet,
 stabbed his right shoulder as he was mounting his chariot;
 he crashed from the car, and mist poured down over his eyes.
- 345 And Idomeneus stabbed Erymas in the mouth
 with the pitiless bronze: the bronze spear passed straight through,
 up under the brain, and split the white bones;
 his teeth were shaken out, and both his eyes
 filled up with blood; and blood through his open mouth
- 350 and through his nostrils he blew as he gaped; and death's black cloud
 wrapped round him.
 These, then, were the Danaan leaders, and each killed his man.
 As ravaging wolves fall on lambs or on kids,
 snatching them out from the flocks, when in the mountains
 a shepherd's carelessness has let them scatter — the wolves see,
- 355 and swiftly seize the young whose hearts have no courage:

so the Danaans fell on the Trojans; and the Trojans remembered
the harsh clamor of rout, and forgot their rushing courage.
And the great Ajax strained forever to cast his spear
at Hector of the bronze helmet; but Hector, in his war-craft,
360 his broad shoulders covered by the bull's-hide shield,
watched the whistle of arrows and the thud of javelins.
Truly he knew the tide of the battle had turned;
but even so he stood, and tried to save his loyal companions.
As when a cloud comes from Olympus into heaven²³
365 out of the clear upper air, when Zeus stretches the squall,
so the shouting and the rout came from the ships;
and in no good order they crossed back. Hector's own swift horses
carried him off, armor and all; and he left the Trojan army
penned against their will by the dug ditch;
370 and in the ditch many swift chariot-teams
snapped the pole at the tip and abandoned their lords' cars.
But Patroclus followed, calling hard to the Danaans,
with evil intent for the Trojans; and they in their shrieking rout
choked every path, once their lines were cut; and high up the dust-
squall
375 scattered under the clouds, and the whole-hoofed horses strained
back toward the city, away from the ships and the huts.
And wherever Patroclus saw the most men driven in confusion,
there he steered with a shout; and men kept falling under his axles
face-first from their chariots, and the cars went clattering over.
380 Straight across the ditch the swift horses leapt —
the immortal horses the gods gave Peleus as shining gifts —
straining onward; and his heart cried out for Hector,
hot to strike him; but Hector's swift horses carried him away.
And as the whole black earth is weighed down under a storm
385 on a day of harvest-season, when Zeus pours down
his most violent water, when in rage he turns bitter
against men who by force render crooked judgments in the assembly
and drive justice out, careless of the gods' vengeance:
all their rivers rise in flood as they run,
390 and the torrents cut the hillsides into gullies,
and down to the darkening sea they roar headlong

from the mountains, groaning huge, and the works of men are
 diminished:
 so huge was the groaning of the Trojan mares as they ran.
 And Patroclus, when he had cut off the front battle-lines,
 395 turned and penned them back against the ships, and would not let
 them
 climb to the city for all their straining, but in the space between
 the ships and the river and the high wall
 he swept and killed, and exacted the blood-price for many.²⁴
 There first he hit Pronous with his shining spear
 400 where the chest showed bare beside the shield, and unstrung his limbs:
 he fell with a thud. Then Thestor, Enops's son —
 his second rush — Thestor, who sat hunched
 in his polished chariot, struck out of his wits, the reins
 slipped from his hands: Patroclus came close and stabbed him
 405 through the right jaw, and drove the spear on through his teeth,
 and hauled him by the spear-shaft over the chariot-rail — as a man
 sitting on a jutting rock hauls a sacred fish
 out of the sea with his line and his glittering bronze:
 so he hauled him gaping from the chariot on the shining spear
 410 and tumbled him down on his face; and the life left him as he fell.
 Then Erylaus, running in — he struck him with a stone
 full mid-skull, and the whole head split in two
 inside the heavy helmet; and he dropped face-first
 to the ground, and death that breaks the spirit poured round him.
 415 Then one upon another — Erymas and Amphoterus and Epaltes,
 Tlepolemus Damastor's son, and Echius and Pyris,
 Ipheus and Euippus and Polymelus, Argeas' son —
 he brought them all, in heaps, to the earth that feeds so many.
 But Sarpedon, when he saw his companions of the unbelted tunics²⁵
 420 broken under the hands of Patroclus, Menoetius's son,
 called out, rebuking the godlike Lycians:
 "Shame, Lycians! Where are you running? Now be quick — against him.
 I will meet this man myself, and learn
 who it is that conquers here — who has worked the Trojans
 425 so much evil already, and unstrung the knees of many good men."
 He spoke, and leapt with his weapons from the chariot to the ground;

- and Patroclus on the other side, seeing him, sprang from his car.
 And they — like hook-clawed, crook-beaked vultures
 screaming great cries on a high rock-face as they fight —
 430 so they rushed screaming at one another.
 And the son of crooked-counseled Cronos saw them, and pitied,
 and spoke to Hera, his sister and his wife:
 "Ah me — my Sarpedon, dearest to me of men,
 is fated to be broken under Patroclus, Menoetius's son.
 435 And my heart is divided as I ponder it:
 whether to snatch him living out of the tearful battle
 and set him down in the rich country of Lycia,
 or to break him now under the hands of Menoetius's son."
 Then ox-eyed lady Hera answered him:
 440 "Most dread son of Cronos, what a word you have spoken!
 A man — a mortal, long since doomed to his fate —
 and you mean to release him back out of harsh-sounding death?
 Do it. But we other gods will not all approve you.
 And I will tell you another thing — lay it away in your mind:
 445 if you send Sarpedon living to his own house,
 consider: some other god may likewise choose
 to send his dear son out of the strong encounter —
 for many sons of the immortals fight around Priam's great city,
 and you will set loose terrible resentment among their fathers.
 450 But if he is dear to you — if your heart grieves for him —
 then let him be broken in the strong encounter
 under the hands of Patroclus, Menoetius's son;
 but when his soul and his life have left him,
 send Death to carry him, and painless Sleep,
 455 until they come to the country of wide Lycia;
 and there his brothers and kinsmen will give him burial
 with a tomb and a grave-stone: for that is the honor-right of the dead."
 So she spoke, and the father of men and gods did not refuse her;
 but he rained down drops of blood upon the earth,
 460 honoring his dear son, whom Patroclus was about
 to destroy in deep-soiled Troy, far from his fatherland.
 And when they were close, advancing on one another,
 Patroclus struck far-famed Thrasymelus,

the brave aide of lord Sarpedon,
 465 in the lower belly, and unstrung his limbs.
 And Sarpedon, casting second, missed his man
 with the shining spear, but wounded the horse Pedasus²⁶
 in the right shoulder; and he screamed away his life,
 and went down crying in the dust, and his spirit flew from him.
 470 The two yoke-horses reared apart, the yoke creaked,
 and the reins fouled over them, with the trace-horse lying in the dust.
 But spear-famed Automedon found the remedy:
 drawing the thin-edged sword from his massive thigh,
 he sprang and cut away the trace-horse, and did not fumble;
 475 the pair righted themselves and pulled taut in the harness;
 and the two men came together again in heart-devouring strife.
 Then Sarpedon missed again with his shining spear:
 over Patroclus's left shoulder the point of the spear
 passed, and did not strike him. But Patroclus in his turn
 480 rose with the bronze; and his shot did not go in vain from his hand,
 but struck where the beating heart is closed in the midriff.
 He fell as an oak falls, or a white poplar,²⁷
 or a towering pine, that carpenters up in the mountains
 cut down with fresh-whetted axes to be a ship's timber:
 485 so he lay stretched out before his horses and chariot,
 bellowing, clawing at the blood-soaked dust.
 As a lion kills a bull, coming in among the herd —
 a fiery, great-hearted bull among the shambling cattle —
 and it perishes groaning under the lion's jaws:
 490 so under Patroclus the leader of the Lycian shield-men
 raged as he was killed; and he called his dear companion by name:
 "Glaucus, old friend — fighter among men — now above all
 you must be a spearman and a daring man of war;
 now let evil battle be your desire, if you are quick at all.
 495 First go everywhere and rouse the leaders of the Lycians
 to fight for Sarpedon's body;
 and then fight for me yourself with the bronze.
 For I will be your shame and your hanging head
 all your days, forever after, if the Achaeans
 500 strip my armor here where I fell in the gathering-place of the ships.

Hold on with all your strength, and drive on the whole army."
 As he was speaking so, the end that is death covered him —
 his eyes and his nostrils. And Patroclus, setting his heel on his chest,
 drew the spear out of his flesh, and the midriff followed it:
 505 he pulled out his life and the spear-point together.²⁸
 And the Myrmidons held the snorting horses there,
 plunging to bolt, now they had left their masters' chariot.
 But on Glaucus came terrible grief at the sound of that voice,
 and his heart was churned, that he could not help him.
 510 He gripped his own arm and pressed it hard, for the wound
 wore at him — the wound Teucer's arrow had dealt him as he stormed
 the high wall, beating harm away from his companions.
 And he spoke in prayer to Apollo who strikes from afar:²⁹
 "Hear me, lord — you who are somewhere in the rich country of Lycia
 515 or here in Troy: you have power everywhere to hear
 a man in grief, as grief has come on me now.
 For I have this powerful wound; my arm is pierced
 with sharp pains through and through, and the blood
 will not dry; my shoulder is heavy under it;
 520 I cannot hold my spear steady, cannot go
 and fight the enemy. And the best of men has perished —
 Sarpedon, son of Zeus; and Zeus does not defend even his own child.
 But you, lord — heal me this powerful wound;
 lull the pains, and give me strength, so I may call
 525 my Lycian companions and drive them to the fighting,
 and fight myself for the body of the dead man."
 So he spoke in prayer, and Phoebus Apollo heard him.
 At once he stilled the pains, and on the grievous wound
 he dried the dark blood, and threw strength into his heart.
 530 And Glaucus knew it in his heart, and was glad
 that the great god had heard his prayer so quickly.
 First he went everywhere and roused the leaders of the Lycians
 to fight for Sarpedon's body;
 then he went with long strides after the Trojans —
 535 after Polydamas, Panthous's son, and brilliant Agenor,
 and after Aeneas, and Hector of the bronze helmet;
 and standing close he spoke winged words:

"Hector — now you have wholly forgotten your allies,³⁰
 who for your sake, far from their friends and their fatherland,
 540 breathe out their lives; and you will not help them.
 Sarpedon lies dead — the leader of the Lycian shield-men,
 who kept Lycia safe by his judgments and his strength:
 brazen Ares has broken him on Patroclus's spear.
 Friends, stand by him! Feel the outrage in your hearts,
 545 or the Myrmidons will strip his armor and defile his body,
 in anger for all the Danaans we have killed,
 the men our spears cut down beside the swift ships."
 So he spoke; and grief seized the Trojans, head to foot,
 unbearable, not to be borne down — for he was a stay of their city,
 550 foreigner though he was: many men had followed him,
 and he himself was their best in battle.
 They went straight for the Danaans, hot; and Hector led them,
 angered for Sarpedon. But the Achaeans were driven on
 by the shaggy heart of Patroclus, Menoetius's son:
 555 he spoke first to the two Ajaxes, eager as they already were:
 "You two Ajaxes — now let your pleasure be defense,
 the men you were among men before — or braver.
 The man lies dead who first leapt inside the wall of the Achaeans:
 Sarpedon. If only we could take him and defile him,
 560 and strip the armor from his shoulders, and break
 some companion of his defending him, with the pitiless bronze."
 So he spoke; and they themselves were furious to beat the enemy off.
 And when on both sides they had strengthened their battle-lines,
 Trojans and Lycians, Myrmidons and Achaeans,
 565 they clashed together to fight around the dead man's body
 with a terrible war-shout; and the men's armor rang loud.
 And Zeus stretched a deadly night over the strong encounter,³¹
 so that around his dear son the deadly toil of battle might be waged.
 And the Trojans at first pushed back the bright-eyed Achaeans,
 570 for a man was hit who was by no means the worst of the Myrmidons:
 brilliant Epeigeus, son of great-hearted Agacles,³²
 who was king once in well-peopled Budeum —
 before: but having killed a noble cousin,
 he came a suppliant to Peleus and silver-footed Thetis,

- 575 and they sent him to follow Achilles, breaker of men,
 to Ilion of the fine colts, to fight the Trojans.
 He was laying hold of the corpse when glorious Hector
 struck him with a stone full on the head; and the whole head split in
 two
 inside the heavy helmet; and he dropped face-first
 580 over the dead man, and death that breaks the spirit poured round him.
 And grief came over Patroclus for his fallen companion,
 and he swept straight through the front-fighters like a swift hawk
 that sends the daws and starlings scattering:
 straight so, Patroclus, master of horses, you swept
 585 at the Lycians and Trojans, with anger in your heart for your
 companion.
 And he struck Sthenelaus, Ithaemenes' dear son,
 on the neck with a stone, and tore the tendons from it;
 and the front-fighters gave ground, and glorious Hector.
 As far as the carry of a long throwing-spear
 590 a man sends flying, testing his strength in the games
 or in war, against enemies who break the spirit:
 so far the Trojans gave, and the Achaeans pushed them.
 Then Glaucus first, the leader of the Lycian shield-men,
 turned, and killed great-hearted Bathycles,
 595 the dear son of Chalcon, whose home was in Hellas —
 a man who stood out among the Myrmidons for riches and wealth:
 him Glaucus stabbed full in the chest with his spear,
 wheeling suddenly, just as the man's pursuit had caught him.
 He fell with a thud; and close grief took the Achaeans,
 600 so good a man went down; and the Trojans rejoiced greatly,
 and came and stood in a mass around him. But the Achaeans
 did not forget their courage: they carried their fury straight at them.
 Then Meriones took a Trojan fighter, helmed in bronze —
 Laogonus, daring son of Onetor, who was priest
 605 of Idaean Zeus, and honored like a god by the people:
 he struck him below the jaw, under the ear; and quickly the spirit
 went out of his limbs, and the hateful darkness took him.
 And Aeneas let fly his bronze spear at Meriones,
 hoping to catch him as he came on under his shield;

- 610 but he saw it coming and dodged the bronze spear,
 ducking forward; and behind him the long spear
 stuck fast in the ground, and the butt-end stood quivering;
 and there at last massive Ares stilled its fury —
 and the point of Aeneas's spear went quivering
 615 into the earth, hurled in vain from his massive hand.
 And Aeneas was angered at heart, and called out:
 "Meriones — dancer though you are, my spear³³
 would have stopped your dancing for good, if I had only hit you."
 And spear-famed Meriones answered him:
 620 "Aeneas — strong as you are, it is hard for you
 to quench the fury of every man who stands
 against you in defense. You too were made mortal.
 And if I hit you square in the middle with the sharp bronze,
 strong as you are, and sure of your hands, you would quickly
 625 give the triumph to me, and your soul to Hades of the famed colts."
 So he spoke; and the stout son of Menoetius rebuked him:
 "Meriones — you are a brave man: why speechify?
 Old friend, the Trojans will not back away from the corpse
 for insults. The earth will hold down some of them first.
 630 In hands lies the outcome of war; of words, in council.
 So there is no need to pile up speech, but to fight."
 So speaking he led the way, and the other followed, a man like a god.
 And from them — as the din of woodcutting men rises
 in the mountain glens, and the sound carries far:
 635 so from the wide-wayed earth their pounding rose,
 of bronze and leather and well-made oxhide shields,
 stabbed at with swords and double-curved spears.
 And by now not even a discerning man could have known
 brilliant Sarpedon, wrapped from his head clean down
 640 to the soles of his feet in missiles and blood and dust.³⁴
 And they crowded round the corpse always — as flies
 in a farmstead buzz about the brimming milk-pails
 in the season of spring, when the milk wets the vessels:
 so they crowded round the corpse. And Zeus never once
 645 turned his shining eyes away from the strong encounter,
 but gazed down at them always, and pondered in his heart,

brooding long over the killing of Patroclus:³⁵
 whether now, in the strong encounter, over godlike
 Sarpedon, glorious Hector should cut him down
 650 with the bronze, and strip the armor from his shoulders —
 or whether he should swell the sheer toil for still more men.
 And as he pondered, this seemed to him the better course:
 that the brave aide of Achilles, Peleus' son,
 should drive the Trojans and Hector of the bronze helmet
 665 back toward the city once more, and take the life from many.
 And in Hector first he put a strengthless heart:
 he climbed into his chariot and turned to flee, and called
 the other Trojans to fly; for he knew the sacred scales of Zeus.
 Then not even the powerful Lycians stood, but panicked
 660 all of them, when they saw their king struck through the heart,
 lying under the pile of dead — for many had fallen
 over him, once the son of Cronos stretched the strife taut.
 And the Achaeans stripped the armor from Sarpedon's shoulders,
 bronze and glittering; and the stout son of Menoetius
 665 gave it to his companions to carry to the hollow ships.
 And then Zeus the cloud-gatherer spoke to Apollo:³⁶
 "Up now, dear Phoebus: go cleanse Sarpedon of the dark
 clotted blood, out of the range of the missiles, and carry him
 far away, and wash him in the running river,
 670 and anoint him with ambrosia, and put immortal clothing round him;
 and send him to be carried by swift escorts,
 the twin brothers Sleep and Death, who quickly
 will set him down in the rich country of wide Lycia.
 There his brothers and kinsmen will give him burial
 675 with a tomb and a grave-stone: for that is the honor-right of the dead."
 So he spoke, and Apollo did not disobey his father,
 but went down from the mountains of Ida into the dread din,
 and at once lifted brilliant Sarpedon out of the missiles,
 and carried him far away, and washed him in the running river,
 680 and anointed him with ambrosia, and put immortal clothing round
 him;
 and he sent him to be carried by swift escorts,
 the twin brothers Sleep and Death, who quickly

set him down in the rich country of wide Lycia.
 But Patroclus, calling to his horses and Automedon,³⁷
 685 went after the Trojans and Lycians — and was greatly blinded,
 the fool: had he kept the word of Peleus' son,
 he would have escaped the evil doom of black death.
 But always the mind of Zeus is stronger than men's:
 he sends even the brave man running, and strips away victory
 690 easily — and then again himself drives a man to fight;
 and it was he who now put the fury in Patroclus's chest.
 Then whom first, whom last did you strip of his arms,
 Patroclus, when the gods were calling you deathward?
 Adrestus first, and Autonus, and Echeclus,
 695 and Perimus, Megas's son, and Epistor, and Melanippus,
 and after them Elasmus, and Mulus, and Pylartes:
 these he took; and the rest were each man minded to run.
 And then the sons of the Achaeans would have taken high-gated Troy
 by the hands of Patroclus — such was his raging spear-charge —
 700 had not Phoebus Apollo taken his stand on the well-built tower,
 with deadly thoughts for him, siding with the Trojans.
 Three times Patroclus set his foot on the angle of the high wall,
 and three times Apollo slapped him back and away,
 thrusting at the shining shield with his immortal hands.
 705 But when for the fourth time he came on like more than man,
 the god shouted terribly, and spoke winged words:
 "Back, Zeus-sprung Patroclus! It is not your portion
 that the proud Trojans' city fall to your spear —
 no, nor to Achilles', who is a far better man than you."
 710 So he spoke; and Patroclus gave back a long way,
 dodging the wrath of Apollo who strikes from afar.
 But Hector held his whole-hoofed horses at the Scaean Gates,
 divided: whether to drive back into the confusion and fight,
 or shout for the army to gather inside the wall.
 715 And as he pondered, Phoebus Apollo came and stood by him³⁸
 in the likeness of a man young and strong,
 Asius — the uncle of horse-taming Hector,
 own brother of Hecuba, and son of Dymas,
 who lived in Phrygia on the streams of Sangarius;

- 720 in his likeness Apollo, son of Zeus, spoke to him:
 "Hector, why have you dropped out of the fighting? It is not right.
 Would that I were as much stronger than you as I am weaker:
 then you would soon and bitterly regret this skulking from the war.
 Come — drive your strong-hoofed horses at Patroclus,
 725 and you may take him yet, and Apollo hand you the glory."
 So speaking, the god went back into the toil of men;
 and glorious Hector ordered war-minded Cebriones
 to lash the horses into the battle. And Apollo
 sank into the crowd, and hurled an evil rout
 730 among the Argives, and handed glory to the Trojans and Hector.
 And Hector let the other Danaans be — killed none of them —
 but drove his strong-hoofed horses straight at Patroclus;
 and Patroclus, facing him, sprang from his chariot to the ground
 with his spear in his left hand; and in the other he caught up a stone,
 735 jagged marble, glittering — his hand just closed around it —
 and planted himself and hurled it, not shrinking long from the man;
 and his missile was not wasted: he struck Hector's charioteer —³⁹
 Cebriones, a bastard son of far-famed Priam —
 with the reins in his hands, full on the forehead with the sharp stone.
 740 The stone crushed both brows together; the bone did not hold;
 and his eyes dropped to the ground in the dust
 there at his feet; and like a diver he plunged
 from the well-wrought chariot, and the life left his bones.
 And mocking him you spoke, Patroclus, horseman:
 745 "Well, well — how nimble the man is! What easy tumbling!
 If ever he found himself on the fish-teeming sea,
 this man could feed a whole crew, diving for oysters,
 leaping overboard even in rough weather —
 as easily as he tumbles now from his chariot onto the plain.
 750 So: there are acrobats among the Trojans too."
 So speaking he went for the hero Cebriones
 with the spring of a lion who, ravaging the farmsteads,
 has been struck in the chest — and his own courage kills him:
 so, Patroclus, you leapt on Cebriones, blazing.
 755 And Hector on the other side sprang from his chariot to the ground;
 and the two fought over Cebriones like two lions

- that on a mountain's peaks, over a slain hind,
 both of them hungry, fight with towering hearts:
 so over Cebriones the two masters of the war-shout,
 760 Patroclus, Menoetius's son, and glorious Hector,
 strained to hew each other's flesh with the pitiless bronze.
 Hector had him by the head, and would not let go;
 Patroclus, opposite, held a foot; and around them the rest,
 Trojans and Danaans, joined the strong encounter.
- 765 As the East Wind and the South contend with one another⁴⁰
 in the mountain glens, to shake the deep timber —
 oak and ash and smooth-barked cornel-tree,
 that hurl their long slim branches each against each
 with a prodigious noise, and the crash of them breaking:
- 770 so Trojans and Achaeans, springing at one another,
 cut men down, and neither side thought of ruinous flight.
 And around Cebriones many sharp spears stood fixed,
 and winged arrows leaping from the bowstrings,
 and many great stones battered against the shields
- 775 of the men fighting round him. And he in the whirl of dust
 lay mighty in his mightiness, his horsemanship all forgotten.
 So long as the sun bestrode the middle heaven,⁴¹
 so long the missiles of both sides struck home, and the people fell;
 but when the sun turned toward the unyoking of oxen,
- 780 then, beyond their portion, the Achaeans proved the stronger.
 They dragged the hero Cebriones out of the missiles,
 out of the Trojans' clamor, and stripped the armor from his shoulders;
 and Patroclus, with evil intent for the Trojans, charged them.
 Three times he charged then, the equal of swift Ares,
- 785 screaming terribly, and three times he killed nine men.
 But when for the fourth time he came on like more than man —
 then, Patroclus, the end of your life showed clear:
 for Phoebus met you in the strong encounter,
 terrible. And Patroclus did not see him coming through the confusion,
- 790 for he came against him wrapped in thick mist,
 and stood behind him, and struck his back and broad shoulders
 with the flat of his hand; and his eyes spun.
 And Phoebus Apollo knocked the helmet from his head:⁴²

it rolled ringing away beneath the horses' hooves,
 795 the socketed helmet, and the plumes were fouled
 with blood and dust. Before this it was not lawful
 for that horsehair-crested helmet to be fouled with dust:
 it guarded the head and the gracious brow of a godlike
 man, Achilles. But then Zeus gave it to Hector
 800 to wear on his own head; and his destruction was near him.
 And the long-shadowed spear was shattered whole in his hands,
 heavy, huge, compact, helmeted in bronze; and from his shoulders
 the fringed shield with its baldric dropped to the ground;
 and the lord Apollo, son of Zeus, loosed the corslet off him.
 805 Blindness took his mind; his shining limbs were unstrung;
 he stood dazed. And from behind, at close range, a Dardanian
 struck him with a sharp spear between the shoulders:
 Euphorbus, Panthous's son, who outshone all men of his age⁴³
 at the spear, at horsemanship, and in the race on foot;
 810 indeed he had already brought down twenty men from their horses,
 though he came the first time with his chariot, still learning war.
 He it was who first sent a missile into you, Patroclus, horseman,
 and did not break you; and he ran back and merged with the crowd,
 snatching the ash spear out of the wound — he did not stand
 815 against Patroclus, even unarmed as he was, in the combat.
 And Patroclus, broken by the god's blow and the spear,
 drew back into the band of his companions, dodging doom.
 But Hector, when he saw great-hearted Patroclus
 drawing back, wounded by the sharp bronze,
 820 came close on him through the ranks, and stabbed with his spear
 into the pit of his belly, and drove the bronze clean through:
 he fell with a thud, and hugely grieved the Achaean army.
 As a lion overpowers a tireless boar in combat⁴⁴
 when the two fight, towering-hearted, on a mountain's peaks
 825 over a little spring, both set on drinking,
 and the lion by main strength breaks the boar as he gasps:
 so the son of Menoetius, killer of many, was robbed
 of his life at close quarters by Hector, Priam's son, with the spear;
 and vaunting over him Hector spoke winged words:
 830 "Patroclus — no doubt you said you would raze our city,

- and take from the women of Troy the day of freedom,
and carry them off in your ships to your dear fatherland —
fool! Before them the swift horses of Hector
stride full-stretch to the fighting; and I with my spear
- 835 am chosen out among the war-loving Trojans, I who beat off
the day of necessity for them. But you — the vultures will eat you here.
Poor wretch: not even Achilles, brave as he is, was any use to you,
who stayed behind, I suppose, and gave you strict orders as you left:
'Do not come back to me, Patroclus, master of horses,
- 840 back to the hollow ships, before you have torn the bloody
tunic around the chest of man-slaughtering Hector.'
So he must have talked to you — and persuaded your witless heart."
And with the little strength left you, you answered, Patroclus,
horseman:
"Boast your fill now, Hector. Yours is the victory — ⁴⁵
- 845 given by Zeus, the son of Cronos, and by Apollo: they broke me
easily; for they themselves took the armor from my shoulders.
Twenty men like you could have come against me,
and all of them would have died here, broken under my spear.
No — deadly fate has killed me, and Leto's son,
- 850 and of men, Euphorbus. You are only the third at my stripping.
And I will tell you another thing — lay it away in your mind:
you yourself have no long life left. Already
death stands close beside you, and fate the overpowering:
you will be broken under the hands of Achilles, Aeacus' blameless son."
- 855 Even as he spoke, the end that is death covered him;
and his soul, flying from his limbs, went down to the house of Hades,
wailing its fate, leaving its manhood and its youth.
And glorious Hector spoke to him — though he was dead:
"Patroclus — why prophesy my sheer destruction?
- 860 Who knows whether Achilles, the son of lovely-haired Thetis,
may not be hit first by my spear, and lose his own life?"
So speaking, he set his heel on him and drew the bronze spear
out of the wound, and shoved him backward off the spear.
And at once he went with the spear after Automedon,
865 the godlike aide of the swift-footed son of Aeacus —
hot to strike him; but the swift horses carried him away,

the immortal horses the gods gave Peleus as shining gifts.

NOTES TO BOOK 16

- 1 ll. 2-11 Patroclus's tears reuse Agamemnon's simile from 9.14-15, our English kept — "like a spring of dark water that pours its black stream down a goat-proof cliff": the general wept so for his army's ruin; the friend weeps so for the same army now. Achilles answers with the poem's tenderest teasing: the little girl running at her mother's skirt, begging to be carried — mockery whose every detail is affection, and whose image (the child who will not be put down until she is lifted) is exactly what Patroclus is about to ask for and receive.
- 2 l. 20 "you answered, Patroclus, horseman" — the narrator's apostrophe, used of Patroclus eight times in this book (20, 584-587, 693-695, 744-746, 754-756, 787-789, 812-814, 843-845) — far more than anyone else receives in the whole poem (elsewhere chiefly Menelaus). The grammar itself breaks neutrality: the singer cannot keep the third person for this man. Antiquity already read the device as pathos; nothing else in the Iliad marks a character as loved by the poem itself.
- 3 ll. 29-35 "you and your cursed valor" — αἰναρέτη, a word invented for this line (excellence-in-disaster, valor that curses); then the great disowning: "the horseman Peleus was no father of yours, nor Thetis your mother — the grey sea bore you, and the sheer cliffs." The gentlest man in the poem delivers its harshest genealogy (he had feared to hear a smaller version at 11.654); Patroclus's twin charges — pitiless (νηλεές) and unbending (ἀπηνής) — are the exact vocabulary the poem will need again for Achilles in Book 24.
- 4 ll. 36-47 The plan repeats Nestor's lines (11.794-803) nearly verbatim, our English kept — the fatal scheme now carried by its victim, in the first person ("send me out... give me your own armor"). The narrator's seal, before Achilles can answer: "So he spoke, begging — the great fool (μέγα νήπιος): it was his own death and evil doom he was begging for." The poem's strongest use of its fool-formula: not blindness to a detail, but a prayer with its object inverted.
- 5 ll. 49-63 Achilles denies the prophecy excuse — no oracle, nothing from his mother (though 9.410-416 told us of the two fates; the poem lets the contradiction stand as suppression rather than ignorance) — and restates the grievance in the quarrel's oldest words: the prize taken back "as though I were some vagrant without rights" (ἀτίμητον μετανάστην, the phrase of 9.648). Then the concession that has already expired: "I said I would not lay my wrath aside until the war-shout reached my own ships" — it has; the fire is minutes away.
- 6 ll. 64-96 The conditions. Drive them from the ships; win me honor so they return the girl "and bring shining gifts besides" (the Book 9 offer, still wanted — the wrath's economy intact); and then the double interdiction: come back; do not lead toward Ilion, "one of the everlasting gods may step in — the worker-from-afar, Apollo, loves them dearly." Achilles speaks his friend's actual death as a hypothesis, naming the god. Zenodotus

compressed 93-96 into a single line ("lest Hector of the flashing helmet catch you stripped bare") — tidier, and deaf to the point: the danger Achilles fears is not a man.

- 7 *ll. 97-100* The prayer that ends the speech: may every Trojan die, and every Argive, "and that we two alone might slip destruction, so that alone we might undo Troy's holy coronal of towers." Zenodotus and Aristarchus athetized the lines (Aristarchus noting that Zenodotus "suspected" them — ancient readers already heard how much the wish contains). It is the wrath's logical terminus: the army abolished, the war reduced to the two of them — spoken to the man whose death will prove they were never separable from the rest.
- 8 *ll. 102-111* Ajax's last stand at the ship, told in pure physiology: the helmet ringing "struck and struck again," the left shoulder aching under the shield, the gasping, the sweat that "could nowhere catch its breath" — and the summary line ancient critics loved to quote: "everywhere evil was propped on evil" (κακὸν κακῷ ἐστήρικτο). The bravest man in the army is described entirely from inside his fatigue.
- 9 *ll. 112-124* The fixed Muse-invocation (= 2.484) — summoned not for a catalogue but for a single fact: "how the fire first fell on the ships." This is the flare Zeus has waited for since 15.599-600. Hector shears the head off Ajax's ash spear — the docked shaft brandished "useless in his hand" — and Ajax reads the theology correctly and withdraws; the flame pours over Protesilaus's ship (the war's first casualty again, 15.705); and Achilles, watching, sees exactly what Zeus sees, and slaps his thighs: "Up, Zeus-sprung Patroclus!" One ship burns for one book: the pivot's mechanism, precise as a clock.
- 10 *ll. 131-145* The arming — the register's standard sequence (greaves, corslet, sword, shield, helmet, spears) with one exception the poem underlines: "only the spear he did not take of Aeacus' blameless son... the Pelian ash that Chiron gave his dear father from the peak of Pelion, to be death for heroes." No other Achaean can even swing it. Zenodotus omitted the lines; they are the scene's whole meaning: the disguise is complete except for the one thing that is Achilles — and the poem measures Patroclus by the weapon he cannot lift, exactly as it will measure Hector by the armor he cannot fill.
- 11 *ll. 145-155* The team: Xanthus and Balius, foaled by the harpy Podarge to the West Wind in the meadow by Ocean — wind-grandsons; and in the side-traces "blameless Pedasus," the war-prize from Eëtion's city, "who, mortal as he was, kept pace with immortal horses." The poem builds the team as it built the expedition: an immortal pair with one mortal running beside them, keeping up. The trace-horse's death (467-471) is the book's first fatality among Achilles' own.
- 12 *ll. 156-164* The Myrmidon wolf simile — the pack at its most physical in Homer: raw flesh, muzzles red, "belching up clotted gore," the thin tongues lapping black spring-water, bellies stretched and hearts still fearless. The dark spring of Patroclus's tears (3-4) returns as the wolves' watering hole: the book's imagery runs on dark water.
- 13 *ll. 168-198* The Catalogue of Myrmidons: fifty ships, fifty men each, five battalions — a miniature of Book 2, complete with erotic biographies. Menesthius, son of the river Spercheius by Peleus's daughter Polydora ("though in name" a mortal's son — the double-paternity formula); and Eudorus, the παρθένιος, born of Hermes' love for Polymele, seen dancing in Artemis's choir — seduction, secret bed, bride-price,

grandfather's rearing: a complete romance in twelve lines. Phoenix (Book 9's tutor) commands the fourth battalion; Alcimedon (who will matter at 17.466ff) the fifth. The muster the wrath had parked since Book 2 stands up again.

- 14 *ll. 200-210* Achilles quotes his own army's grumbling back at them — "Cruel son of Peleus — your mother reared you on bile... Let us at least sail home" — the only place we hear the Myrmidons' opinion of the wrath, and it matches Patroclus's ("pitiless," "cruel"). Achilles repeats it without rebuttal and points them at the work: the speech of a commander who knows exactly what has been said of him and considers the account now settled.
- 15 *ll. 212-218* The wall-builder simile (close-set stones against the wind) introduces the phalanx lines repeated from 13.131-133, our English kept: "buckler pressed on buckler, helmet on helmet, man on man." There the formation was defensive despair; here it is an offensive spring compressed — the same order, opposite potential energy.
- 16 *ll. 220-233* The cup: from the chest Thetis packed — the poem's one glimpse of a mother provisioning her son for war (tunics, wind-proof cloaks, rugs) — a cup reserved for one man and one god: "no other man drank from it, and to no god did he pour from it, except to Zeus the father." Sulphur, clean water, washed hands: the private liturgy of a prince who deals with heaven bilaterally. No other hero in the poem has a personal cult protocol.
- 17 *ll. 233-248* The Dodona prayer: "Zeus — lord — Dodonaean — Pelasgian — dweller far off" — the oldest oracle in Greece (Herodotus agrees), with its astonishing priesthood: "the Selloi, your interpreters, men of unwashed feet, who sleep on the ground" — holiness as permanent contact with the earth (ancient scholars debated Selloi/Helloi, whence "Hellenes"). Achilles prays past every Olympian courtesy to something older and darker than Olympus, in the correct contract-form ("Once before, when I prayed, you heard my word") — the Book 1 plague answered him; now he asks the second favor: glory for Patroclus, and his safe return "with all his armor, and his close-fighting companions."
- 18 *ll. 249-253* "And the father granted him one thing, and refused the other." The poem's most economical sentence of doom: prayer processed as paperwork, one clause approved, one denied, no notification issued. Achilles will stand at his hut believing both clauses filed.
- 19 *ll. 259-267* The wasp simile — with the poet's editorial inside it: boys provoke the roadside nest "as boys will, the little fools: they make a common evil for many." The second child-image of the day's fighting (the sand-castle god, 15.362); this one indicts the war itself — someone poked the nest, and the passer-by gets stung. The Myrmidons ("ant-men" by folk-etymology) fight under insect colors: wasps, then flies (641-644).
- 20 *ll. 269-283* Patroclus's field-speech turns the private grievance public: fight "so that Atreus' son... may know his blindness (ἄτην), that he honored not at all the best of the Achaeans" — the register's ἄτη, deployed by the wrath's gentlest partisan. And the disguise works precisely once, in the aggregate: the Trojans do not identify the man; they identify the armor and infer the reconciliation — "each man looked about him for escape from sheer destruction." The armor is the argument.

- 21 ll. 287-305 Pyraechmes of the Paeonians — mustered at 2.848 with the same river-formula ("out of Amydon, from the wide- flowing Axios") — is the first kill, and the tactical one: the fire is quenched, "and the ship was left there, half- burnt" (ἡμιδαής, a word occurring nowhere else — the poem coins a term for its own precise scorch-line). The clearing simile that follows — Zeus moving one cloud off a peak, "and the prodigious upper air breaks open from heaven" — measures the relief exactly: light, but "no pause in the war."
- 22 ll. 317-330 The sons of Nestor kill the sons of Amisodarus — "the man who reared the raging Chimaera": the monster of Bellerophon's tale (6.179-183) resurfaces as someone's livestock, one genealogical step from the battlefield. The paired-brothers kill (Antilochus and Thrasymedes against Atymnius and Maris) is the book's small mirror of its great theme: companionship as a fighting unit.
- 23 ll. 364-394 The rout at the ditch — Hector's horses carry him clear while the army snaps its chariot-poles behind him — rises into the great storm simile of divine justice: Zeus's worst autumn deluge falls "when in rage he turns bitter against men who by force render crooked judgments in the assembly and drive justice out, careless of the gods' vengeance." Nowhere else does the Iliad's Zeus mind human justice at all — this is the Zeus of Hesiod's Works and Days, surfacing for nine lines to make the routed army's panic a moral weather. That the flood "diminishes the works of men" while the crooked judges sit indoors is the simile's quiet sting.
- 24 ll. 399-419 The angler: Thestor, huddled witless in his chariot, is hooked through the jaw and hauled "gaping" over the rail "as a man sitting on a jutting rock hauls a sacred fish out of the sea with his line and his glittering bronze." The most horrifying transformation in the poem's killing- repertoire — a man landed as a catch — done with a fisherman's leisure. ("Sacred fish": ancient guesses ranged from a species to a fish grown temple-fat; the adjective's unplaceability is half its power.) Then the nine-name sweep, "in heaps, to the earth that feeds so many."
- 25 ll. 419-461 Sarpedon sees his "companions of the unbelted tunics" (the Lycians' native dress, without the Greek war- belt) going down, and the poem mounts its highest scene: Zeus asks Hera whether he may save his son. Her answer is the constitution of the poem's universe: "Do it. But we other gods will not all approve... many sons of the immortals are fighting around the great city of Priam" — fate as the equality of bereavement; if one father cheats, all may. The compromise she offers becomes the poem's tenderest machinery: Death and painless Sleep to carry him home, "with a tomb and a grave-stone: for that is the honor-right of the dead" (τὸ γὰρ γέρας ἐστὶ θανόντων — γέρας, the quarrel's own word for honor's portion, given its final meaning). Zeus consents and "rained down drops of blood upon the earth, honoring his dear son": the sky's grief, the blood-dew of 11.53 made personal. Zenodotus struck the entire dialogue out (432-458) — deleting the theology of the poem to spare Zeus the tears.
- 26 ll. 462-477 The duel's first exchange kills an aide and a horse: Sarpedon's miss finds Pedasus, and the mortal trace- horse "screamed away his life" — the poem's only equine casualty, and the death that previews everything: the mortal yoked beside immortals dies; the immortal pair tangle and rear; and it takes Automedon's sword — cutting the dead weight loose — to right the team. The allegory is left entirely to the reader.

- 27 *ll. 477-507* Sarpedon falls with the shipwright simile repeated from 13.389-391 (our English kept) — Asius's death- tree now felling the man whose Book 12 speech justified every death in the poem — and then the bellowing bull under the lion. His dying speech is not of Lycia, wife, or son, but of the body and the shame-economy: "I will be your disgrace and your hanging head all your days... if the Achaeans strip my armor here." Patroclus's extraction of the spear is the grimmest anatomical clause in Homer: "he pulled out his life and the spear-point together" — the midriff following the bronze, soul and weapon in one motion.
- 28 *ll. 508-533* Glaucus's prayer pays off the wound Teucer dealt him at 12.387-391 (concealed then; crippling now) and briefly indicts heaven itself: "the best of men has perished — Sarpedon, son of Zeus; and Zeus does not defend even his own child." Apollo — hearer "everywhere" of "a man in grief" — stills the pain and dries the blood: the god acting in his oldest capacity, healer, minutes before he acts in his darkest.
- 29 *ll. 538-553* Glaucus's rebuke of Hector states the allied grievance (men dying "far from their friends and their fatherland" for a city not theirs) and the city's debt: Sarpedon "kept Lycia safe by his judgments and his strength" — δίκησι, the justice-word, in the obituary of the man the justice-storm (385-393) did not protect. The Trojan grief- line is the poem's tribute to the foreigner: "he was a stay of their city, foreigner though he was."
- 30 *ll. 567-570* Zeus stretches "a deadly night over the strong encounter, so that around his dear son the deadly toil of battle might be waged" — darkness as paternal mourning-veil, the counterpart of the blood-rain: the god cannot save him, so he dims the lights over the body.
- 31 *ll. 570-582* — see note [32].
- 32 *ll. 570-607* The battle over the body opens with Epeigeus: once a king in Budeum, then a cousin-killer, then a suppliant of Peleus and Thetis, then Achilles' man, now dead across Sarpedon's corpse — the third homicide-exile biography in four books (Medon, Lycophron), and the closest to Patroclus's own (23.85-90). The Myrmidon court at Phthia absorbs killers and re-employs them; the poem keeps burying them in order. Bathycles (richest of the Myrmidons) and Laogonus (priest of Idaean Zeus) follow — wealth and priesthood, the two exemptions that never exempt.
- 33 *ll. 617-633* The dancer taunt: Aeneas mocks Meriones' dodge as Cretan dancing (Crete's dancers were proverbial); Meriones answers with mortality-arithmetic; and Patroclus's rebuke closes the exchange with the poem's own poetics of action: "In hands lies the outcome of war; of words, in council. So there is no need to pile up speech, but to fight." The gentlest speaker in the epic states the genre's law — battle is not a debate — and the poem, which loves its taunts, lets him.
- 34 *ll. 633-646* The signature of this battle: Sarpedon's body made anonymous — "not even a discerning man could have known brilliant Sarpedon, wrapped from his head clean down to the soles of his feet in missiles and blood and dust" — while around it the armies cluster "as flies in a farmstead buzz about the brimming milk-pails in the season of spring." Homer dares the smallest, homeliest life against the largest death: spring,

milk, plenty — and men as flies. The corpse the flies swarm cannot be told from the field it lies on; Apollo's bath (note [36]) exists to reverse exactly this.

- 35 *ll. 644-660* Zeus's gaze never leaves the fight, "brooding long over the killing of Patroclus: whether now... or whether he should swell the sheer toil for still more men." The decision — more — is mercy indistinguishable from sentence: the extra hour of glory is granted the way the prayer was half-granted (note [18]). Hector's panic is knowledge: "he knew the sacred scales of Zeus" — the balance of 8.69 and 22.209 felt from inside, tipping.
- 36 *ll. 666-683* The funeral of Sarpedon: Apollo lifts him from the missiles, washes him in the running river, anoints him with ambrosia, wraps him in immortal clothes, and gives him to "the twin brothers Sleep and Death" for the journey home to Lycia — Zeus's orders repeated in execution almost word for word, as the poem's rituals must be. Zenodotus athetized the whole passage; against him stand the gentlest lines any death receives in the Iliad — and the scene's afterlife: on the Euphronios krater (Athens, c. 515 BC), winged Sleep and Death lift the bleeding Sarpedon while Hermes watches — the single most famous painted image of the Iliad in ancient art. The promise of 14.231 ("Sleep, the brother of Death") completes itself: the pair Hera bribed with a Grace now carry her rival's son to burial. What the honor-right of the dead looks like, the poem shows once, here, done by gods.
- 37 *ll. 684-711* The turn: "the fool (νήπιος): had he kept the word of Peleus' son, he would have escaped the evil doom of black death. But always the mind of Zeus is stronger than men's." The apostrophized roll-call follows ("whom first, whom last did you strip of his arms, Patroclus, when the gods were calling you deathward?" — the fixed register question turned, for the first time, on the poem's beloved), then the thrice-and-fourth at the wall's very angle — Apollo slapping the shield back with immortal hands — and the warning that grades all mortals in one line: not your portion, "no, nor Achilles", who is a far better man than you." Patroclus backs off "dodging the wrath of Apollo" — μήνιν, the poem's title- word, now the god's.
- 38 *ll. 712-726* Apollo as Asius — Hecuba's brother, the third bearer of the name (the doomed captain of Book 12-13; the disguise of Book 10's era) — turns Hector around with a taunt at his skulking. The god who has just saved the wall now aims its defender at Patroclus: the same power working both sides of the same death.
- 39 *ll. 726-752* Cebriones: the stone crushes both brows, "and his eyes dropped to the ground in the dust there at his feet; and like a diver he plunged" — the diver of 12.385 (our phrase kept), now with the eyes watching from the ground. Patroclus's mock-eulogy — the oyster-diver who "could feed a whole crew... even in rough weather... there are acrobats among the Trojans too" — is the war's blackest comedy, and its placement is the point: the poem's kindest man, one god-blow from death, is granted the gallows-wit of the doomed. He has become, for thirty lines, Achilles.
- 40 *ll. 756-778* Over the body: Hector by the head, Patroclus by the foot — the tug-of-war of the whole poem in one grip — while East and South Wind thrash the mountain timber overhead. And beneath it, the line that outlives the battle: Cebriones "in the whirl of dust lay mighty in his mightiness, his horsemanship all forgotten" (κεῖτο μέγας

μεγαλωσί, λελασμένος ἵπποσυνάων). The Odyssey will use the verse of Achilles himself (24.39-40): the poem's ultimate epitaph, first spent on a charioteer.

- 41 ll. 777-790 The clock: sun at mid-heaven, stalemate; sun at "the unyoking of oxen," and the Achaeans prevail "beyond their portion" (ὕπερ αἴσαν — the day's ration of fate overdrawn). Thrice nine men fall; the fourth rush comes "like more than man" (δαίμονι ἴσος — the register phrase, twice in this book); "then, Patroclus, the end of your life showed clear." The formula-system itself has been counting: three-and-the-fourth is the poem's rhythm of trespass (5.436-439, 16.702-705), and the fourth time always finds the god.
- 42 ll. 790-807 The un-arming. Apollo, wrapped in mist, strikes the flat-handed blow — the only time a god personally strikes a mortal dead-on in the poem — and then dismantles the arming scene of 131-139 in reverse: helmet rolling under the hooves ("Before this it was not lawful for that horsehair-crested helmet to be fouled with dust: it guarded the head and the gracious brow of a godlike man, Achilles. But then Zeus gave it to Hector to wear on his own head; and his destruction was near him" — the armor-transfer chain announced with its invoice attached); the spear shattered — the one he could carry; the shield down; "and the lord Apollo, son of Zeus, loosed the corslet off him." A god undresses the man for death. ἄτη — blindness — takes his wits; he stands dazed, naked in the crowd: the poem's most terrifying image of what it is to lose divine favor — not to be struck, but to be unwrapped.
- 43 ll. 806-817 Euphorbus: the beautiful new fighter — best of his age with spear, horse, and foot, twenty men down in his first campaign, "still learning war" — spears the dazed man from behind and runs, "and did not stand against Patroclus, even unarmed as he was." He will die for it at 17.9-60, where his blood wets hair "like the Graces'." Fame followed him strangely: Pythagoras claimed Euphorbus's soul as a former life of his own, and proved it (the story goes) by recognizing the shield Menelaus took, hung in Hera's temple — the poem's minor duelist became antiquity's test-case for transmigration.
- 44 ll. 818-844 Hector, third, into the belly. His vaunt invents a quotation — Achilles supposedly ordering Patroclus not to return "before you have torn the bloody tunic around the chest of man-slaughtering Hector... So he must have talked to you" — the exact inversion of the truth we heard (87-96: come back; avoid the wall; fear Apollo). Hector's tragedy is compressed into his reconstruction of an order that was its opposite: he cannot imagine the restraint that was Achilles' actual love, and so misreads the man he must soon face.
- 45 ll. 843-869 The dying prophecy: "You are only the third at my stripping" — the killers ranked (fate and Apollo; of men, Euphorbus; Hector last), the boast priced ("twenty men like you"), and then the forward sentence: "Already death stands close beside you... you will be broken under the hands of Achilles." The soul-flight couplet — "his soul, flying from his limbs, went down to the house of Hades, wailing its fate, leaving its manhood and its youth" — recurs verbatim at 22.361-363 for Hector himself: reuse this English there; the two deaths are one sentence spoken twice (Plutarch and Athenaeus were still quoting it). Hector answers the corpse — "Who knows whether Achilles... may not be hit first by my spear?" — hope addressed to a dead prophet; then the heel, the spear withdrawn, and the lunge for Automedon, foiled by the book's last image: "the swift

ILIAD — BOOK 16

horses carried him away, the immortal horses the gods gave Peleus as shining gifts." The gods' wedding-present outruns the man wearing the gods' other gift; Book 17 opens over the body.

Iliad — Book 17

*The fight over the body of Patroclus; Hector puts on Achilles' armor;
Achilles' immortal horses weep for the dead.*

- Nor did it escape Atreus' son, Menelaus dear to Ares,
that Patroclus had been broken by Trojans in the combat.
He came through the front-fighters helmed in blazing bronze
and stood over the body — as a mother-cow, lowing,
5 stands over her first calf, who never knew birth before:¹
so tawny-haired Menelaus stood over Patroclus.
He held his spear before him, and his shield, balanced every way,
hot to kill whatever man might come against him.
Nor was Panthous's son of the good ash spear careless
10 of blameless Patroclus fallen: he came and stood
close by, and spoke to Menelaus dear to Ares:
"Son of Atreus — Zeus-nurtured Menelaus, marshal of the people —
give way: leave the body; let the bloody spoils be.
For no man of the Trojans or their famed allies
15 hit Patroclus with the spear in the strong encounter before me:²
so let me take my good fame among the Trojans,
or I will strike you and take your honey-sweet life."
Then, deeply angered, tawny-haired Menelaus answered him:
"Father Zeus — how ugly a thing is arrogant boasting!
20 Not the leopard's fury is so great, nor the lion's,
nor the murderous wild boar's — whose heart in his chest
is the biggest of all, glorying in his strength —
as the pride of the sons of Panthous with their good ash spears.
Yet the strength of Hyperenor, breaker of horses, had no joy
25 of his youth, when he mocked me and stood against me
and called me the sorriest fighter of the Danaans:
I say his own feet never carried him home
to delight his dear wife and his devoted parents.
Just so, I promise you, I will unstring your strength, if you stand
30 against me. Go back into the crowd — that is my counsel —
and do not stand against me, before some evil

- takes you. When the thing is done, even the fool learns."
 So he spoke, and did not persuade him; and he answered:
 "Now, Zeus-nurtured Menelaus, now you will pay in full³
 35 for my brother, whom you killed — and boast of it in speeches —
 whose wife you widowed in the depth of her new bridal chamber,
 who brought his parents cursed mourning and grief.
 I could be some stay of weeping for those unhappy two
 if I brought back your head and your armor
 40 and laid them in the hands of Panthous and brilliant Phrontis.
 But not for long shall the labor go untried between us,
 and unfought — whether it end in courage or in flight."
 So speaking, he stabbed at the shield, balanced every way;
 but the bronze did not break through: the point bent back
 45 in the strong shield. And second, with the bronze,
 rose Atreus' son Menelaus, with a prayer to Zeus the father:
 as Euphorbus drew back, he stabbed the base of his throat,
 and leaned into the thrust, trusting his heavy hand;
 and clean through the soft neck the point ran out.
 50 He fell with a thud, and his armor clattered upon him.
 His hair was soaked with blood — hair like the Graces',⁴
 and the braids pinched tight in gold and silver.
 As a man rears a flourishing olive sapling
 in a lonely place, where water wells up in plenty —
 55 a fair shoot, and a thriving; and the breathing of every
 wind rocks it, and it breaks thick with white blossom;
 but suddenly a wind comes with a great squall
 and wrenches it out of its trench and lays it flat on the earth:
 such was Panthous's son of the good ash spear, Euphorbus,
 60 when Atreus' son Menelaus killed him, and set to stripping his armor.
 And as when some mountain-bred lion, sure of his strength,⁵
 snatches from a grazing herd the finest heifer:
 her neck he breaks first, seizing it in his strong teeth,
 and then he gulps down the blood and all the inward parts,
 65 rending her; and around him the dogs and the herdsmen
 raise clamor upon clamor — from a distance: they have no will
 to go against him, for green fear has hold of them:
 so the heart in the chest of not one of them dared

to go against glorious Menelaus.

70 And now Atreus' son would easily have carried off the famed armor
of Panthous's son, had not Phoebus Apollo grudged it,
and roused Hector against him, the equal of swift Ares,
in the likeness of a man, Mentès, leader of the Cicones;
and speaking winged words he addressed him:

75 "Hector — you are running now, chasing what cannot be caught:⁶
the horses of the war-minded son of Aeacus. They are hard
for mortal men to break or to drive,
for any man but Achilles, whom an immortal mother bore.
And meanwhile Menelaus, warlike son of Atreus,
80 standing over Patroclus, has killed the best of the Trojans —
Panthous's son Euphorbus — and stopped his rushing courage."
So speaking, the god went back into the toil of men;
and terrible grief packed Hector's darkened heart.
He peered along the ranks, and knew at once

85 the one man stripping the famed armor, the other lying
on the ground, the blood running from the open wound.
He came through the front-fighters helmed in blazing bronze,
screaming sharp, like the unquenchable flame
of Hephaestus. And his sharp cry did not escape Atreus' son;
90 troubled, he spoke to his own great-hearted spirit:

"Ah me — if I abandon the fine armor,
and Patroclus, who lies here for the sake of my honor,
I fear any Danaan who sees it will call it my disgrace.
But if, in shame, I fight Hector and the Trojans

95 alone — I fear the many will surround me, one man:
Hector of the flashing helmet is leading all of them here.
But why does my own heart argue these things with me?
When a man wills, against the god's face, to fight a man
whom a god honors — a great woe rolls down on him quickly.

100 So no Danaan who sees me give way before Hector
will call it my disgrace: he fights out of heaven.
But if I could only hear Ajax of the great war-cry —
the two of us together might go back and remember our war-craft,
even against the god's face, and haul the body clear
105 for Achilles, Peleus' son. Of evils, that would be best."

- While he was turning this over in mind and heart,
 the Trojan battle-lines came on; and Hector led them.
 And he gave ground backward, and left the body,
 turning again and again — like a bearded lion⁷
- 110 that dogs and men drive off from the fold
 with spears and shouting: the brave heart in his chest
 goes stiff with the cold, and unwilling he leaves the yard:
 so tawny-haired Menelaus went from Patroclus.
 He turned and stood, when he reached the band of his companions,
- 115 peering everywhere for great Ajax, Telamon's son;
 and he saw him quickly, on the far left of the whole battle,
 heartening his companions and driving them to fight,
 for Phoebus Apollo had thrown unearthly panic among them.
 He set off at a run, and stood by him at once, and spoke:
- 120 "Ajax — this way, old friend! Let us hurry for dead Patroclus,
 and see if we can bring the body at least to Achilles —
 naked: for Hector of the flashing helmet has the armor."
 So he spoke, and stirred the heart in war-minded Ajax,
 and he came through the front-fighters, and with him tawny-haired
 Menelaus.
- 125 Hector, when he had stripped Patroclus of the famed armor,
 was dragging him, to shear the head from the shoulders with the sharp
 bronze⁸
 and haul the body off and give it to the dogs of Troy.
 But Ajax came up close, carrying his shield like a tower,
 and Hector drew back into the band of his companions
- 130 and sprang into his chariot; and he gave the fine armor
 to Trojans to carry to the city, to be his own great glory.
 And Ajax covered Menoetius's son with his broad shield
 and stood — as a lion stands over his young,⁹
 a lion leading his cubs, when hunting men come on him
- 135 in the timber: he glories in his strength,
 and draws the whole scowl of his brows down over his eyes:
 so Ajax bestrode the hero Patroclus.
 And on the other side Atreus' son, Menelaus dear to Ares,
 stood fast, nursing great grief in his chest.
- 140 Then Glaucus, Hippolochus's son, leader of the Lycian men,

- glaring darkly at Hector, rebuked him with a hard word:
 "Hector — best of us all to look at: in battle you fall far short.¹⁰
 Fine fame indeed is yours — a runaway's.
 Consider now how you will save your town and citadel
 145 alone — you with the people born in Ilion;
 for no Lycian, at least, will go out to fight the Danaans
 for your city, since there was no thanks, it seems,
 for battling the enemy without respite, forever.
 How would you save a lesser man in the press of war,
 150 hard-hearted one, when Sarpedon — your guest-friend and companion
 —
 you abandoned to the Argives, their prey and their prize:
 a man who served you greatly, your city and yourself,
 while he lived; and now you have not dared to keep the dogs from him.
 So now, if any Lycian man will obey me,
 155 we go home — and let sheer destruction show over Troy.
 For if the Trojans now had daring fury in them,
 unshaking — the kind that comes into men who for their fatherland
 take on the toil and the grinding of war against their enemies —
 we would quickly haul Patroclus inside Ilion.
 160 And if that man came to the great city of lord Priam,
 dead — if we hauled him out of the fighting —
 the Argives would quickly ransom back the fine armor
 of Sarpedon, and we would bring the man himself into Ilion:
 for the aide of such a man lies killed — far the best
 165 of the Argives by the ships, he and his close-fighting aides.
 But you had not the courage to stand against great-hearted
 Ajax, eye to eye in the enemies' clamor,
 and fight him straight — since he is a better man than you."
 Glaring at him darkly, Hector of the flashing helmet answered:
 170 "Glaucus — why does a man like you talk so overweening?¹¹
 Well now! And I always said you were first in judgment
 of all who live in Lycia of the deep soil;
 but now I scorn your wits outright — such a thing to say:
 you say I did not stand against gigantic Ajax.
 175 It is not battle I shudder at, nor the thunder of horses;
 but always the mind of Zeus who bears the aegis is stronger:

- he sends even the brave man running, and strips away victory easily — and then again himself drives a man to fight. Come stand beside me, old friend — watch my work:
- 180 see whether all day long I prove the coward you call me, or whether I stop many a Danaan too, however hot his courage, from his defense of dead Patroclus."
- So speaking, he called to the Trojans with a great shout: "Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians who fight at close quarters —
- 185 be men, my friends; remember your rushing courage, while I put on the armor of blameless Achilles, the fine armor I stripped from the strength of Patroclus when I killed him."
- So speaking, Hector of the flashing helmet went off out of the grim war; and running he overtook his companions,
- 190 quickly, on swift feet, not yet far away — the men carrying toward the city the famed armor of Peleus' son. And standing apart from the battle of many tears, he changed his armor:¹²
- his own he gave to the war-loving Trojans to carry to holy Ilion; and he put on the immortal armor
- 195 of Achilles, Peleus' son, which the heavenly gods had given his dear father; and the father, grown old, passed it to his son — but the son did not grow old in his father's armor. And when Zeus the cloud-gatherer saw him from afar arming himself in the gear of the godlike son of Peleus,
- 200 he shook his head, and spoke to his own spirit: "Ah, poor man — death is nowhere in your thoughts,¹³ and it stands close beside you. You are putting on the immortal armor of the best of men — a man the others shudder at. His companion you have killed, who was gentle and strong,
- 205 and stripped the armor from his head and shoulders not by right. Yet for now I will hand you great power — as recompense for this: that never home out of the battle will you come, nor Andromache take from you the famous armor of Peleus' son."
- He spoke, and the son of Cronos bowed his head with his dark brows;
- 210 and he fitted the armor to Hector's body, and Ares entered him,

- the terrible war-god, and his limbs were filled inside
with courage and strength. He went out to the famed allies
with a great shout, and showed himself before them all,
blazing in the armor of the great-hearted son of Peleus.
- 215 And going among them he stirred each man with his words —
Mesthles and Glaucus and Medon and Thersilochus,
Asteropaeus and Deisenor and Hippothous,
Phorcys and Chromius and Ennomus the bird-reader;
urging these on, he spoke winged words:
- 220 "Hear me, you numberless tribes of allies who dwell around us:¹⁴
it was not for a crowd's sake — not because I lacked numbers —
that I gathered you here, each man from his own city,
but so that you would guard, with a will, the Trojans' wives
and little children from the war-loving Achaeans.
- 225 With that in mind I wear down my own people
for gifts and provisions, to feed the courage in each of you.
So now — let every man turn straight ahead, and die
or live: that is the trysting-talk of war.
And whoever hauls Patroclus, dead though he is,
- 230 in among the horse-taming Trojans, and Ajax yields to him —
half the spoils I will share out to that man, and half I keep
myself; and his glory shall be as great as mine."
So he spoke; and they marched straight down on the Danaans, heavy,
spears held high; and their hearts had great hope
- 235 of hauling the body from under Ajax, Telamon's son —
fools: over that body he was to rob many of life.¹⁵
And then Ajax spoke to Menelaus, good at the war-cry:
"Old friend — Zeus-nurtured Menelaus — I no longer count
on the two of us, even ourselves, coming home from this war.
- 240 It is not so much for the corpse of Patroclus I fear —
he will glut the dogs and birds of Troy soon enough —
as for my own head, that something may happen to it,
and yours: for Hector, that cloud of war, has covered
everything, and for us sheer destruction shows clear.
- 245 Come — call the best of the Danaans, if any may hear."
So he spoke, and Menelaus, good at the war-cry, did not disobey,
and cried a piercing cry, to carry to the Danaans:

"Friends — leaders and lords of the Argives —
 you who beside the two Atreus' sons, Agamemnon and Menelaus,
 250 drink at the public cost, and each give orders
 to your people — from Zeus come honor and glory.
 It is hard for me to pick out each one
 of the leaders — so great is the strife of war ablaze —
 so let each man come uncalled, and feel the outrage in his heart
 255 that Patroclus should be sport for the dogs of Troy."
 So he spoke; and the swift Ajax, Oïleus' son, heard him sharp,
 and came first to meet him, running through the combat,
 and after him Idomeneus, and Idomeneus's aide
 Meriones, the equal of Enyalius, slayer of men.
 260 But of the rest — who could speak their names out of his own mind,
 all who came up behind and woke the Achaean battle?¹⁵
 And the Trojans struck first, massed; Hector led them.
 As when at the mouth of a sky-fed river
 the great swell bellows against the current, and around it
 265 the jutting shores boom, as the salt sea belches beyond them:
 with such a roar came the Trojans on. But the Achaeans
 stood fast around Menoetius's son, one heart in all of them,
 fenced with their bronze-faced shields. And over their bright
 helmets the son of Cronos poured thick mist,¹⁶
 270 since never in the time before had he hated Menoetius's son,
 while he was alive and the aide of Aeacus' grandson;
 and he loathed that he become the prey of the dogs
 of Troy — and so he roused his companions to defend him.
 And at first the Trojans pushed back the bright-eyed Achaeans:
 275 they left the body and shrank away, and the high-hearted Trojans
 took not one of them with their spears, for all their striving,
 but set to hauling the corpse. Yet only a little while
 were the Achaeans to hold off from it: they were rallied fast
 by Ajax, who in build, and in what he wrought,
 280 surpassed all the Danaans after the blameless son of Peleus.
 He swept straight through the front-fighters, like a wild boar
 in his strength, that up in the mountains scatters hounds
 and strong young men with ease, wheeling through the glens:
 so the son of illustrious Telamon, shining Ajax,

- 285 swept in and easily scattered the Trojan battle-lines
 that had taken their stand over Patroclus, minded above all
 to haul him to their own city and win the glory.
 Now Hippothous, the shining son of Pelasgian Lethus,¹⁷
 was dragging him by the foot through the strong encounter,
 290 a shield-strap bound around the ankle-tendons,
 doing a favor to Hector and the Trojans. But swiftly
 the evil came on him that no one could hold off, wish it as they might:
 the son of Telamon, springing at him through the crowd,
 struck close-in, through the helmet's bronze cheek-pieces;
 295 and the horsehair-crested helmet split around the spear-point,
 struck by the great spear and the heavy hand,
 and the brain came running out of the wound along the socket,
 bloody; and there and then his strength was unstrung, and from his
 hands
 he let the foot of great-hearted Patroclus drop
 300 to lie on the ground; and he fell face-down on the corpse beside it,
 far from deep-soiled Larisa; nor did he repay
 his dear parents the price of his rearing: his life was short,
 broken under the spear of great-hearted Ajax.
 And Hector in turn cast at Ajax with his shining spear;
 305 but he saw it coming and dodged the bronze spear —
 barely; and it struck Schedius, great-hearted Iphitus's son,
 far the best of the Phocians, whose home was in famed
 Panopeus, where he was king over many men:
 it struck him under the middle of the collarbone, and through it
 310 the bronze point drove, and came out at the base of the shoulder.
 He fell with a thud, and his armor clattered upon him.
 And Ajax struck war-minded Phorcys, Phaenops's son,
 full in the belly as he bestrode Hippothous,
 and burst the plate of his corslet, and the bronze
 315 spilled his bowels through; and falling in the dust he clutched the earth
 in his palm.
 And the front-fighters gave ground, and glorious Hector;
 and the Argives shouted loud, and dragged away the corpses,
 Phorcys and Hippothous, and loosed the armor from their shoulders.
 And then once more the Trojans, before the Achaeans dear to Ares,

- 320 would have climbed into Ilion, broken by their own weakness,
 and the Argives would have won glory even beyond the portion of
 Zeus¹⁸
 by their own power and strength — had not Apollo himself
 stirred up Aeneas, in the likeness of the herald
 Periphas, Epytus's son, who at his old father's side
 325 had grown grey in his heraldry, his heart a well of kindly counsel;
 in his likeness Apollo, son of Zeus, spoke to him:
 "Aeneas — how could you and yours hold steep Ilion
 even against a god? — as I have seen other men do,
 trusting their power and strength, their manhood
 330 and their own numbers, though their people were too few.
 But Zeus wills the victory to us, far rather
 than to the Danaans — and you flinch unspeakably, and will not fight."
 So he spoke; and Aeneas knew Apollo who strikes from afar,
 looking him in the face, and called aloud to Hector:
 335 "Hector — and you other leaders of Trojans and allies —
 this now is disgrace: to climb back into Ilion
 before the Achaeans dear to Ares, broken by our own weakness.
 No — for a god has just now stood beside me and said
 Zeus, highest deviser of battle, is still our helper.
 340 So let us go straight for the Danaans, and not let them
 bring dead Patroclus to their ships at their ease."
 So he spoke, and sprang far out beyond the front-fighters, and stood;
 and they wheeled about, and stood to face the Achaeans.
 Then Aeneas wounded Leiocritus with his spear,
 345 the son of Arisbas, brave companion of Lycomedes;
 and as he fell, Lycomedes dear to Ares pitied him,
 and came and stood very close, and cast with his shining spear,
 and struck Apisaon, Hippasus's son, shepherd of the people,
 in the liver below the midriff, and unstrung his knees on the instant —
 350 the man who had come out of deep-soiled Paeonia,
 and was their best in battle after Asteropaeus.
 And as he fell, warlike Asteropaeus pitied him,
 and he too drove forward, willing to fight the Danaans;
 but there was no way any longer: fenced with shields on every side
 355 they stood around Patroclus, spears held out before them.

- For Ajax ranged among them all with strict command:¹⁹
 no man to give back a step from the body,
 no man to fight out in front of the other Achaeans,
 but to stand close over him, and fight hand to hand.
- 360 So gigantic Ajax commanded; and the earth grew soaked
 with purple blood, and they fell in heaps together,
 dead men of the Trojans and their overmastering allies
 and Danaans too — for not without blood did these defend —
 but far fewer of them perished: they remembered always
- 365 to ward sheer ruin from one another in the crowd.
 So they fought on, like fire; nor would you have said²⁰
 the sun was safe in the sky, or the moon:
 for they were held in mist, all the best men in the battle
 who stood around the dead son of Menoetius.
- 370 But the other Trojans and strong-greaved Achaeans
 fought at their ease under clear air: the piercing light
 of the sun lay spread, and no cloud showed over all
 the earth or the mountains; and they fought in pauses,
 keeping well apart, dodging each other's
- 375 missiles of groaning. But those in the middle suffered
 in the mist and the war, worn down by the pitiless bronze —
 all who were the best. And two men had not yet heard —
 two famous men, Thrasymedes and Antilochus —
 that blameless Patroclus was dead: they thought him
- 380 living still, fighting Trojans in the front of the crowd;
 and watching against the death and rout of their companions
 they fought apart, since Nestor had so ordered them,
 when he drove them to the war from the black ships.
 But for the others, all day long the great struggle of grinding
- 385 strife stood taut: with the weariness and the sweat of it,
 without respite, the knees and shins, the feet beneath,
 the hands and eyes of every man were spattered
 in the fight around the brave aide of the swift-footed son of Aeacus.
 As when a man gives his people the hide of a great bull²¹
- 390 to stretch, soaked through with fat:
 they take it and stand in a circle and stretch it
 outward; and quickly the moisture goes, and the fat sinks in

- with so many pulling, and the whole hide is stretched taut through:
 so this way and that, in a little space, both sides hauled
- 395 the corpse; and their hearts had great hope —
 the Trojans, of dragging him to Ilion; the Achaeans,
 to the hollow ships. And around him the brawl rose
 savage: not Ares driver of armies, not Athena
 could have looked at it and scorned it, however great their anger:
- 400 such was the evil toil of men and horses Zeus
 stretched taut over Patroclus on that day.
 And brilliant Achilles knew nothing at all, yet, of Patroclus dead:²²
 for the battle was fought far from the swift ships,
 under the wall of the Trojans. So never in his heart
- 405 did he think him dead — but living, pressed hard on the gates,
 and coming home again; since he never thought at all
 that Patroclus would sack the city without him — nor with him:
 for often he had learned as much from his mother, hearing her apart,
 when she brought him word of the purpose of great Zeus.
- 410 But now his mother told him nothing of the evil that had happened —
 so great — that his far-dearest companion had perished.
 And they around the corpse, holding their sharpened spears,
 pressed close without respite, and killed each other;
 and thus would one of the bronze-shirted Achaeans say:
- 415 "Friends — no glory for us in going back"²³
 to the hollow ships. Sooner let the black earth gape
 for all of us here. That would be better by far, at once,
 than to leave this man to the horse-taming Trojans
 to haul to their own city, and win the glory."
- 420 And thus in turn would one of the great-hearted Trojans say:
 "Friends — even if it is fate that we be broken beside this man,
 all of us alike, let no one yet give way from the war."
 So a man would speak, and stir the fury of each.
 So they fought on; and the iron din went up
- 425 through the barren air to the brazen sky.²⁴
 But the horses of Aeacus' grandson, apart from the battle,²⁵
 were weeping, ever since they first had learned their charioteer
 was fallen in the dust at the hands of man-slaughtering Hector.
 Automedon, Diore's stout son, tried them —

- 430 lashing them again and again with the quick whip's stroke,
 again and again with honeyed words, and again with curses:
 but the pair would not go back to the ships and the broad Hellespont,
 nor into the battle after the Achaeans.
 As a grave-stone stands unmoving, set on the barrow
 435 of a dead man or a woman,
 so they stood, unstirring, with the beautiful chariot,
 drooping their heads to the earth; and hot tears
 ran from their eyelids to the ground as they mourned
 in longing for their charioteer; and their rich manes were fouled,
 440 streaming down from the yoke-pad on both sides of the yoke.
 And seeing the two of them mourning, the son of Cronos pitied them,
 and he shook his head, and spoke to his own spirit:
 "Ah, poor pair — why did we give you to king Peleus,²⁶
 a mortal — you who are ageless and deathless?
 445 Was it so that you too might have sorrows among unhappy men?
 For there is nothing anywhere more pitiful than man,
 of all things that breathe and creep upon the earth.
 But not on you, at least, and your intricate chariot
 shall Hector, Priam's son, ride. I will not allow it.
 450 Is it not enough that he has the armor, and vaunts in it — just so?
 Into your knees and into your hearts I will throw fury,
 so you may carry Automedon safe out of the war
 to the hollow ships. For I will still hand the enemy glory,
 to kill, until they reach the well-benched ships,
 455 and the sun goes down and the sacred darkness comes on."
 So speaking, he breathed brave fury into the horses;
 and the two of them, shaking the dust from their manes to the ground,
 swiftly carried the quick chariot among Trojans and Achaeans.
 And behind them Automedon fought, grieving for his companion,²⁷
 460 swooping with the horses like a vulture on geese:
 easily he would run back out of the Trojans' clamor,
 and easily charge in again, pressing through the thick crowd.
 But he took no men when he swept in pursuit:
 it was not possible, alone in the sacred chariot,
 465 to go at them with the spear and hold the swift horses.
 At last a companion saw him with his own eyes —

- Alcimedon, the son of Laerces, Haemon's son;
 he stood behind the chariot and spoke to Automedon:
 "Automedon — which of the gods put this profitless plan
 470 in your chest, and took your good wits from you?
 — fighting the Trojans alone, in the front of the crowd,
 while your companion lies killed, and Hector himself
 glories with the armor of Aeacus' grandson on his own shoulders."
 And Automedon, Diotes' son, answered him:
- 475 "Alcimedon — what other Achaeans are your equals
 at holding the fury of immortal horses in hand —
 except Patroclus, the equal of the gods in counsel,
 while he lived? Now death and fate have overtaken him.
 So: you take over the whip and the shining reins,
 480 and I will step down from the horses, and fight."
 So he spoke; and Alcimedon, springing onto the rescue-chariot,
 quickly caught up the whip and reins in his hands,
 and Automedon leapt down. And glorious Hector saw it,
 and at once he spoke to Aeneas, who was near:
- 485 "Aeneas — counselor of the bronze-shirted Trojans —
 I see the two horses of the swift-footed son of Aeacus
 come out into the battle with feeble charioteers.
 I could hope to take them, if you in your heart
 are willing; since if the two of us charged, they would not
 490 dare stand against us face to face, and fight the war-god."
 So he spoke, and the brave son of Anchises did not disobey.
 The two went straight on, their shoulders wrapped in oxhides
 dry and stiff, with heavy bronze hammered over them;
 and with them went Chromius, and godlike Aretus,
 495 the two together; and their hearts had great hope
 of killing the men, and driving off the strong-necked horses —
 fools: not without blood were they to come away
 again from Automedon. He, with a prayer to Zeus the father,
 was filled with courage and strength in his darkened heart;
 500 and at once he spoke to Alcimedon, his trusted companion:
 "Alcimedon — hold the horses not far off from me,
 but breathing right on my back. For I do not think
 Hector, Priam's son, will be checked in his fury

- before he has mounted behind the fair-maned horses of Achilles —
 505 with the two of us killed — and routed the ranks of the Argive
 men; or else been taken himself among the first.
 So speaking he called the two Ajaxes and Menelaus:
 "You two Ajaxes, leaders of the Argives, and Menelaus —
 leave the corpse to the best men you have, to stand
 510 and bestride it and hold off the enemy ranks,
 and from the two of us — living men — beat off the pitiless day.
 For here they bear down hard through the war of tears,
 Hector and Aeneas, the best men of the Trojans.
 But these things lie on the knees of the gods:
 515 I too will let fly — and all the rest will be Zeus's care."
 He spoke, and balanced his long-shadowed spear and hurled it,
 and struck the shield of Aretus, balanced every way;
 and the shield did not hold the spear: the bronze drove clean through,
 and through the war-belt it tore into the pit of his belly.
 520 As when a strong-grown man with a sharp axe,²⁷
 striking behind the horns of an ox of the field,
 shears the tendon clean through, and the ox springs forward and drops:
 so Aretus sprang forward and fell on his back; and the spear,
 quivering razor-sharp in his bowels, unstrung his limbs.
 525 And Hector cast at Automedon with his shining spear;
 but he saw it coming and dodged the bronze spear,
 ducking forward; and behind him the long spear
 stuck fast in the ground, and the butt-end stood quivering;
 and there at last massive Ares stilled its fury.
 530 And now they would have gone at each other with swords, close in,
 had not the two Ajaxes parted them for all their heat,
 coming through the crowd at their companion's call.
 In dread of them the others drew back again —
 Hector and Aeneas and godlike Chromius —
 535 and left Aretus lying there, torn through the heart.
 And Automedon, the equal of swift Ares,
 stripped the armor, and spoke his triumph over him:
 "Now I have eased my heart a little of its grief
 for Menoetius's dead son — though the man I killed was worse."
 540 So speaking, he took up the bloody spoils and set them

- in the chariot, and mounted, feet and hands
all bloody, like a lion that has fed on a bull.
And back over Patroclus the strong encounter was stretched again,
grinding, of many tears; and Athena woke the struggle,
545 come down from heaven: for wide-seeing Zeus had sent her
to drive on the Danaans — for now his mind was turned.
As Zeus stretches a shimmering rainbow out of heaven²⁸
for mortals to see, a portent either of war
or of a chill storm — the kind that stops men's work
550 on the face of the earth, and troubles the flocks:
so she, wrapping herself in a shimmering cloud,
sank into the Achaean host, and woke each man.
First she spoke to Atreus' son, urging him on —
strong Menelaus, for he was nearest her —
555 likened to Phoenix in body and tireless voice:
"Yours will be the hanging head, Menelaus, yours the disgrace,
if under the wall of the Trojans the running dogs
drag the trusted companion of illustrious Achilles.
Hold on with all your strength, and drive on the whole army."
560 Then answered her Menelaus, good at the war-cry:
"Phoenix — old father, elder born long ago — if only Athena
would give me strength, and hold off the rush of missiles!
Then I would be willing indeed to stand and defend
Patroclus: for his death has touched me to the heart.
565 But Hector has the terrible fury of fire, and will not stop
cutting men down with the bronze; for Zeus hands him the glory."
So he spoke; and the goddess grey-eyed Athena was glad
that he had prayed to her first of all the gods.
She put strength into his shoulders and his knees,
570 and set in his chest the boldness of the fly,²⁹
which — beaten off again and again from a man's skin —
persists in biting; and human blood is sweet to it:
with boldness like that she filled his darkened heart,
and he strode over Patroclus and cast with his shining spear.
575 Now there was among the Trojans one Podes, Eëtion's son,³⁰
a rich man and a brave one; and Hector honored him
above the people, for he was his dear companion at the feast.

Him tawny-haired Menelaus struck on the war-belt
as he sprang away in flight, and drove the bronze clean through:
580 he fell with a thud; and Atreus' son Menelaus
dragged the corpse away from the Trojans into the band of his
companions.
But Apollo came and stood by Hector, and stirred him,
in the likeness of Phaenops, Asius's son, who of all
his guest-friends was dearest to him, with his house at Abydos;
585 in his likeness Apollo the worker-from-afar spoke to him:
"Hector — what other Achaeon will fear you now?
Look how you flinched from Menelaus, who before this
was a soft spearman — and now he is gone, alone, lifting
the corpse away from under the Trojans: he has killed your trusted
590 companion, brave among the front-fighters — Podes, Eëtion's son."
So he spoke; and the black cloud of grief wrapped Hector round,
and he came through the front-fighters helmed in blazing bronze.
And then the son of Cronos took up the tasseled aegis,³¹
glittering, and hid Ida under clouds,
595 and lightened and thundered hugely, and shook it,
and gave victory to the Trojans, and routed the Achaeans.
First to lead the rout was Peneleos the Boeotian:³²
turned forever toward the enemy, he was hit in the shoulder,
a grazing hit on the crest of it; but the spear-point of Polydamas
600 scored clean to the bone — for he had come close when he threw.
Then Hector wounded Leïtus, close in, on the wrist —
the son of great-hearted Alectryon — and stopped his fighting;
he shrank back, glancing round, for his heart no longer hoped
to hold a spear steady in hand and fight the Trojans.
605 And as Hector chased Leïtus, Idomeneus
struck him on the corslet, on the chest beside the nipple;
but the long spear snapped at the socket, and the Trojans
shouted. And Hector cast at Idomeneus, Deucalion's son,
standing in his chariot; and missed him by a little,
610 but struck the aide and charioteer of Meriones,
Coeranus, who had followed him from well-founded Lyctus.
(Idomeneus had come on foot at first, leaving the double-ended
ships, and would have handed the Trojans a great triumph

- had not Coeranus driven up fast with the swift horses:
 615 to him he came as light, and beat off the pitiless day —
 and lost his own life under man-slaughtering Hector.)
 Him Hector struck below the jaw, under the ear, and the spear-butt
 dashed his teeth out at the roots, and cut the tongue through the
 middle:
 he crashed from the chariot, and poured the reins to the ground.
 620 And Meriones stooped and gathered them up off the plain
 in his own hands, and called to Idomeneus:
 "Lay on the whip now, till you come to the swift ships!
 You see it yourself: the power is no longer with the Achaeans."
 So he spoke; and Idomeneus whipped the fair-maned horses
 625 back to the hollow ships; for fear had fallen on his heart.
 Nor did great-hearted Ajax fail to see it, and Menelaus —
 that Zeus was giving the Trojans the tide-turning victory;
 and great Telamonian Ajax began to speak among them:
 "Shame! By now even a man who was a great fool³³
 630 could see that father Zeus himself is helping the Trojans.
 Every missile of theirs strikes home, whoever lets fly,
 coward or brave man: Zeus guides them all alike;
 and ours drop to the ground, every one, spent for nothing.
 Come then — let us ourselves think out the best plan,
 635 both how to haul the corpse away, and how we ourselves
 may come home to be a joy to our dear companions,
 who look this way, grieving, and say that no longer
 can the fury of man-slaughtering Hector and his invincible
 hands be held — that he will fall on the black ships.
 640 And would there were some companion to carry word quickly
 to Peleus' son; for I do not think he has even heard
 the wretched news — that his dear companion has perished.
 But nowhere can I see such a man among the Achaeans:
 they are held in the mist, themselves and their horses alike.
 645 Father Zeus — deliver the sons of the Achaeans out of the mist;
 make clear sky; grant our eyes to see;
 and in the light — kill us, since that is now your pleasure."
 So he spoke; and the father pitied him as he wept,³⁴
 and at once he scattered the mist and thrust the fog away,

- 650 and the sun blazed out, and the whole battle came clear.
 And then Ajax spoke to Menelaus, good at the war-cry:
 "Look about you now, Zeus-nurtured Menelaus — see if you can
 sight Antilochus alive, great-hearted Nestor's son,
 and send him running to war-minded Achilles
 655 with word that his far-dearest companion has perished."
 So he spoke, and Menelaus, good at the war-cry, did not disobey,
 and set out — like a lion from a farmstead³⁵
 that has grown weary at last of provoking the dogs and the men,
 who will not let him take the fat of the herd,
 660 watching all night long; and he, craving the meat,
 charges in but gets nowhere, for javelins thick and fast
 fly out to meet him from daring hands,
 and burning brands besides, and he flinches at those for all his fury,
 and at dawn he goes off apart, sullen at heart:
 665 so from Patroclus went Menelaus, good at the war-cry,
 much against his will; for he feared the Achaeans
 in the grim rout would leave him, prey for the enemy;
 and long he charged Meriones and the two Ajaxes:
 "You two Ajaxes, leaders of the Argives, and Meriones —
 670 now let each man remember the gentleness
 of poor Patroclus: to every one of us he knew how
 to be kind, while he lived. Now death and fate have overtaken him."
 So speaking, tawny-haired Menelaus went off,
 glancing on every side, like an eagle — the bird
 675 men say has the sharpest sight of all things under heaven:
 high as he rides, the swift-footed hare does not escape him
 crouched under a leafy bush, but down upon it
 he swoops, and seizes it fast, and takes its life:
 so then, Zeus-nurtured Menelaus, your shining eyes
 680 went ranging everywhere across the crowd of your companions,
 hunting Nestor's son, if you might see him still alive.
 And he saw him quickly, on the far left of the whole battle,
 heartening his companions and driving them to fight;
 and standing close, tawny-haired Menelaus spoke:
 685 "Antilochus — come here, Zeus-nurtured; hear
 the wretched news — the thing that should never have happened.

- Already, I think, you see it with your own eyes
 and know it: a god is rolling calamity on the Danaans,
 and victory is the Trojans'. And killed is the best of the Achaeans —
 690 Patroclus; and a great longing is built for the Danaans.
 Run to the ships of the Achaeans, quick, and tell
 Achilles — he may yet bring the body safe to his ship,
 naked: for Hector of the flashing helmet has the armor."
 So he spoke; and Antilochus heard the word with horror.³⁵
- 695 For a long time speechlessness held him: his eyes
 filled with tears, and his strong voice was checked.
 Yet not even so did he neglect Menelaus's charge:
 he set off at a run, and gave his armor to his blameless companion
 Laodocus, who wheeled the whole-hoofed horses close beside him.
- 700 And his feet carried him weeping out of the battle,
 bearing the evil word to Achilles, Peleus' son.
 And your heart, Zeus-nurtured Menelaus, had no will³⁶
 to defend the worn companions there where Antilochus
 had left them, and great longing was built for the Pylians;
- 705 but he sent them brilliant Thrasymedes,
 and himself went back again to bestride the hero Patroclus;
 and running he stood beside the two Ajaxes, and spoke at once:
 "That man I have sent off to the swift ships,
 to go to Achilles of the swift feet. But I do not think
- 710 Achilles will come now, however great his anger at brilliant Hector:
 there is no way he could fight the Trojans naked.
 So let us ourselves think out the best plan,
 both how to haul the corpse away, and how we ourselves
 may escape death and doom out of the Trojans' clamor."
- 715 Then great Telamonian Ajax answered him:
 "All you have said is right and true, far-famed Menelaus.
 You and Meriones — stoop down, quickly, get under him,
 lift the corpse and carry him out of the toil. And behind you
 we two will fight the Trojans and brilliant Hector,
- 720 one heart in us as we share one name, we two who before now
 have stood the sharp war-god side by side, together."
 So he spoke; and they took the corpse up off the ground in their arms,
 high and mightily; and behind them the Trojan army

screamed, when they saw the Achaeans lifting the body,
 725 and charged like hounds that spring on a wounded boar³⁷
 ahead of the young hunters:
 for a while they race in, furious to tear him —
 but when he wheels among them, sure of his strength,
 back they shrink, and scatter in terror this way and that:
 730 so the Trojans for a while kept up the chase in a mass,
 stabbing with swords and double-curved spears;
 but whenever the two Ajaxes turned about and stood
 against them, their color changed, and not one dared
 dart forward and fight for the corpse.
 735 So the two of them, straining, carried the body out of the battle
 toward the hollow ships; and the war stretched taut behind them,
 savage as fire that leaps on a city of men,
 rising suddenly, and blazes, and the houses crumble
 in the great glare, and the wind's strength roars across it:
 740 so the relentless din of horses and of spearmen
 came on behind them as they went.
 And they — like mules who have thrown their great strength into the
 work,
 dragging down from the mountain along a rugged track
 a roof-beam or a huge ship-timber, and inside them the heart
 745 is worn with weariness and sweat together as they strain:
 so the two of them, straining, carried the body. And behind them
 the two Ajaxes held the enemy — as a wooded ridge
 holds back water, a ridge lying clean across a plain,
 which checks even the punishing currents of powerful rivers,
 750 and at once turns the flood of them all to wander
 loose across the lowland; and all their strength cannot break it:
 so the two Ajaxes, behind, kept fending off the battle
 of the Trojans. But they followed hard, and two above all,
 Aeneas, Anchises' son, and glorious Hector.
 755 And as a cloud of starlings goes, or of jackdaws,³⁸
 shrieking ruin, when they see coming at them
 a falcon, that carries death to small birds:
 so before Aeneas and Hector the young Achaean men
 went shrieking ruin, and forgot their war-craft.

760 And much fine armor fell around and about the ditch
as the Danaans fled; and there was no pause in the war.

NOTES TO BOOK 17

- 1 *ll. 1-6* Menelaus over the body "as a mother-cow, lowing, stands over her first calf, who never knew birth before" (πρωτοτόκος κινυρή — the lowing of a first-time mother). The poem opens its longest battle with its most maternal image: the corpse-defense that will consume the book is presented first not as war but as instinct — and given to Menelaus, the poem's specialist in loyal, unglamorous care.
- 2 *ll. 9-32* Euphorbus claims the spoils by right of first blood (his dart at 16.806-815); Menelaus's answer settles the Hyperenor account opened at 14.516 — with details the earlier narrative never gave (the mockery, "sorriest fighter of the Danaans"): the poem's ledgers, as at 17.24-28, remember more than they recorded. His closing proverb — "When the thing is done, even the fool learns" (ῥεχθὲν δέ τε νήπιος ἔγνω) — became Greek proverbial stock permanently.
- 3 *ll. 33-42* Euphorbus's revenge-speech is a family portrait: the brother's widow "in the depth of her new bridal chamber," the parents' "cursed mourning," and the imagined homecoming — your head and armor "in the hands of Panthous and brilliant Phrontis." He is the third Panthoid the war has engaged (Polydamas, Hyperenor); by naming his own parents he writes the address on his own death-notice.
- 4 *ll. 43-60* The kill and the double image. First the hair: "soaked with blood — hair like the Graces", and the braids pinched tight in gold and silver" — the poem's dandy-warrior, beautiful even in the detail of his hair-clasps. Then the olive sapling: reared by hand in a lonely place by welling water, rocked by every breathing of wind, white with blossom — torn out by one squall and laid flat. The most tender death-simile in the Iliad, spent on a minor Trojan — and made immortal twice over: Porphyry's *Life of Pythagoras* quotes the passage because Pythagoras claimed to have been Euphorbus (16.[43]); the sage's remembered death arrived pre-fitted with the loveliest lines in Homer.
- 5 *ll. 61-69* The lion takes the finest heifer: lines 63-64 repeat 11.175-176 verbatim (our English kept) — the neck broken first, the blood and inward parts gulped down — while dogs and herdsman clamor "from a distance," held by green fear. Menelaus, so often the poem's second-rank fighter, is for once the beast nobody dares approach.
- 6 *ll. 70-105* Apollo-as-Mentes turns Hector back with the horses-taunt that reuses Dolon's dream (10.402-404, our English kept): the unattainable team as the measure of Trojan overreach, third time offered, never possessed. Menelaus's soliloquy that follows is the poem's clearest statement of the shame-calculus (fixed frame lines kept: "Troubled, he spoke..."; "But why does my own heart argue..."): abandoning the body is disgrace, fighting a god-backed man is doom — "When a man wills, against the god's face, to fight a man whom a god honors, a great woe rolls down on him quickly" — and the resolution is neither: withdraw, find Ajax, return. Prudence with a plan is not cowardice; the poem lets the calculation stand unmocked.

- 7 *ll. 109-113* The reluctant lion — driven from the fold, "the brave heart in his chest goes stiff with the cold" — the first of the book's two borrowings from Ajax's great retreat-simile family of Book 11 (see note [35] for the second): the poem now clothes Menelaus in the images it minted for its strongest defender.
- 8 *ll. 125-127* Hector's intention, stated flat: to shear the head from the shoulders and give the trunk "to the dogs of Troy." The corpse-outrage theme crosses a line no one has yet crossed in act — and it is Hector, the poem's most humane warrior, who first conceives it. Books 22-24 will weigh everything that follows against these three lines.
- 9 *ll. 132-139* Ajax over the corpse as a lion over his cubs, the whole scowl of his brows drawn down over his eyes — guardianship again (note [1]), now paternal; and Menelaus beside him "nursing great grief." The two images of the book's opening — mother-cow and lion-father — bracket the dead man like parents.
- 10 *ll. 140-168* Glaucus's rebuke — the harshest any ally gives Hector — climaxes in the book's most startling proposal: haul Patroclus into Ilion and trade him — "the Argives would quickly ransom back the fine armor of Sarpedon, and we would bring the man himself into Ilion." Corpse for corpse, gear for gear: the dead as exchangeable stores of value. The poem's whole final movement (Hector's body ransomed for weighed gold) is glimpsed here first as an ally's grievance; and the grievance itself — "there was never any thanks" — is the mercenary's ledger Hector must answer with his own accounting at 220-232.
- 11 *ll. 169-182* Hector's answer reuses the theology of 16.688-692 (our English kept): "always the mind of Zeus... is stronger: he sends even the brave man running... and then again himself drives a man to fight." True doctrine — and, as ever with Hector, deployed exactly where it excuses him. The challenge ("stand beside me, old friend — watch my work") converts the quarrel into witness.
- 12 *ll. 183-197* The changing of the armor, staged "apart from the battle of many tears" like a rite: his own gear sent into Ilion, the immortal gear put on — and the poem recites its provenance as elegy: gods to Peleus; Peleus, "grown old," to his son; "but the son did not grow old in his father's armor." The line every reader remembers: the armor's history is a history of interrupted inheritance, and Hector is now inside it.
- 13 *ll. 198-214* Zeus's head-shake over Hector is the poem's theology of recompense at its most precise: the armor taken "not by right" (οὐ κατὰ κόσμον); the grant of "great power" made explicitly τῶν ποινῆν — as blood-price, compensation paid in advance for the death already decreed: "never home out of the battle will you come, for Andromache to take from you the famous armor of Peleus' son." Andromache, who begged him to fight from the wall (6.431), enters the sentence as the person who will not perform the homecoming ritual. Then the uncanny grace-note: the armor fits — Zeus himself "fitted the armor to Hector's body, and Ares entered him." The gift, the doom, and the ecstasy are one act.
- 14 *ll. 215-232* Hector's speech to the allies is the epic's frankest look at coalition warfare: "it was not for a crowd's sake I gathered you... I wear down my own people for gifts and provisions, to feed the courage in each of you" — the war economy Glaucus invoked (147-148) conceded in full. Then the third and strangest use of the intimacy-word: die or

live — "that is the trysting-talk of war" (πολέμου ὀαριστός; 13.291, 14.216). And the bounty: half-shares with Hector for whoever drags Patroclus in — glory made divisible and priced.

- 15 *ll. 233-261, 260-261* The advance is stamped "fools" (over that body Ajax "was to rob many of life"); Ajax's grim realism ("It is not so much for the corpse I fear... as for my own head"); Menelaus's call to the leaders "who drink at the public cost" — rank invoked through its perquisites; and then the narrator's own confession, athetized by Zenodotus: "But of the rest — who could speak their names out of his own mind...?" The inverted Muse-invocation: where 2.484 called on the goddesses because memory fails, here the singer simply shows the failure. The ancients heard a lapse; it reads as the book's honesty about crowds.
- 16 *ll. 262-273* Zeus pours mist over the body's defenders with the poem's most carefully argued motive: "never in the time before had he hated Menoetius's son, while he was alive... and he loathed that he become the prey of the dogs of Troy." The god who engineered the death (16.644-655) now spends the day protecting the corpse: the two attitudes are not reconciled — they are both true, and the poem leaves them side by side.
- 17 *ll. 274-318* The first full swing of the tug: Hippothous drags the body by a shield-strap bound round the ankle- tendons — the technical, butcher's detail — and dies across it, "far from deep-soiled Larisa; nor did he repay his dear parents the price of his rearing" (θρέπτρα — child-care as a debt the dead leave unpaid; cf. 4.477-478). Schedius the Phocian falls to Hector — the death our register logged when his namesake died at 15.515: the poem keeps both Schedii and spends them in different books. The exchange ends with the Argives dragging away not Patroclus but the Trojan dead: every body on this field is now cargo.
- 18 *ll. 319-334* The counterfactual — Troy broken "even beyond the portion of Zeus" (ὕπὲρ Διὸς αἴσαν) by mortal strength alone — is the strongest such clause in the poem: fate has slack in it, and only Apollo's intervention takes it up. The god borrows the shape of Periphas the herald, "grown grey in his heraldry" beside old Epytus — the poem's tenderness for professions again — and Aeneas knows him at once ("looking him in the face"); the recognition granted to the pious Aeneas and almost no one else.
- 19 *ll. 356-365* Ajax's field-order is the tactical heart of the book: no retreat from the body, no heroics out in front, "stand close over him, and fight hand to hand." The result the poet audits precisely: the ground purple, dead on both sides — "but far fewer of them perished: they remembered always to ward sheer ruin from one another in the crowd." The phalanx-discipline of Books 13 and 16 has become doctrine, stated and costed: cohesion is casualty-arithmetic.
- 20 *ll. 366-383* The doubled sky: over Patroclus, mist and night — "you would not have said the sun was safe, or the moon"; everywhere else "the piercing light of the sun lay spread, and no cloud showed over all the earth or the mountains," where men fight "in pauses, keeping well apart." A private midnight for the best, sunshine for the rest — the poem's most surreal battlefield image, ending on the two who fight in the light and do not know (Thrasymedes and Antilochus): light as ignorance, darkness as the place where the truth is.

- 21 *ll. 384-401* The tanning simile: the great bull's hide, soaked in fat, stretched in a circle by many hands "until the moisture goes and the fat sinks in... and the whole hide is stretched taut through" — the day's whole war compressed into a work-yard: the corpse pulled "this way and that, in a little space," by professionals, patiently. Even Ares and Athena "could not have scorned" the toil — the gods invoked as connoisseurs of labor. Nothing in the poem is grimmer than the craftsmanship of this comparison.
- 22 *ll. 401-411* And Achilles does not know. The passage Zenodotus cut (404-425 in his edition): Thetis "often" told him the purpose of Zeus, "but now his mother told him nothing of the evil that had happened." Inside it, the strangest clause in the poem's plotting: Achilles never hoped Patroclus would sack the city "without him — nor with him": he has carried his mother's prophecies far enough to know Troy is not theirs to take together. The ignorance is thus doubly cruel: he knows the large doom and not the small one that is running toward him on Antilochus's feet.
- 23 *ll. 412-425* The paired anonymous vows (τις-speeches): the Achaeans — "Sooner let the black earth gape for all of us here"; the Trojan — "even if it is fate that we be broken beside this man, all of us alike, let no one yet give way." The two armies, nameless, say the same sentence from opposite sides.
- 24 *ll. 424-425* "the iron din went up through the barren air to the brazen sky" — iron, bronze, and the barren middle air (ἀτρυγέτος, the sea's own epithet lent to the ether): the war as metallurgy filling the whole space between earth and heaven.
- 25 *ll. 426-440* The weeping horses. Immortal Xanthus and Balius stand apart from the battle "as a grave-stone stands unmoving, set on the barrow of a dead man or a woman" — creatures of wind become their charioteer's own monument — heads to the earth, "hot tears" running, "their rich manes fouled, streaming down from the yoke-pad." Automedon tries whip, honey, and curses; grief does not answer to any of the three. It is the poem's only animal mourning, and among its greatest inventions: sorrow without speech, loyalty without hope, in bodies that cannot die.
- 26 *ll. 441-455* Zeus's pity — the sentence at the poem's center of gravity: "why did we give you to king Peleus, a mortal — you who are ageless and deathless? Was it so that you too might have sorrows among unhappy men? For there is nothing anywhere more pitiful than man, of all things that breathe and creep upon the earth." The god who runs the war states its final metaphysics: mortality itself, not any battle, is the pity of it; the immortal horses' one flaw is contact with us. Then the practical rider: Hector shall not have them ("Is it not enough that he has the armor...?"), and the sunset clause of the day repeated word for word from 11.193-194 — the doom still running on schedule beneath the compassion.
- 27 *ll. 456-542* The Automedon sequence: the charioteer fights "like a vulture among geese," is talked into sense by Alcimedon (the Myrmidon fifth-captain of 16.197), and the two-man crew re-forms — driver breathing on his back — against Hector, Aeneas, Chromius, and Aretus. Aretus takes the spear "as when a strong-grown man with a sharp axe, striking behind the horns of an ox of the field, shears the tendon clean through, and the ox springs forward and drops" — the sacrificial slaughter-stroke on the battlefield. And Automedon's vaunt is the book's grief-economy in one line: "Now I have eased my heart

a little of its grief... though the man I killed was worse." Vengeance as approximate payment; the ledger never balances, and he says so.

- 28 *ll. 543-552* Athena comes down wrapped in "a shimmering cloud" like the rainbow Zeus stretches "for mortals to see, a portent either of war or of a chill storm that stops men's work on the face of the earth, and troubles the flocks." The rainbow as omen (11.27-28 made it armor- decoration) — beauty that means interruption: war for men, weather for the sheep, the two disasters given equal standing in the farmer's sky.
- 29 *ll. 553-573* Athena-as-Phoenix, and the fly. She fills Menelaus "with the boldness of the fly, which — beaten off again and again from a man's skin — persists in biting; and human blood is sweet to it." The smallest courage-simile in epic and the most audacious: persistence stripped of all dignity and honored anyway — appetite as valor. Plutarch and Galen both quote it; no other poet would have dared attach it to a king at the moment a goddess strengthens him.
- 30 *ll. 575-591* Podes, Eëtion's son — "his dear companion at the feast" (εἰλαπιναστής): Hector's table-intimate, rich and brave, killed in flight by the man Apollo then calls "before this a soft spearman" (μαλθακὸς αἰχμητής). The grief-cloud that wraps Hector is personal — the war has finally reached his own mess-table. The name Eëtion tolls again (Andromache's father, 6.396; Pedasus's city, 16.153): everything Hector loves seems to descend from men of that name.
- 31 *ll. 593-596* Zeus ends the argument by hand: the tasseled aegis taken up, Ida hidden in cloud, lightning, thunder, the shake — "and gave victory to the Trojans, and routed the Achaeans." The instrument Apollo borrowed at 15.229 is back with its owner; four verbs, and the day tilts.
- 32 *ll. 597-625* The rout ledger: Peneleos and Leïtus wounded (the two Boeotian catalogue-leaders of 2.494 subtracted in two lines); Idomeneus's spear snapping on Hector's corslet; and Coeranus of Lyctus, who dies taking the cast meant for his king — "to him he came as light, and beat off the pitiless day — and lost his own life": the poem's formula of salvation (φάος, light) priced at one charioteer. Meriones stooping to gather the fallen reins off the plain while the world collapses is the kind of detail this poet never omits: someone must always pick up the reins.
- 33 *ll. 626-647* Ajax's prayer. First the observation ("even a man who was a great fool could see that father Zeus himself is helping the Trojans — every missile of theirs strikes home... and ours drop to the ground, every one"), then the double need (save the body; send word to Achilles), and then the request that Longinus (On the Sublime 9.10) set above nearly everything in literature: "Father Zeus — deliver the sons of the Achaeans out of the mist; make clear sky; grant our eyes to see; and in the light — kill us, since that is now your pleasure" (ἐν δὲ φάει καὶ ὀλεσσοῦν). He does not pray to live; he prays to see. The demand is worthy of the fighter the poem has built across seventeen books: no complaint, no bargain — visibility, and then whatever Zeus likes.
- 34 *ll. 648-650* "And the father pitied him as he wept" — the tears are Ajax's (the strongest man in the army weeping inside his prayer, a detail easy to miss and impossible to forget), and Zeus's answer is instant and exact: mist scattered, fog thrust away, "the sun

blazed out, and the whole battle came clear." He grants the seeing. The killing he keeps on its schedule.

- 35 ll. 651-701 The message chain. Menelaus leaves the body "much against his will," in the reluctant-lion simile repeated from 11.550-555 (our English kept — the simile that carried Ajax's retreat now carries Menelaus's errand); his charge to the defenders is the dead man's true eulogy: "let each man remember the gentleness of poor Patroclus: to every one of us he knew how to be kind, while he lived." Then the eagle-eye search, and the delivery to Antilochus — who answers with the poem's most complete silence: "For a long time speechlessness held him: his eyes filled with tears, and his strong voice was checked." He hands his armor to Laodocus and runs weeping — the fastest of the young Achaeans carrying the heaviest sentence in the poem, unarmed, "bearing the evil word." Book 18 opens on his arrival.
- 36 ll. 702-721 Menelaus returns — the apostrophe turned on him twice in fifty lines (679, 702); the book's faithful laborer earns the second person too. Ajax's plan divides the last work: Menelaus and Meriones to carry, the two Ajaxes — "one heart in us as we share one name" — to hold the rear; the pun on Αἴαντε as a fighting unit, two men conjugated as a dual.
- 37 ll. 722-753 The carry: the body hoisted "high and mightily"; the boar wheeling on the hounds; the fire engulfing a city ("the houses crumble in the great glare"); and then the pair of similes that turn rescue into labor and landscape — the mules dragging beam or ship-timber "down from the mountain along a rugged track... the heart worn with weariness and sweat"; the Ajaxes as "a wooded ridge... lying clean across a plain," damming the flood of powerful rivers and turning it loose over the lowland. Men as terrain: the defensive fighter's apotheosis is to become geography.
- 38 ll. 755-761 The end: starlings and jackdaws "shrieking ruin" before the falcon — the young Achaeans in flight before Aeneas and Hector — "and much fine armor fell around and about the ditch as the Danaans fled; and there was no pause in the war." The book that fought all day for one man's body closes with armor strewn like litter and the fighting unpaused: no cadence, no rest — because the poem's next sound is Antilochus's voice in Achilles' hearing, and nothing in the war will ever be the same after it.

Iliad — Book 18

Achilles learns that Patroclus is dead and chooses vengeance over long life; Hephaestus forges him new armor and the great shield.

- So they fought on, like blazing fire;
 and Antilochus came to Achilles, a swift-footed messenger.
 He found him in front of his ships with their upright horns,
 brooding in his heart on what was already done;
 5 and troubled, he spoke to his own great-hearted spirit:
 "Ah me — why are the long-haired Achaeans again¹
 being driven in rout across the plain, back on the ships?
 Let the gods not now accomplish the evil griefs of my heart,
 as my mother once set out for me plainly, and told me
 10 that the best of the Myrmidons, while I still lived,
 would leave the light of the sun at Trojan hands.
 Surely he is dead already — Menoetius's stout son.
 Stubborn man! I ordered him: beat off the enemy fire,
 then back to the ships — do not fight Hector strength to strength."
 15 While he was turning this over in mind and heart,
 the son of illustrious Nestor came up close to him,
 shedding hot tears, and spoke the grievous message:
 "Ah me, son of war-minded Peleus — it is very hard news²
 you must hear now: a thing that should never have happened.
 20 Patroclus lies dead. They are fighting over the body —
 naked: for Hector of the flashing helmet has the armor."
 So he spoke; and the black cloud of grief covered Achilles.
 With both hands he took up the sooty dust³
 and poured it down over his head, and defiled his gracious face;
 25 and on his nectar-fragrant tunic the black ash settled.
 And he himself, in the dust, lay stretched out —
 mighty in his mightiness — with his own hands he tore and fouled his
 hair.
 And the slave-women Achilles and Patroclus had won as plunder
 shrieked aloud in the grief of their hearts, and ran
 30 out of the doors around war-minded Achilles, and all of them

- beat their breasts with their hands, and the limbs of each went slack.
 And Antilochus on the other side mourned, shedding tears,
 holding the hands of Achilles as his glorious heart groaned —
 for he feared he might cut his own throat with the iron.
- 35 Then he cried out, terribly; and his lady mother heard him
 where she sat in the depths of the sea beside her aged father,
 and wailed in answer; and the goddesses gathered around her,
 all the Nereids who were in the depths of the sea.
 There were Glauce and Thaleia and Cymodoce,⁴
- 40 Nesaea and Speio and Thoë and ox-eyed Halië,
 Cymothoë and Actaea and Limnoreia
 and Melite and Iaera and Amphithoë and Agave,
 Doto and Proto and Pherousa and Dynamene,
 Dexamene and Amphinome and Callianeira,
- 45 Doris and Panope and far-famed Galateia,
 Nemertes and Apseudes and Callianassa;
 and there were Clymene and Ianeira and Ianassa,
 Maera and Oreithyia and lovely-braided Amatheia,
 and the other Nereids who were in the depths of the sea.
- 50 The silver-shining cave was filled with them; and all together
 they beat their breasts, and Thetis led the lament:
 "Hear me, sister Nereids, so that all of you
 may know well, hearing it, what griefs are in my heart.
 Ah me, unhappy! Ah me — mother of the best of men, and cursed in it!⁵
- 55 For I bore a son, blameless and powerful,
 first among heroes; and he shot up like a sapling.
 I reared him like a young tree on the orchard's slope
 and sent him out with the beaked ships to Ilion
 to fight the Trojans; and I shall never receive him again,
 60 never coming home again to the house of Peleus.
 And while he still lives, and looks on the light of the sun,
 he grieves; and I can do nothing to help him, though I go to him.
 But go I will, to see my dear child, and to hear
 what grief has come to him as he waits out of the fighting."
- 65 So speaking she left the cave; and they went with her,
 weeping; and around them the wave of the sea
 broke apart. And when they came to deep-soiled Troy

- they stepped up onto the beach, one after another, where the ships of the Myrmidons were drawn up close around swift Achilles.
- 70 And his lady mother came and stood by him as he groaned heavily,⁶ and with a sharp wail she took her son's head in her arms, and mourning him she spoke winged words:
 "Child, why do you weep? What grief has come to your heart? Speak out; hide nothing. All of it has been accomplished
 75 by Zeus, exactly as you prayed with lifted hands: that the sons of the Achaeans be penned against the sterns, in desperate need of you, and suffer shameful things."
 Then, groaning heavily, swift-footed Achilles answered her:
 "Mother — yes: the Olympian has accomplished all of it."⁷
- 80 But what pleasure is it to me, when my dear companion has perished — Patroclus — whom I honored beyond all companions, equal to my own head? I have lost him; and the armor Hector has stripped from his kill — the gigantic armor, a wonder to see, beautiful: the shining gifts the gods gave Peleus
 85 on the day they threw you into the bed of a mortal man. If only you had stayed there among the immortal women of the sea, and Peleus had brought home a mortal wife!
 But now — so that for you too there might be grief past measure for a child destroyed, whom you will never receive again,
 90 never coming home — since my own heart forbids me to live on and remain among men, unless Hector first, beaten under my spear, loses his life and pays for making Patroclus, Menoetius's son, his spoil."
 Then Thetis answered him, shedding tears:
 95 "Quick-fated then you shall be, child, by what you say: for straight after Hector your own doom stands ready."
 Then, deeply troubled, swift-footed Achilles answered her:
 "Then let me die at once, since I was not to help⁸ my companion at his killing. Far from his fatherland
 100 he perished, and had need of me to be his warder-off of ruin. Now — since I shall not come home to my dear fatherland, since I proved no light of safety to Patroclus, nor to my other companions, all the many broken by brilliant Hector, but sit here by the ships, a useless weight on the plowland —

- 105 I, who am such as no other of the bronze-shirted Achaeans
in war, though in assembly there are others better —
may strife perish from among gods and men,⁹
and anger, that drives even the prudent man to harshness:
sweeter by far than honey dripping down,
110 it swells like smoke in the chests of men —
as the lord of men Agamemnon angered me now.
But we will let that be — a thing done and past, for all our grief,
beating down the heart in our chests because we must.
Now I will go, to find the killer of the dear head —
- 115 Hector. My own death-spirit I will accept whenever
Zeus wills to accomplish it, and the other immortal gods.
For not even the might of Heracles escaped his doom —
and he was dearest of all to lord Zeus, Cronos's son —
but fate broke him, and the grinding anger of Hera.
- 120 So I too, if a like fate is built for me,
shall lie still when I die. But now let me win great fame:
let me drive some deep-girdled woman of Troy
or Dardania to wipe with both her hands the tears
from her soft cheeks, sobbing without pause,
125 and let them know how long I have been out of the war.
Do not hold me from the fighting, though you love me. You will not
persuade me."
Then answered him the goddess, silver-footed Thetis:
"Yes, child — all this is true. It is no bad thing
to beat sheer destruction away from worn companions.
- 130 But your fine armor is held among the Trojans,
the glittering bronze; and Hector of the flashing helmet
glories in it on his own shoulders. Yet I promise you
he will not glory in it long: his killing is close to him.
So do not go down into the grind of the war-god yet —
135 not before your own eyes see me come back here.
At dawn I will return, with the rising of the sun,
bringing fine armor from the lord Hephaestus."
So speaking she turned away from her son,
and turning spoke to her sisters of the sea:
140 "Sink now, all of you, into the broad fold of the sea,

- to see the old man of the sea and our father's house,
and tell him everything. I go to high Olympus,
to Hephaestus famed for craft, to see if he is willing
to give my son famed armor, shining bright."
- 145 So she spoke; and they sank at once beneath the wave of the sea,
and the goddess, silver-footed Thetis, went on
to Olympus, to bring famed armor to her dear son.
So her feet carried her toward Olympus. And the Achaeans,
fleeing with unearthly clamor before man-slaughtering Hector,
150 came to the ships and the Hellespont;
nor could the strong-greaved Achaeans drag the corpse
of Patroclus, Achilles' aide, out of the missiles:
for the army overtook it again, and the horses,
and Hector, Priam's son, like flame in his fury.
- 155 Three times glorious Hector seized him from behind by the feet,
straining to drag him off, calling loud on the Trojans;
and three times the two Ajaxes, clothed in rushing courage,
beat him back from the corpse. But he, steady, sure of his strength,
now charged into the crush, and now again
160 stood and shouted his great shout; and he gave back not one step.
As shepherds in the field can in no way drive
a fire-colored lion from a carcass, when his hunger is huge,
so the two Ajaxes, helmed for war, could not
frighten Hector, Priam's son, away from the corpse.
- 165 And now he would have dragged it off, and won unspeakable glory,
had not wind-footed swift Iris come running¹⁰
from Olympus with a message for Peleus' son — to arm —
in secret from Zeus and the other gods: for Hera sent her.
And standing close she spoke winged words:
- 170 "Rise, son of Peleus — most terrifying of all men!
Defend Patroclus, for whose sake the dread struggle
stands before the ships. They are killing one another —
the one side fighting for the dead man's body,
the other, the Trojans, storming to drag him off
175 to windy Ilion; and glorious Hector above all
is wild to haul him away: his heart is set on cutting
the head from the soft neck, and fixing it on the palisade.

- Up — lie there no longer! Let awe come into your heart
that Patroclus should be sport for the dogs of Troy.
- 180 Yours is the disgrace, if the corpse comes back defiled."
Then answered her swift-footed brilliant Achilles:
"Goddess Iris — which of the gods sent you to me with this message?"
Then answered him wind-footed swift Iris:
"Hera sent me, the honored wife of Zeus;
185 and the high-throned son of Cronos does not know it, nor any other
of the immortals who live on snow-capped Olympus."
Answering her spoke swift-footed Achilles:
"And how am I to go into the grind? They have my armor —
those men; and my dear mother forbade me to arm
190 before my own eyes see her come back here:
she promised to bring fine armor from Hephaestus.
I know no other man whose famed gear I could put on —
unless it were the shield of Ajax, Telamon's son;
and he himself, I trust, is out among the front-fighters,
195 wreaking havoc with his spear for dead Patroclus."
Then answered him wind-footed swift Iris:
"We know it well — yes, they hold your famed armor.
But go to the ditch, just as you are, and show yourself to the Trojans:
in dread of you the Trojans may hold back
200 from the fighting, and the warlike sons of the Achaeans catch their
breath,
worn as they are; for the breathing-spaces of war are few."
So speaking, swift-footed Iris went her way;
and Achilles, dear to Zeus, rose up. And around
his powerful shoulders Athena threw the tasseled aegis,
205 and around his head the brilliant goddess set a crown
of golden cloud, and out of it lit a flame, blazing bright.¹¹
As when smoke rises from a city into the upper air,
far off, from an island that enemies have surrounded,
where all day long the men are put to the test of hateful war
210 from their own city walls; and then, with the setting sun,
beacon-fires blaze up one after another, and the glare
shoots high for the neighboring islanders to see,
in hope that they may come with ships as warders-off of ruin:

- so from the head of Achilles the light went up to the upper air.
- 215 He went from the wall and stood at the ditch; nor did he mix
with the Achaeans, for he heeded his mother's strict command.
There he stood, and shouted; and apart, Pallas Athena
gave voice; and among the Trojans he stirred unspeakable tumult.
As piercing-clear as the voice of the trumpet, when it screams
- 220 around a city ringed by life-breaking enemies,
so piercing-clear then was the voice of Aeacus' grandson.
And when they heard the brazen voice of Aeacus' grandson,
the heart in every man was shaken; and the fair-maned horses
wheeled the chariots backward: they smelled sorrows coming.
- 225 And the charioteers were struck out of their wits, seeing
the unwearying fire, terrible, over the head
of great-hearted Peleus' son: grey-eyed Athena made it blaze.
Three times over the ditch brilliant Achilles gave his great shout,
and three times the Trojans and their famed allies were thrown into
confusion;
- 230 and there and then twelve of their best men perished
on their own chariots and their own spears. And the Achaeans,
glad at heart, drew Patroclus out from under the missiles
and laid him on a bier; and his dear companions stood around him
mourning; and among them followed swift-footed Achilles,
- 235 shedding hot tears, when he saw his trusted companion
lying on the litter, torn by the sharp bronze —¹²
the man he had sent out with horses and chariot
into the war, and never received again at his homecoming.
And the ox-eyed lady Hera sent the unwearied Sun,¹³
- 240 much against his will, into the streams of Ocean;
and the Sun set, and the brilliant Achaeans rested
from the strong struggle and the leveling war.
And the Trojans on the other side, back from the strong encounter,
loosed their swift horses from under the chariots
- 245 and gathered in assembly before they thought of supper.
The assembly was held standing: no man dared¹⁴
sit, for trembling held them all — because Achilles
had appeared, who had long stayed out of the grievous fighting.
Among them the level-headed Polydamas began to speak,

- 250 Panthous's son: he alone looked before and behind.
 He was Hector's companion, born in the one night with him;
 but one was far the better in words, the other with the spear.
 With good will toward them he spoke and addressed them:
 "Weigh both sides well, my friends. For my part I command us:
 255 go to the city now — do not wait for the brilliant dawn
 on the plain beside the ships. We are far from our wall.
 So long as that man raged against brilliant Agamemnon,
 so long the Achaeans were easier men to fight —
 I too was glad to camp beside their swift ships,
 260 hoping we should take the double-ended vessels.
 But now I dread the swift-footed son of Peleus, terribly.
 So violent is that man's heart, he will not be willing
 to stay on the plain, where Trojans and Achaeans
 share between them the middle ground and the fury of the war-god:
 265 it is for our city he will fight, and for our women.
 Let us go to the town. Trust me: for so it will be.
 For now, the ambrosial night has stopped the swift-footed
 son of Peleus; but if he finds us here tomorrow
 when he comes out armed, then a man will know him
 270 well enough: gladly will he reach holy Ilion,
 whoever escapes; and dogs and vultures will eat many
 of the Trojans. May such a tale stay far from my hearing!
 But if we do as I say — though it grieves us —
 tonight we keep our force in the meeting-place, and the city
 275 is guarded by its towers and high gates and the tall
 polished doors, fitted close, bolted fast, that shut them;
 and early, toward dawn, armed in our gear,
 we take our stand along the towers. The worse for him then,
 if he wants to come from the ships and fight us for the wall:
 280 back to the ships he must go, when he has worn out his strong-necked
 horses with every kind of running, driving them under the town.
 Inside it his heart will not let him charge;
 never will he sack it: sooner the running dogs will eat him."
 Glaring at him darkly, Hector of the flashing helmet answered:¹⁵
 285 "Polydamas, this talk of yours pleases me no longer —
 you who command us to run back and be penned in the city.

Have you not all had your fill of being cooped inside those towers?
 In the days before, all mortal men would tell of
 Priam's city as rich in gold, rich in bronze;
 290 but now the fine heirlooms are gone out of our houses:
 sold off, our treasures have long since passed to Phrygia
 and lovely Maeonia, since great Zeus turned his wrath on us.
 And now — now, when the son of crooked-counseled Cronos has
 granted me
 to win glory at the ships, and pen the Achaeans against the sea —
 295 fool, do not lay such counsels open before the people!
 No Trojan will obey you: I will not allow it.
 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:
 Take your supper now, through the army, by companies;
 remember the watch; and let every man stay wakeful.
 300 And any Trojan whose goods torment him beyond measure —
 let him gather and give it to the people to consume in common:
 better any of ours enjoy them than the Achaeans.
 and early, toward dawn, armed in our gear,
 we will waken sharp Ares beside the hollow ships.
 305 If it is true that brilliant Achilles has risen by the ships,
 the worse for him, if that is what he wants. I at least
 will not run from him out of the harsh-sounding war: I will stand
 against him, face to face — whether he carries off the great triumph,
 or I carry it. Enyalios is impartial: he kills the would-be killer."
 310 So Hector spoke; and the Trojans roared applause —¹⁶
 the fools: for Pallas Athena had taken their wits from them.
 To Hector they gave their praise, whose counsels were ruinous;
 to Polydamas no man's, who had devised the good counsel.
 Then they took their supper through the army. But the Achaeans
 315 all night long mourned Patroclus with wails and groans;
 and Peleus' son led the thick lament among them,¹⁷
 laying his man-slaughtering hands on his companion's chest,
 groaning again and again — like a bearded lion
 whose cubs a deer-hunter has snatched away
 320 out of the thick wood; and he comes back too late, and grieves,
 and goes down glen after glen tracking the man's footprints,
 hunting him out — for bitter anger takes hold of him:

so, groaning heavily, Achilles spoke among the Myrmidons:
 "Shame! It was an empty word I let fall on that day
 325 when I reassured the hero Menoetius in his halls:
 I said I would bring back his far-famed son to Opoeis
 with his share of the spoils, when he had sacked Ilion.
 But Zeus does not accomplish all the designs of men:
 for the two of us are fated to redden the same earth
 330 here in Troy — since I too will not come home
 to be received in his halls by the old horseman Peleus,
 nor by Thetis my mother: the earth will hold me here.
 But now, Patroclus, since I go under the earth after you,
 I will not give you burial before I bring here
 335 the armor and the head of Hector, your great-hearted killer;
 and before your pyre I will cut the throats of twelve
 shining children of the Trojans, in my rage at your slaying.
 Until then, you shall lie just so by the beaked ships,
 and around you the deep-girdled women of Troy and Dardania
 340 shall mourn you night and day, shedding tears —
 the women we two labored to win, by strength and the long spear,
 sacking the rich cities of mortal men."
 So speaking, brilliant Achilles ordered his companions
 to set a great tripod over the fire, so that with all speed
 345 they might wash the clotted blood from Patroclus.
 And they set the bath-water tripod on the blazing fire
 and poured the water in, and took wood and lit it beneath;
 and the fire wrapped the tripod's belly, and the water warmed.
 And when the water boiled in the glittering bronze,
 350 they washed him then, and anointed him richly with oil,
 and filled his wounds with unguent nine years old;
 and laying him on the bier they covered him with soft linen
 from head to foot, and over that a white cloak.
 Then all night long, around swift-footed Achilles,
 355 the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with wails and groans.
 And Zeus spoke to Hera, his sister and his wife:¹⁸
 "So you have managed it after all, ox-eyed lady Hera —
 you have roused swift-footed Achilles. Truly they must be
 your own children, these long-haired Achaeans — born from you!"

- 360 Then ox-eyed lady Hera answered him:
 "Most dread son of Cronos, what a word you have spoken!
 Even a man, I suppose, will do what he can for a man,
 though he is mortal, and knows no such counsels as ours.
 How then should I — who claim to be the best of goddesses,
 365 doubly: by birth, and because I am called your wife,
 and you are king over all the immortals —
 how should I not stitch evils for the Trojans in my anger?"
 So the two of them spoke such things to one another.
 And silver-footed Thetis came to the house of Hephaestus,¹⁹
 370 imperishable, starry, shining out among the immortals'
 houses, built of bronze — the crook-footed god had made it himself.
 She found him sweating, wheeling about his bellows,
 hard at his hurry: for he was forging tripods, twenty
 in all, to stand around the wall of his well-built hall,
 375 and under the base of each he had set golden wheels,
 so that self-moved they might enter the assembly of the gods
 and come home to his house again — a wonder to see.
 So much was finished; but the intricate handles were not yet
 fitted on: these he was preparing, and hammering their rivets.
 380 While he labored at this with his knowing craft,
 the goddess, silver-footed Thetis, came near him;
 and Charis of the shining veil saw her and came forward —²⁰
 the beautiful Charis, whom the famed crook-footed god had married —
 and clung to her hand, and spoke a word, and named her:
 385 "Thetis of the trailing robe — why have you come to our house,
 honored guest and dear? Before now you have not come often.
 Come further in with me, and let me set the guest-fare before you."
 So speaking, the brilliant goddess led her forward,
 and seated her on a chair, silver-studded,
 390 beautiful, intricate, with a footstool under her feet;
 and she called to Hephaestus famed for craft, and said:
 "Hephaestus — come out here: Thetis has need of you."
 And the famed crook-footed god answered her:
 "Then a dread goddess is inside my house — one I revere:
 395 she saved me when the pain came over me after my great fall,
 by the will of my own bitch-faced mother, who wanted

- to hide me away for being lame. My heart would have suffered then,
had not Eurynome and Thetis caught me to their laps —
Eurynome, daughter of back-flowing Ocean.
- 400 Nine years I forged intricate things beside them —
brooches, and curved spiral-bracelets, and rosette-cups, and necklaces
—
there in the hollow cave; and around us the stream of Ocean
ran on forever, murmuring with foam. And no one knew —
not one of the gods, not one of mortal men:
- 405 only Thetis knew, and Eurynome — the two who saved me.
Now she has come to our house; and so I am bound
to pay fair-braided Thetis the whole ransom of my life.
Set out the fine guest-fare before her now,
while I put away my bellows and all my tools."
- 410 He spoke, and heaved his monstrous bulk up from the anvil-block,²¹
limping; and beneath him his slender legs moved quickly.
He set the bellows away from the fire, and gathered
all the tools of his labor into a silver chest;
and with a sponge he wiped his face and both his hands,
415 his massive neck and his shaggy chest,
and put on a tunic, and took up a thick staff, and came out
limping; and there moved quickly, supporting their lord,
attendants made of gold, in the likeness of living girls:
in them is mind, in their breasts, and voice,
420 and strength; and they know handiwork from the immortal gods.
These moved bustling at their lord's side; and he, laboring on
to where Thetis was, sat down on a shining chair,
and clung to her hand, and spoke a word, and named her:
"Thetis of the trailing robe — why have you come to our house,
425 honored guest and dear? Before now you have not come often.
Say what is in your mind. My heart bids me do it,
if do it I can — if it is a thing that can be done."
Then Thetis answered him, shedding tears:²²
"Hephaestus — is there any goddess, of all on Olympus,
430 who has endured so many bitter griefs in her heart,
as many as the sorrows Zeus, Cronos's son, has given me beyond all?
Out of all the sisters of the sea he broke me to a man,

to Peleus, Aeacus' son; and I endured a man's bed,
 much against my will. That man lies in his halls now
 435 worn out with wretched old age. But there is more for me:
 he gave me a son to bear and to rear,
 first among heroes; and he shot up like a sapling.
 I reared him like a young tree on the orchard's slope
 and sent him out with the beaked ships to Ilion
 440 to fight the Trojans; and I shall never receive him again,
 never coming home again to the house of Peleus.
 And while he still lives, and looks on the light of the sun,
 he grieves; and I can do nothing to help him, though I go to him.
 The girl the sons of the Achaeans picked out as his prize —
 445 her the lord Agamemnon took back out of his hands;
 and grieving for her he was eating his own heart out. Then the Trojans
 penned the Achaeans against the sterns, and would not let them
 come out; and the elders of the Argives begged him,
 naming over the many glorious gifts.
 450 He refused, then, to beat off the ruin himself;
 but he put his own armor on Patroclus
 and sent him into the war, and a great force with him.
 All day they fought around the Scaean Gates,
 and would have sacked the city that same day — had not Apollo
 455 killed the stout son of Menoetius in the front ranks,
 Patroclus who had wrought so much harm, and handed the glory to
 Hector.
 So now I come to your knees: will you give my son —
 quick-fated as he is — a shield and a helmet,
 and fine greaves fitted with ankle-pieces,
 460 and a corslet? What he had, his trusted companion lost
 when the Trojans broke him; and my son lies on the ground, eating his
 heart out."
 Then the famed crook-footed god answered her:²³
 "Take heart. Do not let these things trouble your mind.
 Would that I could hide him away from harsh-sounding death
 465 as surely — when the terrible doom comes for him —
 as fine armor shall be his: armor such that any man
 of the many who see it hereafter will marvel."

So speaking he left her there and went to his bellows,
 and turned them toward the fire and bade them work.
 470 And the bellows — twenty in all — blew on the crucibles,²⁴
 sending out their blast at every strength:
 now to serve him pressing hard, and now the opposite,
 however Hephaestus willed it and the work required.
 And he threw unwearying bronze on the fire, and tin,
 475 and precious gold, and silver; and next he set
 the great anvil on the anvil-block, and took up in one hand
 the massive hammer, and in the other took the tongs.
 And he made first of all a shield, great and heavy,
 working the whole of it with cunning; and around it he threw a rim,
 480 bright, triple, glittering; and from it a silver strap.
 Five were the layers of the shield itself; and on its face
 he wrought many intricate things with his knowing craft.
 On it he made the earth, and the heaven, and the sea,²⁵
 the unwearied sun and the moon at her full,
 485 and on it all the constellations with which heaven is crowned —
 the Pleiades and the Hyades, and the strength of Orion,
 and the Bear, which men also call by the name of the Wagon,
 who turns in her own place, keeping watch on Orion,
 and alone has no share in the baths of Ocean.
 490 And on it he made two cities of mortal men,²⁶
 beautiful. In the one there were weddings and feasts:
 brides were being led from their chambers under blazing torches
 up through the town, and loud rose the wedding-song;
 and young men whirled in the dance, and among them
 495 flutes and lyres kept up their cry; and the women,
 standing each at her door, looked on and marveled.
 And the people were gathered in the meeting-place, where a quarrel
 had risen: two men quarreling over the blood-price
 of a man who was killed. The one claimed he had paid all,
 500 declaring it to the people; the other refused to take anything;
 and both were eager to take an end of it before an arbiter.
 And the people cheered for both, supporters of either side,
 and the heralds held the crowd in check; and the elders
 sat on polished stones in the sacred circle,

- 505 the scepters of the clear-voiced heralds in their hands;
 with these they rose, and gave judgment each in turn.
 And in the middle lay two talents of gold,
 to be given to the one who spoke the straightest judgment.
 But around the other city two armies of fighting men were lying²⁷
 510 blazing in their armor; and their counsel was divided —
 whether to sack it outright, or to divide in two
 all the wealth the lovely town held inside it.
 But the besieged were not yielding: they had armed in secret for an
 ambush.
 Their dear wives and little children stood on the wall
 515 and guarded it, with the men whom old age held;
 and the rest went out. And Ares led them, and Pallas Athena,
 both of gold, and golden the clothes they wore,
 beautiful and great in their armor — like the gods they were,
 conspicuous on every side; and the people under them were smaller.
 520 And when they came to the place that suited their ambush,
 by a river, where there was a watering-place for all the herds,
 there they settled themselves, wrapped in blazing bronze.
 And two scouts sat apart from the army,
 waiting to sight the sheep and the twist-horned cattle.
 525 And these came on soon, and two herdsmen followed with them,
 delighting in their pipes: the trap they never guessed.
 And the men in ambush saw them and ran out, and swiftly
 cut off the herds of cattle and the fine flocks
 of white-shining sheep, and killed the herdsmen over them.
 530 But the besiegers, when they heard the great noise among the cattle
 from where they sat before the assembly-ground, mounted at once
 behind their high-stepping horses and came on fast, and reached them.
 And they formed up and fought their battle on the river-banks,
 striking one another with the bronze-fitted spears.
 535 And Strife was joining the crowd, and Tumult, and deadly Fate,
 holding one man fresh-wounded and alive, another
 unwounded, another dead, dragging him by the feet through the
 fighting;
 and the cloak on her shoulders was red with the blood of men.
 They closed and fought like living mortals,

- 540 and dragged away each other's dead.
 And on it he set a fallow field, soft, rich plowland,²⁸
 wide, thrice-turned; and on it many plowmen
 wheeled their teams and drove them this way and that;
 and whenever they turned and came to the field's edge,
 545 a man would come and put in their hands a cup
 of honey-sweet wine; and they would turn back down the furrows,
 straining to reach the deep fallow's edge again.
 And the field grew black behind them, like earth the plow has turned,
 though it was made of gold: that was the very wonder of the work.
 550 And on it he set a king's estate, where laborers²⁹
 were reaping, with sharp sickles in their hands.
 Some handfuls were falling to the ground in rows along the swath,
 and others the sheaf-binders were tying with twisted straw:
 three binders stood at their work, and behind them
 555 boys gathered the handfals and carried them in their arms,
 keeping them supplied without pause. And the king among them,
 in silence, staff in hand, stood at the swath, glad at heart.
 And heralds apart, beneath an oak, were laying out the feast,
 dressing the great ox they had slaughtered; and the women
 560 sprinkled the meal with white barley in plenty, for the laborers' dinner.
 And on it he set a vineyard, heavy-laden with grape-clusters,³⁰
 beautiful, golden: the grapes along it were black,
 and it stood staked from end to end on silver poles.
 And around it he drove a ditch of blue enamel, and about that a fence
 565 of tin; and one single path led in,
 by which the carriers passed whenever they gathered the vintage.
 And girls and young men, hearts light as children's,
 carried the honey-sweet fruit in woven baskets;
 and in the middle of them a boy with a clear-toned lyre
 570 played longingly, and sang the beautiful Linos-song
 in his delicate voice; and they, stamping in time,
 followed with song and cries, skipping on their feet.
 And on it he made a herd of straight-horned cattle:³¹
 the cows were wrought of gold and of tin,
 575 and streamed lowing from the farmyard toward their pasture
 beside a murmuring river, beside the waving reeds.

And golden herdsmen walked along with the cattle,
 four of them, and nine quick-footed dogs came after.
 But two terrible lions, in among the leading cattle,
 580 had hold of a bellowing bull; and he, roaring loud,
 was dragged away; and the dogs and the young men went after him.
 The two lions, ripping open the great bull's hide,
 were gulping the entrails and the black blood; and the herdsmen
 urged their swift dogs in vain, setting them on:
 585 the dogs kept shying back from sinking teeth in the lions,
 but stood in close and barked, and leapt away.
 And on it the famed crook-footed god made a pasture³²
 in a beautiful glen, a great pasture of white-shining sheep,
 with steadings and roofed huts and pens.
 590 And on it the famed crook-footed god wrought a dancing floor,³³
 like the one that Daedalus once fashioned
 in wide Knossos for lovely-haired Ariadne.
 There young men and girls whose bride-price is many oxen
 were dancing, holding one another's hands at the wrist.
 595 The girls wore fine linen, and the young men tunics
 well-woven, glistening softly with oil;
 and the girls wore beautiful garlands, and the young men carried
 golden daggers hanging from silver belts.
 And now they would run on skillful feet,
 600 lightly, easily — as when a potter, seated, tries
 the wheel fitted to his hands, to see if it will spin —
 and now again they would run in lines toward one another.
 And a great crowd stood around the lovely dance,
 delighting; and among them a divine singer made music,
 605 playing the lyre; and two acrobats, leading the measure,
 whirled through the middle of them.
 And on it he set the great strength of the river Ocean,³⁴
 along the outermost rim of the strong-built shield.
 And when he had made the shield, great and heavy,³⁵
 610 he made him a corslet brighter than the blaze of fire,
 and he made him a heavy helmet, fitted to his temples,
 beautiful, intricate, and set upon it a crest of gold,
 and he made him greaves of pliant tin.

And when the famed crook-footed god had labored out all the armor,
615 he took it up and laid it before the mother of Achilles;
and she like a hawk plunged down from snow-capped Olympus,
carrying the glittering armor from Hephaestus.

NOTES TO BOOK 18

- 1 *ll. 1-14* Achilles reads the rout before the message arrives, through a prophecy remembered: "the best of the Myrmidons, while I still lived, would leave the light of the sun." His mother's oracles (cf. 17.408-411) work in him as dread; the fixed soliloquy frame ("troubled, he spoke...") carries the poem's most fearful private arithmetic. His last clause before the news is a rebuke to the dead man — "I ordered him: beat off the fire, then back" — the conditions of 16.87-96, recited by the man who set them, to no one.
- 2 *ll. 15-21* The delivery: four lines, weeping, with the fixed formula shared by Menelaus's instructions (17.685-693) — "Patroclus lies dead... naked: for Hector of the flashing helmet has the armor" (the line reused verbatim). Nothing softened, nothing arranged: the worst news in the poem is also its shortest speech.
- 3 *ll. 22-35* The unmaking: the black cloud; both hands pouring soot over the head; the "nectar-fragrant tunic" fouled with ash; and the fallen line — "in the dust he lay stretched out, mighty in his mightiness" — the epitaph of Cebriones (16.776, register kept), now describing a living man performing his own burial. The slave-women's shrieking (δμωαί, the register's word) makes the hut a house of mourning; and Antilochus holds Achilles' hands "for fear he might cut his own throat with the iron" — Aristarchus's reading, and the Iliad's only suicide watch: the poem considers, for one line, that its hero might end it here. Then the scream that a goddess hears through the sea.
- 4 *ll. 35-49* The Nereid catalogue: thirty-three names of the sea's daughters, athetized by Zenodotus and Aristarchus and omitted in the Argolic edition — and kept here, because the list is the point: an entire society of the sea rises keening. The names are transparent sea-poetry — Glauce (Grey-green), Cymodoce and Cymothoë (Wave-gatherer, Wave-swift), Nemertes and Apsudes (Truthful and Unlying), Pherousa and Dynamene (Carrier and Capable), Galateia of the milk-white calm — Hesiod's Theogony shares many. Grief summons the whole element: when Achilles screams, the Mediterranean answers by name.
- 5 *ll. 50-64* Thetis leads the lament (ἐξήρχε γόοιο — the ritual term for the chief mourner) for a son not yet dead, and coins for herself the poem's most desolate word: δυσαριστοτόκεια — "unhappy in the best of sons": mother of the best, and cursed by the superlative itself. The sapling lines — "he shot up like a sapling; I reared him like a young tree on the orchard's slope" — recur verbatim in her petition to Hephaestus (437-443): a mother's lament already hardened into liturgy.
- 6 *ll. 65-77* The Nereids beach at Troy; Thetis "took her son's head in her arms" — the position of the chief mourner at a corpse's head (cf. 24.724): she mourns him alive, enacting the funeral she will not attend. Her comfort is the poem's bitterest arithmetic: all this "has been accomplished by Zeus, exactly as you prayed" — the Book 1 petition returned with interest.

- 7 ll. 78-93 Achilles' answer: the prayer granted, "but what pleasure is it to me?" Patroclus "equal to my own head" — self and friend one body — and the armor's loss traced to its origin: the gods' wedding-gift "on the day they threw you into the bed of a mortal man." The logic runs backward from grief to his own conception: better his mother had stayed in the sea, better he had never been. Then the vow that closes the argument of the whole poem's first movement: no life "unless Hector first, beaten under my spear, loses his life."
- 8 ll. 94-116 The choice. Thetis: "Quick-fated then you shall be, child" (ὠκύμορος — her word for him since 1.417); "straight after Hector your own doom stands ready." Achilles: "Then let me die at once (αὐτίκα τεθναίην), since I was not to help my companion at his killing." Plato set this exchange at the center of the *Apology* (28c-d): Socrates, refusing to abandon his post for fear of death, cites Achilles despising danger "when the alternative was to live a coward who does not avenge his friends" — the pagan scripture of principled dying, quoted by philosophy at its own martyrdom. (Aeschines quoted the neighboring lines in court in 345 BC, reading the friendship as love — the ancient debate about what Patroclus was to Achilles begins in the orators.) The self-portrait that follows is pitiless: "a useless weight on the plowland" — the best of the Achaeans as unharvested ground.
- 9 ll. 107-126 The wish against strife: "may strife perish from among gods and men, and anger, that drives even the prudent man to harshness: sweeter by far than honey dripping down, it swells like smoke in the chests of men." The wrath of the poem's first word is renounced by its owner in its most quoted self-description — anger as honey and smoke, pleasure and suffocation in one body. Then the turn: "done is done"; death accepted "whenever Zeus wills"; the Heracles precedent (even Zeus's dearest died); and the terrible new economy of fame — to make "some deep-girdled woman of Troy or Dardania wipe with both her hands the tears from her soft cheeks": his glory henceforth denominated in enemy grief. Thetis does not argue; she schedules the armor.
- 10 ll. 148-202 Hera's covert operation: Iris sent "in secret from Zeus," finding Achilles weaponless — and Iris's answer to "how am I to go?" is the poem's discovery about presence: "go to the ditch, just as you are, and show yourself." The reuse of 16.42-43 (our English kept: "catch their breath... for the breathing-spaces of war are few") makes the point formally: what Patroclus's borrowed armor did in Book 16, Achilles' bare appearance will do now. The disguise-plot ends: the man himself is the weapon.
- 11 ll. 203-231 The epiphany at the ditch: aegis, golden cloud, and flame from the head — and the great simile turns the Achaean camp inside out: the light is like smoke and beacon-fires "from an island that enemies have surrounded... in hope that neighbors may come with ships as warders-off of ruin." The besieged fleet's distress-signal is Achilles himself: he is the rescue the beacons pray for. The trumpet simile (a city ringed by "life-breaking" enemies) keeps the siege inverted; Athena's voice doubles his; and the toll is the poem's most economical: twelve men dead "on their own chariots and their own spears" — killed by sound. He never crosses the ditch; his mother's command holds even here.
- 12 ll. 232-239 The body received: Achilles walking behind the bier "shedding hot tears, when he saw his trusted companion lying on the litter, torn by the sharp bronze — the man he

had sent out with horses and chariot into the war, and never received again at his homecoming." The verb is Thetis's (59, 89, 440): the failed reception, parent's and friend's, is now the poem's defining gesture of loss.

- 13 *ll. 239-242* Hera sends the unwearied Sun into Ocean "much against his will": the goddess closes by force the day that began at 11.1 — the longest day in poetry, eight books long — and with it expires Hector's warrant, which ran "until the sun goes down" (11.193-194). The astronomical order itself is bent to end a battle: nothing in the poem says more economically how much the gods now need Achilles on the field tomorrow.
- 14 *ll. 243-284* The standing assembly ("no man dared sit"): fear given a posture. Polydamas — introduced with his full credentials; born the same night as Hector, "one far the better in words, the other with the spear," the man who "alone looked before and behind" — gives the fourth and last of his counsels (12.61 accepted; 12.211 rejected; 13.726 accepted; now this): into the city tonight, fight from the towers at dawn. Every clause is correct, and the poem lets him paint the alternative exactly as Book 22 will stage it: the horses worn out "with every kind of running, driving them under the town... sooner the running dogs will eat him."
- 15 *ll. 285-310* Hector's answer — the register's darkly- glaring formula for the first time turned on his own counselor since 12.230. Its center is the war's balance- sheet: Priam's city, once "rich in gold, rich in bronze," stripped — "sold off, our treasures have long since passed to Phrygia and lovely Maeonia" — ten years of attrition in four lines, the clearest economics in the poem. Then the fatal logic: Zeus has granted me glory at the ships — "I will not allow" retreat; and the creed: "I will stand against him, face to face — whether he carries off the great triumph, or I. Enyalios is impartial: he kills the would-be killer" (ξυνὸς Ἐνυάλιος — war the commons, shared ground where the hunter is hunted). Magnificent, and the exact miscalculation: the last time Hector trusted a grant of Zeus, it expired at sundown (note [13]). It has.
- 16 *ll. 310-314* The narrator's civic verdict: the Trojans applaud — "the fools: for Pallas Athena had taken their wits from them. To Hector they gave their praise, whose counsels were ruinous; to Polydamas no man's, who had devised the good counsel." The poem's one explicit theory of collective political failure: the assembly's judgment itself god-damaged. Hector will remember this night with these very terms at 22.99-107 ("Polydamas will be first to heap reproach on me"); the applause the Trojans give here is the shame that keeps him outside the wall to die.
- 17 *ll. 314-355* The wake. Achilles leads the lament with "man-slaughtering hands" laid on his companion's chest — the poem's fixed epithet for Hector's hands (ἀνδροφόνος) transferred once, here, to Achilles' (ancient copies read it either way; the transfer is the point). The lion robbed of his cubs "goes down glen after glen tracking the man's footprints... for bitter anger takes hold of him": grief as pursuit — the simile knows revenge is a species of mourning. The speech makes the broken promise to Menoetius explicit (Opoeis, the share of spoils), accepts the shared grave ("the two of us are fated to redden the same earth here in Troy"), and then makes the poem's darkest vow: Hector's armor and head; "and before your pyre I will cut the throats of twelve shining children of the Trojans" — human sacrifice, promised in cold blood and later paid (21.27-32; 23.175-176). The poem neither softens nor condemns it; it sets it beside the tenderness

of the washing — the boiled water, oil, nine-year unguent, soft linen, white cloak — one night containing both.

- 18 *Il. 356-368* Zeus and Hera, dry as a domestic ledger: "So you have managed it... Truly they must be your own children, these long-haired Achaeans — born from you!" Her answer scales godhead by analogy from below: even a mortal man does what he can for a friend — how should the best of goddesses "not stitch evils for the Trojans in my anger?" (κακὰ ῥάψαι — mischief as needlework: the craft-verb of the book, on the eve of its greatest crafting.) An ancient critic (Zenodorus) condemned the exchange; it is the Olympian marriage in equilibrium — the quarrel of Books 1 and 15 subsided into married irony.
- 19 *Il. 369-381* The house of Hephaestus, "imperishable, starry... he had made it himself" — and the first wonder: twenty tripods with golden wheels under their bases, "so that self-moved (αὐτόματα) they might enter the assembly of the gods and come home to his house again." The first self-propelled machines in literature, unfinished on the workbench — their intricate handles still to be riveted — when the biggest commission of the poem walks in. The god of craft is discovered mid-project, sweating; labor is labor even on Olympus.
- 20 *Il. 382-409* Charis — "Grace of the shining veil" — is Hephaestus's wife here (in the *Odyssey* it is Aphrodite: the poem marries the craftsman to the quality of his own work). Her hospitality frames the god's great autobiography: thrown from heaven by "my own bitch-faced mother," who wanted the lame child hidden; caught in the laps of Thetis and Eurynome; nine years in the sea-cave forging "brooches, and curved spiral-bracelets, and rosette-cups, and necklaces" while Ocean foamed around and no one knew. (At 1.590-594 he tells of a different fall — hurled by Zeus, landing on Lemnos: two falls, unreconciled; a god may have more than one myth.) The debt is named in the language of ransom: ζῳάγια, "the whole ransom of my life" — the shield of Achilles will be forged as the repayment of a rescue, the poem's economy of obligation reaching into heaven.
- 21 *Il. 410-421* The god at rest: the "monstrous bulk" heaving up from the anvil-block, the sponge over face and hands and "shaggy chest" — divine labor with human sweat — and then the second wonder: "attendants made of gold, in the likeness of living girls: in them is mind, in their breasts, and voice, and strength; and they know handiwork from the immortal gods." Artificial intelligence, three millennia early: the lame god has built himself helpers with minds. The poem presents them without astonishment — in this house, the made and the living have equal standing.
- 22 *Il. 428-461* Thetis's petition: her own biography first — married off "out of all the sisters of the sea... and I endured a man's bed, much against my will," Peleus now "worn out with wretched old age" (the wedding the gods attended, reduced to a widowhood-in-waiting); the sapling lines repeated verbatim from her lament (note [5]); and then the entire *Iliad* summarized in thirteen lines — the prize taken, the wrath, the embassy's gifts refused, the borrowed armor, Apollo's kill, Hector's glory — the poem retold inside the poem as one mother's grievance (Aristarchus athetized the summary as needless; it is the story's shape seen from the sea: this is what the epic looks like to a bereaved immortal). The request itself is a plain equipment-list: shield, helmet, greaves with ankle-pieces, corslet — for a son she names with her own epithet for him: "quick-fated."

- 23 ll. 462-467 Hephaestus's answer measures exactly what craft can and cannot do: "Would that I could hide him away from harsh-sounding death as surely... as fine armor shall be his." He can make anything except the one thing wanted. The armor is promised not as protection but as marvel — "any man of the many who see it hereafter will wonder" — art's honest offer: not to save, but to amaze.
- 24 ll. 468-482 The forge in motion: twenty bellows blowing "at every strength... however Hephaestus willed it and the work required" — automated, responsive tools; the four metals; anvil, hammer, tongs. The shield: five layers, triple shining rim, silver strap — and the maker's formula that will govern everything on it: "he wrought many intricate things with his knowing craft" (ιδυίησι πραπίδεσσιν — with knowing wits: intelligence in the hands).
- 25 ll. 483-489 The cosmos first: earth, heaven, sea, sun, full moon, "all the constellations with which heaven is crowned" — Pleiades, Hyades, Orion's strength, and the Bear-also-called-Wagon "who turns in her own place, keeping watch on Orion, and alone has no share in the baths of Ocean": the circumpolar star that never sets, described with precise naked-eye astronomy (the same lines steer Odysseus at Od. 5.272-275). The shield begins where Genesis begins; everything human on it will happen under this permanent sky.
- 26 ll. 490-508 The city at peace: weddings first — torchlit processions, the hymenaios, whirling dancers, "the women, standing each at her door, looked on and marveled" (the audience inside the artwork, marveling as we do). Then the trial: two men quarreling "over the blood-price of a man who was killed" — one claiming full payment made, one refusing to accept — both eager for an arbiter; the elders in the sacred circle with the heralds' scepters, judging in turn; two talents of gold for "the straightest judgment." The most-argued lines in Greek legal history (already in antiquity) — and, in this poem, the shield's quiet answer to its bearer: in the city at peace, a killing becomes a procedure; ποινή can be paid, accepted, judged. Ajax said it to Achilles' face (9.632-636): a man accepts the price even for a slain brother. Achilles carries into battle a picture of the settlement he refused — and will, in Book 24, at last enact.
- 27 ll. 509-540 The city at war fights this poem's own war in miniature: the divided counsel of the besiegers (sack, or take half the wealth — the very offer Hector floated at 22.111-121's rehearsal); the wall held by wives, children, and old men (Troy's exact demography, 8.518-522); the ambush at the watering-place; the herdsmen killed "delighting in their pipes: the trap they never guessed" (the shield's one unbearable clause — music as the last sound of the unsuspecting); and the river-bank battle joined by Strife, Tumult, and deadly Fate dragging a dead man by the feet, "and the cloak on her shoulders was red with the blood of men. They closed and fought like living mortals" — the highest compliment art pays itself in the poem: the made men fight like real ones. What Hephaestus forges here is the Iliad.
- 28 ll. 541-550 The plowing: thrice-turned fallow, the teams wheeling, and at every turn "a man would come and put in their hands a cup of honey-sweet wine" — labor's rhythm marked in refreshment. Then the master-stroke: "the field grew black behind them, and looked like earth that the plow has turned, though it was made of gold: that was the very wonder of the work." Gold made to look like soil — the poem names realism itself as the miracle: not the precious material but its perfect surrender to truth.

- 29 *ll. 551-561* The king's estate: reapers, binders, boys with armfuls, the slaughtered ox under the oak, women and barley — and at the center, the poem's image of right lordship: "the king among them, in silence, staff in hand, stood at the swath, glad at heart." A king whose joy is watching his people's work — the anti-Agamemnon: no prize taken, nothing seized; the staff (σκήπτρον, the quarrel's own prop in Book 1) held in stillness over harvest instead of strife. (Some ancient copies added a line naming the grain "Eleusinian Demeter's" — the apparatus records the pious insertion.)
- 30 *ll. 562-573* The vineyard: gold vines, black grapes, silver poles, enamel ditch, tin fence, "and one single path led in" — the picture composed like the object it is. At its heart the poem's most haunting music: the boy with the clear lyre singing "the beautiful Linos-song in his delicate voice" while the pickers stamp and skip in time. The Linos-song was the ancient harvest-lament — grief for the dying year sung inside abundance (Herodotus 2.79 found its double in Egypt) — so even the shield's happiest panel keeps one thread of mourning, in a boy's voice, at the vintage.
- 31 *ll. 574-587* The cattle and the lions: the herd streaming out "beside a murmuring river, beside the waving reeds" — and then the shield's only irruption of the wild: two lions on the bellowing bull, "gulping the entrails and the black blood," the dogs barking close and shying back. The countryside's one violence is the oldest kind — predation, not war: on the shield as in the poem's similes, the lion is what battle keeps trying to look like.
- 32 *ll. 588-590* The sheep pasture: glen, steadings, huts, pens — three lines with no event at all: the shield's one panel of pure peace, and the shortest.
- 33 *ll. 591-607* The dancing floor "like the one that Daedalus once fashioned in wide Knossos for lovely-haired Ariadne" — Homer's only Daedalus, invoked as the craftsman's own benchmark: Hephaestus outdoing the human master. Young men and much-wooded girls ("whose bride-price is many oxen"), hand on wrist; linen and oiled tunics; garlands, gold daggers on silver belts; and the wheeling runs compared to a potter testing his wheel — a craft simile inside the craftwork, the second artisan invoked within the artifact. Then the line with the great textual history: "among them a divine singer made music, playing the lyre." Aristarchus deleted the singer (Athenaeus 180-181 preserves the surgery), claiming the verse was imported from *Odyssey* 4.17-18 — but the printed text keeps him, and rightly: the shield's final human figure is the poet, singing inside the world he is part of, while two acrobats lead the measure. The *Iliad*'s maker signs the work — inside it.
- 34 *ll. 607-608* Ocean at the rim: the river that circles the world circles the shield — the cosmos of line 483 closed by its own boundary; the object is finished as the world is, edged with water. On this disk Achilles will carry the entire ordered world — seasons, courts, weddings, harvests, the dance — into a battle where he intends to die.
- 35 *ll. 610-618* The rest, in one breath each: corslet "brighter than the blaze of fire," helmet with golden crest, greaves of pliant tin; and the delivery — Thetis "like a hawk plunged down from snow-capped Olympus, carrying the glittering armor." The book that began with a scream ends with a stoop of wings: the mother diving seaward-fast out of heaven, bringing her quick-fated son the most beautiful object in literature, so that he can go

ILIAD — BOOK 18

and be killed in it gloriously. Book 19 opens with the armor laid down clashing before him.

Iliad — Book 19

*Achilles gives up his wrath against Agamemnon, who blames a goddess;
Achilles arms for battle, and his horse foretells his death.*

- Dawn in her saffron robe rose up from the streams of Ocean¹
to bring light to the immortals and to mortal men;
and she came to the ships carrying the god's gifts.
She found her dear son lying over Patroclus,
5 wailing his piercing grief; and around him his many companions
mourned. The brilliant goddess stood among them,
and clung to his hand, and spoke a word, and named him:
"My child — we must let this man lie, for all our grief,²
since by the will of the gods, first of all, he was broken.
- 10 Now you: take from Hephaestus this famed armor,
beautiful — such as no man has ever worn on his shoulders."
So speaking, the goddess laid the armor down³
in front of Achilles; and all the intricate work clashed aloud.
And trembling took all the Myrmidons: not one dared
15 look at it straight on; they shrank away. But Achilles —
the more he looked, the deeper the anger sank in him, and his eyes
blazed out terribly under their lids like flame-glare;
and he delighted, holding the god's shining gifts in his hands.
And when he had taken his joy of looking at the intricate work,
20 at once he spoke winged words to his mother:
"Mother, the god has given me arms: such work as is fitting⁴
for immortals — such as no mortal man could have made.
Now I will arm myself in them. But I am terribly
afraid that meanwhile, into the stout son of Menoetius,
25 flies will enter by the bronze-cut wounds
and breed worms in him, and defile the body —
the life is slain out of it — and all the flesh will rot."
Then answered him the goddess, silver-footed Thetis:
"Child, do not let these things trouble your mind.
- 30 I will undertake to beat away those savage tribes,
the flies, that feed on men killed in war.

- Even if he lies here till a year runs to its end,
 his flesh shall stay sound as it is — or better.
 But you: call the Achaean heroes to assembly,
 35 renounce your wrath against Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,
 and then arm quickly for the war, and put on your valor."
 So speaking, she sent daring strength into him;
 and into Patroclus, through the nostrils, she distilled
 ambrosia and red nectar, so his flesh might stay sound.
 40 And brilliant Achilles went along the beach of the sea⁵
 shouting his terrible shout, and roused the Achaean heroes.
 And even those who before had always stayed among the ships —
 the helmsmen, the men who kept the steering-oars,
 and the stewards who stayed aboard as dealers of bread —
 45 even they went then to the assembly, because Achilles
 had appeared, who had long stayed out of the grievous fighting.
 And two came limping, the squires of Ares:
 war-staunch Tydeus's son and brilliant Odysseus,
 leaning on their spears, for they still carried grievous wounds;
 50 and they went and sat down in the front of the assembly.
 And last of all came the lord of men Agamemnon,
 carrying his wound: for he too, in the strong encounter,
 was stabbed by Coon, Antenor's son, with a bronze-fitted spear.
 And when all the Achaeans were gathered together,
 55 swift-footed Achilles rose up among them and spoke:
 "Son of Atreus — was this, then, in any way the better for us both,⁶
 for you and for me, when the two of us, grieved at heart,
 raged in heart-devouring strife for the sake of a girl?
 I wish Artemis had killed her with an arrow at the ships
 60 on the day I chose her from the sack of Lyrnessus:
 then not so many Achaeans would have bitten the boundless earth
 under enemy hands, while I raged on in my wrath.
 For Hector and the Trojans, the gain. The Achaeans, I think,
 will long remember the strife of me and you.
 65 But we will let that be — a thing done and past, for all our grief,⁷
 beating down the heart in our chests because we must.
 Now I end my anger. There is no need for me
 to rage on, relentless, forever. Come then: quickly

- drive the long-haired Achaeans into the war,
70 so that I can go out against the Trojans once again
and test them — whether they choose to spend the night by the ships.
Many a one of them, I think, will be glad to bend the knee,
whoever escapes out of the deadly war from under our spear."
So he spoke; and the strong-greaved Achaeans rejoiced
75 that the great-hearted son of Peleus renounced the wrath.
And among them spoke also the lord of men Agamemnon —⁸
from the place where he sat, not standing up in their midst:
"Friends, Danaan heroes, squires of Ares:⁹
when a man stands to speak, it is right to listen, and unseemly
80 to break in on him: that is hard even for a practiced speaker.
In a great uproar of men, how could anyone hear
or speak? Even a clear-voiced speaker is defeated there.
To the son of Peleus I will declare myself. But the rest of you
Argives, mark it, and each man know my word well.
85 Often the Achaeans have said this thing against me,
and they would revile me for it. But I am not to blame:
Zeus is, and Fate, and the Erinyes who walks in mist,
who cast wild blindness into my mind in the assembly
on that day when I myself stripped Achilles of his prize.
90 But what could I do? A god carries all things to their end:
Blindness, the eldest daughter of Zeus, who blinds¹⁰
all men — the deadly one. Her feet are soft: not on the ground
does she walk, but over the heads of men
she moves, damaging mankind; and one after another she snares.
95 For once she blinded even Zeus — and he, they say, is best
of men and gods alike; yet even Zeus
Hera, female as she is, deceived with her scheming
on the day when the might of Heracles was due to be born
of Alcmene, inside fair-crowned Thebes.
100 For Zeus spoke out in triumph among all the gods:
'Hear me, all you gods and all you goddesses,
while I say what the heart in my chest commands me.
Today Eileithyia of hard labor will bring
into the light a man who shall rule all who dwell around him —
105 of the race of men who are of my own blood.'

- And scheming lady Hera answered him:
 'You will prove a liar: you will set no fulfillment on your word.
 Come then, Olympian: swear me now a strong oath
 that he shall indeed be lord of all who dwell around him
 110 who on this day falls between the feet of a woman,
 of those men who are of the race of your blood.'
 So she spoke; and Zeus saw none of her scheming,
 but swore the great oath — and was blinded to his cost.
 And Hera darted down, leaving the peak of Olympus,
 115 and came quickly to Achaean Argos, where she knew
 the sturdy wife of Sthenelus, Perseus's son.
 She was pregnant with a dear son, and her seventh month was
 standing;
 and Hera brought him out into the light before his month,
 and stayed Alcmene's labor, and held back the Eileithyiai.
 120 Then she herself brought the news, and said to Zeus, Cronos's son:
 'Father Zeus of the bright bolt — I will put a word in your mind.
 Already a fine man is born who shall rule the Argives:
 Eurystheus, son of Sthenelus, Perseus's son —
 your stock. It is no disgrace for him to rule the Argives.'
 125 So she spoke; and sharp grief struck him deep in his mind.
 And at once he seized Blindness by her shining-braided head,
 raging in his heart, and swore a strong oath
 that never again to Olympus and the starry heaven
 would she come back — Blindness, who blinds all.
 130 So speaking, he whirled her in his hand and flung her
 out of the starry heaven; and soon she came to the works of men.
 Over her he groaned forever, whenever he saw his dear son
 doing shameful labor under Eurystheus's tasks.
 So I too — when great Hector of the flashing helmet
 135 kept slaughtering Argives at the sterns of the ships,
 I could not forget the Blindness that first blinded me.
 But since I was blinded, and Zeus took my wits away,¹¹
 I am willing to make amends, and to give ransom past counting.
 Up, then, into the war — and rouse the rest of the army.
 140 The gifts: I am here to furnish all of them, as many
 as brilliant Odysseus promised yesterday in your hut.

Or if you wish, hold back a while, pressed though you are for war,
and my attendants will fetch the gifts out of my ship
and bring them here — and you will see I give what contents your
heart."

- 145 Then in answer spoke to him swift-footed Achilles:
"Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of men Agamemnon:¹²
the gifts — furnish them if you wish, as is proper,
or keep them with you. But now let us remember our war-craft,
at once. There is no need to sit here bandying words,
150 no need for delay: a great work is still undone —
so that men may see Achilles once again among the front-fighters,
wrecking the Trojan battalions with his bronze spear.
So let each of you remember this, and fight your man."
Then in answer spoke to him resourceful Odysseus:
155 "Not so — brave though you are, godlike Achilles.¹³
Do not drive the sons of the Achaeans fasting toward Ilion
to fight the Trojans, since the press of battle will not last
a short time only, once the phalanxes of men
close with each other, and the god breathes fury into both.
160 No — order the Achaeans by the swift ships to take
bread and wine: for that is fury, and that is valor.
No man will be able to fight the whole day through,
to the setting of the sun, fasting from bread:
for even if in his heart he is wild to make war,
165 his limbs grow heavy on him unawares, and thirst
and hunger overtake him, and his knees fail as he goes.
But the man who has had his fill of wine and food
and fights the enemy men the whole day long —
his heart in his chest is daring, and his limbs
170 do not tire before all break off from the war.
Come then: dismiss the army, and order the morning meal
made ready. And the gifts — let the lord of men Agamemnon
bring them into the middle of the assembly, so all the Achaeans
may see them with their eyes, and your heart be warmed.
175 And let him stand up among the Argives and swear you an oath
that he never went up into her bed, he never lay with her,
as is the way, lord, of men and women;

and let the heart in your own chest be gracious.
 And then let him appease you with a rich feast
 180 in his hut, so you may lack nothing of your due.
 And you, son of Atreus, will be more just toward another man
 hereafter. There is no cause for indignation when a king
 makes amends to a man, when he was first to turn harsh."
 Then answered him the lord of men Agamemnon:¹⁴
 185 "I am glad, son of Laertes, to hear your speech:
 you have gone through it all in due measure, point by point.
 The oath — I am willing to swear it; my heart commands me;
 and I will not forswear myself before the god. But let Achilles
 wait here so long, pressed though he is for the war-god's work;
 190 and wait, all the rest of you, together, until the gifts
 come from my hut, and we cut the faithful oaths.
 And to you yourself, Odysseus, I give this charge and order:
 choose out the noblest young men of all the Achaeans
 and carry the gifts from my ship, all that yesterday
 195 we promised to give Achilles — and lead the women too.
 And let Talthybius, quickly, through the broad Achaean camp,
 make ready a boar, to sacrifice to Zeus and to the Sun."
 Then in answer spoke to him swift-footed Achilles:
 "Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of men Agamemnon:¹⁵
 200 some other time were better for busying yourselves with this —
 some pause in the fighting, whenever one may come,
 some hour when the fury is not so great in my chest.
 Now they lie torn — the men whom Hector, Priam's son,
 broke, when Zeus was handing him the glory —
 205 and you two urge us to our food! For my part
 I would command the sons of the Achaeans to fight now,
 fasting, unfed, and at the setting of the sun
 make a great supper — once we have paid off the outrage.
 Before that, down my own throat, not a thing
 210 shall pass — no drink, no food — my companion being dead,
 who lies in my hut torn by the sharp bronze,
 turned toward the doorway, and around him our companions
 mourn. So those things have no place in my thoughts —
 but slaughter, and blood, and the hard groaning of men."

- 215 Then in answer spoke to him resourceful Odysseus:
 "Achilles, son of Peleus, far greatest of the Achaeans,¹⁶
 you are stronger than I am, and mightier, not by a little,
 with the spear; but in thought I would surpass you
 by much, since I was born first and know more things.
- 220 So let your heart endure to hear my words.
 Quickly men have their fill of battle —
 that harvest where the bronze strews the most straw on the ground
 and the crop is smallest, once Zeus tilts his scales —
 Zeus, the dispenser of war to men.
- 225 With the belly the Achaeans cannot mourn a corpse:
 too many men, one on another, day after day,
 are falling; when could anyone breathe from the labor?
 No — we must bury the man who dies,
 keeping a pitiless heart, weeping for one day;
- 230 and all who are left alive from the hateful war
 must remember drink and food, so that all the more
 we may fight the enemy without pause, forever,
 our flesh clothed in unwearying bronze. And let no man
 hang back, waiting for a second summons to the army:
- 235 this is the summons — and it will go hard with the man who is left
 behind at the ships of the Argives. All in one body,
 let us wake the sharp war-god against the horse-taming Trojans."
 He spoke, and took with him the sons of glorious Nestor,¹⁷
 and Meges, Phyleus's son, and Thoas, and Meriones,
- 240 and Lycomedes, Creon's son, and Melanippus;
 and they went to the hut of Agamemnon, Atreus's son.
 Then no sooner was the word said than the thing was done:
 seven tripods they carried out of the hut, as he had promised him,
 and twenty gleaming cauldrons, and twelve horses;
- 245 and they led out at once the women skilled in blameless work,
 seven, and the eighth was fair-cheeked Briseis.
 Then Odysseus weighed out ten full talents of gold
 and led the way; and the young Achaean men behind him carried the
 gifts.
 And they set them in the middle of the assembly; and Agamemnon¹⁸
- 250 stood up. Talthylbius, his voice like a god's,

holding the boar in his hands, stood beside the shepherd of the people.
 And the son of Atreus drew out with his hands the knife
 that always hung beside the great scabbard of his sword,
 cut the first hairs from the boar, and lifting his hands
 255 to Zeus he prayed. And all the Argives sat by in silence,
 in due order, listening to the king.
 And praying, he spoke, looking up into the wide heaven:
 "Let Zeus be witness first — highest of the gods, and best —
 and Earth, and the Sun, and the Erinyes, who under the earth
 260 exact payment from men, whoever swears a false oath:
 I never laid a hand on the girl Briseis,
 neither desiring her for my bed nor for anything else;
 untouched she has remained inside my huts.
 If any of this is falsely sworn, may the gods give me pains
 265 in plenty — all they give a man who sins against them in his oath."
 He spoke, and cut the boar's throat with the pitiless bronze.
 And Talthibius whirled it and threw it into the great gulf
 of the grey sea, food for fish. Then Achilles
 rose up and spoke among the war-loving Argives:
 270 "Father Zeus — great is the blindness you deal to men!¹⁹
 Never otherwise would the son of Atreus have stirred
 the heart in my chest so thoroughly, nor led the girl off
 against my will, unbending. No: it was Zeus, somehow,
 who willed that death should come to many Achaeans.
 275 Now go to your meal, so we may join the war-god together."
 So he spoke, and dissolved the assembly quickly.
 They scattered then, each man to his own ship;
 but the great-hearted Myrmidons busied themselves with the gifts
 and went carrying them to the ship of godlike Achilles.
 280 They laid them in the huts, and seated the women there,
 and proud attendants drove the horses to the herd.
 Then Briseis, like golden Aphrodite,²⁰
 when she saw Patroclus torn by the sharp bronze,
 flung herself on him with a piercing wail, and with her hands tore
 285 her breasts and her soft throat and her beautiful face.
 And weeping, the woman like the goddesses said:
 "Patroclus — dearest of all to my unhappy heart —

- alive I left you when I went out of this hut;
 now I come back, leader of the people, and find you
 290 dead. So evil follows evil for me, always.
 The husband to whom my father and lady mother gave me
 I saw torn by the sharp bronze before our city,
 and my three brothers, whom one mother bore with me,
 beloved — all of them met their day of destruction.
- 295 And you would not let me — not even when swift Achilles
 killed my husband, and sacked the city of godlike Mynes —
 you would not let me weep: you kept saying you would make me
 the wedded wife of godlike Achilles, and take me in the ships
 to Phthia, and hold my marriage-feast among the Myrmidons.
- 300 So I weep your death without ceasing. You were gentle, always."
 So she spoke, weeping; and the women wailed in answer —
 for Patroclus in show; but each for her own sorrows.
 And around Achilles the elders of the Achaeans gathered,²¹
 begging him to eat; but he refused them, groaning:
- 305 "I beg you — if any of my dear companions will hear me —
 do not bid me, before it is time, with food and drink
 to sate my own heart, since terrible grief has come to me.
 Until the sun goes down I will hold out, and endure regardless."
 So speaking, he sent the other kings away,
- 310 but the two sons of Atreus stayed, and brilliant Odysseus,
 and Nestor, and Idomeneus, and the old horseman Phoenix,
 trying to comfort his thick grief. But his heart would not
 be comforted, before he entered the mouth of bloody war.
 Remembering, he heaved a deep sigh, and spoke aloud:
- 315 "There was a time — unhappy man, dearest of my companions —²²
 when you yourself would set the savory meal before me in this hut,
 quickly and deftly, whenever the Achaeans were rushing
 to carry the war of many tears against the horse-taming Trojans.
 Now you lie torn; and my heart goes
- 320 without taste of the drink and food that are here in plenty,
 for want of you. Nothing worse could I suffer —
 not even if I learned my father had died,
 who now in Phthia, I suppose, is letting soft tears fall
 for lack of a son like me — while I, in a strange country,

- 325 fight the Trojans for blood-chilling Helen's sake —
 or the death of my dear son, who is being reared for me on Scyros:
 if he still lives somewhere — godlike Neoptolemus.
 For until now the heart in my chest had hoped
 that I alone would die far from horse-pasturing Argos,
 330 here in Troy, and that you would come home to Phthia,
 so you might take my child in the swift black ship
 out of Scyros, and show him everything of mine —
 my possessions, my slaves, my great high-roofed house.
 For Peleus by now, I think, is either altogether
 335 dead, or — barely living still — he grieves on
 in hateful old age, forever waiting the bitter
 news of me: when he shall hear that I am dead."
 So he spoke, weeping; and the elders groaned in answer,²³
 each remembering what he had left behind in his own halls.
 340 And seeing them mourning, the son of Cronos pitied them,
 and quickly he spoke winged words to Athena:
 "My child, you have deserted your man completely.
 Is Achilles, then, no longer any care to your mind?
 There he sits, in front of his ships with their upright horns,
 345 mourning his dear companion. The others
 have gone to their meal; he is fasting, and will not eat.
 Go — distill nectar and lovely ambrosia
 into his chest, so hunger does not reach him."
 So speaking, he urged on Athena, eager already;
 350 and like a falcon, wide-winged and shrill-voiced,
 she dropped from heaven through the upper air. And the Achaeans
 were arming there and then throughout the camp. To Achilles
 she distilled nectar in his chest, and lovely
 ambrosia, so joyless hunger would not reach his knees;
 355 and she was gone, back to the close-built house of her mighty
 father. And they poured out away from the swift ships.
 As when thick snowflakes flutter down from Zeus,²⁴
 cold under the blast of Boreas born in the clear sky,
 so thick then the helmets, glittering bright,
 360 streamed out of the ships, and the bossed shields,
 the strong-plated corslets and the ash-wood spears.

- The gleam went up to heaven; and all the earth around laughed
 at the lightning-flash of bronze; and a thunder rose from under
 the feet of men. And in their midst brilliant Achilles armed.
- 365 His teeth ground loud against each other; and his two eyes²⁵
 blazed as if they were flame-glare; and into his heart
 sank grief past bearing. Raging against the Trojans,
 he put on the gifts of the god that Hephaestus had labored to forge.
 First he set the greaves along his shins,
- 370 fine greaves, fitted with silver ankle-pieces;
 second, he put the corslet about his chest;
 and around his shoulders he threw the sword, silver-studded,
 bronze; and after that the shield, great and heavy,
 he took up, and its light went out far, like the moon's.
- 375 As when out at sea a light shows to sailors,
 the glare of a burning fire, that burns high in the mountains
 at a lonely steading — while the storm-winds carry them,
 unwilling, over the fish-filled sea away from their dear ones:
 so from Achilles' shield the light went up to the upper air,
- 380 the beautiful, intricate shield. And lifting the heavy helmet
 he set it on his head; and it shone out like a star,
 the horse-haired helmet; and around it shook the plumes
 of gold that Hephaestus had set thick along the crest.
 And brilliant Achilles tried himself in the armor,²⁶
- 385 whether it fitted him, and his shining limbs ran free in it;
 and it became like wings to him, and lifted the shepherd of the people.
 And out of its case he drew his father's spear —
 heavy, huge, compact — no other of the Achaeans
 could swing it; Achilles alone knew how to swing it —
- 390 the Pelian ash that Chiron gave his dear father
 from the peak of Pelion, to be death for heroes.
 And Automedon and Alcimus tended the horses²⁷
 and yoked them: they put the fine breast-straps on, cast the bits
 into their jaws, and drew the reins back tight
- 395 to the jointed chariot. And taking up the shining whip,
 fitted to his hand, Automedon sprang up
 behind the horses; and behind him, armed, mounted Achilles,
 blazing in his gear like Hyperion the shining sun,

and terribly he called to the horses of his father:

- 400 "Xanthus and Balius, far-famed children of Podarge:
take thought, this time, to bring your charioteer back safe
into the crowd of the Danaans, when we have had our fill of war —
do not leave him there, like Patroclus, dead."
Then from under the yoke the glancing-footed horse answered him —
- 405 Xanthus. He dropped his head, suddenly, and all his mane,
spilling from the yoke-pad by the yoke, came down and reached the
ground;
and the goddess white-armed Hera gave him voice:
"This time, yes — we will bring you back safe, mighty Achilles.
But the day of your destruction is near. And it is not we
410 who are to blame, but a great god, and strong Fate.
It was not by our slowness, not by any sloth of ours,
that the Trojans stripped the armor from Patroclus's shoulders:
the best of the gods, whom lovely-haired Leto bore,
killed him among the front-fighters, and gave the glory to Hector.
- 415 We two could run with the very breath of the West Wind,
which men say is the lightest thing that flies; but for you yourself
it is fated to be broken by force — by a god, and by a man."
When he had spoken so, the Erinyes stopped his voice.
Then, deeply troubled, swift-footed Achilles answered him:
- 420 "Xanthus, why prophesy my death? You need not.
I know it well myself: it is my portion to die here,
far from my dear father and my mother. Even so,
I will not stop before I have driven the Trojans to their fill of war."
He spoke; and shouting he held his single-hoofed horses in the front
rank.

NOTES TO BOOK 19

- 1 ll. 1-7 Dawn "in her saffron robe" (κροκόπεπλος, the register's fixed rendering) rises from Ocean to light a day that will end with Hector dead; line 2 repeats 11.2 exactly (our English kept), binding this dawn to the one that opened the poem's longest day. Thetis arrives to find her son not waiting for the armor but "lying over Patroclus" — the delivery of the most beautiful object in literature interrupts an embrace of a corpse.
- 2 ll. 8-11 Thetis's consolation is the poem's hardest kind: "we must let this man lie, for all our grief, since by the will of the gods, first of all, he was broken" — the same verb-frame Achilles used of the quarrel at 18.112. Grief is to be set down the way a settled thing is set down. Then the gift: armor "such as no man has ever worn on his shoulders" — literally true; it was forged for one wearing.
- 3 ll. 12-18 The armor "clashed aloud" (ἀνέβραχε) — its first act is a war-sound — and the Myrmidons cannot look at it: Hephaestus promised that "any man of the many who see it hereafter will marvel" (18.466-467), and the marvel arrives as terror. Only Achilles can face it, and the poem's psychology is exact: "the more he looked, the deeper the anger sank in him." Beauty does not soothe him; it fuels him. His eyes blaze "like flame-glare" — the fire Athena lit over his head at the ditch (18.206-227) has moved inside.
- 4 ll. 21-39 Achilles' first thought after accepting the arms is the flies. The realism is unblinking — "flies will enter by the bronze-cut wounds and breed worms... and all the flesh will rot" — and the divine answer matches it: ambrosia and red nectar distilled through the nostrils, the body kept "a year entire... sound as it is, or better." Embalming, in the poem's idiom: the gods' food, which makes the immortals deathless, here holds one mortal body just short of decay. (Line 39's placement was doubted by some ancient editors; a few copies added an extra line after 38 on Thetis's departure — the apparatus records it.)
- 5 ll. 40-53 The muster of everyone: even the helmsmen and the ships' bread-stewards — the poem's only census of the noncombatants — come to see Achilles reappear. The wounded kings arrive as casualties of Book 11: Diomedes and Odysseus "leaning on their spears," Agamemnon last, still carrying Coön's spear-wound (11.251-253). The assembly that ends the quarrel physically displays what the quarrel cost.
- 6 ll. 56-64 The renunciation begins with a wish that undoes the poem: better Artemis had shot Briseis "on the day I chose her from the sack of Lyrnessus" — the prize whose taking launched the wrath now wished dead by the man who fought for her honor... or rather for his. The accounting is pitiless: "For Hector and the Trojans, the gain." Briseis herself will be standing in the assembly within two hundred lines; the poem lets the wish and the woman meet.
- 7 ll. 65-75 The formal close of the wrath: 65-66 repeat 18.112-113 verbatim (our English kept) — the renunciation rehearsed to his mother now performed in public. The narrator seals it with the poem's own thematic word: "the great-hearted son of Peleus

renounced the wrath" (μῆνιν ἀπειπόντος) — the μῆνις of line 1.1, formally discharged. What replaces it is not peace: it is a purer anger with a different object.

- 8 ll. 76-77 The strangest stage-direction in the poem: Agamemnon speaks "from the place where he sat, not standing up in their midst." Ancient editors were so unsettled that Zenodotus's text (with the Massaliot and Chian editions) substituted a standing formula — "rising up among them spoke the wide-ruling Agamemnon" — and the Massaliot text added a line about him "groaning over his wound." The vulgate's seated king is better: whether he sits as an invalid, or to avoid the exposed stance of a formal orator (his next lines fret about hecklers), or because he cannot bring himself to perform deference standing, the poem's great authority-figure ends the quarrel without ever getting to his feet.
- 9 ll. 78-94 The apology that is not one. After a nervous exordium on heckling ("even a clear-voiced speaker is defeated"), the thesis: "I am not to blame: Zeus is, and Fate, and the Erinys who walks in mist." The word rendered "blindness" is ἄτη — the divinely-sent infatuation that makes disaster feel reasonable. This register keeps "Blindness" from Phoenix's allegory (9.502-512), where she is "strong and sound of foot" and outruns the limping Prayers; here her feet are "soft: not on the ground does she walk, but over the heads of men." Two portraits, one goddess: fast as rumor, soft as a thought. Aristarchus athetized line 94 as an over-explaining tag. Line 77's opening ("when a man stands to speak...") was read by some ancients as a rebuke of Achilles' brevity; more likely it is anxiety dressed as etiquette.
- 10 ll. 95-133 The parable of Ate: even Zeus was blinded — on the day of Heracles' birth, when Hera extracted the unguarded oath, held back the Eileithyiai to delay Alcmena, and rushed Eurystheus into the light at seven months: the poem's most consequential act of obstetric sabotage, making the strongest man ever born the servant of the weakest king. Zeus's response founds the theology Agamemnon needs: he threw Blindness out of heaven by her "shining-braided head" — so she now lives here, "among the works of men." Delusion is a permanent resident of earth by divine eviction: whatever we wreck, we wreck in her company. The self-serving use is patent — if Zeus could be blinded, the king's surrender of judgment is company for gods — and the poem neither endorses nor mocks it; it lets Achilles accept the same doctrine at 270-274.
- 11 ll. 134-144 The amends: 138 repeats 9.120 exactly ("I am willing to make amends, and to give ransom past counting") — Agamemnon's position has not moved one line in ten books; what has moved is everything around it. One ancient text (quoted by Athenaeus from Dioscurides) added a line after 137: "either drunk with wine, or the gods themselves hurt me" — a plus-line that makes the king blame the cup as well as the goddess; the vulgate rightly refuses it.
- 12 ll. 145-153 Achilles' answer prices the gifts at nothing: "furnish them if you wish, as is proper, or keep them with you." The catalogue that Book 9 built across forty lines and Book 19 will parade through the assembly is waved off in a line and a half — the entire heroic economy of compensation dismissed by the man it was designed to persuade. What he wants now cannot be paid in tripods.

- 13 *ll. 154-183* Odysseus's first meal-speech, and a small masterpiece of practical authority: "bread and wine — for that is fury, and that is valor." The physiology is exact (the limbs "grow heavy unawares"; the knees fail), and the procedure he lays out — gifts displayed in mid-assembly, the oath about Briseis' bed sworn standing (176-177 reuse the wording of 9.133-134), the feast of appeasement, so Achilles "may lack nothing of your due" (δίκη — of justice) — is a complete protocol for ending a feud, dikē made procedural. His closing sentence dares what no one else has: "you, son of Atreus, will be more just toward another man hereafter" — the king corrected to his face, inside a compliment.
- 14 *ll. 184-197* Agamemnon accepts everything, gladly — the management of the reconciliation has passed entirely to Odysseus ("to you yourself I give this charge"). The king's one initiative is liturgical: Talthybius and the boar for Zeus and the Sun.
- 15 *ll. 198-214* Achilles' refusal of food is the book's center of gravity. His counter-proposal — fight fasting, feast at sundown "once we have paid off the outrage" — makes eating itself a thing that must be earned by vengeance; and the personal vow beneath it is absolute: "down my own throat, not a thing shall pass." The speech ends on the book's most famous line, the fast's true diet: "but slaughter, and blood, and the hard groaning of men." Grief has reorganized appetite itself.
- 16 *ll. 215-237* Odysseus's second speech is the Iliad's ethics of endurance. The opening claim of eldership (216 = 16.21, our English kept — the vocative Patroclus once used to beg) licenses the great agricultural figure: battle as the harvest "where the bronze strews the most straw on the ground and the crop is smallest, once Zeus tilts his scales" — maximum cutting, minimum grain; and 224 = 4.84, "Zeus, the dispenser of war to men" (our English kept). Then the doctrine: "With the belly the Achaeans cannot mourn a corpse... we must bury the man who dies, keeping a pitiless heart, weeping for one day." An army that loses men daily must ration grief like food — the survivor's discipline stated once for the whole tradition. Achilles is not persuaded; he is overruled by everyone else's hunger.
- 17 *ll. 238-248* The gifts pass in review, matching the Book 9 pledge item for item (9.122-130, renderings kept): seven tripods, twenty cauldrons, twelve horses, seven women of Lesbos — "and the eighth was fair-cheeked Briseis." The woman the poem began over enters as the last item in an inventory, between the women and the gold. Lycomedes and Melanippus and the young nobles carry the treasure; nobody in the text so much as looks at it.
- 18 *ll. 249-268* The oath-rite, in exact ritual order: the herald holding the boar; the knife kept beside the sword's scabbard (a sacrificial implement carried into battle); the first-cut hairs; the invocation of Zeus, Earth, Sun, and the Erinyes "who under the earth exact payment from men" — the oath-police of the cosmos; the oath itself ("I never laid a hand on the girl Briseis" — confirming 9.133 was true when sworn); and the disposal: the boar whirled into the sea, "food for fish." An oath-victim is not eaten — it has absorbed the conditional curse — so the carcass goes to the element that swallows everything.
- 19 *ll. 270-275* Achilles' response accepts Agamemnon's theology wholesale: "Father Zeus — great is the blindness you deal to men!" — the wronged man agreeing that Zeus, not the king, "willed that death should come to many Achaeans." The quarrel thus closes with

both parties blaming heaven: a settlement, not a reckoning — and the poem quietly files it against Zeus's own protest in the *Odyssey* (1.32-34) that mortals blame the gods for what their own recklessness earns. The last line is pure Achilles: dismissal, meal, war — "so we may join the war-god together."

- 20 ll. 282-302 Briseis's only speech in the poem — the prize speaks. Her lament gives her, at last, a biography: husband cut down before the city, three full brothers dead in one day, and the man who did it — Achilles — the man whose wife Patroclus promised she would become, "with the marriage-feast among the Myrmidons." Her grief for Patroclus is grief for the one person who converted her catastrophe into a future; "You were gentle, always" (μεῖλιχον αἰεὶ) is the poem's whole portrait of the dead man in three words. Then the narrator's terrible widening: the captive women wail with her "for Patroclus in show; but each for her own sorrows" — every slave in the camp mourning her own dead under cover of the master's. Two lines that contain the entire suppressed grief of the war's losers.
- 21 ll. 303-313 The comforters: both Atreidae, Odysseus, Nestor, Idomeneus, Phoenix — the embassy of Book 9 enlarged — around a man who again refuses what they offer; but where Book 9's refusal was rage, this is grief with a deadline: "Until the sun goes down I will hold out." He cannot be comforted "before he entered the mouth of bloody war" — battle as the only door out of mourning.
- 22 ll. 314-337 The lament for a lost future. It begins at the table — Patroclus remembered not in arms but serving dinner "quickly and deftly": intimacy measured in housework — and opens into the poem's geography of bereavement: Peleus in Phthia weeping for a son who will not return, "while I, in a strange country, fight the Trojans for blood-chilling Helen's sake"; and on Scyros the son, Neoptolemus, named only here in the *Iliad* — "if he still lives" — whom Patroclus was to fetch home and show "my possessions, my slaves, my great high-roofed house." Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized line 327 (the Neoptolemus line); it should stand: the dead man's assignment was to be the bridge between Achilles' father and Achilles' son, and with him dies the family's last connected future. Achilles imagined one exemption — "that I alone would die" — and Troy has refused even that.
- 23 ll. 338-356 Zeus's pity and the strangest feeding in the poem: Athena, falcon-swift, distills nectar and ambrosia into the chest of a man who must not know he is being fed — the fast kept and the body sustained, both at once. The gods honor his vow by cheating it. The elders' tears ("each remembering what he had left behind in his own halls") make Achilles' singular grief, for one moment, the army's common one.
- 24 ll. 357-364 The arming of the host as weather: helmets thick as snowflakes "under the blast of Boreas born in the clear sky" — cold light, innumerable, wind-driven — "and all the earth around laughed at the lightning-flash of bronze." The laughing earth (γέλασσε... χθών) is the poem's boldest pathetic figure: the world itself amused, or gleaming — the Greek means both — at what is coming.
- 25 ll. 365-383 The fourth and last full arming scene of the poem (Paris 3.330-338; Agamemnon 11.17-45; Patroclus 16.131-139; now this), each item in the canonical order — greaves, corslet, sword, shield, helmet — and everything scaled up: teeth grinding,

eyes as flame-glare, the shield's light "like the moon's." The great simile turns Book 18 inside out: there, beacon-fires promised rescue to a besieged island; here the mountain fire is seen by sailors "storm-driven, unwilling, over the fish-filled sea away from their dear ones" — light as pure distance, home visible and unreachable. It is the truest emblem in the poem of what Achilles' return actually is: he shines, and he is not coming home.

- 26 ll. 384-391 The test: the armor fits so perfectly it "became like wings to him, and lifted the shepherd of the people" — Hephaestus's craft answering the body it was made for. Then the one weapon the god did not make: the Pelian ash of Chiron, which "no other of the Achaeans could swing" — 388-391 repeat 16.141-144 verbatim (our English kept), where Patroclus, taking everything else, left precisely this spear behind. Aristarchus athetized the lines here as an importation ("they were not even in the other editions"); kept, they complete the Book 16 figure: the borrowed armor is gone with the borrower, and what remains, inimitable, is the father's spear — the one piece of Achilles no one else could carry.
- 27 ll. 392-424 The ending no other book has. Achilles charges his horses to bring their driver back — "do not leave him there, like Patroclus, dead" — and Xanthus answers: Hera gives him voice (line 407, athetized by Aristarchus), and the horse first bows till his mane pours from the yoke-pad to the ground: the animal's grief-gesture the poem showed at 17.426-440, the weeping horses, now given language. His speech is exact prophecy: not our slowness but "the best of the gods" killed Patroclus; "we two could run with the very breath of the West Wind" — their sire (16.150) — "but for you yourself it is fated to be broken by force — by a god, and by a man" (Apollo and Paris, 22.359-360, though Aristarchus athetized 416-417). Then "the Erinyes stopped his voice" — the same powers invoked at 259 as oath-police: guardians of the order of things, for whom a speaking horse is a breach to be closed. Achilles' reply is the book in miniature: "I know it well myself." Foreknowledge changes nothing; that is what makes him Achilles. The book ends with the shout and the horses held "in the front rank" — the wrath's second life, pointed at Troy at last.

Iliad — Book 20

*Zeus lets the gods into the fighting; Achilles returns to battle and meets
Aeneas and Hector, whom the gods snatch to safety.*

- So beside the beaked ships the Achaeans armed¹
around you, son of Peleus — insatiate of battle! —
and the Trojans on their side, on the rise of the plain.
And Zeus commanded Themis to call the gods to assembly
5 from the crest of many-folded Olympus; and she went
everywhere, and commanded them to come to the house of Zeus.
Not one of the rivers was absent, except Ocean,
nor one of the nymphs, who haunt the beautiful groves
and the springs of rivers and the grassy water-meadows.
10 And coming to the house of Zeus the cloud-gatherer
they sat down in the polished colonnades that Hephaestus
had built for father Zeus with his knowing craft.
So they gathered inside Zeus's house. Nor did the earth-shaker²
ignore the goddess's call: he came out of the sea among them,
15 and sat in their midst, and asked what Zeus intended:
"Why, lord of the bright bolt, have you called the gods to assembly?
Are you deliberating something for the Trojans and Achaeans?
For now, at closest grip, their battle and war are blazing."
Then in answer spoke to him cloud-gatherer Zeus:
20 "You know, earth-shaker, the counsel in my chest,
the reason I gathered you: they matter to me, even as they perish.
Yet I — I will stay here in a fold of Olympus,
sitting where I can watch and delight my mind. But the rest of you:
go now, till you come among the Trojans and Achaeans,
25 and help both sides, as the mind of each of you inclines.
For if Achilles fights the Trojans alone,
not even briefly will they hold the swift-footed son of Peleus.
Even before, they trembled just to look at him;
now, with his heart raging terribly for his companion,
30 I fear he may storm the wall itself, ahead of what is fated."
So spoke the son of Cronos, and woke unrelenting war.

And the gods went to the war, their hearts divided:³
 Hera to the gathering-place of the ships, with Pallas Athena
 and Poseidon who holds the earth, and the courier
 35 Hermes, unmatched in the shrewdness of his mind;
 and with them went Hephaestus, glorying in his strength,
 limping, and beneath him his slender legs moved quickly.
 To the Trojans went Ares of the flashing helmet, and with him
 Phoebus of the unshorn hair, and Artemis who showers arrows,
 40 and Leto, and Xanthus, and laughter-loving Aphrodite.
 Now as long as the gods stayed apart from mortal men,⁴
 the Achaeans triumphed greatly, because Achilles
 had appeared, who had long stayed out of the grievous fighting,
 and terrible trembling came up in the limbs of every Trojan,
 45 in dread, when they saw the swift-footed son of Peleus
 blazing in his armor, the equal of Ares, bane of mortals.
 But when the Olympians came down into the crowd of men,
 up rose strong Strife, driver of armies, and Athena shouted,
 now standing at the dug ditch outside the wall,
 50 now on the thundering headlands crying her great cry;
 and Ares on the other side, like a black stormwind,
 screamed his shrill commands to the Trojans from the citadel's height,
 now running by Simoïs over Callicolone.
 So the blessed gods, driving both sides on,⁵
 55 clashed them together — and broke out their own heavy strife.
 And terribly, from on high, the father of men and gods
 thundered; and from below Poseidon shook
 the boundless earth and the steep heads of the mountains.
 All the roots of many-springed Ida were shaken,
 60 and all her peaks, and the Trojans' city, and the Achaeans' ships.
 And under the ground the lord of those below, Aïdoneus, took fright,
 and in his fright leapt from his throne and screamed — lest above him
 Poseidon the earth-shaker crack the earth wide open
 and his houses stand exposed to mortals and immortals —
 65 terrible, mouldering houses, which the very gods abhor:
 so great was the crash that rose as the gods came together in strife.
 For there, facing the lord Poseidon,⁶
 stood Phoebus Apollo with his winged arrows,

- and against Enyalios the goddess grey-eyed Athena;
70 against Hera stood the clamorous goddess of the golden shafts,
Artemis who showers arrows, sister of the far-striker;
against Leto the strong courier Hermes;
and against Hephaestus the great deep-eddying river
whom the gods call Xanthus, and men Scamander.
- 75 So god went against god. But Achilles⁷
longed above all to come through the crowd against Hector,
Priam's son: with that man's blood beyond all others
his heart commanded him to glut Ares, the fighter under the ox-hide
shield.
- But Apollo, driver of armies, stirred Aeneas
80 straight against the son of Peleus, and put strong fury in him.
He made his voice like the voice of Lycaon, Priam's son;
in his likeness spoke Apollo, son of Zeus:
"Aeneas, counselor of the Trojans — where are those threats
you made to the kings of Troy over your wine,
85 that you would fight Achilles, Peleus's son, man to man?"
Then in turn Aeneas answered him and said:⁸
"Son of Priam, why do you order me, against my own will,
to stand and fight the overweening son of Peleus?
It would not be the first time I stand against swift-footed
90 Achilles: once before now he chased me with his spear
off Ida, when he came down on our cattle
and sacked Lyrnessus and Pedasus. Zeus saved me,
rousing my strength and my quick knees —
else I had gone down under the hands of Achilles, and of Athena,
95 who went before him setting the light of safety, and urged him on
to slaughter Lelegians and Trojans with his bronze spear.
That is why no man can fight Achilles face to face:
always one of the gods is beside him, beating ruin away.
And even without that, his weapon flies straight, and does not slacken
100 till it has driven through human flesh. Yet if a god
stretched the war's issue level, he would not beat me
so easily — not though he boasts that he is bronze all through."
Then in turn the lord Apollo, son of Zeus, addressed him:⁹
"Hero — come then, you too: pray to the gods

- 105 who live forever. You also, men say, were born
of Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus; his mother is the lesser goddess:
yours is a child of Zeus; his, of the old man of the sea.
Carry your unwearied bronze straight at him. Do not let him
turn you back with contemptuous words and threats."
- 110 So speaking he breathed great fury into the shepherd of the people,
and he went through the front-fighters, helmed in gleaming bronze.
But the son of Anchises did not slip past white-armed Hera¹⁰
as he went through the press of men against the son of Peleus;
and she gathered the gods together and spoke among them:
- 115 "Consider, you two — Poseidon and Athena —
consider in your minds how these things are to go.
Here is Aeneas, marching helmed in gleaming bronze
against the son of Peleus — and Phoebus Apollo set him on.
Come then: either let us turn him back again
- 120 where he stands — or else let one of us
stand by Achilles too, and give him great strength; let his heart
lack nothing; let him know that they love him — the best
of the immortals — and that windy nothings are the ones who till now
have warded war and slaughter from the Trojans.
- 125 We all came down from Olympus to take our part
in this battle, so that among the Trojans he suffer nothing
today. Later he will suffer whatever Fate
spun for him with her thread at his birth, when his mother bore him.
But if Achilles does not learn all this from a god's own voice,
- 130 he will be afraid, when some god comes against him
face to face in the war. Gods seen in their true shapes are hard to bear."
Then answered her Poseidon the earth-shaker:¹¹
"Hera, do not rage beyond good sense. You need not.
I at least would not choose to drive the gods together
- 135 in strife — us against the others — since we are far the stronger.
No: let us go and sit down out of the path,
on a lookout place, and leave the war to men.
But if Ares begins the fighting, or Phoebus Apollo,
or if they hold Achilles back and will not let him fight,
- 140 then at once, on the spot, our own quarrel with them rises —
total war; and very soon, I think, they will break it off

- and go back to Olympus, to the company of the other gods,
beaten down under our hands by force."
So speaking, the dark-haired god led the way¹²
145 to the heaped-up wall of godlike Heracles —
the high wall the Trojans and Pallas Athena
had built him, so he might escape the sea-monster and elude it
whenever it chased him from the beach onto the plain.
There Poseidon sat down, and the other gods,
150 and drew unbroken cloud around their shoulders;
and the others sat over against them on the brows of Callicolone
around you, archer Phoebus, and Ares sacker of cities.
So on either side they sat deliberating
their counsels; but both sides shrank from beginning
155 the grinding war — and Zeus, seated on high, commanded it.
And the whole plain was filled with them, and blazed with the bronze¹³
of men and horses; and the earth rang under their feet
as they rushed together. And two men, the best by far,
came together in the middle ground, hot to fight:
160 Aeneas, Anchises' son, and brilliant Achilles.
Aeneas came out first, with a threat, tossing
his heavy helmet as he strode; his rushing shield
he held before his chest, and he shook his bronze spear.
And the son of Peleus rose from the other side to meet him like a lion,
165 a raider, whom men are wild to kill —
a whole district, gathered; and at first he comes on
heedless of them, but when one of the battle-quick young men
hits him with a spear, he crouches, jaws gaping, foam
gathering on his teeth, and the brave heart in him groans,
170 and with his tail he lashes his ribs and flanks
on both sides, and whips himself on to fight,
and glaring he drives straight in, to see whether he will kill
some man, or die himself in the front of the crowd:
so his fury and his proud heart drove Achilles
175 to go against great-hearted Aeneas.
And when they had come close, advancing on each other,
the first to speak was swift-footed brilliant Achilles:
"Aeneas — why have you come so far out of the crowd¹⁴

- to stand here? Does your heart command you to fight me
180 in hope of ruling the horse-taming Trojans
with Priam's honor? Even if you killed me,
Priam would not lay that prize in your hand:
he has sons; and he is steady, not weak in the head.
Or have the Trojans cut you a private estate, finest of all,
185 fair land of orchard and plowland, to enjoy
if you kill me? You will find that killing hard, I think.
Once before now, I say, my spear has made you run.
Do you not remember when you were alone with the cattle, and I
chased you down the mountains of Ida on my quick feet —
190 headlong? You did not turn to look back once as you ran.
From there you fled to Lyrnessus; and I wrecked it,
storming after you with Athena and father Zeus,
and took the women captive, their day of freedom gone —
though you Zeus rescued, and the other gods.
195 But now I think they will not save you, as in your heart
you reckon. No — go back into the crowd — that is my counsel —
and do not stand against me, before some evil
takes you. When the thing is done, even the fool learns."
Then in turn Aeneas answered him and said:¹⁵
200 "Son of Peleus — do not hope to frighten me with words,
as if I were a silly child, since I too know well enough
how to sling insults, and how to speak outrage.
We know each other's lineage, we know each other's parents,
hearing the famous tales of mortal men —
205 though you have never set eyes on mine, nor I on yours.
They say you are the son of blameless Peleus,
and your mother Thetis of the lovely braids, the sea-born;
I claim to be the son of great-hearted Anchises,
and my mother is Aphrodite.
210 Of those two houses, one pair will mourn their dear son
today: for I tell you, we two will not part from battle
and go our ways on the strength of silly words.
But if you care to learn this too, and know for certain
our lineage — and many men know it already:
215 Dardanus first was begotten by cloud-gatherer Zeus,

and he founded Dardania — for holy Ilion
 was not yet built on the plain, a city of mortal men,
 and they still lived on the lower slopes of many-springed Ida.
 And Dardanus in turn had a son, Erichthonius the king,
 220 who became the richest of mortal men:
 three thousand mares of his grazed the water-meadow,
 mothers, delighting in their tender foals.
 And Boreas desired them as they pastured,
 and covered them in the likeness of a dark-maned stallion;
 225 and they conceived, and bore twelve foals.
 And these, when they frisked over the grain-giving plowland,
 would run along the tips of the wheat-ears and never break them;
 and when they frisked over the broad back of the sea,
 they would run along the crests of the breakers of the grey salt water.
 230 And Erichthonius fathered Tros, lord of the Trojans;
 and from Tros in turn three blameless sons were born:
 Ilus, and Assaracus, and godlike Ganymede,
 who was born the most beautiful of mortal men —
 and the gods caught him up to be the wine-pourer of Zeus,
 235 for his beauty's sake, so he might live among the immortals.
 And Ilus in turn had a son, blameless Laomedon;
 and Laomedon fathered Tithonus and Priam
 and Lampus and Clytius and Hicetaon, sprig of Ares;
 and Assaracus, Capys — whose son was Anchises;
 240 and Anchises fathered me, and Priam brilliant Hector.
 That is the lineage and the blood I claim to come of.
 As for worth — Zeus increases it in men and diminishes it
 however he wills: for he is the strongest of all.
 Come then, let us stand no longer talking of this like children,
 245 here in the middle of the grind of battle.
 There are insults enough for both of us to speak —
 so many, a ship of a hundred benches could not carry the load.
 The tongue of mortals is a twisty thing; the words in it are many,
 of every kind; and the range of speech is wide, this way and that:
 250 whatever sort of word you speak, that is the sort you will hear.
 But what need have we two of strife and quarreling,
 wrangling face to face like women,

who in the anger of some heart-devouring feud
 go out and wrangle with each other in the middle of the street,
 255 and much is true, and much is not: the anger orders that too.
 Words will not turn me back from the valor I burn with —
 not before we have fought it out, bronze against bronze. Come then:
 let us taste one another with our bronze-fitted spears."
 He spoke, and drove his heavy spear into the terrible,¹⁶
 260 dreadful shield; and the great shield rang round the spear's point.
 And the son of Peleus with his thick hand thrust the shield
 out from his body, afraid: he thought the long-shadowed spear
 of great-hearted Aeneas would drive clean through it —
 the fool: he did not consider in mind and heart
 265 that the glorious gifts of the gods do not lie down easily
 under mortal men, do not give way before them.
 So the heavy spear of war-minded Aeneas did not
 break the shield: the gold held it, the god's gift.
 Through two folds he did drive it; but three were still
 270 left, since the crook-footed god had hammered five:
 two of bronze, and inside them two of tin,
 and one of gold — and in the gold the ash spear was held.
 Second in turn Achilles let fly his long-shadowed spear¹⁷
 and struck the balanced round shield of Aeneas
 275 under the outermost rim, where the bronze ran thinnest
 and the oxhide thinnest over it; and straight on through
 shot the Pelian ash, and the shield shrieked under it.
 And Aeneas crouched, and held the shield up and away,
 in dread; and the spear passed over his back and stood
 280 planted in the earth, still hungry, having torn through both circles
 of the man-covering shield. He had dodged the long spear;
 he stood, and grief past measure flooded down over his eyes,
 in terror at how close the point was planted. But Achilles
 drew his sharp sword and leapt on him, furious,¹⁸
 285 shouting his terrible shout. And Aeneas caught up a stone in his hand
 —
 a great feat — which no two men could carry,
 such as mortals are now; but he swung it easily, even alone.
 And now Aeneas would have struck him with the rock as he charged,

- on helmet or shield, which had fended grim death from him,
 290 and the son of Peleus, closing, would have taken his life with the sword,
 had not Poseidon the earth-shaker seen it sharply.
 And at once he spoke among the immortal gods:¹⁹
 "Oh shame — my grief for great-hearted Aeneas,
 who will quickly go down to Hades, broken by the son of Peleus,
 295 because he listened to the words of far-striker Apollo —
 the fool: Apollo will not help him against grim death.
 But why should this man, guiltless, suffer sorrows
 for no reason — for griefs that belong to others — he who always
 gives welcome gifts to the gods who hold the wide heaven?
 300 Come: let us ourselves lead him out from under death,
 for fear the son of Cronos too be angered, if Achilles
 cuts this man down. It is destined for him to escape,
 so that the race of Dardanus not perish seedless, blotted out —
 of Dardanus, whom the son of Cronos loved beyond all the children
 305 born to him from mortal women.
 For the son of Cronos has come to hate the line of Priam;
 and now the might of Aeneas shall be king over the Trojans —
 and his children's children, who shall be born hereafter."
 Then answered him the ox-eyed lady Hera:²⁰
 310 "Earth-shaker, take counsel with your own mind
 about Aeneas: whether to pull him out, or let him
 be broken by Achilles, Peleus's son, brave as he is.
 We two have sworn oaths, many of them,
 before all the immortals — I and Pallas Athena —
 315 never to ward the evil day away from the Trojans,
 not even when all Troy is burning in ravening fire —
 burning, and the warlike sons of the Achaeans light it."
 Now when Poseidon the earth-shaker heard that,²¹
 he went up through the battle and the clatter of spears
 320 and came where Aeneas was, and famed Achilles.
 And at once he poured a mist over the eyes
 of Achilles, Peleus's son; and the ash spear, well-shod in bronze,
 he drew out of the shield of great-hearted Aeneas
 and laid it down in front of Achilles' feet;
 325 and Aeneas he swept off the ground and swung high in the air.

- Over many ranks of heroes, many ranks of horses,
 Aeneas vaulted, launched from the god's hand,
 and came down at the outermost edge of the surging battle,
 where the Caucones were arming themselves for war.
- 330 And Poseidon the earth-shaker came up close beside him,
 and speaking winged words he addressed him:
 "Aeneas, which of the gods commands you to such madness —
 fighting face to face with the overweening son of Peleus,
 who is at once stronger than you and dearer to the immortals?
- 335 No: draw back whenever you find yourself against him,
 or you will enter the house of Hades even beyond your portion.
 But when Achilles has met his death and doom,
 then take courage, and fight among the front-fighters:
 no other of the Achaeans will ever strip your armor."
- 340 So speaking he left him there, when he had told him everything,²²
 and quickly scattered the unearthly mist from the eyes
 of Achilles; and he stared out hard with his eyes,
 and troubled, he spoke to his own great-hearted spirit:
 "Shame! — a great marvel is this I see with my eyes:
 345 my spear lying on the ground, and no sight anywhere
 of the man I hurled it at, hot to kill him.
 So Aeneas really was dear to the immortal gods —
 and I thought his boasting empty wind.
 Let him go, and good riddance. He will find no heart
 350 to test me again — glad enough, this time, to escape death.
 Come then: I will call on the war-loving Danaans
 and go against the rest of the Trojans, and test them."
 He spoke, and leapt along the ranks, and called to every man:²³
 "No longer stand off from the Trojans, brilliant Achaeans!
 355 Come — man against man, and let each be hot to fight!
 It is a hard thing for me, strong as I am,
 to deal with so many men and fight them all:
 not even Ares, immortal god though he is, not even Athena
 could work the mouth of a battle-line so wide, and labor it through.
- 360 But whatever I can do with hands and feet
 and strength, I promise I will not slacken — not one least bit:
 straight through the line I will go; and no Trojan, I think,

- will be glad who comes within reach of my spear."
 So he spoke, urging them on. And glorious Hector²⁴
 365 called to the Trojans, shouting; he said he would go against Achilles:
 "High-hearted Trojans — do not fear the son of Peleus!
 I too could fight the very immortals — with words;
 with the spear it is harder, since they are far stronger.
 Not even Achilles will bring all his words to fulfillment:
 370 one part he will accomplish; the other he cuts short half-done.
 I will go against him, though his hands are like fire —
 though his hands are like fire, and his fury like burning iron."
 So he spoke, urging them; and the Trojans raised their spears²⁵
 to face them; and fury met mingled fury, and the war-cry rose.
 375 And then Phoebus Apollo stood beside Hector and said:
 "Hector — do not fight Achilles out in front any longer.
 Wait for him in the mass, out of the battle's roar,
 or he will hit you with a cast — or close, and cut you down with the
 sword."
 So he spoke; and Hector sank back into the crowd of men,
 380 shaken, when he heard the voice of the god speaking.
 But Achilles leapt in among the Trojans, his heart clothed in valor,²⁶
 shouting his terrible shout. And first he killed Iphition,
 Otrynteus's stout son, a leader of many men,
 whom a naiad nymph bore to Otrynteus, sacker of cities,
 385 under snowy Tmolus, in the rich district of Hyde.
 As he came straight on, brilliant Achilles caught him with the spear
 full in the middle of the head; and the whole skull split in two,
 and he fell with a thud; and brilliant Achilles cried over him:
 "Lie there, son of Otrynteus — most terrifying of all men!
 390 Here is your death. Your birth was by the Gygaean lake,
 where your father's estate lies, by fish-filled
 Hyllus and eddying Hermus."
 So he cried in triumph; and darkness covered his eyes,
 and the wheel-rims of Achaean chariots tore him apart
 395 in the front of the struggle. And after him, Demoleon —²⁷
 a stout warder-off of battle, Antenor's son —
 he stabbed in the temple, through the bronze-cheeked helmet.
 The bronze helmet did not hold it: straight through

drove the point, hungry, and broke the bone; and the brain
 400 was all spattered inside it. He broke him in mid-charge.
 Then Hippodamas: as he sprang down from his horses
 and fled before him, he stabbed him in the back with the spear;
 and he gasped out his life, bellowing — as a bull
 bellows when he is dragged for the Heliconian lord,
 405 young men dragging him, and the earth-shaker delights in them:
 so, as he bellowed, the proud life left his bones.
 Then with his spear he went for godlike Polydorus,²⁸
 Priam's son. His father had forbidden him to fight,
 because among his children he was youngest-born
 410 and dearest; and he beat them all at running.
 And just then, in his boy's folly, showing off the speed of his feet,
 he was darting through the front-fighters — till he lost his dear life.
 As he flashed past, swift-footed brilliant Achilles hit him: the javelin
 square in the back, where the golden clasps of his war-belt
 415 fastened, and the corslet doubled over;
 and the spear-point held straight on through, out beside the navel,
 and he dropped to his knees with a scream, and a cloud of darkness
 wrapped him round, and he clutched his bowels to him with his hands
 as he sank.
 And when Hector saw his brother Polydorus²⁹
 420 clutching his bowels in his hands, sinking to the earth,
 a mist poured down over his eyes. He could no longer bear
 to range apart; he came out against Achilles,
 shaking his sharp spear, like a flame. And Achilles —
 the instant he saw him, he sprang, and spoke his word of triumph:
 425 "Near me — the man who beyond all others has stung my heart,
 who killed my honored companion! No longer now
 shall we cower from each other down the lanes of war."
 He spoke, and glaring darkly he said to brilliant Hector:
 "Come closer — and come the sooner to the borders of destruction."
 430 And unshaken, Hector of the flashing helmet answered him:
 "Son of Peleus — do not hope to frighten me with words,
 as if I were a silly child, since I too know well enough
 how to sling insults, and how to speak outrage.
 I know that you are brave, and that I am far weaker than you.

- 435 But these things lie on the knees of the gods:
 whether I, the weaker man, may still take the life out of you
 with a cast of my spear — since my weapon too has been sharp before
 now."
- He spoke, and poised and hurled his spear; and Athena
 turned it back from glorious Achilles with a breath —
- 440 the gentlest breathing; and it came back to brilliant Hector
 and fell there in front of his feet. And Achilles
 leapt on him, furious, wild to kill him,
 shouting his terrible shout. But Apollo snatched Hector away —
 easily, as a god does — and hid him in thick mist.
- 445 Three times swift-footed brilliant Achilles charged
 with his bronze spear, and three times he struck the deep mist.
 But when for the fourth time he came on like more than man,
 with a terrible shout he spoke winged words at him:
 "Dog! Again you have run out from under death — and yet the evil
- 450 came close. Now once more Phoebus Apollo has pulled you out —
 to him you must pray whenever you go into the thud of javelins.
 I will finish you yet, meeting you later,
 if any god anywhere stands helper to me too.
 For now I will go after the others, whoever I can catch."
- 455 So speaking, he stabbed Dryops full in the neck with the javelin,³⁰
 and he crashed down in front of his feet. He left him there,
 and Demuchus, Philetor's son, a good man and a big one,
 he stopped with a spear-cast to the knee; and then
 he took his life away with a stroke of the great sword.
- 460 Then Laogonus and Dardanus, the two sons of Bias:
 rushing both, he tumbled them from their horses to the ground,
 one with a spear-throw, one with the sword at close quarters.
 Then Tros, Alastor's son — who came at him to clasp his knees,
 hoping he might spare him, take him and let him go alive,
- 465 might pity a man of his own age and not kill him —
 the fool: he did not know there would be no persuading.
 This was not a sweet-tempered man, not mild of mind,
 but all raw fury. Tros reached with his hands for his knees,
 desperate to plead; and he stabbed him in the liver with the sword,
- 470 and the liver slid out, and the black blood pouring from it

- filled the fold of his tunic; and darkness covered his eyes,
 and the life failed. And next, standing over Mulius, he drove
 the spear into his ear, and out through the other ear
 the bronze point passed. Then Agenor's son Echeclus:
- 475 he struck him full mid-head with the hilted sword,
 and the whole blade ran hot with blood, and down over his eyes
 came purple death, and fate the overpowering.
 Then Deucalion: just where the tendons of the elbow
 join, there he pierced him through the arm
- 480 with the bronze point; and he stood and waited, his arm hanging heavy,
 looking at death before him; and with the sword Achilles struck his
 neck
 and sent head and helmet flying far together; and the marrow
 spurted up out of the spine, and the trunk lay stretched on the earth.
 Then he went after the blameless son of Peiros —³¹
- 485 Rhigmus, who had come from deep-soiled Thrace:
 him he hit square with the javelin, and the bronze stuck in his belly,
 and he crashed from his chariot. And Areithous his aide,
 as he wheeled the horses around, he stabbed in the back
 with the sharp spear, and thrust him from the car; and the horses ran
 wild.
- 490 As unearthly fire rages through the deep glens
 of a parched mountain, and the deep forest burns,
 and the wind, driving it everywhere, whirls the flame around:
 so everywhere he stormed with his spear, like more than man,
 harrying the men he killed; and the black earth ran with blood.
- 495 And as when a man yokes broad-browed bull oxen
 to tread white barley on a well-built threshing-floor,
 and quickly the grain is husked under the feet of the bellowing oxen:
 so under great-hearted Achilles the single-hoofed horses
 trampled corpses and shields together; and with blood the axle
- 500 beneath was all spattered, and the rails that ran round the car,
 struck by the drops thrown up from the horses' hooves
 and from the wheel-rims. And on he pressed to win glory —
 the son of Peleus — spattering his invincible hands with gore.

NOTES TO BOOK 20

- 1 *ll. 1-12* The opening apostrophe — "around you, son of Peleus" — puts the poet's own voice in the second line: the book that begins Achilles' *aristeia* begins by addressing him. Themis, Right herself, is the summoner (her one act in the poem), and the invitation-list is total: every river but Ocean (who anchors the world and cannot leave it), every nymph of grove and spring and meadow. The whole animate landscape is called in to watch what Achilles does to the plain it lives in.
- 2 *ll. 13-30* Zeus's convocation speech is the poem's theology at its most compressed. Asked why he has called them, he answers: "they matter to me, even as they perish" (μέλουσί μοι ὀλλύμενοί περ) — care and destruction in one clause, the whole divine economy of the *Iliad*. He will watch from a fold of Olympus and "delight my mind" — the god as spectator at the theater he financed — but the license he gives the gods is practical: without divine interference on both sides, Achilles "may storm the wall itself, ahead of what is fated" (ὑπέρμορον). Fate in Homer is not self-enforcing: it can be jumped, and the gods are deployed here as its police. The Book 8 ban is formally dissolved; the last movement of the poem runs with all gods on the field.
- 3 *ll. 31-40* The order of battle: five gods to the ships (Hera, Athena, Poseidon, Hermes, Hephaestus), five to the Trojans (Ares, Apollo, Artemis, Leto, Xanthus the river, with Aphrodite). Ares arrives as "Ares of the flashing helmet" — Hector's fixed epithet, lent to the war-god this once, as if the poem were already transferring Hector's identity to the god he follows. Xanthus fights for the city through whose plain he flows — the enlistment Book 21 will take terribly seriously.
- 4 *ll. 41-53* Before the gods engage: pure Achilles-effect — Achaeans exultant, "terrible trembling" in every Trojan limb. When they do engage, the poem gives us war-noise as divine antiphony: Athena shouting from the ditch and the headlands, Ares "like a black stormwind" screaming from the citadel and Callicolone — the battlefield turned into a theater with two crying gods for a chorus.
- 5 *ll. 54-66* The cosmic quake. Zeus thunders above, Poseidon shakes "the boundless earth and the steep heads of the mountains," Ida trembles root to peak — and below, the poem's single glimpse into the underworld from the inside: Aïdoneus leaping from his throne with a scream, terrified the crust will split "and his houses stand exposed to mortals and immortals — terrible, mouldering houses, which the very gods abhor." Death's kingdom described only by the horror of its possible exposure: the gods themselves cannot bear to look at what they consign men to. Longinus quoted these lines as the summit of the sublime.
- 6 *ll. 67-74* The pairings — Poseidon/Apollo, Athena/Enyalios, Hera/Artemis, Hermes/Leto, Hephaestus/Xanthus — a formal duel-card that Book 21 will actually play out. The river is introduced with the poem's fullest instance of divine double-naming: "whom the gods call Xanthus, and men Scamander" — the world has two vocabularies, and the poem knows both.

- 7 *ll. 75-85* Apollo picks Aeneas as the delaying weapon and wears the voice of Lycaon, Priam's son — a savage irony held in reserve: the real Lycaon will meet Achilles in Book 21 and become the poem's great emblem of unsparable life. The taunt is perfectly aimed: dinner-table threats "over your wine" against the sober fact of Achilles.
- 8 *ll. 86-102* Aeneas's answer is a veteran's risk-assessment: he has run from Achilles before, off Ida, in the raid that sacked Lyrnessus and Pedasus (the raid that took Briseis — the poem's pre-history everywhere this afternoon), and he names the real problem: "always one of the gods is beside him, beating ruin away." His conditional — with a level field, "he would not beat me so easily" — is exactly the proposition the duel will test and the gods will refuse to let conclude.
- 9 *ll. 103-111* Apollo's counter is genealogical arithmetic: Aphrodite outranks Thetis ("yours is a child of Zeus; his, of the old man of the sea") — therefore fight. The syllogism is divine snobbery, and false as tactics: rank of mother decides nothing on the plain, as the shield of Hephaestus is about to demonstrate. But it works — on "the shepherd of the people," the poem's title for the responsible man goaded into an irresponsible duel.
- 10 *ll. 112-131* Hera's alarm council. Her speech swings characteristically from tactics (turn Aeneas back) to prestige (let Achilles "know that they love him — the best of the immortals — and that windy nothings" defend Troy); lines 125-128, with their weaving Fate ("whatever Fate spun for him with her thread at his birth"), were athetized by Aristarchus. Her closing maxim earns its place in the book of divine epiphanies: "Gods seen in their true shapes are hard to bear" (χαλεποὶ δὲ θεοὶ φαίνεσθαι ἐναργεῖς).
- 11 *ll. 132-143* Poseidon's restraint doctrine — "we are far the stronger" is his reason not to fight: overwhelming force can afford to sit down. "Leave the war to men" is the book's quiet thesis: the gods' battle is theater; the men's is real. His trigger-conditions (if Ares or Apollo start, or if they hold Achilles back) keep the Theomachy loaded for Book 21.
- 12 *ll. 144-155* The gods take their seats — on the wall of Heracles, the rampart Trojans and Athena built a generation ago so Heracles could escape the sea-monster sent against Laomedon's Troy (the Hesione story, surfacing only here). The Greek gods watch this Trojan war from the fortification of the last one: Troy's past salvation reused as the grandstand for its destruction. Both parties sit "deliberating" — and Zeus, alone, "seated on high, commanded" the war on: the only spectator who wants the show to start.
- 13 *ll. 156-175* The champions meet, and Achilles gets the book's great lion simile — not a hunting lion but a hunted one: "a raider, whom men are wild to kill — a whole district, gathered," heedless until wounded, then foaming, groaning, lashing his own ribs with his tail, "whipping himself on to fight," driving in "to see whether he will kill some man, or die himself in the front of the crowd." The simile makes self-destruction part of the charge: kill or die are equal outcomes inside it — which is, since Book 18, precisely Achilles' own arithmetic.
- 14 *ll. 178-198* Achilles' taunt runs through every motive a rational Aeneas could have — the succession ("Priam would not lay that prize in your hand: he has sons; and he is steady"), the land-grant (the temenos of orchard and plowland) — Aristarchus athetized 180-186, but the political satire is sharp and early: the poem knows about princes who fight for estates. Then the memory: the cattle-raid chase down Ida, Lyrnessus wrecked, "the

- women captive, their day of freedom gone." It ends with the registered proverb, reused verbatim from Menelaus at 17.30-32: "When the thing is done, even the fool learns."
- 15 *ll. 199-258* Aeneas's genealogy — the longest pedigree in the poem, and the poem's most self-aware speech about speech. The frame (200-202: "do not hope to frighten me with words, as if I were a silly child") will be repeated verbatim by Hector at 431-433 — the Trojan princes share a script against Achilles. Then the lineage: Dardanus, son of Zeus; Erichthonius, richest of men, whose three thousand mares bore to Boreas twelve foals that ran over wheat-ears without breaking them and along the crests of the breakers — the poem's most weightless image, horses of wind bred from the hill-pastures of Troy; Tros; Ganymede, "most beautiful of mortal men," taken up to pour Zeus's wine; then the split into the two houses — Ilus to Laomedon to Priam and Hector; Assaracus to Capys to Anchises to Aeneas. Two first-cousin lines, and the survival of one is being decided this hour. The coda is the poem's finest statement on language: "The tongue of mortals is a twisty thing... whatever sort of word you speak, that is the sort you will hear" — and the simile of the wrangling women in the street ("and much is true, and much is not: the anger orders that too"), athetized by Aristarchus (251-255), too humanly observed to lose. Then, superbly: "let us taste one another with our bronze-fitted spears."
- 16 *ll. 259-272* The shield test. Aeneas's spear beats two folds and stops in the gold — and the narrator scolds Achilles for flinching ("the fool: he did not consider... that the glorious gifts of the gods do not lie down easily under mortal men"): even its owner does not yet trust divine craft. The five layers (two bronze, two tin, one gold) troubled the ancients — if the gold is decorative surface, how does it stop a spear at the third layer? — and Aristarchus athetized 269-272; some ancient texts omitted them entirely. Kept here: the physics of a miraculous object need not audit.
- 17 *ll. 273-283* Achilles' cast: through both circles of the rim where bronze and hide run thinnest — the Pelian ash "shrieked" through and stood planted in the earth "still hungry" (ἰερὴν — straining onward). Aeneas crouched under his own shield with the spear quivering over his back: "grief past measure flooded down over his eyes, in terror at how close the point was planted." Zenodotus's text had a different pair of lines here; the vulgate's sequence — cast, crouch, the standing spear — is the most cinematic near-miss in the poem.
- 18 *ll. 285-291* The stone "which no two men could carry, such as mortals are now" (the register's fixed diminished- present formula, its fourth occurrence) — and the double counterfactual: rock against sword, both blows about to land, when Poseidon "saw it sharply." The duel is frozen at its decisive instant and never resumed: the poem refuses to know who was better.
- 19 *ll. 292-308* Poseidon's rescue speech — a Greek god saving Troy's prince — is the poem's window onto a future beyond itself: Aeneas is "guiltless," pious, and destined: "It is destined for him to escape, so that the race of Dardanus not perish seedless... and now the might of Aeneas shall be king over the Trojans — and his children's children." The Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite makes the same promise; Strabo knew a variant — "his race shall rule over all" (γένος πάντεσσιν ἀνάξει) — which Rome, tracing the Julii through Iulus to Aeneas, had every reason to prefer; the apparatus records it. Whatever its

politics, the moment is structurally superb: in the middle of the Iliad's terminal battle, the poem certifies that something Trojan survives everything.

- 20 ll. 309-317 Hera's consent is glacial: do as you like about Aeneas — "we two have sworn oaths, many of them... never to ward the evil day away from the Trojans, not even when all Troy is burning in ravaging fire." The burning-city clause, spoken as calmly as a contract term, is the coldest sentence any god utters in the poem.
- 21 ll. 318-339 The rescue itself: mist over Achilles' eyes, the spear laid back at his feet (a courtesy with an edge: nothing of yours is lost — except the kill), and Aeneas thrown over "many ranks of heroes, many ranks of horses" to the Caucones at the battle's rim. Poseidon's parting instructions are precise prophecy: avoid Achilles while he lives; after his death, "fight among the front-fighters: no other of the Achaeans will ever strip your armor." Aeneas exits the poem's war carrying its only personal guarantee of survival.
- 22 ll. 340-352 Achilles' soliloquy over the vanished opponent gets his tone exactly: wonder for one breath ("a great marvel is this I see with my eyes"), then the shrug — "Let him go, and good riddance (ἐπέρτω). He will find no heart to test me again" — and back to work. The *aristeia*'s engine does not idle.
- 23 ll. 353-363 The order of the day: "man against man." His self-estimate is the rarest thing in his mouth — a limit: not even Ares or Athena "could work the mouth of a battle-line so wide" (the battle imagined as a thing with jaws; cf. 19.313 "the mouth of bloody war"). What follows is the promise kept literally: "straight through the line I will go."
- 24 ll. 364-372 Hector's rally answers it with the poem's most honest command ever given to troops: "I too could fight the very immortals — with words; with the spear it is harder, since they are far stronger." Then the great *epanalepsis*, the line that turns on its own hinge: "I will go against him, though his hands are like fire — though his hands are like fire, and his fury like burning iron." The repetition is courage audibly talking itself past its own information.
- 25 ll. 373-380 Apollo's counter-order — wait in the mass, "or he will hit you with a cast — or close, and cut you down with the sword" — names exactly the two deaths Hector risks; and Hector, who told the Trojans not to fear Achilles, obeys the god and sinks back "shaken." The gap between his speech and his obedience is the whole tragedy of Hector, one book early.
- 26 ll. 381-395 The *aristeia*'s first kill: Iphition, a nymph's son from under snowy Tmolus, his skull split clean in two — and Achilles' epitaph-taunt returns the man to his geography: "Here is your death. Your birth was by the Gygaean lake" — death here, birth there, the whole biography reduced to two map-points (the register's "most terrifying of all men" — Iris's address to Achilles at 18.170 — flung at a corpse). Then the poem lets the chariots shred him: no burial-notice, only wheel-rims.
- 27 ll. 395-406 Demoleon (temple, through the bronze-cheeked helmet, "the brain was all spattered inside it") and Hippodamas, whose soul leaves him "bellowing — as a bull bellows when he is dragged for the Heliconian lord": the sacrifice of bulls to Poseidon Heliconius at the Panionian festival, where a bellowing victim was a good omen — "and the earth-shaker delights in them." A man's death-cry heard by the poem as a pleasing

sacrifice: the grimmest cult-note in the Iliad, and Poseidon is standing right there on the field.

- 28 *Il. 407-418* Polydorus — Priam's youngest, forbidden the war "because among his children he was youngest-born and dearest," fastest of them all, killed "in his boy's folly, showing off the speed of his feet" as he darted through the front-fighters: struck where the war-belt's golden clasps meet, the point out beside the navel, kneeling with a scream, "and he clutched his bowels to him with his hands as he sank." The poem will reveal in Books 21-22 that he and Lycaon were Laothoe's sons — Priam mourns the pair at 22.46-48 — making Polydorus the first payment of a double debt this *aristeia* collects from one mother.
- 29 *Il. 419-454* The premature Hector-duel. The sight of his brother's bowels brings Hector out against orders — the mist that "poured down over his eyes" is grief doing to him what gods do to the doomed — and the exchange is a dress rehearsal of Book 22: taunt ("Come closer — so you come the sooner to the borders of destruction"), Hector's reply reusing Aeneas's frame verbatim (431-433 = 200-202) but adding what Aeneas never said: "I know that you are brave, and that I am far weaker than you. But these things lie on the knees of the gods." Then Athena turns his spear back "with a breath — the gentlest breathing" (the war decided by the smallest quantity of divine effort in the poem), Apollo snatches him into mist, and Achilles' three charges and fourth "like more than man" (δαίμονι ἴσοις) end in the shout that repeats 11.362-367 word for word — Diomedes' very speech to the same rescued man: "Dog! Again you have run out from under death." Two heroes, nine years apart in the poem's afternoon, are given identical words against Hector's charmed life — a repetition that makes Apollo's protection feel like policy, and its expiry date (Book 22) feel like doom.
- 30 *Il. 455-483* The spree, each kill a different door out of life: Dryops (neck), Demuchus (knee, then sword), the sons of Bias tumbled from their chariot, Mulius (spear in one ear, point out the other), Echeclus (the whole sword-blade "grew hot with the blood" — the register's "purple death" takes his eyes), Deucalion (arm pinned through the elbow-tendons; he "stood and waited, his arm hanging heavy, looking at death before him" — the poem's stillest instant of doomed consciousness — then head and helmet flying, "and the marrow spurted up out of the spine"). At the center, Tros son of Alastor, who tries the war's other exit: supplication, knees clasped, mercy of an age-mate — "the fool: he did not know there would be no persuading. This was not a sweet-tempered man, not mild of mind." The *litotes* is the *aristeia*'s moral thermometer: the man who once spared and ransomed captives (as Lycaon will remind him, 21.74-96) is not there to be reached. The liver slides out; the tunic fills with blood; the theme is set for Lycaon.
- 31 *Il. 484-503* Rhigmus of Thrace and his driver Areithous close the count (a dozen named kills), and the book ends in two similes that refuse pathos: the fire-storm in the parched glens ("the wind, driving it everywhere, whirls the flame around"), and — harder — the threshing-floor: oxen treading barley, "and quickly the grain is husked under the feet of the bellowing oxen: so under great-hearted Achilles the single-hoofed horses trampled corpses and shields together." Slaughter as agriculture, the dead as processed grain; the axle and chariot-rails "spattered" with the spray from hooves and wheel-rims. The last line hangs the whole book on its hero's hands: "spattering his invincible hands with

ILIAD — BOOK 20

gore" — the hands Thetis called man-slaughtering (18.317), still reaching for glory, not yet for Hector. There is no closural cadence: Book 21 continues the same hour at the river.

Iliad — Book 21

Achilles fills the river Scamander with the dead, and the river rises against him; the gods brawl; the Trojans flee inside the walls.

- But when they came to the ford of the fair-flowing river,¹
 eddying Xanthus, whom immortal Zeus begot,
 there he cut them in two: one half he chased over the plain
 toward the city, where the Achaeans had fled in terror
 5 the day before, when glorious Hector raged —
 there they streamed in rout, and Hera spread deep mist
 in front of them, to hold them; and the other half
 were rolled into the deep-flowing, silver-eddying river.
 In they fell with a great crash, and the sheer current roared,
 10 and the banks rang loud around them; and shouting they
 swam this way and that, spun about in the eddies.
 As when locusts rise on the air before the rush of fire
 and flee toward a river: the unwearied flame burns on,
 leaping up suddenly, and they cower down in the water:
 15 so before Achilles the sounding stream of Xanthus,
 the deep-eddying, was choked with horses and men together.
 And the Zeus-born one left his spear there on the bank,²
 leaned on the tamarisks, and leapt in like more than man,
 holding only his sword, with dark work in his heart,
 20 and struck on every side; and an ugly groaning rose
 from the men the blade hit, and the water reddened with blood.
 As before a huge-mawed dolphin the other fish
 flee and fill the inlets of a fair-anchoring harbor,
 terrified — for he devours whatever he catches:
 25 so the Trojans down the channels of the terrible river
 cowered under the overhangs. And when his hands were weary of
 killing,
 he picked twelve young men alive out of the river —
 blood-price for the death of Patroclus, Menoetius's son.
 He led them out dazed, like fawns,
 30 and tied their hands behind them with the well-cut straps

- they wore on their own supple tunics,
 and gave them to his companions to lead down to the hollow ships.
 Then back he sprang, wild to be killing.
 There he met a son of Priam, Dardanus's descendant,³
 35 running out of the river: Lycaon — whom he himself
 had taken once by night, and led away unwilling
 from his father's orchard: with the sharp bronze he was cutting
 young shoots from a wild fig, to be chariot-rails,
 when — evil unlooked-for — brilliant Achilles came on him.
 40 That time he shipped him to well-built Lemnos and sold him,
 and the son of Jason paid the price;
 from there a guest-friend ransomed him — he paid a fortune —
 Eëtion of Imbros, and sent him to shining Arisbe;
 and slipping away from there, he reached his father's house.
 45 Eleven days he delighted his heart among his dear ones,
 home from Lemnos; and on the twelfth the god threw him
 once more into the hands of Achilles, who was to send him
 down to the house of Hades — not willing to go.
 Now when swift-footed brilliant Achilles saw him —⁴
 50 naked, without helmet or shield, and no spear either:
 he had thrown it all to the ground, for the sweat wore him down
 as he ran from the river, and weariness broke his knees under him —
 troubled, Achilles spoke to his own great-hearted spirit:
 "Shame! — a great marvel is this I see with my eyes:
 55 so the great-hearted Trojans I have killed
 will rise again out of the murky dark below,
 the way this man has come back, escaping the pitiless day —
 sold into holy Lemnos! And the deep of the grey sea
 did not hold him, which holds so many against their will.
 60 Well then: now he shall taste the point of our spear
 as well — so I may see in my mind, and learn for certain,
 whether he will come back equally from down there, or be held
 by the life-giving earth, which holds down even the strong."
 So he weighed it, and waited. And the man came near him, dazed,⁵
 65 desperate to touch his knees: for his heart's whole wish
 was to escape from evil death and the black spirit of destruction.
 Brilliant Achilles lifted the long spear

- meaning to stab; but he ducked under and grasped his knees,
crouching; and the spear passed over his back and stood in the earth,
70 planted, still hungry for the flesh of a man.
With one hand Lycaon held his knees and begged,
and with the other gripped the sharp spear, and would not let go,
and speaking winged words he addressed him:
"By your knees, Achilles: respect me, and pity me.
75 I stand to you, Zeus-nurtured, as a suppliant with a claim:
it was at your table first that I ate the grain of Demeter,
on the day you took me in the well-built orchard,
and led me away, far from father and friends, and sold me
into holy Lemnos: I brought you the price of a hundred oxen.
80 I was freed for three times that; and this dawn
is my twelfth since I came back to Ilion
after much suffering. And now murderous fate has put me
in your hands again. I must be hateful to father Zeus,
who gave me to you twice. To a short life my mother
85 bore me — Laothoe, daughter of the old man Altes:
Altes, who is lord of the war-loving Lelegians,
holding steep Pedasus on the Satnioeis.
Priam had his daughter — among his many wives;
and of her we two were born, and you will butcher both.
90 One you have broken already among the front-rank foot-fighters —
godlike Polydorus, when you hit him with your sharp spear;
and now, here, it will be evil for me: for I do not hope
to escape your hands, since the god has driven me into them.
But I will say one thing more — take it into your heart:
95 do not kill me. I am not from the same womb as Hector,
who killed your companion, the gentle and the strong."
So the shining son of Priam spoke to him,⁶
a speech of begging; but the voice he heard was without honey:
"Fool — offer me no ransom. Make me no speeches.
100 Before Patroclus met his day of destiny,
sparing Trojans was dearer to my heart:
many I took alive, and sold abroad.
Now there is not one who escapes death — not one the god
delivers into my hands in front of Ilion —

- 105 not one of all the Trojans, and of Priam's sons beyond all.
 So, friend — you die too. Why lament it so?
 Patroclus died, and he was a far better man than you.
 And do you not see what I am — how beautiful, how big?
 My father is a noble man, a goddess was the mother who bore me:
 110 yet over me too stand death, and strong fate.
 There will be a dawn, or an evening, or a midday,
 when someone takes my life too out of me in the fighting,
 whether he hits me with a spear or an arrow from the string."
 So he spoke; and there the man's knees went slack, and his own heart.⁷
- 115 He let go of the spear, and sat back, spreading both hands
 wide. And Achilles drew his sharp sword
 and struck at the collarbone, beside the neck, and the whole
 two-edged blade went in; and face-down on the earth
 he lay stretched out, and the black blood ran, and soaked the ground.
 120 Achilles seized him by the foot and slung him into the river,
 and cried in triumph over him with winged words:
 "Lie there now among the fish: they will lick the blood
 from your wound, uncaring. No mother will lay you out
 on a bed and mourn you: eddying Scamander
 125 will carry you into the broad gulf of the sea,
 and many a fish, leaping along the wave, will dart up
 under the black ripple to eat the white fat of Lycaon.
 Perish, all of you — till we reach the city of holy Ilion,
 you running, and I cutting you down from behind!
- 130 Not even the river will save you — the fair-flowing,
 silver-eddying river you have honored so long with slaughtered bulls,
 drowning single-hoofed horses alive in his eddies.
 Even so you shall die evil deaths — every one — till all of you
 pay for the killing of Patroclus and the ruin of the Achaeans
 135 whom you cut down beside the swift ships when I was away."
 So he spoke; and the river's anger rose the higher in his heart,
 and he turned over in his mind how to stop brilliant Achilles
 in his work, and beat destruction away from the Trojans.
 Meanwhile the son of Peleus, with his long-shadowed spear,⁸
 140 sprang on Asteropaeus, wild to kill him —
 the son of Pelegon, whom wide-flowing Axius

begot on Periboea, eldest of the daughters
 of Acessamenus: the deep-eddying river lay with her.
 On him Achilles rushed; and he stood up out of the river
 145 to face him, holding two spears; and Xanthus put fury
 in his chest, in anger for the young men cut down in the fighting,
 the ones Achilles was butchering down the stream without pity.
 And when they had come close, advancing on each other,
 the first to speak was swift-footed brilliant Achilles:
 150 "Who are you — of what men — that you dare come against me?
 Unhappy are the fathers whose sons face my fury!"
 And the shining son of Pelegon answered him:
 "Great-hearted son of Peleus, why ask my lineage?
 I am from Paeonia of the deep soil — a far country —
 155 leading the Paeonian men of the long lances; and this dawn
 is my eleventh now, since I came to Ilion.
 My line is from Axius, the wide-flowing —
 Axius, who sends the most beautiful water over the earth;
 he fathered Pelegon, famed with the spear; and of Pelegon
 160 they say I was born. Now let us fight, brilliant Achilles."
 So he spoke, threatening; and brilliant Achilles raised⁹
 the Pelian ash. But the hero Asteropaeus threw
 both spears at once — for he was a two-handed fighter.
 With the one spear he hit the shield, but did not
 165 break the shield: the gold held it, the god's gift;
 with the other he grazed the elbow of the right arm,
 and the dark blood shot out; and the spear, passing over him,
 stuck fast in the earth, still craving its fill of flesh.
 Second in turn Achilles let fly his straight-flying ash
 170 at Asteropaeus, wild to kill him —
 and missed the man, and hit the high bank,
 and drove the ash spear half its length into the bank.
 Then the son of Peleus, drawing the sharp sword from his thigh,
 leapt on him, furious; and the man could not wrench
 175 Achilles' ash out of the bluff with his thick hand.
 Three times he shook it, straining to pull it free,
 and three times his strength gave out; the fourth time his heart wished
 to bend and snap the ash spear of Aeacus' grandson —

- but before that Achilles closed, and took his life with the sword.
- 180 He struck him in the belly beside the navel, and all
 his bowels gushed out on the ground; and darkness covered his eyes
 as he gasped. And Achilles, springing on his chest,
 stripped his armor, and spoke his word of triumph:
 "Lie there. It is a hard thing to strive with the children¹⁰
 185 of Cronos's mighty son — even for one born of a river.
 You said your birth was from a wide-flowing river;
 I claim the lineage of great Zeus.
 The man who fathered me is lord of many Myrmidons —
 Peleus, Aeacus' son; and Aeacus was from Zeus.
- 190 As Zeus is stronger than the rivers that run murmuring to the sea,
 so the line of Zeus is made stronger than a river's.
 Why — here is a great river at your side, if he can help
 at all. But there is no fighting Zeus, Cronos's son:
 not even Achelous the king is his equal,
 195 not even the great strength of deep-flowing Ocean,
 from whom all rivers flow and every sea,
 and all the springs, and the deep wells:
 even he fears the thunderbolt of great Zeus
 and the terrible thunder, when it crashes out of heaven."
- 200 He spoke, and pulled the bronze spear out of the bluff,¹¹
 and left the man there, where he had taken his dear life,
 lying in the sands; and the dark water lapped him.
 Around him the eels and the fish were busy,
 tearing at the fat of his kidneys, plucking it away.
- 205 And Achilles went on after the chariot-fighting Paeonians,
 who were still running in terror along the eddying river,
 since they had seen their best man in the strong encounter
 broken by force under the hands and sword of the son of Peleus.
 There he took Thersilochus and Mydon and Astypylus
 210 and Mnesus and Thrasius and Aenius and Ophelestes —
 and now swift Achilles would have killed still more Paeonians,
 had not the deep-eddy river called to him in anger,¹²
 likened to a man, and sent his voice out of a deep eddy:
 "O Achilles — beyond men you are strong, and beyond men you do
 215 outrage — and always the gods themselves are your defenders.

- If the son of Cronos has granted you to destroy all the Trojans,
 at least drive them out of me and do your grim work on the plain:
 my lovely streams are crammed full of corpses,
 and I can no longer pour my current through to the bright sea,
 220 choked with the dead — and you kill, and kill.
 Come, let it be. Horror takes me, leader of the people."
 Then in answer spoke to him swift-footed Achilles:
 "It shall be so, Scamander, nurtured of Zeus, as you command.
 But the arrogant Trojans — I will not stop cutting them down
 225 before I pen them in their city, and stand against Hector
 face to face, whether he breaks me or I break him."
 So speaking he swept on the Trojans like more than man.
 And then the deep-eddy river called to Apollo:
 "Shame, lord of the silver bow, child of Zeus — you have not
 230 kept the counsels of Cronos's son, who charged you strictly
 to stand by the Trojans and defend them, until the late
 evening-light comes down and shadows the deep-soiled plowland."
 He spoke; and spear-famed Achilles leapt from the bluff¹³
 and sprang into mid-current. And the river rushed on him, surging
 235 and swelling, and stirred all his streams into turmoil, and shoved
 the many corpses that crowded him — Achilles' killing —
 out onto dry land, bellowing like a bull
 as he threw them; and the living he saved down his beautiful streams,
 hiding them in his eddies, deep and wide.
 240 And terrible around Achilles the churning water towered,
 and the current beat down on his shield and shoved him; nor could
 his feet find purchase. He grasped an elm with both hands —
 full-grown, majestic — and it tore out by the roots,
 brought the whole overhang down with it, dammed the beautiful
 245 streams with its dense branches, and bridged the river itself,
 falling in whole. And he sprang up out of the eddy
 and set off flying across the plain on his quick feet —
 terrified. And the great god did not let up, but rose behind him,
 cresting black, to stop the labor of brilliant
 250 Achilles, and beat destruction away from the Trojans.
 And the son of Peleus bounded away a spear-cast's length,
 with the swoop of the black eagle, the hunter,

- strongest of winged things at once, and swiftest:
 like him he darted, and the bronze on his chest
 255 clashed terribly; and swerving out from under it
 he fled, and the river poured after him, roaring hugely.
 As when a ditch-tending man leads a stream of water¹⁴
 from a dark spring down through his plantings and gardens,
 mattock in hand, knocking the clogs from the channel,
 260 and as it flows all the pebbles are rolled and tumbled
 under it, and it runs murmuring quickly down
 the sloping ground, and outruns the very man who guides it:
 so the wave of the current forever caught Achilles,
 fast as he was: gods are stronger than men.
- 265 And as often as swift-footed brilliant Achilles turned
 to make a stand against it, and to learn whether all
 the immortals who hold the wide heaven were hunting him,
 so often the great wave of the sky-fed river
 battered down on his shoulders; and he sprang high with his feet,
 270 heartsick; and the river was breaking his knees from under him,
 raging slantwise beneath, eating the dust from under his feet.
 And the son of Peleus cried aloud, looking into the wide heaven:¹⁵
 "Father Zeus! — that no god undertakes to save me,
 pitiful as I am, from the river! Afterward let anything happen.
- 275 No other of the sons of Heaven is so much to blame
 as my own mother, who beguiled me with lies:
 she said I would die under the wall of the armored Trojans
 by the swift arrows of Apollo.
 I wish Hector had killed me — the best man reared here:
 280 then a good man would have done the killing, and stripped a good man.
 Now it is my portion to be caught by a wretched death,
 hemmed in a great river, like a swineherd's boy
 swept away by a gully he was crossing in a storm."
 So he spoke; and very quickly Poseidon and Athena
 285 came and stood beside him, likened to men in body,
 and taking his hand in their hands they pledged him with words.
 And Poseidon the earth-shaker began speaking among them:
 "Son of Peleus — do not tremble so hard, do not be afraid.
 Such are we two of the gods who stand your helpers —

- 290 Zeus approving — I and Pallas Athena.
 It is not your portion to be broken by a river:
 this one will soon give over — you will see it yourself.
 And we will give you close counsel, if you will heed it:
 do not rest your hands from the leveling war
 295 before you pen the Trojan army inside the famed walls
 of Ilion — whoever escapes. And when you have taken Hector's life,
 come back to the ships. We give you the glory to carry off."
 The two of them, so speaking, went away to the immortals;¹⁶
 and he went on — for the gods' command stirred him greatly —
 300 into the plain. And the whole of it was filled with flood-water,
 and much beautiful armor of young men killed in battle
 floated there, and their bodies. His knees sprang high
 as he rushed straight on against the current, nor could the river
 hold him now, wide as it flowed: Athena put great strength in him.
 305 But Scamander did not slacken his fury either — worse,
 his rage at Peleus's son grew; and he crested the wave of his current,
 lifting himself high, and shouted a call to Simoïs:
 "Dear brother — the strength of this man — let the two of us
 hold it together, since very soon he will sack the great city
 310 of lord Priam; and the Trojans will not stand in the chaos.
 Help me, and quickly: fill your streams with water
 from the springs, and rouse up every gully;
 raise a great wave, and stir a huge clamor
 of timbers and stones — so we stop the wild man
 315 who is winning now, and straining like the gods themselves.
 For I say his strength will help him nothing, nor his beauty,
 nor those beautiful arms, which deep beneath the mere
 shall lie wrapped in slime — and the man himself
 I will roll in sand, and pour around him shingle
 320 past counting; and the Achaeans will not know where to gather
 his bones, so deep in silt shall I bury him.
 There his burial-mound will stand ready-made: he will need
 no heaping of a tomb when the Achaeans bury him."
 He spoke, and surged at Achilles, churning, rearing high,
 325 seething with foam and blood and dead men.
 And the darkening wave of the sky-fed river

towered above him, and began to drag the son of Peleus down.
 And Hera shrieked aloud, in terror for Achilles,¹⁷
 lest the great deep-eddying river sweep him away,
 330 and at once she called to Hephaestus, her dear son:
 "Up, Crook-foot! Up, my child! — for it was against you
 we always reckoned eddying Xanthus matched in battle.
 Help him, and quickly: bring your flames out in force.
 And I will go rouse a hard storm out of the sea —
 335 the West Wind and the white South Wind — to carry
 the evil burning and set the Trojans' heads and armor alight.
 You, along the banks of Xanthus, burn the trees,
 and throw the fire into the river himself. And do not let him
 turn you back at all with soft words or with threats;
 340 do not slacken your fury — not until the moment
 I shout and call to you: then hold the unwearying fire."
 So she spoke; and Hephaestus made ready unearthly fire.¹⁸
 First the fire blazed on the plain, and burned
 the many corpses that crowded it — Achilles' killing;
 345 and the whole plain was dried, and the shining water stopped.
 As when in late summer the North Wind quickly dries
 a new-watered orchard, and the man who tends it is glad:
 so the whole plain was dried, and the fire consumed
 the corpses. Then he turned his all-shining flame on the river.
 350 The elms burned, and the willows, and the tamarisks;
 the lotus burned, and the rushes, and the galingale,
 which grew in abundance around the river's beautiful streams;
 and the eels and the fish were in torment down the eddies,
 tumbling this way and that through the beautiful streams,
 355 worn down by the blast of resourceful Hephaestus.
 And the strong river burned, and spoke a word, and named him:¹⁹
 "Hephaestus! — no one of the gods can stand against you,
 and I will not fight you, flaming with fire as you are.
 Leave off the strife. As for the Trojans — let brilliant Achilles
 360 drive them out of their city this instant. What are strife and rescue to
 me?"
 He spoke, burning in the fire, and his beautiful streams were seething.
 As a cauldron boils within, hurried by a great fire,

melting down the lard of a fattened hog,
 bubbling up on every side, with dry split wood beneath it:
 365 so his beautiful streams blazed with the fire, and the water boiled,
 and would not flow onward, but stood checked: the breath
 of mighty, wise Hephaestus wore him down. And to Hera,
 begging hard, he spoke winged words:
 "Hera, why has your son fallen on my current, to torment it
 370 out of all others? Surely I am not so much to blame
 as all the rest of them — all the helpers of Troy.
 I will stop — I promise it — if you command it;
 but let him stop as well. And I will swear this oath besides:
 never to ward the evil day away from the Trojans,
 375 not even when all Troy is burning in ravening fire —
 burning, and the warlike sons of the Achaeans light it."
 Now when the goddess white-armed Hera heard that,
 at once she called to Hephaestus, her dear son:
 "Hephaestus — hold, my glorious child. It is not seemly
 380 to batter an immortal god this way for the sake of mortals."
 So she spoke; and Hephaestus quenched the unearthly fire,
 and the wave ran back down the beautiful streams.
 And when the fury of Xanthus was beaten, those two²⁰
 rested — for Hera held them back, angry as she was.
 385 But on the other gods fell strife, heavy and grinding,
 and the hearts in their chests blew two ways at once;
 and they fell together with a great crash, and the wide earth rang,
 and the great heaven trumpeted around them. And Zeus heard it,
 sitting on Olympus; and his own heart laughed
 390 for joy, when he saw the gods coming together in strife.
 Then they stood apart no longer. Ares began it —²¹
 the shield-piercer: first he sprang at Athena,
 bronze spear in hand, and flung the word of insult:
 "Why, dog-fly — why do you drive the gods together in strife
 395 with your gale of daring, your great heart egging you on?
 Do you not remember when you set Diomedes, Tydeus's son,
 on me to wound me — and took the spear yourself, in plain sight,
 and drove it straight at me, and tore my beautiful flesh?
 Now, I think, you will pay me for all you have done."

- 400 So speaking, he stabbed at the tasseled aegis —
the terrible aegis that not even Zeus's thunderbolt breaks:
there blood-stained Ares stabbed her with his long spear.
But she, giving ground, caught up a stone in her thick hand —
a stone that lay on the plain, black, jagged, and huge,
405 which men of former times had set to be a field's boundary-marker.
With it she hit rushing Ares in the neck, and unstrung his limbs.
Seven acres he covered, falling; and his hair was fouled with dust,
and his armor clattered around him. And Pallas Athena laughed,
and triumphing over him she spoke winged words:
410 "Baby fool — you have never yet reckoned how much stronger
I claim to be, that you match your fury against mine.
So pay in full your mother's curses — the Erinyes
she wishes on you in her anger, because you deserted
the Achaeans and defend the arrogant Trojans."
415 So speaking, she turned her shining eyes away.
And Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus, took Ares by the hand²²
and led him off, groaning thick and fast, barely gathering his spirit.
But when the goddess white-armed Hera noticed her,
at once she spoke winged words to Athena:
420 "Shame! Unwearied one, child of aegis-bearing Zeus —
there goes the dog-fly again, leading Ares, bane of mortals,
out of the deadly war through the chaos. After her!"
So she spoke; and Athena sped after, glad at heart,
and rushing on Aphrodite she struck her on the breast
425 with her thick hand; and there her knees went slack, and her own
heart.
So the two of them lay on the earth that feeds many,
and Athena, triumphing, spoke winged words:
"Such may they all be now — all the helpers of the Trojans
when they fight the armored Argives:
430 just so bold, and just so hardy, as Aphrodite
coming to second Ares, and facing my fury.
Then long ago we should have rested from the war,
with the well-built citadel of Ilion sacked."
So she spoke; and the goddess white-armed Hera smiled.
435 And the lord earth-shaker addressed Apollo:²³

- "Phoebus — why do we two stand apart? It is not fitting,
 when the others have begun. The greater shame if we go back
 fightless to Olympus, to the bronze-floored house of Zeus.
 Begin: you are the younger born. It would not be right
 440 for me, since I was born first and know more things.
 Baby fool — how mindless a heart you have! Do you not even
 remember all we two suffered around Ilium,
 alone of the gods, when we came from Zeus and drudged
 a whole year for haughty Laomedon at a stated wage,
 445 and he gave the orders, and we served?
 I built the Trojans their wall around the city —
 wide, and very beautiful, so the city might be unbreakable —
 while you, Phoebus, herded the shambling twist-horned cattle
 in the spurs of wooded, many-folded Ida.
 450 But when the glad seasons brought around the term
 of our hire, then he robbed us of all our wage by force —
 terrifying Laomedon — and sent us off with threats.
 He threatened to bind our feet, and our hands above them,
 and ship us for sale to far-off islands;
 455 and he vowed to lop the ears from both of us with bronze.
 So back we went, the two of us, with rancor in our hearts,
 in anger for the wage he promised and did not pay.
 And it is his people you now favor — instead of trying,
 with us, to make the arrogant Trojans perish
 460 root and branch, evilly, with their children and honored wives!"
 Then in turn the lord Apollo, the worker-from-afar, answered him:²⁴
 "Earth-shaker — you would say I was unsound of mind
 if I fought against you for the sake of mortals —
 pitiful things, who like the leaves at one time
 465 flourish in their blaze, eating the fruit of the plowland,
 and at another wither heartless away. No — quickly,
 let us rest from battle. Let them do their own fighting."
 So speaking he turned away: for he shrank in awe
 from trading blows with his father's brother.
 470 But his sister rebuked him bitterly — the lady of wild beasts,²⁵
 Artemis of the wilds — and flung the word of insult:
 "So you run, worker-from-afar! — and hand Poseidon the whole

- victory, and give him glory for nothing!
 Baby fool — why do you carry that bow, useless as wind?
- 475 Never again let me hear you in our father's halls
 boasting, as before among the immortal gods,
 that you would fight Poseidon face to face."
 So she spoke; and Apollo the worker-from-afar answered nothing;
 but the honored wife of Zeus, in anger,
- 480 reviled the shooter of arrows with words of insult:
 "And how is it you are eager, shameless bitch, to stand
 against me? I am a hard match for your fury,
 bow-carrier though you are — you whom Zeus made a lion
 to women, and gave you leave to kill whichever you choose.
- 485 Better, surely, to slaughter beasts on the mountains,
 and wild deer, than to fight by force with your betters.
 But if you want a lesson in war — so you may know well
 how much stronger I am, when you match your fury against mine —"
- 490 She spoke, and with her left hand caught both the other's hands
 at the wrist, and with her right stripped the bow from her shoulders,
 and with the bow itself, smiling, she boxed her about the ears
 as she twisted this way and that; and the swift arrows spilled out.
 And the goddess fled from under her, weeping, like a dove
 that flies from a hawk into a hollow rock,
- 495 a cleft — for it was not her portion to be caught:
 so she fled weeping, and left her bow and arrows where they lay.
 And to Leto spoke the courier, the slayer of Argus:²⁶
 "Leto, I will not fight you — no: it is a hard thing
 to trade blows with the wives of cloud-gatherer Zeus.
- 500 With all my heart's goodwill: boast among the immortal gods
 that you overcame me with your strong force."
 So he spoke; and Leto gathered up the curved bow
 and the arrows, fallen this way and that in the swirl of dust,
 and taking her daughter's bow and arrows she went back.
- 505 And the girl came to Olympus, to the bronze-floored house of Zeus,²⁷
 and sat down weeping on her father's knees,
 the ambrosial robe trembling around her; and her father
 the son of Cronos drew her to him, and asked, laughing sweetly:
 "Who of the sons of Heaven, dear child, has treated you so —

- 510 for nothing — as if you had been caught doing wrong in the open?"
 And the fair-crowned goddess of the clamorous hunt answered him:
 "Your wife battered me, father — white-armed Hera,
 from whom strife and quarrel cling to the immortals."
 So the two of them spoke such things to one another.²⁸
- 515 And Phoebus Apollo went down into holy Ilion:
 for the wall of the well-built city was on his mind —
 lest the Danaans sack it that day, beyond its fate.
 The other everlasting gods went to Olympus,
 some in anger, and some in high triumph,
- 520 and sat down beside the father of the black cloud. But Achilles
 went on killing the Trojans — the men and their single-hoofed horses.
 As when smoke rises and reaches the wide heaven
 from a burning city — the wrath of the gods has sent it up,
 and it lays labor on all, and grief on many:
- 525 so Achilles laid labor and grief on the Trojans.
 And old Priam stood on the god-built tower,
 and made out gigantic Achilles: and there before him
 the Trojans were being driven pell-mell in rout, and no defense
 was left. He cried out, and came down from the tower,
- 530 to rouse the famed gate-keepers along the wall:
 "Hold the gates spread open in your hands, until the army
 comes into the city in its rout: for here is Achilles
 close by, driving them. Now, I think, comes disaster.
 But the moment they are gathered inside the wall and breathing,
- 535 close the tight-fitted double doors again:
 I dread that ruinous man — that he may leap inside the wall."
 So he spoke; and they loosed the gates and thrust back the bars,
 and the gates, spread wide, made a light of safety. And Apollo
 sprang out to meet the rout, to beat destruction from the Trojans.
- 540 And they, straight for the city and the high wall,
 parched with thirst and caked with dust, came fleeing
 out of the plain; and he pressed hard behind them with the spear:
 raging madness held his heart, and he strained for glory.
 Then the sons of the Achaeans would have taken high-gated Troy,²⁹
- 545 had not Phoebus Apollo stirred up brilliant Agenor —
 Antenor's son, a man blameless and strong.

- Into his heart he threw courage, and himself stood
 beside him, to beat away the heavy hands of death,
 leaning on the oak tree, wrapped in thick mist.
- 550 Now when Agenor caught sight of Achilles, sacker of cities,
 he stood fast; but the heart in him churned dark as he waited,
 and troubled, he spoke to his own great-hearted spirit:
 "Ah me! If I run from strong Achilles
 the way the rest are driven, panicked, in rout —
- 555 he will catch me all the same, and butcher me for the coward I am.
 But if I leave these men to be driven before him —
 before Achilles, Peleus's son — and run on my own feet
 another way, off from the wall, toward the Ileian plain,
 until I reach the spurs of Ida and get into the brush —
- 560 then at evening, when I have bathed in the river
 and cooled the sweat from me, I could come back to Ilion...
 But why does my own heart argue these things with me?
 What if he sees me swinging wide of the city toward the plain,
 and comes after at a sprint, and runs me down on his quick feet?
- 565 Then there will be no more escaping death and the death-spirits:
 he is too strong — strong beyond all mankind.
 But what if, in front of the city, I stand and face him?
 His flesh too, surely, can be cut by the sharp bronze;
 in him is one life, no more; and mortal, men say
- 570 he is — though Zeus, Cronos's son, keeps handing him the glory."
 So speaking, braced and gathered, he waited for Achilles,³⁰
 and the brave heart in him strained toward war and battle.
 As a leopard comes out of deep brush
 to face the huntsman, and her heart neither
- 575 fears nor thinks of flight when she hears the baying —
 for even if he is quicker, and stabs or hits her with a cast,
 still, run through on the very spear, she does not leave off
 her valor, until she closes with him or goes down:
 so the son of proud Antenor, brilliant Agenor,
- 580 refused to run before he had put Achilles to the test.
 He held the balanced round shield out before him,
 aimed at him with his spear, and shouted loud:
 "No doubt you hoped in your heart, shining Achilles,

- to sack the city of the proud Trojans this very day.
- 585 Baby fool — there is grief yet to be suffered over her:
 inside her we are many, and men of valor,
 who will guard Ilion, standing in front of our dear parents
 and wives and sons. It is you who will meet your doom here —
 terrifying as you are, and so daring a fighter."
- 590 He spoke, and let the sharp javelin fly from his heavy hand,
 and hit him on the shin below the knee — no miss:
 and around it the greave of new-forged tin
 screamed terribly; and the bronze sprang back
 from where it struck, and did not pass: the god's gifts held it.
- 595 And the son of Peleus went for godlike Agenor
 in his turn — but Apollo would not let him win the glory:
 he snatched Agenor away, and hid him in thick mist,
 and sent him quietly out of the war, to go his way.
 Then by a trick he kept the son of Peleus from the army:³¹
- 600 likened in every point to Agenor himself, the worker-from-afar
 stood before his feet — and Achilles ran hot after him.
 And while he chased him across the wheat-bearing plain,
 turning him along the deep-eddyin river Scamander
 as he ran just a little ahead — for by that cunning Apollo
- 605 kept him beguiled, always hoping to catch him on his quick feet —
 meanwhile the rest of the routed Trojans, in a mass,
 came glad to the city, and the town was filled with their crowding.
 Nor did they dare wait for one another any longer
 outside the city and the wall, to learn who had escaped
- 610 and who had died in the fighting: in they poured, headlong,
 every man whose feet and knees could save him.

NOTES TO BOOK 21

- 1 *ll. 1-16* The opening repeats 14.433-434 exactly (our English kept): "the ford of the fair-flowing river, eddying Xanthus, whom immortal Zeus begot" — the crossing where the stunned Hector was laid and revived in Book 14. The river of Trojan refuge becomes the killing-pen: Achilles splits the rout, Hera walls one half behind mist, and the other half goes into the water. The locust simile knows what is coming three hundred lines early: men driven into a river by fire is precisely how the book will end for the river himself.
- 2 *ll. 17-33* The spear left leaning on the tamarisks: sword work — butcher's work — is what the moment wants. The dolphin simile makes the water itself predatory ground. Then the poem's coldest logistics: twelve young men taken alive "blood-price for the death of Patroclus" — the vow of 18.336-337 collected on schedule, the victims led out "dazed, like fawns," bound with the belts of their own tunics. They will be paid out at 23.175-176. Between vow and payment the poem never lets them speak.
- 3 *ll. 34-48* Lycaon's dossier — the fullest biography any minor victim receives, given precisely so we know the whole weight of what is about to be refused: the night raid, the fig-shoots cut for chariot-rails (a boy doing farm-work in an orchard war), the sale on Lemnos to Euneus son of Jason (the fleet's wine-merchant, 7.467-469), the ransom by Eëtion of Imbros, Arisbe, the escape home. "Eleven days he delighted his heart among his dear ones; and on the twelfth the god threw him once more into the hands of Achilles." The symmetry is exact and awful: eleven days of resurrection, and then the machinery resumes.
- 4 *ll. 49-63* Achilles' soliloquy over the unarmed man plays the return as ghost-story: "the great-hearted Trojans I have killed will rise again out of the murky dark." The joke — spear as experiment: "so I may see... whether he will come back equally from down there" — is the *aristeia*'s humor: death-dealing grown so routine it wants variety. Under it, the poem's physics: the sea did not hold him; "the life-giving earth... holds down even the strong" will.
- 5 *ll. 64-96* The supplication tableau: one hand on the knees, one gripping the spear itself — clinging to the weapon to keep it out of his own body. Lycaon's claims are, in order: the suppliant-bond; table-fellowship ("at your table first I ate the grain of Demeter" — the captive fed by his captor becomes his guest); the ransom record (a hundred oxen paid, three hundred to free him); the fate-arithmetic of the twelfth dawn; and last, the desperate genealogical wedge — born of Laothoe, not Hecuba: "I am not from the same womb as Hector." He offers every category the heroic world honors. The answer voids the categories.
- 6 *ll. 97-113* The refusal and the consolation, the poem's ethical summit. "Fool — offer me no ransom": the economy that ran Books 1-9 (and Lycaon's own first capture — "before Patroclus met his day of destiny, sparing Trojans was dearer to my heart") is formally closed. Then the turn from wrath to metaphysics — "So, friend, you die too" (ἀλλὰ φίλος θάνε καὶ σύ) — and the terms of the consolation: Patroclus was better, and died; "do you

not see what I am — how beautiful, how big?" — and I die too: "a dawn, or an evening, or a midday." The killer comforts his victim with their equality before death, and means it; φίλος is not sarcasm but the only fellowship left to a man who has accepted his own sentence. No passage of the poem was more quoted in antiquity as the summary of the human condition.

- 7 ll. 114-135 Lycaon's assent: knees slack, spear released, both hands spread — a posture between surrender and embrace — and the sword at the collarbone. Then the anti-funeral: slung into the river with a taunt that negates each rite in turn — no mother's laying-out, no lament; instead fish licking the wound "uncaring" and darting up "under the black ripple to eat the white fat of Lycaon" (the body already imagined as carcass-meat). The closing insult is cultic: the river you honored "so long with slaughtered bulls, drowning single-hoofed horses alive in his eddies" (live-horse sacrifice to rivers is real archaic practice) will not save you. Aristophanes athetized 130-135 — and Didymus suspected Aristarchus agreed — but the lines are the hinge: this speech is what the river cannot forgive, and the next six hundred lines grow out of it.
- 8 ll. 136-160 Asteropaeus: grandson of the river Axius, eleven days at Troy (to Lycaon's twelve — the book counts its doomed newcomers), with Xanthus himself putting fury in his chest: the river's first counter-move is a champion of river-blood. The challenge-exchange is a diptych with Book 20's: where Aeneas gave sixteen generations, the Paonian gives a river and a spear — "Axius, who sends the most beautiful water over the earth."
- 9 ll. 161-183 The double cast — "for he was a two-handed fighter" (περιδέξιος): one spear into the shield's gold, the other grazing Achilles' right elbow — the only blood Achilles sheds in the entire poem, and a river's grandson draws it. The duel then turns on the ash spear stuck in the bluff: three heaves, and on the fourth attempt — trying to snap the spear of Aeacus' grandson — the sword takes him. He dies at the belly like Polydorus, bowels on the ground, "gasping"; the register's darkness-formula closes his eyes.
- 10 ll. 184-199 The victory-boast is a theology lesson: "It is a hard thing to strive with the children of Cronos's mighty son — even for the son of a river." Zeus's line beats water's line; and the ladder runs up: "not even Achelous the king is his equal, not even the great strength of deep-flowing Ocean, from whom all rivers flow and every sea, and all the springs, and the deep wells." Zenodotus and Megaclides omitted line 195 (Pausanias saw such texts), which makes Achelous — not Ocean — the greatest of waters: the two readings preserve the oldest Greek dispute about the primal water. The vulgate keeps Ocean as source of all things and Achelous as king of rivers; this translation keeps the vulgate.
- 11 ll. 200-210 The corpse in the shallows: "around him the eels and the fish were busy, tearing at the fat of his kidneys" — Lycaon's threatened fate enacted on the next body within eighty lines. Then seven Paonians in a line — the plain catalogue-deaths that mark an aristeia running at full mechanical speed — until the river speaks.
- 12 ll. 211-232 The river's protest is the book's ecological center: "my lovely streams are crammed full of corpses, and I can no longer pour my current through to the bright sea... and you kill, and kill." The god of the landscape pleads not for Troy but for his own

nature — a river's function is to flow, and slaughter has clogged it. Achilles' answer grants the venue-change and nothing else, and states the poem's remaining program in one line: "stand against Hector face to face, whether he breaks me or I break him." The river then rebukes Apollo with Zeus's sunset commission — the day-clause that has governed the poem since 11.194 — as if to say: someone must hold the line till dark, and the archer is idle.

- 13 ll. 233-271 The attack. The river fights as water fights: not blows but volume — the surge that shoves corpses ashore ("bellowing like a bull") while hiding the living in his eddies (the river as shepherd of his people, doing with water what Apollo does with mist); the wave on the shield; the uprooted elm that takes the whole bank with it and bridges the stream. Achilles — for the first time since Book 1 — runs. The eagle simile keeps his dignity ("strongest of winged things at once, and swiftest"); the irrigation simile takes it away magnificently: the cosmic terror measured by a gardener whose channel outruns him, mattock in hand — the most domestic image in the Iliad set against its most elemental combat, closed by the flattest of maxims: "gods are stronger than men."
- 14 ll. 272-283 The despair-prayer. Achilles wails (ᾤμωξεν) — the verb of the wounded — that no god will save him, and that "my own mother beguiled me with lies": the promised death "under the wall... by the swift arrows of Apollo" (exactly the death he will in fact receive, 22.359-360 — the complaint certifies the prophecy). The horror is genre-specific: to drown is to die without a victor, without a grave-mound, without kleos — "like a swineherd's boy swept away by a gully he was crossing in a storm." The greatest of heroes measures his death against the smallest imaginable one; Odysseus, drowning, makes the same calculation (Od. 5.306-312).
- 15 ll. 284-297 The rescue is pure dramaturgy: Poseidon and Athena "likened to men," taking his hand — the pledge- gesture — and dictating the remainder of the epic: not fated to die by water; pen the Trojans; kill Hector; return to the ships; "we give you the glory to carry off." (Seleucus athetized 290-292, and the Cretan edition omitted them.) The plot of Books 21-22 is handed over in a handclasp.
- 16 ll. 298-327 Scamander summons Simoïs — "dear brother" — for the war of the waters: springs opened, gullies roused, "a huge clamor of timbers and stones." The threat-speech is the book's dark masterpiece: armor "deep beneath the mere... wrapped in slime," the man rolled in sand under "shingle past counting," and the perfect inversion of epic burial: "the Achaeans will not know where to gather his bones... There his burial-mound will stand ready-made: he will need no heaping of a tomb." Book 23 will build Patroclus (and eventually Achilles) the greatest funeral in poetry; the river offers its exact negation — burial as disappearance, the tomb no one can find. For a hero, that is not death but erasure.
- 17 ll. 328-341 Hera's counter-stroke calls the match-card of 20.73-74 by name: "it was against you we always reckoned eddying Xanthus matched in battle." Her plan is a coordinated burn: Hephaestus on the trees and the river, herself rousing Zephyrus and the white South Wind from the sea to drive the flame onto the Trojans. Her warning — "do not let him turn you back at all with soft words or with threats" — repeats Apollo's coaching of Aeneas (20.108-109): even gods need to be told not to listen.

- 18 *ll. 342-355* Fire eats the book's own scenery. First the corpses — the dead of Achilles' killing get from Hephaestus the cremation the river denied them: the aristeia's litter burned off the plain. The drying simile answers the irrigation simile: there, water outran its gardener; here, the North Wind dries the new-watered orchard "and the man who tends it is glad." Then the riverside flora burns by name — elms, willows, tamarisks (where the spear leaned at line 18), lotus, rushes, galingale — and the eels and fish that ate Asteropaeus tumble in the boil. The book's justice is elemental and complete.
- 19 *ll. 356-382* The surrender: "no one of the gods can stand against you... What are strife and rescue to me?" — the god of the landscape resigning the war effort mid-sentence. The cauldron simile is the poem at its most audaciously domestic: a god's agony rendered as kitchen-work, "melting down the lard of a fatted hog... with dry split wood beneath." And the oath he offers Hera is her own: 374-376 repeat, word for word, the Troy-burning clause she recited at 20.315-317 (renderings kept identical) — the river buys his life by swearing the destruction of the city he rose to save. Hera's stand-down order states the Theomachy's official rule — "not seemly to batter an immortal god for the sake of mortals" — which every god then proceeds to break.
- 20 *ll. 383-390* The gods fall on each other, "the wide earth rang, and the great heaven trumpeted" — and the audience is named: "Zeus heard, sitting on Olympus; and his own heart laughed for joy, when he saw the gods coming together in strife." This is the show he commissioned at 20.23 ("where I can watch and delight my mind"), now delivered. The gods cannot die; therefore their war is comedy, and the poem plays it as such — the laughter of Zeus is the genre-marker for the next hundred lines, while beneath it the mortal war goes on being fatal.
- 21 *ll. 391-415* Ares vs Athena, the grudge-match of Book 5: his "dog-fly" and the memory of Diomedes' guided spear; her weapon a boundary-stone "which men of former times had set to be a field's boundary-marker" — the goddess of civic order felling the war-god with the marker of agreed limits (what Ares tramples, in every sense). Seven acres of fallen god, dusty hair, a laugh, and the taunt: pay "your mother's curses — the Erinyes she wishes on you" for changing sides. The register's formulas — "blood-stained Ares," "unstrung his limbs" — do their fixed work.
- 22 *ll. 416-434* Aphrodite leading Ares off by the hand is Book 5 again (she led him wounded then too), and Hera's "there goes the dog-fly again" hands Athena her second knockdown: one blow to the breast, and the pair lie together "on the earth that feeds many." Athena's boast — had all Troy's helpers been so brave, "long ago we should have rested from the war, with the well-built citadel of Ilion sacked" — is the counterfactual that exposes the whole Theomachy: divine partisanship is what keeps the war long. Hera smiles; the smile is the scene's verdict.
- 23 *ll. 435-460* The one serious challenge: Poseidon to Apollo, elder to younger ("Begin: you are the younger born" — dueling etiquette among immortals), grounded in the poem's deepest Trojan backstory: the year of bonded labor under Laomedon, Poseidon building the wall "wide, and very beautiful, so the city might be unbreakable" (the very fortification this war beats against), Apollo herding cattle on Ida; the wage refused, the threats — binding, sale to far islands, ears lopped with bronze. Troy's royal house cheated two gods and threatened them with mutilation and slavery: the city's doom has

a contract-law history, and Poseidon's indignation — "it is his people you now favor!" — is the poem's last rehearsal of it.

- 24 *ll. 461-469* Apollo's refusal is the great verdict on mankind from above: fighting a fellow-god "for the sake of mortals — pitiful things, who like the leaves at one time flourish in their blaze, eating the fruit of the plowland, and at another wither heartless away." This is Glaucus's leaf-simile (6.146-149) — there, a man's hard-won consolation ("as the generation of leaves, so the generations of men"); here, a god's reason for indifference. The same image carries humility from below and contempt from above: no two lines in the poem measure the distance between gods and men more exactly. He turns away out of respect — for his uncle, not for us. (471 and 475-477 were athetized by Aristarchus.)
- 25 *ll. 470-496* Artemis pays for her brother's prudence: her taunt ("why do you carry that bow, useless as wind?") draws Hera — and the queen of heaven disciplines the huntress like an unruly girl: wrists caught in one hand, the bow stripped and used to box her ears, "smiling" as she does it, the arrows spilling. Hera's speech first defines her — "Zeus made you a lion to women, and gave you leave to kill whichever you choose" (Artemis as the sender of women's sudden deaths) — then demotes her: "better to slaughter beasts on the mountains than to fight by force with your betters." The dove-into-the-rock-cleft simile turns the archeress into her own quarry; the bow lies where it fell.
- 26 *ll. 497-504* Hermes to Leto — the Theomachy's shortest match and its wittiest: an immediate, courteous forfeit ("it is a hard thing to trade blows with the wives of cloud-gatherer Zeus") with the winnings handed over in advance: "boast among the immortal gods that you overcame me with your strong force." Leto, unbloodied, gathers her daughter's scattered arrows — the one maternal gesture in a battle of gods.
- 27 *ll. 505-513* The end of the divine war: Artemis in Zeus's lap, the ambrosial robe trembling, and the father "laughing sweetly" as he asks who hurt her "as if you had been caught doing wrong in the open." Her answer indicts the household: "Your wife battered me... from whom strife and quarrel cling to the immortals." The Theomachy that began with a cosmic quake ends as a family scene in the living room — which is the poem's point: for the deathless, war can only ever be domestic comedy. Below, meanwhile, it is Books 22-24.
- 28 *ll. 514-543* Apollo alone stays at his post, entering Troy "lest the Danaans sack it that day, beyond its fate" — the god now guarding the same limit Zeus feared for at 20.30. The burning-city simile makes Achilles into the thing he is about to cause ("the wrath of the gods has sent it up" — he is that wrath); and Priam appears in his end-game role for the first time: the old man on the tower, ordering the gates held open in men's hands until the rout is in, then barred — "I dread that ruinous man — that he may leap inside the wall." The gates "spread wide, made a light of safety" (φάος — the register's word for rescue): the same doors that will stand between Hector and his life in Book 22.
- 29 *ll. 544-570* Agenor — one man, stiffened by Apollo, between Achilles and the open gates. His soliloquy in the registered frame ("troubled, he spoke to his own great-hearted spirit") is the infantryman's complete decision-tree: flight with the crowd (caught and butchered "for the coward I am"); solo flight to Ida's brush — with the poem's most humane detail, the fugitive's daydream of an evening bath in the river, "cooled the sweat

from me" — rejected on pure footspeed-arithmetic; then the discovery on which the rest of the poem stands: "His flesh too, surely, can be cut by the sharp bronze; in him is one life, no more; and mortal, men say he is." Every man who chooses to stand against Achilles must first say this catechism; Hector will say it, and its refutations, at 22.99-130.

- 30 *ll. 571-598* The leopard simile — she comes out of deep brush at the huntsman and "run through on the very spear, she does not leave off her valor, until she closes with him or goes down": doomed courage as the poem's highest animal image, spent here on a secondary hero to set the standard Hector will be measured against. Agenor's cast hits the shin — "the greave of new-forged tin screamed terribly" — and Hephaestus's armor turns its first blow in combat exactly where Hephaestus promised marvel rather than protection (18.466-467): it gives both. Apollo snatches Agenor into mist before the counterstroke — the third man so saved from Achilles in two books.
- 31 *ll. 599-611* The decoy: Apollo "likened in every point to Agenor" runs, and the fastest man alive chases a god across the wheat-bearing plain, "always hoping to catch him on his quick feet" — Achilles' one weapon against Hector, his speed, played against him to bleed the pursuit of its object. The trade is a city's remnant for one man's glory: while he chases nothing, Troy pours inside, "glad" — and the book's last lines are the rout's arithmetic, without a single name: no one dared wait "to learn who had escaped and who had died in the fighting; in they poured, headlong, every man whose feet and knees could save him." One man is not inside. Book 22 opens with Hector standing in front of the gates.

Iliad — Book 22

Hector waits alone outside the gates; Achilles chases him three times around the city and kills him; Priam, Hecuba, and Andromache mourn.

- So, driven like fawns into the city, the Trojans¹
 dried their sweat, and drank, and slaked their thirst,
 leaning on the beautiful battlements; and the Achaeans
 came up close under the wall, shields tilted on shoulders.
- 5 But Hector — deadly fate shackled him where he stood,
 in front of Ilion and the Scaean Gates.
 And Phoebus Apollo called to the son of Peleus:
 "Why, son of Peleus, do you chase me on your quick feet —
 you a mortal, and I a deathless god? Not even yet
- 10 have you known me for a god: how unrelenting your fury is!
 And the Trojans you routed — no thought for that labor now?
 They are penned in the town, while you swerve away out here.
 You cannot kill me: I am not a man marked out for death."
 Then, deeply troubled, swift-footed Achilles answered him:
- 15 "You have robbed me, worker-from-afar — deadliest of all gods —
 turning me away from the wall. Many more of them
 would have bitten the earth before they got to Ilion!
 Now you have stolen great glory from me, and saved them
 cheaply: you had no vengeance to fear afterward.
- 20 I would pay you back — I! — if only I had the power."
 So speaking, he set off for the city, high-hearted,²
 stretched out like a prize-winning horse with his chariot,
 one that runs at full reach, easily, over the plain:
 so Achilles worked his feet and knees, and they were quick.
- 25 And it was old Priam whose eyes first made him out,
 streaking across the plain, blazing like the star
 that rises at harvest-time, and its rays shine clear
 among many stars in the milking-dark of night —
 the star men call by name the Dog of Orion.
- 30 Brightest of all it is; and it is made an evil sign,
 and brings great fever down on wretched mortals:

so shone the bronze on his chest as he ran.
 And the old man cried out, and beat his head with his hands,
 raising them high, and shouted down, crying aloud,
 35 begging his dear son. But he, before the gates,
 stood fast, hot beyond turning to fight Achilles;
 and the old man called to him piteously, hands outstretched:
 "Hector — do not wait for that man, dear child!³
 Not alone, with no one by you — or you will meet your doom quickly,
 40 broken by the son of Peleus: for he is far the stronger.
 Merciless! I wish the gods loved him just as much
 as I do: quickly enough the dogs and vultures would eat him
 where he lay — and this terrible grief would leave my heart.
 He has emptied me of many sons, and good ones,
 45 killing them, or selling them off to far-lying islands.
 Even now there are two — Lycaon and Polydorus —
 whom I cannot see among the Trojans penned in the town,
 the sons Laothoe bore me, a queen among women.
 If they are alive somewhere in the camp, then we will
 50 ransom them with bronze and gold: it is there, inside —
 old Altes, the famous name, gave plenty with his daughter.
 But if they are dead already, and in the house of Hades,
 that is grief to my heart and their mother's — we who bore them.
 To the rest of the people the grief will be briefer —
 55 so long as you do not die too, broken by Achilles.
 Come inside the wall, my child — so you may save
 the men and women of Troy; do not hand the great glory
 to the son of Peleus, and be stripped of your own dear life.
 And pity me — the wretch, the ill-fated, who can still feel —
 60 whom the father, Cronos's son, on the threshold of old age
 will wither out in hard fate, with my eyes full of evils:
 sons destroyed, daughters dragged away captive,
 store-chambers ransacked, and little children
 dashed against the ground in the terrible slaughter,
 65 and my sons' wives dragged off under the deadly hands of Achaeans.
 And me last of all — at my own front door the dogs
 will tear me raw, when someone with the sharp bronze
 has stabbed or speared the life out of my limbs —

the dogs I fed at my table, to keep my doors,
 70 who will drink my blood, and sprawl, their hearts run mad,
 in my own doorway. For a young man it is all seemly:
 killed in war, torn by the sharp bronze,
 to lie there — everything is beautiful on him, dead, whatever shows.
 But when the dogs defile the grey head and the grey beard
 75 and the naked shame of an old man slain,
 that is the most pitiful thing there is for wretched mortals."
 So the old man spoke, and pulled at his grey hair with his hands,
 tearing it from his head; but he could not move the heart of Hector.
 And his mother in her turn wailed, letting her tears fall,⁴
 80 loosening the fold of her gown; with the other hand she held out her
 breast,
 and letting her tears fall she spoke winged words:
 "Hector, my child — respect this. And pity me —
 me — if ever I gave you this breast, and it stilled your crying.
 Remember that, dear child. Fight that man of death
 85 from inside the wall — do not stand out there to meet him,
 merciless one! For if he kills you, I shall never
 mourn you laid on a bed, dear green shoot I bore —
 nor will your wife of the rich dowry — but far away from us both,
 by the ships of the Argives, the quick dogs will eat you."
 90 So the two of them, weeping, called to their dear son,
 begging over and over; but they could not move the heart of Hector.
 He stood fast, as gigantic Achilles came on nearer.
 And as a mountain snake at his hole waits for a man,⁵
 fed full of evil poisons, and the terrible anger has entered him,
 95 and he glares dreadfully, coiling around his hole:
 so Hector, holding his fury unquenchable, would not give way,
 his shining shield propped on the jut of the tower;
 and troubled, he spoke to his own great-hearted spirit:
 "Ah me! If I go inside the gates and the wall,⁶
 100 Polydamas will be the first to lay reproach on me —
 he who commanded me to lead the Trojans back to the city
 on that ruinous night, when brilliant Achilles rose.
 I would not listen. It would have been far better if I had.
 Now — since I have destroyed the army by my own recklessness —

- 105 I am ashamed before the Trojan men and the trailing-robed
Trojan women: that some worse man than I may say:
'Hector trusted his own strength, and destroyed the army.'
So they will talk. And then it would be far better for me
to meet Achilles man to man, and kill him, and come home —
110 or die at his hands myself, with honor, in front of the city.
Or what if — if I set down the bossed shield
and the heavy helmet, and lean the spear on the wall,
and go out, just myself, to meet blameless Achilles,
and promise him Helen, and all her treasure with her —
115 everything, all that Alexandros in his hollow ships
brought home to Troy, the beginning of the quarrel —
to give to the sons of Atreus to lead away; and for the Achaeans,
to divide with them everything else this city holds;
and after, I would take the elders' oath for the Trojans
120 to hide nothing, but to split it all in two —
all the wealth the lovely town keeps locked within it —
but why does my own heart argue these things with me?
I might come to him, suppliant — and he would show no pity,
no respect at all: he would kill me naked as I stood,
125 just like a woman, once I had put off my armor.
There is no way now, from an oak or from a rock,
to murmur with him softly — the way a girl and a young man,
a girl and a young man, murmur softly with each other.
Better to drive together in strife — and quickly.
130 Let us see to which of us the Olympian hands the triumph."
So he weighed it, waiting. And Achilles came near him,⁷
the equal of Enyalios, the war-god of the flashing helm,
shaking the Pelian ash over his right shoulder,
terrible; and the bronze around him flashed with a light
135 like blazing fire, or the sun as it rises.
And trembling took Hector when he saw him. He could bear it⁸
no longer there: he left the gates behind, and ran in terror;
and the son of Peleus sprang after, trusting his quick feet.
As a falcon in the mountains, lightest of winged things,
140 swoops easily after a trembling dove:
she flees away under him, and he close upon her, shrieking

sharp, lunges again and again, and his heart drives him to take her:
 so Achilles flew straight for him, hot; and Hector fled
 under the wall of the Trojans, working his knees fast.

145 Past the lookout-place, past the wind-blown wild fig,⁹
 always out from under the wall, along the wagon-road
 they sped; and they came to the two fair-flowing springs,
 where the twin sources of eddying Scamander leap up.
 One flows with warm water, and steam all around it
 150 rises off it, as if from a burning fire;
 the other runs out even in summer as cold as hail
 or freezing snow, or ice that forms from water.
 And there beside them are the wide washing-troughs,
 beautiful, of stone, where their glistening clothes
 155 were washed by the Trojans' wives and their beautiful daughters —
 in the old days, in peace: before the sons of the Achaeans came.
 There the two of them ran past, one fleeing, one behind pursuing:
 a brave man fled in front — but a far better one pursued him —
 fast: since it was no beast of sacrifice, no ox-hide,
 160 they strove for — the prizes given for men's running:
 they ran for the life of Hector, the tamer of horses.
 As when prize-winning single-hoofed horses wheel round the turn-
 posts
 at full gallop, and a great prize is set out —
 a tripod, or a woman — in the games for a man who has died:
 165 so the two of them whirled three times around Priam's city
 on their quick feet. And all the gods looked on.
 And the father of men and gods began speaking among them:¹⁰
 "Shame — a man that I love, chased around the wall
 before my own eyes! My heart is grieving for Hector,
 170 who has burned the thigh-cuts of many oxen for me
 on the peaks of folded Ida, and other times again
 on the city's height; and now brilliant Achilles
 hunts him on quick feet around the city of Priam.
 Come, gods — consider it, take counsel:
 175 shall we save him from death? Or now, at last,
 break him — brave though he is — under Achilles, Peleus's son?"
 Then answered him the goddess grey-eyed Athena:

"Father of the bright bolt, of the black cloud — what a word!
 A man — a mortal, long since doomed to his fate —
 180 and you mean to release him back out of harsh-sounding death?
 Do it. But we other gods will not all approve you."
 Then in answer spoke to her cloud-gatherer Zeus:
 "Take heart, Tritogeneia, dear child. I do not speak
 in full earnest, and to you I mean to be kind.
 185 Do as your purpose is. Hold back no longer."
 So speaking, he urged on Athena, eager already,
 and she went darting down from the peaks of Olympus.
 And swift Achilles pressed Hector without pause, driving him.¹¹
 As when a hound in the mountains starts the fawn of a deer
 190 out of its bed, and courses it through glens and gorges;
 and even if it goes to ground, cowering under a thicket,
 the hound tracks it out, running steadily, till he finds it:
 so Hector could not shake the swift-footed son of Peleus.
 As often as he set himself to dash for the Dardanian gates,
 195 to get in under the strong-built towers,
 hoping the men above might defend him with their missiles,
 so often Achilles headed him off and turned him back
 toward the plain, keeping himself always on the city side.
 And as in a dream a man cannot catch one who runs —
 200 the one cannot escape him, nor the other catch —
 so he could not run him down, nor the other get away.
 And how could Hector have slipped the death-spirits of death,
 had not Apollo — for the last and latest time — come near him,
 to rouse his strength in him, and his quick knees?
 205 And brilliant Achilles shook his head to the army: no —
 he would not let them throw their bitter missiles at Hector,
 lest some thrower win the glory, and he come second.
 But when they came the fourth time round to the springs,¹²
 then it was that the father stretched out his golden scales,
 210 and set in them two death-spirits of death that lays men low —
 one for Achilles, one for Hector, tamer of horses —
 and grasping the middle he raised it. And Hector's day of doom
 sank down, and went to Hades; and Phoebus Apollo left him.
 And the goddess grey-eyed Athena came to the son of Peleus,¹³

- 215 and standing close she spoke winged words:
 "Now at last, shining Achilles, dear to Zeus, I hope
 the two of us bring the Achaeans great glory at the ships,
 breaking Hector, however insatiable for battle.
 Now there is no escaping us any longer — not for him,
 220 not though Apollo the worker-from-afar should suffer agonies for it,
 rolling and rolling at the feet of father Zeus of the aegis.
 Now stop, and catch your breath. I will go
 and win this man over to fight you face to face."
 So spoke Athena; and he obeyed, and rejoiced at heart,
 225 and stood there, leaning on his bronze-bladed ash.
 And she left him, and came up with brilliant Hector,
 likened to Deiphobus in body and unwearying voice;
 and standing close she spoke winged words:
 "Old friend — how hard swift Achilles is pressing you,
 230 hunting you on quick feet around the city of Priam!
 Come — let us make our stand, and hold him off together."
 Then answered her great Hector of the flashing helmet:
 "Deiphobus — you were always dearest to me before this
 of all the brothers Hecuba and Priam bore;
 235 and now I mean to honor you in my heart still more,
 who dared for my sake, when your eyes saw me,
 to come outside the wall — while the others stay within."
 Then answered him the goddess grey-eyed Athena:
 "Old friend — yes: father and lady mother begged me hard,
 240 each in turn, clasping my knees, and my companions around them,
 to stay inside — so hard they are all trembling.
 But the heart in me was worn away with grieving.
 Now — straight at him, and let us two fight; and no
 sparing of spears: so we may learn whether Achilles
 245 kills us both and carries our bloody armor
 to the hollow ships — or is broken by your spear."
 So spoke Athena, and led him on by her cunning.
 And when they had come close, advancing on each other,¹⁴
 the first to speak was great Hector of the flashing helmet:
 250 "No more running from you, son of Peleus — not now, as before,
 when I fled three times round the great city of Priam, and dared not

- stand to your coming. Now my heart has risen and set me
to stand against you face to face. I will kill, or be killed.
But come — let us swear here by the gods: for they
255 will be the best witnesses, and the guardians of covenants.
I will not defile you — not monstrosly — if Zeus grants me
the endurance, and I take your life:
no, when I have stripped your famed armor, Achilles,
I will give your body back to the Achaeans. And you do the same."
260 Then, glaring darkly, swift-footed Achilles answered him:¹⁵
"Hector — you past forgiving — talk to me of no covenants.
As between lions and men there are no faithful oaths,
and wolves and lambs do not carry hearts in concord,
but think evil against each other all the way through:
265 so there is no way for me and you to be friends, and between us
there will be no oaths — not before one or the other falls
and gluts with his blood Ares, the fighter under the ox-hide shield.
Remember every kind of valor you own: now above all hours
you must be a spearman, and a daring fighter.
270 There is no way out for you any longer: this instant Pallas Athena
breaks you under my spear. Now, in one payment, you settle
all my grief for my companions — the men you killed, raging with your
spear."
He spoke, and poised and hurled his long-shadowed spear.¹⁶
But shining Hector was watching it, and dodged:
275 he saw it coming and crouched, and the bronze spear flew over
and stuck in the earth. And Pallas Athena snatched it up
and gave it back to Achilles — hidden from Hector, shepherd of the
people.
And Hector called across to the blameless son of Peleus:
"You missed! So after all, godlike Achilles, you never
280 learned my doom from Zeus — though you claimed to know it.
You are a glib one, a very thief with your words —
hoping I would forget my fury and valor for fear of you.
You will plant no spear in my back as I run:
as I charge you straight on, drive it through my chest —
285 if the god has given you that. Now dodge my bronze
in your turn — and may you carry all of it away in your flesh!

The war would be lighter for the Trojans
 with you destroyed. You are their greatest bane."
 He spoke, and poised and hurled his long-shadowed spear,
 290 and hit the shield of the son of Peleus, mid-center — no miss —
 but the spear glanced far off the shield. And Hector was angry
 that the swift cast had left his hand for nothing,
 and stood there hanging his head: he had no second ash spear.
 He shouted then, calling to white-shielded Deiphobus —
 295 a long spear was what he asked — but Deiphobus was nowhere near
 him.
 And Hector understood inside himself, and said:¹⁷
 "So. The gods have called me deathward after all.
 I thought the hero Deiphobus stood beside me;
 but he is inside the wall, and Athena has tricked me.
 300 Now evil death is close to me — not far off now,
 and no way out. So this, long since, was the true pleasure
 of Zeus, and of Zeus's son who strikes from afar, who before
 defended me gladly. And now fate overtakes me.
 Then let me not die without a fight, without glory —
 305 no: having done some great thing first, for men to come to hear of."
 So speaking, he drew the sharp sword¹⁸
 that hung along his flank, heavy and huge,
 gathered himself, and swooped — like the high-flying eagle
 that drops to the plain through the lowering clouds
 310 to snatch a soft lamb or a cowering hare:
 so Hector swooped, shaking his sharp sword.
 And Achilles charged to meet him, his heart crammed full
 of savage fury; over his chest he held the cover of his shield,
 beautiful, intricate; and he nodded with the shining helmet,
 315 four-horned; and around it tossed the beautiful plumes
 of gold that Hephaestus had set thick along the crest.
 And as a star moves among stars in the milking-dark of night —
 Hesperus, the most beautiful star that stands in heaven —
 so the light went from the keen point that Achilles
 320 balanced in his right hand, purposing evil for brilliant Hector,
 searching the beautiful flesh for where it would yield the most.
 Now all the rest of his flesh the bronze armor held —¹⁹

- the beautiful armor he stripped from the might of Patroclus, killed —
 but there showed, where the collarbones part neck from shoulders,
 325 the gullet — where the destruction of a life is quickest.
 There, as he charged, brilliant Achilles drove with the spear,
 and the point went through and out the soft neck —
 yet the ash, heavy with bronze, did not sever the windpipe,
 so that he could still speak, and trade words with him.
- 330 He crashed down in the dust; and brilliant Achilles cried in triumph:
 "Hector — no doubt you thought, while you stripped Patroclus,
 that you were safe; and I, far off — you gave me no thought.
 Fool: far from him, a helper — and a far greater one —
 was left behind at the hollow ships: I,
 335 who have unstrung your knees. You the dogs and the birds
 will drag and defile. Him the Achaeans will bury."
 Then, his strength nearly gone, Hector of the flashing helmet:²⁰
 "I beg you — by your life, by your knees, by your parents:
 do not let the dogs devour me by the ships of the Achaeans.
- 340 Take the bronze — take gold in plenty —
 the gifts my father and my lady mother will give you;
 and give my body back to go home, so that the Trojans
 and the Trojans' wives may grant me, dead, my portion of fire."
 Then, glaring darkly, swift-footed Achilles answered him:
- 345 "Dog. Do not beg me by knees, or by parents.
 I only wish the fury and the heart in me would drive me
 to hack away your flesh and eat it raw myself — for what you have done
 —
 as surely as there is no man alive who will keep the dogs
 from your head: not if they bring here and weigh out
 350 ransom ten times over — twenty times — and promise more;
 not if Priam, Dardanus's descendant, bids them buy you
 for your own weight in gold — not even so shall your lady mother
 lay on a bed and mourn the son she bore.
 No: the dogs and the birds will share you out — all of you."
 355 Then, dying, Hector of the flashing helmet said to him:²¹
 "I know you now — looking at you. There was never a chance
 I would persuade you: the heart in your chest is iron.
 Only take care, now, that I not become the gods' curse

- upon you — on that day when Paris and Phoebus Apollo
 360 destroy you, brave as you are, at the Scaean Gates."
 Even as he spoke, the end that is death covered him;
 and his soul, flying from his limbs, went down to the house of Hades,
 wailing its fate, leaving its manhood and its youth.
 And brilliant Achilles spoke to him — dead already:
 365 "Die. My own death-spirit I will accept whenever
 Zeus wills to accomplish it, and the other immortal gods."
 He spoke, and pulled the bronze spear out of the corpse²²
 and set it aside, and stripped the bloody armor
 from the shoulders. And the other sons of the Achaeans ran up around
 him,
 370 and gazed at the stature and the marvelous beauty
 of Hector; and not one man stood by him without a stab.
 And thus would one of them say, with a glance at his neighbor:
 "Well now — softer to the touch, this Hector, easier handling
 than when he burned the ships with blazing fire!"
 375 So a man would say — and step in close, and wound him.
 Now when swift-footed brilliant Achilles had stripped him,²³
 he stood among the Achaeans and spoke winged words:
 "Friends — leaders and counselors of the Argives —
 since the gods have granted us the breaking of this man,
 380 who did more harm than all the rest together,
 come: let us circle the city under arms and probe it,
 and learn what mind the Trojans have in them now —
 whether they will abandon the high town, with this man fallen,
 or are set on holding it, though Hector is no more.
 385 But why does my own heart argue these things with me?
 By the ships lies a dead man — unwept, unburied —
 Patroclus. I will not forget him, not while I
 am among the living, and my own knees have their spring.
 And if in the house of Hades men forget their dead,
 390 even there I will remember my dear companion.
 Now, singing the paeon, young men of the Achaeans,
 let us go back to the hollow ships, and take this man.
 We have won great glory: we have killed brilliant Hector —
 the man the Trojans prayed to through their city, as to a god."

- 395 He spoke; and he devised foul work against brilliant Hector.²⁴
 Behind both feet he pierced the tendons through,
 from heel to ankle, and threaded straps of oxhide,
 and bound them to his chariot, and left the head to drag;
 and lifting the famed armor into the car, he mounted
 400 and lashed the horses on; and they flew, nothing loath.
 And the dust rose off the dragged man; and his dark hair
 spread wide around him; and in the dust lay all that head
 that was so beautiful before; but now Zeus gave him
 to his enemies, to be defiled in his own fatherland.
 405 So all his head was fouled with dust. And now his mother²⁵
 tore her hair, and flung the shining veil
 far from her, and screamed aloud at the sight of her child;
 and his dear father groaned piteously, and around them the people
 were seized with screaming and with wailing through the city.
 410 It was most like this — as if the whole of
 beetling Ilion, top to bottom, were smouldering in fire.
 The people could barely hold the old man, frantic
 in his grief to go out by the Dardanian gates.
 He begged them all, groveling in the dung,
 415 calling on each man by his name:
 "Let be, friends — for all your care of me, let me alone
 go out of the city and come to the ships of the Achaeans.
 I will beg this man — this reckless doer of violence —
 if somehow he may respect my years, and pity
 420 old age. For he too has a father — such a one as I am:
 Peleus, who begot him and reared him to be a bane
 for the Trojans — and beyond all men he has laid grief on me:
 so many of my sons he has killed in their green prime.
 Yet for all of them I do not mourn so much — grieved as I am —
 425 as for one, whose sharp loss will carry me down into Hades:
 Hector. I wish he had died in my arms!
 Then the two of us could have glutted ourselves with weeping and
 wailing —
 the mother who bore him — born to sorrow — and I myself."
 So he spoke, weeping; and the citizens groaned in answer.
 430 And among the women of Troy, Hecuba led the thick lament:²⁶

- "My child — I am destroyed. Why should I live now, in this horror,
with you dead? — you who were, night and day,
my boast through the city, and a blessing to all,
to the men and women of Troy through the town, who greeted you
435 like a god: for you were their great glory too,
while you lived. Now death and fate have overtaken you."
So she spoke, weeping. But the wife of Hector had not yet²⁷
heard anything: no true messenger had come to her
to tell her that her husband stood alone outside the gates.
- 440 She was weaving at her loom, deep in the high house,
a double cloak, purple, sprinkling in flowers of many colors;
and she had called through the house to her lovely-braided handmaids
to set a great tripod over the fire, so there would be
a warm bath for Hector, for his return out of the fighting.
- 445 Poor innocent: she did not know that far from all baths
grey-eyed Athena had broken him under the hands of Achilles.
Then she heard the shrieking and the wailing from the tower;
and her limbs whirled where she stood, and the shuttle fell out of her
hand,
and she called again to her lovely-braided slave-women:
- 450 "Here — two of you, come with me. I must see what has happened.
I heard the voice of my honored mother-in-law, and in me
my own heart leaps to my mouth, and beneath me my knees
are frozen: something evil is close to the children of Priam.
May the word stay far from my ear! — but I am terribly
455 afraid that brilliant Achilles has cut off my bold Hector,
alone, from the city, and driven him toward the plain,
and has ended it — that grievous pride of his
that always held him: he would never stay back in the crowd of men,
but ran far out in front, yielding first place to no one."
- 460 So speaking she rushed through the hall like a madwoman,²⁸
her heart slamming; and her maids went with her.
But when she reached the tower and the crowd of men,
she stopped on the wall, staring — and saw him:
dragged in front of the city, and the quick horses
465 dragging him, uncaring, toward the hollow ships of the Achaeans.
Then black night came down and covered her eyes,

- and she toppled backward, and gasped her spirit out.
 And off her head she flung the shining head-dress —
 the frontlet, and the cap, and the woven band,
 470 and the veil that golden Aphrodite gave her
 on the day Hector of the flashing helmet led her
 out of Eëtion's house, when he had brought bride-gifts past counting.
 Around her, thick, stood her husband's sisters and his brothers' wives,
 and held her up among them, dazed to the point of death.
 475 But when she caught her breath, and the spirit gathered again in her
 chest,²⁹
 with bursting sobs she spoke among the women of Troy:
 "Hector — I am wretched. To one fate, then, we were born,
 the two of us: you in Troy, in the house of Priam,
 and I in Thebe, under wooded Placus,
 480 in the house of Eëtion — who reared me when I was little,
 the doomed man, the ill-doomed girl. I wish he had never begotten me.
 Now you go down to the house of Hades under the hidden places
 of the earth, and you leave me in hateful mourning,
 a widow in your halls. And the boy is just a baby still,
 485 whom we bore, you and I — the two ill-fated. No help
 will you be to him, Hector — you are dead — nor he to you.
 For even if he escapes the Achaeans' war of many tears,³⁰
 still there will be nothing for him ever after but labor
 and sorrows: other men will strip away his fields.
 490 The day of orphaning makes a child companionless:
 his head is bowed to everyone; his cheeks are wet with tears;
 and in his need the boy goes up to his father's friends,
 tugging at one man's cloak, another's tunic;
 and of those who pity him, one holds out his cup — a moment:
 495 he wets his lips; his palate he does not wet.
 And a boy with both parents living beats him from the feast,
 striking him with his fists, jeering at him with insults:
 'Get out — just as you are! No father of yours dines with us.'
 And in tears the boy goes up to his widowed mother —
 500 Astyanax: who before, on his own father's knees,
 would eat only marrow and the rich fat of sheep;
 and when sleep came over him, and he left off his child's play,

he would slumber in a bed, in the arms of his nurse,
 in soft bedding, his heart brimful of good things.
 505 But now he will suffer and suffer, missing his dear father —
 Astyanax, 'the lord of the city,' as the Trojans call him
 by name: for you alone guarded their gates and their long walls.
 Now, by the beaked ships, far away from your parents,³¹
 the writhing worms will eat you, when the dogs have had
 510 their fill of you — naked: though here in your halls lies clothing,
 fine-woven and lovely, made by the hands of women.
 All of it — all — I will burn now in blazing fire:
 no use to you: you will not lie in it.
 Let it be your glory in the eyes of the men and women of Troy."
 515 So she spoke, weeping; and the women wailed in answer.

NOTES TO BOOK 22

- 1 *ll. 1-20* The frame: Troy drinking and drying its sweat on the battlements — safety made physical — while one man stands outside, "shackled" by fate (πέδησεν: the poem's verb for the trap already sprung). Apollo's revelation ends the decoy-chase of 21.599-611, and his taunt — "you cannot kill me: I am not a man marked out for death" — states the book's whole geometry: gods are unkillable, so all the afternoon's fury must land on the one man who is not. Achilles' reply — "I would pay you back, if only I had the power" — is the closest any mortal in the poem comes to declaring war on heaven.
- 2 *ll. 21-32* The Dog Star simile. Priam sees Achilles as Sirius — "brightest of all... and it is made an evil sign, and brings great fever down on wretched mortals": the most beautiful light in the sky, read as pestilence. It is the book's signature: brilliance and disaster in a single body, seen by an old man from a wall. (Achilles' own armor makes the same double sign at 134-135 — fire, or sunrise.)
- 3 *ll. 38-76* Priam's plea moves from policy to the body. The center is Lycaon and Polydorus — "whom I cannot see among the Trojans penned in the town" — the audience knowing what the father does not: Book 20 and 21 have already answered him. The close is the most terrible passage spoken by any parent in the poem: the vision of his own scavenging — the table-dogs, "my door-keepers," drinking his blood at his own threshold — governed by the law he states with dreadful calm: on a young man killed in war "everything is beautiful, dead, whatever shows" (πάντα καλὰ); but dogs at the grey head and beard and "the naked shame of an old man slain — that is the most pitiful thing there is for wretched mortals." Tyrtæus rebuilt the lines for Spartan war-song; here they are not exhortation but a father's terror.
- 4 *ll. 79-89* Hecuba's argument is the breast itself — λαθικηδέα μαζόν, "the breast that stills care" — motherhood presented as evidence: "if ever I gave you this breast... remember that." Both parents end at the same image (the dogs, the unmourned bed) because both know what corpse-treatment this war has come to; the poem has spent four books teaching it.
- 5 *ll. 93-98* The snake simile: coiled at his hole, "fed full of evil poisons," glaring — the only simile in the poem that makes a hero venomous. It renders exactly what shame has done to Hector: courage held not as flame (his usual fire-similes) but as toxin — swallowed anger waiting at a threshold it cannot abandon.
- 6 *ll. 99-130* The soliloquy. Its logic deserves tracing: (1) Polydamas was right on the ruinous night (18.249-313 — "whose counsels were ruinous" said the narrator; Hector now says it of himself: "I have destroyed the army by my own recklessness"); (2) therefore the city's eyes — down to "some worse man than I" — are unbearable: shame (αἰδέομαι) holds him outside; (3) the fantasy of total surrender — Helen, her treasure, half the city's wealth under oath — rehearsed in loving legal detail and cut off by the fixed register line ("but why does my own heart argue these things with me?" = 21.562): he would be killed "naked... just like a woman"; (4) the strangest and most human turn in the poem —

"There is no way now, from an oak or from a rock, to murmur with him softly — the way a girl and a young man, a girl and a young man, murmur softly with each other." The doubled phrase (the Greek repeats it too) is courtship remembered at the door of death: no more beginning-talk; only the ending. So: "Let us see to which of us the Olympian hands the triumph."

- 7 *ll. 131-135* Achilles arrives as the war-god ("the equal of Enyalios"), the Pelian ash over his shoulder, bronze like "blazing fire, or the sun as it rises" — the Dog Star of 26-31 come to ground-level. The poem has spent two similes making him light; the third thing light does, after shining and warming, is blind.
- 8 *ll. 136-144* "And trembling took Hector... he left the gates behind, and ran." The poem does not soften it: the snake bolts from its hole; the best man of Troy, having chosen to stand through ninety lines of deliberation, is undone in one look. The falcon-and-dove simile gives the chase its physics (the shriek, the repeated lunges) and its verdict: from here to the springs Hector is prey.
- 9 *ll. 145-166* The run past the landmarks — lookout, wild fig, wagon-road — to the double springs of Scamander (one steaming, one ice-cold) and the stone washing-troughs "where the Trojans' wives and their beautiful daughters used to wash their glistening clothes — in the old days, in peace, before the sons of the Achaeans came." No passage in Homer does more with less: the whole lost civilian world folded into laundry, set at the exact spot where its defender is being run down. Then the narrator's cold accounting — "a brave man fled in front, but a far better one pursued" — and the great inversion of the games: they run as at funeral games, "a tripod, or a woman" for prize — "but they ran for the life of Hector, the tamer of horses." (Some ancient copies added a plus- line at 158; the apparatus records it.) Book 23 will run real races, for real tripods, around this dead man's pyre.
- 10 *ll. 167-187* The divine council in miniature: Zeus's grief for a pious man ("who has burned the thigh-cuts of many oxen for me") and the proposal to save him — answered by Athena with the same three lines Hera used over Sarpedon (179-181 = 16.441-443, kept verbatim): a mortal "long since doomed" cannot be un-doomed without cosmic scandal; "Do it. But we other gods will not all approve you." The rescue-debate has become a form-letter, and both times the father yields — adding here, with terrible mildness, that he "does not speak in full earnest." Zeus's love is real; it is simply not the kind that saves.
- 11 *ll. 188-207* Three similes of unclosable distance: the hound and the fawn (tracking "steadily, till he finds it"); Achilles heading Hector off from the Dardanian gates "keeping himself always on the city side" — the pursuit as sheep-dogging, the runner herded away from rescue; and the dream — "as in a dream a man cannot catch one who runs — the one cannot escape him, nor the other catch." Aristarchus athetized the dream-lines as undignified; they are the passage's genius — the one simile in Homer taken not from the world but from the experience of nightmare, where both runners labor and neither moves. Achilles' head-shake to the army (no missiles — "lest some thrower win the glory, and he come second") keeps the kill private: this death has an owner.
- 12 *ll. 208-213* The scales. "Then the father stretched out his golden scales" — as at 8.69-74 for the armies, now for two men — "and Hector's day of doom sank down, and went to

Hades; and Phoebus Apollo left him." Two clauses, no comment: the god who saved him at 20.443, who roused his knees at 22.204, departs like an advocate leaving a courtroom at verdict. Fate in the Iliad is exactly this scene: not a decree from above the gods, but the moment the gods stop arguing.

- 13 *ll. 214-247* Athena's masterpiece of cruelty. To Achilles she is plain ("Now stop, and catch your breath. I will go and win this man over"); to Hector she is Deiphobus — the dearest brother, "in body and unwearying voice" — with a fabricated biography of devotion (the parents' clasped knees, "the heart in me was worn away with grieving") engineered to convert the fugitive's shame into hope. Hector's answer — "I mean to honor you in my heart still more" — is the sound of a man being loved back into a trap. The narrator closes the scene with the plainest possible verdict: "So spoke Athena, and led him on by her cunning" (κερδοσύνη). Nothing else any god does in the poem is this personal.
- 14 *ll. 248-259* Hector's compact: he has stopped running — "I will kill, or be killed" — and offers the war's last treaty, with the gods as "witnesses and guardians of covenants": the winner strips the armor and returns the body. It is the decent minimum of heroic war, the norm the whole Patroclus-sequence has been shredding; and he offers it to the one man in the poem for whom it is now unthinkable.
- 15 *ll. 260-272* The refusal, in natural law: "As between lions and men there are no faithful oaths, and wolves and lambs do not carry hearts in concord... there will be no oaths — not before one or the other falls and gluts with his blood Ares, the fighter under the ox-hide shield" (the register's phrase, 5.289 = 20.78 — now at its terminus). Achilles has left the covenant-species; he says so in genus terms. The taunt's ledger — "in one payment, you settle all my grief" — makes Hector the invoice for every companion dead since Book 16.
- 16 *ll. 273-295* The exchange of casts, rigged: Achilles misses — and Athena returns the spear "hidden from Hector, shepherd of the people" (the title never crueller than here, applied to the deceived). Hector's speech at the false parity — "You missed!... You will plant no spear in my back as I run: drive it through my chest as I charge" — is magnificent precisely because it is obsolete: he thinks he is in a duel; he is in an execution with an intermission. His own cast hits mid-shield, true — against the shield of Hephaestus. Then: "he had no second ash spear," and Deiphobus "was nowhere near him."
- 17 *ll. 296-305* The recognition. "So. The gods have called me deathward... Athena has tricked me. Now evil death is close to me — not far off now, and no way out." Four lines from deception to acceptance, and then the sentence on which Hector's whole meaning rests: "Then let me not die without a fight, without glory — no: having done some great thing first, for men to come to hear of" (ἐσσομένοισι πῦθ' ἔσθαι — for those-to-be to learn). Cheated by heaven, out of weapons, out of brothers, he reorganizes in four heartbeats around the only future left: the story. It is the clearest statement in Greek of what heroism is for.
- 18 *ll. 306-321* The last charge: Hector's eagle-stoop with the sword (the predator-simile returned to him for his final act — he dies attacking); Achilles' counter-charge behind the shield, the four-horned helmet, and Hesperus — "the most beautiful star that stands in heaven" — as the light of the spear-point "purposing evil." The evening star: the day-

clause of Zeus's plan, the sunset Hector was granted through, now rising as the gleam on the weapon that ends him.

- 19 ll. 322-330 The gap in the armor: Hector dies through Achilles' own stolen gear — "the beautiful armor he stripped from the might of Patroclus" — pierced at the one place it leaves open, the collarbones' notch, "the gullet — where the destruction of a life is quickest." The borrowed-armor chain (16.793-804; Zeus's comment at 17.198-208) closes with precise irony: Patroclus's disguise becomes Hector's coffin, and its known gap the door. The spear spares the windpipe "so that he could still speak" — the poem granting itself the dying dialogue it needs, and saying so.
- 20 ll. 331-354 Triumph and plea. Achilles' first speech is the ledger (you thought you were safe; "I... have unstrung your knees"), with the sentence-pair the whole corpse-war rests on: "You the dogs and the birds will drag and defile. Him the Achaeans will bury." Hector, "his strength nearly gone," begs by life, knees, parents — the full suppliant formula — for burial at any price; and the answer passes beyond the human: "I only wish the fury and the heart in me would drive me to hack away your flesh and eat it raw myself." Not even Zeus's scale of ransom — Hector's weight in gold — would move him. The wish to eat the enemy is the *aristeia*'s terminal reading: Achilles has argued himself, by grief, to the edge of what the poem's world can call a man. Book 24 exists because the poem cannot leave him there.
- 21 ll. 355-366 The dying prophecy and the double death. "I know you now... the heart in your chest is iron" — then the curse-warning: "that I not become the gods' wrath (μήνιμα) upon you — on that day when Paris and Phoebus Apollo destroy you, brave as you are, at the Scaean Gates" — naming the god, the man, and the place (Xanthus's "a god and a man," 19.416-417, now specified; the gates are the very ones behind him). Then 361-363 repeat 16.855-857 verbatim, as the Greek repeats them — the soul-flight couplet, "wailing its fate, leaving its manhood and its youth": Patroclus and Hector go down through the same three lines, killer echoing killed. And Achilles answers the corpse with 18.115-116, kept verbatim: "Die. My own death-spirit I will accept whenever Zeus wills to accomplish it" — the acceptance he spoke to his mother, restated over the man whose death guarantees his own.
- 22 ll. 367-375 The stabbing-circle: the Achaeans running up to admire "the stature and the marvelous beauty of Hector — and not one man stood by him without a stab." The anonymous soldier's joke — "softer to the touch, this Hector, than when he burned the ships" (line 375 was athetized in antiquity) — is the war's ugliest line, and true to armies: the terror of months paid out on a body that can no longer object.
- 23 ll. 376-394 Achilles' speech breaks in half exactly where his mind does: strategy (probe the city — will it fall now?) collapsing mid-sentence into the register's self-interruption ("But why does my own heart argue these things with me?" = 122 = 21.562 — the third use binds victor to victim: Hector's phrase, in Achilles' mouth, within four hundred lines). What replaces strategy is Patroclus — "unwept, unburied... And if in the house of Hades men forget their dead, even there I will remember my dear companion" — memory outlasting death itself. Then the paean-couplet ("we have killed brilliant Hector — the man the Trojans prayed to... as to a god"), athetized by Aristarchus, kept here: the poem needs the army's song to set against what the next line does.

- 24 ll. 395–404 The outrage, in procedural detail: tendons pierced heel to ankle, oxhide straps, the head left to drag; the dust; "his dark hair spread wide around him; and in the dust lay all that head that was so beautiful before." The narrator's judgment is one clause wide and bottomless: "Zeus gave him to his enemies, to be defiled in his own fatherland" (ἔῃ ἐν πατρίδι γαίῃ) — the last three words doing what no exclamation could. αἰκία ἔργα, "foul work": the poem names the deed and does not look away; its whole final book will be the undoing of these ten lines.
- 25 ll. 405–429 Troy's grief begins with a simile of the end: the city's wailing "most like this — as if the whole of beetling Ilion, top to bottom, were smouldering in fire." Troy burns in the poem only here — in a comparison: with Hector dead, the fall is now a fact of grammar, needing no narration. Priam in the dung, begging to go out to the ships, announces Book 24 entire: "I will beg this man... He too has a father — such a one as I am: Peleus." The wish — "I wish he had died in my arms! Then the two of us could have glutted ourselves with weeping" — makes grief itself the feast (κορεσάμεθα: the verb of eating one's fill): the only satiety left to the old.
- 26 ll. 430–436 Hecuba's lament is civic: Hector as "boast" and "blessing," greeted "like a god" — the exact echo of the army's paean-line at 394, spoken now from the other wall: what the Achaeans sang as trophy, the mother sings as loss. Between the two uses, the poem holds its balance.
- 27 ll. 437–446 The most devastating dramatic irony in epic: Andromache "had not yet heard anything," weaving flowers into a purple cloak — making beauty — and ordering the cauldron heated "for Hector, for his return out of the fighting. Poor innocent (νηπίη): she did not know that far from all baths grey-eyed Athena had broken him under the hands of Achilles." The bath for the living that becomes the bath for the dead (the washing of corpses) hovers unspoken; the narrator's νηπίη — the word for doomed unknowing children and soldiers all poem long — is spent here on its most undeserving bearer.
- 28 ll. 447–474 The recognition sequence, staged in the body before the mind: the shuttle drops; the heart "to my mouth"; knees frozen; her exact guess about his "grievous pride... he would never stay back in the crowd of men" (she knew him better than his own soliloquy did); the run "like a madwoman"; the sight from the wall — the horses dragging him "uncaring" (ἀκηδέστως — the word for funeral-neglect); night on her eyes. Then the fall's one gesture: the head-dress flung off — frontlet, cap, woven band, "and the veil that golden Aphrodite gave her on the day Hector of the flashing helmet led her out of Eëtion's house." Widowhood performed as un-wedding: the marriage undone garment by garment in the sight of the city, at the news, before a word of lament is possible.
- 29 ll. 475–486 The lament's opening: "To one fate, then, we were born, the two of us" — Troy and Thebe, Priam's house and Eëtion's, joined in a single doom (her whole Book 6 biography compressed: the father who reared her "when I was little," dead at Achilles' hands with all her brothers — this is the second household Achilles has emptied for her). Its center is the child: "No help will you be to him, Hector — you are dead — nor he to you": mutual uselessness as the measure of death, between father and infant son.

- 30 *ll. 487-507* The orphan-passage, athetized by Aristarchus (487-499) as beneath the moment — kept here, because its smallness is the point. Andromache's grief goes microscopically social: the seized fields; the bowed head and wet cheeks; the boy tugging at cloaks for charity; the friend's cup lent "a moment: he wets his lips; his palate he does not wet" — the most exactly observed line about charity in ancient poetry; the beating at the feast ("No father of yours dines with us"). Against it, the pampered past — the marrow, the sheep's fat, the nurse's arms — and the name that has become a taunt: Astyanax, "lord of the city... for you alone guarded their gates and their long walls." She is wrong about his future — the tradition kills him at the sack, thrown from these walls — and the poem lets her terrible modest fears stand as the mercy of not knowing worse.
- 31 *ll. 508-515* The close: worms and dogs at the naked body "far away from your parents" — while at home the clothes lie "fine-woven and lovely, made by the hands of women." Her one remaining act is the fire: to burn the unused garments — "no use to you: you will not lie in it — let it be your glory (κλέος) in the eyes of the men and women of Troy." Kleos, the poem's grand word — what Achilles traded his life for, what Hector died reorganizing himself around — is here a widow burning shirts: glory reduced to, and rescued as, a household rite performed in the absence of a body. "So she spoke, weeping; and the women wailed in answer" — the same close as Briseis's lament (19.301-302, wording kept): the poem ends its greatest book on the sound it trusts most, the antiphony of grieving women — which is also how, two books from now, the whole Iliad will end.

Iliad — Book 23

The ghost of Patroclus asks for burial; his funeral; the games held in his honor, from the chariot race to the spear-throw.

- So they mourned through the city. And the Achaeans,¹
 when they had come to the ships and the Hellespont,
 scattered, each man to his own ship —
 but Achilles would not let the Myrmidons scatter:
- 5 he spoke out among his war-loving companions:
 "Myrmidons of the fast horses, my trusted companions,
 let us not yet loose the single-hoofed horses from the cars:
 with the very horses and chariots let us drive close
 and mourn Patroclus: for that is the honor-right of the dead.
- 10 Then, when we have taken our fill of the deadly lament,
 we will unyoke the horses, and all take supper here."
 So he spoke; and they wailed as one body, and Achilles led.
 Three times around the corpse they drove their well-maned horses,
 mourning; and among them Thetis stirred the desire of lament.
- 15 The sands were wet, and the armor of the men was wet
 with tears: such a machine of rout they missed.
 And the son of Peleus led the thick lament among them,²
 laying his man-slaughtering hands on his companion's chest:
 "Rejoice, O Patroclus, even in the house of Hades:
- 20 for now I am accomplishing all I promised you before —
 to drag Hector here and give him raw to the dogs,
 and before your pyre to cut the throats of twelve
 shining children of the Trojans, in my rage at your slaying."
 He spoke, and devised foul work against brilliant Hector,
- 25 stretching him face-down in the dust beside the bier of Menoetius's
 son.
 And the men put off their armor, each his gear of glittering bronze,
 and loosed their high-necked horses, and sat down beside the ship
 of the swift-footed son of Aeacus, in their thousands;
 and he set the funeral feast before them, to their hearts' fill.
- 30 Many shining oxen bellowed around the iron³

- as their throats were cut, and many sheep and bleating goats;
 and many white-tusked swine, blooming with fat,
 were stretched to singe across the flame of Hephaestus;
 and everywhere around the corpse the blood ran in cupfuls.
- 35 But the lord, the swift-footed son of Peleus —
 the kings of the Achaeans led him to brilliant Agamemnon,
 persuading him with effort, his heart still angry for his companion.
 And when they came in their going to Agamemnon's hut,
 at once they ordered the clear-voiced heralds
- 40 to set a great tripod over the fire, in hope of persuading
 the son of Peleus to wash off the clotted gore.
 But he refused them flatly, and swore an oath on it:
 "No — by Zeus, who is highest of the gods and best,
 it is not right that water come near this head
- 45 before I lay Patroclus on the fire, and heap his mound,
 and cut my hair for him: since never a second time
 will such grief reach my heart, while I am among the living.
 For now — yes, let us yield to the hateful feast;
 and at dawn, lord of men Agamemnon, drive the men
- 50 to bring in wood, and furnish all that is fitting
 for a dead man to have, going under the murky dark,
 so that untiring fire may burn him the sooner
 out of our eyes, and the army turn back to its work."
 So he spoke; and they listened to him well, and obeyed.
- 55 Quickly, each company, they made the supper ready
 and feasted; and no man's appetite went short of the equal feast.
 And when they had put away the desire for drink and food,
 the rest went off to their rest, each man to his hut;
 but the son of Peleus, on the shore of the loud-roaring sea,
- 60 lay groaning heavily, among his many Myrmidons,
 in a clear space, where the waves washed up along the beach —
 until sleep took hold of him, loosening the cares of his heart,
 poured sweet around him: for his shining limbs were spent
 with chasing Hector toward windy Ilion.
- 65 And there came to him the soul of unhappy Patroclus,⁴
 in everything like the man himself — in stature, and the beautiful
 eyes, and the voice; and the same clothes were on his body.

- He stood above his head, and spoke a word to him:
 "You sleep — and you have forgotten me, Achilles.
 70 You were never careless of me living — only dead.
 Bury me with all speed, and let me pass the gates of Hades.
 The souls keep me at a distance — the images of the worn-out —
 and they will not yet let me join them across the river:
 I wander, just as I am, through the wide-gated house of Hades.
 75 And give me your hand: I am weeping. Never again
 shall I come back out of Hades, once you have given me my fire.
 Never again in life shall we two sit apart
 from our dear companions, making our plans. The hateful
 death-spirit has gaped around me — the one allotted at my very birth.
 80 And for you too the portion stands, Achilles like the gods:
 to die beneath the wall of the rich Trojans.
 And one thing more I will say, and charge you, if you will listen:
 do not lay my bones apart from yours, Achilles,
 but together — as we were raised together in your house,
 85 when Menoetius brought me, still a small boy,
 out of Opoeis to your country, for a grim killing:
 the day I killed the son of Amphi-damas —
 a child's act; I did not mean it; I was angry over the dice.
 The horseman Peleus took me into his house then,
 90 and raised me with kindness, and named me your companion.
 So let one vessel enfold the bones of us both —
 the golden two-handled jar your lady mother gave you."
 Then in answer swift-footed Achilles spoke to him:⁵
 "Why have you come to me here, beloved head,
 95 and why do you charge me with all these things? For me,
 I will accomplish everything, and bow to what you ask.
 But stand nearer to me: even for a little, let us
 put our arms around each other and take our fill of deadly lament."
 So speaking, he reached out with his own hands —
 100 and grasped nothing: the soul, like smoke, was gone
 under the earth, squeaking. And Achilles started up, astonished,
 and drove his hands together, and spoke the word of mourning:
 "Ah then — so there is, even in the house of Hades,
 a soul and an image — but the wits are not in it at all!

- 105 All night long the soul of unhappy Patroclus
 stood over me, weeping and wailing,
 and charged me point by point — and it was marvelously like him."
 So he spoke; and in them all he stirred the desire of lament;
 and rosy-fingered Dawn shone out upon them still
 110 mourning around the pitiful corpse. And lord Agamemnon
 drove out the mules and men from every hut
 to bring in wood; and a good man oversaw them —
 Meriones, the aide of kind-hearted Idomeneus.
 They went out with woodcutters' axes in their hands
 115 and well-braided ropes; and the mules went on before them;
 and long they climbed — uphill, downhill, sidehill, slantwise.
 But when they came to the spurs of many-springed Ida,
 at once they set to felling the high-crowned oaks
 with the long-edged bronze, in haste; and with a great crashing
 120 the trees came down. Then the Achaeans split them
 and lashed them behind the mules; and these tore up the ground with
 their feet,
 straining for the plain through the dense thickets.
 And all the woodcutters carried logs: for so commanded
 Meriones, the aide of kind-hearted Idomeneus.
 125 They laid them down along the shore in rows, at the place
 where Achilles planned the great mound for Patroclus — and for
 himself.⁶
 And when they had laid down measureless wood on every side,
 they sat where they were, all together, and waited. And Achilles
 at once commanded the war-loving Myrmidons
 130 to belt on their bronze, and each man yoke his horses;
 and they rose and got into their armor,
 and mounted their chariots, fighters and drivers both,
 the horsemen in front, and behind them followed a cloud of foot-
 soldiers,
 thousands; and in their midst his companions carried Patroclus,
 135 and they heaped the whole corpse with the locks of hair they cut
 and cast on him. And behind, brilliant Achilles held the head,
 grieving: a blameless companion he was sending down to Hades.
 And when they came to the place Achilles had appointed,

- they set him down, and quickly piled the wood to his heart's fill.
- 140 Then swift-footed brilliant Achilles thought of one thing more:⁷
 standing apart from the pyre, he cut the tawny lock
 he had been growing long for the river Spercheius,
 and troubled, he spoke, looking out on the wine-dark sea:
 "Spercheius — for nothing did my father Peleus vow to you
 145 that when I came home there, to my dear fatherland,
 I would cut my hair for you, and offer a holy hecatomb,
 and sacrifice fifty rams into your very sources,
 where your sacred plot and your smoking altar stand.
 So the old man vowed; and you did not accomplish his intent.
 150 Now — since I am not going home to my dear fatherland —
 let me give my hair to the hero Patroclus, to carry with him."
 So speaking, he laid the hair in the hands of his dear
 companion; and in them all he stirred the desire of lament.
 And the light of the sun would have gone down on their mourning
 155 had not Achilles quickly stepped to Agamemnon's side:
 "Son of Atreus — you are the man whose word the army
 most obeys. Of lament there can be fill enough.
 Disperse them now from the pyre; tell them to make
 their meal. We to whom the dead is nearest care
 160 will labor at the rest; and let the leaders stay beside us."
 Now when the lord of men Agamemnon heard him,⁸
 at once he dispersed the army among the balanced ships;
 and the mourners of the closest care stayed there and heaped the
 wood,
 and made a pyre a hundred feet this way and that,
 165 and on the pyre's height they laid the corpse, grieving at heart.
 Many fat sheep and shambling twist-horned cattle
 they flayed and dressed before the pyre; and from them all
 great-hearted Achilles took the fat, and wrapped the corpse
 from head to foot, and heaped the flayed carcasses around him.
 170 And he set two-handled jars of honey and of oil
 leaning against the bier; and four strong-necked horses
 he flung on the pyre with violence, groaning aloud.
 Nine dogs the lord had, fed from his table;
 and of these he cut the throats of two, and flung them on;

- 175 and twelve noble sons of the great-hearted Trojans
he butchered with the bronze — and evil was the work his heart
intended —
and into it all he threw the iron strength of fire, to feed.
Then he wailed aloud, and called his dear companion by name:
"Rejoice, O Patroclus, even in the house of Hades:
180 for now I am accomplishing all I promised you before.
Twelve noble sons of the great-hearted Trojans —
the fire is eating all of them with you. But Hector,
Priam's son, I will not give to the fire to feed on — but to the dogs."
So he spoke, threatening. But the dogs did not deal with Hector:
185 the daughter of Zeus, Aphrodite, kept the dogs from him
by day and by night, and anointed him with oil of roses,
ambrosial, so the dragging would not tear him;
and Phoebus Apollo drew a dark-blue cloud
down from heaven to the plain, and covered all the ground
190 the corpse lay over, so the sun's strength would not
wither the flesh too soon on his sinews and limbs.
But the pyre of dead Patroclus would not kindle.⁹
Then swift-footed brilliant Achilles thought of one thing more:
standing apart from the pyre, he prayed to the two winds,
195 Boreas and Zephyrus, and promised them fine offerings;
and pouring many libations from a golden cup he begged them
to come, so the dead would blaze up in the fire
with all speed, and the wood take flame. And quickly Iris,
hearing his prayers, went messenger to the winds.
200 They were all indoors at the house of gusting Zephyrus,
feasting at a banquet, when Iris came running
and stood on the stone threshold. And the moment their eyes saw her
they all sprang up, and each one called her to himself.
But she refused to sit, and said her word:
205 "No seat for me: I am away over the streams of Ocean
to the Aethiopians' land, where they are offering hecatombs
to the immortals — so I too may share the feast.
But Achilles is praying to Boreas and loud Zephyrus
to come, and he promises you fine offerings,
210 so you may rouse the pyre to burning, where lies

Patroclus, whom all the Achaeans mourn aloud."
 So speaking she went her way; and they rose up
 with an unearthly roar, driving the clouds in rout before them.
 Quickly they came to the sea, to blow across it, and the wave
 215 swelled under their shrill blast; and they reached deep-soiled Troy
 and fell upon the pyre; and the unearthly fire howled huge.
 All night long together they beat the flame of the pyre,
 blowing shrill; and all night long swift Achilles,
 taking a two-handled cup from a golden bowl,
 220 drew wine and poured it on the ground, and soaked the earth,
 calling upon the soul of unhappy Patroclus.
 As a father mourns, burning the bones of his son,
 a bridegroom, whose death has grieved his unhappy parents:
 so Achilles mourned, burning the bones of his companion,
 225 dragging himself around the pyre, groaning without pause.
 At the hour the morning star goes forth to herald light over the earth,
 and behind it Dawn in her saffron robe spreads out across the sea,
 at that hour the pyre died down, and the flame was done.
 And the winds set out again, to go back home
 230 across the Thracian sea; and it groaned, seething with swell.
 And the son of Peleus turned a little from the burning-place
 and lay down, worn out; and sweet sleep leapt upon him.
 But the others gathered in a body around the son of Atreus,
 and the noise and tramp of their coming woke him;
 235 and he sat upright, and spoke his word to them:
 "Son of Atreus, and you other chiefs of all the Achaeans:¹⁰
 first quench the burning-place with glistening wine,
 all of it, wherever the fire's strength has reached. Then
 let us gather the bones of Patroclus, Menoetius's son,
 240 telling them apart well — and they are easily known:
 he lay in the middle of the pyre; the others burned apart,
 at the edge, horses and men together.
 And let us lay his bones in a golden vessel, in a double
 fold of fat, until I myself am hidden in Hades.
 245 And no huge mound do I ask you to labor over —
 a seemly one, no more. Then afterward the Achaeans
 may build it wide and high — you who are left

- behind me in the many-benched ships."
 So he spoke; and they obeyed the swift-footed son of Peleus.
- 250 First they quenched the burning-place with glistening wine,
 far as the flame had gone, and the ash had settled deep;
 and weeping, they gathered the white bones of their kindly companion
 into a golden vessel, in a double fold of fat,
 and laid it in the hut, and covered it with soft linen;
- 255 and they drew the circle of the mound, and set its footing-stones
 around the pyre, and heaped the piled earth over it;
 and when they had heaped the mound, they turned to go. But Achilles
 held the army there, and sat them in a wide assembly,
 and out of the ships he brought his prizes: cauldrons and tripods,
 260 and horses and mules and strong heads of oxen,
 and deep-girdled women, and grey iron.
- For the swift charioteers first he set out shining prizes:¹¹
 a woman skilled in blameless work, to lead away,
 and an eared tripod holding twenty-two measures —
- 265 these for the first man; and for the second he set a mare,
 six years old, unbroken, carrying a mule foal;
 and for the third he set down a cauldron untouched by fire,
 a beautiful one, holding four measures, white as new;
 and for the fourth he set out two talents of gold;
- 270 and for the fifth, a two-handled bowl untouched by flame.
 Then he stood upright, and spoke his word among the Argives:
 "Son of Atreus, and you other strong-greaved Achaeans:¹²
 these prizes lie in the gathering, waiting for the charioteers.
 If we Achaeans were competing now for any other man,
- 275 I would take the first prize myself, and carry it to my hut:
 you know how far my horses surpass all others in their worth —
 for they are immortal: Poseidon gave them
 to my father Peleus, and he passed them into my hands.
 But I will stay aside, I and my single-hoofed horses:
- 280 such is the driver whose glory they have lost —
 the gentle one, who so many times poured smooth oil
 down their manes, when he had washed them in shining water.
 They stand and mourn him now; their manes trail
 on the ground; they stand with grief in their hearts.

- 285 But the rest of you make ready through the army — whoever
of the Achaeans trusts his horses and his bolted car."
So spoke the son of Peleus, and the swift charioteers gathered.¹³
Up first, far first, rose Eumelus, lord of men,
Admetus's dear son, supreme in horsemanship;
- 290 and after him rose Tydeus's son, strong Diomedes,
and led under the yoke the horses of Tros, which he once
stripped from Aeneas — though Apollo saved the man himself;
and after him rose Atreus's son, fair-haired Menelaus,
the Zeus-born, and led beneath the yoke two swift horses —
- 295 Aethe, Agamemnon's mare, and his own Podargus.
Her Echepolus, Anchises' son, gave to Agamemnon
as a gift, so he need not follow him to windy Ilion
but stay at home and take his ease: for Zeus had given him
great wealth, and he lived in Sicyon of the wide dancing-floors.
- 300 Her Menelaus led beneath the yoke, athirst for the running.
And fourth, Antilochus made ready his well-maned horses —
the shining son of Nestor, the great-hearted lord,
Neleus's son; and horses bred in Pylos
drew his car, quick-footed. And his father, standing by him,
- 305 spoke good counsel to a son who knew it for himself:
"Antilochus — young as you are, Zeus and Poseidon
have loved you, and taught you horsemanship
of every kind. So there is no great need to teach you:
you know well how to wheel the turning-post. But your horses
- 310 are the slowest in the running; so I expect a sorry business.
Their horses are faster — but the men themselves
do not know more of cunning than you do.
Come then, dear boy: lay up cunning in your heart,
cunning of every kind, so the prizes do not slip past you.
- 315 By cunning, far more than by force, is the woodcutter better;
by cunning the helmsman on the wine-dark sea
holds his swift ship on course when the winds are tearing at it;
by cunning charioteer outdoes charioteer.
One man, trusting in his horses and his car,
- 320 swings wide, mindlessly, this way and that,
and his horses wander down the course, and he cannot hold them.

But the man who knows his advantages, driving lesser horses,
 keeps his eye on the post and turns it close, and never forgets
 how much rein of oxhide to give at the start —
 325 he holds his line securely, and watches the man in front.
 And the mark itself I will tell you — plain to see; you cannot miss it.
 A dry stump stands there, a fathom high above the ground,
 of oak or of pine, not rotted by the rain,
 and two white stones are set against it, one on either side,
 330 at the joining of the track; and around it the racing-ground is smooth.
 Either it is the grave-mark of a man dead long ago,
 or it was set for a turning-post by men before our time;
 and now swift-footed brilliant Achilles has made it the goal.
 Drive your car and horses grazing hard against it,
 335 and lean your own body, in the well-plaited chariot,
 a little to their left; and the right-hand horse —
 goad him and call to him, and give him rein from your hands.
 And let your left-hand horse graze the post so close
 that the hub of the well-wrought wheel seems to touch
 340 its very edge — but take care not to catch the stone,
 or you will wound the horses and wreck the car:
 joy for the others, and reproach for you.
 Dear boy — keep your wits about you; be watchful.
 For if at the turn you slip past them in your pursuit,
 345 there is no man who will catch you with a lunge, or pass you —
 not though he drove brilliant Arion behind you,
 Adrastus's swift horse, whose line was from the gods,
 or the horses of Laomedon, best of the breed reared here."
 So speaking, Nestor Neleus's son sat back down in his place,
 350 when he had told his son the essentials of each thing.
 And Meriones was the fifth to make ready his well-maned horses.¹⁴
 They mounted their chariots, and cast in their lots;
 and Achilles shook them, and out sprang the lot of Nestor's son,
 Antilochus; and after him lord Eumelus drew;
 355 and after him Atreus's son, spear-famed Menelaus;
 and after him Meriones drew his place to drive; and last of all
 the son of Tydeus, far the best of them, drew his place to drive.
 They stood in line; and Achilles showed them the turn-post,

far off on the level plain; and beside it he set an umpire,
 360 godlike Phoenix, his own father's follower,
 to keep the running in memory, and report the truth.
 Then all of them together raised the lash over their horses,
 and struck with the reins, and shouted them on with words,
 furiously; and they swept fast across the plain,
 365 away from the ships; and under their chests the dust
 hung, rising like a cloud or a stormwind,
 and their manes streamed back on the rush of the wind.
 And the chariots now hugged the earth that feeds many,
 now leapt bounding high in the air; and the drivers
 370 stood in the cars, and each man's heart was pounding
 in his hunger for victory; and each one called to his horses,
 and they flew through the dust of the plain.
 But when the swift horses were running the last of the course¹⁵
 back toward the grey sea, then each man's worth
 375 showed itself, and the pace stretched them flat out; and quickly
 the swift-footed mares of Pheres' grandson shot ahead,
 and behind them the stallions of Diomedes, the horses of Tros,
 ran close — not far at all, but hard upon him:
 they seemed forever on the point of mounting his chariot,
 380 and their breath was hot on the back and broad shoulders
 of Eumelus: their heads were laid right on him as they flew.
 And now he would have passed him, or made it a dead heat,
 had not Phoebus Apollo been angry with Tydeus's son
 and dashed the shining whip out of his hands.
 385 Then the tears of rage sprang from his eyes: he saw
 the mares going better still — better and better —
 while his own pair faltered, running without the goad.
 But Apollo's cheating of the son of Tydeus did not
 slip past Athena: she swept after the shepherd of the people,
 390 gave him back his whip, and put fury in his horses;
 and after Admetus's son she went in her anger
 and shattered — a goddess — his horses' yoke; and his mares
 ran out to either side of the road, and the pole slewed to the ground,
 and he himself was tumbled out of the car beside the wheel,
 395 and the skin was ripped from his elbows, his mouth, his nostrils,

- and his forehead bruised above the brows; and his eyes
filled up with tears, and the strong voice stuck in his throat.
And the son of Tydeus swung his single-hoofed horses past him,
leaping far out in front of the rest: for Athena
400 had put fury in his horses, and set the glory on him.
And after him came Atreus's son, fair-haired Menelaus.
But Antilochus called to his father's horses:¹⁶
"Get in there, you two as well! Stretch out — as fast as you can!
I am not telling you to race with those in front —
405 the horses of war-minded Tydeus's son, to whom Athena
has just now given speed, and set the glory on their driver.
But catch the horses of Atreus's son — don't be left behind them! —
quickly — or Aethe will pour shame over the two of you:
a female! Why are you falling behind, my braves?
410 For I will tell you this, and it will be accomplished:
there will be no more care for you two at the hands of Nestor,
shepherd of the people — he will cut your throats on the spot
with the sharp bronze, if by your slacking we carry off the lesser prize.
After them! Press hard — fast as you can!
415 And I myself will devise it and manage it —
a way to slip past in the narrow of the road. It will not escape me."
So he spoke; and in dread at their master's rebuke
they ran the harder for a little while; and quickly then
Antilochus, staunch in battle, saw the narrows of the sunken road.
420 There was a break in the ground, where winter-gathered water
had torn away the track and hollowed the whole place deep;
there Menelaus held his line, shy of fouling wheels;
but Antilochus swerved his single-hoofed horses and drove
outside the track, and pressed him hard, bearing in a little.
425 And the son of Atreus was afraid, and shouted to Antilochus:
"Antilochus — this is mad driving! Hold in your horses!
The road is narrow here — it widens soon for passing —
you'll wreck the both of us, fouling my car!"
So he spoke; but Antilochus drove all the harder,
430 laying on the goad, like a man who had not heard.
As far as the swing of a discus flung from the shoulder,
hurled by a young man testing the strength of his youth,

- so far they ran on together; and then the mares of Atreus's son
dropped back: he slackened his driving by his own will,
435 for fear the single-hoofed horses would collide in the road
and overturn the well-plaited cars, and the men themselves
go down in the dust for all their straining after victory.
And fair-haired Menelaus called after him in rebuke:
"Antilochus — no mortal man alive is more ruinous than you!
440 Go, and be damned — we Achaeans were wrong to call you sane.
But even so, you shall not carry off the prize without an oath."
So he spoke, and called out to his horses:
"Don't hang back on me now, don't stand there grieving!
Their feet and knees will tire before yours do:
445 the pair of them are past their youth."
So he spoke; and in dread at their master's rebuke
they ran the harder, and quickly closed the gap.
Meanwhile the Argives, sitting in the assembly, watched¹⁷
for the horses; and these came flying through the dust of the plain.
450 And the first to make them out was Idomeneus, leader of the Cretans:
for he sat outside the gathering, highest up, on a lookout;
and hearing the voice of a driver shouting, far off as he was,
he knew it; and he made out a horse, clear in the lead,
chestnut over all the rest of him, except that on his forehead
455 a white blaze was set, round as the full moon.
And he stood upright, and spoke his word among the Argives:
"Friends — leaders and counselors of the Argives —
am I the only one who sees the horses, or do you see them too?
Other horses seem to me to be in front now —
460 another driver shows. The mares must have come to grief
out on the plain — the ones that led on the way out:
I saw them rounding the turn-post first,
and now I cannot see them anywhere, though my eyes
go searching everywhere across the Trojan plain.
465 Did the reins escape their driver, so he could not
hold them well around the post, and failed to make the turn?
He was thrown out there, I think, and the chariot wrecked,
and the mares bolted off the course, their hearts gone wild.
But stand up and look for yourselves: I cannot

- 470 make it out for certain. The man in front seems to me
to be Aetolian by birth — and a lord among the Argives —
the son of horse-taming Tydeus, strong Diomedes."
Then swift Ajax, Oileus's son, rounded on him shamefully:
"Idomeneus — why this blather before the time? The mares
475 are far away still, sweeping the wide plain.
You are not so much the youngest among the Argives,
and the eyes in your head are not the sharpest lookers —
yet you are always blathering. There is no need for you
to blather here: better men than you are present.
480 The mares in front are the same that led before —
Eumelus's; and it is he who stands there holding the reins."
And the leader of the Cretans answered him in anger:
"Ajax — champion of insult, wit of straw — in all things else
you are least of the Argives: your mind is a stubborn mind.
485 Come then: let us wager a tripod or a cauldron,
and let us both make Agamemnon, Atreus's son, our judge —
whose mares are in front. You will learn as you pay."
So he spoke; and at once swift Ajax, Oileus's son,
rose up in anger to answer with hard words —
490 and the quarrel between the two would have gone further,
had not Achilles himself stood up, and said his word:
"No longer answer each other with hard words,
Ajax — Idomeneus — with evil words: it is not seemly.
You would be indignant at another man who acted so.
495 Sit down in the gathering, and watch
for the horses: they are straining for victory, and they
will be here soon enough. Then each of you can know
the Argive horses — who is behind, and who in front."
So he spoke — and the son of Tydeus came driving in nearly upon
them,¹⁸
500 laying on the whip down from the shoulder, stroke on stroke; and his
horses
lifted high, going fast, devouring the way.
And the spatters of dust rained without pause on the driver,
and the chariot, plated with gold and tin,
ran hard on the heels of the quick-footed horses — and behind them

- 505 the tires left hardly a trace of wheel-track
in the fine dust: the pair of them flew, straining.
He pulled up in the middle of the gathering, the sweat
streaming to the ground from his horses' necks and chests;
and he himself leapt to the ground from his shining car
510 and leaned the whip against the yoke. Nor did strong Sthenelus
delay: he seized the prize at once, eagerly,
and gave the woman to his high-hearted companions to lead,
and the eared tripod to carry; and he loosed the horses from the yoke.
Next after him Antilochus of Neleus's line drove in his horses —¹⁹
515 by craft, not speed at all, he had slipped past Menelaus;
yet even so Menelaus held his swift horses close behind.
As far as a horse stands from the wheel, when he strains
drawing his master over the plain with the chariot,
and the tips of his tail-hairs brush against the tire,
520 for he runs close in front, and there is little space between
as he sweeps the wide plain:
so far was Menelaus behind blameless Antilochus —
though at first he was left a discus-throw behind,
he was catching him fast: the fine fury of Aethe,
525 Agamemnon's lovely-maned mare, was rising still;
and had the course run longer for the two of them,
he would have passed him clean, beyond dispute.
And Meriones, the good aide of Idomeneus,
came in a spear-cast behind famed Menelaus:
530 for his lovely-maned horses were the slowest of them all,
and he himself the least of them at driving in a race.
And Admetus's son came last of all the others,
dragging his beautiful chariot, driving his horses before him.
And swift-footed brilliant Achilles saw him, and pitied him,²⁰
535 and stood among the Argives and spoke winged words:
"Last comes the best man, driving his single-hoofed horses.
Come, let us give him a prize, as is fitting —
the second; and let the son of Tydeus carry off the first."
So he spoke; and they all approved what he commanded.
540 And now he would have given him the mare — for the Achaeans
approved —

- had not Antilochus, great-hearted Nestor's son,
 stood up and answered Achilles, Peleus's son, with a claim of right:
 "Achilles, I will be very angry with you if you accomplish
 this word: for you mean to take away my prize,
 545 weighing this — that his chariot came to grief, and his swift horses,
 and he himself a good man. But he should have prayed
 to the immortals: then he would not have come in last of all.
 If you pity him, and he is dear to your heart,
 there is gold in plenty in your hut, and there is bronze,
 550 and sheep and goats, and there are slave-women and single-hoofed
 horses:
 take from those, and give him afterward an even greater prize —
 or right now, this moment — and the Achaeans will applaud you.
 But the mare I will not give up. For her, let any man
 who wants her try me — hand to hand."
 555 So he spoke; and swift-footed brilliant Achilles smiled,
 delighting in Antilochus, because he was his dear companion;
 and in answer he spoke winged words to him:
 "Antilochus — if you would have me give Eumelus
 some other thing from my stores, that too I will do.
 560 I will give him the corslet I stripped from Asteropaeus —
 bronze, with a casting of shining tin
 run round it. It will be worth much to him."
 He spoke, and told Automedon, his dear companion,
 to bring it from the hut; and he went and brought it,
 565 and laid it in Eumelus's hands; and he received it, rejoicing.
 Then Menelaus also rose among them, grieved at heart,²¹
 angry past soothing at Antilochus. And the herald
 put the staff into his hand, and called the Argives
 to silence; and then that man like a god spoke out:
 570 "Antilochus — you who had good sense before — what have you done?
 You have shamed my skill and fouled my horses,
 throwing your own in front, which were far the worse.
 Come then, leaders and counselors of the Argives:
 judge between the two of us — and no favor either way —
 575 so no man of the bronze-shirted Achaeans ever says:
 'Menelaus beat Antilochus down with lies

and went off leading the mare — his horses were far the worse,
 but he himself the greater in rank and power.'
 Or come — I will judge it myself; and I say no other
 580 Danaan will fault the judgment: it will be straight.
 Antilochus — come here, Zeus-nurtured, as the custom stands:
 stand in front of your horses and your chariot, take in your hand
 the slender whip you drove with,
 lay your hand on your horses, and swear by the earth-upholder,
 585 the earth-shaker, that you did not foul my car by deliberate craft."
 Then in his turn sound-minded Antilochus answered him:
 "Bear with me now: I am far younger
 than you, lord Menelaus — you are the elder, and the better man.
 You know how a young man's trespasses come about:
 590 his mind is the quicker, but his judgment thin.
 So let your heart endure it. The mare I won —
 I give her to you myself. And if you asked of me some greater thing
 from my own stores besides, I would choose to give it to you
 at once, this moment, Zeus-nurtured — rather than fall
 595 out of your favor all my days, and be wrong before the gods."
 So spoke great-hearted Nestor's son, and led the mare
 and put her into Menelaus's hands. And that man's heart
 was warmed like the dew about the ears of ripening corn,
 when the fields are bristling: so, Menelaus,
 600 was the heart in your chest warmed within you.
 And he spoke to him in answer winged words:
 "Antilochus — now I will yield to you myself, out of my anger:
 for you were never scattered or light of mind before.
 This once, youth got the better of your judgment;
 605 the next time, take care not to outscheme your betters.
 No other man of the Achaeans would have soothed me quickly —
 but you have suffered much, and labored much for my sake,
 you and your good father and your brother.
 So I will be persuaded by your plea; and the mare —
 610 mine though she is, I will give her to you — so these men too may know
 that my heart was never overbearing and unbending."
 He spoke, and gave the mare to Noëmon, Antilochus's
 companion, to lead away; and took for himself the shining cauldron.

And Meriones took up the two talents of gold,
 615 fourth, as he had driven. But the fifth prize was left over —
 the two-handled bowl. Achilles gave it to Nestor,
 carrying it to him across the gathering of the Argives, and said:
 "Here, old man. Let this be a treasure laid away for you,²²
 a memorial of the burial of Patroclus: for never again
 620 will you see him among the Argives. I give you this prize
 outright: for you will not box, and you will not wrestle,
 nor enter for the javelins, nor race
 on foot: the hard weight of age is on you now."
 So speaking, he laid it in his hands; and he received it, rejoicing,
 625 and speaking winged words he addressed him:
 "Yes, child — all this you have said aright.
 My limbs are no longer sound, dear friend — my feet — nor do my arms
 swing light from my shoulders on either side.
 Would that I were young, and my strength as firm
 630 as when the Epeians buried lord Amarynceus
 at Buprasium, and his sons set out the king's prizes.
 There no man proved my equal — not of the Epeians,
 not of the Pylians themselves, not of the great-hearted Aetolians.
 In boxing I beat Clytomedes, Enops's son;
 635 at wrestling, Ancaeus of Pleuron, who stood up against me;
 Iphiclus I outran on foot, good runner though he was;
 and with the spear I out-threw Phyleus and Polydorus.
 Only with the horses did the two sons of Actor pass me —
 crowding ahead by force of numbers, grudging me the victory,
 640 because the biggest prizes had been left for the horses.
 They were twins: one held the reins — held the reins
 for good and all — while the other laid on the whip.
 Such I was once. Now let younger men take on
 such labors: I must bow to grim old age —
 645 though in my day I shone among the heroes.
 But go: honor your companion too with funeral games.
 This gift I receive gladly, and my heart rejoices
 that you remember me always as your kindly friend, and never forget
 the honor with which it is fitting I be honored among the Achaeans.
 650 And may the gods, in return, grant you grace to your heart's fill."

So he spoke; and the son of Peleus went back through the great crowd of Achaeans, when he had heard out all the praise of Neleus's son.

Then he set out the prizes for the punishing fist-fight:²³
a hard-working mule he led out and tethered in the gathering,
655 six years old, unbroken — the hardest kind to break;
and for the beaten man he set a two-handled cup.

Then he stood upright, and spoke his word among the Argives:
"Son of Atreus, and you other strong-greaved Achaeans:
for these we summon two men — the best there are —

660 to put up their fists and trade blows. The man to whom Apollo
grants endurance, and all the Achaeans acknowledge it,
let him lead the hard-working mule away to his hut;
and the beaten man carries off the two-handled cup."

So he spoke; and at once a man rose up, huge and strong,
665 skilled in fist-fighting — Epeius, Panopeus's son;
and he laid a hand on the hard-working mule, and said:
"Step up, whoever wants to carry off the two-handled cup:
the mule — I say no other Achaean is taking her
by winning with his fists. I claim to be the best.

670 Is it not enough that I fall short in battle? There was never a way,
it seems, for one man to be skilled in every work there is.

For I tell you this, and it will be accomplished:
I will split his skin clean open and stave his bones in.
Let his next of kin stand waiting here in a body

675 to carry him out when my fists have finished him."

So he spoke; and they all fell silent, stilled.
Euryalus alone stood up to face him, a man like a god,
son of lord Mecisteus, Talaus's son,
who once came to Thebes for the burial of fallen

680 Oedipus, and there beat all the sons of Cadmus.
And Tydeus's spear-famed son busied himself about him,
cheering him with words, wanting the victory for him badly.
First he threw down the girdle for him, and then
he gave him the well-cut thongs of a field-ranging ox.

685 Girded, the two men strode into the middle of the gathering,
and squaring up, both at once, with their heavy hands,

they fell on each other, and their heavy fists mixed.
 Terrible was the grinding of jaws, and the sweat ran
 everywhere off their limbs. And brilliant Epeius rose to it:
 690 as the other glanced for an opening, he struck him on the cheek,
 and he could stand no longer: there his shining limbs went down.
 As under the North Wind's shiver a fish leaps up
 on the weed-strewn shallows, and the black wave hides it again:
 so he leapt at the blow. But great-hearted Epeius
 695 took him in his hands and set him upright; and his own companions
 crowded round and led him through the gathering, feet trailing,
 spitting thick blood, his head lolling to one side;
 and they sat him down among them, wits astray,
 and went themselves and fetched the two-handled cup.
 700 Then the son of Peleus set out at once, and showed the Danaans,²⁴
 a third set of prizes, for the punishing wrestling:
 for the winner a great tripod made to stand over fire —
 the Achaeans among themselves priced it at twelve oxen —
 and for the beaten man he put a woman in their midst,
 705 skilled in many kinds of work; they priced her at four oxen.
 And he stood upright, and spoke his word among the Argives:
 "Up — you two who will make trial of this prize."
 So he spoke; and then great Telamonian Ajax rose,
 and resourceful Odysseus stood up, the knower of advantages.
 710 Girded, the two men strode into the middle of the gathering
 and grappled each other arm on arm with their heavy hands,
 like the gable-rafters a famous builder joins
 in a high house, to baffle the strength of the winds.
 Their backs creaked under the stubborn hauling
 715 of bold hands; and the wet sweat ran down;
 and welts thick and many along their ribs and shoulders
 sprang up red with blood; and always they
 strained for victory, and the wrought tripod;
 and Odysseus could not trip him and bring him to the ground,
 720 nor could Ajax — the strong build of Odysseus held.
 But when they began to weary the strong-greaved Achaeans,
 then great Telamonian Ajax said to him:
 "Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of many devices:

- lift me — or I lift you. And the rest will be Zeus's business."
- 725 So speaking he heaved him up. But Odysseus did not forget his craft:
he caught him with a kick behind the knee, and unstrung his limbs,
and threw him backward, and fell on his chest
himself. The watching army marveled at it.
Second, much-enduring brilliant Odysseus heaved in his turn,
730 and budged him a little off the ground — but could not lift him —
and hooked his knee inside; and both went down together
close in each other's grip, and were fouled with dust.
And now they would have sprung up and wrestled a third fall,
had not Achilles himself risen, and held them back:
735 "Strain against each other no more. Do not wear yourselves out with
pain.
Victory to you both. Take equal prizes
and go — so the other Achaeans may compete."
So he spoke; and they listened to him well, and obeyed,
and wiped away the dust, and put their tunics on.
740 Then the son of Peleus set out at once the prizes for the foot-race:²⁵
a mixing-bowl of silver, a worked piece: six measures
it held, and in beauty it outdid all others on earth
by far, since craftsmen of Sidon, the cunning-handed, made it well,
and Phoenician men carried it over the misty sea,
745 set it up in harbor, and gave it as a gift to Thoas;
and Euneus, Jason's son, gave it as the price of Lycaon,
Priam's son, to the hero Patroclus.
This too Achilles set out as a prize for his companion —
for the man who should prove the lightest on his quick feet;
750 for the second again he set out an ox, big and heavy with fat;
and a half-talent of gold he set out for the last.
And he stood upright, and spoke his word among the Argives:
"Up — you who will make trial of this prize."
So he spoke; and at once swift Ajax rose, Oileus's son,
755 and resourceful Odysseus stood up, and then Nestor's son
Antilochus: for he beat all the young men at running.
They stood in line; and Achilles showed them the goal.
The course was stretched flat-out from the start; and quickly
the son of Oileus shot ahead; and brilliant Odysseus drove in

- 760 close behind — close as the weaving-rod to the breast
of a fair-girdled woman, when she pulls it deftly in her hands,
drawing the spool out along the warp, and holds the rod
near her breast: so close Odysseus ran, and behind him
he struck the man's footprints with his feet before the dust could
settle,
- 765 and brilliant Odysseus poured his breath down on his head,
running lightly on and on; and all the Achaeans roared
for his straining after victory, and cheered him pressing on.
But when they were running the last of the course, at once
Odysseus prayed in his heart to grey-eyed Athena:
- 770 "Hear me, goddess: come a good helper to my feet!"
So he spoke, praying; and Pallas Athena heard him,
and made his limbs light — his feet, and his arms above them.
And when they were on the point of darting in for the prize,
then Ajax slipped at a dead run — for Athena tripped him —
- 775 just where the dung lay scattered from the slaughtered bellowing
oxen swift-footed Achilles had killed for Patroclus;
and his mouth and nostrils filled with ox-dung.
So much-enduring brilliant Odysseus took up the bowl,
having come in first; and shining Ajax took the ox.
- 780 And he stood there holding the horn of the field-ranging ox,
spitting out dung, and spoke among the Argives:
"Damn it all — the goddess hobbled my feet! — she who forever
stands by Odysseus like a mother, and comes to help him."
So he spoke; and they all laughed at him sweetly.
- 785 And Antilochus carried off the last prize
smiling, and spoke his word among the Argives:
"I tell you all what you know already, friends: the immortals
honor the elder generation of men, now as always.
For Ajax is only a little older than I am —
- 790 but this one is of an earlier stock, of earlier men:
a green old age, they say, is his. And it is hard work
for any Achaean to race him — except Achilles."
So he spoke, and gave glory to the swift-footed son of Peleus.
And Achilles answered him with his word, and said:
- 795 "Antilochus — your praise shall not be spoken for nothing:

- I will add to your prize a half-talent of gold."
 So speaking, he laid it in his hands; and he received it, rejoicing.
 Then the son of Peleus carried into the gathering and set down²⁶
 a long-shadowed spear, and a shield and helmet —
- 800 the armor of Sarpedon, which Patroclus stripped from him.
 And he stood upright, and spoke his word among the Argives:
 "For these we summon two men — the best there are —
 to put on armor, take up the flesh-cutting bronze,
 and make trial of each other before the crowd.
- 805 Whichever man first reaches the other's fair flesh
 and touches the inward parts through armor and dark blood,
 to him I will give this sword with its silver studs —
 a beautiful Thracian blade I stripped from Asteropaeus;
 and the armor — let both men carry it off in common;
- 810 and we will set a good feast before them in the huts."
 So he spoke; and then great Telamonian Ajax rose,
 and up rose the son of Tydeus, strong Diomedes.
 And when they had armed themselves on opposite sides of the crowd,
 the two came together in the middle, hot for combat,
- 815 glaring terribly; and awe held all the Achaeans.
 And when they had come close, advancing on each other,
 three times they lunged in, three times they charged to close quarters.
 Then Ajax stabbed at the balanced round shield —
 but did not reach the flesh: the corslet inside it held.
- 820 And the son of Tydeus, over the rim of the great shield,
 kept reaching for his neck with the point of the shining spear.
 And then, in fear for Ajax, the Achaeans
 called on them to stop, and take equal prizes.
 But to the son of Tydeus the hero gave the great sword,
- 825 bearing it with its scabbard and well-cut baldric.
 Then the son of Peleus set out a lump of self-smelted iron²⁷
 that the huge strength of Eëtion used to throw;
 but him swift-footed brilliant Achilles killed,
 and carried the iron off in his ships with the rest of his goods.
- 830 And he stood upright, and spoke his word among the Argives:
 "Up — you who will make trial of this prize.
 Though his rich fields lie very far away,

the winner will have this to use for five revolving years:
 not for want of iron will his shepherd or his plowman
 835 go into town — this will supply them."
 So he spoke; and then war-staunch Polypoetes rose,
 and the strong might of godlike Leonteus rose,
 and Ajax, Telamon's son, and brilliant Epeius.
 They stood in order; and brilliant Epeius took the weight,
 840 whirled, and let it fly; and all the Achaeans laughed at him.
 Second in turn Leonteus, sprig of Ares, threw it;
 and third, great Telamonian Ajax flung it
 from his heavy hand, and passed the marks of all the others.
 But when war-staunch Polypoetes took up the weight —
 845 far as a herdsman sends his throwing-staff
 spinning away through the herds of his cattle —
 so far past the whole field he threw it; and the people shouted;
 and the companions of strong Polypoetes stood up
 and carried the king's prize away to the hollow ships.
 850 Then for the archers he set out the dark-blue iron:²⁸
 ten double axes he laid down, and ten half-axes,
 and he set up the mast of a dark-prowed ship
 far off in the sands, and to it, by a thin cord,
 tied a trembling dove by the foot, and commanded them
 855 to shoot at her: "Whoever hits the trembling dove,
 let him take up all the double axes and carry them home;
 whoever hits the cord, and misses the bird —
 he is the lesser man: let him carry off the half-axes."
 So he spoke; and then the strength of lord Teucer rose,
 860 and up rose Meriones, the good aide of Idomeneus.
 They took lots and shook them in a bronze helmet,
 and Teucer drew first place; and at once he let fly
 an arrow with all his force — but did not vow to the lord
 a famous hecatomb of firstling lambs.
 865 So he missed the bird — Apollo grudged him that —
 but hit the cord beside her foot, where the bird was tied,
 and the bitter arrow cut the cord clean through.
 She darted up toward heaven; and the cord fell slack
 toward the earth; and the Achaeans thundered.

- 870 But Meriones, in one motion, snatched the bow
 out of his hand — an arrow he had held ready while the other aimed —
 and vowed at once to Apollo who strikes from afar
 a famous hecatomb of firstling lambs;
 and high under the clouds he saw the trembling dove:
 875 there, as she circled, he shot her under the wing, full through,
 and the shaft passed clean out, and came back down to plant itself
 in the earth before Meriones's foot. And the bird
 settled on the mast of the dark-prowed ship,
 her neck drooped over, and the close-set wings went slack,
 880 and the life flew swift from her limbs, and she dropped far down
 from the mast; and the watching army marveled at it.
 And Meriones took up all ten double axes,
 and Teucer carried the half-axes to the hollow ships.
 Then, last, the son of Peleus carried into the gathering²⁹
 885 a long-shadowed spear and an unfired cauldron worked with flowers,
 worth an ox; and the javelin-throwers stood up:
 up rose the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon,
 and up rose Meriones, the good aide of Idomeneus.
 And among them spoke swift-footed brilliant Achilles:
 890 "Son of Atreus — we know how far you surpass all others,
 how much you are the best in power and in the throw:
 take this prize with you to the hollow ships,
 and let us give the spear to the hero Meriones —
 if your own heart is willing: for that is what I urge."
 895 So he spoke; and the lord of men Agamemnon did not refuse.
 Achilles gave the bronze spear to Meriones; and the hero
 handed his prize, the beautiful cauldron, to Talthybius the herald.

NOTES TO BOOK 23

- 1 *ll. 1-16* The Myrmidons mourn mounted: three circuits of the body with horses and chariots — cavalry honors, the war-machine itself made to grieve — with Thetis stirring "the desire of lament" (γόου ἕμερος; grief in Homer is an appetite, roused, fed, and satisfied). Achilles' ruling is the book's charter: "that is the dead man's due" (γέρασ θανόντων) — the prize of the dead, in the same word the living quarreled over in Book 1.
- 2 *ll. 17-25* The vow reported to its beneficiary: 22-23 repeat the wording of 18.336-337 (register kept), and Hector is laid "face-down in the dust beside the bier" — the outrage arranged like a grave-good. The poem keeps Achilles' promise-keeping and its horror in one frame: he is exact with the dead on both sides of hate.
- 3 *ll. 26-58* The funeral feast — "everywhere around the corpse the blood ran in cupfuls" — and the refusal to wash: the fast of Book 19 (19.208-210, 305-308) still governs Achilles' body; he yields to the "hateful feast" but swears off water "before I lay Patroclus on the fire." His oath contains the book's quiet self-knowledge: "never a second time will such grief reach my heart, while I am among the living" — true both ways, as he intends it and as the poem knows it: there is not much "while" left.
- 4 *ll. 59-92* The ghost. Patroclus comes "in everything like the man himself" — stature, the beautiful eyes, the voice, even the clothes — and opens with the gentlest rebuke in epic: "You sleep — and you have forgotten me, Achilles." His requests are a dead man's administration: burial now, because the other souls bar him from crossing the river (the poem's one glimpse of the afterlife's waiting-room); the hand ("I am weeping"); and the shared urn — grounded in the biography only now revealed: Patroclus came to Peleus's house as a child-killer, a boy who slew the son of Amphidamas "angry over the dice — a child's act; I did not mean it." The gentlest man in the poem was a refugee from his own temper: gentleness, the lines quietly say, was something he built. Aristarchus athetized 92 (the golden amphora, "which your lady mother gave you" — Dionysus's gift to Thetis in the later tradition; Aeschines' text lacked it), but the request stands: one vessel, two friends, the arrangement the *Odyssey* (24.74) confirms was kept.
- 5 *ll. 93-108* The failed embrace: Achilles reaches, "and grasped nothing: the soul, like smoke, was gone under the earth, squeaking." His waking cry is the plainest statement of Homeric eschatology: "so there is, even in the house of Hades, a soul and an image (ψυχή καὶ εἶδωλον) — but the wits (φρένες) are not in it at all." (Aristophanes athetized the line as too doctrinal; it is the shape of the whole scene.) The dead persist as form without force — enough to be loved, too little to be held: the exact measure of what the living owe them, which is everything this book does.
- 6 *ll. 109-140* The wood-train — Meriones's logistics, the mules, the felled oaks "with a great crashing" — ends at the shore where Achilles plans "the great mound for Patroclus — and for himself": his own funeral entering the arrangements as a fact needing no comment. The army heaps the corpse with cut hair; Achilles carries the head — chief mourner's station, as Thetis held his (18.71).

- 7 ll. 141-154 The Spercheius lock: hair grown long for a homecoming vow — Peleus's fifty rams at the river's sources — cut now and given to the dead instead: "since I am not going home to my dear fatherland." The vow of return is formally transferred to the grave; no line in the book cancels Achilles' future more quietly. He says it looking at the sea — the road home, declined.
- 8 ll. 161-192 The pyre, a hundred feet each way, and its freight: fat-wrapped corpse, honey and oil, four horses, two of the nine table-dogs — and the twelve Trojan youths of the vow, butchered with the narrator's own verdict attached: "and evil was the work his heart intended" (κακὰ δὲ φρεσὶ μῆδετο ἔργα). The poem does not flinch from human sacrifice and does not condone it: one clause of judgment, unique in the epic, set exactly here. And then, within eight lines, Book 24 quietly begins: Aphrodite keeping the dogs from Hector "by day and by night," the oil of roses, Apollo's sheltering cloud — the gods already voting against the rage they have stopped assisting.
- 9 ll. 193-232 The winds must be asked: Iris fetches Boreas and Zephyrus from a banquet (declining a seat — she is expected at the Aethiopians': divine society continuing around the edges of grief), and they burn the pyre all night while Achilles pours wine and calls the soul. Over it, the poem's most terrible simile of mourning: "As a father mourns, burning the bones of his son, a bridegroom" — the worst grief the Greek imagination could name, a child dead at the threshold of marriage — given to a friend for a friend, and doubled by the fact that the mourner's own father will soon have precisely this grief and no body to burn.
- 10 ll. 236-257 The white bones "of their kindly companion" (ἐννέος — the dead man's adjective) into the golden vessel "until I myself am hidden in Hades"; the mound deliberately modest, "then afterward the Achaeans may build it wide and high — you who are left behind me": Achilles designs his own tomb as an afterthought to his friend's, assigning the enlargement to survivors he has already stopped counting himself among. The funeral is double throughout; only one of the dead is present.
- 11 ll. 257-271 The pivot of the book: "But Achilles held the army there" — grief converted, by decree, into games. The prize-list is the Iliad's economy in miniature: women, tripods, mares, cauldrons, gold, iron — the same currencies men died over, now to be won by rule.
- 12 ll. 271-286 Achilles' abdication: his immortal horses would win, so he withdraws — and the reason is their mourning: they stand with manes trailing the ground for "the gentle one" (ἡπίου), who washed them and oiled their manes. Patroclus's epithet-world (kindly, gentle) persists in the memory of animals; the horses that wept at 17.426-440 are still in mourning, and their grief disqualifies the field's best entry.
- 13 ll. 287-351 Nestor's sermon on μῆτις — "by cunning, far more than by force, is the woodcutter better; by cunning the helmsman... by cunning charioteer outdoes charioteer" — the poem's most explicit praise of intelligence over strength, delivered to a son whose horses are slowest. The turn-post itself is the book's emblem: "either it is the grave-mark of a man dead long ago, or it was set for a turning-post by men before our time; and now Achilles has made it the goal" — a monument whose meaning is already lost, reused as sport: what tombs become, in the long run the poem knows all

about. The driving instructions (lean left, goad the right-hand horse, graze the post with the hub) are the oldest coaching manual in literature.

- 14 *ll. 352-373* The start: lots drawn (Antilochus first — the inside track his tactics will need), Phoenix as umpire "to keep the running in memory and report the truth," and the break — dust like cloud or stormwind, manes streaming, the cars now hugging earth, now airborne, "and each man's heart was pounding in his hunger for victory." The poem's joy in speed, absent since the chariots ran for Hector's life, is given back clean.
- 15 *ll. 373-402* The gods play the race as they played the war: Apollo dashes the whip from Diomedes (still angry from Book 5, perhaps — or just partisan); Athena returns it and breaks Eumelus's yoke — the best horseman skinned across mouth and elbows in the dust. Divine interference, which cost Patroclus his life and Hector his, here costs a man a mare and his skin: the same machinery at play-scale, safe at last.
- 16 *ll. 402-447* Antilochus's foul: the speech to his horses (threatening them with Nestor's knife — charioteer's hyperbole; "Aethe will pour shame over you: a female!"), the sunken narrows, and the swerve that forces Menelaus to yield or wreck. The narrator is exact: Menelaus dropped back "by his own will," the prudence of the elder buying both men's safety — and his shout ("you shall not carry off the prize without an oath") files the case the assembly will hear. The young man drives "like a man who had not heard": Nestor's cunning-lecture, over-learned in one generation.
- 17 *ll. 448-499* The spectators' quarrel — Idomeneus's sharp-eyed call (the chestnut with the moon-round blaze), Oilean Ajax's gratuitous insult, the proposed wager with Agamemnon as judge — is Book 1 in a teacup: two proud men, a prize, an arbiter. And it is stopped by Achilles — "it is not seemly... You would be indignant at another man who acted so" — the poem's original quarreler now its peacemaker, speaking to others the sentence nobody managed to speak to him. The reformation is complete and completely unremarked: the poem lets you notice it yourself.
- 18 *ll. 499-514* Diomedes wins — whip-strokes "down from the shoulder," the gold-and-tin car running the horses' heels down, wheel-tracks barely printed in the fine dust (speed measured by what it fails to leave), and the cool gesture at the end: the whip leaned against the yoke. Sthenelus takes the woman and the tripod: Book 5's team, intact, at play.
- 19 *ll. 514-533* The placings, with the poem's own verdict on Antilochus: "by craft, not speed at all" (κέρδεσιν, οὐ τι τάχει γε). The tail-hairs-brushing-the-tire figure measures Menelaus's closing surge; Meriones a spear-cast back; and last, dragging his wreck, "the best man" — Eumelus, whose excellence the race no longer records, which is why the next scene has to.
- 20 *ll. 534-566* Justice, round one: Achilles proposes second prize for Eumelus (pity ranking worth above result), and Antilochus objects on procedure — the mare is won; compensate from your own stores — with the challenge-tag of a man standing on right ("let any man who wants her try me — hand to hand"). And Achilles smiled — his only smile in the Iliad — "delighting in Antilochus, because he was his dear companion." The word ἑταῖρος, freighted with all the book's grief, spent here on the living: the smile is

the poem's first evidence that Achilles can still be reached. Eumelus gets Asteropaeus's corslet; everyone is paid; nobody is wronged.

- 21 *Il. 566-613* Justice, round two — the poem's model trial. Menelaus rises "grieved at heart," takes the herald's staff (procedure!), and offers two courses: judgment by the leaders, "and no favor either way," or — better — the self-executing oath: stand before your horses, whip in hand, touch the team, and swear by the earth-upholder, the earth-shaker, that the foul was not deliberate. Antilochus folds precisely at the oath — he will not perjure — with the young man's confession for all time: "his mind is the quicker, but his judgment thin" — and hands over the mare with his whole inheritance in one sentence rather than "be wrong before the gods." And Menelaus melts — the dew-on-the-ripening-corn simile, the gentlest in the poem, for the untensing of an angry heart — and gives the mare back. Compare Book 1: a prize, a grievance, an assembly — and there, wrath; here, yielding met by yielding. This scene is the Iliad showing what the quarrel of Achilles and Agamemnon should have been.
- 22 *Il. 615-652* Nestor's prize for nothing: the leftover bowl, given "a memorial of the burial of Patroclus: for never again will you see him among the Argives." The old man's answer is his career in miniature — the games for Amarynceus at Buprasium, four victories named, and the one defeat: the Molione twins who beat him "by force of numbers... one held the reins — held the reins for good and all — while the other laid on the whip" (the doubled phrase is the Greek's own, an old man's groove in the telling). His thanks name the thing the whole book trades in: "my heart rejoices that you remember me always as your kindly friend" (ἐννέος — Patroclus's word, 252). Honor, in the end, is being remembered kindly: the games' true currency, and the poem's.
- 23 *Il. 653-700* The boxing: Epeius's magnificent boast with its disarming core — "Is it not enough that I fall short in battle? There was never a way for one man to be skilled in every work there is" — the most honest self-assessment in the epic (this is the man who will build the wooden horse: his skill was coming). Euryalus's pedigree is a funeral-games résumé — he won at the burial of "fallen Oedipus" at Thebes, the Iliad's only notice of Oedipus, dead at home and buried with games. One counter-punch ends it; the fish-leap simile under Boreas's shiver lands him; and Epeius "took him in his hands and set him upright" — courtesy inside violence, the book's whole ethic in one gesture.
- 24 *Il. 700-740* The wrestling, with the poem's price-list attached: the tripod worth twelve oxen; the woman "skilled in many kinds of work," worth four. The Iliad states its world's arithmetic without comment, and no reader is meant to pass it in silence: this is the economy the whole war runs on. Ajax and Odysseus lock like "gable-rafters a famous builder joins"; two falls — Odysseus's knee-trick, then the failed lift and mutual tumble — and Achilles calls it: "Victory to you both." Force and cunning, the poem's two great modes, wrestle to a draw and are sent to dinner.
- 25 *Il. 740-798* The foot-race, and the bowl with a biography: Sidonian work, Phoenician freight, guest- gift to Thoas, and then — the price of Lycaon, paid by Euneus to Patroclus. The object that once bought Lycaon's life (21.40-41) is now the prize at the funeral of the man it was paid to, raced for while Lycaon lies in the river. Objects in Homer remember what men would rather not. The race itself is the book's comedy: Odysseus running so close he treads Ajax's prints "before the dust could settle," breathing on his head (with

the weaving-woman simile — the poem's most domestic measure of distance); the prayer; Athena's trip; Ajax face-down in the sacrificial ox-dung, spitting, with the complaint that convulses the army: "she stands by Odysseus like a mother!" — "and they all laughed at him sweetly" (ἡδύ). Laughter, which this poem has mostly given to gods and scorners, comes back to men, sweet, at a funeral. Antilochus's graceful last-place speech ("the immortals honor the elder generation... hard work to race him — except Achilles") wins a half-talent bonus for pure charm.

- 26 *ll. 798-826* The armed duel — for Sarpedon's armor, Patroclus's greatest spoil (16.663-665) — is the one event that edges too close to the real thing: first blood "through armor and dark blood" for Asteropaeus's Thracian sword. Ajax and Diomedes close "glaring terribly; and awe held all the Achaeans"; Diomedes keeps reaching over the shield-rim for the neck — the exact stroke that killed Hector — and the Achaeans, "in fear for Ajax," stop it. Play that can kill is called before it does: the community knows where the line is now. (Aristophanes' text varied the victory-terms; Aristarchus athetized 806 and 810; 824-825 were athetized too — antiquity was uneasy exactly where the game is uneasy.)
- 27 *ll. 826-849* The weight-throw: the prize is the implement — Eëtion's self-smelted iron lump, war-booty from Andromache's father's city, now five years' supply for a winner's shepherd and plowman: iron passing from a king's sport through sack and spoil to farm-tools — the poem's whole material history in one object. Polypoetes's cast, measured by a herdsman's throwing-staff "spinning away through the herds," wins it for the ships.
- 28 *ll. 850-883* The archery: a dove on a cord at the mast-head. Teucer shoots without vowing the hecatomb — "Apollo grudged him that" — and cuts the cord; Meriones, arrow already in hand, vows, and takes the bird under the wing as she circles the clouds. Piety as marksmanship's missing variable, scored like the contest it is; and the poem's last death — after Hector, after the twelve — is a dove's, drooping her neck on the mast "and the life flew swift from her limbs." The Iliad's killing ends in miniature, feathered, at a game.
- 29 *ll. 884-897* The close: Agamemnon stands up for the javelin — and Achilles awards him the prize without a throw: "we know how far you surpass all others... take this prize" — with the spear to Meriones. The poem's first quarrel was these two men over a prize; its last prize passes between them ungrudged, unthrown-for, by the loser of Book 1 now presiding in perfect courtesy. Agamemnon hands the cauldron to Talthylbius — the herald who once came to Achilles' hut to take Briseis (1.320-348) now receives, from Agamemnon's own hands, a gift born of Achilles' graciousness. The circle shuts without a word of comment: the games have done what nine years of war could not. All that remains is a corpse behind the hut, and a father across the plain — Book 24.

Iliad — Book 24

*The gods order Hector's body returned; Priam crosses the plain at night
to ransom his son from Achilles; the burial of Hector.*

- The gathering broke, and the people scattered, each man¹
to his own swift ship. The rest turned their minds to supper
and to sweet sleep, and took their fill; but Achilles
wept, remembering his dear companion; and sleep
- 5 that subdues all things would not take him: he turned this way and
that,
aching for Patroclus — for his manhood and his brave strength,
and all he had wound through and suffered at his side,
threading the wars of men and the punishing waves.
Remembering these things he let the swollen tears fall,
- 10 lying now on his side, now again
on his back, now face-down; and then he would stand
straight up, and wander in circles, distraught, along the beach. Nor did
dawn
ever slip past him, showing over the sea and the shores:
he would yoke his swift horses under the chariot,
- 15 and tie Hector behind the car, to drag him,
and haul him three times round the tomb of Menoetius's dead son,
then rest again in his hut, and leave him there,
stretched face-down in the dust. But Apollo kept
all disfigurement from the flesh, pitying the man
- 20 even in death: he covered him round with the aegis,
all golden, so the dragging would not tear him.
So Achilles in his fury defiled brilliant Hector;²
but the blessed gods, looking on, were moved to pity,
and kept urging the sharp-eyed slayer of Argus to steal him.
- 25 That pleased all the others — but never Hera,
nor Poseidon, nor the grey-eyed maiden:
they held fast, as when it first began, to their hatred
of holy Ilion, and Priam, and his people — for the blindness
of Alexandros, who insulted the goddesses when they came

- 30 to his sheep-fold, and praised the one who fed his grievous lust.
 But when the twelfth dawn rose from that day,³
 then Phoebus Apollo spoke among the immortals:
 "You are hard, you gods — you destroyers! Did Hector never
 burn for you the thigh-cuts of oxen and unblemished goats?
- 35 And now you cannot bring yourselves to save him — a corpse! —
 for his wife to look upon, and his mother, and his child,
 and his father Priam, and the people, who would quickly
 burn him in the fire and give him his portion of rites.
 No — it is ruinous Achilles you gods choose to help:
- 40 a man with no fit wits in him, no purpose in his chest
 that will bend: his thoughts are savage, like a lion
 who yields to his own great strength and lordly heart
 and goes at the flocks of men, to take his feast:
 so Achilles has destroyed pity; and there is no shame in him —
- 45 shame, which harms men greatly, and profits them too.
 A man may lose someone even closer than a friend —
 a brother of one womb, or his own son —
 and yet, when he has wept and lamented, he lets go:
 for the Fates gave mankind an enduring heart.
- 50 But this man — since he stripped great Hector of his dear life,
 he ties him behind his horses and drags him round the tomb
 of his dear companion. It is not the finer thing, nor the better.
 Let him take care we do not turn on him in anger, great as he is:
 it is dumb earth he defiles in all his fury."
- 55 And white-armed Hera, angered, answered him:⁴
 "Even that word of yours might stand, lord of the silver bow,
 if you gods will set Achilles and Hector at one price.
 Hector is mortal, and was suckled at a woman's breast;
 but Achilles is the child of a goddess — one I myself
- 60 reared and cherished and gave to a man to be his wife —
 to Peleus, dear beyond all men to the immortals.
 All of you gods were at the wedding; and you among them
 sat at the feast with your lyre — companion of evils, faithless forever!"
 Then in answer spoke to her cloud-gatherer Zeus:
- 65 "Hera — do not be wholly furious with the gods.
 Their honor shall not be one price. And yet Hector

- was dearest to the gods of all mortals in Ilion —
 so he was to me: he never failed in the gifts I love.
 Never did my altar lack its fair share of the feast,
 70 the libation and the savor: for that is the honor-portion we gods have.
 But the stealing — let it go. There is no way to take
 bold Hector unseen by Achilles: his mother
 is beside him always, mingled with his nights and days.
 No — let one of the gods call Thetis here to me,
 75 so I can tell her a close-packed word: that Achilles
 shall take gifts from Priam, and give Hector back."
 So he spoke; and storm-footed Iris rose to carry it,⁵
 and midway between Samos and rugged Imbros
 she plunged into the black sea; and the water groaned above her.
 80 Down she shot to the bottom like the lead sinker
 that rides the horn of a field-ox down the line
 and goes among the ravening fish, carrying death.
 She found Thetis in the hollow cave, and around her
 the other sea-goddesses sat gathered; and she in their midst
 85 was weeping the fate of her blameless son, who was to
 perish in deep-soiled Troy, far from his fatherland.
 And standing close, swift-footed Iris addressed her:
 "Rise, Thetis. Zeus of the imperishable counsels calls you."
 Then answered her the goddess, silver-footed Thetis:
 90 "Why does the great god summon me? I shrink from
 mixing with the immortals: the griefs in my heart are past counting.
 But I will go. Whatever word he speaks shall not be spoken in vain."
 So speaking, the brilliant goddess took up a veil —
 a dark-blue one: there is no garment blacker.
 95 And she set out, and wind-footed swift Iris led
 before her; and around them the wave of the sea gave way.
 They stepped out on the beach and darted up to heaven,
 and found the wide-seeing son of Cronos, and around him
 sat gathered all the other blessed gods who are forever.
 100 And she sat down beside father Zeus — Athena yielded her place —
 and Hera put a beautiful golden cup in her hand
 and cheered her with words; and Thetis drank, and gave it back.
 And the father of men and gods began speaking among them:

- "You have come to Olympus, goddess Thetis, for all your sorrow,
 105 carrying unforgettable grief in your heart. I know it myself.
 Even so, I will tell you why I called you here.
 For nine days a quarrel has stood among the immortals
 over Hector's body, and Achilles sacker of cities;
 they keep urging the sharp-eyed slayer of Argus to steal him.
 110 But I attach this glory to Achilles instead —
 guarding your reverence and your love for the days to come.
 Go quickly to the camp, and lay this charge on your son:
 tell him the gods are indignant with him — and I beyond all
 immortals am angered — because in his heart's madness
 115 he holds Hector at the beaked ships, and has not released him:
 so that, it may be, he will fear me, and give Hector back.
 And I will send Iris to great-hearted Priam:
 to ransom his dear son, going to the ships of the Achaeans,
 bearing gifts to Achilles that will warm his heart."
 120 So he spoke; and the goddess, silver-footed Thetis, obeyed,⁶
 and went darting down from the peaks of Olympus,
 and came to her son's hut. There she found him
 groaning without pause; and around him his companions
 were busy at speed, making the morning meal:
 125 a great shaggy sheep lay slaughtered in the hut.
 And she, his lady mother, sat down close beside him,
 and stroked him with her hand, and spoke a word, and named him:
 "My child — how long will you eat your own heart out
 with weeping and grieving, remembering neither bread
 130 nor bed? Yet it is good to lie with a woman
 in love. For you will not be with me long: already
 death stands close beside you, and fate the overpowering.
 Now listen quickly: I am a messenger of Zeus to you.
 He says the gods are indignant with you — and he beyond all
 135 immortals is angered — because in your heart's madness
 you hold Hector at the beaked ships, and have not released him.
 Come: give him up, and accept ransom for the dead."
 Then in answer spoke to her swift-footed Achilles:
 "So be it. Whoever brings the ransom, let him take the body,
 140 if the Olympian himself, in earnest, commands it."

- So the two of them, in the gathering-place of the ships,
 mother and son, spoke many winged words to each other.
 And the son of Cronos sent Iris down to holy Ilion:
 "Up, swift Iris: leave the seat of Olympus⁷
 145 and carry word to great-hearted Priam inside Ilion:
 to ransom his dear son, going to the ships of the Achaeans,
 bearing gifts to Achilles that will warm his heart —
 alone: let no other man of the Trojans go with him.
 A herald may follow him, an elder one, to steer
 150 the mules and the smooth-wheeled wagon, and to carry
 back to the city the dead man brilliant Achilles killed.
 And let no thought of death trouble his mind, no fear:
 such an escort we will give him — the slayer of Argus,
 who will lead him until his leading brings him to Achilles.
 155 And when he has led him inside Achilles' hut,
 that man will not kill him — he will hold all others back:
 for he is not witless, not blind, not godless;
 he will spare a suppliant man, and treat him with all kindness."
 So he spoke; and storm-footed Iris rose to carry it,
 160 and came to Priam's house, and found there crying and mourning.
 The sons sat around their father inside the courtyard,
 soaking their clothes with tears; and in their midst the old man,
 wrapped tight in his mantle; and thick on the old man's
 head and neck lay the dung
 165 he had gathered on himself with his own hands, rolling in it.
 And his daughters and his sons' wives wailed through the house,
 remembering the men — so many, and so brave —
 who lay dead at Argive hands, their lives destroyed.
 And the messenger of Zeus stood by Priam and spoke,
 170 in a small voice; and trembling took his limbs:
 "Take courage in your heart, Priam, Dardanus's descendant. Do not
 fear.
 I do not come to you with my eye on evil,
 but meaning well. I am a messenger of Zeus to you,
 who far away cares for you greatly, and pities you.
 175 The Olympian commands you: ransom brilliant Hector,
 bearing gifts to Achilles that will warm his heart —

- alone: let no other man of the Trojans go with you.
 A herald may follow you, an elder one, to steer
 the mules and the smooth-wheeled wagon, and to carry
 180 back to the city the dead man brilliant Achilles killed.
 And let no thought of death trouble your mind, no fear:
 such an escort will go with you — the slayer of Argus,
 who will lead you until his leading brings you to Achilles.
 And when he has led you inside Achilles' hut,
 185 that man will not kill you — he will hold all others back:
 for he is not witless, not blind, not godless;
 he will spare a suppliant man, and treat him with all kindness."
 So speaking, swift-footed Iris went her way.⁸
 And Priam ordered his sons to make ready the smooth-wheeled
 190 mule-wagon, and to lash the wicker box upon it;
 and he himself went down to the vaulted store-room,
 cedar-beamed, high-roofed, that held his many treasures,
 and called his wife Hecuba, and said to her:
 "Lady — a messenger from Zeus has come to me from Olympus:
 195 I am to ransom our dear son, going to the ships of the Achaeans,
 bearing gifts to Achilles that will warm his heart.
 So come, tell me: how does it seem to your mind?
 For my own strength and heart are urging me terribly
 to go there — to the ships, into the broad camp of the Achaeans."
 200 So he spoke; and the woman shrieked, and answered:
 "Ah me — where have your wits gone, for which you once
 were famous among strangers and the people you rule?
 How can you want to go to the ships of the Achaeans — alone —
 into the eyes of the man who has stripped your many
 205 brave sons? Your heart must be iron.
 If he takes you — if he sets eyes on you —
 savage and faithless as that man is, he will not pity you,
 he will not respect you. No: let us weep for our son far off,
 sitting in the hall. So overpowering Fate
 210 spun for him with her thread at his very birth, when I bore him:
 to glut the running dogs, far from his own parents,
 beside a violent man — oh, that I could fasten on that man's
 liver, and eat it raw! Then there would be work paid back

- for my son — for it was no coward he killed:
 215 a man who stood for the men of Troy and the deep-girdled women
 of Troy, with no thought of shelter, none of flight."
 Then in turn the old man, godlike Priam, answered her:
 "I will go. Do not hold me back — and do not be
 a bird of evil omen in my own halls. You will not persuade me.
 220 If any other man on earth had ordered this —
 some seer reading the smoke, some priest —
 we would call it false, and keep our distance from it.
 But now — I heard the god myself; I looked her in the face —
 I go; and her word shall not be spoken in vain. And if it is my portion
 225 to die by the ships of the bronze-shirted Achaeans,
 I choose it. Let Achilles kill me on the spot —
 once I have taken my son in my arms, and put away my fill of weeping."
 He spoke, and lifted the beautiful lids of the chests,⁹
 and out of them he took twelve magnificent robes,
 230 twelve single-fold cloaks, and as many blankets,
 as many white mantles, and as many tunics besides.
 He weighed and carried out ten full talents of gold,
 and two glittering tripods, and four cauldrons,
 and a cup of great beauty, which the men of Thrace had given him
 235 when he went on embassy — a great treasure. Not even this
 did the old man spare in his halls: he wished with all his heart
 to ransom his dear son. And the Trojans — all of them —
 he drove from the colonnade, lashing them with words of shame:
 "Out, you disgraces! You objects of reproach! Have you no
 240 mourning of your own at home, that you come to torment me?
 Is it nothing to you that Zeus, Cronos's son, has given me this grief —
 to lose my best son? You will learn it yourselves:
 you will be far easier now for the Achaeans
 to slaughter, with that man dead. But as for me —
 245 before I see this city sacked and ravaged
 with my own eyes, let me go down into the house of Hades."
 He spoke, and went at the men with his staff; and they fled out
 before the old man's fury. And he shouted at his own sons,
 cursing Helenus and Paris and brilliant Agathon
 250 and Pammon and Antiphonus and Polites of the war-cry

- and Deiphobus and Hippothous and noble Dius —
 nine sons; and the old man bellowed his orders at them:
 "Move, you worthless children — my shames! I wish the whole pack of
 you
 had been killed at the swift ships instead of Hector.
- 255 Ah, my evil fate! — I fathered the best sons
 in wide Troy, and I tell you not one of them is left:
 Mestor the godlike, and Troilus the chariot-fighter,
 and Hector, who was a god among men — he did not seem
 the son of a mortal man, but of a god.
- 260 Ares destroyed them. And these — these disgraces — are all left me:
 liars, dancers, heroes of the beaten dance-floor,
 plunderers of their own people's lambs and kids!
 Will you not get a wagon ready for me — now —
 and load all this on it, so we can be on our way?"
- 265 So he spoke; and dreading their father's rebuke¹⁰
 they brought out the smooth-wheeled mule-drawn wagon,
 a beautiful one, fresh-built, and lashed the wicker box upon it;
 and they took down from its peg the box-wood mule-yoke
 with its knob, well fitted with guide-rings,
- 270 and brought out with the yoke its lashing, nine cubits long.
 They set the yoke with care on the polished pole,
 on the rest at the pole's end, and threw the ring on the peg,
 and lashed it three times each way round the knob, and then
 wound the rest down the pole and tucked the tongue beneath.
- 275 Then they brought from the store-room and heaped on the polished
 wagon
 the ransom past counting for Hector's head,
 and yoked the strong-hoofed mules, trained to the harness,
 which once the Mysians gave to Priam, a shining gift;
 and for Priam they led beneath the yoke the horses
- 280 the old man kept for himself, and fed at the polished manger.
 So the two of them, in the high house, were having their teams yoked —
 the herald and Priam, with close-packed counsel in their minds —
 when Hecuba came up to them, her heart heavy,¹¹
 carrying honey-hearted wine in her right hand
- 285 in a golden cup, for them to pour before they went;

- and she stood before the horses, and spoke a word, and named him:
 "Here: pour to father Zeus, and pray to come home again
 out of the enemy's hands — since your heart
 drives you to the ships, though I would not have it so.
- 290 Pray, then, to the son of Cronos of the black cloud,
 the god of Ida, who looks down on all the Troad,
 and ask for a bird of omen — the swift messenger
 that is dearest of birds to him, whose power is greatest —
 on the right, so that seeing it with your own eyes
- 295 you may trust it, and go to the ships of the quick-horsed Danaans.
 But if wide-seeing Zeus will not give you his messenger,
 then I at least would not urge you on, or bid you
 go to the Argive ships, however hard you desire it."
 Then in answer spoke to her godlike Priam:
- 300 "Lady, I will not refuse what you ask.
 It is good to lift hands to Zeus, in hope he will pity."
 He spoke, and the old man told the housekeeper to pour
 clean water over his hands; and she stood by,
 the serving-woman, with basin and pitcher in her hands.
- 305 He washed, and took the cup from his wife,
 and standing in the middle of the court he prayed, and poured the
 wine,
 looking up into heaven, and spoke aloud:
 "Father Zeus, ruling from Ida, most glorious, greatest:
 grant that I come to Achilles welcome, and pitied;
- 310 and send me a bird of omen — the swift messenger
 that is dearest of birds to you, whose power is greatest —
 on the right, so that seeing it with my own eyes
 I may trust it, and go to the ships of the quick-horsed Danaans."
 So he spoke, praying; and Zeus the counselor heard him,
- 315 and at once sent an eagle, surest omen of flying things,
 the dark hunter, the one men call the dusky one.
 Wide as the door of some rich man's high-roofed
 treasure-chamber stands, a door well fitted with bolts,
 so wide his wings spread out on either side. He appeared to them
- 320 on the right, sweeping across the city; and seeing him
 they rejoiced, and the hearts in them all were warmed.

Then the old man in haste mounted his chariot¹²
 and drove out of the gateway and the echoing colonnade.
 In front the mules drew the four-wheeled wagon —
 325 war-minded Idaeus drove them — and behind came the horses
 the old man urged along with the whip
 at a brisk pace through the city; and all his people followed,
 mourning without end, as if he were going to his death.
 And when they had come down from the city and reached the plain,
 330 the others turned back for Ilion —
 the sons and the sons-in-law. But the two of them did not slip past
 wide-seeing Zeus as they came out on the plain: he saw, and pitied
 the old man, and quickly spoke to Hermes, his dear son:
 "Hermes — since to you, beyond all gods, it is dearest
 335 to be man's companion, and you listen to whom you will,
 go now, and lead Priam to the hollow ships of the Achaeans
 so that no one sees him, no one marks him,
 of all the Danaans, before he reaches the son of Peleus."
 So he spoke; and the courier, the slayer of Argus, obeyed.
 340 At once he bound beneath his feet the beautiful sandals,
 ambrosial, golden, that carry him over the water
 and over the boundless land with the breath of the wind;
 and he took up the wand with which he charms men's eyes
 to sleep, whomever he wishes, and wakes the sleeping;
 345 with this in his hands the strong slayer of Argus flew,
 and quickly came to Troy and the Hellespont,
 and went on his way in the likeness of a princely youth
 with the first down on his lip — the age when youth has its highest
 grace.
 Now when the two had driven past the great mound of Ilus,
 350 they halted the mules and horses at the river
 to drink; for dusk by now had come down over the earth.
 And the herald peered close, and made out Hermes
 near at hand, and spoke out to Priam:
 "Look sharp, Dardanus's descendant! Here is work for a careful mind.
 355 I see a man; and I think we are about to be torn to pieces.
 Come — let us flee with the horses; or if not,
 clasp his knees and beg him — he might pity us."

- So he spoke; and the old man's mind was scattered, and he was terribly afraid, and the hair stood up on his bent limbs,
 360 and he froze, dazed. But the helper-god came close himself, and took the old man's hand, and questioned him:
 "Where, father, are you steering these horses and mules¹³ through the ambrosial night, when other mortals sleep?
 Have you no fear of the Achaeans, breathing fury,
 365 your enemies, pitiless, so near at hand?
 If one of them saw you through the running black night bringing so many treasures — what would your plan be then?
 You are not young yourself, and this man with you is old — no strength to fight off a man who starts a quarrel.
 370 But I will do you no harm — no: I would defend you against another. You are the image of my own dear father."
 Then in turn the old man, godlike Priam, answered him:
 "It is all much as you say, dear child.
 But some god, even now, has held his hand over me,
 375 who sent a wayfarer like you to cross my path — a good omen: such is your body and your beauty, a wonder, and your mind is sound. Blessed are the parents you come of."
 Then in turn the courier, the slayer of Argus, addressed him:
 "Yes, old man — all this you have said aright.
 380 But come, tell me this, and recount it truly:
 are you sending away a great treasure, and a fine one, to foreign men somewhere, so that much at least survives you?
 Or are you all abandoning holy Ilion now in fear — such a man has perished, the best among you,
 385 your son: who never hung back from battle with the Achaeans."
 Then in turn the old man, godlike Priam, answered him:
 "Who are you, my brave one? Of what parents do you come, who speak so beautifully of my ill-fated son's death?"
 Then in turn the courier, the slayer of Argus, addressed him:
 390 "You test me, old man — asking about brilliant Hector.
 Him my own eyes have seen — and often — in the battle where men win glory; and when he drove the Argives onto their ships and kept killing, carving with the sharp bronze, we stood and marveled at it: for Achilles,

- 395 in his anger at Atreus's son, would not let us fight.
 I am his squire; one strong-built ship brought us both.
 I am a Myrmidon by birth; my father is Polycctor —
 a wealthy man, and old, just as you are:
 six sons he has, and I am his seventh;
- 400 I shook lots with the others, and the lot fell to me to sail here.
 Now I have come to the plain from the ships: for at daybreak
 the bright-eyed Achaeans will set their battle around the city.
 They chafe at sitting idle, and the kings of the Achaeans
 cannot hold them back, so hot they are for war."
- 405 Then in turn the old man, godlike Priam, answered him:
 "If you are truly a squire of Achilles, Peleus's son,
 come then — tell me the whole truth:
 is my son still by the ships? Or has Achilles
 cut him limb from limb by now, and thrown him to his dogs?"
- 410 Then in turn the courier, the slayer of Argus, addressed him:
 "Old man — the dogs have not eaten him, nor the birds:
 he lies there still, beside the ship of Achilles,
 just as he was, among the huts. Twelve dawns now
 he has lain there; and his flesh does not decay, and the worms
- 415 do not eat him — the worms that devour men killed in war.
 It is true that around the tomb of his dear companion
 Achilles drags him, careless, whenever bright dawn shows —
 but he cannot disfigure him. You would marvel yourself, if you came,
 at how he lies there dewy-fresh, the blood all washed
- 420 from him, no stain anywhere; and every wound has closed,
 every one that was struck — and many drove their bronze into him.
 Such is the care the blessed gods take for your son,
 a dead man though he is — because they loved him at heart."
 So he spoke; and the old man rejoiced, and answered:
- 425 "My child — how good a thing it is to give the immortals
 their due gifts! For my son — if ever he truly was —
 never forgot, in his halls, the gods who hold Olympus;
 and so they have remembered him, even in the portion of death.
 But come — take from me this beautiful cup,
- 430 and guard my body, and escort me, with the gods,
 until I come to the hut of Peleus's son."

Then in turn the courier, the slayer of Argus, addressed him:
 "You test me again, old man — the young man — but you will not
 persuade me,
 asking me to take your gifts behind Achilles' back.

- 435 I fear that man; my heart shrinks with too much awe
 to rob him — lest some evil find me afterward.
 But you — I would escort you with all care, even to famous Argos,
 by swift ship or on foot beside you;
 and no man would make light of your escort, or attack."
- 440 He spoke, and the helper-god sprang up onto the chariot,¹⁴
 and swiftly caught the whip and reins into his hands,
 and breathed brave strength into the horses and the mules.
 And when they came to the towers and the ditch of the ships,
 the sentries were just busying themselves with supper;
- 445 and the courier, the slayer of Argus, poured sleep
 over them all, and opened the gates at once, and thrust back the bars,
 and led in Priam and the shining gifts on the wagon.
 And when they came to the hut of Peleus's son —
 the high hut the Myrmidons had built their lord,
 450 cutting beams of fir, and roofed it over
 with a shaggy thatch of reeds mown from the meadow,
 and around it made their lord a great courtyard
 with close-set stakes; and one single bar of fir
 held the door — a bolt three Achaeans would drive home
- 455 and three would draw, of the others: three men
 to that great bolt, though Achilles would ram it home alone —
 then Hermes the helper opened it for the old man,
 and brought in the famed gifts for the swift-footed son of Peleus,
 and stepped down from the chariot to the ground, and said:
- 460 "Old man — I am an immortal god come down to you:
 Hermes. My father sent me with you as your escort.
 But now I will go back: I will not walk
 into Achilles' sight. It would stir indignation —
 an immortal god openly entertained by mortals.
- 465 You go in; clasp the knees of Peleus's son,
 and beg him by his father, by his mother of the lovely hair,
 by his child — so you may stir the heart in him."

- So speaking, Hermes went his way to high Olympus;¹⁵
and Priam leapt from the chariot to the ground
470 and left Idaeus there to hold
the horses and mules; and the old man walked straight in,
to where Achilles, dear to Zeus, was sitting. Inside
he found him — his companions sitting apart; only two,
the hero Automedon and Alcimus, sprig of Ares,
475 were busy at his side; he had newly finished eating,
finished food and drink; the table still stood by him.
Great Priam came in unseen by them all, and standing close,
he clasped Achilles' knees with his hands, and kissed his hands —
the terrible, man-slaughtering hands that had killed so many of his
sons.
- 480 As when thick blindness takes a man, who in his own country
kills another, and comes among a different people,
to a rich man's house, and wonder holds all who see him:
so Achilles wondered, seeing godlike Priam;
and the others wondered too, and looked at one another.
- 485 And Priam, in supplication, spoke his word to him:¹⁶
"Remember your father, Achilles like the gods —
a man of my years, on the ruinous threshold of old age.
It may be that the men who live around him
are grinding him down, and there is no one to beat off ruin and
destruction.
- 490 Yet he at least, hearing that you are alive,
rejoices in his heart, and hopes through all his days
to see his dear son coming home from Troy.
But I am doomed to the last: I fathered the best sons
in wide Troy, and I tell you not one of them is left.
- 495 Fifty I had, when the sons of the Achaeans came:
nineteen were mine from a single womb,
and the others women of the palace bore me.
Rushing Ares has unstrung the knees of most of them;
and the one who was left me, who guarded the city and the people —
- 500 him you killed, days ago, fighting for his fatherland:
Hector. For his sake I come now to the ships of the Achaeans
to ransom him from you; and I bring ransom past counting.

Respect the gods, Achilles, and pity me,
 remembering your own father. And I am still more pitiable:
 505 I have endured what no other mortal on earth has yet endured —
 to lift to my lips the hand of the man who killed my son."
 So he spoke; and he stirred in Achilles the desire to weep for his
 father.¹⁷
 He took the old man's hand, and gently pushed him back;
 and the two of them remembered: the one wept long and sore
 510 for man-slaughtering Hector, huddled at Achilles' feet,
 and Achilles wept for his own father — and now again
 for Patroclus; and the sound of their mourning filled the house.
 But when brilliant Achilles had taken his fill of lament,
 and the longing for it had gone out of his chest and limbs,
 515 he rose from his seat at once, and raised the old man up by the hand,
 pitying the grey head and the grey beard,
 and speaking winged words he addressed him:
 "Poor man. How much evil your heart has endured!"¹⁸
 How could you bear to come to the ships of the Achaeans — alone —
 520 into the eyes of the man who has stripped your many
 brave sons? Your heart must be iron.
 Come, sit on this chair; and our griefs — we will let them
 lie quiet in our hearts, for all our sorrow.
 There is nothing to be gained from chill lament.
 525 For this is the way the gods have spun it for wretched mortals:
 to live in grief. And they themselves are free of care.
 Two jars stand on the floor of Zeus's hall,
 full of the gifts he gives: one of evils, one of blessings.
 The man to whom Zeus who delights in thunder gives a mixture,
 530 meets now with evil, and now again with good;
 but the man to whom he gives only from the jar of sorrows —
 him he has made an outcast: ravening hunger drives him over the
 earth,
 and he wanders honored neither by gods nor by mortals.
 So it was with Peleus: the gods gave him shining gifts
 535 from his birth; he outshone all mankind
 in wealth and fortune, and was king of the Myrmidons,
 and mortal though he was, they made a goddess his wife.

- But even on him the god laid evil: no brood
of ruling sons was born to him in his halls —
- 540 one child he fathered, doomed out of season. And I give him
no care in his old age: far from my fatherland
I sit here in Troy, grieving you and your children.
And you, old man — we hear you prospered once:
all that Lesbos out to sea, the seat of Macar, bounds,
545 and Phrygia inland, and the boundless Hellespont —
over all these, old man, they say you were first in wealth and sons.
But since the gods of heaven brought this affliction on you,
there is nothing around your city now but battles and the killing of
men.
Bear it. Do not mourn without respite in your heart.
- 550 You will accomplish nothing, grieving for your son;
you will not raise him up — sooner you will suffer some new evil."
Then in turn the old man, godlike Priam, answered him:¹⁹
"Do not seat me on a chair, Zeus-nurtured — not while Hector
lies in the huts uncared-for. Give him back
555 quickly, so my eyes can see him; and accept the ransom —
the great ransom we bring you. May you have joy of it, and come
to your own fatherland — since you have let me,
from the first, live on and look upon the light of the sun."
Then, glaring darkly, swift-footed Achilles answered him:
- 560 "Do not provoke me now, old man. I mean myself
to give Hector back to you: a messenger came to me from Zeus —
my mother, who bore me, the daughter of the old man of the sea.
And I know you too, Priam — do not think to hide it:
some god led you to the swift ships of the Achaeans.
- 565 No mortal would have dared come into the camp — not even
a man in his prime: he could not have slipped past the sentries,
nor easily levered back the bar of our doors.
So do not stir my heart further in its griefs,
or I may not spare even you, old man, inside my huts —
- 570 suppliant though you are — and may trespass against the commands of
Zeus."
So he spoke; and the old man was afraid, and obeyed.
And the son of Peleus sprang out the door of the house like a lion —²⁰

not alone: two of his aides went with him,
 the hero Automedon and Alcinus, the two Achilles
 575 honored most of his companions after dead Patroclus.
 They loosed the horses and mules from the yokes,
 and led in the old man's clear-voiced herald
 and sat him on a bench; and from the polished wagon
 they lifted down the ransom past counting for Hector's head.
 580 But they left two mantles and a fine-spun tunic,
 so he might wrap the body and give it to be carried home.
 And Achilles called out slave-women, and ordered them to wash him
 and anoint him — but apart, moved away, so Priam would not see his
 son:
 lest the grief in his heart not master his anger
 585 at the sight of his child, and Achilles' own spirit be stirred,
 and he kill him, and trespass against the commands of Zeus.
 And when the slave-women had washed him and anointed him with oil,
 and wrapped the beautiful mantle and the tunic around him,
 Achilles himself lifted him and laid him on a bier,
 590 and his companions with him raised it onto the polished wagon.
 Then he groaned, and called his dear companion by name:
 "Do not be angry with me, Patroclus, if you learn —
 even in the house of Hades — that I released brilliant Hector
 to his dear father: the ransom he gave was not unworthy.
 595 And to you, in turn, I will give your share of it — all that is fitting."
 He spoke, and went back into the hut, brilliant Achilles,
 and sat down on the richly-worked couch he had risen from,
 against the far wall, and spoke his word to Priam:
 "Your son is given back, old man, as you commanded:
 600 he lies on a bier. At the showing of dawn
 you will see him yourself, and take him. Now — let us remember
 supper.
 For even lovely-haired Niobe remembered food,²¹
 though twelve children perished in her halls —
 six daughters, and six sons in the pride of their youth.
 605 The sons Apollo killed with his silver bow,
 in anger at Niobe; and Artemis who showers arrows killed the
 daughters —

because Niobe had matched herself with fair-cheeked Leto:
 Leto, she said, bore two; she herself had borne many.
 So those two, though they were only two, destroyed them all.
 610 Nine days they lay in their blood, and there was no one
 to bury them: the son of Cronos had turned the people to stones.
 On the tenth day the gods of heaven buried them.
 And she remembered food, when she was worn out with weeping.
 And now, somewhere among the rocks, in the lonely mountains,
 615 on Sipylus, where they say the goddess nymphs
 have their beds — the nymphs who dance along the Achelous —
 there, stone though she is, she broods on the griefs the gods gave her.
 Come then, noble old man: let the two of us also remember
 food. Afterward you may weep for your dear son again,
 620 when you have brought him into Ilion. He will cost you many tears."
 He spoke, and swift Achilles sprang up and slaughtered²²
 a white-fleeced sheep; and his companions flayed and dressed it well
 and duly, and cut it up with skill, and pierced it on the spits,
 and roasted it with care, and drew off every portion.
 625 And Automedon took bread and set it out along the table
 in beautiful baskets; and Achilles portioned out the meat.
 And they reached out their hands to the good things lying ready.
 And when they had put away the desire for drink and food,
 then Priam, Dardanus's descendant, marveled at Achilles —
 630 how big he was, how beautiful: like the gods to look upon;
 and Achilles marveled at Priam, Dardanus's descendant,
 looking at his fine face and listening to his words.
 And when they had taken their fill of looking at each other,
 the first to speak was the old man, godlike Priam:²³
 635 "Give me a bed now quickly, Zeus-nurtured, so that we
 may lie down at last and take our fill of sweet sleep.
 For my eyes have never closed beneath their lids
 since my son lost his life under your hands:
 I have done nothing but groan, and brood on griefs past counting,
 640 rolling in the dung in the yard where my cattle are penned.
 Now at last I have tasted bread, and let the gleaming wine
 down my throat. Before this I had touched nothing."
 He spoke; and Achilles ordered his companions and the slave-women

to set out beds under the porch, and to throw on them
645 fine purple rugs, and spread blankets over these,
and lay out fleecy cloaks on top for covering.
And the women went from the hall with torches in their hands,
and quickly and busily made up two beds.
And swift-footed Achilles said to him, with an edge in his voice:
650 "Sleep outside, dear old man — in case some Achaean
councilor comes here: they are forever sitting
at my side weaving plans, as is their custom.
If one of them saw you through the running black night,
he would tell it at once to Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,
655 and there would be delay in the release of the body.
But come, tell me this, and recount it truly:
how many days do you need for the burial of brilliant Hector —
so I may wait that long myself, and hold back the army."
Then in turn the old man, godlike Priam, answered him:²⁴
660 "If you are truly willing that I give brilliant Hector burial,
then this, Achilles, is how you would do me kindness.
You know how we are penned in the city; and the wood
is far to bring from the mountain, and the Trojans are afraid.
Nine days we would mourn him in the halls;
665 on the tenth we would bury him, and the people feast;
on the eleventh we would raise the mound above him;
and on the twelfth we will fight again — if we must."
Then in turn swift-footed brilliant Achilles addressed him:
"This too shall be as you command, old Priam:
670 I will hold off the war for the time you ask."
So speaking, he took the old man's right hand
at the wrist, so his heart should not be afraid.
So there in the fore-hall of the house they lay down,
the herald and Priam, with close-packed counsel in their minds;
675 but Achilles slept in the inner corner of his strong-built hut,
and fair-cheeked Briseis lay beside him.
The other gods, and men who fight from chariots,²⁵
slept the whole night through, subdued by soft sleep;
but sleep would not take Hermes the helper,
680 turning it over in his heart how he would bring king Priam

- away from the ships unseen by the strong gate-keepers.
 He stood above his head, and spoke a word to him:
 "Old man — no evil worries you, to judge by how you sleep
 among enemy men, because Achilles spared you.
- 685 You have ransomed your dear son now; you paid a great price.
 But for you — alive — your sons left behind would pay
 three times as much again, if Agamemnon
 Atreus's son knew of you — if all the Achaeans knew."
 So he spoke; and the old man was afraid, and woke the herald.
- 690 And Hermes yoked the horses and the mules for them,
 and drove them quickly through the camp himself; and no one knew.
 But when they came to the ford of the fair-flowing river,
 eddying Xanthus, whom immortal Zeus begot,
 then Hermes went his way to high Olympus,
- 695 and Dawn in her saffron robe was spreading over all the earth,
 and they drove the horses toward the city with wailing
 and lamentation; and the mules carried the dead.
 Nor did any other know them, man or fair-girdled woman —²⁶
 only Cassandra, like golden Aphrodite,
- 700 who had climbed Pergamus, and saw her dear father
 standing in the chariot, and the herald, the city's crier,
 and saw him too — lying on the bier behind the mules —
 and shrieked, and cried out through the whole city:
 "Come, men of Troy, women of Troy: come and see Hector —
- 705 if ever, while he lived, you rejoiced when he came home
 from battle: for he was a great joy to the city and all its people."
 So she spoke; and not one man was left in the city,
 not one woman: on all of them came grief past bearing;
 and close by the gates they met him bringing home the dead.
- 710 First of all his dear wife and his lady mother
 tore their hair for him, rushing at the smooth-wheeled wagon,
 touching his head; and the crowd stood around them, weeping.
 And now the whole day long until the setting sun
 they would have mourned Hector before the gates, pouring their tears,
- 715 had not the old man spoken to the people from his chariot:
 "Make way for the mules to pass. Afterward

you may glut yourselves with weeping — when I have brought him home."

So he spoke; and they parted, and made way for the wagon.

And when they had brought him into the famous house, they laid him

720 on a corded bed, and set beside him singers,

leaders of the dirge, who sang their mournful song —

they chanted the dirge, and the women wailed in answer.

And among them white-armed Andromache led the lament,²⁷

holding in her hands the head of man-slaughtering Hector:

725 "Husband — you were lost young out of life, and you leave me

a widow in your halls; and the boy is just a baby still,

whom we bore, you and I — the two ill-fated. And I think

he will not reach manhood: before that, this city

will be sacked from its height. For you have perished — you, its watcher,

730 who guarded it, and kept safe its honored wives and little children.

They will ride away soon in the hollow ships,

and I with them. And you, my child — you will follow me

where degrading labors wait for you,

drudging under a harsh master's eye — or some Achaeans

735 will seize you by the arm and fling you from the wall — a wretched death —

in anger, because Hector killed his brother,

or his father, or his son: for very many Achaeans

bit the boundless earth in their teeth at Hector's hands.

Your father was not gentle in the sad fighting;

740 and so the people mourn him through the city,

and you have laid a cursed grief and mourning, Hector,

on your parents. And for me beyond all others the bitter

pain is left: you did not die in bed, reaching your arms to me,

you spoke no close last word that I might have

745 remembered always, nights and days, with my tears falling."

So she spoke, weeping; and the women wailed in answer.

And among them Hecuba in her turn led the thick lament:²⁸

"Hector — far dearest to my heart of all my children,

dear to the gods you were while you lived with me,

750 and they have cared for you even in the portion of death.

My other sons — swift-footed Achilles would sell them,

- whichever ones he took, across the barren sea,
 into Samos, and Imbros, and Lemnos of the smoke.
 But you — when he had taken your life with the long-edged bronze,
 755 he dragged you again and again around the tomb of his companion
 Patroclus, whom you killed — though not even so did he raise him up.
 And now you lie in my halls dewy-fresh, as if newly slain,
 like one whom Apollo of the silver bow has visited
 and killed with his gentle arrows."
- 760 So she spoke, weeping, and roused the endless lament.
 And third after them, Helen led the lament:²⁹
 "Hector — far dearest to my heart of all my husband's brothers!
 My husband is godlike Alexandros,
 who brought me to Troy. I wish I had died before that day.
- 765 This is now the twentieth year for me
 since I came away from there and left my own country;
 yet never once did I hear from you an evil word, or a slighting one.
 No — if any other rebuked me in the halls,
 a brother of my husband, or a sister, or a brother's fine-robed wife,
 770 or my husband's mother — though his father was always gentle as my
 own —
 you would turn them aside, you would restrain them,
 with your gentle-mindedness and your gentle words.
 And so I weep for you — and for myself, doomed as I am — grieving at
 heart:
 for there is no one else now in wide Troy
 775 gentle to me, or kind: they all shudder at me."
- So she spoke, weeping; and the vast crowd groaned in answer.
 And old Priam spoke his word among the people:³⁰
 "Bring wood now, Trojans, into the city; and have no fear
 in your hearts of an Argive ambush: for Achilles,
 780 sending me from the black ships, gave me his pledge
 that he will do us no harm until the twelfth dawn comes."
 So he spoke; and they yoked oxen and mules to the wagons,
 and quickly then they gathered before the city.
 Nine days they hauled in wood past measuring;
 785 and when the tenth dawn rose with its light for mortals,
 then they carried out bold Hector, weeping,

and set the body on the height of the pyre, and threw on the fire.
 And when young Dawn showed again, the rosy-fingered,
 then the people gathered around glorious Hector's pyre.
 790 And when they had assembled and were gathered together,
 first they quenched the burning-place with glistening wine,
 all of it, wherever the fire's strength had reached; and then
 his brothers and companions gathered the white bones,
 mourning, and the swollen tears ran down their cheeks.
 795 And they took the bones and laid them in a golden box,
 wrapping them in soft purple robes,
 and quickly set it down in a hollow grave,
 and roofed it over with great stones set close together;
 and swiftly they heaped the mound — with watchers posted round on
 every side,
 800 lest the strong-greaved Achaeans should storm out before the time.
 And when they had heaped the mound they went back; and then,
 gathered together in due order, they feasted a glorious feast
 in the house of Priam, the king nurtured of Zeus.
 So they busied themselves with the burial of Hector, the tamer of
 horses.

NOTES TO BOOK 24

- 1 ll. 1-21 The book opens on the community dissolving back into ordinary life — supper, sweet sleep — and one man exempt: Achilles cycling through the postures of grief (side, back, face-down, up and pacing), unreached by "sleep that subdues all things." The dawns are iterative — the Greek's tenses make the dragging a routine: harness, drag three times round the tomb, rest, leave him face-down. And the routine accomplishes nothing: Apollo with the golden aegis keeps the flesh whole, "pitying the man even in death." Rage has become machinery — running, grinding, and feeding no one. That futility is the book's premise.

- 2 ll. 22-30 The divine majority wants the corpse stolen; three gods refuse — Hera, Poseidon, Athena — because of the poem's oldest wound: "the blindness of Alexandros, who insulted the goddesses when they came to his sheep-fold, and praised the one who fed his grievous lust." This is the Iliad's only mention of the Judgment of Paris, and Aristarchus athetized the passage — partly because the poem nowhere else knows the story, partly for the coarse word *μαχλοσύνη* ("lust"). Kept here: at the very end, the poem finally names the beginning — a beauty contest on a hillside as the seed of everything we have watched.

- 3 ll. 31-54 Apollo's indictment is the poem's ethical summit-speech: Achilles has "destroyed pity," and lost *aidōs* — the shame-before-others "which harms men greatly, and profits them too": the double-edged social emotion that the whole epic runs on, defined in one line. The lion comparison strips the *aristeia* of its glamour (savagery "at the flocks of men, to take his feast"); and the norm is stated with terrible gentleness: a man may lose a brother or a son, "and yet, when he has wept and lamented, he lets go: for the Fates gave mankind an enduring heart" (*τλητὸν γὰρ Μοῖραι θυμὸν θέσαν ἀνθρώποισιν*) — endurance as the species-defining gift. The close is the book's moral in five words: "it is dumb earth he defiles in all his fury" — the dead man is beyond harm; the harm is all the living man's own.

- 4 ll. 55-76 Hera's counter is pure rank (a breast-fed mortal cannot be priced with a goddess's son — with her swipe at Apollo's lyre-playing at the very wedding: "companion of evils, faithless forever"); and Zeus's ruling splits the difference with statesman's care: no equal honor — but Hector was "dearest to the gods of all mortals in Ilium" for the oldest reason in the poem's theology, the unfailing altar. The theft is rejected on practical grounds (Thetis's watch), but the true design appears in one phrase: "I attach this glory (*κῦδος*) to Achilles" — the return of the body is arranged not as defeat but as honor, mercy denominated in the only currency the recipient still values.

- 5 ll. 77-119 Iris's dive "like the lead sinker that rides the horn of a field-ox down the line" — the most homely simile ever given a goddess: heaven's messenger as fishing-tackle. Thetis's veil is the poem's blackest object ("there is no garment blacker"); she dresses for her son's death to attend a council about his mercy. On Olympus the courtesies are exact

— Athena yields her place, Hera hands the cup — the divine family arranging itself gently around a bereaved mother whose bereavement has not yet happened.

- 6 *Il. 120-142* Thetis delivers Zeus's rebuke and adds what no god scripted: "it is good to lie with a woman in love. For you will not be with me long..." (Aristarchus athetized 130-132 as indecorous; they are the scene's heart). A mother's last advice to a doomed son is bread, bed, and love — the whole mortal portion, urged because the portion is nearly spent. And Achilles' answer, after three books of iron: "So be it" (τῆδ' εἴη) — the wrath that filled an epic ends in two words of assent, the moment the demand comes from the one person he cannot refuse, carrying an honor he can accept.
- 7 *Il. 143-187* Iris's commission to Priam repeats Zeus's wording verbatim (146-158 = 175-187, kept identical here): heaven's mercy delivered twice, unedited — the poem's formulaic economy made providential. The house she enters is a tableau of collective ruin: sons weeping in the courtyard, daughters and sons' wives wailing within, and the king wrapped in his mantle with dung on his head and neck, "gathered on himself with his own hands." The message lands on a man already performing his own burial.
- 8 *Il. 188-228* The marriage scene: Priam tells Hecuba, and her answer is the poem's final maternal ferocity — the wish to "fasten on that man's liver, and eat it raw." The raw-eating triplet closes: Hera (4.35), Achilles (22.346), and now Hecuba — goddess of the winning side, killer, and grieving mother speaking one idiom; grief and hate converge in the same appetite. Priam's answer sets the book's terms: he has seen the god face to face; and if the price is death, "I choose it. Let Achilles kill me on the spot — once I have taken my son in my arms, and put away my fill of weeping." The embassy is a father's calculated exchange: his life, if need be, for one embrace.
- 9 *Il. 229-264* The ransom counted out (the poem loves the inventory: robes, cloaks, blankets, mantles, tunics, twelve of each; ten talents; tripods, cauldrons, the Thracian cup "not even this did the old man spare") — and then Priam's rage: first at the Trojans ("Have you no mourning of your own at home?"), then the terrible roll-call of the nine surviving sons — "liars, dancers, heroes of the beaten dance-floor, plunderers of their own people's lambs and kids" — against the dead: Mestor, Troilus, "and Hector, who was a god among men." Grief in old men, the poem knows, comes out as fury at the living for not being the dead. (Among the cursed: Helenus, Paris, Deiphobus — the city's remaining leadership, measured and found wanting by their father in public.)
- 10 *Il. 265-282* The yoking, in loving procedural detail — the box-wood yoke, the knob, the guide-rings, the nine-cubit lashing wound three times each way. The poem slows to craftsman's tempo exactly as it did for Hera's chariot and Priam's own libation to come: ritual care in the doing is how the Iliad marks an act as sacred. This wagon is an altar being assembled.
- 11 *Il. 283-322* Hecuba's libation-counsel — having failed to stop him, she arms him with piety: pour to Zeus, ask for the eagle on the right; "but if wide-seeing Zeus will not give you his messenger, I at least would not urge you." The omen comes: the dusky hunter-eagle, wings as wide "as the door of some rich man's high-roofed treasure-chamber" — the simile drawn from precisely the world of stored wealth Priam has just emptied for

the ransom. And the exit: all Troy follows the wagon "mourning without end, as if he were going to his death" — which is, as far as anyone knows, the truth.

- 12 *ll. 322-362* Zeus's commission to Hermes defines the god: "to you, beyond all gods, it is dearest to be man's companion" (ἀνδρὶ ἑταίρισσαι) — the escort-god, the one Olympian whose office is company. He comes as a princely youth "with the first down on his lip — the age when youth has its highest grace," and the meeting at the ford by Ilus's tomb, at dusk, is built as pure terror first: the herald's whisper, the old man's hair standing on his bent limbs — before the god takes his hand. Every earlier night-crossing in this poem (Book 10) ended in blood; the poem uses that memory to make this one tremble.
- 13 *ll. 362-440* The interrogation is Hermes at play — "You are the image of my own dear father"; the invented Myrmidon biography (seventh son of Polyctor, chosen by lot) — but its center is the report on the corpse: twelve days dead, dragged daily, and "his flesh does not decay... You would marvel yourself, if you came, at how he lies there dewy-fresh, the blood all washed from him, no stain anywhere; and every wound has closed... Such is the care the blessed gods take for your son, a dead man though he is — because they loved him at heart." The kindest sentence in the Iliad, spoken by a disguised god to a father in the dark. Priam's response makes it doctrine — "how good a thing it is to give the immortals their due gifts" — with the one heartbreaking parenthesis, "if ever he truly was" (εἴ ποτ' ἔην γε): grief's suspicion that the beloved might have been a dream. Hermes' refusal of the cup — no gifts "behind Achilles' back" — teaches with a light hand the order of things: even gods respect what is owed to Achilles; mercy must come from the man himself.
- 14 *ll. 440-468* Into the camp: sleep poured on the sentries, the gates opened — and the poem pauses to build Achilles' hut in full (fir beams, meadow-thatch, the palisade court) for the sake of one detail: the fir-wood bar that "three Achaeans would drive home and three would draw... though Achilles would ram it home alone." The door is a strength-gauge; Hermes opens it for an old man. His parting instructions are the supplication-manual: knees, and the names — father, mother, child.
- 15 *ll. 469-485* The entrance. Priam walks in unseen (a god's last gift), and the recognition is staged in gestures before any word: knees clasped, and the kiss — "the terrible, man-slaughtering hands that had killed so many of his sons" (χεῖρας δεινὰς ἀνδροφόνους): the fixed epithet of Hector's hands, then Achilles', pressed now to a father's lips. Then the simile that turns the world over: as when a man who has killed someone in his own country arrives in exile at a rich man's hall, "and wonder holds all who see him" — the innocent suppliant king compared to a murderer, the killer cast as the startled host. The reversal is the scene's meaning: guilt and grief have changed places so many times in this poem that only an exchanged simile can measure the moment. "And the others wondered too, and looked at one another" — the poem's people, like its audience, checking that everyone is seeing this.
- 16 *ll. 486-507* The plea. "Remember your father" — the argument Hermes assigned and Priam perfects: Peleus, same age, same encircling enemies — but with hope, because his son lives; "But I am doomed to the last": fifty sons, nineteen from one womb, and the guardian of all of them killed "days ago, fighting for his fatherland: Hector" — the name held back to the end of its clause. Then the two lines on which the Iliad closes its account

of what humans can do: "I have endured what no other mortal on earth has yet endured — to lift to my lips the hand of the man who killed my son." Endurance — Apollo's τλητὸν θυμόν of line 49 — performed past its imaginable limit.

- 17 *ll. 507-518* The weeping. Priam's words stir in Achilles "the desire to weep for his father" — grief answering grief by way of substitution — and the poem's quietest, deepest sentence: "the two of them remembered: the one wept long and sore for man-slaughtering Hector, huddled at Achilles' feet, and Achilles wept for his own father — and now again for Patroclus; and the sound of their mourning filled the house." Two men weeping for different dead in one sound: shared mourning without shared objects — the only communion the Iliad believes in, and enough. When it is spent, Achilles lifts the old man up by the hand, "pitying the grey head and the grey beard" — the exact grey head and beard Priam foresaw defiled by his own dogs (22.74): the image returns, and is pitied instead.
- 18 *ll. 518-553* The consolation of the jars. Achilles' speech is the poem's theology spoken by its protagonist: "this is the way the gods have spun it for wretched mortals: to live in grief. And they themselves are free of care." Two jars on Zeus's floor — evils and blessings — and only two possible mixtures: mixed, or purely evil. No mortal draws unmixed good; the best life alternates. The proofs are the two fathers in the room: Peleus — wealth, kingship, a goddess-wife — and one doomed son who gives him "no care in his old age"; Priam — wealth and sons from Lesbos to the Hellespont — and this. The counsel is Apollo's from line 49, now spoken by the man it indicted: "Bear it... you will not raise him up." Achilles has become the teacher of the endurance he could not practice; saying it to Priam is how he begins to practice it.
- 19 *ll. 552-573* The flash of the old fire: Priam pushes — no chair while Hector lies uncared-for — and Achilles darkens: "Do not provoke me now, old man... or I may not spare even you... suppliant though you are, and may trespass against the commands of Zeus." The rage is not cured; it is contained, and knows itself. That self-knowledge — Achilles managing his own danger like a man banking a fire — is what makes the mercy trustworthy: the poem does not sentimentalize its hero into safety; it shows him holding himself, barely and deliberately, on the right side of the line. "And the old man was afraid, and obeyed."
- 20 *ll. 574-597* The ransoming, managed with the same self-knowledge: the body washed and anointed away from Priam's sight, "lest the grief in his heart not master his anger... and Achilles' own spirit be stirred, and he kill him" — mercy engineering its own conditions. Then Achilles himself lifts Hector onto the bier: the hands that dragged him now carry him — the body given back by the same strength that destroyed it. And the apology to Patroclus, with its scrupulous accounting ("the ransom he gave was not unworthy — and I will give you your share"): even now, the dead friend is a partner whose consent matters, and the transaction must be squared with the grave.
- 21 *ll. 598-622* Niobe. The paradigm is chosen with terrifying precision: the mother of twelve dead children "remembered food" — therefore eat. Inside it, the poem's darkest wonder-tale: nine days the children lay in blood "and there was no one to bury them: the son of Cronos had turned the people to stones. On the tenth day the gods of heaven buried them" — a world petrified by grief until heaven itself performs the funeral; and Niobe on

Sipylus, "stone though she is, she broods on the griefs the gods gave her" (614-617 were athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus — the mourner turned mountain, weeping forever, kept here). Eating, in this logic, is not the end of grief but the body's assent to go on being mortal: Niobe ate; Achilles ate (24.475-476; 19's fast long broken); now Priam must. The shared meal is the sacrament of the enduring heart.

- 22 *ll. 623-635* The meal and the gaze. Achilles slaughters, his companions dress, Automedon serves, Achilles portions — the host's offices performed in full for the father of his enemy. And then the poem's most humane astonishment: "Priam marveled at Achilles — how big he was, how beautiful: like the gods to look upon; and Achilles marveled at Priam... And when they had taken their fill of looking at each other" (the verb of satiety the book has used for grief and food now given to sight). Two men who have destroyed each other's lives sit and behold each other as marvels. It is the closest the Iliad comes to peace: not reconciliation, not forgiveness — just the full, mutual, unhurried sight of another human being.
- 23 *ll. 636-660* Priam's first sleep-request since his son died ("my eyes have never closed... I have done nothing but groan"), and his first food ("Before this I had touched nothing" — his fast ending in the same hut where Achilles' ended). Achilles' bed-arrangement comes "with an edge in his voice" (ἐπικερτομέων): sleep outside, lest a wandering Achaean councilor see you and Agamemnon "delay the release of the body" — the grim comedy of a mercy that must be hidden from its own army, and a last flick at the king he quarreled with. Then the question no one could have predicted in Book 22: "how many days do you need for the burial of brilliant Hector?"
- 24 *ll. 661-678* The truce: nine days of mourning, the tenth for burial and the feast, the eleventh for the mound — "and on the twelfth we will fight again — if we must" (εἴ περ ἀνάγκη; the war resumed as necessity, not appetite; no one in this room wants it anymore). Achilles grants it with the book's definitive gesture: he takes the old man's right hand "at the wrist, so his heart should not be afraid" — the killer's hand as guarantee of safety. And then, in one clause with no comment: "and fair-cheeked Briseis lay beside him." The woman the wrath began over is home; Thetis's counsel (130-132) is kept; the poem's first quarrel closes in a domestic sentence.
- 25 *ll. 679-695* Hermes' midnight warning turns the ransom grammar around — "for you — alive — your sons left behind would pay three times as much": Priam himself is the last treasure in the camp — and the departure crosses "the ford of the fair-flowing river, eddying Xanthus, whom immortal Zeus begot": the register's line (14.433-434 = 21.1-2), at its third and last station. Hector was revived at this ford; the rout was split here; now his body crosses it homeward. Hermes leaves at the boundary; Dawn in her saffron robe spreads over the whole earth; the poem's last day begins.
- 26 *ll. 696-724* Cassandra — her only appearance in the poem's action, "like golden Aphrodite" — is Troy's watcher now (climbing Pergamus as Priam climbed the tower), and her cry is the city's whole relation to Hector in one sentence: "come and see Hector — if ever, while he lived, you rejoiced when he came home from battle." The gate-scene reprises Book 22's discovery in the key of ritual — wife and mother first, hands on his head — and Priam's crowd-order ("you may glut yourselves with weeping — when I have brought him home") is grief marshaled into procession. The bed, the singers, the

antiphony: at last, the apparatus of proper mourning around the body that was promised to dogs.

- 27 ll. 725-749 Andromache's lament — holding "the head of man-slaughtering Hector in her hands": the epithet of the killing hands (479, 509) given now to the head a widow cradles; the poem's fiercest word gentled by its final position. Her lament is all future tense: the child who "will not reach manhood," the city sacked, the ships, the slavery — and the alternative she imagines for Astyanax, flung from the wall by an Achaean avenging what "Hector killed — his brother, or his father, or his son": the fate the tradition indeed assigns him, spoken here as a mother's reasoned dread. Her last grievance is the tenderest in the poem: "you did not die in bed, reaching your arms to me, you spoke no close last word that I might have remembered always" — not the death, but the missing goodbye.
- 28 ll. 750-763 Hecuba's lament is a theodicy: her sold sons (Samos, Imbros, "Lemnos of the smoke") against this one, killed, dragged — "though not even so did he raise him up" (the futility of the outrage stated by the victim's mother) — and yet lying "dewy-fresh, as if newly slain, like one whom Apollo of the silver bow has visited and killed with his gentle arrows." The gods' care, which Hermes reported to Priam in the dark, is now visible in Troy by torchlight: the body itself has become the proof that heaven loved him.
- 29 ll. 764-779 Helen's lament, third and last — the poem's final speech given to the woman the war was fought over. Twenty years from home, and her praise of Hector is the smallest and most exact in the three laments: "never once did I hear from you an evil word, or a slighting one" — and when others reviled her, "you would turn them aside... with your gentle-mindedness and your gentle words." She mourns him as the last kindness in Troy — "there is no one else now in wide Troy gentle to me, or kind: they all shudder at me" — so that the poem's cause weeps for the poem's best man as her only friend. The crowd's groan answers her: the city, for one moment, grieving with the woman it shudders at.
- 30 ll. 780-804 The ending: the truce honored (wood gathered nine days under Achilles' pledge), the pyre, rosy-fingered Dawn, the wine-quench and white bones — the rites following, step for step, the liturgy of Patroclus's funeral in Book 23: the two enemies buried by the same book of rites. The bones in the golden box, the soft purple robes, the hollow grave roofed with great stones, the mound raised quickly with watchers posted (grief efficient under threat — the war visible at the edges of the funeral), and the feast "in the house of Priam, the king nurtured of Zeus." Then the last line: "So they busied themselves with the burial of Hector, the tamer of horses" — the poem of wrath ends with no death, no fall, no victory: with rites performed, a feast eaten, and a single dead man given his due — the γέρας θανόντων Achilles named at 23.9. Everything else — Achilles' death, the horse, the sack, the fates Andromache numbered — stands just outside the final line, known to every hearer and refused entry. (Antiquity's rhapsodes felt the door ajar: a variant continuation ran "So they busied themselves with the burial of Hector; and there came the Amazon, the daughter of great-hearted Ares..." — splicing the epic onward into the Aethiopis. Our text ends where the poet ended: on the funeral, the feast, and the name of the man the city buried.) The Iliad begins with a father begging a king for his child and being refused; it ends with a father begging a king for his

ILIAD — BOOK 24

child and being answered. That is the distance the poem travels; the wrath of Achilles is the space between.

THE TRANSLATOR'S NOTES ON THE BOOKS

The translator's note on each book, gathered here so that the poem itself is not interrupted.

BOOK 1

This translation aims at plain, dignified modern English free verse, kept line-for-line with the Greek of the Monro-Allen text, so that any English line can be checked against its original. It follows the printed text throughout, including passages that ancient critics athetized (marked as spurious but retained); atheteses are recorded in the notes, not acted on. Where the printed text itself embodies an editorial choice against the manuscript majority — most strikingly at 1.350, where it reads "boundless sea" where nearly all manuscripts have the famous "wine-dark sea" — the note says so.

The poem's first word, *mēnis*, is rendered "wrath" rather than "rage" or "anger": *mēnis* in Homer is not a mood but a durable, quasi-divine cosmic grudge, and English "wrath" carries the required archaic, more-than-human weight. The other load-bearing terms of the quarrel are kept consistent so their economy stays visible: *timē* is always "honor," *geras* always "prize" (the concrete, publicly awarded object in which honor is embodied — Chryseis, Briseis), and *atē* "blindness" (the god-sent ruin-bringing delusion Agamemnon will later plead). The quarrel of Book 1 is unintelligible unless the reader can see that Achilles' complaint is not about a woman but about the public arithmetic of honor; the vocabulary is kept rigid for that reason.

Recurring epithets are translated by fixed English equivalents ("swift-footed Achilles," "white-armed Hera," "the lord of men Agamemnon"), footnoted at first occurrence only, and entered in the translator's register as binding for later books. Fixity is deliberate: the epithets are load-bearing oral formulas, and varying them for elegance would erase exactly the texture that makes them Homeric. Proper names use familiar Latinized spellings (Achilles, Ajax, Clytemnestra), also logged there.

On the one disputed passage of Book 1 (1.4-5): Zenodotus athetized both lines, and his text is reported to have read *daita*, making the corpses a "feast" for the birds. The translation follows the vulgate ("prey for dogs / and every bird"), keeping the grim literal image rather than the sardonic "banquet"; the opening sentence is already as harsh as English can decently make it, and the "feast" reading, though grotesquely apt, rests on a single reported reading of doubtful standing. See note 3.

One grammatical crux, at 1.291: *protheousin* is taken here as a form of *protithēmi* ("set forth, grant"), and the translation follows that parse ("do they therefore give him leave to hurl insults?"); the rival parse is recorded in note 25.

BOOK 2

Book 2 falls into two very different halves — the night-intrigue, failed test, and Thersites scene (1-493), and then the Catalogue of Ships with its Trojan counterpart (494-877) — and the main book-wide decision here was how to handle the second half. The Catalogue has been suspected since antiquity's critics and modern Analysts alike of being an originally independent composition, and several manuscripts omit the span entirely (see note 20). I have translated it as fully integral, and deliberately kept its litany register rather than flattening it into a gazetteer: one English line per Greek line as elsewhere, every place-epithet translated ("Thisbe of the many doves," "rocky Aulis"), leader-genealogies given their full ceremonial weight. The incantatory repetition of the ship-count refrains ("With him followed forty black ships") is preserved exactly where the Greek repeats and varied only where the Greek varies. The little narrative windows that open out of the list — Thamyris maimed by the Muses, Protesilaus' half-built house, Philoctetes on Lemnos, Nireus beautiful and negligible — are the Catalogue's own pulse, and the notes flag them rather than the geography.

The other live decision was tonal: Odysseus' two-tier crowd control (kings get "gentle words," commoners get the scepter across the back). Aristarchus athetized 193-197, and the passage is independently missing from Xenophon's quotation of the scene (note 11); I translate as printed and let the class asymmetry stand at full strength, since Thersites' beating immediately afterward depends on it. Thersites himself I have kept rough — "endless babble," "word-slinging insulter" — because the poem's own verdict on him is rough; this is the one place in the *Iliad* where the army's laughter is turned on a named common soldier, and softening it misrepresents the scene.

Zenodotus is unusually active in this book: he condensed the Dream's triple-repeated message (notes 4), athetized Agamemnon's *atē*-speech (11-118, note 7), the Thersites portrait-lines, the Nireus anaphora (note 26), and the Achilles-passage inside the Catalogue (note 27). As in Book 1, the translation follows the printed vulgate text throughout and records *atheteses* in the notes.

Two carried-over threads from Book 1 to watch: Agamemnon here blames his quarrel with Achilles on Zeus-sent *atē* ("blindness," 111, and openly "it was I who began the anger," 378) — the same vocabulary Achilles used of him at 1.412; and the Catalogue's

Achilles-paragraph (686-694) holds the plot's tension in place mid-list. New recurring epithets are footnoted at first occurrence and entered in the register; the famous crux at 318 (did the god make the serpent-portent "conspicuous" or "invisible"?) is note 14, and the Salamis couplet with its ancient forgery accusation is note 23.

BOOK 3

Book 3 reads like the war's first year transplanted into its tenth: a duel between the two men the whole war is about, a truce, and Helen naming the Achaean commanders for Priam as though he had never seen them in nine years of siege. Ancient and modern critics alike noticed the chronological strain; the poem plainly does not care, and the translation does not try to smooth it. What the book actually does is introduce the war's cause and cast in the most economical way possible, and it is built almost entirely out of formal, ceremonial speech — challenge, herald's summons, oath, prayer, curse. Those registers are rendered with deliberate stiffness (the oath-language especially), because Book 9's embassy and later truce scenes will reuse them; the conventions are entered in the register.

One idiom is kept literal as a matter of policy: ὄρκια τέμνειν, "to cut oaths" — from cutting the victims' throats — is translated "cut the sworn oaths" throughout, not softened to "swear a treaty." The whole oath scene (hair distributed to the chief men, wine poured as the curse names the perjurers' spilled brains, the lambs' throats cut with the same knife) is a single ritual gesture, and the verb carries it.

Paris is called both Ἀλέξανδρος and Πάρις by the poem, with Ἀλέξανδρος predominating; the translation reproduces whichever name the Greek uses in each line rather than normalizing to "Paris" (see note 2). Helen's voice is this book's discovery: her self-lacerating "dog-face that I am" (note 13), the elders' hushed astonishment, and the confrontation in which she — alone of mortals in the Iliad — talks back to a god to her face and is crushed into obedience (notes 22-24). Aristarchus athetized both that confrontation and her bitter speech to Paris; Zenodotus rewrote the line in which Aphrodite carries her a chair. The ancient editors were visibly uncomfortable with exactly the scenes a modern reader values most, and the notes record each intervention while the translation keeps the vulgate text intact.

The apparatus also preserves, at line 302, four "plus verses" found in a Ptolemaic papyrus but absent from the medieval manuscripts — a live specimen of the pre-Aristarchean fluidity of the text (note 19).

BOOK 4

Book 4 contains the poem's moral pivot — the gods deliberately engineer the breaking of a sworn truce — and its first battle. The divine council that opens the book is the darkest divine politics in the *Iliad*: Zeus proposes peace (perhaps in earnest, perhaps as bait), Hera offers him her own three dearest cities, Argos, Sparta, and Mycenae, to destroy at will in exchange for Troy's ruin, and Zeus concedes with the unforgettable "willingly — with unwilling heart." Aristarchus athetized the sharpest couplet of Hera's speech (55-56; note 3), but the transaction stands in the text: the war resumes because two gods trade cities like counters. I have translated the scene coldly, without softening the horse-trading tone, because the Pandarus scene that follows — Athena talking a fool into perjury his whole people will pay for — is its direct execution.

This is also the book where the poem's combat idiom begins, and the conventions set here bind the remaining twenty books (all entered in the register): death formulas rendered fixed and unvarying ("darkness covered his eyes"; "he fell with a thud, and his armor clattered upon him"; "unstrung his limbs"), wound anatomy kept clinically precise as the Greek keeps it, and the armor vocabulary settled (ζωστήρ "war-belt," ζῶμα "loin-guard," μίτρη "waist-guard"). The first man to die in the *Iliad* is Echepolus at 457 (note 22); the first extended pathos-vignette is Simoeisios at 473-489 (note 23), the young man felled like a poplar cut for a chariot-wheel, who "never paid back the cost of his rearing" — the template for a hundred deaths to come.

Agamemnon's inspection tour (the *epipōlēsis*, 223-421) is the book's long character study: honeyed words for Idomeneus and the Ajaxes, wistful respect for Nestor, and gratuitous insults for Odysseus and Diomedes — both unearned, both answered in ways that define each man (Odysseus with hot dignity, Diomedes with a silence that will pay out in Book 9). The rebuke of Diomedes drags in the Theban saga (notes 18, 19) — the *Iliad*'s fullest glance at the war of the previous generation, and Sthenelus's retort ("we took seven-gated Thebes; our fathers died of their own recklessness") was athetized by Aristarchus, perhaps for its flat contradiction of Agamemnon's point.

BOOK 5

Book 5 is the poem's first *aristeia* — the sustained blaze of a single hero — and its most theologically audacious book: a mortal wounds two gods, and the poem takes the wounds seriously enough to invent divine physiology for them (ichor, "for they eat no bread," note 16) and divine medicine (Paiëon and the rennet simile, notes 18, 43). The structure is a standing order and its two-stage release: Athena's instruction at 127-132 — fight no god except Aphrodite — governs the first half; her revocation at 825-834 licenses the second. Diomedes is exactly as obedient as the order requires,

which is what separates his god-fighting from hybris: when Apollo warns him off with the poem's theology compressed into one couplet ("never of one kind / are the race of immortal gods and of men who walk the earth," 441-442, note 21), he yields at the fourth rush. That three-times-then-the-fourth pattern is planted here for its terrible recurrences later in the poem.

The book's gods are physical to the point of comedy, and the translation does not tone it down: the chariot axle groans under Athena's weight (athetized by Aristarchus, note 39), Ares bellows like ten thousand men and then whimpers to his father, and Zeus's rebuke of him (889-891) repeats verbatim the words Agamemnon flung at Achilles in Book 1 — "most hateful to me are you... strife is always dear to you, and wars, and battles" — the poem's own judgment on the war-god delivered in a mortal quarrel's language (note 42). Dione's consolation of the wounded Aphrodite (382-404) reaches back to older, stranger myth — Ares thirteen months in a bronze jar, Hera and Hades shot by Heracles — and Dione herself, Aphrodite's mother here, contradicts the Hesiodic foam-birth (note 17).

Two continuity matters are recorded rather than smoothed: Pylaemenes, killed at 576, will reappear alive in Book 13 — the most famous authorial nod in the poem (note 26) — and the Ortilochus/Orsilochus spellings at 542-549 follow the printed text's own variation. New fixed epithets are registered for Ares ("bane of mortals," "blood-stained," "rushing," "brazen") and for the book's one-off divine names (Cypris, Enyo, Païëon, the Seasons). The formula checker has been extended to cover the Ares set.

BOOK 6

Book 6 is the poem's great turn inward: the battle continues offstage while Hector walks through his city — mother, brother, sister-in-law, wife, son — and every meeting is a farewell taken in advance. The book's engineering is visible and unbearable at once: Athena refuses Troy's prayer in a single line ("But Pallas Athena turned her head away," 311 — athetized by Aristarchus, kept here as the bleakest line in the poem), Hector answers Andromache's plea with the same verbatim prophecy Agamemnon spoke as a threat in Book 4 ("the day will come when holy Ilion shall perish," 448-449 — an echo the translation reproduces word for word), and the household mourns Hector alive before he has died (500-502). Against all this the poem sets its one scene of family comedy — the baby screaming at his father's helmet crest, and both parents laughing (466-474).

The Glaucus-Diomedes encounter (119-236) — which some ancient critics wanted to transpose elsewhere in the poem (note 6) — carries the book's other cargo: the

generation-of-leaves simile, the Bellerophon story with the poem's only reference to writing (the "baneful signs... in a folded tablet," note 10), and the guest-friendship that stops a duel and ends in the proverbial exchange of gold armor for bronze.

Two register events. First, the δμῶς policy adopted from the Odyssey project goes live: δμῶαί is rendered "slave-women" at its first occurrences (6.323, 375-376, note 21), with ἀμφίπολος "handmaid" and ταμίη "housekeeper" kept distinct — the vocabulary of the household the book itself is about, in the book where Hector imagines Andromache's "day of slavery" (463). Second, Agamemnon's atrocity-counsel at 55-60 (kill even the unborn) is followed by the narrator's much-disputed half-line "for his urging was of things due" (αἵσιμα παρειπών) — translated at face value and flagged in note 3, where the interpretive dispute belongs.

BOOK 7

Book 7 is the poem's book of institutions. Its duel replays Book 3 with the war's real fighters — and the poem says so in its own medium: the spear-exchange at 244-254 reuses the Paris-Menelaus lines of 3.355-360 verbatim, and this translation repeats its own Book 3 English word for word (note 16). Around the duel stand the machinery of managed violence: the challenge with terms for the corpse, the marked lots, the heralds parting the fighters at dusk ("It is good to yield to night as well"), the exchange of gifts — Hector's sword and Ajax's belt, on which later tradition hung both their deaths (note 20) — the burial truce, the diplomatic offer and its refusal, and at last the wall and ditch that will be the stage-set of Books 8-15.

The wall carries the book's strangest scene: Poseidon's complaint that the Achaeans built it "and gave the gods no glorious hecatombs," and Zeus's answer licensing its future erasure — sweep it into the sea, hide the beach under sand again. All three Alexandrian critics athetized the exchange (443-464), and it is easy to see why it unsettled them: the poem pauses to arrange the demolition of its own scenery, as if to certify that no trace of the fiction will contradict the visible coastline (note 27; the demolition is narrated at 12.13-33). Nestor's proposal that each man's bones be carried "home to the children" (334-335) was also athetized — the custom looks Athenian, not Homeric — and Antenor's motion to hand Helen back completes the pattern of a book in which every institution for ending the war is tried and fails (notes 22, 23).

Small register notes: αἵσιμα παρειπών, the disputed narratorial phrase from the Adrestus scene (6.62), recurs at 120-121 in a context where it is plainly benign — evidence worth weighing back into that dispute. Poseidon "the earth-shaker" enters the register, with "green fear," the "bronze-greaved" hapax at 41, and the slave-trade

line at 475 — the only occurrence of ἀνδράποδα in Homer, athetized by all three critics, and rendered "slaves" as a matter of policy (note 28).

BOOK 8

Book 8 exists to reverse the war's flow and set up everything that follows: Zeus takes the field-glass seat on Ida, forbids divine interference on pain of Tartarus, tips his golden scales, and by nightfall the Trojans — for the first time in ten years — are camped in the open plain. Ancient critics disliked the book intensely (its nickname was "the docked battle"), and the apparatus shows the highest athetesis-density of any book so far: the golden-cord boast, Zeus's smiling "I am not in earnest," the four named horses, Andromache's fodder, the whole Iris relay, the Heracles digression, and even the shepherd's gladness in the watchfire simile all drew critical daggers. This translation keeps the printed text entire and records each mark; what the critics read as padding largely reads now as the book's system: everything in it — the cord, the scales, the thunder repeated three times, the prophecy — performs Zeus's singular, uncontested weight.

Two disclosures anchor the book. At 475-478 Zeus names the plot of the rest of the poem: Hector will not stop "until the swift-footed son of Peleus rises beside the ships... over Patroclus fallen" — the first explicit statement of Patroclus's death, delivered as decree eight books before the event (note 26). And at 161-166 stands the one passage of this book on the list of disputed lines: Hector's taunt to Diomedes ("you were a woman after all... painted doll"), athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus, with Zenodotus's variant close (note 10). The book ends on the poem's most famous nocturne — the watchfires like stars around the moon, the shepherd glad at heart (a gladness Zenodotus deleted), a thousand fires, fifty men at each, and the horses waiting for Dawn (notes 30, 31).

Repetition discipline mattered here: the Athena arming scene reuses Book 5's lines and this translation's Book 5 English verbatim; Iris relays Zeus's threat word for word and adds one line of her own venom; and the Hera-Athena murmuring scene repeats 4.20-24 exactly. New register entries: saffron-robed Dawn, "much-enduring brilliant Odysseus" (first Iliad occurrence, in the awkward scene where he fails to hear Diomedes — note 7), the golden scales, and "fair-throned Dawn" closing the book.

BOOK 9

Book 9 is the poem's hinge and its greatest sustained writing: the offer that should end the wrath, and the answer that reveals the wrath has outgrown its cause. The book's architecture is a series of descents. The gift-catalogue is spoken three times —

by Agamemnon with its poison pill ("let him yield to me by as much as I am more kingly," 158-161), by Odysseus verbatim but with the poison silently cut (note 20), and back through Achilles' contempt. And Achilles' three answers step downward: to Odysseus, "tomorrow I sail"; to Phoenix, "at dawn we will decide"; to Ajax, "I fight when Hector reaches my own ships" — which is, of course, exactly what he will do. Odysseus then reports only the first answer (note 41), and Diomedes closes the book with the truest sentence in it: he will fight "whenever the heart in his chest commands him, and the god rouses him."

All three curated disputes for this book are handled in place. The dual verbs of 182-198 (disputed #5) are translated as duals — "the two of them went" — with the crux laid out in note 15. The "gates of Hades" lines (312-313, disputed #6) and their contested referent are note 21. And the famous four lines in which Phoenix contemplated killing his father (458-461) are physically absent from the printed Monro-Allen text — the numbering jumps 457 to 462 — athetized by Aristarchus for their content and preserved only through Plutarch; the translation reproduces the gap, and note 32 supplies the missing lines so the reader loses nothing but the illusion that the text was ever whole.

Watch also: Achilles heard singing "the fames of men" — the poem's only image of epic performed, by its own hero, on a lyre looted from Andromache's city (note 16); the demolition of the honor-economy at 318-321; the two fates and "imperishable fame" (410-416); the Litai allegory (note 34); and the Meleager paradigm, at whose center sleeps a wife named Cleopatra — Patroclus's name reversed — while Patroclus sits listening (note 35). Register notes: 18-25 reuse the Book 2 English verbatim, now spoken in earnest; ἄττα "old father" joins the vocatives; δμῳαί "slave-women" appears twice more under the policy.

BOOK 10

Book 10 is the Iliad's night. Nothing in it happens by daylight rules: the arming is in animal skins, the omens are heard rather than seen, the fighting is throat-cutting among sleeping men, and the one killing that follows a supplication does not even wait for the suppliant to finish his sentence. It is also the only book of the Iliad whose right to be in the poem has been disputed since antiquity (curated dispute #8): a scholion reports that "this rhapsody was arranged separately by Homer and not counted part of the Iliad, but was placed into the poem by Pisistratus." Aristarchus kept it; Analysts have excised it; its defenders answer that the ambush (the lochos) is an ancient heroic theme with its own conventions — leaders' fear, borrowed gear, beast- skins, two-man teamwork — which this book executes with complete control,

and that the poem's long day of Books 11-18 needs precisely this restorative night between the Embassy's failure and disaster. The internal evidence cuts both ways: the diction has an Odyssean cast (the bathing-tubs of 576 and the whistle of 502 occur nowhere else in the Iliad; Athena tells Diomedes to "think of your return"), and nothing in the book — Rhesus, his marvelous horses, Dolon's intelligence — is ever mentioned again in the poem. Our policy is unchanged: the printed text is translated entire, and the argument lives in the notes (1, 39, 43).

What the book is, read on its own terms, is a study in symmetry. Two sleepless kings; two councils held in the dark, each seated in the other's killing-ground (note 13); two spies sent out in the same hour with twinned volunteer-speeches (note 25) — but one side sends its best two men for a black ewe apiece, and the other sends its worst man alone, for a promise of Achilles' horses that was never Hector's to give. The interrogation runs on the courteous formulas of guest- conversation with a corpse at the end of it (note 29); the thirteenth Thracian killed matches the "thirteenth" scout in Odysseus's tally (note 42); and the book ends with the poem's only laughter after killing and its only hot bath — the night washed off before rosy- fingered dawn restores the day-world's rules.

Register notes: the boar's-tusk helmet pedigree returns the loot of Phoenix's father's house (note 19); "when two go together" enters the proverb-stock (note 15); ἀλαοσκοπή "no blind man's watch" is fixed for Books 13-14; ἄτη "blindness" shrinks to fit Dolon (note 30); and 10.199 reuses our 8.491 verbatim, as the Greek does.

BOOK 11

Book 11 opens the longest day in poetry: the sun that rises from Tithonus's bed in line 1 will not set until 18.239-242, seven and a half books from now, and Zeus dictates the day's whole shape in advance in his message to Hector (185-194): let Agamemnon rage; when he is wounded and mounts his chariot, Hector's hour begins, and runs until he reaches the ships and the sun goes down. What follows is a day of subtraction. Agamemnon's *aristeia* — the poem's first sight of the commander actually pre-eminent in battle — burns hot and short, and then the captains are removed one by one: Agamemnon by Coon's spear, Diomedes and Eurypylus and Machaon by Paris's arrows, Odysseus by Socus's thrust; by the book's end Ajax alone is left in the field, backing away like a beast, like a donkey — and the despised bow (note 29) has done most of the day's work.

The book's second half changes register entirely, and is the hinge of the whole epic. Achilles, watching the rout from his stern for pleasure, sees Nestor carry a wounded man past and sends Patroclus to ask the name — and the poet stamps the errand at

once: "he came out, the equal of Ares — and that was the beginning of his evil" (604). In Nestor's hut the plan is invented that Patroclus will repeat at the opening of Book 16: let Achilles send you out in his own armor (794-803, largely athetized in antiquity — see notes 42-43). Nestor's enormous Pylian reminiscence (656-762) earns its length as paradigm — the young Nestor fought although his father forbade him and hid his horses; Achilles, able, withholds — and closes on the saddest line the old man speaks: "Such was I among men — if ever I was." Patroclus, running back, is detained by the wounded Eurypylus and stays to cut out the arrow: the book ends with the gentlest man in the poem healing one wound while his own death is being prepared, and its last clause repeats, word for word, the drying of Agamemnon's wound at 267 — the day's first casualty and its last, rhymed.

The printed Greek genuinely lacks line 543 — the line Aristotle read, "for Zeus would be indignant with him, whenever he fought a better man" — and the translation reproduces the gap (numbering jumps 542 to 544), with the line translated in note 35. Register notes: the Muse-invocation reuses 2.484; 13-14 reuse 2.453-454 (athetized here as a wrongful repeat); 5-9 reuse the camp geometry of 8.222-226; Peleus's "always to be the best" repeats 6.208, our wording kept; and the cup of Nestor (632-637) meets the oldest joke in Greek epigraphy (note 38).

BOOK 12

The shortest book of the *Iliad* so far translated is also its most tightly built: a single military action — the storming of the Achaean wall — organized as a sequence of thresholds: ditch, gates, breastwork, bar; and at each threshold, a debate. Polydamas counsels leaving the chariots, and Hector accepts; Asius refuses, and the narrator files his death-notice in advance (note 7); Polydamas reads the eagle-and-snake omen and counsels retreat, and Hector answers with the most quoted line of the poem — "One bird-sign is best: to fight for your fatherland" (243) — an answer that is magnificent, politically immortal, and wrong (note 12). The book's crown is Sarpedon's speech to Glaucus (310-328), the classic statement of why kings fight — honor received obliges honor paid, and since death comes anyway, the only choice left is the manner — the exact contract whose repudiation by Achilles in Book 9 the poem has already staged (note 19).

The opening is unlike anything else in Homer: the narrator steps out of the story's time to tell how, after the war, Poseidon and Apollo turned eight rivers against the wall and erased it from the beach (3-35) — epic covering its own tracks, since no trace of the wall survived to be seen; the passage contains the poem's only "race of half-god men," the heroes seen for once from the far side of the gulf that separates them from

the audience (note 2). Equally unusual is the narrator's cry of overload at 176 — "hard for me to tell it all through, as though I were a god" — which ancient critics athetized, perhaps for its very humanity (note 10).

Throughout, the poet measures the widest war by the smallest peace: stones fall like snow muffling the works of men (note 16); the deadlock is two farmers with measuring-rods disputing a boundary (note 27); the balance of battle is an honest wool-worker's scale, held level "to win a pitiful wage for her children" (note 28). Then Hector lifts the stone two men of today could not shift, breaks the double gate, and leaps through "in his face the very likeness of swift night" — and the book ends inside the breach, the Danaans in rout among their ships, nothing resolved except the door.

Register notes: 12.96-97 reuse the Asius entry of the Catalogue (2.838-839) verbatim; the Lapiths keep their Book 2 epithets; "such as mortals are now" recurs twice (383, 449) in its fixed form; and Menestheus's message is relayed by the herald almost word for word (343-350 = 354-363) — the verbatim discipline of messengers, kept.

BOOK 13

Book 13 begins with a look and ends with a noise. Zeus, satisfied, turns his shining eyes away from Troy toward the far pastoral north — the mare-milkers and the Abioi, "most righteous of men" (note 1) — certain no god will dare interfere; Poseidon, watching from the peak of Samothrace, comes down in four strides, and the whole book runs on his stolen presence: a god working the Achaean line in borrowed shapes and voices, "in secret, always, up and down the army" — because Zeus is elder-born and knows more (note 15). The last line closes the frame: the clamor of both armies "reached the ether and the radiance of Zeus" — the battle he refused to watch arrives as sound (note 37).

Its centerpiece is the poem's one aristeia of a middle-aged man: Idomeneus of Crete, "half-grey," met coming back from a comrade's sickbed, talked into glory by a god, and given the book's most famous set-piece before he throws a spear — the anatomy of courage and cowardice in ambush, where the coward's color runs and his teeth chatter and the brave man's color never changes (note 12). His kills are the book's plot: Othryoneus, who bid for Cassandra with a promise instead of gifts (note 16); Asius, paying the death-notice filed in Book 12; and Alcatous, whom Poseidon freezes where he stands — the god holding the victim for the blow, the most terrible divine intervention in the poem (note 19).

Around the aristeia the book builds the day's resistance out of lists and low things: the locked phalanx where "shield pressed on shield, helmet on helmet, man on man"

(note 6); the defense roster with its Ionians (nowhere else in Homer) and its exiled homicide Medon; the Locrians who fight shoeless of honor, with bows and wool slings, unseen from behind (note 31); beans jumping from a winnowing-shovel; oxen sweating at one plow; a roped bull; a worm. Where Book 12 measured war by peace, Book 13 arms peace and sends it back in. Two wounds are planted for later books: Ascalaphus lies dead and his father Ares, penned on Olympus by Zeus's command, does not know it (note 23); and Harpalion's father walks weeping behind the bier — Pylaemenes, whom the poem killed in Book 5: the most famous inconsistency in Homer, which ancient critics solved with an athetesis and this translation keeps in the open (note 27).

Register notes: 13.769 reuses 3.39 ("Paris — evil Paris...") verbatim; 13.10 uses the fixed "kept no blind man's watch"; the phalanx lines are fixed for reuse at 16.215-217, the shipwright tree-fall for 16.482-484, and Medon's biography for 15.333-336.

BOOK 14

The Dios Apatē — the Deception of Zeus — is the Iliad's great comic interlude, and its comedy is engineering: every scene is a tool fetched for the next. Hera sees Poseidon working the lines and Zeus sitting on Ida (153-158); what follows is a bathing and dressing scene built exactly like an arming scene (note 9); a lie to Aphrodite that borrows the deep past — Oceanus "begetting of the gods" and mother Tethys quarreling — as cover story (note 10); the loan of the keston, the embroidered band that holds "love, and desire, and the trysting-talk — persuasion, that steals the wits even of the close-thinkers," a line Aristotle quoted (note 10); the recruitment of Sleep, who once before put Zeus under for Hera's sake and barely survived it — saved only by Night, "subduer of gods and men," the one power Zeus fears to displease (note 12); and the payment, negotiated upward from golden furniture to a Grace, sworn by Styx with one hand on the earth and one on the shining sea, the Titans under Tartarus called to witness (note 13).

The seduction itself is the poem at its most audaciously funny — Zeus woos his wife with a catalogue of seven prior conquests, mothers and offspring itemized, ending "not even you yourself, as I love you now" (317-328; ancient critics athetized the whole list as indecorous, note 16) — and then, without warning, at its most beautiful: the golden cloud, and the earth flowering beneath them, "dewy lotus, and crocus, and hyacinth, thick and soft, that held them up off the ground" — the sacred marriage older than the comedy, glittering dew falling from the cloud (note 18). Zeus sleeps; Sleep runs to Poseidon; and the last third of the book is the counterattack the nap purchases: the armor sorted by size to the men who can use it, Ajax's boulder

spinning Hector "like a top" and putting him, vomiting blood, out of the poem until Zeus wakes, and a chain of vaunts — grief answering grief — that ends with Ilioneus's head raised on a spear "like a poppy-head," the poem's own earlier poppy (8.306) grown monstrous (note 29).

The printed Greek lacks line 269 — the naming of Pasithea in Hera's offer, an addition in only part of the tradition; the numbering jumps 268 to 270, the line is translated in note 13, and Sleep names her anyway at 276: the third transmission-gap this translation reproduces (with 9.458-461 and 11.543). Register notes: 14.82-83 reuse 4.349-350 verbatim ("the fence of your teeth"); 14.508 reuses the fixed Muse-invocation; the ford-of-Xanthus formula (433-434) is laid down for reuse at 21.1-2.

BOOK 15

Book 15 is the great correction. Zeus wakes on Gargaron, sees the rout and Hector vomiting blood, and in three moves restores the poem's direction: Hera is terrorized with the memory of her punishment — hung from heaven with anvils at her ankles (note 2) — and swears the greatest oath in the poem, by Styx, his sacred head, and their bridal bed, a lawyer's truth that acquits her of Poseidon while saying nothing of the seduction (note 3); Iris carries an ultimatum to Poseidon, who answers with the three-way division of the cosmos — sea, murk, and sky by lot, "earth and Olympus common to all" — and yields only to the argument of the Erinyes who attend elder-born brothers (notes 8, 9); and Apollo, given the aegis, revives Hector and levels the ditch and wall "as when a boy by the sea heaps sand in his childish play and then, still playing, scatters it with his feet and hands" — the most devastating image of divine ease in epic, delivered, uniquely, as an apostrophe to the god himself (note 18).

At the center, before any of this, Zeus speaks the rest of the poem aloud (56-77, athetized in antiquity for that very completeness): Patroclus sent out, Sarpedon killed, Patroclus killed by Hector, Hector killed by Achilles, and after that the long Achaean tide "until they take steep Ilion through Athena's counsels" — all of it suspended from the promise to Thetis in Book 1 (note 4). From here forward the audience watches men choose what it has heard decreed. The narrator twice does the same on his own account: Zeus waits "to see with his eyes the flare of a burning ship," and Hector rages superb in his last full day of glory — "for he was to be short-lived: already Pallas Athena was speeding his death-day under the strength of Peleus' son" (610-614, which Zenodotus cut; note 30).

The fighting that fills the second half is the war at its narrowest: pikes on ship-decks, axes and swords at arm's length, Ajax striding from deck to deck with a twenty-two-cubit boarding pike like a trick-rider leaping between four horses (note 34). The

paired exhortations are the book's moral architecture: Hector's "it is no dishonor to die defending your fatherland — his wife is safe, his children after him" (494-499, quoted three centuries later by Lycurgus prosecuting an Athenian deserter, note 25) against Ajax's stripped-down answer to men who have no fatherland at their backs: "our light of safety is in our hands, not in any gentleness of war" (733-741, note 36). Patroclus, mid-book, finally leaves Eurypylus's hut quoting Nestor's own hope back to himself — the fatal errand resumes (note 21). The book ends with Hector's hand on the stern-horn of the ship that carried the war's first casualty, calling for fire, and Ajax on a seven-foot plank, counting his twelve.

Register notes: 15.263-268 reuse the stalled-horse simile of 6.506-511 verbatim, as the Greek does; 15.333-336 reuse Medon's biography from 13.694-697, at his death; 15.550-551 reuse 13.175-176 (the returned-exile lines); 15.563-564 reuse 5.531-532; 15.403-404 reuse Nestor's persuasion-couplet from 11.792-793, now in Patroclus's own mouth.

BOOK 16

Book 16 is the poem's pivot, and it knows it: the narrator turns eight times to address Patroclus by name — "you answered, Patroclus, horseman" — an intimacy of grammar shown to no one else in the *Iliad* (note 2). Every promissory note the epic has issued since Book 9 is called in. The dark-spring tears reuse Agamemnon's simile from 9.14-15; Patroclus repeats Nestor's plan of 11.794-803 nearly word for word, and the narrator stamps it before Achilles can answer: "So he spoke, begging — the great fool: it was his own death and evil doom he was begging for" (46-47, note 4). Achilles' consent comes wrapped in the conditions that will be violated one by one — drive them from the ships, then come back; do not push on toward Ilion, "lest one of the everlasting gods step in: the worker-from-afar, Apollo, loves them" (93-94) — the death spoken as a warning by the man who will mourn it (note 6). The Dodona prayer asks two things, and "the father granted one, and refused the other" (note 18).

At the center, the poem's theology pays its highest price. Zeus watches his son Sarpedon come against Patroclus and asks Hera whether he may save him; her answer — every god has sons in this war — holds the door of fate shut from inside, and the compromise is the poem's most beautiful invention: Sleep and Death, the twin brothers, to carry the body home to Lycia for tomb and grave-stone, "for that is the honor-right of the dead" (457, 675). Zeus consents and rains blood; Apollo washes the body in the river and hands it to the twins — the lines Zenodotus deleted and athetized, and the scene painted on the Euphronios krater three centuries later (notes 25, 35). Between father and corpse the poem sets its most pitiless couplet: the extra

hour of glory Zeus grants Patroclus is deliberated over his head like a sentence (note 34).

The death itself is built as an un-arming: Apollo, hidden in mist, strikes the flat-handed blow, and the arming-scene of line 130 runs backwards — helmet rolling under the hooves ("before this it was not lawful for that helmet to be fouled with dust"), spear shattered, shield down, corslet loosed by the god's own hands (note 41); then Euphorbus's dart from behind, and only third, Hector, into the belly. The dying prophecy counts the killers in order and adds Hector to the list of the dead (note 44); the soul-flight lines — "wailing its fate, leaving manhood and youth" — are fixed here for their verbatim return at 22.361-363, where Hector will speak a dying prophecy of his own. The book ends with Hector answering a corpse and the immortal horses, "the gods' shining gifts to Peleus," carrying Automedon out of his reach.

Register notes: 16.3-4 = 9.14-15; 16.36-45 c. 11.794-803 (16.44-45 = 11.802-803 exactly); 16.112 reuses the fixed Muse-invocation; 16.215-217 = 13.131-133; 16.482-484 = 13.389-391; 16.742-743 reuses the diver of 12.385-386; the apostrophe roll-call line (16.692-693) adapts the fixed "Whom first, whom last."

BOOK 17

Book 17 is the Iliad's longest tug-of-war: one dead man at the center, and the whole day's war reorganized around the question of who will hold him. The poem frames it in similes of guardianship and labor rather than glory — Menelaus over the body "as a mother- cow, lowing, stands over her first calf" (note 1); the corpse dragged this way and that "as men stretch a great bull's hide soaked in fat," the tanning-yard come to the battlefield (note 21); the rescue at last like mules hauling a ship-timber down a rocky path, the two Ajaxes behind it like a wooded ridge damming a flood (note 37). Against these stand the book's two heights of theology. Zeus watches Hector put on the stripped armor of Achilles and shakes his head: the gear "not taken by right," the power granted as *ποινή* — blood-price paid in glory to a man who will never come home from the battle, "nor will Andromache take from you the famous armor of Peleus' son" (notes 12, 13). And Zeus watches the immortal horses stand like a grave-stone, manes in the dust, weeping for their charioteer, and asks the poem's deepest question of his own gift: why did we give you to a mortal, "you who are ageless and deathless? Was it so that you too might have sorrows among unhappy men? For there is nothing anywhere more pitiful than man, of all things that breathe and creep upon the earth" (notes 25, 26).

The book's people are its second glory: Euphorbus dead with his Graces' hair in the blood and the olive-sapling simile that Pythagoras's biographers never stopped

quoting (note 4); Glaucus proposing to trade corpse for corpse, Patroclus for Sarpedon — bodies as the war's currency (note 10); the anonymous soldiers' paired vows (note 23); Antilochus struck speechless by the news he must carry (note 35); and Ajax, in the god-sent mist, making the request Longinus judged the most sublime in literature — not life, but light: "and in the light — kill us, since that is now your pleasure" (note 33).

Register notes: 17.63-64 reuse the lion lines of 11.175-176; 17.75-78 reuse the horses-of-Aeacus taunt of 10.402-404; 17.97 and 17.106 reuse the fixed soliloquy lines; 17.177-178 reuse 16.691-692; 17.454-455 reuse the sunset clause of 11.193-194; the reluctant lion of 17.657-664 reuses 11.550-555. Zenodotus's excision of 404-425 (Achilles' ignorance) and the athetized narrator's confession at 260-261 are noted in place.

BOOK 18

Book 18 is built from three scenes of making and unmaking: a man unmade by four lines of news; a night of vows over a washed body; and a god at his anvil making a world. The unmaking first: Antilochus delivers the catastrophe in the poem's most economical sentence — "Patroclus lies dead... naked; and Hector of the flashing helmet has the armor" — and Achilles pours soot on his head and lies down in the dust "mighty in his mightiness," the epitaph-line of Cebriones (16.776) settling on a living man, while Antilochus holds his hands "for fear he would cut his throat with the iron": the Iliad's only suicide watch (notes 2, 3). Thetis rises with all the Nereids — the catalogue of sea-names the ancients athetized and this translation keeps (note 4) — to mourn a son still alive; and in their exchange the poem reaches its hinge: "quick-fated then you shall be, child" — "Then let me die at once, since I could not defend my companion." Plato put the exchange at the center of the Apology; Socrates chose his death by quoting this one (note 8). With it comes the wrath's own retraction: "may strife perish from among gods and men, and anger — sweeter far than dripping honey, it swells like smoke in men's chests" (note 9).

The middle movement belongs to voice and light: the unarmed Achilles at the ditch, flame streaming from his head like the beacon of a besieged island city — the Achaeans' own situation made into his halo — killing twelve men with three shouts (note 11); Hera forcing the sun into Ocean to end the longest day of the poem (note 13); and, in the standing Trojan assembly, Polydamas's fourth and fatal counsel rejected — "Enyalios is impartial: he kills the would-be killer" — with the narrator's civic verdict on the applause (notes 14-16).

Then the Shield (478-608), which Zenodotus athetized entire and which is the reason the book is immortal: the cosmos; the city at peace with its weddings and its trial —

where the blood-price for a killed man is argued before elders, the very *ποινή* Achilles refused in Book 9, shown working (note 26); the city at war fighting this poem's own battle in miniature, Fate dragging the dead by the feet (note 27); the plowland turning black behind the plow "though it was made of gold" (note 28); the harvest, the vineyard with the boy singing the Linos-song, the lions on the bull, the dancing floor of Daedalus with its potter's-wheel simile and — kept in our printed text against Aristarchus's deletion — the divine singer himself, the poet inside his own artifact (note 33); and Ocean round the rim. A world of peace is forged as the equipment of revenge: the poem's whole argument, carried on one arm.

Register notes: 18.21 reuses 17.693; 18.200-201 reuse 16.42-43; Thetis's sapling-lament (56-62) recurs verbatim at 437-443, both kept identical; "quick-fated" continues 1.417; the slave-women, the fixed soliloquy frames, and the Book 1 "Most dread son of Cronos" line all recur in their registered forms.

BOOK 19

Book 19 is called the Renunciation of the Wrath, and its business is to close the quarrel that opened the poem — which it does in the strangest scene of public reconciliation in literature. Achilles, who now wants only to kill, renounces the wrath in nine lines and wishes Briseis — the girl the quarrel was about — had died before it started (note 6). Agamemnon answers seated, "not standing up in their midst" (the ancient editors were so unsettled that Zenodotus's text made him stand; note 8), and delivers not an apology but a theology: "I am not to blame: Zeus is, and Fate, and the Erinyes who walks in mist" — followed by the great parable of Ate, Blindness, the soft-footed eldest daughter of Zeus who walks on the heads of men, and whom Zeus himself, blinded over the birth of Heracles, hurled from heaven by her shining braids (notes 9, 10). Book 9's Blindness was "strong and sound of foot"; this register keeps the one English name so the two portraits can argue with each other. And Achilles accepts the theology — "Father Zeus, great is the blindness you deal to men!" — so the quarrel ends with both parties agreeing that nobody human did it (note 19). The gifts so bitterly itemized in Book 9 are carried into the middle of the assembly, and the man they were meant to persuade tells Agamemnon to give them or keep them as he pleases.

The book's real argument is between grief and the belly. Odysseus — "I was born first and know more things" — insists twice that armies cannot mourn fasting: his harvest of bronze, "where the bronze strews the most straw on the ground and the crop is smallest," and his terrible discipline: bury the dead "keeping a pitiless heart, weeping for one day" (note 16). Achilles refuses — "slaughter, and blood, and the hard

groaning of men" is the only food he wants (note 15) — and has to be fed like a wick, drop by drop, with nectar by Athena. Between the two positions stands the book's finest scene: Briseis, restored at last and given her only speech in the poem, keening over Patroclus who had promised to make her Achilles' wedded wife — "You were gentle, always" — while the narrator, in two lines as cold and true as anything in Homer, notes that the women wailed with her "for Patroclus in show; but each for her own sorrows" (note 20).

Then the arming — snowfall of helmets, the earth laughing at the lightning of bronze, the shield's light like a lonely mountain fire seen by sailors storm-driven away from their dear ones (the inverse of Book 18's rescue-beacon; note 25) — the Pelian ash only Achilles can swing (kept verbatim from Book 16, against Aristarchus; note 26), and the ending no other book has: the war-horse Xanthus, given voice by Hera, bows his head till his mane pours to the ground and tells his master he will die — "by a god, and by a man" — before the Erinyes shut his mouth. Achilles already knows. He says so, and drives.

Register notes: 19.2 = 11.2; 19.65-66 = 18.112-113; 19.78 = 2.110 ("squires of Ares"); 19.176-177 reuse the oath-wording of 9.133-134; 19.216 = 16.21; 19.224 = 4.84; 19.388-391 = 16.141-144; Ate is "Blindness" per 9.502-512; the gift-catalogue matches 9.122-130 item for item.

BOOK 20

Book 20 begins the single continuous battle — one afternoon long, four books wide — that runs from here to Hector's death. It opens with the poem's fullest divine mobilization: Themis summons every god to assembly, rivers and nymphs included (only Ocean stays home), and Zeus, whose ban of Book 8 kept the gods in the stands, now reverses it: go down, help whichever side you love. His reasons are the poem's theology in two lines: "they matter to me, even as they perish" — and the fear that Achilles, unchecked, "may storm the wall itself, ahead of what is fated" (note 2). Fate, it turns out, needs defending; that is what gods are for this afternoon. The mobilization produces the Iliad's greatest seismic picture — Zeus thundering above, Poseidon shaking the mountain roots below, and Hades leaping from his throne with a scream, lest the crust crack open and his "terrible, mouldering houses, which the very gods abhor" stand naked to the daylight (note 5) — and then, superbly, anticlimax: the gods pair off, look at one another, and sit down. The Theomachy is postponed to Book 21; what we get instead is men fighting under divine spectatorship.

The core of the book is the duel that cannot happen: Achilles against Aeneas — pushed into the ring by Apollo wearing the voice of Lycaon (whose own meeting with

Achilles, in Book 21, will be very different). Aeneas answers Achilles' magnificent taunting with the longest genealogy in the poem: Dardanus to Erichthonius — whose three thousand mares bore to the North Wind foals that ran over wheat-ears without breaking them — to Tros, to Ganymede taken up for his beauty, down the twin branches to Hector and to himself (note 15). It is a speech about why he cannot die here, and the poem agrees: when the boulder and the sword are about to decide it, Poseidon — a Greek partisan — saves Troy's enemy prince, because "it is destined for him to escape, so that the race of Dardanus not perish seedless": "the might of Aeneas shall be king over the Trojans — and his children's children" (note 19). The apparatus records the variant Strabo knew, "his race shall rule over all" — the reading Rome preferred; Virgil's epic grows out of this rescue. Hector too is saved — once by Apollo's word, once by Apollo's mist, after Athena turns his spear back with a breath — and Achilles' frustrated cry over him repeats, word for word, what Diomedes shouted at Hector in Book 11: "Dog! Again you have run out from under death" (note 29).

Everyone the gods do not save, dies. The book's last movement is the first panel of Achilles' *aristeia*, and this translation keeps its full brutality: Iphition's split skull and the chariots that shred him; Polydorus — Priam's youngest, forbidden the war, showing off his running — holding his own bowels; Tros of the refused supplication, "not a sweet-tempered man, not mild of mind" (the *litotes* that measures what Achilles has become; the theme will climax with Lycaon in 21 and Hector in 22); Deucalion beheaded with the marrow spurting from his spine. The closing similes — forest fire, and oxen threshing barley — end the book mid-carnage, blood on the axle, "spattering his invincible hands with gore": no cadence, because the *aristeia* has only begun.

Register notes: 20.196-198 reuse 17.30-32 ("When the thing is done, even the fool learns"); 20.449-454 = 11.362-367 verbatim; 20.431-433 repeat 20.200-202 (Aeneas's opening returned by Hector, kept identical); 20.287 "such as mortals are now"; 20.78 keeps 5.289's "Ares, the fighter under the ox-hide shield"; Ares borrows Hector's "flashing helmet" at 20.38 — the register's one loan of that epithet, as printed.

BOOK 21

Book 21 is the wildest book of the *Iliad* — the one where the fighting bursts every frame that holds it: ransom, river-banks, even the difference between the elements. It opens at the ford of Xanthus (the lines repeat 14.433-434, where the stunned Hector was laid at this same crossing: the river of Trojan refuge becomes the trap), where Achilles cuts the rout in two, drives half into the water, and wades in after them with

a sword — locusts before a grass-fire, fish before a dolphin. He takes twelve boys alive for Patroclus's pyre, collecting the vow of 18.336-337, and then meets Lycaon.

The Lycaon scene (34-135) is the moral center of the second half of the poem. The poem gives him the fullest biography of any minor figure — caught at night cutting fig-shoots for chariot-rails, sold to Lemnos, ransomed, home eleven days, and on the twelfth delivered by "the god" back into the same hands — precisely so that his death will be the death of the old economy: Achilles had sold him once, because "sparing was dearer to my heart"; now "Fool — offer me no ransom." What follows the refusal is the most quoted consolation in Greek literature, spoken with the spear raised: "So, friend — you die too. Why lament it so? Patroclus died, and he was a far better man than you... over me too stand death and strong fate: there will be a dawn, or an evening, or a midday..." (note 6). The word is φίλος — friend — and it is not irony: it is the fellowship of the doomed, which is the only fellowship Achilles has left. Lycaon opens his arms and takes the sword; the body goes to the fish, with a taunt that cancels every funeral rite the poem holds dear — and the river begins to be angry.

Asteropaeus, who fights with a spear in each hand and draws the only blood Achilles loses in the Iliad, dies over the argument his corpse then illustrates: rivers against Zeus. Achilles' boast descends the ladder — Zeus beats rivers; not even Achelous, "not even the great strength of deep-flowing Ocean, from whom all rivers and all the sea and all springs and deep wells flow," can face the thunderbolt. Zenodotus's text omitted the Ocean line, crowning Achelous the first of waters — the oldest recorded Greek quarrel about cosmology, sitting in our apparatus (note 10). Then the river itself has had enough: "my lovely streams are full of corpses... and you kill and kill." The battle with Scamander (233-382) is the poem's one war between a man and an element, and it strips Achilles to something no enemy has seen: running, outrun, wailing to Zeus that his mother lied, dreading the "wretched death" of a boy swept down a gully — death by water, without glory, without a grave. The river's threat makes that explicit in the poem's bitterest mock-burial: sand and shingle heaped so deep "the Achaeans will not know where to gather his bones... he will need no heaped tomb" (note 16). Rescue comes as plot: Poseidon and Athena, hand in hand, dictate the rest of the epic — pen the Trojans, kill Hector, take the glory — and Hera throws Hephaestus at the water. Fire drinks the plain; the riverside trees burn by name; eels tumble; the god of water surrenders while boiling "like a cauldron melting the lard of a fattened hog."

Then the Theomachy the poem has owed us since Book 20 — and it is played as comedy under one laughing spectator ("Zeus heard, sitting on Olympus, and his own heart laughed for joy"). Athena fells Ares with a boundary-stone and Aphrodite with a

fist; Hera boxes Artemis's ears with her own bow; Hermes politely forfeits to Leto; Artemis ends in Zeus's lap in tears. Only one exchange is in earnest: Poseidon reminds Apollo of Laomedon's cheat — the wall built for a wage never paid, the threatened ear-lobbing — and Apollo refuses combat with the most devastating thing any god says about us in the poem: mortals are not worth a fight, "who like the leaves now flourish in their blaze... and now wither heartless away" — Glaucus's leaf-simile of 6.146 returned from above, as contempt (note 24). The gods go home; Achilles remains — smoke of a burning city — and the book ends with Priam opening the gates, Agenor's lonely stand (the soliloquy where a frightened man discovers that Achilles too "has one life"), and Apollo in Agenor's shape running the fastest man alive across the plain, "always just a little ahead," while everything that is left of Troy's army pours inside the walls — everything except the man who will be standing outside them when the next book begins.

Register notes: 21.1-2 = 14.433-434; 21.374-376 repeat Hera's oath verbatim (= 20.315-317) — the river swears her own clause back at her; 21.69-70 keep 20.279-280's planted-spear wording; the twelve youths pay the vow of 18.336-337; "worker-from-afar," "bane of mortals," "blood-stained," "who showers arrows," and the death-formulas hold their registered forms.

BOOK 22

Everything in the poem has narrowed to this: one man outside the wall, "penned by deadly fate" at the Scaean Gates, and the whole apparatus of the epic — parents, gods, landscape, army, similes — arranged around the last hour of Hector. The book is built as three concentric scenes: the pleading (Priam and Hecuba from the tower); the running (three circuits of Troy); the killing and its consequences — and at each stage the poem does the thing only it would dare: it makes the terror specific. Priam does not simply fear death; he sees his own house-dogs — "the dogs I fed at my table, to keep my doors" — drinking his blood in the doorway, and states the poem's cruelest law of decorum: a young man dead in battle is seemly, "all things are beautiful on a dead young man"; it is the mauled grey head of an old one that is "the most pitiful thing there is for wretched mortals" (note 3). Hecuba answers with the bared breast that once quieted him — the body's own argument (note 4). Neither works, because Hector's real audience is neither parent: it is Polydamas ("who will be the first to lay reproach on me"), and behind him the nameless "worse man" of the streets. Shame, not courage, holds him at the gate — his soliloquy admits it in so many words — until Achilles is close, and then shame does what shame does under enough pressure: it collapses, and the best man of Troy runs (notes 6, 8).

The chase (136-213) is the greatest sustained passage of the poem, and its power is in what the runners pass: the lookout, the wind-blown fig, and the two springs of Scamander — one steaming, one ice-cold — "and there beside them are the wide washing-troughs, beautiful, of stone, where the Trojans' wives and their beautiful daughters used to wash their glistening clothes — in the old days, in peace, before the sons of the Achaeans came." Domestic memory set flush against the fact: "they ran for the life of Hector the horse-tamer" (note 9). Zeus proposes rescue; Athena answers him with the same rebuke Hera used over Sarpedon (179-181 = 16.441-443, kept verbatim); the gods themselves have a form-line for this argument, and it always ends the same way. The dream-simile — pursuer who cannot catch, quarry who cannot pull away — was athetized by Aristarchus and kept here (note 11); the golden scales dip; Apollo leaves; and Athena, wearing the face and "unwearying voice" of the brother Hector loves, commits the coldest act any god performs in the poem (note 13).

The duel is short because it was never a duel: it is the supplication theme played to its end. Hector offers a compact about corpses; Achilles answers with wolves and lambs — "there are no faithful oaths between lions and men" — and, when the throat is pierced and the dying man begs again, with the wish he could "hack your flesh away and eat it raw" (notes 15, 20). Hector dies prophesying — Paris and Phoebus Apollo at the Scaean Gates — exactly as Patroclus died prophesying Hector's own death, and the soul-flight couplet repeats 16.856-857 verbatim, as the Greek does: the poem's two great deaths are one death, twice (note 21). What follows — the ankle-thongs, the dragging, the head "that was once so beautiful" in its own country's dust — the narrator marks with the plainest sentence available: "Zeus gave him to his enemies to defile in his own fatherland."

And then the poem does what only the Iliad does: it leaves the victor, and goes inside. Priam rolling in dung, already planning the journey of Book 24 ("He too has a father like me — Peleus"); Hecuba's lament; and Andromache — who has heard nothing — at the loom, weaving flowers into a purple cloak, ordering the cauldron heated "for Hector, for his return out of the fighting. Poor innocent." She reaches the wall in time to see the dragging, and her fainting fling scatters the headdress Aphrodite gave her on her wedding day — the marriage undone garment by garment — before the great widow's lament, with the athetized orphan-passage (the child at the feast, lips wetted, palate dry) defended in note 31, and the last quiet horror: the fire she will feed with his unused clothes, "no use to you: you will not lie in them." The book ends on the women's answering wail — the sound Book 24 will finally be allowed to finish.

Register notes: 22.179-181 = 16.441-443; 22.361-363 = 16.855-857 (the soul-flight couplet, both kept verbatim); 22.365-366 reuse 18.115-116; "But why does my own

heart argue these things with me?" (122, 385) = 21.562; "gluts with his blood Ares, the fighter under the ox-hide shield" (267) keeps 5.289 = 20.78; "portion of fire" (343) keeps 15.350's wording; Hector's Polydamas-shame (99-107) answers 18.249-313 as registered; the fixed formulas (glaring darkly, flashing helmet, swift-footed, the scales) hold.

BOOK 23

Book 23 is the *Iliad*'s demonstration that civilization is a thing people do on purpose, the day after the worst thing in their lives. Its first movement is all night and fire: the Myrmidons' three circuits of the body, the funeral feast where "blood ran in cupfuls," Achilles' refusal to wash until the pyre is built (the fast of Book 19 still governing his body), and the visit of the ghost — Patroclus "in everything like himself, in stature and the beautiful eyes and the voice," standing above the sleeper's head with the poem's most quietly devastating reproach: "You sleep — and you have forgotten me, Achilles" (note 4). What the ghost asks for is administration: burial, quickly, so the other souls will let him across the river; and one thing more — "give me your hand: I am weeping" — which the living man cannot deliver: the embrace closes on nothing, and the soul goes down "like smoke... squeaking," leaving Achilles with the poem's plainest statement of its afterlife: "a soul and an image — but the wits are not in it at all" (note 5). Homer's dead are real enough to make requests and too thin to hold.

The pyre-sequence keeps every terrible ledger the poem has opened: the hair vowed to the river Spercheius given to the dead instead (the vow of homecoming formally cancelled, note 7); and the twelve Trojan youths of the vow of 18.336-337, killed with the narrator's own verdict attached — "and evil was the work his heart intended" — while, two lines later, the gods quietly begin Book 24: Aphrodite keeping the dogs from Hector with rose-oil, Apollo roofing the corpse with cloud (note 8). The winds must be fetched by Iris from a dinner-party to make the pyre burn; and over the all-night fire the poem sets its most terrible simile of grief: Achilles mourning "as a father mourns, burning the bones of his son, a bridegroom" (note 9).

Then the games — two-thirds of the book, and the poem's whole social philosophy in action. Every crisis of the *Iliad* recurs here in miniature, and every one is resolved: a dispute over a prize (Antilochus's foul and Menelaus's oath-challenge) ends not in wrath but in yielding, a young man handing over the mare and an elder, melted "as dew softens the ears of ripening corn," handing it back (note 21); a spectators' quarrel (Idomeneus and Oilean Ajax) is stopped by — of all men — Achilles, the poem's original quarreler, now its arbiter (note 17); and the book ends with Agamemnon standing up for the javelin-throw and Achilles awarding him the prize uncontested —

the two men whose fight over a prize began the epic closing it with a prize freely given (note 29). Around these, the poem's late tenderness is everywhere: Achilles' only smile (at Antilochus, note 20); Epeius's disarming self-knowledge ("no man can be best in everything"); Nestor given a prize for nothing but memory; the biography of a silver bowl that once ransomed Lycaon and is now raced for at the funeral of the man whose death doomed him (note 25); Ajax face-down in cattle-dung while the army "laughed at him sweetly." The dead man gets his games; the living get their order back; and the host of the funeral arranges prizes for a future — his own burial mound, his own bones in the same urn — that he has already scheduled (note 10). It is the gentlest book of the poem, and it earns its gentleness line by line over an open grave.

Register notes: 23.22-23 report the vow of 18.336-337 in its registered wording; the twelve youths' thread (18.336 – 21.27 – 23.175) closes; 23.179-180 repeat 23.19-20 verbatim (kept); the fast-and-wash continuity honors 19.208-210; "loud-roaring sea," "rosy-fingered Dawn," "saffron robe," "of many devices," "resourceful," "much-enduring," "who strikes from afar," and the "earth-upholder, earth-shaker" oath-title hold their registered forms; Patroclus is ἐννῆς — "the kindly" — at 252 and 648, both kept as "kindly," the dead man's adjective shared with Nestor's self-description.

BOOK 24

The Iliad does not end with a fall of a city or a death of a hero. It ends with an act of mercy so difficult that heaven has to engineer it and two broken men have to perform it — and with a funeral. Book 24 begins where Book 23's community ended: everyone else asleep, Achilles alone on the beach, cycling through his postures of grief, harnessing at each dawn to drag Hector three times round the tomb — and going nowhere, because Apollo keeps the corpse whole with the golden aegis. The mutilation has become a machine that grinds and does not feed. The gods' council states the poem's verdict through Apollo's indictment — Achilles "ravages dumb earth in his fury," having lost pity and that *aidōs* "that harms men greatly, and profits them"; even a man who loses a brother or a son "weeps, and laments, and lets go; for the Fates gave mankind an enduring heart" (note 3). Zeus's ruling refuses both theft and equal honor: Hector was dearest of Troy's mortals to the gods; Achilles shall have the glory — of giving him back. Mercy is arranged as an honor, because that is the only currency the recipient still accepts (note 4).

The double embassy — Thetis down to Achilles, Iris down to Priam — produces the book's two impossible journeys: a mother telling her doomed son to eat, sleep, and lie with a woman, "for you will not be with me long" (note 6); and an old man driving a

treasure-wagon at night into the camp of the man who has killed his sons, against his wife's plea (her wish to eat Achilles' liver raw is the third and most terrible of the poem's raw-eating wishes, because it is hers; note 8). Hermes — the god whose dearest thing is "to be man's companion" — walks Priam through the sleeping army disguised as a princely squire with his first beard, and delivers, along the way, the poem's kindest sentence: Hector lies twelve days unburied and "dewy-fresh... the blessed gods care for your son though he is nothing now but a dead man, because they loved him at heart" (note 13).

Then the scene the whole epic exists for. Priam enters unnoticed, clasps Achilles' knees, and kisses "the terrible, man-slaughtering hands that had killed so many of his sons" — while the poem compares him, the suppliant king, to a murderer arriving in exile at a rich man's hall: the roles of killer and victim deliberately exchanged in the simile (note 15). "Remember your father" opens the plea that ends: "I have endured what no other mortal on earth has yet endured: to lift to my lips the hand of the man who killed my son." And the two of them weep together — Priam for Hector, Achilles "now for his father, now again for Patroclus" — two griefs, one sound, filling the house (note 17). What follows is the consolation of the two jars — no unmixed good exists for mortals; Peleus's splendor and Priam's fifty sons end the same way; "Bear it... you will not raise him up" — and then supper, and the strangest, most humane moment in Homer: the two enemies simply look at each other, each marveling at what the other is, "and when they had taken their fill of looking" (note 22). The old rage flickers once — "Do not provoke me now, old man" — and its live presence under the mercy is exactly what makes the mercy real (note 19).

The supplication-arc of the late books (Tros refused, Lycaon refused, Hector refused) closes with supplication accepted; and with it the poem's largest ring: an aged father comes with ransom to redeem his child from a king's wrath — Chryses, Book 1, line 12 — and this time the king says yes. Achilles washes and lifts the body himself, apologizes to Patroclus, promises a share of the ransom, and grants eleven days' truce with his hand on the old man's wrist "so his heart should not be afraid." Briseis, in one quiet clause, sleeps at his side again. Priam drives home past the ford of Xanthus (the register's line, its third appearance); Cassandra cries the city awake; and the three laments — Andromache with the head in her hands, Hecuba, and last Helen, mourning the one man in Troy who was kind to her — carry the poem to the pyre, the golden box, the purple robes, the mound raised under guard, the funeral feast. "So they busied themselves with the burial of Hector, the tamer of horses": the epic of wrath ends on rites performed — grief, at last, allowed to do its work properly (note 30).

THE TRANSLATOR'S NOTES ON THE BOOKS

Register notes: 24.692-693 = 21.1-2 = 14.433-434 (the ford, third occurrence); Iris's message 175-187 repeats Zeus's 146-158 verbatim (kept); "your heart must be iron" 205 = 521 (Hecuba's phrase returned by Achilles); the raw-eating triplet closes (4.35, 22.346, 24.212); "man-slaughtering" passes to Hector's own head at 724; the Judgment of Paris (25-30, ath.), the jars, and Niobe's petrification (614-617, ath.) are kept and noted; all fixed formulas hold to the last line.

FOR FURTHER READING

The Iliad's ancient company: a guide

FOREWORD

The Iliad was never alone. It stands at the head of a crowd of ancient works that continue it, contradict it, dramatize its aftermath, parody it, argue about it, and forge eyewitness rebuttals to it — a conversation that ran for well over a thousand years before the poem reached us, and whose voices are already present in this edition's notes (Aristarchus athetizing, Zenodotus emending, Plutarch preserving four suppressed lines, Strabo reporting the variant Rome preferred). This list gathers that company. It is arranged not by date but by relationship to the Iliad — the companion, the sequels, the stage, the parody, the quarrel, the answer, the hoax, the scholars — because that is how the works themselves understood their positions. Each entry notes what survives and in what form; the losses are part of the story, and are reported as plainly as the survivals. Dates are approximate throughout; almost every early date in this field is argued about.

A note on access: nearly everything here exists in a Loeb Classical Library volume (Greek or Latin with facing English), and most of it in public-domain translations available through Perseus or the Internet Archive. Specific standard editions are named where they matter.

I. THE COMPANION

THE ODYSSEY · attributed to Homer · complete, 12,109 lines

The other survivor. Composed in the same formulaic tradition, plausibly within a generation or two of the Iliad, and built to fit around it with astonishing tact: the Odyssey retells almost nothing the Iliad narrates, and instead slots its Trojan flashbacks — the horse, the sack, the quarrel of Odysseus and Achilles, the ghosts of Achilles and Ajax — into the gaps the older poem left. Where the Iliad asks what a short glorious life is worth, the Odyssey asks what a long unglorious survival is worth; the shade of Achilles, telling Odysseus in the underworld that he would rather be a poor man's field-hand among the living than king of all the dead, is the one poem answering the other. A companion translation on the same principles as this one, sharing its formula register where the poems share formulas, is published alongside this one.

II. THE REST OF THE STORY: THE EPIC CYCLE

Antiquity possessed the whole war in verse: six more epics, collectively the "Epic Cycle," wrapped around the *Iliad* and *Odyssey* like the lost panels of an altarpiece. All six perished. What survives is a set of terse plot summaries made by one Proclus (perhaps 2nd c. AD) for his *Chrestomathy* — themselves preserved only in Photius and in the margins of *Iliad* manuscripts — plus a few dozen quoted fragments. The standard collection is M. L. West's *Loeb, Greek Epic Fragments* (2003). Aristotle (*Poetics* 23) already saw the difference in kind: the cyclic poets narrated everything in order, one thing after another, while Homer took a single action and made everything else radiate from it. The Cycle is the everything; reading even its skeletons shows what the *Iliad* chose not to be.

THE CYPRIA · attributed to Stasinus · 11 books, lost; summary and ~50 fragments

The prequel: Zeus's plan to thin mankind, the wedding of Peleus and Thetis, the Judgment of Paris, the abduction of Helen, the gathering at Aulis, Iphigenia, Philoctetes abandoned, the first nine years — everything the *Iliad* presupposes in its opening line. Herodotus (2.117) already argued it could not be Homer's, because it contradicts the *Iliad*'s account of Paris's voyage: the oldest surviving act of Homeric source-criticism.

THE AETHIOPIS · attributed to Arctinus of Miletus · 5 books, lost; summary and fragments

The direct sequel — it opened where our Book 24 closes, with a line ancient readers knew as an alternative ending to the *Iliad* itself ("So they busied themselves with the burial of Hector; and an Amazon came..."). Penthesileia the Amazon queen, killed by Achilles as they fall in love across the spear; Memnon the Aethiopian, son of the Dawn, killed for killing Antilochus; and then Achilles' own death at the Scaean Gates by the arrow of Paris and Apollo — the event the *Iliad* prophesies five times and refuses to narrate.

THE LITTLE ILIAD · attributed to Lesches · 4 books, lost; summary and fragments

The Judgment of the Arms (Achilles' armor awarded to Odysseus; Ajax's madness and suicide), Philoctetes fetched, Neoptolemus brought from Scyros — the poem behind the son Achilles mourns for in our Book 19 — and the building of the horse.

THE SACK OF ILION (*Iliou Persis*) · attributed to Arctinus · 2 books, lost; summary and fragments

The horse debated, Laocoon, the night of the fall: Priam killed at the altar of Zeus, Astyanax thrown from the wall — the death Andromache foresees for him at our 24.734-738 — Polyxena sacrificed at Achilles' tomb. The atrocities that made the "sack of a city" the ancient shorthand for ultimate suffering all lived here.

FOR FURTHER READING

THE RETURNS (Nostoi) · attributed to Agias of Troezen · 5 books, lost; summary

The costly homecomings: the wreck of Ajax son of Oileus, Menelaus blown to Egypt, and Agamemnon walking into his own murder — the story the *Odyssey* uses as its dark counter-example and the tragedians made their own.

THE TELEGONY · attributed to Eugammon of Cyrene · 2 books, lost; summary

The Cycle's strange coda: Odysseus's last wanderings and his death at the hands of Telegonus, his son by Circe — killed by a spear barbed with a sting-ray's spine, the sea reaching inland at last.

III. THE SEQUEL THAT SURVIVES

QUINTUS OF SMYRNA · *Posthomerica* · probably 3rd c. AD · complete, 14 books

Late antiquity, missing its Cycle, rewrote the gap: Quintus begins at Hector's funeral and marches in Homeric hexameters all the way to the sack and the storm over the returning fleet — Penthesileia, Memnon, the death of Achilles, the Judgment of the Arms, Philoctetes, the horse. Homer's manner without Homer's inwardness, but the only continuous ancient narrative of the war's end, and often better than its reputation.

TRIPHODORUS · *The Sack of Troy* · 3rd-4th c. AD · complete, 691 lines

A single night in a single sitting: a compact, theatrical telling of the horse and the fall.

COLLUTHUS · *The Rape of Helen* · c. 500 AD · complete, ~390 lines

The last ancient Troy poem: a small, ornamental *epyllion* on the Judgment of Paris and the abduction — the war's first evening, written at the tradition's last.

IV. THE TRAGIC STAGE

Aeschylus is said to have called his plays "slices from the great banquets of Homer" (Athenaeus 8.347e), and the phrase is exact: fifth-century Athens treated the Trojan matter — mostly the Cycle's panels rather than the *Iliad*'s own plot — as its common story-board. This is the ancient fan fiction, written by masters, and it consistently does what fan fiction does: it goes looking for the people the epic wronged.

AESCHYLUS · *Oresteia* (Agamemnon, Libation Bearers, *Eumenides*) · 458 BC · complete — the only surviving trilogy

The homecoming as catastrophe: Agamemnon walks the crimson cloth into the bath, and three plays work the blood out of the house. The *Iliad*'s king of men becomes a study in what the war cost the victors; the herald's speech on the rains and frosts at Troy is the veteran's *Iliad* in twenty lines. His lost Achilles trilogy (*Myrmidons*, *Nereids*, *Phrygians*) dramatized our Books 9-24 directly — the surviving fragments of Achilles' lament over Patroclus were famous in antiquity, and their loss is among the tradition's heaviest.

FOR FURTHER READING

SOPHOCLES · Ajax · c. 440s BC · complete

What happens to the Iliad's second-best fighter when the poem's economy of honor fails him: cheated of Achilles' arms, mad among the cattle, and dead by the sword Hector gave him at the end of our Book 7 — the guest-gift completing its arc. The quiet debate over his burial replays the Iliad's final question (what is owed a dead enemy?) in a Greek camp without an Achilles to answer it.

SOPHOCLES · Philoctetes · 409 BC · complete

The man the expedition abandoned, the bow the war requires, and the young son of Achilles caught between honesty and Odysseus: the epic's margins turned into the sharpest ethics on the Athenian stage.

EURIPIDES · Trojan Women · 415 BC · complete

The sack from beneath: Hecuba, Cassandra, Andromache, one day on the beach among the allotted captives, and the body of Astyanax brought in on his father's shield — the deliberate answering echo of every Hector-and-Andromache scene in the Iliad. Produced months after Athens massacred Melos; the oldest surviving anti-war play, made entirely of Homer's widows.

EURIPIDES · Hecuba · c. 424 BC · complete

Polyxena sacrificed to Achilles' ghost, Polydorus murdered by a guest-friend for gold — a different death from the one Achilles gives him at our 20.407-418; the tradition never agreed on its youngest victim — and the old queen's revenge: grief curdling into atrocity.

EURIPIDES · Andromache · c. 425 BC · complete

The afterlife of Hector's wife as the war-prize of Achilles' son: the sequel to our 6.450-465, where Hector foresaw exactly this.

EURIPIDES · Iphigenia at Aulis · 405 BC · complete

The war's first death, bought before the fleet could sail: the Cypria's story done as domestic tragedy, with Agamemnon drafting and redrafting the letter — the ancestor of every study in the cowardice of command.

EURIPIDES · Helen · 412 BC · complete

Built on Stesichorus's recantation (below): the real Helen sat out the war in Egypt, and Troy burned for a phantom. The Iliad weighed against a hypothesis: what if it was for nothing — literally nothing?

RHESUS · transmitted under Euripides' name; authorship disputed · complete

The one surviving tragedy that dramatizes an actual episode of the Iliad: our Book 10, the night raid, seen this time from the Trojan watch-fires. Whoever wrote it, it is the only chance to watch the fifth century stage a scene we also have in Homer.

Lost, and worth mourning by name: Aeschylus's Myrmidons (above); Sophocles' Polyxena and his Lovers of Achilles; Euripides' Alexandros (Paris exposed and

FOR FURTHER READING

recognized — partially recovered from papyrus), Palamedes, and Philoctetes (the versions that competed with the survivors). The tragic Troy we have is perhaps a tenth of the tragic Troy there was.

V. LYRIC VOICES

SAPPHO · fragment 44 ("The Wedding of Hector and Andromache") · c. 600 BC

The marriage the Iliad only mourns, sung whole: Hector and Andromache brought over the salt sea to Troy amid myrrh and cassia and the sound of pipes, "like to the gods." Whether it ends in shadow is invisible — the fragment breaks off at the height of the joy, which is somehow the most Iliadic thing about it.

STESICHORUS · Palinode · 6th c. BC · fragments

The poet struck blind, tradition said, for blaming Helen — and cured on recanting: "The story is not true. You never went in the well-benched ships; you never came to the citadel of Troy." The first recorded retraction in Western literature, and the seed of Euripides' Helen.

PINDAR · Nemean 7, Nemean 8, Isthmian 8, and passim · early 5th c. BC · complete odes

The Iliad's heroes as the currency of praise: Nemean 8 on Ajax destroyed by the secret ballot ("envy fastens always on the good"); Nemean 7 on Neoptolemus dead at Delphi, with Pindar's startling charge that Odysseus's reputation outruns his deeds because sweet-worded Homer inflated it; Isthmian 8 on Themis's prophecy that Thetis's son would outdo his father — the divine near-miss behind the whole poem. Pindar reads Homer the way the fifth century did: as scripture to be corrected.

VI. THE PARODY

BATRACHOMYOMACHIA ("The Battle of Frogs and Mice") · Hellenistic, though antiquity credited it to Homer · complete, ~300 lines

A mouse drowns; the mice arm for war; Zeus convenes the gods to watch; crabs settle it. Every convention of the Iliad — the arming scene, the aristeia, the divine council, the pathetic obituary — miniaturized onto a pond. The ancients thought Homer wrote it as a joke on himself, which is false as scholarship and perfect as criticism.

LUCIAN · True History; Dialogues of the Dead · 2nd c. AD · complete

In the True History Lucian sails to the Isle of the Blest and interviews Homer, settling the scholarly questions directly: asked about the lines the critics bracket as spurious, Homer says he wrote every one — a joke aimed precisely at the atheteses recorded throughout this edition's notes. The Dialogues of the Dead send Achilles, Ajax, and Helen's skull down to Hades to be needled by Menippus: the underworld of Odyssey 11 replayed as satire.

FOR FURTHER READING

VII. THE PHILOSOPHERS' QUARREL

Homer was ancient Greece's schoolbook, scripture, and moral authority — which is why the philosophers could not leave him alone.

XENOPHANES and HERACLITUS · 6th-5th c. BC · fragments

The opening shots: Xenophanes — "Homer and Hesiod attributed to the gods everything that is shame and reproach among men"; Heraclitus — Homer "deserves to be thrown out of the contests and beaten with a staff." The scandal of the Iliad's gods, stated at maximum volume, within two centuries of the poem.

PLATO · Ion; Republic, books 2-3 and 10 · 4th c. BC · complete

The Ion teases a Homeric performer who knows everything about the poems and nothing about anything; the Republic, with visible reluctance and repeated professions of love, banishes Homer from the ideal city for making gods lie and good men wail — citing the Iliad's grieving Achilles by name. "There is an ancient quarrel between philosophy and poetry": this is where it is declared, and the Iliad is the battlefield.

ARISTOTLE · Poetics · 4th c. BC · complete (the surviving book)

The defense. Homer is "divine beyond the rest" precisely for what this edition's introduction calls the poem's shape: he took one action — not the whole war — and made a unity of it, and he knew, alone among epic poets, when to shut up and let his people speak. Aristotle's few pages set the terms of epic criticism permanently.

LONGINUS · On the Sublime · 1st c. AD · complete (with gaps)

The most quotable of ancient critics on the Iliad's grandeur (the gods' battle, the horses' leap — our 5.770-772 — measured against the space of the world), and author of the famous verdict that in the Odyssey Homer is the setting sun: the greatness remains, without the intensity.

PLUTARCH · How the Young Man Should Study Poetry · 1st-2nd c. AD · complete

The ancient world's reading manual for Homer — how to profit from a poet who shows bad behavior — and, for this edition, a benefactor: his quotation is the sole preserver of the four suppressed lines of Phoenix's confession (our 9.458-461 gap, translated in the note there from his text).

DIO CHRYSOSTOM · Oration 11, "The Trojan Discourse" · c. 100 AD · complete

A sophist's tour de force arguing, with a straight face, that Homer lied and Troy won the war. Silly and serious at once: the earliest full display of how much play there is in a story everyone knows from one contested source.

FOR FURTHER READING

VIII. ROME'S ANSWER

VIRGIL · Aeneid · 19 BC · complete, 12 books

The losers' sequel and the Iliad's greatest reply. Virgil takes the one Trojan the Iliad conspicuously saves — Aeneas, rescued by Poseidon in our Book 20 "so that the race of Dardanus not perish seedless," with the note there recording the variant Strabo knew, in which his line shall rule "over all" — and builds Rome on the prophecy. Books 1-6 rewrite the Odyssey, books 7-12 the Iliad, and the poem ends on a deliberate, troubling inversion of our Book 24: where Achilles yields to a suppliant, Aeneas, remembering a dead friend, does not.

OVID · Metamorphoses, books 12-13; Heroides 3 · c. 8 AD · complete

Metamorphoses 12-13 run the war past at Ovid's speed — invulnerable Cygnus, the centaurs' brawl told by Nestor grown even older, and the Judgment of the Arms staged as a full courtroom debate between Ajax's deeds and Ulysses' words (words win; Ajax becomes a flower). Heroides 3 is the letter of Briseis to Achilles: the woman over whom the Iliad's quarrel broke, given at last a voice and a viewpoint — the ancient poem this translation's Briseis passages most want beside them.

CATULLUS · Poem 64 · c. 55 BC · complete

The wedding of Peleus and Thetis in miniature epic, with the Fates singing the unborn Achilles as a prophecy of glorious slaughter — the Iliad's future tense made a lullaby, and meant to chill.

SENECA · Trojan Women · 1st c. AD · complete

Euripides' beach re-staged in the imperial manner: Astyanax and Polyxena, rhetoric at the cliff's edge. The Troy play as Rome's meditation on its own capacity for atrocity.

ILIAS LATINA · attributed to Baebius Italicus · 1st c. AD · complete, ~1,070 lines

The Iliad compressed into a Latin school text — and, after the West lost its Greek, the thread by which the poem itself (as opposed to the Troy story) stayed faintly alive in Europe for a thousand years.

IX. THE HOAX

DICTYS CRETENSIS · Journal of the Trojan War · Greek original c. 1st-2nd c. AD (papyrus-confirmed), Latin version 4th c. · complete in Latin DARES PHRYGIUS · The Fall of Troy: A History · Latin, 5th-6th c. · complete

The fake eyewitnesses: "Dictys" claims to be a Cretan soldier's war diary dug up from his tomb, "Dares" a Trojan priest's account (he is borrowed from our 5.9, where a Dares serves as priest of Hephaestus) — both "predating" Homer, both correcting him, both stripping out the gods, and both written centuries after him. The Middle Ages, preferring eyewitnesses to poets, took them as history: through Benoît de Sainte-Maure and Guido delle Colonne they begat the medieval Troy, and thence Boccaccio, Chaucer's

FOR FURTHER READING

Troilus and Criseyde, and Shakespeare's *Troilus and Cressida* — a whole tradition descended from two forgeries and a minor character. (Troilus himself gets one line in the *Iliad*, among the dead sons Priam counts at 24.257.)

PHILOSTRATUS · *Heroicus* ("On Heroes") · early 3rd c. AD · complete

A Phoenician traveler and a vinedresser talk in a vineyard haunted by the ghost of Protesilaus — the first Achaean to die at Troy, dead before the *Iliad* opens — who corrects Homer on points of detail from personal experience. The gentlest of the rebuttal-fictions: it is, in its way, an interview with the fallen.

X. THE SCHOLARS

THE ALEXANDRIANS · Zenodotus, Aristophanes of Byzantium, Aristarchus · 3rd-2nd c. BC · surviving only through the scholia

The founders of the text: the librarians of Alexandria who collated the manuscripts, invented the critical signs, bracketed what they doubted, and fixed the vulgate this translation renders. They appear throughout this edition's notes as living interlocutors — Zenodotus making Agamemnon stand, Aristarchus doubting the divine singer and the Judgment of Paris — because the poem we have is, in part, their argument.

THE SCHOLIA · especially the Venetus A manuscript (10th c. AD) · edited by Erbse (1969-88)

The margins of the great Byzantine *Iliad* manuscripts preserve, in compressed centuries-deep layers, the wreckage of ancient Homeric scholarship — Aristarchus's judgments, rejected variants, allegorists, grammarians, the lot. The Venetus A, whose margins carry the richest layer, is the single most important physical object in the poem's transmission; its apparatus is the ancestor of the one this edition's notes draw on. High-resolution images of the manuscript itself are freely available online through the Homer Multitext project.

PORPHYRY · *Homeric Questions* · 3rd c. AD · partially preserved

The problem-and-solution tradition: apparent contradictions in Homer posed and resolved, some brilliantly, some by main force. The ancestor of every "but in Book 5 he was wounded" argument readers have with epics to this day.

EUSTATHIUS OF THESSALONICA · *Commentaries on the Iliad* · 12th c. AD · complete, enormous

A Byzantine archbishop's line-by-line commentary that folds in everything he could still read of the older scholarship — much of it now surviving nowhere else. The last ancient reader, in effect, writing at the door of the modern ones.

FOR FURTHER READING

THE CONTEST OF HOMER AND HESIOD (Certamen) · compiled 2nd c. AD from older material · complete

A fiction in which the two founding poets compete before a king: Hesiod asks the trick questions, Homer answers in effortless hexameters, and the prize goes to Hesiod — because the judge prefers the poet of peace and farming to the poet of slaughter. The tradition's own verdict on the Iliad's greatness, and its own joke about what greatness is for.

A CLOSING NOTE

The shortest true history of ancient literature is that it is a long argument with the Iliad. The Odyssey answers it; the Cycle completes it; the tragedians prosecute it on behalf of its victims; the philosophers put it on trial; Alexandria edits it; Rome appropriates it; the forgers depose it; the satirists interview it; and the scholiasts annotate every round of the fight in the margins. Any door in this list opens back into the poem. Begin anywhere.

INDEX OF NAMES AND PLACES

The poem's principal persons, gods, peoples, and places — every figure of consequence — with a pronunciation (*Say:*), epithets, aliases, kin, and line citations. Pronunciations give the traditional anglicized reading; stress falls on the capitalized syllable. The several hundred men who are named once and killed in the same breath are not indexed.

Abantes (Ἀβαντες) · PEOPLE — *Say:* uh-BAN-teez

The Euboean contingent of the Catalogue of Ships, holding Chalcis, Eretria, Histiaea, Cerinthus, Dios, Carystus and Styra, and led by Elephenor son of Chalcodon. The poem marks them twice over: they wear their hair long behind and shorn in front, and they are spearmen who close to break corslets rather than fight at range.

Kin: led by Elephenor, Chalcodon's son.

Refs: 2.536, 2.541, 2.542, 4.464. Books 2, 4.

See also: Achaeans.

Abydos (Ἀβυδος) · PLACE — *Say:* uh-BY-dos

A town on the Asian shore of the Hellespont, held with Sestus and Arisbe by Asius' contingent of Trojan allies. It is named twice more for the men who come from it: Democoon, Priam's bastard son, who kept the fast mares there, and the Phaenops whose shape Apollo borrows to shame Hector.

Refs: 2.836, 4.500, 17.584. Books 2, 4, 17.

See also: Asius, Arisbe, Hellespont.

Acamas (Ἀκάμας) · MORTAL — *Say:* AK-uh-mas

Two men of the name fight on the Trojan side, and the poem keeps them apart. The first is a son of Antenor, named with his brother Archelochus in the Catalogue and again among Hector's captains at 11.60; in Book 14 he stands over Archelochus' body and kills Promachus in vengeance, vaunting over him, and Meriones runs him down as he mounts his chariot at 16.342. The second is a Thracian leader, Eussorus' son, "the man who was best among the Thracians," whom Telamonian Ajax kills at 6.8; Ares had worn his likeness to rally the Trojans a book earlier (5.462).

Kin: the Trojan Acamas is Antenor's son and Archelochus' brother; the Thracian is Eussorus' son.

Kills: Promachus (14.476–477). *Killed by:* Meriones (16.342); the Thracian

Acamas by Ajax (6.8).

Refs: 2.823, 2.844, 5.462, 6.8, 11.60, 12.100, 14.476, 14.478, 14.488, 16.342. Books 2, 5, 6, 11, 12, 14, 16.

See also: Antenor, Archelochus, Peiroos, Thracians, Meriones.

Achaea (Ἀχαιΐς) · PLACE — Say: uh-KEE-uh

The Achaeans' homeland, named in the formula "horse-pasturing Argos and Achaea of the beautiful women" that closes the terms of the duel in Book 3, and turned against the army as a taunt in Menelaus' reproach — "Women of Achaea, men of Achaea no longer" (7.96).

Refs: 3.75, 3.258, 7.96, 11.770. Books 3, 7, 11.

See also: Achaeans, Argos.

Achaeans (Ἀχαιοί) · PEOPLE — Say: uh-KEE-unz

The poem's default name for the Greeks besieging Troy, used interchangeably with Argives and Danaans for the same host. After Zeus and the Trojans it is the commonest name in the Iliad: the army is the standing audience before which honor is won and lost, the assembly that must be persuaded, and the collective whose griefs the second line of the poem announces (1.2).

Epithets: "the long-haired Achaeans" (κάρη κομόωντες Ἀχαιοί, 2.11); "the strong-greaved Achaeans" (ἑυκνήμιδες Ἀχαιοί, 1.17); "the bronze-shirted Achaeans" (χαλκοχίτωνες Ἀχαιοί, 1.371).

Also called: Argives; Danaans — metrically convenient synonyms for the same host, not distinct peoples. The Myrmidons and Hellenes are Achilles' own contingent and are not synonyms for the whole army.

Refs: 1.2, 1.17, 1.371, 2.11, 2.51 ...and throughout.

Books 1–24.

See also: Argives, Danaans, Myrmidons, Hellenes, Achaea, Agamemnon.

Achilles (Ἀχιλλεύς) · MORTAL — Say: uh-KIL-eez

The poem's subject, greatest of the Achaeans, whose wrath is its announced theme and its first word. Agamemnon's seizure of Briseis drives him from the fighting; his refusal of the embassy in Book 9 hardens the quarrel past mending; and Patroclus' death in his own armor brings him back not to win the war but to kill Hector. The Iliad ends not with that vengeance but with him giving the body up to Priam, having been argued out of his rage by an old man who kisses his hands.

Epithets: "swift-footed" (πόδας ὠκύς / ποδάρκης, 1.58); "brilliant" (διός, 1.7); "Zeus-sprung" (διογενής, 1.489).

Also called: Peleus' son; Aeacus' grandson; Thetis' son.

ACTOR – ADMETUS

Kin: son of Peleus and the sea-nymph Thetis; grandson of Aeacus; father of Neoptolemus, reared on Scyros. Companion of Patroclus; foster-son of Phoenix.

Refs: 1.1, 1.58, 1.348, 9.199, 16.2, 18.22, 22.330, 24.596 ...and throughout.

Books 1–2, 4–24.

See also: Patroclus, Hector, Agamemnon, Thetis, Peleus, Aeacus, Briseis, Priam, Phoenix.

Actor (Ἀκτωρ) · MORTAL — Say: AK-tor

A name borne by more than one man of the older generation, all of them fathers rather than fighters. The poem's Actors include Azeus' son, in whose house Astyoche bore Ares' twin sons Ascalaphus and Ialmenus; the father of Menoetius, and so Patroclus' grandfather (11.785, 16.14); the father of Echeclus (16.189); and the father of the twins Cteatus and Eurytus, called both "Actor's line" and "the two sons of Actor," who crowd past Nestor's horses in his reminiscence of the Epeian games.

Kin: variously father of Menoetius, of Echeclus, and of the Molione twins.

Refs: 2.513, 2.621, 11.750, 11.785, 13.186, 16.14, 16.189, 23.638.

Books 2, 11, 13, 16, 23.

See also: Menoetius, Patroclus, Amarynceus.

Adamas (Ἀδάμας) · MORTAL — Say: AD-uh-mas

Son of Asius, one of the Trojan captains who storm the wall in Book 12. In the fighting at the ships he stabs Antilochus' shield and slips back into the ranks "dodging doom," but Meriones catches him with a spear-cast in the groin and he dies writhing like a roped bull. Deiphobus names him among the dead Trojan leaders at 13.771.

Kin: son of Asius, Hyrtacus' son.

Killed by: Meriones (13.567–575).

Refs: 12.140, 13.561, 13.566, 13.760, 13.771. Books 12, 13.

See also: Asius, Meriones, Antilochus.

Admetus (Ἀδμητος) · MORTAL — Say: ad-MEE-tus

Father of Eumelus and husband of Alcestis, "brilliant among women, loveliest of the daughters of Pelias." He does not come to Troy: the name is a patronymic throughout, marking his son, who brings eleven ships from Pherae and drives the best horses in the Achaean host.

Kin: husband of Alcestis; father of Eumelus.

Refs: 2.713, 2.714, 23.289, 23.391, 23.532. Books 2, 23.

See also: Eumelus, Alcestis.

Adrastus (Ἀδρηστος) · MORTAL — Say: uh-DRAS-tus

King of Sicyon in the older generation — "Sicyon, where Adrastus first was king" — and owner of Arion, the swift horse "whose line was from the gods," against which Antilochus is told even a better driver could not have won. His daughters marry into the poem's Argive houses: Aegialeia is named as Diomedes' wife at 5.412, and Tydeus married a daughter of his after settling at Argos (14.121). The translation spells him *Adrastus* and the Trojan-side leader *Adrestus*, keeping two men distinct whom one spelling would merge; see `canon.md`.

Kin: father of Aegialeia; father-in-law of Tydeus.

Refs: 2.572, 5.412, 14.121, 23.347. Books 2, 5, 14, 23.

See also: Adrestus, Arion, Diomedes, Sicyon.

Adrestus (Ἀδρηστος) · MORTAL — Say: uh-DRES-tus

Three Trojan-side men bear this spelling. One leads the contingent from Adresteia and Apaesus with his brother Amphius, sons of Merops of Percote, who foresaw their deaths and could not keep them home. The second is the suppliant of Book 6, thrown from a bolting chariot, who clasps Menelaus' knees and offers ransom. Menelaus is on the point of granting it when Agamemnon runs up and shames him — "Soft-hearted Menelaus!" — so that Menelaus pushes the man back with his hand and Agamemnon does the killing (6.62–65). A third falls to Patroclus. The translation reserves *Adrastus* for the Sicyon king.

Kin: the Percotian Adrestus is Merops' son and Amphius' brother.

Killed by: Agamemnon (6.63–65); the third by Patroclus (16.694).

Refs: 2.830, 6.37, 6.45, 6.63, 16.694. Books 2, 6, 16.

See also: Adrastus, Amphius, Merops, Agamemnon, Menelaus.

Aeacus (Αἰακός) · MORTAL — Say: EE-uh-kus

Peleus' father and Achilles' grandfather, himself sprung from Zeus (21.189). He never appears: in all its occurrences the name is a patronymic, and the translation keeps the generations apart by a fixed rule — "Aeacus' son" is

Peleus, "Aeacus' grandson" is **Achilles**, except inside the fixed epithet formulas, where "the swift-footed son of Aeacus" and "Aeacus' blameless son" mean Achilles.

Kin: son of Zeus; father of Peleus; grandfather of Achilles.

Refs: 2.860, 2.874, 9.184, 16.15, 16.140, 16.854, 21.178, 21.189 ...and throughout. Books 2, 9–11, 16–18, 21, 23.

See also: Achilles, Peleus.

Aeneas (Αἰνείας) · MORTAL — Say: ee-NEE-us or uh-NEE-us

Leader of the Dardanians and, after Hector, Troy's best fighter. Son of Anchises and Aphrodite, he is twice snatched from death by gods who have plans for him — by his mother and Apollo when Diomedes crushes his hip with a boulder (5.311ff), and by Poseidon when Achilles has him beaten, in the scene that gives the poem its one glance past its own ending: Aeneas is destined to escape, "so that the race of Dardanus not perish seedless," and his line will rule the Trojans hereafter (20.302–308).

Also called: Anchises' son.

Kin: son of Anchises and Aphrodite; of the line of Dardanus through Assaracus.

Refs: 2.820, 5.166, 5.311, 5.445, 13.459, 16.620, 17.323, 20.302 ...and throughout. Books 2, 5–6, 8, 11–17, 20, 23.

See also: Anchises, Aphrodite, Dardanus, Dardanians, Achilles, Diomedes.

Aeseopus (Αἴσηπος) · MORTAL — Say: ee-SEE-pus

A Trojan twin, killed with his brother Pegasus by Euryalus in the general rout of Book 6. The poem gives the pair a full genealogy at the moment of their death: the water-nymph Abarbarea bore them to Bucolion, Laomedon's eldest son, got in secret while he was shepherding. The name is also a river of the Troad, one of those the gods turn against the Achaean wall (12.21).

Kin: son of Bucolion and the nymph Abarbarea; twin of Pegasus.

Killed by: Euryalus (6.20–28).

Refs: 2.825, 4.91, 6.21, 12.21. Books 2, 4, 6, 12.

See also: Pegasus, Bucolion, Euryalus, Laomedon.

Aethe (Αἴθη) · OTHER — Say: EE-thee

Agamemnon's mare, lent to Menelaus for the chariot race at Patroclus' funeral — a gift to Agamemnon from Echepolus son of Anchises, made so that he might stay home from the war. Nestor's son Antilochus is warned that she will "pour shame" on his horses, and her fury nearly carries Menelaus past him at the finish.

Kin: yoked with Menelaus' own horse Podargus.

Refs: 23.295, 23.408, 23.524. Book 23.

See also: Podargus, Menelaus, Antilochus, Echepolus.

Aetolians (Αἰτωλοί) · PEOPLE — Say: ee-TOH-lee-unz

The contingent from Pleuron, Olenus, Pylene, Chalcis and Calydon, led to Troy by Thoas son of Andraemon with forty ships. The Catalogue explains the odd succession: Oeneus' sons were dead and Meleager with them, so the whole rule fell to Thoas. Their older war against the Curetes over Calydon is the setting of

Phoenix's Meleager story in Book 9.

Kin: led by Thoas, Andraemon's son.

Refs: 2.638, 2.643, 4.527, 9.529, 9.531, 13.218, 23.633. Books 2, 4–5, 9, 13, 15, 23.

See also: Thoas, Meleager, Oeneus, Calydon, Curetes.

Agamemnon (Ἀγαμέμνων) · MORTAL — *Say:* ag-uh-MEM-non

Commander of the whole Achaean expedition and Achilles' antagonist in the quarrel that starts the poem. His refusal to give Chryseis back brings the plague, and his taking of Briseis in compensation drives Achilles from the fighting; the disaster that follows is his to answer for, and in Book 19 he answers for it by blaming Blindness sent from Zeus. His authority rests on the sceptre whose descent Hephaestus to Zeus to Hermes to Pelops to Atreus to Thyestes to himself the poem traces at 2.101–108: he rules "many islands and all of Argos," and he is consistently a worse fighter than the men he commands.

Epithets: "lord of men" (ἄναξ ἀνδρῶν, 1.7); "wide-ruling" (εὐρὺ κρείων, 1.102); "shepherd of the people" (ποιμὴν λαῶν, of Agamemnon at 2.243) — the last is a general royal epithet, used of Atreus and others too.

Also called: Atreus' son — in the singular this means Agamemnon unless the scene is Menelaus'; see `canon.md`.

Kin: son of Atreus, grandson of Pelops; brother of Menelaus; husband of Clytemnestra.

Refs: 1.24, 1.130, 2.100, 2.107, 4.148, 9.114, 11.91, 19.86 ...and throughout. Books 1–11, 13–14, 16–19, 23–24.

See also: Achilles, Menelaus, Atreus, Briseis, Chryseis, Blindness.

Agenor (Ἀγήνωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-JEE-nor

Antenor's son, "a man blameless and strong," and the last Trojan to stand in Achilles' path before Hector. Apollo puts courage in him at 21.545 and he turns to face the charge, breaking off his own debate with the formula the poem gives its cornered men — "But why does my own heart argue these things with me?" (21.562, as at 11.407, 17.97, 22.122, 22.385). He casts, and Apollo snatches him away in mist, then wears his shape to decoy Achilles from the walls: the trick that lets the routed Trojans get inside the gates.

Kin: son of Antenor; father of Echeclus (20.474).

Refs: 4.467, 11.59, 12.93, 13.490, 15.340, 20.474, 21.545, 21.595, 21.600. Books 4, 11–16, 20–21.

See also: Antenor, Achilles, Apollo, Hector.

Ajax (Αἴας) · MORTAL — Say: AY-jaks

Telamon's son, from Salamis with twelve ships: the biggest man in the army and its best fighter after Achilles, whom Helen picks out from the wall as "gigantic Ajax, wall of the Achaeans." He carries a tower-like shield of seven oxhides and an eighth layer of bronze, made by Tychius of Hyle. The lot chooses him to duel Hector in Book 7, and they part at nightfall exchanging gifts; he is one of the three sent to Achilles in Book 9, where his short blunt speech comes nearest to moving him; and in Book 15 he holds the last deck alone against the fire, giving ground plank by plank. Unqualified "Ajax" means him unless the line marks the other.

Epithets: "wall of the Achaeans" (ἔργκος Ἀχαιῶν, 3.229).

Also called: Telamonian Ajax; Telamon's son; the great Ajax.

Kin: son of Telamon; half-brother of Teucer.

Refs: 2.557, 3.229, 7.183, 7.219, 9.622, 15.727, 17.132 ...and throughout.

Books 1–18, 23.

See also: Ajax son of Oileus, Ajaxes, Telamon, Teucer, Hector, Achilles.

Ajax son of Oileus (Αἴας Ὀϊλήος υἱός) · MORTAL — Say: AY-jaks, son of oh-EYE-lyoos

Leader of the Locrians with forty ships: "the lesser Ajax, in no way so big as Telamonian Ajax / but far smaller: a little man, in a linen corslet, / but with the spear he surpassed all Hellenes and Achaeans" (2.528–530). He is the fastest Achaean in the chase — most of the kills in the Book 14 rout are his, "for there was no one like him for speed of foot" when men broke and ran — and the savage half of the pair: it is he who cuts off Imbrius' head in wrath for Amphimachus and sends it "rolling like a ball through the crowd" to fall at Hector's feet (13.202–205). In the footrace of the games Athena trips him at a dead run into the cattle-dung, and he stands spitting it out while the Argives laugh at him (23.774–784).

Also called: swift Ajax; the lesser Ajax; Oileus' son. Unqualified "Ajax" is the Telamonian — see `canon.md`.

Kin: son of Oileus; half-brother of Medon, Oileus' bastard son (13.694–695).

Refs: 2.527, 13.203, 13.701, 14.520, 23.473, 23.754, 23.774. Books 2, 13–14, 23.

See also: Ajax, Ajaxes, Oileus, Locrians, Medon.

Ajaxes (Αἴαντες) · MORTAL — Say: AY-jak-seez

The dual — Telamonian Ajax and Ajax son of Oileus fighting as a single unit, and the poem's standing image of a defensive line that holds. They are always found

where the wall or the ships are about to break: marshaling the towers in Book 12, addressed first by Poseidon when he comes to rally the army in Book 13, carrying Imbrius' body off like two lions with a goat, and holding the line over Patroclus' corpse in Book 17. The Book 4 simile of a black storm-cloud coming on before the West Wind is given to them together.

Also called: the two Ajaxes.

Refs: 2.406, 4.273, 4.280, 12.265, 13.46, 13.197, 17.507, 17.732, 18.157.

Books 2, 4–8, 10, 12–13, 16–18.

See also: Ajax, Ajax son of Oïleus, Poseidon, Patroclus.

Alastor (Ἀλάτωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-LAS-tor

At least three men. One is a Pylian, named among Nestor's captains at 4.295 and twice paired with Mecisteus son of Echius as a stretcher-bearer, carrying the wounded off to the ships (8.333, 13.422). Another is a Trojan-side victim in Odysseus' rally at 5.677. The third is named only as a father: Tros, "Alastor's son," is the suppliant who reaches for Achilles' knees and is killed anyway at 20.463.

Refs: 4.295, 5.677, 8.333, 13.422, 20.463. Books 4–5, 8, 13, 20.

See also: Nestor, Odysseus, Tros.

Alcathous (Ἀλκάθοος) · MORTAL — *Say:* al-KATH-oh-us

A Trojan captain, Aesyetes' son, married to Anchises' eldest daughter Hippodameia. Idomeneus kills him in one of the poem's strangest deaths: Poseidon charms his eyes and shackles his limbs so that he stands unmoving "like a grave-pillar or a tree in high leaf" and cannot dodge, and his heart goes on beating hard enough to shake the spear standing in it. Deiphobus calls Aeneas to avenge the man who reared him.

Kin: son of Aesyetes; husband of Hippodameia, Anchises' eldest daughter; brother-in-law and foster-father to Aeneas.

Killed by: Idomeneus (13.427–444).

Refs: 12.93, 13.428, 13.465, 13.496. Books 12, 13.

See also: Idomeneus, Aeneas, Anchises, Poseidon.

Alcimedon (Ἀλκιμέδων) · MORTAL — *Say:* al-SIM-uh-don

Son of Laerces and grandson of Haemon, one of the five company-commanders Achilles sets over the Myrmidons when Patroclus goes out (16.197). In Book 17 he finds Automedon fighting alone from Achilles' chariot with Patroclus dead and Hector wearing the armor, tells him he has lost his wits, and takes the reins so that Automedon can fight on foot.

Kin: son of Laerces, grandson of Haemon.

Refs: 16.197, 17.467, 17.475, 17.481, 17.500, 17.501. Books 16, 17.

See also: Automedon, Achilles, Myrmidons, Patroclus.

Alpheius (Ἀλφειός) · PLACE — Say: al-FEE-us

The great river of the western Peloponnese, "which flows wide through the Pylians' land." It marks Nestor's country in his reminiscences — the cattle-raid that reached its sacred stream by midday, the ford named in the Catalogue — and as a river-god it heads a Pylian genealogy: Alpheius begot Ortilochus, who fathered Diocles, whose twin sons Aeneas kills at 5.541–560.

Refs: 2.592, 5.545, 11.712, 11.726, 11.728. Books 2, 5, 11.

See also: Nestor, Pylos, Elis.

Altes (Ἄλτης) · MORTAL — Say: AL-teez

Lord of the Lelegians, "holding steep Pedasus on the Satnioeis," and father of Laothoe, one of Priam's wives. He is named only through his grandsons: Lycaon recites the descent while begging Achilles for his life at 21.85, and Priam names him again mourning Lycaon and Polydorus at 22.51, recalling the dowry "the famous name" gave with his daughter.

Kin: father of Laothoe; grandfather of Lycaon and Polydorus.

Refs: 21.85, 21.86, 22.51. Books 21, 22.

See also: Laothoe, Lycaon, Polydorus, Priam, Pedasus.

Amarynceus (Ἀμαρυγκεύς) · MORTAL — Say: am-uh-RIN-syoos

An Epeian lord of the older generation, father of Diore. Nestor's last long reminiscence is of the funeral games his sons held for him at Buprasium, where Nestor beat every man there at boxing, wrestling, running and the spear, and lost only the chariot race to the two sons of Actor — the memory he offers Achilles as he accepts a prize he no longer has to compete for.

Kin: father of Diore.

Refs: 2.622, 4.517, 23.630. Books 2, 4, 23.

See also: Diore, Nestor, Actor, Epeians, Buprasium.

Amazons (Ἀμαζόνες) · PEOPLE — Say: AM-uh-zonz

A people of women who fight, named only in the back-story and only twice: Priam recalls campaigning against them in Phrygia in his youth, and Bellerophon is set to fight them as the third of the impossible tasks he survives.

Epithets: "the match of men" (ἀντιάνειραι, 3.189).

Refs: 3.189, 6.186. Books 3, 6.

See also: Priam, Bellerophon.

Amphidamas (Ἀμφιδάμας) · MORTAL — Say: am-FID-uh-mas

Two men. One is of Cythera, a link in the descent of the boar's-tusk helmet Odysseus wears on the night raid: Autolycus stole it, gave it to Amphidamas at Scandea, who gave it to Molus, whose son Meriones lends it on. The other is of Opoeis, whose son Patroclus killed as a boy in a quarrel over dice — "a child's act; I did not mean it" — the killing that brought him to Peleus' house.

Kin: the Cytheran is a guest-friend of Molus; the Opoeisian is father of the boy Patroclus killed.

Refs: 10.268, 10.269, 23.87. Books 10, 23.

See also: Meriones, Molus, Patroclus, Opoeis.

Amphimachus (Ἀμφίμαχος) · MORTAL — Say: am-FIM-uh-kus

Two men, both leaders in the Catalogue. The Epeian is a son of Cteatus, of Actor's line, one of four captains from Elis; Hector spears him in the chest as he comes into the fighting at the ships and is reaching to strip his helmet when Ajax drives him back, and the lesser Ajax kills Imbrius in wrath for him. The other is a Carian, son of Nomion and brother of Nastes, one of the pair who "went to war decked in gold, like a girl."

Kin: the Epeian is Cteatus' son, of Actor's line; the Carian is Nomion's son and Nastes' brother.

Killed by: Hector (13.185–187).

Refs: 2.620, 2.870, 2.871, 13.185, 13.189, 13.195, 13.203. Books 2, 13.

See also: Nastes, Actor, Cteatus, Hector, Ajax.

Anchises (Ἀγχίσης) · MORTAL — Say: an-KY-seez

Aeneas' father by Aphrodite, who "conceived him to Anchises herding cattle" on the spurs of Ida. He does not fight: he belongs to the genealogy Aeneas recites to Achilles at 20.208–241, the Dardanian line running Dardanus — Erichthonius — Tros — Assaracus — Capys — Anchises — Aeneas, the branch that survives when Priam's does not. A different Anchises, of Sicyon, is the father of the Echeolus who bribed Agamemnon with a mare to be let off the war (23.296).

Kin: son of Capys; father of Aeneas by Aphrodite; father-in-law of Alcatous.

Refs: 2.819, 5.247, 5.313, 13.428, 17.491, 20.208, 20.240, 23.296.

Books 2, 5, 12–13, 17, 20, 23.

See also: Aeneas, Aphrodite, Dardanus, Capys, Alcatous, Echeolus.

Andromache (Ἀνδρομάχη) · MORTAL — Say: an-DROM-uh-kee

Hector's wife, daughter of Eëtion of Thebe-under-Placus, whose father and seven brothers Achilles killed in the sack of that city — so that, as she tells Hector,

ANTENOR – ANTILOCHUS

he is now father and mother and brother to her as well as husband. She meets him at the Scaean Gates in Book 6 with their son in her arms and begs him to fight from the wall; he refuses, and the scene ends with the child frightened by his own father's helmet. She is at her loom, ordering a bath for him, when the wailing tells her he is dead (22.437–515), and she leads the lament over his body in the poem's last scene.

Epithets: "white-armed" (λευκώλενος, 6.371).

Kin: daughter of Eëtion; wife of Hector; mother of Astyanax.

Refs: 6.371, 6.377, 6.395, 6.405, 8.187, 17.208, 24.723. Books 6, 8, 17, 24.

See also: Hector, Astyanax, Eëtion, Thebe, Achilles.

Antenor (Ἀντήνωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* an-TEE-nor

The wisest of the Trojan elders and the one who says plainly what the war is about. He had hosted Menelaus and Odysseus on the embassy that first asked for Helen back, and he identifies them for Priam from the wall; in Book 7 he tells the assembly to give Helen and her goods to the Atreidae, since "it is with sworn oaths made false that we fight," and Paris refuses. Many of his sons die in the poem — Archelochus, Acamas, Iphidamas, Coon, Polybus — and Agenor is the last to face Achilles.

Kin: husband of Theano, Athena's priestess in Troy; father of Archelochus, Acamas, Agenor, Iphidamas, Coon, Polybus, and others.

Refs: 2.822, 3.148, 3.203, 3.262, 6.299, 7.347, 11.221, 14.463, 21.546.

Books 2–7, 11–12, 14–15, 19–21.

See also: Theano, Agenor, Acamas, Archelochus, Iphidamas, Coon, Helen, Paris.

Antilochus (Ἀντίλοχος) · MORTAL — *Say:* an-TIL-oh-kus

Nestor's son, the youngest of the Achaean captains and among the fastest. He kills the first Trojan of the general fighting (4.457) and fights hard through the middle books; but his two great scenes are late. It falls to him to carry the news of Patroclus' death to Achilles, and he does it holding Achilles' hands, afraid he will cut his own throat (18.32). In the funeral games he takes second place in the chariot race by forcing Menelaus into a narrow gully — his father having coached him at length in exactly such guile — and then gives the mare back when Menelaus challenges him on oath, in a scene of tact that ends the quarrel.

Also called: Nestor's son.

Kin: son of Nestor; brother of Thrasymedes.

Refs: 4.457, 5.565, 13.396, 15.585, 16.317, 17.685, 18.2, 18.32, 23.514, 23.541 ...and throughout. Books 4–6, 13–18, 23.

See also: Nestor, Menelaus, Achilles, Patroclus, Thrasymedes.

Antimachus (Ἀντίμαχος) · MORTAL — Say: an-TIM-uh-kus

The Trojan who took Paris' gold and argued in the assembly against giving Helen back — and who urged that Menelaus be killed on the spot when he came as an envoy. Agamemnon kills two of his sons, Peisander and Hippolochus, in Book 11 and refuses their ransom on the strength of it: "now you will pay for your father's foul outrage." A third son falls to Leonteus at 12.188.

Kin: father of Peisander, Hippolochus, and Hippomachus.

Refs: 11.123, 11.132, 11.138, 12.188. Books 11, 12.

See also: Agamemnon, Menelaus, Paris, Helen, Leonteus.

Antiphus (Ἀντίφος) · MORTAL — Say: AN-tih-fus

Three men. On the Achaean side, a son of Thessalus and grandson of Heracles, who leads thirty ships with his brother Pheidippus from Cos and the Calydnian islands. On the Trojan side, a son of Talaemenes who leads the Maeonians with Mesthles, and a true-born son of Priam whom Agamemnon kills at 11.104 — he and his bastard half-brother Isus riding one chariot, both of them men Achilles had once caught on Ida watching sheep and released for ransom.

Kin: variously son of Thessalus; son of Talaemenes; son of Priam.

Killed by: Agamemnon (11.109), the Priamid.

Refs: 2.678, 2.864, 11.101, 11.104, 11.109. Books 2, 11.

See also: Pheidippus, Mesthles, Priam, Isus, Agamemnon.

Aphareus (Ἀφαρεύς) · MORTAL — Say: AF-uh-ryoos

Son of Caletor, one of the younger Achaean captains who keep company with Meriones and Deïpyrus on guard duty in Book 9 and in the line Idomeneus calls to in Book 13. Aeneas kills him there with a spear-thrust to the turned throat, so that shield and helmet crumple down on him.

Kin: son of Caletor.

Killed by: Aeneas (13.541–544).

Refs: 9.83, 13.478, 13.541. Books 9, 13.

See also: Meriones, Deïpyrus, Idomeneus, Aeneas.

Aphrodite (Ἀφροδίτη) · GOD — Say: af-roh-DY-tee

Paris' patron and the cause, through the judgment implied at 24.29–30, of the war itself. She rescues Paris out of the duel in a mist and carries him to Helen's bedchamber, then bullies Helen into following — the poem's coldest scene between goddess and woman. In Book 5 she comes to save Aeneas, her son, and Diomedes wounds her hand; she flees weeping to Olympus, where Dione comforts her and Zeus

tells her to keep to the works of marriage and leave war alone. She lends Hera the embroidered strap of desire in Book 14, and in the theomachy Athena knocks her flat with a blow to the breast.

Epithets: "laughter-loving" (φιλομειδῆς Ἀφροδίτη, 3.424).

Also called: Cypris — used in Book 5 only.

Kin: daughter of Zeus and Dione; mother of Aeneas by Anchises.

Refs: 3.374, 3.389, 3.424, 5.131, 5.312, 5.330, 5.375, 14.188, 21.416, 24.699.

Books 2–5, 9, 14, 19–24.

See also: Paris, Helen, Aeneas, Anchises, Dione, Diomedes, Hera, Athena.

Apisaon (Ἀπισίων) · MORTAL — *Say:* ap-ih-SAY-on

Two Trojan-side men, killed in the same words. Phausius' son falls to Eurypylus at 11.578, struck "in the liver below the midriff," and Paris shoots Eurypylus in the thigh as he strips the body. Hippasus' son, a Paeonian and "their best in battle after Asteropaeus," falls to Lycomedes at 17.348 in a line repeated verbatim from the first.

Kin: one is Phausius' son; the other Hippasus' son.

Killed by: Eurypylus (11.578–579); Lycomedes (17.348–349).

Refs: 11.578, 11.582, 17.348. Books 11, 17.

See also: Eurypylus, Lycomedes, Asteropaeus, Paris.

Apollo (Ἀπόλλων) · GOD — *Say:* uh-POL-oh

Troy's chief defender among the gods and the poem's first mover: Chryses' prayer brings him down from Olympus "like nightfall," and his arrows loose the plague that starts the quarrel (1.43–53). He fights on the Trojan side throughout — snatching Aeneas and Hector out of danger, standing off Diomedes at 5.437–444, levelling the Achaean wall — and his decisive act is to strike Patroclus from behind with the flat of his hand, knocking off helmet and corslet and leaving him dazed for Euphorbus and Hector (16.788–806). He puts strength in Hector one last time in Book 22 and then leaves him when Zeus's scales sink. In Book 24 he keeps Hector's body from disfigurement and shames the gods into ransoming it.

Epithets: "who strikes from afar," standalone "the far-striker" (ἐκῆβόλος / ἔκατος, 1.15 / 1.385); "the worker-from-afar" (ἐκάεργος, 1.147); "god of the silver bow" (ἀργυρότοξος, 1.37); "the Lycian-born" (Λυκηγενής, 4.101); "famed for the bow" (κλυτότοξος, 4.101); "of the golden sword" (χρυσόαρος, 5.509).

Also called: Phoebus; Smintheus — the cult title of Chryses' prayer (1.39).

Kin: son of Zeus and Leto; brother of Artemis.

Refs: 1.36, 1.43, 1.370, 1.479, 4.101, 5.437, 16.788, 21.545, 22.213, 24.18

...and throughout. Books 1–2, 4–5, 7–13, 15–18, 20–24.

See also: Chryses, Artemis, Leto, Patroclus, Hector, Aeneas.

Archelochus (Ἀρχέλοχος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ar-KEL-oh-kus

One of Antenor's sons, named in the Catalogue and again among the captains of the Trojan storming-parties at the wall, always paired with his brother Acamas as "skilled in all fighting." Telamonian Ajax kills him in Book 14 with a cast meant for Polydamas: the spear takes him where head and neck join and shears both tendons, so that his head strikes the ground before his knees do. Ajax then calls across to Polydamas to say whether the man is a fair exchange for Prothoenor.

Kin: son of Antenor; brother of Acamas.

Killed by: Ajax (14.463–468).

Refs: 2.823, 12.100, 14.463. Books 2, 12, 14.

See also: Antenor, Acamas, Ajax, Polydamas, Prothoenor.

Areithous (Ἀρήϊθος) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-REE-thoh-us

Three men. The first is the fighter of Nestor's Book 7 reminiscence, called by his surname the Club-man because he fought with neither bow nor long spear but smashed companies apart with a club of iron; Lycurgus killed him by craft in a narrow lane where the club was useless, and stripped the armor that passed to Ereuthalion. The same man is named at 7.8–10 as the father of Menesthius of Arne, whom Paris kills, by ox-eyed Phylomedusa. A third Areithous is a Thracian charioteer, Rhigmus' aide, whom Achilles spears in the back at 20.487.

Kin: the Club-man is husband of Phylomedusa and father of Menesthius.

Killed by: the Club-man by Lycurgus (7.142–145); the Thracian aide by Achilles (20.487–489).

Refs: 7.8, 7.10, 7.137, 7.138, 20.487. Books 7, 20.

See also: Menesthius, Lycurgus, Ereuthalion, Nestor, Rhigmus, Achilles.

Ares (Ἄρης) · GOD — *Say:* AIR-eez

The war-god, who fights on the Trojan side and is the least dignified of the Olympians in the poem's handling of him. Athena leads him off the field by the hand in Book 5 and then, at Diomedes' shoulder, rams the mortal's spear into his belly, so that he bellows like ten thousand men and flees to Zeus, who tells him he is the most hateful of the gods. In Book 21 Athena knocks him flat with a boundary-stone and he covers seven acres falling. His son Ascalaphus is killed at Troy (13.518) and he is barred from avenging him by Zeus's designs.

Epithets: "bane of mortals" (βροτολοιγός, 5.31); "blood-stained" (μυιαφόνος, 5.31); "stormer of walls" (τειχεσιπλήτης, 5.31); "rushing" (θοῦρος, 5.30);

ARGIVES – ARION

"insatiate of war" (ἄτοξ πολέμοιο, 5.388); "brazen Ares" (χάλκεος Ἄρης, 5.704);

"massive" (ὄβριμος, 5.845); "turncoat" (ἄλλοπρόσαλλος, 5.831).

Also called: Enyalios — chiefly in the formula "the equal of Enyalios, slayer of men" for Meriones (2.651).

Kin: son of Zeus and Hera; father of Ascalaphus and Ialmenus by Astyoche.

Refs: 5.30, 5.31, 5.385, 5.859, 13.521, 15.113, 21.391, 21.406 ...and

throughout. Books 2–13, 15–24.

See also: Athena, Diomedes, Ascalaphus, Aphrodite, Zeus.

Argives (Ἀργεῖοι) · PEOPLE — Say: AR-jyvz or AR-gyvz

One of the poem's three interchangeable names for the whole Greek host, taken from Argos and used without distinction from Achaeans and Danaans — the choice among them is metrical, not ethnic. Helen is "Argive Helen" (2.161); the plague and the grief are the Argives' as often as the Achaeans'; and the assemblies, the funeral games, and the fighting at the ships are all narrated with the three names in rotation.

Also called: Achaeans; Danaans — the same host under three names. The Myrmidons and Hellenes are Achilles' own contingent and are not synonyms for the army.

Refs: 1.79, 1.119, 2.109, 2.159, 5.3, 7.350, 9.22 ...and throughout.

Books 1–19, 21–24.

See also: Achaeans, Danaans, Argos, Helen.

Argos (Ἄργος) · PLACE — Say: AR-gos

Agamemnon's realm — the sceptre makes him "lord over many islands and all of Argos" (2.108) — and, loosely, the whole Greek mainland the army came from and hopes to go home to: "horse-pasturing Argos," "Achaean Argos, udder of the plowland." The Catalogue gives a narrower Argos, held with Tiryns by Diomedes (2.559); Hera names it first of the three cities dearest to her, with Sparta and Mycenae, and offers all three for Troy's destruction (4.52–53). Bellerophon's Ephyra lies "in a fold of horse-pasturing Argos" (6.152).

Refs: 1.30, 2.108, 2.559, 4.52, 6.152, 9.22, 9.141, 19.115, 24.437.

Books 1–7, 9, 12–15, 19, 24.

See also: Argives, Agamemnon, Diomedes, Mycenae, Hera.

Arion (Ἀρίων) · OTHER — Say: uh-RY-on

Adrastus' horse, "whose line was from the gods," named once: Nestor coaches Antilochus that if he takes the turn well no one will catch him — not even a man driving Arion, nor the horses of Laomedon.

Kin: Adrastus' horse.

Refs: 23.346, Book 23.

See also: Adrastus, Nestor, Antilochus, Laomedon.

Arisbe (Αρίσβη) · PLACE — Say: uh-RIZ-bee

A town on the Trojan side, held with Sestus and Abydos by Asius son of Hyrtacus, whose tall fire-colored horses came from there, from the river Selleïs — a detail the poem repeats verbatim when he storms the wall (2.838 = 12.96). Axylus, killed by Diomedes in Book 6, lived there and kept an open house by the road; and it is to Arisbe that Eëtion of Imbros sends Lycaon after ransoming him.

Refs: 2.836, 2.838, 6.13, 12.96, 21.43. Books 2, 6, 12, 21.

See also: Asius, Axylus, Lycaon, Abydos.

Artemis (Ἄρτεμις) · GOD — Say: AR-tuh-mis

Apollo's sister, huntress and killer of women, who takes the Trojan side in the theomachy and is humiliated for it: Hera catches both her wrists in one hand, strips the bow from her shoulders, boxes her about the ears with it until the arrows spill, and she flees weeping to Zeus's knees like a dove from a hawk (21.479–513). Elsewhere she works chiefly in the back-stories, as the god whose anger kills — Andromache's mother, Bellerophon's daughter, Niobe's six daughters, and the boar sent against Calydon when Oeneus forgot her offering.

Epithets: "who showers arrows" (ιοχέαιρα, 5.53); "of the golden reins" (χρυσήνιος, 6.205).

Kin: daughter of Zeus and Leto; sister of Apollo.

Refs: 5.51, 5.53, 6.205, 6.428, 9.533, 20.39, 21.471, 24.606. Books 5–6, 9, 16, 19–21, 24.

See also: Apollo, Leto, Hera, Niobe, Andromache, Bellerophon, Calydon.

Ascalaphus (Ἀσκάλαφος) · MORTAL — Say: as-KAL-uh-fus

A son of Ares, who with his brother Ialmenus leads thirty ships from Aspledon and Mynyan Orchomenus; Astyoche bore the two of them in Actor's house, having gone up to her upper chamber where the god lay with her in secret. He stands the night watch in Book 9 and dies in Book 13, when Deiphobus' cast — aimed elsewhere — takes him through the shoulder. Ares knows nothing of it, penned on Olympus by Zeus's designs, until Hera tells him at 15.110; then he beats his thighs and calls for his armor.

Kin: son of Ares and Astyoche; brother of Ialmenus.

Killed by: Deiphobus (13.518–520).

Refs: 2.512, 9.82, 13.478, 13.518, 13.526, 15.112. Books 2, 9, 13, 15.

See also: Ares, Ialmenus, Astyoche, Deiphobus, Actor.

Asclepius (Ἀσκληπιός) · GOD — Say: as-KLEE-pee-us

The healer, father of the army's two physicians, Podaleirius and Machaon, who lead thirty ships from Tricca and Ithome. He does not appear: the name is a patronymic throughout, and the poem calls him "the blameless healer" whenever Machaon is fetched to a wound. His own healing knowledge came from Chiron, who "once gave his father" the soothing drugs Machaon uses on Menelaus (4.219).

Kin: father of Machaon and Podaleirius; taught by Chiron.

Refs: 2.731, 4.194, 4.204, 11.518, 11.614, 14.2. Books 2, 4, 11, 14.

See also: Machaon, Podaleirius, Chiron, Tricca.

Asius (Ἄσιος) · MORTAL — Say: AY-see-us

Three men bear the name. The chief one is Hyrtacus' son, leader of the contingent from Percote, Sestus, Abydos and Arisbe, "whom horses carried from Arisbe, tall and fire-colored, from the river Selleis" — a couplet repeated verbatim in Book 12 when he alone of the Trojan captains refuses Polydamas' advice to dismount and drives his chariot at the gate. Idomeneus spears him under the chin, and he falls like an oak cut for ship-timber, bellowing and clawing at the bloody dust. A second Asius is Hecuba's brother, son of Dymas, whose likeness Apollo borrows to urge Hector on (16.717); a third is the father of Phaenops of Abydos (17.583).

Kin: the leader is son of Hyrtacus and father of Adamas; the second is son of Dymas and brother of Hecuba.

Killed by: Idomeneus (13.387–393).

Refs: 2.837, 2.838, 12.96, 12.110, 12.140, 13.384, 13.771, 16.717, 17.583.

Books 2, 12–13, 16–17.

See also: Adamas, Idomeneus, Polydamas, Arisbe, Hecuba, Phaenops.

Asteropaeus (Ἀστεροπαῖος) · MORTAL — Say: as-ter-oh-PEE-us

Leader of the Paeonians of the long lances, at Troy eleven days when he dies, and picked out by Sarpedon with Glaucus as the best of the allies after himself. In Book 21 he stands up out of the Scamander to face Achilles, throws both spears at once — "for he was a two-handed fighter" — grazes Achilles' elbow with one and pins the other's shield with the first cast to draw the blood of a god's gift. Achilles kills him with the sword and strips him; the corslet and the Thracian sword become prizes at Patroclus' games.

Kin: son of Pelegon; grandson of the river Axius by Periboea, daughter of Aecessamenus.

Killed by: Achilles (21.179–182).

Refs: 12.102, 17.351, 21.140, 21.162, 21.170, 23.560, 23.808. Books 12, 17,

21, 23.

See also: Axius, Pelegon, Achilles, Paeonians, Sarpedon, Glaucus.

Astyanax (Ἀστυάναξ) · MORTAL — *Say:* as-TY-uh-naks

Hector's infant son, carried to the Scaean Gates in his nurse's arms and frightened by his own father's helmet. The poem glosses the name twice and both times the gloss is the child's doom: his father called him Scamandrius, "but the others Astyanax — for Hector alone was the saving of Ilion" (6.402–403); and Andromache, keening over the body, repeats it — "Astyanax, 'the lord of the city,' as the Trojans call him by name: for you alone guarded their gates and their long walls" (22.506–507). She foresees him pushed from other men's tables and fatherless.

Also called: Scamandrius — Hector's own name for him.

Kin: son of Hector and Andromache; grandson of Priam.

Refs: 6.403, 22.500, 22.506. Books 6, 22.

See also: Hector, Andromache, Scamandrius, Priam.

Athena (Ἀθήνη) · GOD — *Say:* uh-THEE-nuh

The Achaeans' fiercest divine partisan and, with Hera, the implacable enemy of Troy. She checks Achilles' sword-hand in Book 1, seizing him by the hair and visible to him alone; she stops the army's flight to the ships in Book 2; and on Zeus's word — obtained by Hera — she goes down to make the Trojans break the truce first (4.64–73). In Book 5 she mounts Diomedes' chariot herself and guides his spear into Ares' belly. Her last work is the cruelest: she takes Deiphobus' shape to persuade Hector to stand, hands Achilles his spear back, and leaves Hector calling for a brother who is not there (22.214–247).

Epithets: "grey-eyed," standalone "grey-eyes" (γλαυκῶπις, 1.206 / 8.373); "the driver of the spoil" (ἀγελείη, 4.128); "Unwearied one" (Ἀτρυτώνη, 2.157) — translated, not transliterated; "she of the mighty father" (ὀβριμοπάτερη, 5.747); "guardian of the city" (ἐρυσίπολις, 6.305).

Also called: Pallas; Tritogeneia (4.515).

Kin: daughter of Zeus.

Refs: 1.194, 1.200, 2.156, 4.73, 5.1, 5.856, 21.406, 22.214 ...and throughout.

Books 1–11, 13–24.

See also: Zeus, Hera, Diomedes, Achilles, Hector, Ares.

Athenians (Ἀθηναῖοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* uh-THEE-nee-unz

The contingent from Athens, "the district of great-hearted Erechtheus," under Menestheus son of Peteos with fifty ships. They are a minor presence in the

fighting: "masters of the war-cry" when Agamemnon comes on them in his review of the army, and picked men holding the line against Hector's charge at the ships in Book 13, where Stichius, Pheidas and Bias fight beside Menestheus. Iasus, son of Sphelus, is set a captain over them, and Aeneas kills him at 15.332.

Kin: led by Menestheus, Peteos' son.

Refs: 2.550, 4.328, 13.196, 13.689, 15.337. Books 2, 4, 13, 15.

See also: Menestheus, Peteos, Erechtheus, Stichius, Bias, Iasus.

Atreus (Ἀτρεΰς) · MORTAL — *Say:* AY-tree-us or AY-troos

Father of Agamemnon and Menelaus, and the man from whose hand the sceptre passed to Thyestes and so to Agamemnon in the descent traced at 2.101–108. He is dead before the poem opens and never acts in it: in nearly all of the name's 181 occurrences it is a patronymic, and "Atreus' son" in the singular means Agamemnon unless the scene is Menelaus's — the duel of Book 3, the oath-breaking and the wounding of Book 4, the fight over Patroclus' body. The dual "Atreus' sons" means the two brothers together. See `canon.md` for the rule.

Kin: son of Pelops; brother of Thyestes; father of Agamemnon and Menelaus.

Refs: 1.7, 2.105, 2.106, 2.249, 3.271, 9.340, 11.131 ...and throughout.

Books 1–11, 13–14, 16–17, 19, 22–24.

See also: Agamemnon, Menelaus, Thyestes, Pelops.

Augeias (Αὔγείας) · MORTAL — *Say:* aw-JEE-us

An Epeian king of the older generation, "lord of men," named only in genealogy and in Nestor's long reminiscence of the Pylian cattle-raid. He had kept four prize-winning horses that came to Elis for the games and sent their driver home grieving — the debt that provoked Neleus' raid. Nestor's first kill in that fight was Augeias' son-in-law Mulius, husband of his eldest daughter, tawny-haired Agamede.

Kin: grandfather of Polyxeinus through Agasthenes; father of Agamede; father-in-law of Mulius.

Refs: 2.624, 11.701, 11.739. Books 2, 11.

See also: Nestor, Epeians, Elis, Mulius, Agamede, Polyxeinus.

Automedon (Αὐτομέδων) · MORTAL — *Say:* aw-TOM-uh-don

Achilles' charioteer, "the man he honored most after Achilles breaker of men, and trustiest at his post to await the shout of battle" (16.146–147). He yokes Xanthus and Balius for Patroclus and drives him out; when Patroclus is dead he fights on alone from the chariot, swooping like a vulture on geese and taking no man, because one man cannot both hold the immortal horses and use a spear — until

Alcimedon asks who took his wits and takes the reins from him. He drives Achilles back to the war in Book 19 and helps serve Priam his supper in Book 24.

Kin: son of Diore (17.429, 17.474).

Refs: 9.209, 16.145, 16.864, 17.429, 17.459, 17.474, 19.396, 24.574.

Books 9, 16–17, 19, 23–24.

See also: Achilles, Patroclus, Alcimedon, Alcimus, Xanthus (horse).

Axius (Ἀξίος) · PLACE — *Say:* AK-see-us

The Paeonian river, twice praised in the same phrase — "the wide-flowing Axius, whose water spreads fairest over the earth" — as the country the Paeonians of the curved bows come from, with Amydon, under Pyraechmes. As a river-god he lay with Periboea, eldest daughter of Aecessamenus, and begot Pelegon, so that Asteropaeus recites him as the head of his own line when Achilles asks who he is (21.157–160).

Refs: 2.849, 2.850, 16.288, 21.141, 21.157, 21.158. Books 2, 16, 21.

See also: Asteropaeus, Pelegon, Paeonians, Pyraechmes, Amydon.

Bear (ἄρκτος) · OTHER

The constellation set on the Shield of Achilles among the Pleiades, the Hyades and Orion — "the Bear, which men also call by the name of the Wagon, who turns in her own place, keeping watch on Orion, and alone has no share in the baths of Ocean" (18.487–489). The one occurrence; the token's other appearances in the poem are the imperative "Bear up."

Also called: the Wagon.

Refs: 18.487. Book 18.

See also: Orion, Ocean, Achilles, Hephaestus.

Bellerophon (Βελλεροφόντης) · MORTAL — *Say:* buh-LAIR-uh-fon

Glaucus' grandfather, whose story is the long back-piece of the Book 6 meeting with Diomedes. Proetus, believing his wife Anteia's lie, sent him to Lycia with "baneful signs" scratched in a folded tablet — the poem's one mention of writing — and the Lycian king set him three tasks meant to kill him: the Chimaera, the Solymi, the Amazons. He survived all three and an ambush besides, and was given the king's daughter and half his kingly honor. He ended hated by the gods, wandering the Aleian plain alone and eating out his heart, his son killed by Ares and his daughter by Artemis. His guest-friendship with Oeneus is what stops Glaucus and Diomedes from fighting.

Kin: son of Glaucus, grandson of Sisyphus; father of Isander, Hippolochus and Laodameia; grandfather of Glaucus and, through Laodameia and Zeus, of Sarpedon.

Refs: 6.155, 6.162, 6.190, 6.196, 6.200, 6.217, 6.220. Book 6.

See also: Glaucus, Hippolochus, Sarpedon, Proetus, Anteia, Chimaera, Oeneus, Diomedes.

Bias (Βίας) · MORTAL — Say: BY-us

Three men. One is a Pylian, "Bias, shepherd of the people," named among the captains Nestor is arraying at 4.296. Another is an Athenian, "brave Bias," in Menestheus' company at the ships (13.691). The third is named only as a father: Achilles kills "Laogonus and Dardanus, the two sons of Bias," tumbling both from their horses, one with a spear-throw and one with the sword (20.460–462).

Kin: the third is father of Laogonus and Dardanus.

Refs: 4.296, 13.691, 20.460. Books 4, 13, 20.

See also: Nestor, Menestheus, Laogonus, Achilles.

Blindness (ἄτης) · GOD

ἄτης personified — the ruinous folly that comes over a man before he acts. Phoenix makes her the runner the limping Prayers can never catch: "Blindness is strong and sound of foot, and far outruns them all, and gets in first over all the earth tripping mankind" (9.505–507). Agamemnon builds his whole apology on her in Book 19, calling her "the eldest daughter of Zeus, who blinds all men," whose feet are soft and walk over men's heads, and telling how she once blinded Zeus himself over the birth of Heracles, so that he seized her by her shining braids and flung her out of heaven forever. She also takes Patroclus' mind at 16.805, when Apollo has struck him.

Kin: eldest daughter of Zeus.

Refs: 9.504, 9.505, 9.512, 16.805, 19.91, 19.126, 19.129, 19.136.

Books 9, 16, 19.

See also: Prayers, Agamemnon, Zeus, Phoenix, Patroclus.

Boeotians (Βοιωτοί) · PEOPLE — Say: bee-OH-shunz

The first contingent of the Catalogue of Ships, under five leaders — Peneleos, Leïtus, Arcesilaus, Prothoenor and Clonius — with fifty ships and a hundred and twenty young men to each. They hold the left of the line at the muster, and turn up again where the fighting is thickest: Hera watches two of them killing Argives in Book 5, and Hector cuts down Arcesilaus, "a leader of the bronze-shirted Boeotians," at 15.330.

Kin: led by Peneleos, Leïtus, Arcesilaus, Prothoenor and Clonius.

Refs: 2.494, 2.510, 2.526, 5.710, 13.685, 13.700, 15.330. Books 2, 5, 13, 15.

See also: Peneleos, Leïtus, Arcesilaus, Prothoenor, Achaeans.

Boreas (Βορέης) · GOD — Say: BOR-ee-us

The north wind, personified and genealogically active. He is the cold blast behind

the snow-simile of Book 19; he desired Erichthonius' three thousand mares as they pastured, covered them in the likeness of a dark-maned stallion, and got twelve foals so light they ran over standing grain without breaking it (20.223–226); and in Book 23 Iris fetches him with Zephyrus from the feast in Zephyrus' house, at Achilles' prayer, to make Patroclus' pyre burn.

Refs: 19.358, 20.223, 23.195, 23.208. Books 19, 20, 23.

See also: Zephyrus, Iris, Erichthonius, Patroclus, Achilles.

Briseis (Βρισηΐς) · MORTAL — *Say:* bry-SEE-is

Achilles' prize, taken from him by Agamemnon in compensation for Chryseis, and so the occasion — not the cause — of the quarrel that is the poem's subject. Achilles had taken her out of Lyrnessus, where he killed her husband Mynes; she goes from his hut unwilling, led out by Patroclus. Agamemnon offers her back in Book 9 with an oath he never touched her, and swears that oath publicly over a boar in Book 19. Her one speech is the lament for Patroclus, who had promised to make her Achilles' wedded wife in Phthia and who "was gentle, always" — after which the women wail "for Patroclus in show; but each for her own sorrows." She is restored to Achilles' side in the poem's last book.

Epithets: "fair-cheeked" (καλλιπάρηος, 1.184).

Also called: the daughter of Briseus.

Kin: daughter of Briseus; widow of Mynes of Lyrnessus.

Refs: 1.184, 1.323, 1.346, 2.689, 9.107, 19.246, 19.282, 24.676.

Books 1–2, 9, 19, 24.

See also: Briseus, Achilles, Agamemnon, Patroclus, Chryseis, Mynes, Lyrnessus.

Briseus (Βρισεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* BRY-syoos

Briseis' father, who never appears and is never described. The name occurs only in the periphrasis "the daughter of Briseus" — Achilles' complaint to Thetis (1.392) and, twice over, in Agamemnon's list of amends and Odysseus' verbatim relaying of it (9.132 = 9.274).

Kin: father of Briseis.

Refs: 1.392, 9.132, 9.274. Books 1, 9.

See also: Briseis, Achilles, Agamemnon.

Cadmeans (Καδμεῖοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* kad-MEE-unz

The Thebans of the earlier war, named only in the back-story of Tydeus' embassy. Sent forward alone from the Asopus, he found them feasting in Eteocles' house, challenged them to contests and won every one with Athena's help; they set fifty young men to ambush him on the road home, and he killed all but one. Agamemnon

tells the story to shame Diomedes, and Athena tells it again herself to shame him further; Diomedes recalls it to her on the night raid.

Refs: 4.385, 4.388, 4.391, 5.804, 10.288. Books 4, 5, 10.

See also: Tydeus, Diomedes, Athena, Eteocles, Thebes, Maeon.

Calchas (Κάλλας) · MORTAL — Say: KAL-kus

The army's seer, "far the best of bird-readers, who knew what is, what will be, and what was before," and who had guided the ships to Ilion by the craft Apollo gave him. He names the plague's cause only after Achilles guarantees his safety, and Agamemnon answers him as "seer of evils" — the exchange that opens the quarrel. Odysseus recalls his reading of the serpent and the nine sparrows at Aulis, which fixed the war at nine years and a tenth. In Book 13 Poseidon takes his shape to rally the two Ajaxes, and Ajax son of Oïleus knows the god by his footprints going away — "and that is not Calchas."

Also called: Thestor's son.

Kin: son of Thestor.

Refs: 1.69, 1.86, 1.105, 2.300, 2.322, 13.45, 13.70. Books 1, 2, 13.

See also: Apollo, Agamemnon, Achilles, Poseidon, Ajax son of Oïleus, Aulis.

Calydon (Καλυδών) · PLACE — Say: KAL-ih-don

Oeneus' city in Aetolia, "rocky Calydon" of the Catalogue and "lovely Calydon" of Phoenix's tale. Artemis raised the war between the Curetes and the Aetolians over it in anger at Oeneus' forgotten harvest-offering, and it is the city Meleager would not defend until his wife described what a sacked town looks like — the exemplum Phoenix presses on Achilles in Book 9. Poseidon takes the shape of Thoas, who rules "all Pleuron and steep Calydon," to stir Idomeneus; and Diomedes names it in reciting Portheus' three sons.

Refs: 2.640, 9.530, 9.531, 9.577, 13.217, 14.116. Books 2, 9, 13, 14.

See also: Meleager, Oeneus, Aetolians, Curetes, Phoenix, Thoas, Artemis.

Capaneus (Καπανεύς) · MORTAL — Say: KAP-uh-nyoos

One of the Seven against Thebes and father of Sthenelus, Diomedes' charioteer. He does not appear: the name is a patronymic throughout — "Sthenelus, Capaneus' son" — and it carries the argument his son makes at 4.404–410, that the sons who took seven-gated Thebes with a smaller host were better men than the fathers who perished there by their own recklessness.

Kin: father of Sthenelus.

Refs: 2.564, 4.367, 4.403, 5.108, 5.109, 5.241, 5.319. Books 2, 4, 5.

See also: Sthenelus, Diomedes, Thebes, Tydeus.

Cassandra (Κασσάνδρη) · MORTAL — Say: kuh-SAN-druh

Priam's daughter, "the loveliest of Priam's daughters," whom Othryoneus asked for without bride-gifts, promising to drive the Achaeans out of Troy; Priam bowed his head to it, and Idomeneus killed him for it. She has one living appearance, in the last book: she has climbed Pergamus and is the first to see her father coming back with the herald and the body on the bier, and her cry through the city brings all Troy out to the gates. The poem says nothing of her prophecy.

Kin: daughter of Priam and Hecuba.

Refs: 13.366, 24.699. Books 13, 24.

See also: Priam, Othryoneus, Hector, Idomeneus.

Cebriones (Κεβριόνης) · MORTAL — Say: seb-RY-oh-neeZ

Hector's half-brother, "a bastard son of far-famed Priam," who takes the reins after Archeptolemus is killed and drives for Hector through the rest of the poem. He is the man Hector left the chariot to when the Trojans went at the wall on foot, and it is he who tells Hector the Trojans are being driven on the other wing. In Book 16 Patroclus kills him with a jagged stone that crushes both brows together and drops his eyes into the dust at his feet, so that he goes over the rail "like a diver" — and Patroclus mocks him for it before the fight over his body, where he lies "mighty in his mightiness, his horsemanship all forgotten."

Kin: bastard son of Priam; brother of Hector.

Killed by: Patroclus (16.737–743).

Refs: 8.318, 11.521, 12.91, 13.790, 16.727, 16.738, 16.756, 16.776.

Books 8, 11–13, 16.

See also: Hector, Patroclus, Priam, Archeptolemus.

Chiron (Χείρων) · MORTAL — Say: KY-ron

"The most righteous of the Centaurs," named four times and always as a source of gifts to the house of Peleus. He taught the healing drugs Achilles knows and passed on to Patroclus, and which reach Menelaus' arrow-wound through Machaon's hands, Asclepius having had them from him. And he gave Peleus the Pelian ash from the peak of Pelion, "to be death for heroes" — the spear no other Achaean could swing, which Patroclus alone of Achilles' arms leaves behind when he borrows the rest.

Refs: 4.219, 11.832, 16.143, 19.390. Books 4, 11, 16, 19.

See also: Achilles, Peleus, Patroclus, Machaon, Asclepius, Pelion.

Chromius (Χρομῖος) · MORTAL — Say: KROH-mee-us

At least four men, on both sides. One is a Pylion, in the group Nestor is arraying at 4.295. A son of Priam of the name is taken with his brother Echemmon, both from

one chariot, when Diomedes falls on them like a lion among cattle (5.160). A Lycian falls in Odysseus' rally at 5.677, and another Trojan-side man to Teucer's bow at 8.275. A fifth is alive in Book 17, ranged among the Trojan allies Hector harangues and then, with Aeneas and Hector, drawing back from Automedon's rescuers and leaving Aretus dead.

Refs: 4.295, 5.160, 5.677, 8.275, 17.218, 17.494, 17.534. Books 4, 5, 8, 17.

See also: Nestor, Diomedes, Odysseus, Teucer, Aretus, Automedon.

Chryse (Χρύση) · PLACE — Say: KRY-see

The town of Apollo's priest Chryses, over which the god "stands guard" with Cilla and Tenedos in the prayer that brings the plague. It is where the hecatomb has to go: Odysseus sails there with the girl and the beasts, and the ceremony on its shore — the prayer, the thigh-bones, the paeon sung all afternoon — is the poem's fullest account of a sacrifice made right.

Refs: 1.37, 1.100, 1.390, 1.431, 1.451. Book 1.

See also: Chryses, Chryseis, Apollo, Cilla, Tenedos, Odysseus.

Chryseis (Χρυσηΐς) · MORTAL — Say: kry-SEE-is

Daughter of the priest Chryses, given to Agamemnon out of the plunder of Eëtion's Thebe. Agamemnon refuses her ransom and says he prefers her to Clytemnestra, "since she is not her inferior in build or bearing, in mind or in any work of her hands" — so the god's arrows come, and when he is forced to give her up he takes Briseis instead. Odysseus commands the ship that carries her home and puts her in her father's arms at the altar. She never speaks.

Epithets: "fair-cheeked" (καλλιπάρης, 1.143).

Kin: daughter of Chryses.

Refs: 1.112, 1.143, 1.182, 1.310, 1.369, 1.439. Book 1.

See also: Chryses, Chryse, Agamemnon, Apollo, Briseis, Odysseus.

Chryses (Χρύσης) · MORTAL — Say: KRY-seez

Apollo's priest, whose daughter Agamemnon holds as a prize. He comes to the ships with a ransom past counting and the god's wreaths on a golden staff; the army approves, Agamemnon sends him off harshly, and his prayer walking alone along the shore brings the plague that begins the poem. When Odysseus returns the girl to his arms at the altar of Chryse he prays a second time — "Once before you heard me when I prayed" — and the plague stops. He does not appear again.

Kin: father of Chryseis.

Refs: 1.11, 1.12, 1.370, 1.442, 1.450. Book 1.

See also: Chryseis, Chryse, Apollo, Agamemnon, Odysseus.

Clytius (Κλυτίος) · MORTAL — Say: KLIT-ee-us

One of Priam's brothers, a son of Laomedon, who sits with Lampus and Hicetaon among the elders at the Scaean Gates, "finished with war now because of age, but speakers of quality." He is named in both Trojan genealogies — the elder-list of Book 3 and Aeneas' recital of the house of Dardanus at 20.238 — and his son Caletor, carrying fire toward a ship, is killed by Ajax under Hector's eyes; Hector calls on the Trojans to save "the son of Clytius" and cast at Ajax for him. A second Clytius is the father of an Achaean Dolops killed by Hector at 11.302. *Kin:* son of Laomedon; brother of Priam, Tithonus, Lampus and Hicetaon; father of Caletor.

Refs: 3.147, 11.302, 15.419, 15.427, 20.238. Books 3, 11, 15, 20.

See also: Priam, Laomedon, Lampus, Hicetaon, Caletor, Dolops.

Coeranus (Κοίρανος) · MORTAL — Say: SEER-uh-nus

Meriones' aide and charioteer, who had followed him from well-founded Lyctus in Crete. Hector casts at Idomeneus, misses, and hits Coeranus instead — the spear under the jaw and ear, dashing his teeth out at the roots and cutting the tongue through the middle, so that he crashes from the chariot and pours the reins to the ground. The poem stops to say that his driving up had saved Idomeneus, on foot and in danger: "to him he came as light, and beat off the pitiless day — and lost his own life." A different Coeranus is a Lycian killed by Odysseus at 5.677.

Killed by: Hector (17.610–619).

Refs: 5.677, 17.611, 17.614. Books 5, 17.

See also: Meriones, Idomeneus, Hector, Lyctus.

Coon (Κόων) · MORTAL — Say: KOH-on

Antenor's eldest son, who stabs Agamemnon mid-forearm from the side, unseen, after watching him strip his fallen brother Iphidamas — "strong grief came down over his eyes." Agamemnon shudders but fights on, spears him as he drags the body away by the foot, and cuts his head off over Iphidamas. The wound is what drives Agamemnon from the field, and he is still carrying it in Book 19 when he comes late to the assembly of reconciliation.

Kin: son of Antenor; brother of Iphidamas.

Killed by: Agamemnon (11.256–261).

Refs: 11.248, 11.256, 11.257, 19.53. Books 11, 19.

See also: Antenor, Iphidamas, Agamemnon.

Cos (Κόως) · PLACE — Say: kos

"Cos, city of Eurypylus," an island of the Catalogue's southeast group, sending

thirty ships under Pheidippus and Antiphus, sons of Thessalus and grandsons of Heracles. It matters chiefly in the back-story Hera and Zeus each rehearse: after the sack of Troy, Hera laid Zeus's mind asleep and Sleep roused the winds that carried Heracles far off course to "well-peopled Cos," for which Zeus hunted the gods through his house and would have flung Sleep into the sea.

Refs: 2.677, 14.255, 15.28. Books 2, 14, 15.

See also: Heracles, Sleep, Hera, Zeus.

Cretans (Κρήτες) · PEOPLE — *Say:* KREE-tunz

Idomeneus' contingent, eighty ships from Knossos, Gortyn and hundred-citied Crete, led by him with Meriones. They are named almost always through their leader, in the formulas "Idomeneus, leader of the Cretans" and "counselor of the bronze-shirted Cretans" that carry his long exchange with Meriones in Book 13. Helen points them out from the wall — Idomeneus standing among them "like a god, and the Cretan captains gathered around him" — and Agamemnon finds them arming in his review of the army.

Kin: led by Idomeneus and Meriones.

Refs: 2.645, 3.230, 4.251, 4.265, 13.219, 13.255, 23.450, 23.482.

Books 2–4, 13, 23.

See also: Idomeneus, Meriones, Crete, Achaeans.

Crete (Κρήτη) · PLACE

Idomeneus' island, "hundred-citied Crete" of the Catalogue, whose towns — Knossos, Gortyn, Lyctus, Miletus, chalk-white Lycastus, Phaestus, Rhytium — the poem lists in full. Helen recalls that Menelaus was often host to Idomeneus "whenever he came from Crete." Idomeneus gives its royal line to Othryoneus as a boast just before he kills him: Zeus begot Minos, Minos begot Deucalion, and Deucalion begot Idomeneus, "lord over many men in wide Crete."

Refs: 2.649, 3.233, 13.450, 13.453. Books 2, 3, 13.

See also: Idomeneus, Cretans, Minos, Deucalion, Meriones.

Cronos (Κρόνος) · GOD — *Say:* KROH-nos

Zeus's father, deposed and shut away: Zeus "put Cronos down beneath the earth and the barren sea" (14.203–204), and he sits now at the nethermost limits of earth and sea with Iapetus, in Tartarus, taking no joy in Hyperion the Sun (8.479–481) — the gods gathered around him below are the Titans Hera swears by (14.274–279). He never acts. Of the name's 109 occurrences almost all are the patronymic "Cronos' son," which means **Zeus**; Hera and Poseidon are also his children, and Poseidon's claim to equal honor rests on it: "Three brothers are we, whom Rhea bore to Cronos"

(15.187).

Epithets: "crooked-counseled Cronos" (ἀγκυλομήτεω Κρόνου, 2.205).

Kin: with Rhea, father of Zeus, Poseidon, Hades, Hera and Demeter.

Refs: 2.205, 4.59, 5.721, 8.479, 14.203, 14.274, 15.187, 15.225 ...and

throughout, chiefly as the patronymic of Zeus. Books 1–9, 11–22, 24.

See also: Zeus, Rhea, Poseidon, Hera, Hades, Iapetus, Titans.

Curetes (Κουρήτες) · PEOPLE — *Say:* kyoo-REE-teez

The besiegers of Calydon in Phoenix's tale of Meleager, fighting the Aetolians over the head and hide of the boar Artemis sent against Oeneus' orchards. While Meleager fought they could not hold their ground outside the wall, though they were many; when he withdrew in anger at his mother they came on until the chamber itself was under bombardment. The exemplum Phoenix presses on Achilles turns on their advance.

Refs: 9.529, 9.532, 9.549, 9.551, 9.588. Book 9.

See also: Meleager, Aetolians, Calydon, Oeneus, Phoenix, Artemis.

Danaans (Δαναοί) · PEOPLE — *Say:* DAN-ay-unz or DAN-uh-unz

The third of the poem's interchangeable names for the whole Greek host, alongside Achaeans and Argives; the choice among the three is metrical, not ethnic. It is the name in Chryses' curse — "may the Danaans pay for my tears by your arrows" (1.42) — and the one the Catalogue uses for the leaders it is about to list. Agamemnon's standing address to the army is "Friends, Danaan heroes, squires of Ares."

Epithets: "the Danaans of swift colts" (ταχύπωλοι Δαναοί, 4.232).

Also called: Achaeans; Argives — the same host under three names. The Myrmidons and Hellenes are Achilles' own contingent and are not synonyms for the army.

Refs: 1.42, 1.56, 2.110, 2.487, 4.232, 4.257, 7.382, 8.161 ...and throughout.

Books 1–17, 19–21, 23–24.

See also: Achaeans, Argives, Agamemnon.

Dardania (Δαρδανία) · PLACE — *Say:* dar-DAY-nee-uh

The city Dardanus founded on the lower slopes of many-springed Ida, "for holy Ilion was not yet built on the plain, a city of mortal men" (20.216–218) — the elder settlement of the Trojan line, named in Aeneas' genealogy. Elsewhere it is a region paired with Troy as the home of the women who will mourn: Achilles means to make "some deep-girdled woman of Troy or Dardania" wipe the tears from her cheeks, and promises the same women will keen night and day around Patroclus' body.

Refs: 18.123, 18.339, 20.216. Books 18, 20.

See also: Dardanus, Dardanians, Troy, Ida, Aeneas.

Dardanians (Δάρδανοι) · PEOPLE — Say: dar-DAY-nee-unz

Aeneas' people, Trojan-side allies of the house of Dardanus, led by "the good son of Anchises" with Antenor's sons Archelochus and Acamas. The name lives chiefly in two fixed address-formulas that recur across the battle books: "Hear from me, Trojans and Dardanians and allies," and the rallying line "Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians who fight at close quarters — be men, my friends; remember your rushing courage" (8.173–174, repeated verbatim five times). The Dardanian gates of Troy are named for them, and Euphorbus, who strikes Patroclus first, is introduced simply as "a Dardanian."

Kin: led by Aeneas, Anchises' son.

Refs: 2.819, 3.456, 7.348, 8.173, 11.286, 15.425, 16.806, 17.184.

Books 2–3, 5, 7–8, 11, 13, 15–17, 22.

See also: Aeneas, Anchises, Dardanus, Trojans, Euphorbus.

Dardanus (Δάρδανος) · MORTAL — Say: DAR-duh-nus

Founder of the Trojan line and its eponym: "Dardanus first was begotten by cloud-gatherer Zeus, and he founded Dardania" (20.215–216), in the days before Ilion stood on the plain. Aeneas recites the descent to Achilles, and Poseidon saves Aeneas so "the race of Dardanus not perish seedless" — Zeus having loved Dardanus beyond all his mortal children, and having come to hate the line of Priam (20.302–306). He never acts: outside the two genealogies the name is the patronymic "Dardanus' descendant," used of Priam throughout and of the ancient Ilus at 11.166–372. A second Dardanus, a son of Bias, is killed with his brother Laogonus by Achilles at 20.460.

Kin: son of Zeus; father of Erichthonius; ancestor of Tros, Ilus, Laomedon, Priam, and through Assaracus of Aeneas.

Refs: 3.303, 5.159, 7.366, 11.166, 11.372, 20.215, 20.303, 21.34, 24.171.

Books 3, 5, 7, 11, 13, 20–22, 24.

See also: Priam, Aeneas, Dardania, Erichthonius, Ilus, Zeus, Bias.

Dawn (Ἠώς) · GOD

Personified daybreak, whose formulas divide the poem into days. She rises from her bed beside illustrious Tithonus "to bring light to the immortals and to mortal men" (11.1–2), spreads over all the earth in her saffron robe, and rises out of the streams of Ocean at 19.1 on the day Achilles arms. Her fixed line — "and when early-born rosy-fingered Dawn appeared" — opens days from Book 1 to the poem's close. She acts once in her own right, going up to high Olympus to announce the light to Zeus and the other gods (2.48); and in Book 8 she is what the Trojans wait

for, sitting all night by their fires.

Epithets: "rosy-fingered Dawn" (ροδοδάκτυλος Ἡώς, 1.477); "early-born" (ἡριγένεια, 1.477); "Dawn in her saffron robe" (κροκόπεπλος Ἡώς, 8.1); "fair-throned Dawn" (ἐὕθρονος Ἡώς, 8.565). Note χρυσόθρονος "of the golden throne" is **Hera's**, not Dawn's; all four occurrences are hers or Zeus's.

Kin: consort of Tithonus, Laomedon's son.

Refs: 1.477, 2.48, 8.1, 8.565, 9.240, 11.1, 19.1, 23.109, 24.695, 24.788.

Books 1–2, 6, 8–9, 11, 19, 23–24.

See also: Tithonus, Ocean, Sun, Zeus.

Death (Θάνατος) · GOD

Personified, and twinned with Sleep: "Sleep, the brother of Death" (14.231), "the twin brothers Sleep and Death" (16.672 = 16.682). Zeus, unable to keep Sarpedon alive, has Apollo wash the body in the running river, anoint it with ambrosia and give it to the two of them as escorts, who set him down in wide Lycia for his brothers and kinsmen to bury — "for that is the honor-right of the dead." Agamemnon uses the name unpersonified at 4.270 in the oath-breaking scene: "Death and sorrows hereafter will be theirs."

Kin: brother of Sleep.

Refs: 4.270, 14.231, 16.454, 16.672, 16.682. Books 4, 14, 16.

See also: Sleep, Sarpedon, Apollo, Zeus, Lycia.

Deiphobus (Δηϊφωβος) · MORTAL — Say: dee-IF-oh-bus

A son of Priam and Hecuba, one of the more active Trojan fighters and the shape Athena wears to kill Hector. He leads the third storming-party at the wall with Helenus, and in Book 13 he is everywhere: he grieves for Asius and kills Hypsenor in vengeance, vaunts over him, then strikes Ascalaphus down with a cast meant for Idomeneus and is wounded in the arm by Meriones over the body, so that Polites has to lead him out of the fighting. In Book 22 Athena takes his likeness "in body and unwearying voice," offers to stand with Hector, and vanishes; Hector calls for a spear and finds no one there — "he is inside the wall, and Athena has tricked me."

Kin: son of Priam and Hecuba; brother of Hector, Paris, Helenus and Polites.

Kills: Hypsenor (13.410–412); Ascalaphus (13.516–520).

Refs: 12.94, 13.156, 13.402, 13.413, 13.516, 13.534, 22.227, 22.294, 24.251.

Books 12–13, 22, 24.

See also: Priam, Hector, Athena, Helenus, Ascalaphus, Idomeneus, Meriones.

Demeter (Δημήτηρ) · GOD — Say: dih-MEE-tur

The grain-goddess, never present and never speaking. She stands behind the poem's

fixed way of saying "mortal": Ajax will not give way "to any man who is mortal and eats the grain of Demeter" (13.322), and Lycaon's plea to Achilles begins from the same phrase — "it was at your table first that I ate the grain of Demeter." She has a winnowing simile at 5.500, where "tawny-haired Demeter in the driving wind divides the grain from the husks"; a precinct at Pyrasus in the Catalogue; and a place in Zeus's list of loves, "the lady Demeter of the lovely braids."

Kin: daughter of Cronos and Rhea; sister of Zeus.

Refs: 2.696, 5.500, 13.322, 14.326, 21.76. Books 2, 5, 13, 14, 21.

See also: Zeus, Cronos, Lycaon, Ajax.

Deucalion (Δευκαλίων) · MORTAL — Say: dyoo-KAY-lee-on

Two men. The first is Idomeneus' father, son of Minos and grandson of Zeus, named only in the line Idomeneus recites over Othryoneus — "Minos got a son, blameless Deucalion; and Deucalion fathered me, lord over many men in wide Crete" — and otherwise carried as the patronymic "Deucalion's son," which the poem uses of Idomeneus at the moments of his greatest exposure (12.117, 17.608) and Meriones uses to address him. The second is a Trojan Achilles kills in Book 20, pierced through the arm where the tendons of the elbow join, so that he stands waiting with his arm hanging heavy and sees death in front of him.

Kin: the Cretan is son of Minos and father of Idomeneus.

Killed by: the Trojan by Achilles (20.478–483).

Refs: 12.117, 13.307, 13.451, 13.452, 17.608, 20.478. Books 12–13, 17, 20.

See also: Idomeneus, Minos, Crete, Meriones, Achilles.

Deïpyrus (Δηϊπυρος) · MORTAL — Say: dee-IP-ih-rus

An Achaean captain of the second rank, one of the seven leaders of the night sentries in Book 9 and one of the men Poseidon rallies and Idomeneus calls to in Book 13. Helenus kills him there at close quarters, shearing his helmet away with a great Thracian sword — the helmet knocked spinning off between the fighters' feet for some Achaean to pick up — and gloomy night comes down over his eyes. His death is what stirs Menelaus to the duel with Helenus that follows.

Killed by: Helenus (13.576–580).

Refs: 9.83, 13.92, 13.478, 13.576. Books 9, 13.

See also: Helenus, Menelaus, Idomeneus, Meriones, Aphareus.

Diomedes (Διομήδης) · MORTAL — Say: dy-oh-MEE-deez

Tydeus' son, lord of Argos and Tiryns with eighty ships, and the Achaean whose aristeia fills Book 5. Athena kindles unwearying fire from his helmet and shield, takes the mist from his eyes so that he may know god from man, and licenses him to

DIONE – DIORES

wound Aphrodite — which he does, drawing the ichor from her hand as she carries Aeneas off — and then mounts his chariot herself and rams his spear into Ares' belly. He is the poem's model of the young man who takes rebuke in silence: Agamemnon rakes him at 4.365 and he does not answer, and pays it back in the assembly of Book 9. He meets Glaucus between the lines, discovers their grandfathers' guest-friendship, and exchanges armor rather than blows; he goes with Odysseus on the night raid and kills Dolon and Rhesus; and he is wounded in the foot by Paris' arrow at 11.377.

Epithets: "good at the war-cry" (βοῆν ἀγαθός, 2.563).

Also called: Tydeus' son.

Kin: son of Tydeus of the Seven against Thebes; his charioteer is Sthenelus, Capaneus' son.

Refs: 2.563, 4.365, 5.1, 5.114, 5.330, 5.855, 6.122, 6.235, 9.31 ...and throughout. Books 2, 4–11, 14, 16, 21, 23.

See also: Tydeus, Sthenelus, Athena, Aphrodite, Ares, Glaucus, Odysseus, Dolon.

Dione (Διώνη) · GOD — *Say:* dy-OH-nee

Aphrodite's mother in this poem, named only in the scene after Diomedes wounds her. Aphrodite falls on her knees; Dione gathers her daughter in her arms, strokes her, and comforts her with a catalogue of gods who have suffered at mortal hands — Ares bound in a jar by Otus and Ephialtes, Hera and Hades shot by Heracles — before warning that a man who fights the immortals does not come home to his children.

Kin: mother of Aphrodite by Zeus.

Refs: 5.370, 5.371, 5.381. Book 5.

See also: Aphrodite, Zeus, Diomedes, Ares, Heracles.

Diores (Διώρης) · MORTAL — *Say:* dy-OR-eez

Two men. The first is an Epeian leader, Amarynceus' son, captain of the third of the four Elian companies, whose death closes the general fighting of Book 4: a jagged stone thrown by Peiroos of the Thracians crushes both tendons and the bones beside his right ankle, and he falls back in the dust stretching out his hands to his companions, and Peiroos runs up and spears him beside the navel. The second is Automedon's father, named only in the patronymic "Diores' son" during the fight over Patroclus' body.

Kin: the Epeian is son of Amarynceus; the second is father of Automedon.

Killed by: Peiroos (4.517–526).

Refs: 2.622, 4.517, 17.429, 17.474. Books 2, 4, 17.

See also: Amarynceus, Peiroos, Epeians, Automedon.

Dog (Κύων) · OTHER

The star Sirius, "the star men call by name the Dog of Orion" — brightest of all, rising at harvest-time among many stars in the milking-dark of night, "made an evil sign, and brings great fever down on wretched mortals." It is what Achilles' bronze looks like to Priam as he comes across the plain (22.26–32), the simile that opens the last hunt of Hector. The name's other occurrences in the poem are the insult: Achilles' "Dog's eyes and a deer's heart" to Agamemnon (1.225), the vaunt "Dog! Again you have run out from under death" that Diomedes and then Achilles throw at Hector (11.362 = 20.449), and Achilles' one-word refusal of Hector's dying plea (22.345).

Also called: the Dog of Orion.

Refs: 1.225, 11.362, 20.449, 22.29, 22.345. Books 1, 11, 20, 22.

See also: Orion, Achilles, Hector, Priam.

Dolon (Δόλων) · MORTAL — Say: DOH-lon

The Trojan scout of Book 10, son of the herald Eumedes, "ugly to look at, but swift-footed," and an only son among five sisters. He volunteers to spy on the ships and asks as his price the horses and chariot of Achilles; Odysseus and Diomedes let him run past them and take him, and he is caught green with fear, his teeth chattering. He tells them everything they ask — the watch, the disposition of the allies, the new-come Thracians of Rhesus and their horses — and is begging with his hand out to Diomedes' chin when Diomedes shears through both tendons of his neck and "the head of the still-speaking man was mingled with the dust." His spoils go on Odysseus' stern as an offering for Athena.

Kin: son of Eumedes the herald.

Killed by: Diomedes (10.454–457).

Refs: 10.314, 10.374, 10.390, 10.412, 10.426, 10.447, 10.478, 10.571. Book 10.

See also: Eumedes, Odysseus, Diomedes, Rhesus, Hector, Athena.

Dolops (Δόλοψ) · MORTAL — Say: DOH-lops

Two men. The Achaean is Clytius' son, killed by Hector in the rally of Book 11 and named only in the list of that killing. The Trojan is Lampus' son and Laomedon's grandson, "a master of the spear" and "the strongest son that Lampus fathered": he springs on Meges as he strips Croesmus and stabs his shield, but Phyleus' old corslet from Ephyra turns it; Meges shears the plume off his helmet, and while the two fight Menelaus comes up unseen from behind and drives a spear through his chest. Hector rallies his kinsmen over the armor — "do you not see how they swarm over Dolops's armor?"

Kin: the Achaean is son of Clytius; the Trojan is son of Lampus, grandson of Laomedon, and Hector's kinsman.

Killed by: the Achaean by Hector (11.302); the Trojan by Menelaus (15.540–543).

Refs: 11.302, 15.525, 15.536, 15.555. Books 11, 15.

See also: Clytius, Lampus, Meges, Menelaus, Hector, Melanippus.

Dream (ὄνειρος) · GOD

The messenger Zeus sends to deceive Agamemnon — "baneful Dream" — with the false promise that he may take Troy now, because the immortals are no longer divided and Hera has bent them by her begging. It stands above Agamemnon's head in the likeness of Nestor, "whom Agamemnon honored most of the elders," delivers the word exactly as charged, and flies away; Agamemnon reports it to the council as "a divine Dream" and acts on it, and the army's near-flight to the ships follows.

Refs: 2.6, 2.8, 2.16, 2.22, 2.56, 2.70. Book 2.

See also: Zeus, Agamemnon, Nestor, Blindness.

Earth (Γαῖα) · GOD

Invoked, never acting; one of the standing witnesses of the poem's oaths. Two lambs are brought "for Earth and Sun" at the truce of Book 3, and Priam's oath-prayer calls on "Rivers, and Earth, and you two below who punish the dead." Hera swears by Earth, wide Heaven and the down-flowing water of Styx that she has not moved Poseidon; Agamemnon swears by Zeus, Earth, the Sun and the Erinyes that he never touched Briseis. The related "Earth-shaker" is a fixed epithet of Poseidon, not this entity.

Refs: 3.104, 3.278, 15.36, 19.259, 20.310, 21.462. Books 3, 15, 19–21.

See also: Sun, Zeus, Styx, Erinyes, Poseidon, Hera.

Echius (Ἐχίος) · MORTAL — *Say:* EK-ee-us

Three men. One is a father only: "Mecisteus, Echius' son," one of the two loyal companions who twice stoop under a wounded man and carry him groaning to the ships (8.333 = 13.422). An Achaean of the name is killed by Polites in the rout of Book 15, in the same onset in which Polydamas kills that Mecisteus. A third is a Trojan, one of nine men Patroclus brings down in heaps at 16.415–418.

Kin: the first is father of Mecisteus.

Killed by: the Achaean by Polites (15.339); the Trojan by Patroclus (16.416).

Refs: 8.333, 13.422, 15.339, 16.416. Books 8, 13, 15, 16.

See also: Mecisteus, Polites, Polydamas, Patroclus.

Elis (Ἠλīs) · PLACE — *Say:* EE-lis

"Brilliant Elis" in the western Peloponnese, the Epeians' country in the Catalogue,

bounded by Hyrmine, Myrsinus at the land's edge, the Olenian rock and Alesium, and sending forty ships under four leaders; the Echinae islands lie "across the sea facing Elis." It is the setting of Nestor's long reminiscence in Book 11: the cattle-raid in which he killed Itymoneus, the debt owed the Pylians "in brilliant Elis," and Augeias' seizure of the four prize-winning horses that had come there for the games.

Refs: 2.615, 2.626, 11.673, 11.686, 11.698. Books 2, 11.

See also: Epeians, Nestor, Augeias, Buprasium, Meges.

Ennomus (Ἐννομος) · MORTAL — *Say:* EN-oh-mus

"Ennomus the bird-reader," who leads the Mysians with Chromis in the Catalogue, where the poem adds the notice that his birds did not save him from black doom: he was broken under the hands of Achilles in the river, with the other Trojans (2.858–861). He is still among the allied captains Hector harangues at 17.218, so the Catalogue's notice runs ahead of the narrative. A second man of the name is killed by Odysseus with Thoon in Book 11.

Killed by: Achilles, in the Scamander (2.860–861); the second by Odysseus (11.422).

Refs: 2.858, 11.422, 17.218. Books 2, 11, 17.

See also: Chromis, Mysians, Achilles, Scamander, Odysseus, Thoon.

Enops (Ἐνοψ) · MORTAL — *Say:* EE-nops

A name borne by three fathers, none of whom appears. One is the Trojan who herded by the banks of the Satnioeis, where a blameless naiad nymph bore him Satnius, killed by Ajax son of Oïleus (14.444–446). Another is father of the Trojan Thestor, whom Patroclus hooks out of his chariot by the jaw like a fish (16.401). The third is father of Clytomedes, the boxer Nestor beat at the funeral games of Amarynceus.

Kin: father, severally, of Satnius, Thestor and Clytomedes.

Refs: 14.444, 14.445, 16.401, 23.634. Books 14, 16, 23.

See also: Satnius, Thestor, Clytomedes, Nestor, Patroclus, Satnioeis.

Epeians (Ἐπειοί) · PEOPLE — *Say:* eh-PEE-unz

The people of Elis and Buprasium, forty ships under four leaders — Amphimachus and Thalpius, Diores, and Polyxeinus — and "the shining Epeians" who hold part of the line at the ships with the Locrians and Phthians under Meges and Amphion. Their larger role is retrospective: Nestor's Book 11 reminiscence is entirely about them, the debt they owed the Pylians, the Molione brothers, and the battle by the Alpheius; and the funeral games they held for lord Amarynceus at Buprasium are the measure Nestor sets against Patroclus'.

Kin: led by Amphinachus, Thalpius, Dioreas and Polyxenus.

Refs: 2.619, 4.538, 11.688, 11.694, 11.737, 13.686, 15.519, 23.630.

Books 2, 4, 11, 13, 15, 23.

See also: Elis, Nestor, Dioreas, Meges, Amarynceus, Buprasium.

Epeius (Ἐπειός) · MORTAL — *Say:* eh-PEE-us

Panopeus' son, "huge and strong, skilled in fist-fighting," who claims the boxing prize before the fight and gets it: "I claim to be the best. Is it not enough that I fall short in battle?" He drops Euryalus with one blow to the cheek — the man leaps at it like a fish under the North Wind and goes down — then sets him upright again with his own hands. In the weight-throw he takes the lump of pig-iron first, whirls, lets it fly, and the Achaeans laugh at him.

Kin: son of Panopeus.

Refs: 23.665, 23.689, 23.694, 23.838, 23.839, Book 23.

See also: Panopeus, Euryalus, Achilles, Polypoetes, Leonteus.

Epistrophus (Ἐπίστροφος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ee-PIS-troh-fus

Three men, all named in Book 2 and none of them again. Two are Catalogue leaders: the Phocian, who leads forty ships with his brother Schedius, sons of Iphitus Naubolus' son; and the Halizonian, who leads with Odius "from far away, from Alybe, where silver has its birthplace." The third is one of the "spear-mad sons of lord Euenus" whom Achilles cut down with Mynes at the sack of Lyrnessus, where he took Briseis.

Kin: the Phocian is son of Iphitus, brother of Schedius; the third is son of Euenus, brother of Mynes.

Killed by: the third by Achilles (2.692).

Refs: 2.517, 2.692, 2.856. Book 2.

See also: Schedius, Odius, Phocians, Halizones, Mynes, Briseis, Lyrnessus.

Ereuthalion (Ἐρευθαλίων) · MORTAL — *Say:* er-yoo-THAY-lee-on

The champion young Nestor killed, and the standing proof of what Nestor once was. He wore the armor Ares gave Areithous the Club-man, which Lycurgus took by craft in a narrow lane and gave in old age to Ereuthalion, his aide; wearing it he challenged all the Pylian best by the walls of Pheia, and they trembled and no man dared until Nestor, youngest-born of all, went out and killed him. "The tallest and the strongest man I ever killed: a great sprawl of him lay there, this way and that." Nestor tells it twice, both times to shame men into fighting.

Killed by: Nestor (7.153–156).

Refs: 4.319, 7.136, 7.149, 7.150. Books 4, 7.

See also: Nestor, Areithous, Lycurgus, Arcadians, Hector.

Erinyes (Ἐρινύες) · GOD — Say: ee-RIN-ee-eez

The avenging powers a curse calls up, and the poem's guarantors of oaths and of due order. Amyntor's curse on Phoenix summons "the hateful Erinyes"; Althaea, beating the earth and calling on Hades and Persephone for her son's death, is heard "out of Erebus" by an Erinyes "who walks in mist." Iris tells Poseidon that "the Erinyes always side with the elder-born," and Agamemnon lays his blindness on Zeus, Fate, and the Erinyes who walks in mist. They are witnesses under the earth in his oath at 19.259, and they stop the mouth of Achilles' speaking horse (19.418).

Epithets: "who walks in mist" (ἡεροφοῖτις, 9.571).

Refs: 9.454, 9.571, 15.204, 19.87, 19.259, 19.418, 21.412.

Books 9, 15, 19, 21.

See also: Phoenix, Amyntor, Althaea, Meleager, Agamemnon, Blindness, Xanthus (horse).

Euaemon (Εὐαίμων) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-EE-mon

Eurypylus' father, who never appears: in all seven occurrences the name is the patronymic, and almost always in the fixed phrase "Eurypylus, Euaemon's shining son" — which carries him through the Catalogue, his killing of Hypsenor, the volunteering for the duel with Hector, and finally his own wounding, "Euaemon's Zeus-sprung son, hit in the thigh by the arrow."

Kin: father of Eurypylus.

Refs: 2.736, 5.76, 5.79, 7.167, 8.265, 11.575, 11.810. Books 2, 5, 7, 8, 11.

See also: Eurypylus, Hypsenor, Patroclus.

Eumedes (Εὐμήδης) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-MEE-deez

Dolon's father, "the sacred herald — rich in gold and rich in bronze," named only to place his son: the wealth is what makes Dolon's offer of ransom credible when Odysseus and Diomedes take him. The name appears three times in Book 10 and nowhere else, twice in the formula "Dolon, Eumedes' son" that introduces the scout's two truthful answers.

Kin: father of Dolon.

Refs: 10.314, 10.412, 10.426. Book 10.

See also: Dolon, Odysseus, Diomedes.

Eumelus (Εὐμηλος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-MEE-lus

Leader of eleven ships from Pherae and Iolcus, and owner of the best horses in the host: the Muse-question at 2.761–767 answers that the finest were "the mares of Pheres' line, which Eumelus drove," matched in coat and years, reared by Apollo in Pereia. He is "supreme in horsemanship" and rises first for the chariot race in

Book 23, but Athena — retaliating for Apollo's sabotage of Diomedes — shatters his yoke, and he is thrown and comes in last, dragging his chariot. Achilles pities him and proposes second prize; Antilochus objects, and Eumelus is given Asteropaeus' corslet instead.

Also called: Admetus' son.

Kin: son of Admetus and Alcestis, "brilliant among women, loveliest of the daughters of Pelias" (2.715); grandson of Pheres.

Refs: 2.714, 2.764, 23.288, 23.354, 23.381, 23.481, 23.558, 23.565. Books 2, 23.

See also: Admetus, Alcestis, Athena, Diomedes, Antilochus, Asteropaeus.

Euphorbus (Εὐφορβος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-FOR-bus

The Dardanian who strikes Patroclus first — from behind, between the shoulders, after Apollo has already dazed him — then pulls his spear free and runs back into the crowd rather than face even an unarmed man. The poem gives him a resumé in the same breath: he outshone all men of his age at the spear, at horsemanship and in the footrace, and had brought down twenty men his first time out with a chariot. Dying, Patroclus names him second of his three killers, after Apollo. In Book 17 he claims the body from Menelaus and is speared through the throat; his blood-soaked hair, "hair like the Graces'," braided in gold and silver, gets the poem's olive-sapling simile.

Also called: Panthous' son — the patronymic also serves Polydamas and Hyperenor.

Kin: son of Panthous.

Kills: wounds Patroclus (16.806–815).

Killed by: Menelaus (17.45–60).

Refs: 16.808, 16.850, 17.47, 17.59, 17.81. Books 16–17.

See also: Patroclus, Menelaus, Panthous, Polydamas, Apollo, Hector, Graces.

Euryalus (Εὐρύαλος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RY-uh-lus

Third captain of the Argive contingent under Diomedes, behind Diomedes himself and Sthenelus, "a godlike man." He kills four Trojans in the Book 6 rout, among them the twins Aesepus and Pedasus, whom the water-nymph Abarbarea bore to Bucolion. In Book 23 he alone stands up to Epeius at boxing — Diomedes girds him and talks him up — and is knocked flat with a blow to the cheek, led away through the gathering with his feet trailing, spitting thick blood, his wits astray.

Kin: son of Mecisteus, son of Talaus. His father once came to Thebes for the burial of fallen Oedipus and beat all the sons of Cadmus (23.679–680).

Kills: Dresus, Opheltius, Aesepus and Pedasus (6.20–28).

Refs: 2.565, 6.20, 23.677. Books 2, 6, 23.

See also: Diomedes, Sthenelus, Mecisteus, Epeius, Bucolion.

Eurypylus (Εὐρύπυλος) · MORTAL — *Say:* yoo-RIP-ih-lus

Thessalian leader of forty ships from Ormenion and Hypereia, and one of the nine who stand up to answer Hector's challenge in Book 7. He kills Hypsenor the Scamander-priest's son in Book 5 and Melanthius in Book 6, and in Book 11, coming to the rescue of the hard-pressed Ajax, is shot through the right thigh by Paris. His wound is the hinge of the plot: Patroclus, sent by Achilles to ask after the wounded, meets him limping from the field, and though on an errand he will not abandon him — he cuts the arrow out, washes the wound and lays on a root Chiron taught Achilles. Patroclus is still sitting in his hut at 15.390, delighting him with talk, when the Trojans storm the wall; the delay is the last thing between him and his own death. A different Eurypylus is the hero of Cos (2.677).

Also called: Euaemon's son — the recurring line is "Euaemon's shining son."

Kin: son of Euaemon.

Kills: Hypsenor (5.76–83); Melanthius (6.36); Apisaon (11.578).

Refs: 2.736, 5.76, 6.36, 7.167, 11.583, 11.809, 12.2, 15.392, 16.27. Books 2, 5–8, 11–12, 15–16.

See also: Patroclus, Paris, Ajax, Machaon, Achilles.

Eurystheus (Εὐρυσθέυς) · MORTAL — *Say:* yoo-RIS-thyooos

The king Heracles served, present only in the back-story. Athena complains at 8.362–369 that Zeus forgets how often she was sent to rescue his son "worn to breaking under Eurystheus's labors" — among them the descent to Hades to fetch the hound. His birth is the point of Agamemnon's Blindness-parable in Book 19: Hera, trapping Zeus in an oath, hurried this child into the light before his month and held back Alcmene's labor, so that the rule Zeus meant for Heracles fell to Eurystheus, and Zeus groaned ever after to see his son "doing shameful labor under Eurystheus's tasks." His herald Copreus carried the orders (15.639–640).

Kin: son of Sthenelus, son of Perseus.

Refs: 8.363, 8.367, 15.640, 19.123, 19.133. Books 8, 15, 19.

See also: Heracles, Hera, Alcmene, Blindness, Sthenelus, Perseus, Copreus.

Eëtion (Ἠετίων) · MORTAL — *Say:* ay-EE-tee-on

King of Thebe-under-Placus, lord over the Cilician men, and Andromache's father. Achilles sacked his city before the poem opens — the raid that also took Chryseis — and killed him there, but "did not strip him: his heart stood in awe of that," burning him in his armor and heaping a mound over which the mountain nymphs planted

elms. Achilles killed all seven of his sons in one day and ransomed his wife back. The spoils of Thebe run through the poem: the lyre Achilles is singing to when the embassy arrives, the horse Pedasus, and the lump of self-smelted iron he sets up as a prize at Patroclus' games, "that the huge strength of Eëtion used to throw." Two other men bear the name: Eëtion of Imbros, who ransomed Lycaon (21.43), and the father of Podes, Hector's feast-companion (17.575).

Kin: father of Andromache and of seven sons; father-in-law of Hector.

Killed by: Achilles (6.414–420).

Refs: 1.366, 6.396, 6.416, 8.187, 9.188, 16.153, 21.43, 22.472, 23.827. Books

1, 6, 8–9, 16–17, 21–23.

See also: Andromache, Achilles, Hector, Thebe, Placus, Chryseis, Podes.

Fate (Μοῖρα) · GOD

Personified only where the translation capitalizes her; elsewhere μοῖρα is the common noun "fate," and the death-line formula μοῖρα κραταίη is rendered "fate the overpowering." She walks the shield of Achilles beside Strife and Tumult, "deadly Fate, holding one man fresh-wounded and alive, another unwounded, another dead, dragging him by the feet through the fighting," her cloak red with the blood of men (18.535–538). Elsewhere she is a spinner: what she "spun for him with her thread at his birth" is said of Achilles by Zeus (20.127–128) and of Hector by Hecuba (24.209–210), in the same wording. Agamemnon names her with Zeus and the Erinyes as the causes of his blindness, and the horse Xanthus names "a great god, and strong Fate" as the killers of Patroclus.

Refs: 18.535, 19.87, 19.410, 20.127, 24.209. Books 18, 19, 20, 24.

See also: Strife, Blindness, Erinyes, Xanthus (horse), Zeus, Hecuba.

Gargaron (Γάργαρον) · PLACE — *Say:* GAR-guh-ron

The peak of Ida where Zeus's precinct and smoking altar are, and the seat from which he watches the war: he halts his horses there at 8.48–52, pours mist around them, and sits "looking out at the Trojans' city and the ships of the Achaeans."

It is where Hera comes to him arrayed in the keston, and where he sleeps after, "broken by sleep and love, his wife in his arms," while Sleep runs to Poseidon with the news; and where Iris and Apollo find him wreathed in a fragrant cloud when he wakes.

Refs: 8.48, 14.292, 14.352, 15.152. Books 8, 14–15.

See also: Ida, Zeus, Hera, Sleep, Iris.

Glaucus (Γλαῦκος) · MORTAL — *Say:* GLAW-kus

Co-leader of the Lycians with Sarpedon, and one of the two men — with Asteropaeus —

whom Sarpedon picks out as best of the allies after himself. In Book 6 he meets Diomedes between the lines and answers the challenge with the poem's most famous image, "As the generation of leaves, so is the generation of men," then recites the Bellerophon story; the two discover their grandfathers' guest-friendship, refuse to fight, and exchange armor — at which "Zeus took Glaucus's wits away," gold for bronze, a hundred oxen's worth for nine. Teucer's arrow through his bared arm takes him out of the fight at the wall; Apollo heals it at his prayer in Book 16 so that he can rally the Lycians over Sarpedon's body. In Book 17 he rounds on Hector for letting Sarpedon's corpse go and threatens to take the Lycians home. His great-grandfather Glaucus, son of Sisyphus, bears the same name (6.154).

Kin: son of Hippolochus; grandson of Bellerophon; cousin of Sarpedon through Laodameia.

Kills: Iphinous (7.13–16); Bathycles (16.593–598).

Refs: 2.876, 6.119, 6.234, 7.13, 12.309, 12.387, 16.492, 16.530, 17.140.

Books 2, 6–7, 12, 14, 16–17.

See also: Sarpedon, Diomedes, Hippolochus, Bellerophon, Teucer, Apollo, Hector.

Graces (Χάριτες) · GOD

Divine craftswomen and, in Book 14, marriageable persons. They wove the ambrosial robe Aphrodite is wearing when Diomedes cuts her hand (5.338). Hera buys Sleep's help against Zeus by offering him "one of the younger Graces" to marry, and he names his price: Pasithea, "whom I myself have longed for all my days." Their name is also the poem's measure of male beauty — Euphorbus dies with "hair like the Graces'."

Also called: the younger Graces (14.267, 14.275); Pasithea is the one named.

Refs: 5.338, 14.267, 14.275, 17.51. Books 5, 14, 17.

See also: Aphrodite, Hera, Sleep, Pasithea, Euphorbus.

Hades (Ήιδης) · GOD — Say: HAY-deez

Lord of the dead, and by metonymy the underworld itself — most of the poem's forty-six occurrences are the destination in phrases like "went down to the house of Hades," which is where the wrath of the poem sends "many strong souls of heroes" in the fourth line. As a person he is the third of Cronos' sons: Poseidon's account of the lots at 15.187–193 gives Zeus the wide heaven, himself the grey sea, and "Hades the misty dark," with earth and Olympus common to all three. Heracles shot him at Pylos "among the dead, and gave him over to pain" (5.395–397); Athena wears his helmet to hide from Ares (5.845); and in the theomachy he leaps screaming from his throne, afraid Poseidon will crack the earth open and expose his "terrible, mouldering houses, which the very gods abhor" (20.61–65). Achilles learns from

Patroclus' ghost that there is a soul and an image in his house "but the wits are not in it at all."

Epithets: "the gate-closer" (πυλάρτης, 8.367); "of the famed colts" (κλυτόπωλος, 5.654).

Also called: Aïdoneus (5.190, 20.61).

Kin: son of Cronos and Rhea; brother of Zeus, Poseidon and Hera.

Refs: 1.3, 5.395, 5.654, 5.845, 8.367, 9.158, 15.188, 15.191, 16.856, 20.294, 22.213, 23.103 ...and throughout. Books 1, 3, 5–9, 11, 13–16, 20–24.

See also: Zeus, Poseidon, Persephone, Erebus, Patroclus, Heracles.

Haemon (Αἴμων) · MORTAL — Say: HEE-mon

Three men. The first is a Pylian, "the lord Haemon," one of the five captains Nestor is arraying his companions around when Agamemnon reaches him in Book 4. The second is a Cadmean, father of Maeon — one of the two leaders of the fifty-man ambush the Thebans set for Tydeus, and the only man Tydeus let go home alive. The third is named once as Alcimedon's grandfather, father of Laerces, among the Myrmidons.

Refs: 4.296, 4.394, 17.467. Books 4, 17.

See also: Nestor, Maeon, Tydeus, Alcimedon, Laerces.

Hebe (Ἥβη) · GOD — Say: HEE-bee

Daughter of Zeus and Hera, and the gods' cup-bearer: the poem's first sight of Olympus at the opening of Book 4 has her pouring nectar among the seated gods while they look out at the city of the Trojans. She also works as Hera's groom, setting the bronze eight-spoked wheels on the chariot when her mother goes to war (5.722), and it is she who bathes Ares and dresses him in graceful clothing after Paiëon has healed his belly-wound.

Epithets: "the lady Hebe" (πότνια Ἥβη, 4.2).

Kin: daughter of Zeus and Hera; sister of Ares.

Refs: 4.2, 5.722, 5.905. Books 4–5.

See also: Hera, Zeus, Ares, Paiëon.

Hector (Ἑκτωρ) · MORTAL

Priam's eldest son, Troy's champion, and the man on whom the city rests — "for Hector alone was the saving of Ilion" (6.403). He is the poem's second protagonist: he duels Ajax to a standstill in Book 7, breaks the Achaean gate with a stone in Book 12, fires the ships in Book 15, and strips Achilles' armor from Patroclus' body, the act that brings Achilles back and destroys him. His domestic scene with Andromache and the infant Astyanax at the Scaean Gates (6.390–496) is set against

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his own certainty that Ilion will fall; he twice rejects Polydamas' counsel to withdraw, the second time fatally. In Book 22 he waits alone outside the wall, runs three times around the city, is tricked by Athena in Deiphobus' shape, and takes Achilles' spear through the gullet. Achilles drags his body for twelve days until Priam ransoms it, and the poem closes on his burial.

Epithets: "of the flashing helmet" (κορυθαίολος, 2.816); "glorious" (φαίδιμος, 4.505); "man-slaughtering" (άνδροφόνος, 1.242 — given last to his own head at 24.724); "breaker of horses" (ιππόδαμος, 7.38), rendered "tamer of horses" in the line that ends the poem (22.161, 24.804).

Also called: Priam's son — the default referent of the patronymic, though it also serves Paris, Helenus, Deiphobus, Polydorus, Lycaon and the Book 24 roll-call.

Kin: son of Priam and Hecuba; husband of Andromache, daughter of Eëtion; father of Astyanax; brother of Paris, Helenus, Deiphobus, Polydorus, Lycaon, Cassandra and Laodice.

Kills: Patroclus (16.818–863), with Apollo and Euphorbus striking before him; Amphinomachus, Schedius, Asaeus, Autonomus and many more.

Killed by: Achilles (22.326–330).

Refs: 1.242, 2.816, 3.38, 6.390, 6.440, 7.38, 12.445, 16.818, 18.284, 22.326, 24.724, 24.804 ...and throughout. Books 1–24.

See also: Achilles, Priam, Andromache, Astyanax, Polydamas, Patroclus, Ajax, Apollo, Deiphobus.

Hecuba (Ἑκάβη) · MORTAL — Say: HEK-yoo-buh

Priam's wife and Hector's mother. She meets Hector at the palace in Book 6 and offers him wine, then leads the older women to lay the loveliest robe of her Sidonian store on Athena's knees — a prayer Athena refuses. On the wall at 22.79–89 she bares her breast and begs him to come inside; she leads the lament over his body twice, at the wall and at the bier, where she says his flesh is unmarked and "dear to the gods you were while you lived with me." In Book 24 she opposes Priam's journey to the ships outright, calling Achilles savage and faithless and wishing she could eat his liver, then yields and makes her husband pour a libation before he goes.

Epithets: "gentle-giving" (ἡπιόδωρος, 6.251).

Kin: daughter of Dymas, sister of Asius (16.718); wife of Priam; mother of Hector, Paris, Deiphobus, Helenus, Laodice, Cassandra and the rest.

Refs: 6.293, 6.451, 16.718, 22.234, 22.430, 24.193, 24.283, 24.747. Books 6, 16, 22, 24.

See also: Priam, Hector, Andromache, Athena, Achilles, Dymas, Asius.

Helen (Ἑλένη) · MORTAL — Say: HEL-un

Menelaus' wife, taken to Troy by Paris, and the cause the whole war is fought over — "Argive Helen, for whose sake so many Achaeans have perished at Troy." The poem handles her almost entirely through her own speech, and every scene of it is self-reproach: she names herself "dog-face" to Priam on the wall while identifying the Achaean captains for him, calls herself "the dog, the evil-scheming horror" to Hector, and wishes a storm had carried her off the day she was born. Aphrodite compels her to Paris' bed in Book 3 with a threat, and she goes in silence. She speaks last of the three women who lament Hector, mourning the only man in Troy who never gave her a hard word: "there is no one else now in wide Troy gentle to me, or kind: they all shudder at me."

Epithets: "of the trailing robe" (τανύπεπλος, 3.228).

Kin: daughter of Zeus (3.418, "Helen sprung of Zeus"); wife of Menelaus; taken by Paris; she names a daughter left behind at Sparta (3.175).

Refs: 2.161, 3.121, 3.171, 3.228, 3.418, 6.343, 7.350, 24.761. Books 2–4, 6–9, 11, 13, 19, 22, 24.

See also: Paris, Menelaus, Priam, Hector, Aphrodite, Antenor, Laodice.

Helenus (Ἑλένος) · MORTAL — Say: HEL-uh-nus

Priam's son, "far the best of bird-readers," whose counsel twice sets the plot moving: at 6.75–101 he sends Hector back into the city to have Hecuba petition Athena, which produces the Andromache scene; and at 7.44–53 he hears "the voice of the gods who are forever," relays that it is not yet Hector's fate to die, and prompts the challenge that brings on the duel with Ajax. He also fights — he leads one of the storming-parties at the wall with Deiphobus, kills Deïpyrus with a Thracian sword, and is shot in the bow-hand by Menelaus and carried out. Priam curses him by name among the nine surviving sons in Book 24. A different Helenus, son of Oenops, is one of the Achaeans Hector and Ares kill at 5.707.

Kin: son of Priam and Hecuba; brother of Hector, Paris and Deiphobus.

Kills: Deïpyrus (13.576–580).

Refs: 5.707, 6.75, 7.44, 12.94, 13.576, 13.582, 24.249. Books 5–7, 12–13, 24.

See also: Priam, Hector, Deiphobus, Menelaus, Cassandra, Deïpyrus.

Hellas (Ἑλλάς) · PLACE — Say: HEL-us

Not yet a name for Greece: in this poem it is a district of Phthia, listed in the Catalogue with Alos, Alope, Trachis and Phthia as the country of Achilles' contingent, and fixed as "Hellas of the beautiful women." Achilles offers it as his marriage-market — "There are Achaean girls enough through Hellas and through Phthia"

— and Phoenix fled from it to Peleus after the quarrel with his father Amyntor, crossing "Hellas of the wide spaces." Bathycles, the richest of the Myrmidons, had his home there.

Refs: 2.683, 9.395, 9.447, 9.478, 16.595. Books 2, 9, 16.

See also: Hellenes, Phthia, Achilles, Phoenix, Myrmidons, Bathycles.

Hellenes (Ἑλλήνες) · PEOPLE — *Say:* HEL-eenz

Still a narrow regional term, twice only. At 2.684 it is one of the three names of Achilles' own contingent — "and they were called Myrmidons, and Hellenes, and Achaeans" — and at 2.530 the lesser Ajax "with the spear surpassed all Hellenes and Achaeans," a pairing that keeps the two distinct. It is not a name for the whole host; that is Achaeans, Argives, Danaans.

Refs: 2.530, 2.684. Book 2.

See also: Hellas, Myrmidons, Achaeans, Achilles, Ajax son of Oïleus.

Hellespont (Ἑλλήσποντος) · PLACE — *Say:* HEL-uh-spont

The strait beside the Achaean camp, always "strong-flowing" or "wide" or "boundless," and the poem's standing figure for the far edge of the beachhead. Nestor proposes the barrow of the unnamed dead be heaped "beside the wide Hellespont" so that men sailing by in later ages will see it; Achilles threatens to load his ships and be seen sailing it at earliest light; Poseidon's wall-destroying flood in Book 12 smooths the beach "along the strong-flowing Hellespont." It bounds the Thracian contingent in the Catalogue and, in Priam's mind, the whole extent of his former wealth.

Refs: 2.845, 7.86, 9.360, 12.30, 15.233, 17.432, 18.150, 23.2, 24.346, 24.545.

Books 2, 7, 9, 12, 15, 17–18, 23–24.

See also: Troy, Ida, Poseidon, Nestor, Achilles.

Hephaestus (Ἥφαιστος) · GOD — *Say:* hih-FES-tus or hih-FEE-stus

The smith-god, lamed and comic in Book 1 — where he bustles round the hall pouring nectar to break up his parents' quarrel, and tells how Zeus once caught him by the foot and flung him from the threshold of heaven to fall all day and land on Lemnos — and formidable everywhere after. He made Agamemnon's sceptre and the houses of the gods; his name stands by metonymy for fire ("the flame of Hephaestus," 2.426). His great work is the armor and the shield of Achilles, forged at Thetis' asking, with the earth, heaven, sea, two cities, the plowing and harvest, the vineyard, the herd and the lions, the dancing-floor and the river of Ocean on it (18.478–608). In Book 21 Hera sets him on the Scamander: he burns the plain, then the river itself, until the water boils in its channel and the god begs off.

HERA – HERACLES

Epithets: "crook-footed" (ἀμφιγυῖς, 1.607); "famed for craft" (κλυτότεχνης, 1.571); "famed" (περικλυτός, 1.607).

Kin: son of Hera (1.572, 21.330); husband of Charis (18.382).

Refs: 1.571, 1.600, 2.101, 2.426, 14.239, 18.137, 18.369, 18.473, 20.36, 21.342, 21.367, 21.381. Books 1–2, 5, 8–9, 14–15, 17–23.

See also: Hera, Thetis, Achilles, Charis, Scamander, Zeus, Lemnos.

Hera (Ἥρη) · GOD — *Say:* HEER-uh or HAIR-uh

Zeus's wife and sister, and the Achaeans' most relentless partisan — she will trade Argos, Sparta and Mycenae, the three cities dearest to her, for the sack of Troy (4.51–56), and Zeus says she would eat Priam and his sons raw if she could get at them. She sets the poem going by putting the assembly into Achilles' mind (1.55), and her Book 14 deception is its central act of divine mischief: she borrows the *kestos* from Aphrodite, buys Sleep with the promise of Pasithea, and takes Zeus on Gargaron so that Poseidon can turn the battle while he sleeps. Zeus's fury when he wakes — and his reminder of the time he hung her from heaven with anvils on her feet — does not change her; she extorts his consent for Troy's fall in Book 4 and again in Book 21, and sends Hephaestus against the river to save Achilles.

Epithets: "white-armed" (λευκώλενος, 1.55); "ox-eyed lady Hera" (βοῶπις πότνια Ἥρη, 1.551); "eldest goddess" (πρέσβα θεά, 5.721); "of the golden throne" (χρυσόθρονος, 1.611).

Kin: daughter of Cronos and Rhea; sister and wife of Zeus; sister of Poseidon and Hades; mother of Ares, Hebe and Hephaestus.

Refs: 1.55, 1.400, 1.536, 4.5, 4.50, 5.721, 8.198, 14.159, 14.292, 15.5, 19.407

...and throughout. Books 1–2, 4–5, 7–11, 13–16, 18–21, 24.

See also: Zeus, Athena, Sleep, Aphrodite, Hephaestus, Poseidon, Hebe, Ares.

Heracles (Ἡρακλῆς) · MORTAL — *Say:* HER-uh-kleez

Always in the past tense, and always as the measure of a generation stronger than this one. His Troy is the earlier sack: he came for the horses of Laomedon "with only six ships and fewer men, and sacked the city of Ilion, and widowed her streets," and Laomedon cheated him of the horses (5.638–651). Sleep and Hera between them wrecked his homecoming and blew him to Cos, for which Zeus hurled gods through the house; Poseidon shows Aeneas the wall the Trojans built him against the sea-monster. Achilles takes him as the precedent for his own death — "not even the might of Heracles escaped his doom" — and Agamemnon takes his birth as the great instance of Blindness, when Hera's trick handed his rule to Eurystheus. He wounded Hades at Pylos, and he battered Nestor's Pylos so hard that eleven of Neleus' twelve

sons were killed.

Epithets: "the might of Heracles" (βίη Ἡρακλεΐη, 2.658) — the periphrasis is kept, and is the usual form of the name.

Kin: son of Zeus and Alcmene; father of Tlepolemus by Astyocheia and of Thessalus.

Refs: 2.658, 2.666, 5.638, 11.690, 14.255, 15.25, 18.117, 19.98, 20.145. Books 2, 5, 11, 14–15, 18–20.

See also: Zeus, Hera, Alcmene, Eurystheus, Laomedon, Tlepolemus, Sarpedon, Nestor.

Hermes (Ἑρμείας) · GOD — *Say:* HUR-meez

The gods' messenger and escort. He passes the sceptre from Zeus to Pelops in the Book 2 genealogy, steals Ares out of the bronze jar where the sons of Aloeus had him bound, fathers Eudorus on Polymele, and is paired against Leto in the theomachy — where he declines to fight, saying it is a hard thing to trade blows with the wives of Zeus. His great scene is Book 24: Zeus sends him to bring Priam through the Achaean camp unseen, and he comes as a young man, takes the reins, drugs the gate-keepers, opens the gate, identifies himself at Achilles' door, and comes back before dawn to wake the old man and drive him out again. Every occurrence of "Argus" in the poem is inside his fixed epithet.

Epithets: "the slayer of Argus" (ἀργεΐφόντης, 2.103); "the guide" (διάκτορος, 2.103) — rendered "the courier" in its later occurrences (20.34, 24.339).

Kin: son of Zeus; father of Eudorus by Polymele (16.181–186).

Refs: 2.103, 5.390, 14.490, 16.181, 20.35, 21.497, 24.334, 24.339, 24.461, 24.679, 24.694. Books 2, 5, 14–16, 20–21, 24.

See also: Zeus, Priam, Achilles, Eudorus, Leto, Ares, Pelops.

Hicetaon (Ἥκετάων) · MORTAL — *Say:* hy-suh-TAY-on

One of Priam's brothers, a son of Laomedon, and one of the Trojan elders sitting at the Scaean Gates in Book 3 who watch Helen come and say she is worth the suffering. He does not fight. In the poem he functions mainly as a patronymic: his son Melanippus, who had herded cattle at Percote until the war came close, is rebuked by Hector into the front line and shot in the chest by Antilochus.

Epithets: "scion of Ares" (ὄζος Ἄρηος, 3.147), varied as "sprig of Ares" in the genealogy at 20.238.

Kin: son of Laomedon; brother of Priam, Tithonus, Lampus and Clytius; father of Melanippus.

Refs: 3.147, 15.546, 15.576, 20.238. Books 3, 15, 20.

See also: Priam, Laomedon, Melanippus, Antilochus, Hector.

Hippasus (Ἱππασος) · MORTAL — Say: HIP-uh-sus

A name attached to men on both sides, never a character himself. On the Trojan side he is father of Charops and of Socus, "such a pair of men," both killed by Odysseus in Book 11 — Odysseus taunts the dying Socus as "son of war-minded Hippasus, breaker of horses." A second Hippasus is the father of Hypsenor, killed by Deiphobus at 13.411; a third the father of Apisaon of Paeonia, killed by Lycomedes at 17.348. The last two die in the same verbatim line, hit "in the liver below the midriff."

Kin: father of Charops and Socus; also named as father of Hypsenor and of Apisaon.

Refs: 11.426, 11.431, 11.450, 13.411, 17.348. Books 11, 13, 17.

See also: Socus, Charops, Odysseus, Hypsenor, Apisaon.

Hippolochus (Ἱππόλοχος) · MORTAL — Say: hip-OL-oh-us

Glaucus' father, son of Bellerophon and brother of Isander and Laodameia — so the link between the Lycian house and Sarpedon, who is Laodameia's son by Zeus. He does not appear: the name is Glaucus' patronymic throughout, and his one act reported is sending his son to Troy with the charge "always to be the best, and to hold his head above all others" (6.207–208), the line Peleus also gives Achilles. A second Hippolochus is a son of Antimachus, killed with his brother Peisander by Agamemnon in Book 11, who shears off his hands and his head and sends him rolling like a stone through the crowd.

Kin: son of Bellerophon; father of Glaucus; brother of Isander and Laodameia.

Refs: 6.119, 6.144, 6.197, 6.206, 7.13, 11.122, 11.145, 12.309, 12.387, 17.140.

Books 6–7, 11–12, 17.

See also: Glaucus, Bellerophon, Sarpedon, Laodameia, Antimachus, Agamemnon.

Hippothous (Ἱππόθους) · MORTAL — Say: hip-OTH-oh-us

Two men. The chief one leads the Pelasgian spearmen of Larisa in the Catalogue with his brother Pylaeus, and dies in Book 17 in the fight over Patroclus' body: he has run a shield-strap round the dead man's ankle-tendons and is dragging him off by the foot "doing a favor to Hector and the Trojans" when Telamonian Ajax spears him through the helmet's cheek-piece and the brain runs out along the socket. He falls face-down on the corpse, "far from deep-soiled Larisa; nor did he repay his dear parents the price of his rearing." Priam's son Hippothous is a different man, named once in the roll-call of the nine sons Priam curses (24.251).

Kin: the Pelasgian is son of Lethus, son of Teutamus; brother of Pylaeus.

Killed by: Ajax (17.293–303).

Refs: 2.840, 2.842, 17.217, 17.288, 17.313, 17.318, 24.251. Books 2, 17, 24.

See also: Lethus, Larisa, Pelasgians, Ajax, Patroclus, Priam.

Hyle (Ἥλη) · PLACE — Say: HY-lee

A Boeotian town by the Cephisian lake, listed in the Catalogue. Two men are placed there: Oresbius "of the glancing waist-guard," who lived there hoarding his wealth with care and is killed by Hector in the Book 5 roll-call; and Tychius, "far the best of leather-cutters," who made the seven-hide tower shield Ajax carries against Hector.

Refs: 2.500, 5.708, 7.221. Books 2, 5, 7.

See also: Boeotians, Oresbius, Tychius, Ajax.

Hyrtaeus (Ἥρτακος) · MORTAL — Say: HUR-tuh-kus

Asius' father, and in the poem only that: every occurrence is the patronymic "Asius, Hyrtacus' son," including the couplet the poem repeats verbatim from the Catalogue when Asius storms the wall — "whom horses carried from Arisbe, tall and fire-colored, from the river Selleis" (2.838 = 12.96). Hector names him twice in the same formula when he searches the front for his missing captains in Book 13.

Kin: father of Asius, leader of the men of Percote, Sestus, Abydos and Arisbe.

Refs: 2.837, 2.838, 12.96, 12.110, 12.162, 13.760, 13.771. Books 2, 12–13.

See also: Asius, Arisbe, Percote, Adamas, Hector.

Ida (Ἰδη) · PLACE — Say: EYE-duh

The mountain above Troy, "of the many springs, mother of wild things," from whose peaks the eight rivers of the Troad run down to the sea. It is Zeus's station for most of the poem: he comes there from Olympus in Book 8, sits on Gargaron looking out at the city and the ships, thunders from it, and sends Iris and Apollo out from it with his orders. Hera climbs it to seduce him; the earth-quake of the theomachy shakes "all the roots of many-springed Ida." Aeneas was got on its spurs, "a goddess bedded with a mortal"; Apollo herded Laomedon's cattle "in the spurs of wooded, many-folded Ida"; and Agamemnon's oath calls on "Father Zeus, ruling from Ida." *Epithets:* "Ida of the many springs, mother of wild things" (πολυπίδαξ Ἰδη, μήτηρ θηρῶν, 8.47).

Refs: 2.821, 3.276, 8.47, 11.184, 12.19, 14.283, 15.151, 20.59, 21.449.

Books 2–4, 7–8, 11–17, 20–24.

See also: Gargaron, Zeus, Hera, Troy, Scamander, Simois, Aeneas.

Idaeus (Ἰδαῖος) · MORTAL — Say: eye-DEE-us

Priam's herald, "wise" and "war-minded," and the poem's chief instrument of truce. He carries the oath-offerings and the mixing-bowl for the Book 3 duel, and rouses Priam to come out to the plain. In Book 7 he and Talthylbius force their staffs between Ajax and Hector to stop the duel at nightfall; then he goes alone to the

Achaean assembly with Paris' offer of the treasure but not of Helen, hears it refused, and takes Agamemnon's answer back — the truce for the burning of the dead. In Book 24 he drives the mule-wagon of ransom to Achilles' hut and is left holding the teams outside. A different Idaeus is a son of Dares the Hephaestus-priest, who leaps from his chariot in Book 5 and is snatched away in darkness by Hephaestus so that the old man should not lose both sons.

Epithets: "the far-calling herald" (ἡπύτα κῆρυξ, 7.384).

Refs: 3.247, 5.11, 5.20, 7.276, 7.372, 7.381, 7.413, 24.325, 24.470. Books 3, 5, 7, 24.

See also: Priam, Talthybius, Hector, Ajax, Dares, Hephaestus, Achilles.

Idomeneus (Ἰδομενεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* eye-DOM-uh-nyoos or eye-DOM-ih-nee-us
Leader of the Cretans of hundred-citied Crete, with Meriones, and one of the Achaean elder statesmen — Agamemnon gives him a cup that is always full and honors him "beyond all the Danaans of swift colts." He is one of the men Achilles names in Book 1 as fit to arbitrate, and one of the nine who volunteer against Hector. His aristeia fills the middle of Book 13: Poseidon, in the likeness of Thoas, sends him back into the fight, and though "his hair was half-grey" he kills Othryoneus, Asius, Alcatous and Oenomaus before Aeneas comes at him and he gives ground, admitting his legs are no longer what they were. In Book 23 he is first to see Diomedes coming out of the dust and quarrels with the lesser Ajax over whose horses lead.

Epithets: "famed with the spear" (δοῦρὶ κλυτός, 2.645).

Kin: son of Deucalion (13.451); grandson of Minos.

Kills: Othryoneus (13.370–373); Asius (13.387–393); Alcatous, Oenomaus, Erymas.

Refs: 1.145, 2.645, 4.252, 4.265, 13.210, 13.361, 13.370, 13.467, 23.450.

Books 1–8, 10–13, 15–17, 19, 23.

See also: Meriones, Cretans, Poseidon, Asius, Othryoneus, Aeneas, Deucalion.

Ilioneus (Ἰλιονεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* il-ee-OH-nyoos

A Trojan, the only son of Phorbas "rich in flocks, whom Hermes loved beyond all the Trojans, and gave him wealth." Peneleos spears him under the brow at the root of the eye, pushes the eyeball out, and drives the point through the nape; then draws his sword, hews through the neck, and holds up head, helmet and the spear still standing in the eye "like a poppy-head" to show the Trojans — telling them to carry word to Ilioneus' father and mother to start wailing. It is the poem's grimmest single image, and the Trojans' limbs shake at the sight.

Kin: only son of Phorbas.

Killed by: Peneleos (14.489–500).

Refs: 14.489, 14.492, 14.502. Book 14.

See also: Peneleos, Phorbas, Hermes, Promachus.

Ilus (Ἴλος) · MORTAL — *Say:* EYE-lus

An ancestor of the Trojan kings, given in Aeneas' recital of the line at 20.231–236: Tros' eldest son, brother of Assaracus and Ganymede, and father of Laomedon — so Priam's grandfather. The poem does not gloss his name against Ilion. He is dead long before the action, and what survives him is his tomb, "the man-made mound," a fixed landmark in the middle of the plain: Hector holds his night council beside it, Agamemnon's rout streams past it, Paris shoots Diomedes from behind its pillar, and Priam and Idaeus drive past it on the road to the ships.

Kin: son of Tros; brother of Assaracus and Ganymede; father of Laomedon; great-grandfather of Hector.

Refs: 10.415, 11.166, 11.372, 20.232, 20.236, 24.349. Books 10–11, 20, 24.

See also: Tros, Laomedon, Priam, Assaracus, Dardanus, Troy.

Imbros (Ἰμβρος) · PLACE — *Say:* IM-bros

An island off Troy, always "rugged," and in the poem a marker of the sea-road rather than a place with people. Poseidon's undersea cave lies "midway between Tenedos and rugged Imbros"; Iris dives into the sea "midway between Samos and rugged Imbros" on her way to Thetis; Hera and Sleep pass over it and Lemnos on the way to Ida. Eëtion of Imbros is the guest-friend who ransomed Lycaon out of Lemnos, and Hecuba names it in her lament as one of the places across the sea Achilles sold her sons into.

Refs: 13.33, 14.281, 21.43, 24.78, 24.753. Books 13–14, 21, 24.

See also: Lemnos, Samos, Tenedos, Poseidon, Eëtion, Lycaon.

Iphiclus (Ἰφικλος) · MORTAL — *Say:* IF-ih-klus

Father of Protesilaus and Podarces, and "rich in flocks," son of Phylacus; he does not appear, and both his sons are named by the patronymic when the Phylacean contingent is handed on from the first man killed at Troy to his younger brother (2.703–708, 13.698). The Iphiclus Nestor claims to have outrun in the games at Buprasium — "good runner though he was" — belongs to the same back-story generation, but the text does not say he is the same man.

Kin: son of Phylacus; father of Protesilaus and Podarces.

Refs: 2.705, 13.698, 23.636. Books 2, 13, 23.

See also: Protesilaus, Podarces, Phylacus, Nestor, Phylace.

Iphidamas (Ἰφιδάμας) · MORTAL — Say: if-ID-uh-mas

Antenor's son, "a good man and a big one," and the answer to the Muse-question of who first came against Agamemnon in his aristeia. Reared in Thrace by his mother's father Cisses, who tried to keep him there by giving him his daughter, he left the bridal chamber "chasing the report of the Achaeans" with twelve ships, beached them at Percote, and walked the rest of the way to Ilion. His thrust bends on Agamemnon's war-belt "like lead"; Agamemnon wrenches the spear from his grip and cuts his neck, and he "slept a sleep of bronze," far from the wife he had bought with a hundred cattle and a promise of a thousand goats and sheep. His brother Coon wounds Agamemnon in the forearm trying to drag the body clear and is beheaded over it.

Kin: son of Antenor and Theano; grandson of Cisses; brother of Coon.

Killed by: Agamemnon (11.238–241).

Refs: 11.221, 11.234, 11.257, 11.261. Book 11.

See also: Antenor, Coon, Agamemnon, Theano, Cisses, Percote.

Iris (Ἴρις) · GOD — Say: EYE-ris

The gods' runner, and the poem's most reliable instrument: she carries Zeus's word and no one else's business is ever her own. She rouses the Trojan assembly in Priam's likeness at 2.786, leads the wounded Aphrodite out of the fighting and up to Olympus (5.353–369), turns Hera and Athena back from the field with Zeus's threat (8.398–425), and brings Achilles unarmed to the ditch on Hera's secret errand (18.166–202). She has one line of her own judgment — telling Poseidon that the hearts of the great can turn (15.203) — and Poseidon calls it the mark of a messenger who knows what is fitting. In Book 23 she carries Achilles' prayer to the winds; in Book 24 she goes down through the sea to Thetis and then to Priam, and her speech to him repeats Zeus's word almost exactly.

Epithets: "wind-footed swift Iris" (ποδὴνέμος ὠκέα Ἴρις, 2.786); "swift-footed Iris" (πόδας ὠκέα Ἴρις, 2.790); "of the golden wings" (χρυσόπτερος, 8.398); "storm-footed" (ἀελλόπος, 8.409).

Refs: 2.786, 3.121, 5.353, 8.398, 11.185, 15.157, 18.166, 24.143 ...and throughout. Books 2–3, 5, 8, 11, 15, 18, 23–24.

See also: Zeus, Hera, Aphrodite, Poseidon, Thetis, Priam, Achilles.

Jason (Ἰήσων) · MORTAL — Say: JAY-sun

In the back-story only: "shepherd of the people," to whom Hypsipyle bore Euneus, the king of Lemnos who sends wine-ships to the Achaean camp and gives a thousand measures separately to Agamemnon and Menelaus (7.467–471). The poem's interest in him is entirely through his son, who buys Lycaon when Achilles sells him into

Lemnos (21.41) and whose silver mixing-bowl — paid as Lycaon's price to Patroclus — becomes the foot-race prize in Book 23.

Kin: by Hypsipyle, father of Euneus.

Refs: 7.468, 7.469, 7.471, 21.41, 23.746. Books 7, 21, 23.

See also: Euneus, Hypsipyle, Lemnos, Lycaon.

Laertes (Λαέρτης) · MORTAL — *Say:* lay-UR-teez

Odysseus's father, who never appears: in every one of his occurrences the name is a patronymic for his son. It carries the fixed vocative "Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus of many devices" (2.173), used by Athena, Agamemnon, Nestor, Diomedes and Achilles in turn; Helen names Odysseus to Priam from the wall as "Laertes' son, resourceful Odysseus" (3.200).

Kin: father of Odysseus.

Refs: 2.173, 3.200, 4.358, 8.93, 9.308, 10.144, 19.185, 23.723. Books 2–4, 8–10, 19, 23.

See also: Odysseus.

Lampus (Λάμπος) · MORTAL — *Say:* LAM-pus

One of the elders sitting with Priam at the Scaean Gates — "finished with war now because of age, but speakers of quality, like cicadas" — and one of Laomedon's sons, so Priam's brother; the genealogy Aeneas recites to Achilles puts him with Clytius and Hicetaon (20.238). His son Dolops, "the strongest son that Lampus fathered," is killed by Menelaus while fighting Meges (15.525–543). The name also belongs to one of Hector's four chariot-horses, called by name at 8.185.

Kin: son of Laomedon; brother of Priam, Tithonus, Clytius and Hicetaon; father of Dolops.

Refs: 3.147, 8.185, 15.526, 20.238. Books 3, 8, 15, 20.

See also: Laomedon, Priam, Clytius, Hicetaon, Dolops, Hector.

Laodice (Λαοδίκη) · MORTAL — *Say:* lay-OD-ih-see

Two women. Priam's daughter, "loveliest of the daughters of Priam" (3.124), married to Antenor's son Helicaon; Iris takes her likeness to fetch Helen to the wall, and Hecuba is leading her when she meets Hector in Book 6. A second Laodice is one of Agamemnon's three daughters, offered to Achilles with Chrysothemis and Iphianassa in the embassy's list of gifts (9.145 = 9.287).

Kin: Priam's daughter is the daughter of Priam and Hecuba, and wife of Helicaon; the other is a daughter of Agamemnon.

Refs: 3.124, 6.252, 9.145, 9.287. Books 3, 6, 9.

See also: Priam, Hecuba, Helicaon, Antenor, Agamemnon, Chrysothemis, Iphianassa.

Laomedon (Λαομέδων) · MORTAL — *Say:* lay-OM-uh-don

Priam's father, dead before the poem, and its standing example of a man who cheats gods. Poseidon tells the story twice: he and Apollo served him a whole year at a stated wage — Poseidon building the city wall, Apollo herding cattle on Ida — and at the term he robbed them by force and threatened to bind them and sell them overseas and cut off their ears (21.441–457, cf. 7.452–453). He also refused Heracles the horses promised for a service, and Heracles sacked Ilium for it (5.640–651). His horses remain the standard of excellence: Nestor tells Antilochus no man will pass him, not driving Arion nor "the horses of Laomedon, best of the breed reared here" (23.348).

Kin: son of Ilus; father of Priam, Tithonus, Lampus, Clytius, Hicetaon and Bucolion.

Refs: 3.250, 5.269, 5.640, 5.649, 7.453, 20.236, 21.444, 21.452, 23.348.

Books 3, 5–7, 15, 20–21, 23.

See also: Priam, Poseidon, Apollo, Heracles, Ilus, Lampus, Tros.

Laothoe (Λαοθόη) · MORTAL — *Say:* lay-OTH-oh-ee

One of Priam's wives, daughter of Altes lord of the Lelegians, and mother of Lycaon and Polydorus — the two sons Achilles kills within a book of each other. Lycaon names her as he supplicates: "to a short life my mother bore me — Laothoe, daughter of the old man Altes" (21.84–89). Priam, watching from the wall, counts the same two as missing and says that if they are dead it is grief to his heart and their mother's, "a queen among women" (22.46–53).

Kin: daughter of Altes; wife of Priam; mother of Lycaon and Polydorus.

Refs: 21.85, 22.48. Books 21–22.

See also: Altes, Priam, Lycaon, Polydorus, Achilles.

Lemnos (Λῆμνος) · PLACE — *Say:* LEM-nos

The island Hephaestus fell on when Zeus flung him from the threshold of heaven, where the Sintian men took him up (1.593); Philoctetes lies there abandoned with his snake-bite while his ships fight at Troy (2.722); and it is "the city of godlike Thoas" that Hera passes through on her way to find Sleep (14.230). It is also the poem's slave-market: Achilles ships Lycaon there and sells him, and the son of Jason pays the price (21.40–41) — a sale Lycaon and Achilles both throw back at each other in Book 21, and one Priam expects for his other sons in Book 24.

Refs: 1.593, 2.722, 8.230, 14.230, 14.281, 21.40, 21.58, 21.79, 24.753.

Books 1–2, 7–8, 14, 21, 24.

See also: Hephaestus, Philoctetes, Thoas, Lycaon, Euneus, Imbros.

Leonteus (Λεοντεύς) · MORTAL — Say: lee-ON-tyoos

One of the two Lapith captains, always paired with Polypoetes: they lead forty ships in the Catalogue and stand before the gate in Book 12 "like high-crowned oaks in the mountains that abide the wind and rain through all their days," refusing to be driven inside the wall. There he spears Hippomachus at the war-belt and then goes at the rest with the sword. In Book 23 he throws the lump of pig-iron second and loses to Polypoetes.

Epithets: "scion of Ares" (ὄζος Ἄρηος, 2.745).

Kin: son of Coronus, Caeneus' son.

Refs: 2.745, 12.130, 12.188, 23.837, 23.841. Books 2, 12, 23.

See also: Polypoetes, Coronus, Caeneus, Lapiths.

Lesbos (Λέσβος) · PLACE — Say: LEZ-bos

One of Achilles' conquests before the poem opens: the seven women skilled in blameless work whom Agamemnon offers in the embassy are the ones Achilles himself chose "when he himself took well-built Lesbos" (9.129–130 = 9.271–272), and the woman sleeping beside him at the end of Book 9 is Diomedes, Phorbas's daughter, brought from there. Achilles names it again in Book 24 as the seaward bound of Priam's old prosperity, "the seat of Macar."

Refs: 9.129, 9.130, 9.271, 9.664, 24.544. Books 9, 24.

See also: Achilles, Diomedes, Macar, Priam.

Leto (Λητώ) · GOD — Say: LEE-toh

Mother of Apollo and Artemis by Zeus, named in the poem's ninth line as the parent of the god who sends the plague. She takes the Trojan side: she heals Aeneas with Artemis in Apollo's shrine on Pergamos (5.447), and in the theomachy she is matched against Hermes — who declines to fight her, telling her to boast among the gods that she overcame him, and leaves her to gather up her daughter's scattered bow and arrows (21.497–504). Zeus names her in his catalogue of loves at 14.327, and it is for matching herself against Leto that Niobe's twelve children are killed (24.607). Achilles' horse Xanthus calls Apollo "the best of the gods, whom lovely-haired Leto bore" (19.413).

Epithets: "lovely-haired" (ἡῦκομος, 1.36); "fair-cheeked" (καλλιπάρης, 24.607).

Kin: by Zeus, mother of Apollo and Artemis.

Refs: 1.9, 1.36, 5.447, 14.327, 16.849, 19.413, 20.40, 21.497, 24.607.

Books 1, 5, 14, 16, 19–21, 24.

See also: Apollo, Artemis, Zeus, Hermes, Niobe.

Leïtus (Λήϊτος) · MORTAL — Say: LEE-ih-tus

One of the five Boeotian leaders in the Catalogue, and the one of them the poem keeps using. He kills Phylacus in Book 6, is among the captains Poseidon rouses in Book 13, and in Book 17 Hector wounds him on the wrist at close quarters and stops his fighting for good: "he shrank back, glancing round, for his heart no longer hoped to hold a spear steady in hand and fight the Trojans."

Kin: son of Alectryon (17.602).

Refs: 2.494, 6.35, 13.91, 17.601, 17.605. Books 2, 6, 13, 17.

See also: Peneleos, Boeotians, Alectryon, Hector.

Locrians (Λοκροί) · PEOPLE — Say: LOK-ree-unz

The lesser Ajax's forty ships, from Cynus, Opoeis and the towns around the Boagrius, "who live across from holy Euboea." Book 13 makes them the poem's only distinct light infantry: they carry no bronze helmets, no shields and no ash spears, only bows and slings of twisted wool, so they will not stand in the close fight — they follow behind the armored line and shoot unseen, and it is their arrows that break the Trojan formations and rout them (13.712–722).

Refs: 2.527, 2.535, 13.686, 13.712. Books 2, 13.

See also: Ajax son of Oïleus, Opoeis, Euboea.

Lycaon (Λυκάων) · MORTAL — Say: ly-KAY-on

Two men. The chief one is Priam's son by Laothoe, whose supplication in Book 21 is the poem's most sustained refusal. Achilles had taken him once by night in his father's orchard cutting fig-shoots for chariot-rails, shipped him to Lemnos and sold him; ransomed by Eëtion of Imbros, he had been home eleven days when Achilles meets him again in the river. He grasps the knees with one hand and the spear with the other and pleads guest-right and the grain of Demeter; Achilles answers that Patroclus died and was a better man, and that death and strong fate stand over himself too, then cuts through his collarbone and slings him into the river to the fish. His corslet is what Paris arms in for the duel (3.333). The second Lycaon is Pandarus's father, of Zeleia, whose eleven new-built chariots stand under cloths at home while Pandarus fights on foot (5.193–197); "Lycaon's shining son" throughout Books 4 and 5 means Pandarus, not Priam's son.

Kin: Priam's son is son of Priam and Laothoe, brother of Polydorus; the other is father of Pandarus.

Killed by: Achilles (21.114–119).

Refs: 2.826, 3.333, 4.89, 5.95, 5.193, 20.81, 21.35, 21.71, 21.127, 22.46, 23.746. Books 2–5, 20–23.

LYCIA – LYCOMEDES

See also: Pandarus, Priam, Laothoe, Polydorus, Achilles, Eëtion, Lemnos.

Lycia (Λυκία) · PLACE — *Say:* LISH-uh or LIS-ee-uh

The homeland of Sarpedon and Glaucus, the farthest of Troy's allies — "from far Lycia, from the eddying Xanthus" (2.877). Sarpedon names it as what he has left: his wife, his little son, and great wealth (5.480–481). It is also where Bellerophon was sent with the folded tablet, and where the king gave him his daughter and the best of the land (6.168–195); and Glaucus's account of the estate on the banks of Xanthus is the ground of Sarpedon's argument about why kings must fight in front (12.310–321). Sleep and Death carry Sarpedon's body back to "the rich country of wide Lycia" for burial (16.683).

Refs: 2.877, 5.105, 5.479, 6.168, 6.172, 6.225, 12.312, 12.319, 16.437, 16.673, 16.683. Books 2, 5–6, 12, 16–17.

See also: Lycians, Sarpedon, Glaucus, Bellerophon, Hippolochus.

Lycians (Λύκιοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* LISH-unz

Troy's strongest allies, led by Sarpedon and Glaucus, and the only contingent the poem treats as a rival to the Trojans themselves. Hector's rallying-cry names them in their own clause — "Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians who fight at close quarters" (8.173) — and it is they who first break through the Achaean wall in Book 12. Sarpedon shames them into the assault ("Lycians, why do you slacken your rushing courage so?", 12.409) and again as he dies over his own body; when he is killed they panic and abandon it, and Glaucus rounds on Hector for it in Book 17, threatening that no Lycian will fight for Troy again.

Refs: 2.876, 4.197, 5.633, 5.676, 8.173, 12.317, 12.409, 16.421, 16.659, 17.146. Books 2, 4–8, 10–17.

See also: Lycia, Sarpedon, Glaucus, Trojans, Hector.

Lycomedes (Λυκομήδης) · MORTAL — *Say:* ly-koh-MEE-deez

An Achaean captain of the second rank: one of the seven leaders of the night watch in Book 9, left with the lesser Ajax to hold the line while Telamonian Ajax goes along the wall (12.366), and one of the seven men Achilles sends to fetch Agamemnon's gifts in Book 19. His one killing comes in Book 17: when Aeneas spears his companion Leiocritus, he casts in pity and hits Apisaon in the liver below the midriff.

Kin: son of Creon.

Refs: 9.84, 12.366, 17.345, 17.346, 19.240. Books 9, 12, 17, 19.

See also: Creon, Ajax son of Oïleus, Leiocritus, Apisaon.

Lycurgus (Λυκοῦργος) · MORTAL — Say: ly-KUR-gus

Two men, both from stories told inside the poem. Diomedes cites the first as the warning against fighting gods: Dryas' son, who chased the nurses of raving Dionysus down Nysa beating them with an ox-goad, until Dionysus dived under the sea and Thetis took him in terror; the gods were angered, Zeus struck him blind, and he did not live long, "hated by all the immortal gods" (6.130–140). The second is the Arcadian of Nestor's Book 7 reminiscence, who killed Areithous the Club-man by craft in a narrow lane where the iron club was useless, and in old age passed the stripped armor to his aide Ereuthalion.

Kin: the first is son of Dryas.

Kills: the Arcadian kills Areithous (7.142–145).

Refs: 6.130, 6.135, 6.139, 7.142, 7.144, 7.148. Books 6–7.

See also: Dryas, Dionysus, Diomedes, Areithous, Ereuthalion, Nestor.

Lyrnessus (Λυρνησσός) · PLACE — Say: lur-NES-us

The town Achilles sacked, taking Briseis out of it "with great toil" and killing Mynes and Epistrophus, the sons of Euenus (2.690–693). Achilles wishes in Book 19 that Artemis had killed the girl with an arrow "on the day I chose her from the sack of Lyrnessus." Aeneas names it too, in a different register: it was to Lyrnessus he fled when Achilles came down on the cattle off Ida and chased him, and Achilles wrecked the town behind him while Zeus saved the man (20.90–92, 20.191).

Refs: 2.690, 2.691, 19.60, 20.92, 20.191. Books 2, 19–20.

See also: Briseis, Achilles, Aeneas, Mynes, Thebe, Pegasus.

Machaon (Μαχάων) · MORTAL — Say: muh-KAY-on

One of the army's two physicians, son of Asclepius, who leads thirty ships from Tricca with his brother Podaleirius. He is fetched by Talthybius to draw the arrow from Menelaus's war-belt and sprinkle the soothing drugs Chiron once gave his father (4.193–219). His own wounding turns the poem: Paris hits him in the right shoulder, Nestor drives him out of the fighting, Achilles sees the pair from his ship's stern and sends Patroclus to ask who the wounded man is — "and that was the beginning of his evil" (11.504–605). Patroclus finds him drinking Hecamede's posset in Nestor's hut and does not stay; Eurypylus later notes that of the two healers one lies wounded and the other is still on the plain (11.833).

Kin: son of Asclepius; brother of Podaleirius.

Refs: 2.732, 4.193, 4.200, 4.213, 11.506, 11.598, 11.651, 11.833, 14.3.

Books 2, 4, 11, 14.

See also: Asclepius, Podaleirius, Nestor, Patroclus, Menelaus, Eurypylus, Tricca.

Maeonia (Μηονία) · PLACE — Say: mee-OH-nee-uh

"Lovely Maeonia," in Asia Minor beside Phrygia, named three times and always in a pair with it. Helen taunts Aphrodite by asking whether she means to carry her off next to some fine city of Phrygia or Maeonia (3.401); the simile for Menelaus's wound has "some woman of Maeonia or Caria" staining ivory with crimson for a horse's cheek-piece (4.141); and Hector says Troy's heirlooms have been sold off into Phrygia and Maeonia since Zeus turned his wrath on the city (18.292).

Refs: 3.401, 4.141, 18.292. Books 3, 4, 18.

See also: Maeonians, Phrygia, Caria.

Maeonians (Μήονες) · PEOPLE — Say: mee-OH-nee-unz

A Trojan-side contingent from under Tmolus, led by Mesthles and Antiphus, the two sons of Talaemenes, "whom the Gygaean lake bore" (2.864–866). Dolon places them in the night dispositions among the allies quartered toward Thymbre, as "men who fight from chariots" (10.431).

Refs: 2.864, 2.866, 10.431. Books 2, 10.

See also: Maeonia, Mesthles, Antiphus, Dolon.

Mecisteus (Μηκιστεύς) · MORTAL — Say: muh-SIS-tyoos

Three men. The first belongs to the Theban generation: Talaus' son, father of Euryalus, and the man who went to Thebes for the burial of fallen Oedipus and beat all the sons of Cadmus at the games there (23.678–680) — a father's exploit of the kind Agamemnon uses to shame the sons. The second is Echius' son, a rescuer rather than a fighter: twice, in identical lines, he and Alastor stoop under a wounded Ajax or Hypsenor and carry him groaning to the ships (8.333 = 13.422). A third Mecisteus is killed by Polydamas in the rout at the ships (15.339).

Kin: the first is son of Talaus and father of Euryalus; the second is son of Echius.

Killed by: the third by Polydamas (15.339).

Refs: 2.566, 6.27, 8.333, 13.422, 15.339, 23.678. Books 2, 6, 8, 13, 15, 23.

See also: Euryalus, Talaus, Echius, Alastor, Polydamas, Oedipus.

Medon (Μέδων) · MORTAL — Say: MEE-don

The lesser Ajax's bastard half-brother, whom Rhene bore to Oïleus; he commands Philoctetes' abandoned contingent in the Catalogue and the Phthians in Book 13. His biography is given twice in the same four lines: he lived in Phylace, far from his own country, having killed a kinsman of his stepmother Eriopis (13.694–697 = 15.333–336). The second telling is his obituary — Aeneas strips the life from him and Iasus together at 15.332. A Trojan-side Medon is named among the allied captains

Hector rouses at 17.216.

Kin: son of Oïleus and Rhene; half-brother of Ajax son of Oïleus.

Killed by: Aeneas (15.332).

Refs: 2.727, 13.693, 13.694, 15.332, 15.333, 17.216. Books 2, 13, 15, 17.

See also: Ajax son of Oïleus, Oïleus, Philoctetes, Aeneas, Phylace, Podarces.

Meges (Μέγης) · MORTAL — *Say:* MEE-jeez

Leader of the forty ships from Dulichium and the Echinae, son of the horseman Phyleus who had moved there in anger at his own father. He kills Antenor's bastard son Pedaeus in Book 5, and in Book 13 is named among the leaders of the Epeians. His long scene is Book 15: he kills Croesmus, and while he strips him Dolops son of Lampus drives a spear into his shield — the corslet Phyleus had brought home from Ephyra as a guest-gift saves him — and he shears the plume clean off Dolops's helmet before Menelaus comes to his rescue. He is one of the seven who fetch Agamemnon's gifts in Book 19.

Epithets: "the equal of Ares" (ἰσάμενος Ἄρηϊ, 2.627).

Also called: Phyleus' son.

Kin: son of Phyleus.

Refs: 2.627, 5.69, 13.692, 15.302, 15.520, 15.535, 19.239. Books 2, 5, 13, 15, 19.

See also: Phyleus, Dolops, Pedaeus, Croesmus, Menelaus, Dulichium.

Melanippus (Μελάνιππος) · MORTAL — *Say:* mel-uh-NIP-us

Four men bear the name. The one the poem develops is Hicetaon's son, a cousin of Hector's: he had been herding cattle in Percote until the Danaan ships came, and then lived in Priam's house and was honored like his own children. Hector rebukes him over Dolops's body and he follows; Menelaus sets Antilochus on him, and Antilochus hits him in the chest by the nipple and springs on him like a hound on a hit fawn, only to be driven off by Hector (15.546–585). The others are a Trojan Teucer kills at 8.276, one of Patroclus's victims in the roll-call at 16.695, and an Achaean among the men Achilles sends for Agamemnon's gifts (19.240).

Kin: the Trojan is son of Hicetaon.

Killed by: Hicetaon's son by Antilochus (15.576–578).

Refs: 8.276, 15.547, 15.553, 15.576, 15.582, 16.695, 19.240. Books 8, 15, 16, 19.

See also: Hicetaon, Antilochus, Hector, Dolops, Menelaus, Teucer.

Meleager (Μελέαγρος) · MORTAL — *Say:* mel-ee-AY-jur

Phoenix's exemplum in the embassy, and the poem's model for Achilles' own case. Oeneus' son, dead before the Catalogue is spoken (2.642), he killed the boar Artemis sent against Calydon and then, in anger at his mother Althaea's curses, withdrew

from the fighting and lay beside his wife Cleopatra while the Curetes stormed the walls. Elders, priests, his father, his sisters and his mother all begged him and he refused the more; only when the towers were under bombardment and the city burning did his wife's plea move him, and he went out — and got none of the gifts he had been offered. Phoenix's point is the moral: come out while the gifts are still on the table.

Kin: son of Oeneus and Althaea; husband of Cleopatra.

Refs: 2.642, 9.543, 9.550, 9.553, 9.565, 9.590. Books 2, 9.

See also: Phoenix, Oeneus, Althaea, Cleopatra, Calydon, Curetes, Artemis.

Menelaus (Μενέλαος) · MORTAL — *Say:* men-uh-LAY-us

Agamemnon's brother and Helen's husband, the man the war is nominally for, and the one Achaean whose motive is personal. He volunteers unbidden for the muster (2.408), takes the duel with Paris in Book 3 and all but wins it — the spear through the shield, the sword shattering on the helmet-ridge, the chin-strap strangling Paris until Aphrodite breaks it and carries the man off — and is then shot by Pandarus in the broken truce, the arrow steered by Athena into the buckles of his war-belt (4.127–140). The poem's word for him is restraint verging on softness: Agamemnon overrules his mercy to the suppliant Adrestus and does the killing himself (6.51–65), the army fears for him when he offers to fight Hector (7.104–109). His full measure comes in Book 17, where he stands over Patroclus's body, kills Euphorbus for it, and, when at last he must leave it to the Ajaxes, goes off to find Antilochus so someone can carry the news to Achilles. In Book 23 he charges Antilochus with fouling him in the chariot-race and then, satisfied by an apology, gives the mare back.

Epithets: "dear to Ares" (ἀρηϊφίλος, 3.21); "tawny-haired" (ξανθός, 3.284); "good at the war-cry" (βοῆν ἀγαθός, 2.408).

Also called: Atreus' son — but "Atreus' son" in the singular means Agamemnon unless the scene is Menelaus's; see `canon.md`.

Kin: son of Atreus; brother of Agamemnon; husband of Helen.

Kills: Peisander (13.601–642), Euphorbus (17.45–60), Podes (17.578–581).

Refs: 1.159, 2.408, 3.21, 3.339, 4.128, 6.37, 7.94, 13.601, 17.1, 17.60, 23.566 ...and throughout. Books 1–8, 10–11, 13, 15–17, 23.

See also: Agamemnon, Helen, Paris, Atreus, Antilochus, Euphorbus, Patroclus, Ajax.

Menestheus (Μενεσθεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* muh-NES-thyoos

The Athenian leader, of Erechtheus' city, with fifty ships: "no man on the face of the earth was his equal at marshaling horses and shield-bearing men — Nestor alone

rivalled him, for he was older" (2.553–555). The praise is not borne out in action. His scene is Book 12, where Sarpedon's Lycians come at his stretch of wall and he peers along it for help, unable to make himself heard over the din, until Thootes fetches Telamonian Ajax and Teucer to his tower. He and Stichius carry Amphinachus's body back in Book 13; his trusted companion Arcesilaus is killed by Hector at 15.331.

Also called: Peteos' son.

Kin: son of Peteos.

Refs: 2.552, 4.327, 12.331, 12.373, 13.195, 13.690, 15.331. Books 2, 4, 12, 13, 15.

See also: Peteos, Athenians, Ajax, Teucer, Sarpedon, Stichius.

Menoetius (Μενοίτιος) · MORTAL — Say: muh-NEE-tee-us

Patroclus' father, Actor's son, of Opoeis: he brought his son as a small boy to Peleus' house after a killing over a game of dice, and Peleus raised the two children together (23.85–90). He is alive in Phthia through the poem — Achilles asks whether Patroclus has news that he or Peleus has died (16.14) — but he never appears, and in nearly all of the name's 38 occurrences it is the patronymic "Menoetius' son" or "Menoetius's stout son," meaning Patroclus. Nestor quotes the charge he gave at parting: you are the elder, so advise Achilles well, he will listen (11.785–789).

Achilles' reproach to himself in Book 18 is that he promised to bring the man's far-famed son back to Opoeis with his share of the spoils.

Kin: son of Actor; father of Patroclus.

Refs: 1.307, 9.202, 11.605, 11.765, 11.785, 16.14, 18.12, 18.325, 21.28, 23.85, 24.16 ...and throughout. Books 1, 9, 11–12, 16–19, 21, 23–24.

See also: Patroclus, Achilles, Peleus, Actor, Opoeis, Nestor.

Meriones (Μηριόνης) · MORTAL — Say: muh-RY-oh-neeZ

Idomeneus's aide and second in command of the Cretans, and one of the poem's most consistently competent fighters. Their exchange outside the huts in Book 13 — he has come back for a spear, having shattered his on Deiphobus's shield, and Idomeneus offers him twenty Trojan spears taken from the men he has killed — is the poem's fullest picture of two veterans talking shop. He wounds Deiphobus in the arm, shoots Harpalion through the buttock into the bladder as he retreats, kills the priest Laogonus in Book 16 and trades taunts with Aeneas over a missed cast. He is Odysseus's armorer for the night raid, lending the boar's-tusk helmet whose four-generation provenance the poem tracks (10.260–271). In Book 23 he drives the slowest horses and finishes fourth, then wins the archery: Teucer, who did not vow to Apollo, cuts only the cord; Meriones snatches the bow, vows the hecatomb, and shoots the dove through under the wing high under the clouds.

Epithets: "the equal of Enyalios, slayer of men" (ἰσάμενος Ἐνυαλίῳ, 2.651).

Kin: son of Molus.

Refs: 2.651, 10.260, 13.249, 13.528, 13.650, 16.603, 17.717, 23.528, 23.870.

Books 2, 4–5, 7–10, 13–17, 19, 23.

See also: Idomeneus, Molus, Cretans, Deiphobus, Teucer, Odysseus, Harpalion.

Molus (Μῶλος) · MORTAL — *Say:* MOH-lus

Meriones' father, named only in the patronymic and in the pedigree of the boar's-tusk helmet: Amphidamas of Cythera gave it to Molus as a guest-gift, and Molus gave it to his son Meriones to wear — the third of four hands it passes through before it is set on Odysseus's head for the night raid.

Kin: father of Meriones.

Refs: 10.269, 10.270, 13.249. *Books* 10, 13.

See also: Meriones, Amphidamas, Odysseus, Idomeneus.

Mulius (Μούλιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* MYOO-lee-us

Three men, all killed. The first is the Epeian of Nestor's Book 11 reminiscence, Augeias' son-in-law, husband of his eldest daughter Agamede "who knew as many drugs as the wide earth grows" — the first man Nestor ever killed, and he took his whole-hoofed horses. The second is one of Patroclus's victims in the roll-call at 16.696. The third is a Trojan Achilles spears through the ear in Book 20, the bronze point passing out through the other ear.

Kin: the Epeian is son-in-law of Augeias and husband of Agamede.

Killed by: the Epeian by Nestor (11.742); the second by Patroclus (16.696); the third by Achilles (20.472–473).

Refs: 11.739, 16.696, 20.472. *Books* 11, 16, 20.

See also: Nestor, Augeias, Agamede, Patroclus, Achilles.

Muses (Μοῦσαι) · GOD

Daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus, singers in answer to Apollo's lyre at the gods' feast in Book 1. Their function in the poem is to know: the poet invokes them before the Catalogue because "you are goddesses, you are present, you know all things, while we hear only the report and know nothing" (2.484–486), and the same line opens the three later roll-calls (11.218, 14.508, 16.112). At 2.761 the singular Muse is asked who was best of the men and horses. Their one action is punitive: they met Thamyras the Thracian at Dorium, who had boasted he would win a singing contest against them, and maimed him — took away his wondrous song and made him forget his harping.

Kin: daughters of Zeus.

Refs: 1.604, 2.484, 2.491, 2.594, 2.598, 2.761, 11.218, 14.508, 16.112.

MYCENAE – MYSIANS

Books 1, 2, 11, 14, 16.

See also: Zeus, Apollo, Thamyris, Olympus.

Mycenae (Μυκῆνη) · PLACE — Say: my-SEE-nee

Agamemnon's city and the seat of his fleet — "the great fleet that followed you from Mycenae" (9.44) — and, in the formula, "Mycenae rich in gold" (7.180 = 11.46). Hera names it third of the cities dearest to her, with Argos and Sparta, and offers all three to be sacked whenever they grow hateful to Zeus, if Troy may fall (4.52–53). Tydeus came there once as a guest with Polyneices, raising troops for Thebes (4.376–377). Periphetes, the best man in the city, is Hector's one kill in the rout of Book 15.

Refs: 2.569, 4.52, 4.376, 7.180, 9.44, 11.46, 15.638. Books 2, 4, 7, 9, 11, 15.

See also: Agamemnon, Argos, Hera, Tydeus, Periphetes.

Myrmidons (Μυρμιδόνες) · PEOPLE — Say: MUR-mih-donz

Achilles' own contingent, fifty ships from Phthia and Hellas; the Catalogue notes that the same men "were called Myrmidons, and Hellenes, and Achaeans" (2.684), which makes the last a regional name here and not the whole host. They sit out the war with their leader — Agamemnon's insult is "go home and be king over your Myrmidons" (1.180) — until Book 16, when Achilles arms them for Patroclus. Their two similes there are the poem's harshest: wolves that have torn a stag, their muzzles red, going down to lap black water; and roadside wasps that boys have been provoking, who come out all at once. They mourn Patroclus, drive their chariots three times around the body, and build Achilles' hut in the description that opens the last scene of Book 24.

Refs: 1.180, 2.684, 9.185, 16.155, 16.200, 16.266, 18.355, 19.278, 23.6, 24.449.

Books 1–2, 7, 9, 11, 16, 18–19, 21, 23–24.

See also: Achilles, Patroclus, Phthia, Hellenes, Achaeans.

Mysians (Μυσοί) · PEOPLE — Say: MIZH-unz

Trojan-side allies, led in the Catalogue by Chromis and Ennomus the bird-reader, "but his birds did not save him from black doom" (2.858–860). Dolon puts them in the night dispositions with the Lycians and Phrygians, and Zeus turns his eyes from Troy in Book 13 to look on "the close-fighting Mysians" and the Mare-milkers. Ajax wounds their leader Hyrtius son of Gyrtius at 14.512. Their last appearance is as gift-givers: the strong-hoofed mules Priam yokes for the journey to Achilles were once a Mysian present to him (24.278).

Refs: 2.858, 10.430, 13.5, 14.512, 24.278. Books 2, 10, 13, 14, 24.

See also: Ennomus, Chromis, Hyrtius, Priam, Dolon.

Nastes (Νάστης) · MORTAL — Say: NAS-teez

Captain, with his brother Amphimachus, of "the Carians of barbarous speech" from Miletus and the Maeander — "Nastes and Amphimachus, the shining children of Nomion."

The Catalogue then says one of the two went to war decked in gold like a girl, "the fool: it did not ward off wretched destruction from him," and was broken in the river under Achilles, who carried off the gold; the text does not say which brother it was.

Kin: son of Nomion; brother of Amphimachus.

Refs: 2.867, 2.870, 2.871. Book 2.

See also: Amphimachus, Nomion, Carians, Achilles.

Neleus (Νηλεύς) · MORTAL — Say: NEE-lee-us

Nestor's father and king of Pylos, dead before the action: in nearly every one of its occurrences the name is a patronymic, and "Neleus' son" means Nestor. He appears in his own right only inside Nestor's Book 11 reminiscence, glad at heart when his young son drives Eleian plunder into Pylos, and afterward hiding the boy's horses and forbidding him to arm, "for he said I did not yet know the works of war." Twelve sons were born to him, Nestor says, and Nestor alone was left — the might of Heracles had killed the rest.

Kin: father of Nestor and eleven other sons.

Refs: 2.20, 10.87, 11.683, 11.692, 11.717, 15.378, 23.303, 23.514.

Books 2, 8, 10, 11, 14, 15, 23.

See also: Nestor, Pylos, Heracles, Antilochus.

Nereids (Νηρηίδες) · GOD — Say: NEER-ee-idz

Thetis's sisters, the sea-nymphs who gather around her in the depths when she wails for Achilles at the opening of Book 18. The poem names thirty-three of them in a four-line catalogue (18.39–49) — Glauce, Thaleia, Cymodoce and the rest — and closes it "and the other Nereids who were in the depths of the sea." They fill the silver-shining cave, beat their breasts, and follow Thetis ashore;

Thetis addresses them as "sister Nereids" and leads the lament.

Kin: daughters of the old man of the sea; sisters of Thetis.

Refs: 18.38, 18.49, 18.52. Book 18.

See also: Thetis, Achilles.

Nestor (Νέστωρ) · MORTAL — Say: NES-tor

The aged king of Pylos, third-generation ruler who has outlived two generations of mortal men, and the counselor whose plans set the poem's machinery moving. He tries and fails to compose the quarrel in Book 1; he proposes the wall and ditch (7.325–343); he frames the embassy to Achilles and picks its members (9.162–172);

NIGHT – NIOBE

he devises the night raid; and it is his suggestion at 11.794–803 — send Patroclus out in Achilles' armor — that Patroclus carries back and that kills him. His authority is verbal, not martial: he is rescued out of the fighting in Book 8, and at the funeral games Achilles gives him a prize outright because he will not compete, "the hard weight of age is on you now."

Epithets: "the Gerenian horseman Nestor" (Γερήνιος ἵπποτα Νέστωρ, 2.336); "the Gerenian, warden of the Achaeans" (Γερήνιος οὔρος Ἀχαιῶν, 8.80); "the clear-voiced speaker" (λίγυς ἀγορητής, 1.248).

Also called: Neleus' son.

Kin: son of Neleus; father of Antilochus and Thrasymedes.

Refs: 1.247, 2.336, 4.293, 7.325, 8.80, 9.162, 10.18, 11.501 ...and throughout.

Books 1–2, 4–11, 13–19, 23.

See also: Neleus, Antilochus, Thrasymedes, Patroclus, Pylos, Agamemnon.

Night (Νύξ) · GOD

Personified, and named once in a story Sleep tells Hera to explain why he will not put Zeus to sleep a second time. Hunted through the house by a furious Zeus and about to be flung from the sky into the sea, Sleep ran to Night for refuge, and Zeus checked himself: "he stood in awe of doing what swift Night would hate." The poem gives her no other action; the line is its shortest statement that some things are older than Zeus.

Epithets: "Night, subduer of gods and men" (Νύξ δμῆτιρα θεῶν καὶ ἀνδρῶν, 14.259).

Refs: 14.259, 14.261. Book 14.

See also: Sleep, Zeus, Hera.

Niobe (Νιόβη) · MORTAL — *Say:* NY-oh-bee

Achilles' exemplum in the last book: he tells Priam that even Niobe remembered food, though twelve children died in her halls — six daughters and six sons, killed by Artemis and Apollo because she had matched herself against Leto, who bore only two. The dead lay nine days unburied, the people having been turned to stone by Zeus, and the gods buried them on the tenth; and Niobe, worn out with weeping, ate. She is now stone herself on Sipylus, brooding on the griefs the gods gave her. The story is the argument that persuades Priam to eat.

Kin: mother of six sons and six daughters.

Refs: 24.602, 24.606, 24.607. Book 24.

See also: Achilles, Priam, Leto, Apollo, Artemis, Sipylus.

Nireus (Νιρεύς) · MORTAL — Say: NY-ryoos

Leader of three ships from Syme, named three times over in three consecutive lines of the Catalogue — the poem's most conspicuous piece of anaphora — as "the most beautiful man who came under Ilion / of all the Danaans, after the blameless son of Peleus." The compliment is immediately withdrawn: "But he was a slight man, and few people followed him." He never appears again.

Kin: son of Aglaia and lord Charopus.

Refs: 2.671, 2.672, 2.673. Book 2.

See also: Achaeans, Achilles.

Ocean (Ὠκεανός) · GOD

The stream that encircles the world and the god of it. As geography it is where the sun and stars go down and Dawn rises out (8.485, 19.1), where Zeus goes feasting with the Ethiopians (1.423), and the outermost rim of the Shield of Achilles (18.607); the Bear alone "has no share in the baths of Ocean." As a person he is the father from whom, Achilles says, all rivers and seas and springs flow, and who nonetheless fears Zeus's thunderbolt (21.195–199); with Tethys he is "the begetting of the gods," and Hera's pretext for leaving Olympus is that she goes to reconcile their long estrangement.

Also called: Oceanus — the spelling the translation uses of the named god in Book 14; "Ocean" elsewhere for the encircling stream.

Kin: consort of Tethys; father of Eurynome (18.399) and, as the poem has it, of all waters.

Refs: 1.423, 8.485, 14.201, 14.246, 14.302, 18.607, 19.1, 21.195.

Books 1, 3, 5, 7, 8, 14, 16, 18–21, 23.

See also: Tethys, Hera, Achelous, Scamander, Eurynome.

Odus (Ὀδῖος) · MORTAL — Say: OH-dee-us

Two men. The first leads the Halizones with Epistrophus "from far away, from Alybe, where silver has its birthplace," and is the first man killed in the general fighting of Book 5: Agamemnon spears him in the back between the shoulders as he turns to run, and drives the point through his chest. The second is an Achaean herald, sent with Eurybates to accompany the embassy to Achilles. *Killed by:* Agamemnon (5.38–42).

Refs: 2.856, 5.39, 9.170. Books 2, 5, 9.

See also: Agamemnon, Epistrophus, Eurybates, Halizones.

Odysseus (Ὀδυσσεύς) · MORTAL — Say: oh-DIS-ee-us or oh-DISS-yoos

The Achaeans' tactician, and the man the poem sends whenever a thing must be

managed rather than won by force. He turns the army back from the ships in Book 2 and beats Thersites out of the assembly; he escorts Chryseis home; he speaks first for the embassy in Book 9 and Nestor charges him "above all" to win Achilles over; he goes out with Diomedes on the night raid and brings back Rhesus' horses; and in Book 19 he holds Achilles to the army's need to eat before fighting. Antenor's account of him at Troy long before the war (3.203–224) is the poem's fullest portrait of a speaker: a man who stands with his eyes on the ground like a fool until the words come out of him like snowflakes in winter.

Epithets: "resourceful" (πολύμητις, 1.311); "of many devices" (πολυμήχανος, 2.173); "the equal of Zeus in counsel" (Διὶ μῆτιν ἀτάλαντος, 2.169); "sacker of cities" (πτολίπορθος, 2.278); "much-enduring brilliant Odysseus" (πολύτλας δῖος Ὀδυσσεύς, 8.97); "of the many tales" (πολύαινος, 9.673); "hardy" (τλήμων, 10.231); "patient-hearted" (ταλασίφρων, 11.466); "of the subtle wiles" (ποικιλομήτης, 11.482).

Also called: Laertes' son.

Kin: son of Laertes; father of Telemachus (2.260); of Ithaca.

Refs: 1.311, 2.169, 2.244, 3.200, 3.216, 9.169, 10.243, 11.466 ...and throughout. Books 1–11, 14, 16, 19, 23.

See also: Diomedes, Athena, Thersites, Laertes, Nestor, Achilles, Ithaca.

Oeneus (Οἰνεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* EE-nyoos

King of Calydon in the generation before the war, and the root of two of the poem's houses: Tydeus' father and so Diomedes' grandfather, and the father of Meleager. It was his failure to give Artemis a harvest-offering from his orchard slope — "he forgot, or he did not think of it: a great blindness of heart" — that loosed the Calydonian boar and set the whole Meleager story going; and it is Oeneus who begs his son at the threshold, one of the suppliants Meleager refuses. Glaucus and Diomedes discover their inherited guest-friendship through him: Oeneus once entertained Bellerophon twenty days and gave him a crimson war-belt.

Kin: son of Portheus, brother of Agrius and Melas (14.115–118); father of Tydeus and Meleager; grandfather of Diomedes.

Refs: 2.641, 5.813, 6.216, 6.219, 9.534, 9.543, 9.581, 14.117.

Books 2, 5, 6, 9, 10, 14.

See also: Tydeus, Diomedes, Meleager, Bellerophon, Glaucus, Calydon, Portheus.

Oenomaus (Οἰνόμαος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ee-noh-MAY-us

Two men, one on each side. The first is an Achaean, named in the roll-call of those Hector and Ares strip of their arms in Book 5, between Trechus the Aetolian

OLYMPUS – ORESTES

and Helenus son of Oenops. The second is a Trojan, one of the captains who storm the wall around Asius in Book 12; Idomeneus kills him in Book 13 with a spear mid-belly that bursts the corslet-plate and spills his bowels, and cannot strip the armor for the missiles flying.

Killed by: the Achaean by Hector or Ares (5.706); the Trojan by Idomeneus (13.506–510).

Refs: 5.706, 12.140, 13.506. Books 5, 12, 13.

See also: Idomeneus, Asius, Hector.

Olympus (Ὀλυμπος) · PLACE — Say: oh-LIM-pus

The mountain where the gods live, and by extension the divine household itself — the place Thetis goes to petition, Hera and Athena start from, and Iris is sent down from. Its gates are kept by the Seasons, who roll the cloud aside (5.749); Zeus sits apart from the others on its topmost peak; and when he bows his head he shakes the whole of it (1.530). The poem's assemblies of the gods are held there, and it is measured against the world below in Zeus's boast that he could hang earth and sea from a horn of Olympus with all the gods pulling (8.25).

Epithets: "snow-capped" (ἀγάννιφος, 1.420); "shining" (αἰγλήεις, 1.532).

Also called: Olympian, of the gods who dwell there.

Refs: 1.18, 1.420, 1.499, 1.530, 5.750, 8.3, 8.25, 20.5 ...and throughout.

Books 1–8, 10–16, 18–22, 24.

See also: Zeus, Hera, Thetis, Ida, Iris.

Opoeis (Ὀποῦς) · PLACE — Say: oh-POH-is

A town in Locris, named in the Catalogue among the places the Locrians held, and otherwise the home of Menoetius and Patroclus. Patroclus was brought out of it as a small boy, exiled for killing Amphidamas' son in a quarrel over dice, and taken into Peleus' house; and Achilles admits at 18.324–327 that he promised Menoetius he would bring the son back to Opoeis with his share of the spoils.

Refs: 2.531, 18.326, 23.86. Books 2, 18, 23.

See also: Patroclus, Menoetius, Locrians, Amphidamas, Peleus.

Orestes (Ὀρέστης) · MORTAL — Say: oh-RES-teez

Three men. Agamemnon's son, "my late-born boy, reared in high plenty," is named only as the measure of the honor promised Achilles in the embassy offer — a son-in-law would be honored his equal — and the phrase is repeated verbatim when Odysseus relays it. Of the other two, one is an Achaean stripped of his arms by Hector and Ares in Book 5, "Orestes, driver of horses"; the other a Trojan, in Asius' storming-party at the wall and killed by Leonteus at 12.193.

ORION – ΟΪΛΕΥΣ

Kin: Agamemnon's Orestes is his only son, brother of Chrysothemis, Laodice and Iphianassa.

Killed by: the Trojan by Leonteus (12.193).

Refs: 5.705, 9.142, 9.284, 12.139, 12.193. Books 5, 9, 12.

See also: Agamemnon, Achilles, Leonteus, Asius.

Orion (Ὠρίων) · OTHER — *Say:* oh-RY-un

The constellation. Hephaestus sets "the strength of Orion" on the Shield among the Pleiades, the Hyades and the Bear — the Bear "who turns in her own place, keeping watch on Orion, / and alone has no share in the baths of Ocean." His name returns in Book 22 for the star Achilles is compared to as Priam watches him cross the plain: "the star men call by name the Dog of Orion," brightest of all, and an evil sign that brings fever on wretched mortals.

Refs: 18.486, 18.488, 22.29. Books 18, 22.

See also: Achilles, Ocean, Hephaestus.

Othryoneus (Ὀθρυονεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* oth-ry-OH-nyoos

A newcomer to Troy from Cabesus, "lately come, chasing the report of the war," who asked Priam for Cassandra without bride-gifts and promised in exchange to drive the Achaeans out of the land; Priam bowed his head to it, and Othryoneus fought trusting the promise. Idomeneus spears him in mid-stride through the belly and then jeers over the corpse, offering him instead the loveliest of Agamemnon's daughters — "you will find we are not hard men over bride-terms" — while dragging him off by the foot. Deiphobus names him among the lost Trojan leaders at 13.772.

Killed by: Idomeneus (13.370–383).

Refs: 13.363, 13.369, 13.374, 13.772. Book 13.

See also: Idomeneus, Cassandra, Priam, Asius, Deiphobus.

Otrynteus (Ὀτρυντεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* oh-TRIN-tyoos

Father of Iphition, the first man Achilles kills on his return to the fighting.

He is a "sacker of cities" whose estate lay by the Gygaean lake in the rich district of Hyde, under snowy Tmolus, and a naiad nymph bore him the son. He does not appear himself; Achilles names him twice standing over the split skull — "Lie there, son of Otrynteus — most terrifying of all men!"

Kin: father of Iphition, by a naiad nymph.

Refs: 20.383, 20.384, 20.389. Book 20.

See also: Iphition, Achilles, Hyde.

Oïleus (Οἰλεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* oh-EYE-lyoos

Two men. The first is the father of the lesser Ajax, whose name is the standing

way of distinguishing him from Telamon's son — "swift Ajax, Oïleus' son" — and also the father, by Rhene, of the bastard Medon, who lives in exile at Phylace for killing a kinsman of his stepmother Eriopis. He is called "sacker of cities" at 2.728 and never appears in the action. The second is a Trojan charioteer, "Oïleus, lasher of horses," who leaps down from his car to face Agamemnon and is killed at once (11.93).

Kin: father of Ajax son of Oïleus and, by Rhene, of Medon; husband of Eriopis.

Killed by: the charioteer by Agamemnon (11.93–95).

Refs: 2.527, 2.727, 2.728, 11.93, 13.694, 13.712, 14.442, 15.333, 23.754.

Books 2, 11–17, 23.

See also: Ajax son of Oïleus, Medon, Ajax, Locrians, Agamemnon.

Paeonians (Παίονες) · PEOPLE — Say: pee-OH-nee-unz

Trojan-side allies from Amydon on the Axios, "Axius, whose water spreads fairest over the earth," led at first by Pyraechmes and later by Asteropaeus. Patroclus kills Pyraechmes and panics them; and in Book 21 Achilles, having killed Asteropaeus, hunts them down the river — Thersilochus, Mydon, Astypylus, Mnesus, Thrasius, Aenius, Ophelestes — and would have killed more had the river not called out to him in anger.

Epithets: "the Paeonians of the curved bows" (2.848); "the chariot-fighting Paeonians" (ἵπποκορυσταί, 21.205).

Kin: led by Pyraechmes, then by Asteropaeus, son of Pelegon.

Refs: 2.848, 10.428, 16.287, 16.291, 21.205, 21.211. Books 2, 10, 16, 21.

See also: Pyraechmes, Asteropaeus, Axios, Pelegon, Amydon.

Paiëon (Παιήων) · GOD — Say: pay-EE-on

The gods' physician, kept distinct from Apollo. He appears twice, in the same two lines both times: he "sprinkled pain-killing drugs upon the wound / and healed him: for he was not of mortal make" — first of Hades, shot at Pylos by Heracles, and then of Ares, when Zeus has finished telling him he is the most hateful of the gods and orders him healed.

Refs: 5.401, 5.899, 5.900. Book 5.

See also: Ares, Hades, Zeus, Heracles, Apollo.

Pandarus (Πάνδαρος) · MORTAL — Say: PAN-duh-rus

The Lycian archer from Zeleia "to whom Apollo himself gave the bow," and the man whose shot breaks the truce. Athena, in the likeness of Laodocus, persuades him to shoot Menelaus during the sworn oath; the arrow is deflected by Athena herself and only grazes, but the oath is broken and the war resumes. In Book 5 Aeneas

finds him and they charge Diomedes together: his spear-cast fails and Diomedes' answering throw, steered by Athena, goes in beside the nose and cuts his tongue off at the root.

Also called: Lycaon's son — this Lycaon is his father, not Priam's son of the same name; see `canon.md`.

Kin: son of Lycaon.

Killed by: Diomedes (5.290–296).

Refs: 2.827, 4.88, 5.168, 5.171, 5.246, 5.795. Books 2, 4, 5.

See also: Diomedes, Aeneas, Athena, Menelaus, Lycaon, Zeleia.

Panic (Φόβος) · GOD

Rout personified, and one of the attendants of Ares — "Panic, his dear son, strong and fearless, / who sends even the patient-hearted warrior running" (13.299). He is paired with Terror in the pair's first appearance driving the armies on (4.440), is figured with Terror around the Gorgon's head on Agamemnon's shield (11.37), and is ordered with Terror to yoke Ares' horses when Ares means to avenge Ascalaphus (15.119). The same English also renders Φύζα at 9.2, where the Achaeans are held by "unearthly Panic, the companion of icy Rout."

Kin: son of Ares.

Refs: 4.440, 9.2, 11.37, 13.299, 15.119. Books 4, 9, 11, 13, 15.

See also: Terror, Ares, Strife, Ascalaphus.

Panthous (Πάνθοος) · MORTAL — Say: PAN-thoh-us

A Trojan elder, one of the old men sitting with Priam on the wall in Book 3, and in the rest of the poem a patronymic: "Panthous' son" is Polydamas in most places, Euphorbus in Book 17, and Hyperenor at 17.24. Menelaus, having killed Euphorbus, notes that he has now killed three of the line and that Panthous and his wife Phrontis got the arms of none of them; the family is called "the pride of the sons of Panthous with their good ash spears."

Kin: husband of Phrontis; father of Polydamas, Euphorbus and Hyperenor.

Refs: 3.146, 14.450, 16.808, 17.9, 17.23, 17.40, 17.59, 18.250.

Books 3, 13–18.

See also: Polydamas, Euphorbus, Hyperenor, Menelaus, Priam, Phrontis.

Paphlagonians (Παφλαγόνες) · PEOPLE — Say: paf-luh-GOH-nee-unz

Trojan-side allies under Pylaemenes "of the shaggy heart," from the Eneti "where the breed of wild mules is born," holding Cytorus, Sesamus, Cromna, Aegialus and the heights of Erythini around the river Parthenius. In Book 13 they carry the body of Harpalion off the field toward Ilion, his father walking among them in

tears with no blood-price for his son; Paris, who had been the dead man's guest-friend among them, shoots in anger for him.

Kin: led by Pylaemenes.

Refs: 2.851, 13.656, 13.661. Books 2, 13.

See also: Pylaemenes, Harpalion, Paris.

Paris (Πάρις) · MORTAL

Priam's son, whose taking of Helen is the cause of the war and who is the least admired man in the poem. He challenges the Achaean champions in Book 3, loses his nerve when Menelaus comes forward, is shamed back by Hector, and is snatched out of the losing duel by Aphrodite and set down in his scented chamber. He refuses in assembly to give Helen back, offering only the goods (7.362–364). His weapon is the bow: he shoots Diomedes through the foot and laughs, cripples Machaon, kills Euchenor, and hits Nestor's horse — and it is Paris, with Apollo, whom the dying Hector names as Achilles' killer to come. The translation keeps both of his names as the Greek gives them, per the Book 3 policy.

Epithets: "godlike" (θεοειδής, 3.16); "brilliant" (δῖος, 7.355); recurrently "the husband of lovely-haired Helen" (3.329, 11.369). Hector's "Paris — evil Paris" renders Δύσπαρι (3.39).

Also called: Alexandros — one man, both names in use; Priam's son.

Kin: son of Priam and Hecuba; brother of Hector, Helenus, Deiphobus and the rest; husband of Helen.

Refs: 3.16, 3.39, 3.380, 6.321, 6.503, 7.362, 11.369, 22.359 ...and throughout. Books 3–8, 11–13, 15, 22, 24.

See also: Helen, Hector, Menelaus, Aphrodite, Priam, Achilles.

Patroclus (Πάτροκλος) · MORTAL — *Say:* puh-TROH-klus

Achilles' companion, and the hinge of the poem. He is silent through the first half — leading Briseis out of the hut at Achilles' order (1.345), receiving the embassy, sent to Nestor to ask after the wounded Machaon — and it is Nestor's plan that he take Achilles' armor and go out himself that he brings back in tears. Achilles grants it with a limit; Patroclus exceeds it, drives the Trojans from the ships, kills Sarpedon, and charges the wall four times. Apollo strikes him from behind, knocks off helmet and corslet, Euphorbus spears him between the shoulders, and Hector finishes him — his dying words the prophecy of Hector's own death. His body is fought over through Book 17, his ghost comes to Achilles for burial in Book 23, and his bones are to lie in one jar with Achilles'.

Epithets: "Zeus-sprung" (διογενής, 1.337).

Also called: Menoetius' son.

Kin: son of Menoetius of Opoeis, an exile in Peleus' house from boyhood.

Kills: Sarpedon (16.480–491), Pyraechmes, and many others.

Killed by: Hector, with Apollo and Euphorbus (16.783–822).

Refs: 1.337, 11.602, 16.2, 16.49, 16.480, 16.787, 16.822, 23.65 ...and

throughout. Books 1, 8, 9, 11, 15–19, 21–24.

See also: Achilles, Menoetius, Hector, Sarpedon, Euphorbus, Nestor, Opoeis, Automedon.

Pedasmus (Πήδασος) · PLACE — Say: PED-uh-sus

Two towns and, in Book 16, a horse. The Trojan-side Pedasus is "steep Pedasus on the Satnioeis," the town of Altes lord of the Lelegians, Laothoe's father;

Agamemnon kills Elatus there in Book 6, and Aeneas recalls Achilles sacking it with Lyrnessus. A second Pedasus, "Pedasus of the vines," is one of the seven citadels near sandy Pylos that Agamemnon offers Achilles. The horse Pedasus is Achilles' trace-horse, taken when he sacked Eëtion's city, "a horse who, mortal as he was, kept pace with immortal horses"; Sarpedon's cast kills him. A man of the name, twin of Aesepus, is killed by Euryalus at 6.21.

Refs: 6.21, 6.35, 9.152, 9.294, 16.152, 16.467, 20.92, 21.87.

Books 6, 9, 16, 20, 21.

See also: Altes, Laothoe, Satnioeis, Achilles, Xanthus (horse), Sarpedon.

Peirithous (Πειρίθοος) · MORTAL — Say: py-RITH-oh-us

The Lapith king of the back-story, first of the giant men of Nestor's Book 1 reminiscence — "strongest they grew of all men reared on earth" — who fought and destroyed the beast-men of the mountains. Zeus names him in Book 14 among his own sons by mortal women, born of Ixion's wife. He does not come to Troy: in the Catalogue and at the wall the name marks his son Polypoetes, born to him by Hippodameia on the day he drove the shaggy beast-men out of Pelion.

Kin: son of Zeus by Ixion's wife; father of Polypoetes by Hippodameia.

Refs: 1.263, 2.741, 2.742, 12.129, 12.182, 14.318. Books 1, 2, 12, 14.

See also: Polypoetes, Nestor, Lapiths, Zeus, Leonteus.

Peiroos (Πείροος) · MORTAL — Say: PY-roh-os

Leader of the Thracians with Acamas in the Catalogue, son of Imbrasus, come from Aenus. In the closing exchange of Book 4 he kills Diores with a jagged stone that crushes both tendons and the bones of his shin, then runs up and spears him beside the navel; and as he springs back Thoas the Aetolian catches him in the chest above the nipple, wrenches the spear out, and finishes him with the sword. The Thracians save the body; the two dead men are left stretched beside each

other. His son Rhigmus is killed by Achilles at 20.485, where the printed text spells the father "Peiros."

Kin: son of Imbrasmus; father of Rhigmus.

Kills: Diore (4.517–526). *Killed by:* Thoas (4.527–531).

Refs: 2.844, 4.520, 4.525, 4.527. Books 2, 4.

See also: Diore, Thoas, Acamas, Thracians, Rhigmus.

Peisander (Πείσανδρος) · MORTAL — Say: py-SAN-der

Three men. The first is a son of Antimachus — the man who took Paris' gold and argued against giving Helen back — caught with his brother Hippolochus in a bolting chariot; the two beg Agamemnon for ransom, and he kills them both for their father's counsel, spearing Peisander in the chest. The second is a Trojan who comes at Menelaus in Book 13, breaks his spear on the shield, pulls a bronze axe from under it, and is struck at the base of the nose so that his eyeballs drop in the dust at his feet. The third is a Myrmidon captain, Maemalus' son, best of them all with the spear after Patroclus.

Kin: the first is Antimachus' son and Hippolochus' brother; the Myrmidon is Maemalus' son.

Killed by: Agamemnon (11.143–144); the Trojan by Menelaus (13.615–618).

Refs: 11.122, 11.143, 13.601, 13.606, 13.611, 13.614, 16.193.

Books 11, 13, 16.

See also: Antimachus, Hippolochus, Agamemnon, Menelaus, Patroclus.

Pelagians (Πελαγοί) · PEOPLE — Say: puh-LAZ-jee-unz

Trojan-side allies, "the tribes of the Pelagian spearmen" from deep-soiled Larisa, led in the Catalogue by Hippothous and Pylaeus, the two sons of Lethus son of Teutamus; Dolon places them among the allies camped toward the sea. In Book 17 Hippothous is killed dragging Patroclus' body by the foot. The name is also used adjectivally of things not this people: "Pelagian Argos" is Achilles' Thessalian country (2.681), and Achilles prays to "Zeus — lord — Dodonaean — Pelagian" (16.233).

Kin: led by Hippothous and Pylaeus, sons of Lethus.

Refs: 2.681, 2.840, 2.843, 10.429, 16.233, 17.288. Books 2, 10, 16, 17.

See also: Hippothous, Lethus, Larisa, Dodona, Dolon.

Pelegon (Πηλεγών) · MORTAL — Say: PEL-uh-gon

Father of Asteropaeus, and the link between the Paeonian contingent and the river Axios: the river begot him on Periboea, eldest daughter of Acessamenus. He does not appear; Asteropaeus gives the descent himself when Achilles asks who he is,

in the exchange before the duel in the river — "he fathered Pelegon, famed with the spear; and of Pelegon / they say I was born."

Kin: son of the river Axius and Periboea; father of Asteropaeus.

Refs: 21.141, 21.152, 21.159. Book 21.

See also: Asteropaeus, Axius, Paeonians, Achilles, Periboea.

Peleus (Πηλεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* PEE-lee-us

Achilles' father, king of the Myrmidons, and in the great majority of its 146 occurrences a patronymic: "Peleus' son" is Achilles, and the name's work in the poem is to keep saying whose son he is, beginning with the first line. Peleus himself stays in Phthia. He is present as a voice in other men's memories — Odysseus and Phoenix and Nestor all quote his parting charge, "always to be the best, and to hold his head above all others" (11.784) — and as an argument: he took Patroclus in as an exiled boy and raised him; his marriage to Thetis is the gift the gods gave and the wound they left; and Achilles' surrender of Hector's body is won when Priam makes him think of his own father, old and alone with one son doomed out of season.

Epithets: "the old horseman Peleus" (7.125).

Also called: Aeacus' son — the fixed rendering of the bare patronymic for Peleus, as "Aeacus' grandson" is Achilles; see `canon.md`.

Kin: son of Aeacus; husband of Thetis; father of Achilles; foster-father of Patroclus.

Refs: 1.1, 9.252, 9.438, 11.769, 11.783, 16.33, 18.84, 24.534 ...and throughout. Books 1, 2, 7–11, 13, 15–24.

See also: Achilles, Thetis, Aeacus, Patroclus, Phoenix, Phthia, Priam.

Pelion (Πήλιον) · PLACE — *Say:* PEE-lee-on

The Thessalian mountain, home country of the Magnetes and the place from which Peirithous drove the beast-men to the Aethices. Its use in the poem is chiefly adjectival: "the Pelian ash that Chiron gave his dear father / from the peak of Pelion, to be death for heroes" is Achilles' spear, the one weapon Patroclus cannot take because no other Achaean can swing it. Achilles takes it out of its case in Book 19 and carries it against Aeneas, Asteropaeus and Hector.

Refs: 2.744, 2.757, 16.143, 16.144, 19.390, 19.391, 20.277, 21.162, 22.133. Books 2, 16, 19–22.

See also: Achilles, Chiron, Peleus, Peirithous, Peneius, Magnetes.

Peneius (Πηνειός) · PLACE — *Say:* puh-NEE-us

A Thessalian river of the Catalogue, named for the marvel at its confluence: the

Titaessus pours its water into Peneius but does not mingle with his silver eddies, and "flows along on top of him like oil," being a branch broken off the water of Styx, the dread oath. The Magnetes under Prothoos dwell around Peneius and Pelion.

Refs: 2.752, 2.753, 2.757. Book 2.

See also: Titaessus, Styx, Pelion, Prothoos, Magnetes.

Peneleos (Πηνέλεως) · MORTAL — *Say:* puh-NEL-ee-os

One of the five Boeotian leaders of the Catalogue, and a steady presence in the fighting at the ships. His killing of Ilioneus in Book 14 is the poem's most gruesome vaunt: he spears him through the eye-socket and out the nape, hews the head off with the sword, and holds it up on the spear-point "like a poppy-head" to show the Trojans. He kills Lycon in Book 16 with a sword-stroke to the neck that leaves the head hanging by skin, and in Book 17 he is wounded in the shoulder by Polydamas' spear and leads the rout.

Kills: Ilioneus (14.493–500); Lycon (16.339–341).

Refs: 2.494, 13.92, 14.487, 14.489, 14.496, 16.335, 16.339, 17.597.

Books 2, 13, 14, 16, 17.

See also: Boeotians, Leïtus, Ilioneus, Lycon, Polydamas.

Percote (Περκώτη) · PLACE — *Say:* pur-KOH-tee

A town on the Asian side of the Hellespont, on the Trojan side of the war. Merops of Percote, "who beyond all men knew the seer's art," foresaw the deaths of his sons Adrestus and Amphius and could not keep them from the war; the poem repeats his lines verbatim when Diomedes and Odysseus kill the pair at 11.329–332. Asius son of Hyrtacus left his ships there and came the rest of the way to Ilion on foot; Odysseus kills Pidytes of Percote in Book 6; and Melanippus herded cattle there until the Achaean ships came.

Refs: 2.831, 2.835, 6.30, 11.229, 11.329, 15.548. Books 2, 6, 11, 15.

See also: Merops, Adrestus, Amphius, Asius, Melanippus, Hellespont.

Pergamos (Πέργαμος) · PLACE — *Say:* PUR-guh-mos

Troy's citadel, the high ground inside the city, and Apollo's station. He looks down from it to shout the Trojans back into the fight at 4.508, sets the wounded Aeneas down "in holy Pergamos, where his own temple stood" to be healed by Leto and Artemis while a phantom of him fights on below, and sits on its height to send Ares after Diomedes. Paris comes down "from the height of Pergamos, blazing in his armor like the beaming sun" to rejoin Hector at 6.513.

Refs: 4.508, 5.446, 5.460, 6.513, 7.21. Books 4–7.

See also: Troy, Apollo, Aeneas, Paris.

Periphas (Περίφας) · MORTAL — Say: PER-ih-fas

Two men. The first is "gigantic Periphas, far the best of the Aetolians, Ochesius' shining son," killed by Ares in Book 5; Ares is stripping the body when he sees Diomedes coming and leaves it lying where it fell. The second is a Trojan herald, Epytus' son, who had grown grey in his heraldry at his old father's side, "his heart a well of kindly counsel"; Apollo takes his shape to stir Aeneas at 17.324.

Kin: the Aetolian is Ochesius' son; the herald is Epytus' son.

Killed by: the Aetolian by Ares (5.842–848).

Refs: 5.842, 5.847, 17.324. Books 5, 17.

See also: Ares, Diomedes, Aeneas, Apollo.

Peteos (Πετewός) · MORTAL — Say: PEE-tee-os

Father of Menestheus, the Athenian leader, and himself Zeus-nurtured. He does not appear: in every occurrence the name is a patronymic marking his son — in the Catalogue, in Agamemnon's tour of the ranks where Menestheus is rebuked for hanging back, at the wall where "Menestheus, Peteos' son, shuddered to see them" and sent Thootes for help, and in the muster of the Athenians in Book 13.

Kin: father of Menestheus.

Refs: 2.552, 4.327, 4.338, 12.331, 12.355, 13.690. Books 2, 4, 12, 13.

See also: Menestheus, Athenians.

Phaenops (Φαίνoψ) · MORTAL — Say: FEE-nops

The name of more than one Trojan father, and each time the poem uses it to weigh a death. Xanthus and Thoon, "both late-born and beloved," are killed together by Diomedes, leaving their father "worn with hard age" no other son, so that kinsmen of the widowed house divide the estate; Phorcys, Phaenops' son, is killed by Telamonian Ajax over Hippothous' body. A third Phaenops is Asius' son of Abydos, Hector's dearest guest-friend, whose likeness Apollo borrows at 17.583 to shame Hector for flinching from Menelaus.

Kin: father of Xanthus and Thoon (5.152); father of Phorcys (17.312); the guest-friend is Asius' son.

Refs: 5.152, 17.312, 17.583. Books 5, 17.

See also: Xanthus (horse), Phorcys, Asius, Abydos, Apollo, Hector.

Phocians (Φωκewς) · PEOPLE — Say: FOH-shunz

A Catalogue contingent of forty ships from Cyparissus, Pytho, Crisa, Daulis, Panopeus and the towns along the Cephissus, led by Schedius and Epistrophus, sons

of Iphitus; they arm on the left, next to the Boeotians. Both their named casualties are called captains of the Phocians: Schedius son of Perimedes, killed by Hector at the ships, and Schedius son of Iphitus, "far the best of the Phocians," killed by Hector's cast in Book 17.

Kin: led by Schedius and Epistrophus, Iphitus' sons.

Refs: 2.517, 15.516, 17.307. Books 2, 15, 17.

See also: Schedius, Epistrophus, Panopeus, Boeotians, Achaeans.

Phoenix (Φοῖνιξ) · MORTAL — *Say:* FEE-niks

Achilles' old tutor, sent from Phthia by Peleus with the boy to teach him "to be a speaker of words, and a doer of deeds"; he had fled his own father Amyntor's house and been received by Peleus, who made him lord of the Dolopes at the edge of Phthia. Agamemnon names him first of the embassy, and his is its longest and central speech — the story of his own exile, the allegory of the Prayers limping after Blindness, and the tale of Meleager. Achilles refuses the honor but keeps him to sleep in the hut and sail home with him. Later he leads the fourth Myrmidon company, is among those who try to comfort Achilles in Book 19, and serves as umpire at the turn-post in the chariot race. Athena takes his likeness to rouse Menelaus over Patroclus' body (17.555).

Kin: son of Amyntor; foster-father of Achilles; called "his own father's follower," i.e. Peleus' (23.360). The "far-famed Phoenix" whose daughter Zeus loved (14.321) is a different figure, the Phoenician eponym.

Refs: 9.168, 9.432, 9.607, 9.621, 16.196, 17.555, 19.311, 23.360. Books 9, 14, 16, 17, 19, 23.

See also: Achilles, Peleus, Phthia, Meleager, Dolopes, Menelaus.

Phrygia (Φρυγία) · PLACE — *Say:* FRIJ-ee-uh

A land inland from Troy, allied to it and tied to Priam's house. Priam recalls going there as an ally in his youth — "Phrygia of the vines," the hosts of Otreus and Mygdon camped along the Sangarius, on the day the Amazons came — and Hecuba's brother Asius, Dymas' son, lives there on the streams of Sangarius. Paris offers Helen no woman as lovely "in the cities of Phrygia or lovely Maeonia"; Hector says Troy's heirlooms have been sold off to Phrygia and Maeonia; and Achilles counts Phrygia inland among the bounds of Priam's old prosperity.

Refs: 3.184, 3.401, 16.719, 18.291, 24.545. Books 3, 16, 18, 24.

See also: Phrygians, Sangarius, Priam, Hecuba, Maeonia, Amazons.

Phthia (Φθία) · PLACE — *Say:* FTHY-uh or THY-uh

Achilles' homeland in Thessaly, Peleus' kingdom and the Myrmidons' country,

called "deep-soiled Phthia, feeder of men" and "mother of flocks." It is the poem's standing image of the alternative to Troy: Achilles threatens in Book 1 to sail home to it, and in Book 9 sets out the choice plainly — three days' sail and a long life without fame, or death here with imperishable fame. Phoenix and Patroclus were both received there by Peleus, and both the embassy and the funeral looking-back turn on the day the two of them were sent out of Phthia to Agamemnon.

Refs: 1.155, 1.169, 2.683, 9.363, 9.439, 9.479, 11.766, 19.330. Books 1, 2, 9, 11, 16, 19.

See also: Achilles, Peleus, Myrmidons, Hellas, Phoenix, Patroclus, Phthians.

Phthians (Φθῖοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* FTHY-unz or THY-unz

Men of Phthia, named only in the Book 13 muster of the contingents holding Hector off the ships, where they stand beside the Boeotians with the Ionians, Locrians and Epeians. Their leaders there are not Achilles' Myrmidons but Medon — Oïleus' bastard son, exiled to Phylace for killing a kinsman of his stepmother Eriopis — and Podarces son of Iphiclus.

Kin: led at 13.693 by Medon and Podarces.

Refs: 13.686, 13.693, 13.699. Book 13.

See also: Phthia, Medon, Podarces, Boeotians, Myrmidons.

Phyleus (Φυλεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* FY-lyoos

Father of Meges, "the horseman Phyleus dear to Zeus," who had once quarreled with his own father and moved away to Dulichium. He does not come to Troy: the name is almost always a patronymic for Meges, in the Catalogue, in the night muster, in the Epeian ranks at 13.692, and through the fighting at the ships in Book 15, where the corslet Phyleus brought home from Ephyra by the river Selleïs — a guest-gift from Euphetes — turns Dolops' spear and keeps destruction from his son's flesh. A Phyleus is also named among the men Nestor beat with the spear at Amarynceus' funeral games (23.637).

Kin: father of Meges. The poem does not name Phyleus's own father, only that he quarreled with him and left for Dulichium.

Refs: 2.628, 5.72, 10.110, 13.692, 15.519, 15.530, 16.313, 19.239, 23.637.

Books 2, 5, 10, 13, 15, 16, 19, 23.

See also: Meges, Dulichium, Epeians, Dolops, Ephyra, Nestor.

Placus (Πλάκος) · PLACE — *Say:* PLAY-kus

A wooded mountain in the Troad, under which stood Thebe, Eëtion's city. The name comes only in the formula for Andromache's origin — "Eëtion, who lived under

wooded Placus, / in Thebe-under-Placus, lord over the Cilician men" — used at their meeting at the Scaean Gates, again when she names her mother "queen under wooded Placus," and a third time in her lament over Hector, where the two of them are born to one fate, "you in Troy, in the house of Priam, / and I in Thebe, under wooded Placus."

Refs: 6.396, 6.397, 6.425, 22.479. Books 6, 22.

See also: Thebe, Eëtion, Andromache, Cilicians.

Pleiades (Πληϊάδες) · OTHER

A constellation, named once: among the stars Hephaestus works into the Shield of Achilles, with the Hyades, the strength of Orion, and the Bear.

Refs: 18.486. Book 18.

See also: Orion, Hephaestus, Achilles.

Pleuron (Πλευρών) · PLACE — Say: PLOOR-on

An Aetolian city, named with Olenus and Pylene in the Catalogue of Thoas' contingent and twice paired with "steep Calydon" — in Poseidon's disguise as Thoas, who "in all Pleuron and steep Calydon ruled the Aetolians, honored like a god," and in Diomedes' genealogy, where Portheus' three sons Agrius, Melas and Oeneus lived there. Nestor names Ancaeus of Pleuron as the wrestler he beat at Amarynceus' funeral games.

Refs: 2.639, 13.217, 14.116, 23.635. Books 2, 13, 14, 23.

See also: Aetolians, Calydon, Thoas, Oeneus, Ancaeus, Nestor.

Podargus (Πόδαργος) · OTHER — Say: poh-DAR-gus

Two horses of the name, and the poem keeps them apart. The first is one of Hector's four, called by name with Xanthus, Aethon and Lampus when he tells them to pay him back for the honey-hearted wheat Andromache set before them. The second is Menelaus' own trace-horse in the chariot race at Patroclus' funeral, yoked beside Aethe, Agamemnon's mare.

Refs: 8.185, 23.295. Books 8, 23.

See also: Hector, Menelaus, Aethe, Xanthus (horse), Andromache.

Polites (Πολίτης) · MORTAL — Say: poh-LY-teez

A son of Priam, and the Trojan lookout: he sat "on the very top of the tomb of old Aesyetes, watching for when the Achaeans should rush out from their ships," trusting the speed of his feet, and Iris takes his shape to bring Zeus's message to the assembly at Priam's doors. In battle he carries his wounded brother Deiphobus out of the fighting to the chariots and kills Echius at the ships. He is one of the nine sons Priam curses and drives to yoke the wagon in Book 24, where

he is "Polites of the war-cry."

Kin: son of Priam; brother of Deiphobus.

Kills: Echius (15.339).

Refs: 2.791, 13.533, 15.339, 24.250. Books 2, 13, 15, 24.

See also: Priam, Deiphobus, Iris, Aesyetes.

Polydamas (Πουλυδάμας) · MORTAL — *Say:* pol-ih-DAY-mas or puh-LID-uh-mas
Panthous' son, Hector's companion, born in the same night with him: "one was far the better in words, the other with the spear." He is the poem's counter-voice on the Trojan side, and Hector takes his advice three times and refuses it twice, the refusals being the ones that matter. He reads the eagle-and-snake omen at the ditch and urges the Trojans not to press on to the ships, and Hector answers with "One bird-sign is best: to fight for your fatherland" and a threat to kill him. He urges retreat inside the walls the night Achilles reappears, and Hector's refusal — praised by the Trojans, "the fools: for Pallas Athena had taken their wits from them" — is what Hector remembers alone before the gates: "Polydamas will be the first to lay reproach on me." He fights as well as he counsels, killing Prothoenor and Otus and vaunting over the body.

Also called: Panthous' son.

Kin: son of Panthous; brother, in the family the poem names, of Euphorbus and Hyperenor.

Kills: Prothoenor (14.450); Mecisteus (15.339); Otus of Cyllene (15.518).

Refs: 12.60, 12.210, 12.231, 13.756, 14.450, 15.518, 18.249, 18.313, 22.100
...and throughout. Books 11–18, 22.

See also: Hector, Panthous, Euphorbus, Prothoenor, Ajax, Meges.

Polydorus (Πολύδωρος) · MORTAL — *Say:* pol-ih-DOR-us
Priam's youngest and dearest son, by Laothoe daughter of Altes, forbidden by his father to fight; "in his boy's folly, showing off the speed of his feet" he darts through the front-fighters and Achilles' javelin takes him in the back, so that he sinks clutching his bowels. It is the sight of his brother dying that brings Hector out of the crowd against Achilles. Lycaon names him as the brother already killed while pleading for his own life at 21.91, and Priam names the two of them together at 22.46 as the sons of Laothoe he cannot see among the Trojans. A different Polydorus is one of the men Nestor out-threw with the spear at Amarynceus' funeral games (23.637); the poem keeps them separate.

Kin: son of Priam and Laothoe; brother of Lycaon.

Killed by: Achilles (20.407–418).

POLYIDUS – POSEIDON

Refs: 20.407, 20.419, 21.91, 22.46, 23.637. Books 20–23.

See also: Priam, Laothoe, Lycaon, Altes, Achilles, Hector, Nestor.

Polyidus (Πολύιδος) · MORTAL — *Say:* pol-ih-EYE-dus

Two men. The first is a Trojan, son of Eurydamas "the old reader of dreams," killed with his brother Abas by Diomedes in Book 5 — and the poem's point is that "the old man read no dreams for them at their going." The second is a seer of Corinth, father of Euchenor, who told his son often that he would either waste to death of a sickness at home or fall under Trojan hands at the ships; Euchenor sailed knowing his fate, and Paris' arrow found him under the ear.

Kin: the Trojan is Eurydamas' son and Abas' brother; the Corinthian is Euchenor's father.

Killed by: the Trojan Polyidus by Diomedes (5.148–151).

Refs: 5.148, 13.663, 13.666. Books 5, 13.

See also: Eurydamas, Abas, Euchenor, Diomedes, Paris.

Polypoetes (Πολυποίτης) · MORTAL — *Say:* pol-ih-PEE-teez

A Lapith leader, son of Peirithous and Hippodameia, born on the day his father drove the shaggy beast-men out of Pelion; he brings forty ships from Argissa and Gyrtone with Leonteus, and the two are inseparable in the poem. They hold the gate against Asius "like high-crowned oaks in the mountains that abide the wind and rain through all their days," and Polypoetes kills Damasus through the bronze-cheeked helmet, then Pylon and Ormenus. In Book 23 he throws the lump of iron past the whole field — Epeius, Leonteus and Telamonian Ajax — and his companions carry the prize away.

Epithets: "steadfast in battle" (μενεπτόλεμος, 2.740).

Kin: son of Peirithous and Hippodameia; grandson of Zeus by Peirithous.

Kills: Astyalus (6.29); Damasus, Pylon, Ormenus (12.182–187).

Refs: 2.740, 6.29, 12.129, 12.182, 23.836, 23.844, 23.848. Books 2, 6, 12, 23.

See also: Leonteus, Peirithous, Lapiths, Asius, Epeius, Ajax.

Poseidon (Ποσειδάων) · GOD — *Say:* poh-SY-dun

Zeus's brother, lord of the sea and the Achaeans' most active divine partisan. He and Apollo built Laomedon's wall and were cheated of their wage, which he still holds against Troy in Book 21, when he offers Apollo the first blow and is refused. His great sequence is Books 13–15: he watches from the peak of Thracian Samos, comes down in three strides, and works behind Zeus's back — rallying the Argives as Calchas, leading them with a sword "like a lightning-flash," then stretching

PRIAM – PROETUS

the strife taut against Hector — until Zeus sends Iris to order him off and he yields, protesting that the three brothers drew sky, sea and underworld by lot and he is Zeus's equal in honor. He resents the Achaean wall for outshining his own work and unbuilds it after the war; he saves Aeneas from Achilles because the race of Dardanus must not perish; and he alone with Hera and Athena holds to his hatred of Ilion to the end.

Epithets: "the earth-shaker" (ἐνοσίχθων / ἐννοσίγαιος, 7.445); "wide-ruling" (εὐρυσθενής, 7.455); "the holder of the earth" (γαιήοχος, 9.183); "blue-maned" (κυανοχαίτης, 13.563).

Kin: son of Cronos and Rhea; brother of Zeus and Hades.

Refs: 7.445, 12.17, 13.19, 13.43, 14.384, 15.158, 15.205, 20.291, 21.435, 24.26 ...and throughout. Books 1, 2, 7, 8, 11–15, 20, 21, 23, 24.

See also: Zeus, Hades, Apollo, Laomedon, Aeneas, Samos, Achaeans.

Priam (Πρίαμος) · MORTAL — *Say:* PRY-am

King of Troy, old and past fighting, whose name the poem uses as much for the city and the doom as for the man — "Priam's city," "Priam and the people of Priam of the good ash spear." He appears rarely in battle books and decisively at the frame: on the tower in Book 3, calling Helen to him and refusing to blame her, and driving out through the Scaean Gates to swear the oaths for the duel, then leaving because he cannot watch his son fight; in Book 22 on the wall, tearing his hair and begging Hector to come inside, arguing that Achilles too has a father. That argument he carries into the Achaean camp in Book 24, going alone by night with Hermes for guide, kissing "the terrible, man-slaughtering hands that had killed so many of his sons," and winning Hector's body back. He tells Achilles he had fifty sons when the Achaeans came, and not one is left him.

Epithets: "of the good ash spear" (ἐϋμμελίω, 4.47); "the equal of the gods in counsel" (θεόφιν μῆστωρ ἀτάλαντος, 7.366).

Also called: Dardanus' descendant (Δαρδανίδης, 3.303).

Kin: son of Laomedon; husband of Hecuba, daughter of Dymas, and of many wives including Laothoe; father of Hector, Paris, Helenus, Deiphobus, Polydorus, Lycaon, Polites and the rest, and of Laodice and Cassandra.

Refs: 1.19, 2.37, 3.105, 3.303, 4.47, 6.242, 7.366, 22.25, 24.160, 24.477 ...and throughout. Books 1–9, 11–24.

See also: Hector, Hecuba, Laomedon, Troy, Achilles, Hermes, Dardanus.

Proetus (Προῖτος) · MORTAL — *Say:* PREE-tus

A king of the Argives in Glaucus' back-story, who drove Bellerophon out of the

land. His wife Anteia was mad to lie with Bellerophon and, refused, lied to her husband that he had forced her; Proetus shrank from killing him — "his heart stood in awe of that" — but sent him to Lycia with the folded tablet of "many life-destroying marks" for the king there to read, meaning his death. The poem's one instance of writing.

Kin: husband of Anteia; son-in-law of the lord of Lycia.

Refs: 6.157, 6.160, 6.163, 6.164, 6.177. Book 6.

See also: Bellerophon, Anteia, Glaucus, Lycia.

Promachus (Πρόμαχος) · MORTAL — Say: PROM-uh-kus

A Boeotian, Alegenor's son, killed by Acamas in Book 14 as he was hauling Archelochus' body away by the feet. Acamas vaunts over him — "Look how your Promachus sleeps, beaten down by my spear" — as blood-price for his brother, and the vaunt is what rouses Peneleos, whose killing of Ilioneus answers it in kind.

Kin: son of Alegenor.

Killed by: Acamas (14.476–477).

Refs: 14.477, 14.482, 14.503. Book 14.

See also: Acamas, Archelochus, Peneleos, Ilioneus, Boeotians.

Protesilaus (Πρωτεσίλαος) · MORTAL — Say: proh-tes-ih-LAY-us

Leader of the contingent from Phylace, and the first Achaean to die: "a Dardanian man had killed him as he leapt from his ship, far the first of the Achaeans." He is already dead when the Catalogue reaches him — "by then the black earth held him under" — leaving a wife with torn cheeks in Phylace and a half-built house, and his brother Podarces, the younger and lesser man, leads his forty ships. His ship becomes the poem's landmark for the crisis at the camp: Hector breaks through where the ships of Ajax and Protesilaus are drawn up, lays his hand on its stern at 15.705, and Patroclus' first cast in Book 16 is thrown into the press around it.

Kin: son of Iphiclus, Phylacus' line; brother of Podarces.

Refs: 2.698, 2.706, 2.708, 13.681, 15.705, 16.287. Books 2, 13, 15, 16.

See also: Podarces, Phylace, Hector, Patroclus, Phthians.

Prothoenor (Προθοήνωρ) · MORTAL — Say: proh-thoh-EE-nor

One of the five Boeotian leaders of the Catalogue and, in Book 14, Polydamas' victim: the spear takes him in the right shoulder and he falls clutching the earth in his palm. Polydamas' vaunt over him — that the man will lean on the spear for a staff walking down into Hades — stirs Telamonian Ajax, who casts back, misses Polydamas, and kills Archelochus instead, then asks across the field whether that

man is "a worthy exchange for Prothoenor dead."

Kin: son of Areilycus.

Killed by: Polydamas (14.450–452).

Refs: 2.495, 14.450, 14.471. Books 2, 14.

See also: Polydamas, Ajax, Archelochus, Boeotians.

Pylaemenes (Πυλαϊμένης) · MORTAL — *Say:* py-LEM-uh-neeZ

Leader of the Paphlagonians from the Eneti, "of the shaggy heart," called "captain of the great-hearted Paphlagonian shieldmen." Menelaus spears him through the collarbone as he stands, while Antilochus kills his driver Mydon in the same exchange. His son Harpalion is killed by Meriones in Book 13, and the poem there calls him "the son of king Pylaemenes" — the father, killed in Book 5, is present again as a name.

Kin: father of Harpalion.

Killed by: Menelaus (5.576–579).

Refs: 2.851, 5.576, 13.643. Books 2, 5, 13.

See also: Paphlagonians, Menelaus, Antilochus, Harpalion, Mydon.

Pyliaus (Πύλαιοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* PY-lee-unZ

Nestor's people, whose land the Alpheius "flows wide through." They are named mostly inside Nestor's own reminiscences — the fight with the Arcadians by the Celadon, and the long Book 11 tale of the cattle-raid on Elis, the division of the spoil at Pylos, and the battle with the Epeians in which Zeus "handed great power to the Pyliaus." In the present action they are the contingent Antilochus leaves when he runs to Achilles with the news of Patroclus' death, and "great longing was built for the Pyliaus" until Menelaus sends them Thrasymedes.

Refs: 5.545, 7.134, 11.687, 11.737, 11.753, 17.704, 23.633. Books 5, 7, 11, 17, 23.

See also: Nestor, Pylos, Antilochus, Thrasymedes, Epeians, Alpheius.

Pylos (Πύλος) · PLACE — *Say:* PY-los

Nestor's kingdom, "sandy Pylos," Neleus' before him; the Catalogue gives him ninety ships from Pylos, Arene and the towns along the Alpheius. Nestor was already king "among the third" generation there when he came to Troy, and the place belongs mostly to his memories: the cattle driven at night into Neleian Pylos, the debts divided among the leading men, the return from Buprasion. Agamemnon offers seven citadels "on the edge of sandy Pylos" among the gifts for Achilles. Dione names it as where Heracles shot Hades among the dead.

Refs: 1.252, 2.77, 2.591, 5.397, 9.153, 11.682, 11.712, 23.303. Books 1, 2,

4, 5, 9, 11, 23.

See also: Nestor, Neleus, Pylians, Alpheius, Heracles.

Rhesus (Ῥῆσος) · MORTAL — *Say:* REE-sus

Thracian king, son of Eioneus, whose men are "new-come, outermost of all" — they stand outside the Catalogue. Dolon, questioned under the knife, gives him up: his horses are the finest and biggest Dolon has ever seen, "whiter than snow, and like the winds in running," and his armor is golden, fit for gods and not for mortal men. Diomedes kills him in his sleep, thirteenth of the Thracians, while Odysseus leads the horses out; Apollo wakes his kinsman Hippocoon, who finds the place empty and the men gasping. A river of Ida also bears the name (12.20).

Kin: son of Eioneus; kinsman of Hippocoon.

Killed by: Diomedes (10.474–497).

Refs: 10.435, 10.474, 10.519, 12.20. Books 10, 12.

See also: Dolon, Diomedes, Odysseus, Thracians, Hippocoon.

Rhodes (Ῥόδος) · PLACE

Tlepolemus' island, sending nine ships of "the lordly Rhodians," who "dwelt through Rhodes in three divisions: Lindus, Ialysus, and chalk-white Cameirus." He came there as an exile and a wanderer after killing Licymnius, his father Heracles' aged uncle, and the settlers were loved by Zeus, who "poured wondrous wealth upon them."

Refs: 2.654, 2.655, 2.667. Book 2.

See also: Tlepolemus, Rhodians, Heracles, Licymnius.

Samos (Σάμος) · PLACE — *Say:* SAY-mos

Two islands of the name, and the poem distinguishes them. The Samos of Odysseus' Catalogue entry (2.634) lies among Ithaca, Zacynthus and the facing mainland. The other is "wooded Samos, Thracian Samos" — Samothrace — from whose topmost peak Poseidon watches the fighting, because from there "all Ida showed clear, and Priam's city showed clear, and the ships of the Achaeans"; Iris plunges into the sea between Samos and rugged Imbros, and Priam names Samos with Imbros and Lemnos as the islands Achilles sold his sons into.

Refs: 2.634, 13.12, 13.13, 24.78, 24.753. Books 2, 13, 24.

See also: Poseidon, Imbros, Lemnos, Ithaca, Odysseus.

Sarpedon (Σαρπηδών) · MORTAL — *Say:* sar-PEE-don

King of the Lycians, son of Zeus by Laodameia, Bellerophon's daughter — the only child of Zeus fighting at Troy whom the poem lets die. He comes "from far Lycia, from the eddying Xanthus" with Glaucus, rebukes Hector for leaving the fighting to

the allies, survives Tlepolemus' spear through the thigh in Book 5, and is the first man over the Achaean wall, tearing the breastwork away with his hands "and he had made a road for many." His speech to Glaucus before that assault — why kings are honored with the seat of honor and the fat land, and why, since death stands over them in thousands, they must go — is the poem's clearest statement of the warrior's bargain. Patroclus kills him with a spear through the midriff and he falls like a felled oak; Zeus, who has weighed snatching him out alive and been argued down by Hera, rains blood on the earth for him, then has Apollo wash the body and give it to Sleep and Death to carry to Lycia. The fight over his stripped corpse fills the rest of Book 16, and his armor is the prize Achilles sets for the duel in the funeral games.

Epithets: "of the bronze helmet" (χαλκοκορυστής, 6.199).

Kin: son of Zeus and Laodameia; grandson of Bellerophon; cousin and companion of Glaucus.

Kills: Tlepolemus (5.655–659); Alcmaon, Thestor's son (12.394). In the duel his own casts miss Patroclus twice; the second kills the trace-horse Pedasus (16.466).

Killed by: Patroclus (16.480–505).

Refs: 2.876, 5.633, 5.657, 6.199, 12.292, 12.397, 16.419, 16.480, 16.667, 23.800 ...and throughout. Books 2, 5, 6, 12, 14–17, 23.

See also: Glaucus, Lycians, Zeus, Patroclus, Tlepolemus, Bellerophon, Hector.

Satnioeis (Σατνιόεις) · PLACE — Say: sat-nee-OH-is

A river of the Troad, always named for the men who lived on it: Elatus, killed by Agamemnon, "who lived by the banks of fair-flowing Satnioeis in steep Pedasus"; Satnius, son of Enops by a nymph who bore him "as he herded by the banks of Satnioeis," killed by Ajax son of Oïleus; and Pedasus, the town Altes holds "on the Satnioeis," home of Laothoe, mother of Lycaon and Polydorus.

Refs: 6.34, 14.445, 21.87. Books 6, 14, 21.

See also: Pedasus, Elatus, Satnius, Altes, Laothoe.

Scaean (Σκαίαί) · PLACE — Say: SEE-un

The Scaean Gates, Troy's main gate onto the plain, and with the oak beside them the fixed landmark of the poem's approaches to the city. The elders sit there watching Helen come up onto the tower; Priam drives out through them to swear the oaths; Hector meets Andromache there on his way out and it is where Theano's prayer asks Athena to bring Diomedes down; Achilles' chase brings Hector back to them, "in front of Ilion and the Scaean Gates," and the dying Hector names them as the place where Paris and Apollo will destroy Achilles.

Also called: the Scaean Gates.

Refs: 3.145, 3.149, 3.263, 6.237, 6.307, 6.393, 9.354, 11.170, 16.712, 18.453, 22.6, 22.360. Books 3, 6, 9, 11, 16, 18, 22.

See also: Troy, Hector, Andromache, Priam, Achilles.

Scamander (Σκάμανδρος) · PLACE — Say: skuh-MAN-dur

Troy's chief river and the god who runs in it, "whom the gods call Xanthus, and men Scamander" — the poem states the double name outright at 20.74. It is the plain's standing feature: Ares set down on its high bank, the burial-ground of the Achaean dead, the ford Priam and Hermes cross, the twin springs where the Trojan women used to wash and past which Achilles chases Hector. In Book 21 the river becomes a combatant: choked with corpses, he asks Achilles to do his killing on the plain, then crests over him, calls his brother Simois to help drown him, and is beaten only when Hera sends Hephaestus' fire against the water. He is one of the eight Idaean rivers Apollo and Poseidon turn against the Achaean wall (12.21). *Also called:* Xanthus — the gods' name for it (20.74). NB: "Xanthus" also names one of Achilles' immortal horses, a Trojan killed by Diomedes (5.152), and a separate river of Lycia (2.877, 6.172, 12.313).

Kin: "eddying Xanthus, whom immortal Zeus begot" (21.2).

Refs: 5.36, 5.78, 7.330, 11.499, 12.21, 20.74, 21.15, 21.223, 21.305, 22.148 ...and throughout. Books 5–8, 11–12, 14, 20–22, 24.

See also: Simois, Achilles, Hephaestus, Hera, Xanthus (horse), Troy.

Schedius (Σχεδῖος) · MORTAL — Say: SKEE-dee-us

Two Phocian leaders of the name, both killed by Hector. The first is Iphitus' son, Naubolus' grandson, who with his brother Epistrophus leads forty Phocian ships in the Catalogue; he is "far the best of the Phocians," king over many men in famed Panopeus, and Hector's cast — dodged by Ajax — takes him under the collarbone and comes out at the base of the shoulder. The second is Schedius son of Perimedes, "a captain of the Phocians," cut down by Hector at the ships in Book 15.

Kin: the Catalogue leader is son of Iphitus; the other is son of Perimedes.

Killed by: both by Hector (15.515; 17.306–311).

Refs: 2.517, 15.515, 17.306. Books 2, 15, 17.

See also: Phocians, Epistrophus, Panopeus, Hector, Ajax.

Seasons (῾Ωραι) · GOD

The ῾Ωραι, keepers of the gates of heaven, "to whom great heaven and Olympus are entrusted, to roll the thick cloud aside, or set it back." They appear only in the formula for Hera's chariot passing out and back: the gates groan open self-moved

as she and Athena drive through (5.749 = 8.393), and when the ride is called off they unyoke the lovely-maned horses, tether them at the ambrosial mangers and lean the chariot against the shining wall.

Refs: 5.749, 8.393, 8.433. Books 5, 8.

See also: Hera, Athena, Olympus, Zeus.

Selleïs (Σελλήεις) · PLACE — Say: sel-EE-is

A river named only in contingent back-stories, always in the same phrase, "from the river Selleïs." Heracles brought Astyocheia, Tlepolemus' mother, out of Ephyra by it; Asius' tall fire-colored horses come from it, in a line the poem repeats verbatim when he storms the wall (2.839 = 12.97); and Phyleus brought home from it the corslet that saves Meges in Book 15.

Refs: 2.659, 2.839, 12.97, 15.531. Books 2, 12, 15.

See also: Ephyra, Tlepolemus, Asius, Arisbe, Meges.

Simoeisios (Σιμοείσιος) · MORTAL — Say: sim-oh-EE-see-os

A young Trojan killed by Telamonian Ajax in the first general engagement, born by the banks of the Simois while his mother was coming down from Ida with her parents to see the flocks, and named for the river. He never paid back to his parents the cost of his rearing; Ajax's spear takes him in the chest by the right nipple and he falls like a black poplar felled by a chariot-maker to bend a wheel-rim, left lying to season along the river bank.

Kin: son of Anthemion.

Killed by: Ajax (4.473–489).

Refs: 4.474, 4.477, 4.488. Book 4.

See also: Ajax, Simois, Telamon.

Simois (Σιμόεις) · PLACE — Say: SIM-oh-is

The second of Troy's two rivers, running with the Scamander across the plain: the armies fight "midway between the streams of Simois and Xanthus," and Hera halts her horses where the two join, whereupon Simois makes ambrosia spring up for them to graze. It is one of the eight Idaean rivers Apollo turns against the Achaeans wall — named there for the shields and helmets and "the race of half-god men" fallen in its dust — and in Book 21 Scamander calls to it as "dear brother" for help against Achilles. Spelled *Simois* at 20.53 and 21.307.

Refs: 4.475, 5.774, 5.777, 6.4, 12.22. Books 4–6, 12.

See also: Scamander, Simoeisios, Ida, Troy.

Sleep (Ύπνος) · GOD

"Sleep, the brother of Death," personified, and Hera's accomplice in the Deception

of Zeus. He refuses her at first — a previous commission of hers, laying Zeus's mind asleep so she could drive Heracles to Cos, nearly got him flung out of heaven, and only Night saved him — and yields only when she swears by the water of Styx to give him Pasithea, one of the younger Graces, whom he has longed for all his days. He perches in a fir on Ida in the likeness of the bird "the gods call chalkis, and men call kymindis," then runs to tell Poseidon that Zeus is out. In Book 16 he and Death are "the twin brothers" who carry Sarpedon's body home to Lycia.

Kin: brother of Death; son of Night in effect, who shelters him (14.259).

Refs: 14.231, 14.233, 14.242, 14.264, 14.270, 14.286, 14.354, 16.454, 16.672, 16.682. Books 14, 16.

See also: Death, Hera, Zeus, Pasithea, Night, Sarpedon, Poseidon.

Socus (Σῶκος) · MORTAL — *Say:* SOH-kus

A wealthy Trojan, brother of Charops, who comes to his brother's rescue when Odysseus is cutting through Hippasus' sons and drives a spear through Odysseus' shield and corslet, tearing the flesh from his ribs — Athena keeps the point from his vitals. Odysseus, knowing the wound is not mortal, tells him destruction has caught him, and spears him between the shoulders as he turns to run. The wound Socus deals is what brings the Trojans down on Odysseus alone in the crowd.

Kin: son of Hippasus; brother of Charops.

Killed by: Odysseus (11.446–449).

Refs: 11.427, 11.428, 11.440, 11.446, 11.450, 11.456. Book 11.

See also: Odysseus, Charops, Hippasus, Athena.

Sparta (Σπάρτη) · PLACE

Menelaus' city in the Peloponnese, named in the Catalogue among the towns of his contingent and again by Hera, who names Argos, Sparta and wide-wayed Mycenae as the three cities dearest to her and offers all three for Troy's destruction (4.52–53). The poem more often calls the country **Lacedaemon** — "hollow Lacedaemon full of ravines" heads the same catalogue entry — and it is from Lacedaemon that Paris carried Helen off, and there that she left the daughter and the household she keeps naming in Book 3.

Also called: Lacedaemon, the district in which the Catalogue places it (2.581).

Refs: 2.581, 2.582, 3.239, 3.244, 3.388, 3.443, 4.52. Books 2–4.

See also: Menelaus, Helen, Argos, Mycenae, Hera.

Spercheius (Σπερχειός) · PLACE — *Say:* spur-KY-us

The river of Phthia, "the sky-fed river," to whom Peleus vowed that Achilles would cut his hair and sacrifice fifty rams at its sources if he came home. He does not

come home: standing apart from the pyre, Achilles cuts the tawny lock he had been growing for the river and puts it in Patroclus' hands instead, telling Spercheius plainly that his father's vow was made for nothing. The river also fathered Menesthius, a Myrmidon company-leader, on Peleus' daughter Polydora.

Kin: father of Menesthius by Polydora.

Refs: 16.174, 16.176, 23.142, 23.144. Books 16, 23.

See also: Achilles, Peleus, Patroclus, Menesthius, Polydora, Phthia.

Sthenelus (Σθένηςλος) · MORTAL — Say: STHEN-uh-lus

Diomedes' charioteer and companion, one of the Epigoni whose fathers fell at Thebes. He pulls Pandarus' arrow from Diomedes' shoulder in Book 5, spots Aeneas and Pandarus coming and urges retreat, and drives off the horses of Tros; Athena shoves him bodily off the chariot to take the reins herself. He answers Agamemnon's shaming of the fathers by claiming the sons took seven-gated Thebes where the fathers failed — the speech Diomedes silently declines to endorse. In Book 9 Diomedes vows that he and Sthenelus alone will fight on to the end of Ilion. **A second Sthenelus**, son of Perseus and father of Eurystheus, belongs to the Heracles back-story of Book 19 and is a different man.

Also called: Capaneus' son.

Kin: son of Capaneus.

Refs: 2.564, 4.367, 5.108, 5.111, 5.241, 5.835, 8.114, 9.48, 19.116, 19.123, 23.510. Books 2, 4–5, 8–9, 19, 23.

See also: Diomedes, Capaneus, Thebes, Athena, Eurystheus, Perseus.

Stichius (Στιχίος) · MORTAL — Say: STIK-ee-us

An Achaean captain, named three times and killed by Hector in the rout of Book 15. The poem describes him inconsistently: at 13.195 and 13.691 he is one of the Athenian captains under Menestheus, helping carry the dead back among the host, but at 15.330, in the couplet on his death, he is "a leader of the bronze-shirted Boeotians." The text does not reconcile the two.

Killed by: Hector (15.329–330).

Refs: 13.195, 13.691, 15.329. Books 13, 15.

See also: Menestheus, Athenians, Boeotians, Hector, Arcesilaus.

Strife (Ἔρις) · GOD

Discord personified and capitalized, one of the battle-abstractions who take the field with Ares. She stands with Terror and Panic in the muster of Book 4, works beside "Ares bane of mortals" over the corpses, and is blazoned on Athena's aegis with Valor and blood-chilling Pursuit. Zeus sends her down to the ships at the

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opening of Book 11 to raise the war-cry; "Strife of the many groans" then rejoices alone among the gods to see the armies close. Hephaestus sets her on the shield with Tumult and deadly Fate, and at the theomachy "strong Strife, driver of armies" rises against Athena's shout.

Epithets: the fixed capitalization of the personified Δεῖμος / Φόβος / Ἔρις group is set at 4.440; the poem also calls her "insatiably raging" (4.440) and "of the many groans" (11.73).

Refs: 4.440, 5.518, 5.740, 11.3, 11.73, 18.535, 20.48. Books 4–5, 11, 18, 20.

See also: Terror, Panic, Ares, Athena, Tumult, Fate.

Sun (Ἡέλιος) · GOD

Helios, invoked in the oath-scenes as the god "who see all things and hear all things": one of the two lambs of the truce is for Earth and Sun, and he is called to witness both Agamemnon's oath over the sworn oaths in Book 3 and his oath about Briseis in Book 19, with Earth and the Erinyes. He also marks the poem's time — "when the Sun bestrode the middle of heaven" Zeus lifts his scales — and is once made to act: Hera sends "the unwearied Sun, much against his will, into the streams of Ocean" to end the day Achilles rearms, fulfilling the sunset clause of Zeus's plan. Called "Hyperion the Sun" at 8.480 and 19.398, and named Helios once (14.344).

Refs: 3.104, 3.277, 8.68, 8.480, 18.239, 18.241, 19.197, 19.259. Books 3, 8, 18, 19.

See also: Zeus, Hera, Earth, Ocean, Hyperion, Erinyes.

Talthybius (Ταλθύβιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* tal-THIB-ee-us

Agamemnon's herald, "the godlike herald," and the man sent to do what his king does not do himself. With Eurybates he goes unwillingly to Achilles' hut to take Briseis in Book 1; he fetches the lamb for the truce-sacrifice in Book 3, and calls Machaon to the wounded Menelaus in Book 4; with Idaeus of Troy he parts Ajax and Hector when night falls on their duel. In Book 19 he holds the boar for Agamemnon's oath and throws the carcass into the sea. The poem closes his arc at 23.897, where Agamemnon's prize is handed to Talthybius to carry — the mirror of 1.320.

Refs: 1.320, 3.118, 4.192, 4.193, 7.276, 19.196, 19.250, 19.267, 23.897.

Books 1, 3–4, 7, 19, 23.

See also: Agamemnon, Eurybates, Idaeus, Briseis, Machaon.

Tartarus (Τάρταρος) · PLACE — *Say:* TAR-tuh-rus

The pit below Hades — "where the deepest pit yawns under the earth, / where the gates are iron and the threshold bronze, / as far beneath Hades as heaven is above

the earth." It is Zeus's standing threat at the opening of Book 8 against any god who helps either side, and the measure of how far he is strongest. Iapetus and Cronos sit at the world's limit with "deep Tartarus all around them," and Hera swears her oath to Sleep by the gods beneath it, "who are called the Titans."

Refs: 8.13, 8.481, 14.279. Books 8, 14.

See also: Zeus, Hades, Cronos, Iapetus, Sleep, Hera.

Telamon (Τελαμών) · MORTAL — Say: TEL-uh-mon

Father of Ajax the greater and, by another woman, of Teucer; a king of Salamis in the older generation who does not come to Troy. In nearly all of its occurrences the name is a patronymic — "Telamonian Ajax," "Ajax, Zeus-sprung son of Telamon, marshal of the people" — and the referent is Ajax, per `canon.md`. He appears in his own right only at 8.283, where Agamemnon urges Teucer to keep shooting and be a light "to your father Telamon, who reared you when you were little / and cared for you in his own house, bastard though you were."

Also called: the source of the adjective Telamonian.

Kin: father of Ajax and of Teucer, who are brothers "by one father" (12.371).

Refs: 2.528, 2.768, 6.5, 7.234, 8.281, 8.283, 9.644, 12.371, 13.170, 17.284

...and throughout. Books 2, 4–9, 11–18, 23.

See also: Ajax, Teucer, Salamis, Ajax son of Oileus.

Terror (Δεῖμος) · GOD

One of the battle-abstractions personified and capitalized with Panic and Strife (4.440). He and Panic attend Athena as she arms, "glaring terribly, and around her Terror and Panic," and Ares orders the pair to yoke his horses when he means to break Zeus's ban and avenge Ascalaphus. He never acts alone.

Refs: 4.440, 11.37, 15.119. Books 4, 11, 15.

See also: Panic, Strife, Ares, Athena.

Tethys (Τηθύς) · GOD — Say: TEE-this

"Mother Tethys," Ocean's consort, named twice in the Deception of Zeus and only there, in the lie Hera tells first to Aphrodite and then verbatim to Zeus: that she is going to the ends of the earth to see "Oceanus, the begetting of the gods, and mother Tethys," who reared her in their halls when Rhea gave her up as Zeus put Cronos down, and to settle their long quarrel. The pair are the poem's nearest thing to a cosmogony.

Kin: consort of Ocean; foster-mother of Hera.

Refs: 14.201, 14.302. Book 14.

See also: Ocean, Hera, Rhea, Cronos, Zeus.

Teucer (Τεῦκρος) · MORTAL — Say: TYOO-sur

Telamon's bastard son and Ajax's half-brother, "his brother by one father," and the best archer in the Achaean host — Idomeneus calls him "best of the Achaeans / in bowmanship, and good too in the standing fight." His method is fixed in Book 8: he shoots from under Ajax's shield and slips back behind it "like a child to his mother," and the poem gives him a roll-call of eight victims before Hector breaks his collarbone with a stone and snaps his bowstring. In Book 15 he has Hector lined up when Zeus himself breaks the fresh-twisted string, and Teucer, shuddering, gives the bow up for spear and shield. He hits Glaucus on the wall (12.387) and loses the archery contest at the funeral games by forgetting to vow to Apollo.
Kin: son of Telamon; half-brother of Ajax.

Refs: 6.31, 8.266, 8.273, 8.322, 12.371, 12.387, 13.313, 15.458, 15.462, 23.862. Books 6, 8, 12–16, 23.

See also: Ajax, Telamon, Hector, Glaucus, Meriones, Apollo.

Theano (Θεανώ) · MORTAL — Say: thee-AN-oh

Antenor's wife, made priestess of Athena by the Trojans, and the woman who performs the poem's one Trojan supplication of a goddess: she opens the temple doors on the city's height, takes the robe Hecuba has brought and lays it on Athena's knees, and vows twelve unbroken yearling heifers if the goddess will break Diomedes' spear and drop him before the Scaean Gates — "So she spoke, vowing. But Pallas Athena turned her head away." She had also reared Antenor's bastard son Pedaeus with her own children, to please her husband.

Epithets: "fair-cheeked" (καλλιπάρης, 6.298).

Kin: daughter of Cisseus (6.299; called Cisses at 11.223); wife of Antenor; foster-mother of Pedaeus; aunt of Iphidamas.

Refs: 5.70, 6.298, 6.302, 11.224. Books 5–6, 11.

See also: Antenor, Athena, Hecuba, Pedaeus, Iphidamas, Diomedes.

Thebe (Θήβη) · PLACE — Say: THEE-bee

Eëtion's city under wooded Placus, "Thebe of the high gates," seat of the Cilician men, sacked by Achilles before the poem opens. It is where Chryseis was taken — the sack that begins the plague-chain — and where Achilles killed Eëtion without stripping him, burning him in his armor and heaping a mound that the mountain nymphs planted round with elms. Andromache was born there and names it in both her laments. Not the Boeotian Thebes: see **Thebes**.

Refs: 1.366, 2.691, 6.397, 6.416, 22.479. Books 1–2, 6, 22.

See also: Eëtion, Andromache, Achilles, Chryseis, Placus, Lyrnessus, Thebes.

Thebes (Θῆβαι) · PLACE — Say: thee**z**

"Seven-gated Thebes," the Boeotian city of the war before this one. Tydeus went there as an envoy for Polyneices, beat the Cadmeans at their own games and killed the fifty men they set to ambush him; the Seven perished before the walls, and the heaped earth covers Tydeus there still. Agamemnon uses the fathers' Theban exploits to shame the sons (4.370–400), and Sthenelus retorts that the sons took the city where the fathers failed. Euryalus once beat all comers at the games for fallen Oedipus there. A different Thebes — Egyptian Thebes, "where the houses hold the greatest treasures" — is Achilles' measure of a ransom he will not take (9.381–382).

Refs: 4.378, 4.406, 5.804, 6.223, 9.381, 9.382, 10.286, 14.114, 19.99, 23.679.

Books 4–6, 9–10, 14, 19, 23.

See also: Tydeus, Diomedes, Sthenelus, Polyneices, Cadmeans, Euryalus, Thebe.

Thersites (Θερσίτης) · MORTAL — Say: thur-SY-tee**z**

The one common soldier in the poem who speaks in assembly. He is described at length and unkindly — bandy-legged, lame in one foot, hunched, his head coming to a point with sparse stubble on it, "the ugliest man who came under Ilion" — and he attacks Agamemnon for his greed in terms not far from Achilles' own in Book 1. Odysseus strikes him across the back and shoulders with the scepter until a bloody welt rises and he sits down weeping, and the army, vexed as it is, laughs at him sweetly. He is never mentioned again. Odysseus' abuse still calls him a "clear-voiced speaker."

Refs: 2.212, 2.244, 2.246, 2.266. Book 2.

See also: Odysseus, Agamemnon, Achaeans.

Thestor (Θέστωρ) · MORTAL — Say: THES-tor

Three men. The first is Calchas' father, named in the line that introduces the seer "far the best of bird-readers" (1.69), and never otherwise present. The second is the father of Alcmaon, whom Sarpedon spears at the wall (12.394). The third is a son of Enops, caught by Patroclus' second rush in his aristeia: he sits hunched in his chariot with the reins fallen from his hands, struck out of his wits, and Patroclus spears him through the right jaw and hauls him over the chariot-rail like a fisherman landing a sacred fish.

Kin: the first is father of Calchas; the second father of Alcmaon; the third son of Enops.

Killed by: the third by Patroclus (16.401–410).

Refs: 1.69, 12.394, 16.401, 16.402. Books 1, 12, 16.

See also: Calchas, Alcmaon, Sarpedon, Patroclus, Enops.

Thetis (Θέτις) · GOD — *Say*: THEE-tis or THET-is

A sea-nymph, daughter of the old man of the sea, married against her will to a mortal, and the mother of Achilles — the figure through whom the plot of the poem is made. She takes her son's grievance to Zeus, clasps his knees on the peak of Olympus, and holds on until he bows his head: the promise to give the Trojans power until the Achaeans honor Achilles is the mechanism of everything that follows, and she can extract it because she once saved Zeus from being bound by summoning Briareus. She leads the Nereids' lament for a son not yet dead, tells him plainly that his own doom stands ready straight after Hector's, and goes to Hephaestus — who owes her his nine years' refuge after his fall — for the new armor. In Book 24 Zeus sends her to her son with the order to give Hector back, and she delivers it sitting beside him, stroking him with her hand.

Epithets: "silver-footed" (ἄργυρόπεζα, 1.538).

Also called: Achilles' "lady mother" (18.35, 24.126).

Kin: daughter of Nereus, "the old man of the sea," never named; sister of the Nereids; wife of Peleus, "Aeacus' son"; mother of Achilles. She sheltered Dionysus from Lycurgus (6.136) and, with Eurynome, saved the fallen Hephaestus (18.398).

Refs: 1.413, 1.495, 1.512, 1.537, 6.136, 18.51, 18.127, 18.369, 24.74, 24.120

...and throughout. Books 1, 4, 6, 8–9, 13, 15–16, 18–20, 23–24.

See also: Achilles, Peleus, Zeus, Hephaestus, Nereids, Briareus, Hera, Eurynome.

Thoas (Θόας) · MORTAL — *Say*: THOH-as

Leader of the Aetolians, Andraemon's son, who inherited the whole rule of Aetolia because Oeneus' sons were dead and fair-haired Meleager with them. He kills Peiroos over the body of Diore in Book 4 and cannot strip him for the Thracian topknots around him; he volunteers for the duel with Hector; and at 15.281–299 he gives the poem's most level piece of tactical advice, telling the best men to stand and blunt Hector while the multitude falls back on the ships — "far the best of the Aetolians — skilled with the javelin, / brave in the standing fight," and few could beat him in debate. **Two other men bear the name**: Thoas king of Lemnos, to whom the Phoenicians gave the silver mixing-bowl that becomes a prize at Patroclus' games (14.230, 23.745), and a Trojan whom Menelaus kills at 16.311. See `canon.md`.

Kin: son of Andraemon.

Refs: 2.638, 2.643, 4.527, 4.529, 7.168, 13.92, 13.222, 14.230, 15.281, 16.311, 19.239, 23.745. Books 2, 4, 7, 13–16, 19, 23.

See also: Aetolians, Peiroos, Diore, Meleager, Oeneus, Euneus, Hypsipyle.

Thoon (Θόων) · MORTAL — Say: THOH-on

More than one Trojan of the name, all of them killed. The first is a son of Phaenops, cut down with his brother Xanthus by Diomedes — the two were late-born and beloved, and their father, worn with age, had no other son, so that kinsmen of the widowed house divided the estate (5.152–158). The second falls to Odysseus in Book 11. A Thoon is also named among Asius' captains storming the wall (12.140); and in Book 13 Antilochus catches one as he turns and severs the vein that runs the length of the back to the neck.

Killed by: Diomedes (5.152–155); Odysseus (11.422); Antilochus (13.545–548).

Refs: 5.152, 11.422, 12.140, 13.545. Books 5, 11–13.

See also: Phaenops, Xanthus (horse), Diomedes, Odysseus, Antilochus, Asius.

Thrace (Θρήκη) · PLACE — Say: thrayss

The land north of the Hellespont, "Thrace of the deep soil, mother of flocks," where Iphidamas was reared in Cisses' house. Boreas and Zephyrus blow out of it across the Aegean; wine is brought daily from it to the Achaean camp; Poseidon watches the war from Samothrace over the heads of the Thracians. Rhesus' late-come contingent and Rhigmus come from there, and the cup Priam takes to Achilles among his ransom was a Thracian gift.

Refs: 9.5, 9.72, 11.222, 13.301, 20.485, 24.234. Books 9, 11, 13, 20, 24.

See also: Thracians, Rhesus, Iphidamas, Rhigmus, Hellespont, Samos.

Thracians (Θρήκες) · PEOPLE — Say: THRAY-shunz

Trojan-side allies from beyond the Hellespont, led in the Catalogue by Acamas and the hero Peiroos, and marked by their hair: "the Thracians with their hair in topknots, long spears in their hands," who stand over Peiroos' body and thrust Thoas back. Ares wears Acamas' likeness to rally the Trojans, and Telamonian Ajax kills "the man who was best among the Thracians." Their second, larger appearance is Rhesus' company, new-come and camped outermost of all, whose watch Dolon betrays and whom Diomedes kills sleeping — twelve men and their king — while Odysseus drags the bodies clear for the horses.

Refs: 2.844, 4.519, 4.533, 4.537, 5.462, 6.7, 10.434, 10.470, 10.559, 13.4, 14.228. Books 2, 4–6, 10, 13–14, 23.

See also: Rhesus, Dolon, Diomedes, Acamas, Peiroos, Thrace, Thoas.

Thrasymedes (Θρασυμήδης) · MORTAL — Say: thras-ih-MEE-deez

Nestor's son and Antilochus' brother, "steadfast in battle" and "horse-taming." He commands the night sentries in Book 9, lends Diomedes a sword and shield for the night raid, and his shield is the one his father takes up in Book 14 — the son

having his father's. In Book 16 he kills Maris, who is standing over his brother's body in fury; in Book 17 he and Antilochus are the last two who have not heard that Patroclus is dead, and when Antilochus runs with the news it is Thrasymedes whom Nestor sends to replace him.

Epithets: "steadfast in battle" (μενεπτόλεμος, 10.255).

Kin: son of Nestor; brother of Antilochus.

Refs: 9.81, 10.255, 14.10, 16.321, 17.378, 17.705. Books 9–10, 14, 16–17.

See also: Nestor, Antilochus, Maris, Patroclus, Diomedes.

Tlepolemus (Τληπόλεμος) · MORTAL — Say: tluh-POL-uh-mus or tuh-LEP-oh-lee-mus
Heracles' son by Astyocheia, leader of the nine Rhodian ships. The Catalogue gives him an exile's biography: grown to manhood he killed his father's aging uncle Licymnius on the instant, and fled over the sea from Heracles' sons and grandsons to settle Rhodes in three tribes, where Zeus poured wondrous wealth upon them. Fate drives him against Sarpedon — the son and the grandson of Zeus — and he opens with a taunt about Heracles' six ships and the sack of Ilion; Sarpedon's spear goes through his neck, and murky night covers his eyes, while his own cast only grazes Sarpedon's thigh-bone. **A second Tlepolemus**, Damastor's son, is one of the Trojans Patroclus kills in heaps at 16.416.

Kin: son of Heracles and Astyocheia.

Killed by: Sarpedon (5.655–659).

Refs: 2.653, 2.657, 2.661, 5.628, 5.632, 5.648, 5.655, 5.660, 5.669, 16.416.

Books 2, 5, 16.

See also: Heracles, Sarpedon, Rhodes, Licymnius, Astyocheia, Selleïs.

Trojans (Τρῶες) · PEOPLE

The defenders of Troy and, loosely, their allies with them — the poem's second great collective, and after Zeus its commonest name. They are the army the Achaeans face and the people whose city is doomed: the poem sets against the Achaeans' anonymous mass a Trojan side that is a city with women and children in it, and its formulas of address gather in the allies — "Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians who fight at close quarters." Their assemblies, their truce, their oath-breaking under Pandarus, their one night camped in the open on the plain, and their lamentations over Hector are as fully narrated as anything on the Achaean side.

Epithets: "horse-taming" (ἵππόδαμοι, 2.230); the individual form of the same word is "breaker of horses."

Refs: 1.152, 2.123, 3.2, 4.509, 8.173, 12.440, 18.243, 22.1 ...and throughout.

Books 1–24.

See also: Troy, Hector, Priam, Dardanians, Lycians, Achaeans.

Tros (Τρώς) · MORTAL — *Say:* tros

Two men. The first is the eponym of the Trojans, in the fourth generation of the house of Dardanus: "Erichthonius fathered Tros, lord of the Trojans; / and from Tros in turn three blameless sons were born: / Ilus, and Assaracus, and godlike Ganymede." Zeus gave him the immortal horses in payment for Ganymede, and it is that stock — "the horses of Tros" — that Anchises stole a breed from, that Diomedes takes from Aeneas, and that he drives in the chariot race. The second Tros is Alastor's son, killed at 20.463: he comes to clasp Achilles' knees hoping to be spared as a man of his own age, and Achilles, "all raw fury," stabs him in the liver — the first of the poem's three refused supplications.

Kin: the ancestor is son of Erichthonius, father of Ilus, Assaracus and Ganymede, and great-grandfather of Priam; the victim is Alastor's son.

Killed by: the victim, by Achilles (20.463–472).

Refs: 5.222, 5.265, 8.106, 20.230, 20.231, 20.463, 20.468, 23.291, 23.377.

Books 5, 8, 20, 23.

See also: Dardanus, Erichthonius, Ilus, Assaracus, Ganymede, Aeneas, Achilles, Lycaon, Hector.

Troy (Τροίη / Ἴλιος) · PLACE

The city, and the poem's fixed point: everything happens on the plain before it or inside its walls. The translation keeps both surface names the Greek uses —

Ilion, "holy Ilion," "the well-built citadel of Ilion," and **Troy**, "well-walled," "wide-wayed," "deep-soiled" — and both are headwords. The city is never taken in the poem, but its fall is stated as certain from Book 4 on ("the day will come when holy Ilion shall perish, / and Priam, and the people of Priam of the good ash spear," 4.164–165 = 6.448–449), and Zeus names it the dearest of mortal cities to him even as he concedes it. It is Poseidon and Apollo's own work, built for Laomedon, and its wall is what Hector must come outside of to die.

Also called: Ilion — the same city, both spellings throughout; its citadel is Pergamos.

Refs: 1.71, 1.129, 2.113, 2.141, 4.46, 4.164, 6.315, 7.20, 21.544, 22.411

...and throughout. Books 1–24.

See also: Troy, Trojans, Priam, Hector, Pergamos, Scaean, Laomedon.

Tydeus (Τυδεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* TY-dee-us

Diomedes' father, one of the Seven against Thebes, dead before the poem opens and covered by the heaped earth at Thebes. The name is overwhelmingly a patronymic:

XANTHUS (HORSE) – ZELEIA

"Tydeus' son" is Diomedes, and in most of its 109 occurrences the father is not the referent. Where he is, he is the standing measure the sons are held against — Agamemnon shames Diomedes with the story of the envoy who beat the Cadmeans at their games and killed the fifty men they ambushed him with, and concludes that "the son he fathered is worse than he in battle — better in the assembly"; Athena tells Diomedes he is "no son of Tydeus" if fear holds him, recalling that his father was a small man in build but a fighter. Diomedes says he does not remember him.
Kin: son of Oeneus' line, of Portheus through Oeneus; married a daughter of Adrastus and settled at Argos; father of Diomedes.

Refs: 2.406, 4.370, 4.372, 4.384, 4.399, 5.800, 5.813, 6.222, 14.114 ...and throughout. Books 2, 4–11, 14, 16, 19, 21, 23.

See also: Diomedes, Thebes, Oeneus, Adrastus, Polyneices, Agamemnon, Athena.

Xanthus (horse) (Ξάνθος) · OTHER — *Say*: ZAN-thus

One of Achilles' two immortal horses, yoked with Balius; the harpy Podarge conceived the pair by the West Wind as she grazed in a meadow beside the stream of Ocean. In Book 19, when Achilles reproaches them for leaving Patroclus dead, white-armed Hera gives Xanthus voice: he drops his head until his mane spills to the ground and answers that they will bring Achilles back safe this time, but that his day of destruction is near, and that the blame is a great god's and strong Fate's — "it is fated to be broken by force — by a god, and by a man." The Erinyes then stop his voice. The token *Xanthus* is otherwise counted under the river Scamander; see `canon.md`'s homonym register.

Also called: named always with Balius as a pair.

Kin: offspring of Podarge and the West Wind; yoked with Balius, and with the mortal Pedasus in the side-traces.

Refs: 16.149, 19.400. Books 16, 19.

See also: Podarge, Achilles, Automedon, Pedasus, Scamander, Erinyes, Zephyrus.

Zeleia (Ζέλεϊα) · PLACE — *Say*: zuh-LY-uh

Pandarus' town, "under the lowest foot of Ida," whose men drink the dark water of the Aesepus. The Catalogue calls them Trojans; the town itself appears twice more, in the vow Athena puts in Pandarus' mouth and then in his own performance of it — a hecatomb of firstborn lambs to Apollo the Lycian-born "when he came home to the town of holy Zeleia." He does not come home.

Refs: 2.824, 4.103, 4.121. Books 2, 4.

See also: Pandarus, Ida, Aesepus, Apollo, Lycaon.

Zephyrus (Ζέφυρος) · GOD — Say: ZEF-ih-rus

The west wind, named in Book 23 only, where Iris finds all the winds feasting indoors at "the house of gusting Zephyrus" and delivers Achilles' prayer: he and Boreas rise with an unearthly roar, drive the clouds before them, and fall on the pyre so that Patroclus burns all night. Elsewhere in the poem the same wind is called "the West Wind" without the name — as the sire of Xanthus and Balius by the harpy Podarge (16.150), and in Xanthus' own boast that the two of them could run with its breath (19.415).

Kin: father of Xanthus and Balius by Podarge (named there as "the West Wind").

Refs: 23.195, 23.200, 23.208. Book 23.

See also: Boreas, Iris, Achilles, Patroclus, Xanthus (horse), Podarge.

Zeus (Ζεύς) · GOD — Say: ZOOS

The presiding god of the poem and the agent of its plot. Its fifth line announces that through all the deaths "the will of Zeus moved toward fulfillment," and the mechanism is set in Book 1: Thetis clasps his knees, he bows his head — the pledge that cannot be taken back — and promises to give the Trojans power until the Achaeans honor Achilles. He enforces it by banning the gods from the field on pain of Tartarus, by his golden scales, and by a long plan-speech at 15.56–77 that lays out Books 16 through 22 in advance. He is not omnipotent in it so much as bound by it: he cannot save Sarpedon, his own dearest son, without unmaking the order the other gods live by, and instead rains drops of blood on the earth; he weighs Hector's fate and lets it sink; Hera deceives him into sleep and he wakes furious but does not undo it. In Book 24 he ends the poem by sending Thetis to Achilles and Iris to Priam, ransom for a body.

Epithets: "aegis-bearing" (αἰγίοχος, 1.202); "Zeus the cloud-gatherer"

(νεφεληγερέτα, 1.511); "Zeus the counselor / of the counsels" (μητίετα, 1.175);

"who thunders on high" (ὕψιβρεμέτης, 1.354); "who delights in thunder"

(τερπικέραυνος, 1.419); "lord of lightning" (ἀστεροπηγῆς, 1.580); "wide-seeing"

(εὐρύοπα, 1.498); "high-throned" (ὕψιζυγος, 4.166); "father of men and gods"

(πατὴρ ἀνδρῶν τε θεῶν τε, 1.544); "the dispenser of war" (ταμίης πολέμοιο, 4.84);

"the loud-thunderer, Hera's lord" (ἐρίγδουπος πόσις Ἥρης, 7.411); "Zeus of All

Voices" (Πανομφαῖος, 8.250); "Zeus of Guest-right" (Ζεὺς ξείνιος, 13.625).

Also called: "son of Cronos" (Κρονίδης / Κρονίων, 1.398) — the patronymic that resolves to Zeus throughout; "Cronos" alone is the Titan father.

Kin: son of Cronos and Rhea; brother of Poseidon, Hades and Hera, who is also his wife; the three brothers divide sky, sea and underworld by lot (15.187–193).

ZEPHYRUS – ZEUS

Father of Athena, of Apollo and Artemis by Leto, of Ares and Hebe by Hera, of Aphrodite by Dione, of Hermes, of Heracles by Alcmene, and of Sarpedon.

Refs: 1.5, 1.503, 1.528, 8.5, 15.187, 16.431, 22.209, 24.103 ...and throughout.

Books 1–24.

See also: Hera, Thetis, Achilles, Poseidon, Athena, Apollo, Sarpedon, Hector, Cronos, Tartarus, Fate.